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Hosea

Hosea 1:1

Section 1:1: Preface/Introduction

This opening verse introduces the whole book. It tells us that this book was a message from the LORD to his people through the prophet Hosea. It also tells when Hosea received this message from the LORD.

In Hebrew, this first verse serves as a title for the whole book. Andersen and Freedman (pages 142–149). Most English versions have a separate book title, such as “Hosea,” followed directly by 1:1. There are two ways to show the relationship of 1:1 to the rest of the book:

- Place a section heading before 1:1. Here are some other examples of section headings:

The beginning of the book

The LORD gave a message to Hosea

- Do not place any heading before 1:1. Instead, place the first heading before 1:2. See the examples in the note on Section 1:2–9.

1:1a

This is the word of the LORD that came to Hosea son of Beeri

- ¶ This is the message that Yahweh gave to Hosea, Beeri’s son,
- ¶ This book contains the words that Yahweh made known to Hosea, the son/child of Beeri.
- ¶ In this book are the words that Yahweh spoke to Hosea, the son/child of Beeri.

This is the word of the LORD that came to Hosea son of Beeri: The expression the word of the LORD refers here to the message that the LORD gave to the prophet Hosea. It is implied that Hosea would make this message known by his words or actions to the people.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

This is the message which the Lord gave Hosea son of Beeri.... (GNT)

This book contains the words/message that God made known to Hosea the son of Beeri

LORD: The word LORD represents the Hebrew word “Yahweh,” the personal name of God. In Hebrew, this is a proper name, not a title or general noun. See the discussion of Yahweh, the LORD in the Introduction.

to Hosea son of Beeri: See the discussion of The author in the Introduction.

The writer introduced himself in the third person, as if he were speaking about someone else. The writers of the New Testament letters did this also. Most English versions keep the third person forms. However, if this would be confusing for your readers, you could reword it using “I...me.” For example:

I am Hosea son of Beeri. This is the message that God gave to me during...

If you use “I” or “me” in this verse, you will need to make the same change in some of the verses that follow. For example, in 1:3, the CEV has:

So I married Gomer (CEV)

son of Beeri: In languages that do not use specific terms for son or “daughter,” you may use a general term. For example:

child of Beeri

1:1a–c

combined/reordered

- ¶ During the time that Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah ruled in Judah, and Jeroboam the son of Jehoash ruled in Israel, Yahweh spoke this message to Hosea the son of Beeri.

1:1b

in the days of Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, kings of Judah,

- while Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah were kings of Judah.
- Yahweh made these words known during the time when Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah ruled as kings of Judah,
- Yahweh spoke these words during the time when Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah ruled as kings in the country of Judah,

in the days of Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, kings of Judah: This is a list of the kings of the southern kingdom of Judah who ruled one after the other. Hosea prophesied sometime within this same time period. Verse 1:2a–b does not imply that Hosea’s

ministry began during the same year as the reign of King Uzziah or that it ended during the same year as the reign of King Hezekiah. See the discussion of The historical background in the Introduction.

kings: The word “king” is a title that refers to the highest official of a country. In languages where a word for “king” is not known, you may use a title with a similar meaning. For example:

chief officials

rulers

1:1c

and of Jeroboam son of Jehoash, king of Israel.

- During this same time, Jeroboam, the son of Jehoash, was king of Israel.
- and while Jeroboam, son of Jehoash, ruled as king in the country of Israel.

and of Jeroboam son of Jehoash, king of Israel: This statement refers to the reign of Jeroboam II. He ruled as king over Israel in the north during the same time period as the kings of Judah in the south that are listed above. Hosea prophesied sometime within this same time period. See the discussion of The historical background in the Introduction.

General Comment on 1:1a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse. The CEV has reordered some of the verse parts using the first person pronouns “I” and “me.”

^{1a}I am Hosea son of Beerī. ^{1b}When Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah were the kings of Judah, ^{1c}and when Jeroboam son of Jehoash was king of Israel, ^{1a}the Lord spoke this message to me.

For a way to reorder the parts of this verse using third person forms, see 1:1a–c (combined/reordered) in the Display. Use an order that is natural in your language.

In chapters 1–3, Hosea’s relationship with Gomer illustrates the LORD’s relationship to his people, the Israelites. Hosea married Gomer, but she was not faithful to him. Instead, she left him and lived with other men. In a similar way, the LORD had made an agreement with the people of Israel that he would be their God and they should worship only him. But they were not faithful to obey that agreement. Instead, they turned away from him and worshiped false gods. The LORD punished Israel because of their unfaithful-

ness, but eventually he was merciful and restored their relationship. In a similar way, Hosea was merciful to Gomer and restored their relationship.

Hosea 1:2

Section 1:2–9: Hosea married an unfaithful wife and fathered three children

The LORD commanded Hosea to marry Gomer. She was an immoral woman who would be unfaithful to him. Her unfaithfulness illustrated Israel’s unfaithfulness to the LORD. The LORD also commanded Hosea to give their three children names that would serve as warnings of future judgments.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Hosea’s wife and children (GNT)

Hosea’s marriage symbolized the LORD’s relationship to Israel

1:2a

When the LORD first spoke through Hosea, He told him,

- ¶ When Yahweh first spoke to the people of Israel through Hosea, Yahweh said to Hosea,
- ¶ When Yahweh first used Hosea to make known his message to the people of Israel, he said to him,

When the LORD first spoke through Hosea, He told him:

These words introduce Hosea’s prophetic ministry. They refer to the first time that the LORD spoke to Israel through Hosea. In Hebrew, these two clauses are literally “[the] beginning of [when] Yahweh spoke by Hosea. And Yahweh said to Hosea...” These words introduce the LORD’s first message to Hosea. Hosea’s first act as a prophet was to marry Gomer.

Here are some other ways to translate these two clauses:

When the LORD first spoke through Hosea, the Lord said to Hosea (NRSV)

This is the beginning of the Lord’s message given by Hosea. (REB)

In some languages, it may be necessary to make explicit who the LORD spoke to when he spoke through Hosea. For example:

When the Lord first spoke to Israel through Hosea, he said to Hosea (GNT)

1:2b

“Go, take a prostitute as your wife and have children of adultery,

- “Go, marry a woman who is a prostitute and have children with her.
- “Get married to a woman who sleeps with other men. You^(sing) will be the father of her children.

Go, take a prostitute as your wife: These two commands function as a single command to get married. The word Go serves primarily to introduce the second command. It may emphasize the need for Hosea to take action. It does not imply that Hosea should first go on a journey and then marry someone. BDB (#1980) and HALOT (#2289) both list various ways in which the Hebrew root hlk can be used in combination with other verbs. Some of the verses listed (such as 1 Samuel 9:9, Isaiah 2:3, and Genesis 19:32) have combinations such as “Come, let us go” or “Come, let us make our father drink...” (In these verses “come” is a translation of Hebrew hlk.) These combinations focus attention on the following action. Andersen and Freedman (page 156) understand a similar use of the verb “go” here. They say specifically that “it does not imply a journey.” They point to 1 Kings 1:12, where Nathan said to Bath-Sheba, “Go, let me counsel you, although he clearly wanted her to stay and hear his counsel.

Here are some other ways to translate this kind of double command:

- Use a word or phrase that directs attention to the main command to get married. For example:

Go marry... (NET)

What I want you to do is to get married to...

- Translate the main command to get married. Leave a word or phrase such as Go implied. For example:

Marry... (GW)

Translate these commands in a way that is clear and natural in your language.

a prostitute as your wife: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as a prostitute as your wife is literally “a wife/woman of immoralities.” The Hebrew word “immoralities” refers to sexual activity that is contrary to God’s law. It includes both adultery and sexual

relations between unmarried people. Some forms of this word refer to prostitution, that is, offering to have sexual intercourse for pay.

In this context, the plural form “immoralities” indicates repeated or habitual behavior. Biblical Hebrew Reference Grammar for Students, NET footnote, Stuart, HALOT (#2529), and McComiskey (page 14). HALOT defines the plural form in this context as “inclined to fornicate.” There are two main ways to interpret this phrase:

1. The LORD told Hosea to marry a woman who had already engaged in sexual relations contrary to God’s law. She may have been a prostitute. People knew about her immoral character before her marriage to Hosea. This interpretation is supported by Keil (page 37), McComiskey (page 14), and Pusey (page 20). For example:

Go and marry a prostitute (NLT)

Go marry a promiscuous woman (NIV2011) (BSB, CEV, GW, NET, NIV2011, NJB, NLT, REB)

1. The LORD told Hosea to marry a woman who would be unfaithful to him after their marriage. Her promiscuous character would develop or become clear only after she became his wife. See Andersen and Freedman (pages 157–167), Macintosh (page 8), and Wood (page 166). Andersen and Freedman present evidence that this expression cannot refer to an unmarried prostitute. It can only mean a married woman who is promiscuous. They suggest that Hosea’s wife only became an adulteress after marriage but that the verse is speaking about that future state as if it had already occurred. (The technical term for this is prolepsis, a literary device that is fairly common in prophecies.) McComiskey (pages 11–14) argues against this evidence and points out some of the weaknesses of the proleptic view. For example:

Go and get married; your wife will be unfaithful (GNT)

Go marry a woman who will commit adultery. (GNT)

Some English versions translate the Hebrew phrase “wife/woman of immoralities” quite literally. For example, the KJV, ESV, NJPS, and NRSV have “wife of whoredom(s).” The NASB has “wife of harlotry.” These

expressions can refer to more than one interpretation, so the Notes have not listed them under either one. In addition to these versions, the NIV has “an adulterous wife” which could imply that Gomer was already married to someone else and was committing adultery. Similarly, the NCV translation “an unfaithful woman” would normally refer to someone’s wife, not to an unmarried woman. But there is no evidence that Gomer was already married to a different man, and the commentaries used in preparing these Notes did not suggest this as a possible interpretation, so the Notes have not listed these versions under any particular interpretation.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most English versions. However, both interpretations have good commentary support. So it is also recommended that you mention interpretation (2) in a footnote. You may also want to mention interpretation (2) for the next phrase (“children of unfaithfulness”) in the same footnote, because the two interpretations correspond to each other.

and have children of adultery: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “and children of immoralities.” There are three main interpretations of this phrase: A fourth interpretation is that Gomer had some children who were conceived as a result of her prostitution before Hosea married her. After her marriage, she had three more children with Hosea. See McComiskey (page 15). This interpretation is not explicitly followed in any of the English versions cited in Translator’s Notes. The BSB (“children of adultery”) is ambiguous, so it has not been listed under any interpretation.

1. The children born to Gomer and Hosea would be born to an immoral mother. Nothing is indicated about the behavior of the children. Chisholm (page 1380). The expression “children of immoralities” is understood in the same way as similar expressions in the OT. “Children of old age” means “children born to an elderly parent,” so “children of immoralities” means “children born to an immoral mother.” For example:

and have children with her (NIV2011) (CEV, GW, NIV2011, NJB, REB)

1. The children born to Gomer and Hosea would be like their mother in their behavior and character. The immoral character of each would become evident in the future. Wood (page 170). For example:

and your children will be just like her (GNT) (GNT, NCV)

1. The children born to Gomer after her marriage would be a result of her adultery. Hosea would not be their father. For example:

a prostitute who will bear illegitimate children conceived through prostitution (NET) (NET, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. The first and second interpretations are more likely than the third, since the rest of the chapter seems to indicate that Hosea is the father of these children. See 1:3, 1:6, 1:8.

1:2c

because this land is flagrantly prostituting itself by departing from the LORD.”

- Do^(sing) this because the people of Israel are also unfaithful. They repeatedly commit prostitution by forsaking Yahweh to follow other gods.”
- Marry such a woman to show the people of Israel that they have sinned like a completely unfaithful/immoral wife. Yes, they have left me in order to follow other gods.”

because: In Hebrew, this word introduces the reason that the LORD commanded Hosea to marry “a woman of immoralities.” The reason is that his marriage to an unfaithful wife would illustrate the LORD’s relationship to his unfaithful people, the Israelites.

Some English versions translate this word as “for” or because. Other versions leave it implied. Use a natural way in your language to introduce the LORD’s reason for his command to Hosea. In some languages, it may be necessary to make more information explicit. For example:

This will illustrate how Israel... (NLT)

Do that, because it will show how the people in this land...

this land: Here the term this land is a figure of speech (metonymy). It represents the people who lived in the land, that is, the Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this figure of speech:

the people in this country (NCV)

my people (GNT)

is flagrantly prostituting itself: In Hebrew, this expression refers here to committing sexual immorality or behaving as a prostitute. It is used here as a figure of speech (metaphor). In this metaphor, the people of Israel are compared to a wife who is repeatedly unfaithful to her husband, because they had stopped worshiping the LORD and begun to worship other gods. See the General Comment on 1:2c for other ways to translate this figure of speech.

The form of the Hebrew expression emphasizes the extent of their immorality. It may imply several things:

1. They repeatedly or continually commit immoral acts.
2. They are openly, brazenly, or flagrantly immoral.
3. Their immoral behavior is vile, extreme, or of the worst kind.

Here are some ways to express this emphasis:

have been completely unfaithful (NCV)

continually commit adultery

openly committing adultery (NLT96)

You should express this emphasis in a way that is appropriate in your language.

by departing from the LORD: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “from after the LORD.” By worshiping other gods, the people of Israel had abandoned the LORD. To make the meaning clear, English translations supply a verb such as departing (BSB), “forsaking” (NRSV), “abandon” (GW), “turning away” (NET). You may also have to supply additional words to make the meaning clear in your language.

the LORD: The LORD referred to himself in the third person, the LORD, as if he were speaking about someone else. This was good style in Old Testament Hebrew. In some languages, it may be more natural to use the pronoun “me” to make it explicit that the LORD is referring to himself. For example:

the people in this land have abandoned me, the LORD.

Another way to avoid confusion is to use only the pronoun “me.” It may not be necessary to repeat the words the LORD. For example:

my people have left me and become unfaithful.
(GNT)

General Comment on 1:2c

The phrase “in departing from the LORD” explains the meaning of the figure of speech “vilest adultery” in nonfigurative language.

Here are some other ways to express these two phrases:

- Change the phrase “vilest adultery” into a simile. For example:

it is like the people of this land are being totally immoral, because they have turned their backs on me, the LORD.

- Place the nonfigurative phrase “in departing from the LORD” first. For example:

the people of this land have abandoned the LORD. They are like a woman who repeatedly commits adultery.

- Combine the two phrases into one phrase. For example:

the people in this country have been completely unfaithful to the Lord (NCV)

Hosea 1:3

Section 1:2–9: Hosea married an unfaithful wife and fathered three children

The LORD commanded Hosea to marry Gomer. She was an immoral woman who would be unfaithful to him. Her unfaithfulness illustrated Israel’s unfaithfulness to the LORD. The LORD also commanded Hosea to give their three children names that would serve as warnings of future judgments.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Hosea’s wife and children (GNT)

Hosea’s marriage symbolized the LORD’s relationship to Israel

1:3a

So Hosea went and married Gomer daughter of Diblaim,

- ¶ So Hosea obeyed Yahweh. He went and married Gomer, the daughter of Diblaim.
- ¶ So Hosea did what Yahweh wanted. He got married to a woman named Gomer who was the daughter/child of Diblaim.

So: Verses 1:2 and 1:3 are connected by a Hebrew word that English versions translate as So. In this context, this word expresses result. Hosea married Gomer as a result of the LORD's command to him in 1:2b. Use a natural way in your language to introduce a result.

Hosea went and married: The Hebrew verbs that the BSB translates as Hosea went and married are literally “he went and he took.” These repeat the verbs of the LORD's command to Hosea in 1:2b, “Go, take.” Many English versions follow the Hebrew pattern of repeating the same verbs in both places. For example, the RSV has “Go and take” for the command in 1:2b and “he went and took” in 1:3. Other versions have “marry” in both places. You may wish to repeat the same verbs here that you used in 1:2b in order to highlight Hosea's complete obedience to the LORD's command.

Gomer daughter of Diblaim: This is the first time that Gomer is mentioned in this book. In some languages, it may be more natural to introduce her in a slightly different way. For example:

a woman named Gomer, the daughter of Diblaim
(GNT)

Use a natural way in your language to introduce a new participant in the story.

1:3b

and she conceived and bore him a son.

- Afterwards Gomer became pregnant and gave birth to a/their son.
- After the birth of their first child, a son/male,

and she conceived and bore him a son: This clause implies that Hosea was the child's father. There are different ways to make this clear and at the same time to express the idea of conceiving a child. For example:

she became pregnant and gave birth to Hosea's son (NCV)

After the birth of their first child, a son (GNT)

In languages that do not use a gender-specific word such as son, you may need to use a phrase such as “male child.”

If you referred to Hosea in 1:1–2 with “I” or “me,” you may be able to translate this verse as the CEV has done:

So I married Gomer the daughter of Diblaim, and we had a son. (CEV)

Hosea 1:4

Section 1:2–9: Hosea married an unfaithful wife and fathered three children

The LORD commanded Hosea to marry Gomer. She was an immoral woman who would be unfaithful to him. Her unfaithfulness illustrated Israel's unfaithfulness to the LORD. The LORD also commanded Hosea to give their three children names that would serve as warnings of future judgments.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Hosea's wife and children (GNT)

Hosea's marriage symbolized the LORD's relationship to Israel

Paragraph 1:4–5

This paragraph refers back to an event that occurred in a place called Jezreel. In Jezreel, King Jehu, an ancestor of Jeroboam II, had brutally killed the family of King Ahab (see 2 Kings 9–10). Although the LORD himself had commanded Jehu to destroy the family of Ahab (see 2 Kings 9:7), Jehu had exceeded this command when he killed many other people as well. For this reason, the LORD was going to punish Jehu's descendants. It may be helpful to include some of this historical information in a footnote to help your readers to understand the reason for God's judgment.

1:4a

Then the LORD said to Hosea, “Name him Jezreel,

- ¶ Then Yahweh said to Hosea, “Name your^(sing/plur) son/child Jezreel,
- ¶ Yahweh said to Hosea, “Name^(sing) him Jezreel,

Then the LORD said to Hosea, “Name him Jezreel:

The LORD told Hosea to name his son after the place in Israel called Jezreel. Jezreel was the name of both a valley and a town. The name Jezreel means “God scatters.” Here it has a bad connotation. In 1:11d it has a good connotation. See the notes there for more information.

1:4b–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{4b}for soon I will bring the bloodshed of Jezreel upon the **house of Jehu**,

^{4c}and I will put an end to the **kingdom of Israel**.

Verse 1:4c adds information that clarifies how the LORD will punish the descendants of King Jehu.

1:4b

for soon I will bring the bloodshed of Jezreel upon the house of Jehu,

- because I will soon punish the descendants of King Jehu of Israel for the slaughter/murders he committed in Jezreel Valley,
- because it will not be long before I punish the king of Israel on account of the people that his ancestor Jehu murdered/killed at Jezreel.

for: In Hebrew, this word introduces the reason that the LORD told Hosea to name his child Jezreel. Some English versions translate it as for or “because.” Other versions leave this connection implied. Use a natural way in your language to introduce this reason.

soon I will bring the bloodshed of Jezreel upon the house of Jehu: This is the reason that the LORD told Hosea to name his child Jezreel. The name would be a reminder and a warning. It would remind the Israelites of the murders that Jehu committed at Jezreel when he was king of Israel. It would also warn them that the LORD was going to punish Jehu’s descendants for what he had done.

the bloodshed of Jezreel: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “the blood of Jezreel.” It refers to the murders that Jehu committed at Jezreel.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the bloodshed at Jezreel (NJB)

the people they killed at Jezreel (NCV)

the murders he committed in Jezreel Valley (CEV)

In some languages, it may be necessary to make explicit that Jehu committed the murders. For example:

the murders that his ancestor Jehu committed (GNT)

Use a phrase that communicates the meaning clearly in your language.

the house of Jehu: In Hebrew, the phrase the house of may have more than one meaning. It can refer to the people of an entire nation (see 1:6c “the house of Israel” and 1:7a “the house of Judah”), the family or descendants of an individual, or the dynasty of a king. Here it refers specifically to Jehu’s descendant King Jeroboam II and his family.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

dynasty of Jehu (REB)

the descendants of King Jehu of Israel (CEV)

It may also be helpful to make it explicit that the king of Israel is the actual person to whom the house of Jehu refers. For example:

punish the king of Israel for the murders that his ancestor Jehu committed (GNT)

Even though the GNT does not use an expression like house of Jehu, it makes clear the connection between the king of Israel and Jehu by using the phrase “his ancestor Jehu.” Translate this idea in a way that communicates the meaning clearly in your language.

1:4c

and I will put an end to the kingdom of Israel.

- and I will no longer allow the kingdom/nation of Israel to exist.
- And I will cause Israel’s status as a country to end.

and I will put an end to the kingdom of Israel: In Hebrew, the phrase the kingdom of Israel is literally “the kingdom of the house of Israel.” There are two ways to interpret this phrase here:

1. It refers to the northern kingdom of Israel. It means that Israel would cease to exist as an independent nation. Keil (page 42), Macintosh (page 14), Phillips (page 28), and Wood (page 171). For example:

I will put an end to the kingdom of Israel. (GW) (BSB, GW, KJV, NCV, NIV, NLT, NJB, NRSV, REB)

1. It refers specifically to the rule of Jehu’s descendant, Jeroboam II. It means that this dynasty would cease to exist and that a new king who was not descended from Jehu would replace Jeroboam II. For example:

I am going to put an end to Jehu's dynasty. (GNT)
(CEV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It best fits the context of 1:5.

I will put an end to: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as put an end to means "to cause to stop." The LORD will no longer allow the northern kingdom of Israel to exist as an independent nation. This statement does not include the southern kingdom of Judah. See the note on 1:7a.

Here are some other ways to translate 1:4c:

I will bring an end to Israel's independence. (NLT)

I will cause the nation/government of Israel to cease to exist.

I will cause Israel's status as a country to end.

Hosea 1:5

Section 1:2–9: Hosea married an unfaithful wife and fathered three children

The LORD commanded Hosea to marry Gomer. She was an immoral woman who would be unfaithful to him. Her unfaithfulness illustrated Israel's unfaithfulness to the LORD. The LORD also commanded Hosea to give their three children names that would serve as warnings of future judgments.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Hosea's wife and children (GNT)

Hosea's marriage symbolized the LORD's relationship to Israel

Paragraph 1:4–5

This paragraph refers back to an event that occurred in a place called Jezreel. In Jezreel, King Jehu, an ancestor of Jeroboam II, had brutally killed the family of King Ahab (see 2 Kings 9–10). Although the LORD himself had commanded Jehu to destroy the family of Ahab (see 2 Kings 9:7), Jehu had exceeded this command when he killed many other people as well. For this reason, the LORD was going to punish Jehu's descendants. It may be helpful to include some of this historical information in a footnote to help your readers to understand the reason for God's judgment.

1:5

And on that day I will break the bow of Israel in the Valley of Jezreel."

- At that time I will destroy Israel's army/soldiers in the Valley of Jezreel."
- At that time I will cause Israel to be defeated at Jezreel Valley so that they will no longer be able to fight."

And on that day: This phrase refers here to the time in the future when the LORD will bring an end to the kingdom of Israel. It does not refer to a literal 24-hour day.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

At that time (GNT)

Some versions omit this expression, because the meaning is clear from the context. Do what is most natural in your language.

I will break the bow of Israel in the Valley of Jezreel:

The LORD warned Israel here that he would use an enemy army to defeat them in the Valley of Jezreel and destroy their military power.

I will break the bow of Israel: The bow was one of the main instruments of warfare in Hosea's time. Here it is used as a figure of speech to symbolize Israel's power and military strength. Wood (page 171) and Stuart (page 30).

If this figure of speech is not clear in your language, here are some other ways to translate it:

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

I will at that time destroy Israel's military power. (GNT)

- Use a similar figure of speech that conveys the right meaning in your language.

With either option, be careful not to imply that God literally will be fighting Israel at Jezreel. In some languages, it may be necessary to make explicit that the LORD will use an enemy nation as his instrument to destroy Israel's military power. For example:

At that time, I will cause the enemies of Israel to defeat her at the Valley of Jezreel, so that Israel will not be able to fight any more.

Hosea 1:6

Section 1:2–9: Hosea married an unfaithful wife and fathered three children

The LORD commanded Hosea to marry Gomer. She was an immoral woman who would be unfaithful to him. Her unfaithfulness illustrated Israel's unfaithfulness to the LORD. The LORD also commanded Hosea to give their three children names that would serve as warnings of future judgments.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Hosea's wife and children (GNT)

Hosea's marriage symbolized the LORD's relationship to Israel

Paragraph 1:6–7

This paragraph tells about the birth of Gomer's second child. The meaning of the child's name, "not loved/pitied," reinforced the LORD's promise that he would destroy the northern kingdom of Israel. He promised to show them no mercy. In contrast, the LORD promised to deliver the people of Judah from destruction.

1:6a

Gomer again conceived and gave birth to a daughter,

- ¶ Later Gomer became pregnant again and gave birth to a/their daughter.
- ¶ When Gomer became pregnant again and their next/second child was born, it was a daughter/female.

Gomer again conceived and gave birth to a daughter:

Although the verse does not explicitly say that Hosea was the father, it is implied here. Andersen and Freedman (page 187). See how you translated the similar sentence in 1:3b.

In Hebrew, there is no explicit transition between the birth of Hosea and Gomer's first child in 1:3 and the birth of their second child here in 1:6. In some languages, it may be necessary to make explicit that some time passed between the two births. For example:

Soon Gomer became pregnant again and gave birth to a daughter. (NLT)

Later, Gomer had a daughter (CEV)

daughter: In languages that do not use a gender-specific word such as daughter, you may need to use a phrase such as "female child."

Notice that the CEV leaves implicit the information that Gomer "conceived again." Describe this event in a way that is natural in your language.

1:6b

and the LORD said to Hosea, "Name her Lo-ruhamah,

- Then Yahweh said to Hosea, "As for this child, name^(sing) her Lo-Ruhamah,
- And Yahweh said to Hosea, "Name this child 'Not Loved/Pitied,'

Name her Lo-ruhamah: The literal meaning of the Hebrew name Lo-ruhamah is "Not having obtained mercy/love." This name covers more than one aspect of meaning. For example:

Not pitied (RSV)

Not Loved (NIV footnote)

No Mercy (CEV footnote)

Choose an expression in your language that includes one or more of these aspects of meaning. It is important that your translation communicates the meaning of the name to your readers. Otherwise your readers will not know why the LORD told Hosea to give her that name.

Here are some other ways to translate this name:

- Omit the Hebrew name and write the meaning of the name in the translation. This is a good option, especially if it is a custom in your culture to give children names with meanings that the people understand. For example:

Call her name Not pitied (RSV)

Name her 'Unloved' (GNT)

- Write the Hebrew name in the translation and give the meaning in a footnote. Many English versions do this. For example:

Name her Lo-Ruhamah (NCV) Here is the NCV footnote:

[Lo-Ruhamah] This name in Hebrew means “not pitied.” (NCV)

- Write both the Hebrew name and the meaning in the translation. If you do this, avoid giving the impression that the LORD explained the meaning of the name to Hosea. The GW uses brackets to accomplish this. For example:

Name her Lo Ruhamah [Unloved].

If your readers are not familiar with this use of brackets, the first two options may be preferable to this one.

The names of Gomer’s next two children are discussed in 1:9a and 2:23b–c. Consider the context carefully to see whether you can use the same method to translate all three names. See especially the notes on 2:23b–c.

1:6c

for I will no longer have compassion on the house of Israel,

- because I will no longer show love/pity to the people/nation of Israel,
- I will stop loving/pitying the people of Israel.

for: In Hebrew, this word introduces a two-part reason for the LORD’s command that Hosea should name his child Lo-ruhamah. Most English versions translate this word as for or “because.” For example:

because I will not pity Israel anymore (NCV)

Some versions leave the connection implied. Introduce this two-part reason in a natural way in your language.

I will no longer have compassion on the house of Israel: This is the first reason that the LORD told Hosea to name his daughter Lo-ruhamah. The name will indicate to them that the LORD will no longer show them love or mercy.

have compassion: This is the verb in Hebrew from which Lo-ruhamah’s name is derived. You should translate this phrase with the same word or phrase that you used to describe the meaning of Lo-ruhamah’s name. For example, if you said that her name means “Not pitied,” you should also translate the verb here as “show pity.”

the house of Israel: This phrase is a figure of speech that refers here to the nation of Israel, specifically the people of that nation.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Israel (REB)

the nation of Israel (NET)

the people of Israel (GNT)

Try to translate the phrase house of Israel consistently, if the context is the same. In some verses, such as 1:4c, this phrase occurs in a different context, so your translation there may be different.

1:6d

that I should ever forgive them.

- and I certainly will not forgive them.
- I will not forgive them again.

that I should ever forgive them: In Hebrew, this clause is closely related to the previous statement, “I will no longer show love to the house of Israel.” It gives the second part of the reason for Lo-ruhamah’s name. Her name indicates that the LORD will no longer forgive them. Both clauses have a similar, negative meaning. See Follingstad for a comprehensive discussion of the particle *ki*. McComiskey (page 24) says that the second clause further develops the thought of the first clause. According to Andersen and Freedman (page 192), the conjunction *ki* is “resumptive or assertive.” Their translation connects the two clauses with the word “or.” Dearman (page 92) agrees with Andersen and Freedman that the negative word “not” in the first clause modifies the second clause as well. Dearman connects the two negative statements with the word “and.”

Here are some other ways to express the relationship between these clauses:

- Use a conjunction such as “and” or “or.” For example:

I will no longer show love to the people of Israel or forgive them (NLT)

I will no longer have mercy and forgive Israel (CEV)

- Start a new sentence or clause at this point. Leave the connection implied. For example:

I will no longer love the nation of Israel. I will no longer forgive them. (GW)

I shall never again show love to Israel, never again forgive them. (REB)

ever forgive them: In Hebrew, an emphatic form of the verb forgive is used here. It corresponds to the emphasis expressed in the phrase “no longer” in 1:6c. Some versions, such as the GW and REB quoted above, use an emphatic word or phrase in both 1:6c and 1:6d. The NET is similar:

I will no longer have pity on the nation of Israel.
For I will certainly not forgive their guilt. (NET)

Other English versions use one expression of emphasis to cover both phrases. For example:

I will no longer have mercy and forgive Israel.
(CEV)

Emphasize this phrase in a way that is natural in your language.

Hosea 1:7

Section 1:2–9: Hosea married an unfaithful wife and fathered three children

The LORD commanded Hosea to marry Gomer. She was an immoral woman who would be unfaithful to him. Her unfaithfulness illustrated Israel’s unfaithfulness to the LORD. The LORD also commanded Hosea to give their three children names that would serve as warnings of future judgments.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Hosea’s wife and children (GNT)

Hosea’s marriage symbolized the LORD’s relationship to Israel

Paragraph 1:6–7

This paragraph tells about the birth of Gomer’s second child. The meaning of the child’s name, “not loved/pitied,” reinforced the LORD’s promise that he would destroy the northern kingdom of Israel. He promised to show them no mercy. In contrast, the LORD promised to deliver the people of Judah from destruction.

1:7a

Yet I will have compassion on the house of Judah,

- But unlike the people/nation of Israel I will show love/pity to the people/nation of Judah.
- But as for the people/nation of Judah, I will love/pity them,

Yet I will have compassion on the house of Judah:

In contrast to the nation/people of Israel, the LORD will continue to show his compassion to the nation of Judah. This implies that the nation of Judah will not be judged/punished by the LORD at that time.

Yet: The BSB uses the conjunction Yet to introduce the contrast between the LORD’s judgment of Israel in 1:6 and his compassion toward Judah here in 1:7. Some versions use “but” or “instead.” You should introduce this contrast in a natural way in your language.

have compassion: This is the same verb that was used in 1:6c. You should translate it in the same way.

the house of Judah: This phrase is a figure of speech. It refers here to the people of the nation of Judah, the southern kingdom. See how you translated the similar expression “house of Israel” in 1:6c.

1:7b

and I will save them—

- I will rescue them from their enemies.
- and I will save/rescue them.

and I will save them: In this context, this phrase does not refer to spiritual salvation. The LORD promises here to save or rescue them from defeat by their enemies in battle.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I will deliver them (NET)

I will free them from their enemies (NLT)

I will rescue them (GW)

1:7c

not by bow or sword or war, not by horses and cavalry,

- It will not be their army that fights with its bows and swords that will rescue them. It will also not be their soldiers that ride on horses.
- But I will not use their soldiers or weapons or horses to save them.

not by bow or sword or war, not by horses and

cavalry: The bow and the sword were the main instruments used in war at that time. The horses and cavalry (the men who rode the horses or drove the chariots

into battle) were the strongest units in an army. By mentioning these weapons, horses, and cavalry, the LORD compared his power to the strongest human army and implied that he is stronger.

In some cultures, people may not be familiar with these weapons and the use of horses in war. If that is true in your culture, you may need to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

I will not do it by war—with swords or bows and arrows or with horses and horsemen (GNT)

I will personally free them from their enemies without any help from weapons or armies (NLT)

1:7d

but by the LORD their God.”

- Rather it will be Yahweh their God who will rescue them.”
- No, I myself, Yahweh their God, will rescue them with my own power.”

but by the LORD their God: The LORD indicated that he will not be using a human army as his instrument to save Judah. Instead, he will do it personally with his own power.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

but by my power as the LORD their God

General Comment on 1:7a–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of these verse parts. For example:

But I am the Lord God of Judah, and I will have mercy and save Judah by my own power—not by wars and arrows or swords and cavalry. (CEV)

Arrange this information in a natural order in your language.

Hosea 1:8

Section 1:2–9: Hosea married an unfaithful wife and fathered three children

The LORD commanded Hosea to marry Gomer. She was an immoral woman who would be unfaithful to him. Her unfaithfulness illustrated Israel’s unfaithfulness to the LORD. The LORD also commanded Hosea to give their three children names that would serve as warnings of future judgments.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Hosea’s wife and children (GNT)

Hosea’s marriage symbolized the LORD’s relationship to Israel

Paragraph 1:8–9

This paragraph tells about the birth of Gomer’s third child. Once again, the LORD told Hosea to give his child a name that would communicate a message of judgment to the people of Israel. This was the third and most severe judgment. In Exodus 6:7, the LORD described to Moses the covenant he would later make with the people of Israel at Mount Sinai. He said, “I will take you as my own people, and I will be your God.” (See also Leviticus 26:12). For many generations the people of Israel continued to break their covenant with the LORD and continued to reject him. As a result, the LORD negated the words of the covenant by saying: “you are not my people, and I am not your God.” (See the note on 1:9b.)

1:8

After she had weaned Lo-ruhamah, Gomer conceived and gave birth to a son.

- ¶ When/After Gomer weaned her daughter, Lo-Ruhamah, she became pregnant again and gave birth to another son.
- ¶ Time went by and Gomer stopped nursing Lo-Ruhamah. After that she became pregnant again and gave birth to their second male child.

After she had weaned Lo-ruhamah, Gomer conceived and gave birth to a son: As in 1:6a, the verse does not explicitly say that Hosea is the father, but it is implied here.

After she had weaned Lo-ruhamah: Unlike 1:6a, the author added these words to indicate that a certain amount of time (perhaps three years or so) passed by between the births of these two children.

Gomer conceived and gave birth to a son: Refer to the way you translated the similar expressions in 1:3b and 1:6a. For example:

she became pregnant again and had another son (GNT)

Hosea 1:9

Section 1:2–9: Hosea married an unfaithful wife and fathered three children

The LORD commanded Hosea to marry Gomer. She was an immoral woman who would be unfaithful to him. Her unfaithfulness illustrated Israel's unfaithfulness to the LORD. The LORD also commanded Hosea to give their three children names that would serve as warnings of future judgments.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Hosea's wife and children (GNT)

Hosea's marriage symbolized the LORD's relationship to Israel

Paragraph 1:8–9

This paragraph tells about the birth of Gomer's third child. Once again, the LORD told Hosea to give his child a name that would communicate a message of judgment to the people of Israel. This was the third and most severe judgment. In Exodus 6:7, the LORD described to Moses the covenant he would later make with the people of Israel at Mount Sinai. He said, "I will take you as my own people, and I will be your God." (See also Leviticus 26:12). For many generations the people of Israel continued to break their covenant with the LORD and continued to reject him. As a result, the LORD negated the words of the covenant by saying: "you are not my people, and I am not your God." (See the note on 1:9b.)

1:9a

And the LORD said, "Name him Lo-ammi,

- And Yahweh said to Hosea, "Name^(sing) him Lo-Ammi,
- Then Yahweh said to Hosea, "As for this child, name him 'Not My People.'

Name him Lo-ammi: The literal meaning of the Hebrew name Lo-ammi is "Not my people." It is important that your translation communicates the meaning of the name to your readers. If possible, use the same method to express the meaning of Lo-ammi as you used to express the meaning of Lo-ruhamah in 1:6b.

1:9b

for you are not My people, and I am not your God.

- because you^(plur) people of Israel are no longer my people, and I am no longer your^(plur) God."
- The reason is that you Israelites are not my people, and I am not the God whom you worship/serve."

for: This word introduces the reason that the LORD told Hosea to name his child Lo-ammi. Most English versions translate it as for or "because." Some versions leave this connection implied. Use a natural way in your language to introduce this reason.

you are not My people: This is the reason that the LORD told Hosea to name his son Lo-ammi. The name will indicate to the people of Israel that the LORD will no longer regard them as his people.

The pronoun you here is plural. Although God was speaking to Hosea, the plural pronoun indicates that these words referred to the people of Israel. If it is confusing to use a plural you pronoun, you may need to change the wording to make it clear that this clause refers to a group of people. For example:

because the people of Israel are not my people
(GNT)

because you, the people of Israel, are not my people

and I am not your God: In Hebrew, this clause is literally "and I, I will not be to you^(plur)." The word God is not in the Hebrew, but it is clearly implied. It is recommended that you make it explicit, as in most English versions.

If you translated the previous phrase "you are not my people" similarly to the GNT, it is suggested that you follow a similar approach here. For example:

and I am not their God (GNT)

In some languages, a phrase such as your God may imply "God belongs to you." If that is true in your language, you may need to express the meaning of this phrase in a different way. For example:

I am no longer the God whom you worship/serve.

If you have a section heading between this verse and 1:10, you will need to decide whether to use a closed quote mark at the end of the LORD's words. Some versions do, others do not. The meaning lines in the Display will use closed quote marks.

Hosea 1:10

Section 1:10–2:1: The LORD promised to make the people of Israel his own again

The Hebrew text has a chapter break here. It has different verse and chapter numbers from the majority of English translations. These Notes follow the system of most English versions (unlike the NJPS and the NJB, which follow the Hebrew numbering system). You need to decide which system you are going to follow and be consistent throughout your translation. Usually it is good to follow the same chapter and verse numbering that is used by most other translations in your area.

In the previous section, 1:2–9, the LORD said that he no longer considered the people of Israel to be his people. In this section, 1:10–2:1, the LORD continued to speak to the people of Israel. He told them that there was still hope. He would make them a great and mighty nation in the future.

The BSB does not start a new section here, but TN and some other versions do.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God's Promise to Israel (NCV)

Hope for Israel (CEV)

The Restoration of Israel (NRSV)

Paragraph 1:10–2:1

The message of future hope for Israel in this paragraph contrasts with the messages of judgment that precede it. The Israelites had been unfaithful to the LORD. They had broken the covenant he made with them through Moses at Mt. Sinai. In spite of that, the LORD reminded them here that he still intended to keep the promise of the earlier covenant that he had made with their ancestor Abraham. In the future, he will once again bless the nation of Israel. He will increase their numbers and reunite the northern kingdom of Israel with the southern kingdom of Judah.

1:10

If you start a new section here, you may need to make explicit at the beginning of 1:10 that the LORD is still speaking. For example:

The Lord continued to speak. He said ...

1:10a

Yet the number of the Israelites will be like the sand of the sea, which cannot be measured or counted.

- ¶ Then Yahweh said, “But in the future the people of Israel will become as many as the grains of sand on the seashore that no one can count or measure.
- ¶ Yahweh continued to speak, saying, “But in the future I will cause the Israelites to become many again. Their number will be like the sand on the edge of the ocean that is impossible to count.

Yet: This verse contrasts strongly with the previous verses. You should translate it in a way that indicates this contrast. If this is a new section in your translation, you may have to make the link to the previous section explicit by repeating part of verse 9. For example:

Although I have said that you are no longer my people, yet....

the Israelites: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “the number of the sons of Israel.” It refers here to the entire nation.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the number of the people of Israel (NRSV)

will be like the sand of the sea, which cannot be measured or counted: This is a figure of speech (simile) that the LORD first used in Genesis 22:17 and Genesis 32:12. Those verses expressed his covenant promise to Abraham. Here the simile compares the number of Israelites to the sand on the seashore. The point of similarity is that they will be so many that no one will be able to count them.

Hebrew and most English versions state the word “number” explicitly. For example:

the Israelites will become as numerous as the grains of sand on the seashore. No one will be able to measure them or count them. (GW)

the number of the people of Israel will be like the sand of the sea which can be neither measured nor numbered. (NET)

Translate in a natural way that makes the correct meaning of the simile clear.

cannot be measured or counted: The words measured and counted have almost the same meaning in this context. They are used together for the sake of emphasis. The word measured does not occur in either of the similar verses in Genesis. In this context, it refers to measuring the amount of something dry like sand, using a container whose size is known.

If your language has a word for measuring something like sand, you may use it here. If it is confusing to compare the number of people to sand that is measured, you may want to use only one expression, as some English versions have done. For example:

Someday it will be impossible to count the people of Israel, because there will be as many of them as there are grains of sand along the seashore. (CEV)

You should translate this figure of speech in a way that is consistent with Genesis 22:17 and 32:12, so that readers can recognize that these words refer back to the LORD's covenant with Abraham. At the same time, notice that there are some minor differences between these verses. If possible, you should maintain these differences in your translation. It is suggested that you refer to these Genesis verses in a footnote or in some other way.

1:10b–c

And it will happen that in the very place where it was said to them, 'You are not My people,' they will be called 'sons of the living God.'

- In the place where they were told, 'You^(plur) are no longer my people,' they will be told, 'You are children of the living God.'
- In the location where Yahweh said to them, 'You are not my people,' he will say to them, 'You are the children of the God who is alive.'
- In the place where Yahweh said to them that they were not his people, he will say to them that they are the children of the God who has life.

1:10b

in the very place where it was said to them: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as in the very place where:

1. It refers to a literal geographical place, either the land of Israel or the land where the people will be exiled. Andersen and Freedman, Stuart, Keil, Davies, McComiskey, Dearman, and Wood all understand this to refer to a place. Keil (page 32) supports the land of exile, citing v. 11 where the people come out of exile. The Targums, Rashi and Ibn Ezra also understand the land of exile, but Davies (pages 60–61)

feels that the land of Israel is more likely, following the people's return from exile. Wood (page 173) says that the particular place is not important. In this same place, the words that the LORD will say to the people will contrast with his previous words. For example:

at the place where they were told (NLT) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NIV, NLT, NJB, NRSV)

1. It is a special use of the Hebrew phrase. Here it means "in place of" or "instead of." It does not refer here to a literal place. It simply introduces the contrasting words that the LORD will say to the people with his previous words. For example:

instead of being told (NJPS) (CEV, GNT, NCV, NET, NJPS, REB) The CEV, NCV, REB, and GNT do not use an explicit word or phrase such as "instead." They simply give the contrasting statements. The NET has "Although..." indicating a concessive relationship. The NJPS is the only version that uses the word "instead."

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with almost all commentaries and lexicons. The Hebrew word for place normally refers to a location. It occurs with this meaning approximately five hundred times in the Old Testament. HALOT (#5582) says there are approximately 500 occurrences of maqom. All the senses given in HALOT refer to locations. TWOT (#1999h) says that this "noun represents the physical location where something is or ought to be." NIDOTTE (#5226) is similar. Its glosses all indicate locations. BDB (#8491, page 880) lists Hosea 1:10 (2:1) under sense 4, "place, locality, spot." It also lists this verse under sense 7, "peculiar uses," where it has "perhaps b...instead of." The two other verses listed under 7b (Isaiah 33:21 and Nahum 1:8) are not translated as "instead of" by any English version on TW or Bible Gateway. With this interpretation, the focus in this verse is still on the changed relationship between God and his people.

it was said to them: This is a passive clause. The implied speaker is the LORD.

If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb in this context, here is another way to translate it:

the LORD said to them

You are not My people: This is the same phrase as in 1:9b. Translate it the same way here.

1:10c

they will be called: This is a passive clause like the similar clause in 1:10b. See the General Comment on 1:10b–c for a way to translate this as an active clause.

sons of the living God: The Hebrew expression sons of can refer either to sons or to both sons and daughters. In this context, it refers to the entire nation, so a translation such as “children” is preferable to sons. For example:

they will be told they are ‘Children of the living God.’ (NJB)

living God: The phrase living God is probably used here to contrast the true God with the false gods that the people worshiped. Macintosh (page 36). God was truly alive. The false gods had no life.

General Comment on 1:10b–c

Try to use similar expressions in 1:10b and 1:10c to show the contrast between what the LORD called the people in the past and what he will call them in the future. For example:

^{10b}Wherever they were told, ‘You are not my people,’ ^{10c}they will be told, ‘You are the children of the living God.’ (GW)

Hosea 1:11**Section 1:10–2:1: The LORD promised to make the people of Israel his own again**

The Hebrew text has a chapter break here. It has different verse and chapter numbers from the majority of English translations. These Notes follow the system of most English versions (unlike the NJPS and the NJB, which follow the Hebrew numbering system). You need to decide which system you are going to follow and be consistent throughout your translation. Usually it is good to follow the same chapter and verse numbering that is used by most other translations in your area.

In the previous section, 1:2–9, the LORD said that he no longer considered the people of Israel to be his people. In this section, 1:10–2:1, the LORD continued to speak to the people of Israel. He told them that there was still hope. He would make them a great and mighty nation in the future.

The BSB does not start a new section here, but TN and some other versions do.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God’s Promise to Israel (NCV)

Hope for Israel (CEV)

The Restoration of Israel (NRSV)

Paragraph 1:10–2:1

The message of future hope for Israel in this paragraph contrasts with the messages of judgment that precede it. The Israelites had been unfaithful to the LORD. They had broken the covenant he made with them through Moses at Mt. Sinai. In spite of that, the LORD reminded them here that he still intended to keep the promise of the earlier covenant that he had made with their ancestor Abraham. In the future, he will once again bless the nation of Israel. He will increase their numbers and reunite the northern kingdom of Israel with the southern kingdom of Judah.

1:11a

Then the people of Judah and of Israel will be gathered together,

- The people of Judah and Israel will unite,
- The people/nation of Judah and the people/nation of Israel will become one kingdom/nation again.

the people of Judah and of Israel: In Hebrew, these two phrases are literally “sons of Judah” and “sons of Israel.” See the note on “the Israelites” in 1:10a. These expressions refer here to the nations or people of Judah and Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate these expressions:

Israel and Judah (CEV)

Judeans and Israelites (NJB)

will be gathered together: This phrase probably means that the previously divided kingdoms of Judah and Israel will become a single nation again.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The people of Judah and Israel will join together again (NCV)

The nations of Judah and Israel will unite

1:11b

and they will appoint for themselves one leader,

- and they will appoint one person as their ruler.

- At that time, they will choose one leader to rule over them all.

and they will appoint for themselves one leader:

After the time of King Solomon, the divided kingdoms of Israel and Judah each had their own leader. The future united kingdom will have a single leader.

Here is another way to translate this clause :

and will choose one leader for themselves (NCV)

1:11c

and will go up out of the land.

- And they will return from the land where they were exiles/captives.
- They will leave the land where they lived as captives of their enemies and return to their homeland.
- Then they will return to their own land.

and will go up out of the land: In Hebrew, this clause is literally “they will go up from the land.” There are three main ways to interpret this clause:

1. They will leave a foreign land to return to Israel. The people of Israel (and later Judah) will first be taken into exile, but in the future they will leave that land and return to their own country. Stuart (page 37). Some versions focus on leaving a foreign land. Others focus on returning to their own country. For example: The expression may be an allusion to the exodus from Egypt, which the people of Hosea’s time may have recognized. In Exodus 1:10, Pharaoh of Egypt warned that the Hebrews might “go up from the land,” that is, escape from Egypt. The BSB translation of the expression here in Hosea 1:11 can have that meaning.

they will return from exile together (NLT)

they will return to their own land (BSB, CEV, ESV, KJV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NLT, RSV)

1. The people will increase in numbers and spread beyond the borders of their land. For example:

and will spread far beyond their country (NJB) (NJB)

1. The people will prosper in their own land. This meaning is figurative. It fits with the metaphor of planting that is used in 2:23. For example:

they will grow and prosper in their land (GNT) (GNT, GW, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a majority of versions. It fits best with the rest of the verse.

1:11d

For great will be the day of Jezreel.

- Because the day of Jezreel will be a great/important day.
- They will do these things, because the day called Jezreel will be wonderful/marvelous! It is the day when God will again plant his people in his land.

For great will be the day of Jezreel: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as For:

1. It introduces a reason or explanation for the wonderful future result in 1:11a–c. In contrast to the negative connotations of Jezreel in 1:4–5, it explains that the LORD intends to give the name Jezreel the good connotations of planting. For example:

for great will be the day of Jezreel (REB) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NASB, NCV, The NCV has “because the day of Jezreel will be truly great. It has been listed under interpretation (1), because it translates the initial Hebrew word ki as “because.” The whole clause, which includes “truly great,” is also emphatic, but it differs from interpretation (2) in which the deictic particle ki introduces the clause as a whole. NIV, NJB, NRSV, REB)

1. It introduces an emphatic statement. Commentaries that support interpretation (2) include: Andersen and Freedman, Stuart, and Lange. Andersen and Freedman (pages 209–210) point out that this clause doesn’t seem to be a logical reason. They argue that ki serves rather to intensify the word “great.” Stuart (pages 35–36) admits that the ki clause is grammatically ambiguous, but he agrees that an explanation does not seem to fit here. He translates the clause as an exclamation: “How great the day of Jezreel will be!” In contrast to the negative connotations of Jezreel in 1:4–5, it emphasizes the LORD’s wonderful plans for Jezreel in the future. For example:

Certainly, the day of Jezreel will be great! (NET) (GNT, NET, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Most versions and commentaries follow this

interpretation. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include: Keil, McComiskey, Dearman, and Barnes. McComiskey (page 30) gives the fullest explanation that the Hebrew particle introduces a reason here. He says that “Jezreel...prefigures a time of sowing (or great repopulation) for the nation.... Thus Hosea gives new significance to the name of the valley that witnessed the demise of the northern kingdom...” Other commentaries (including Wood and Macintosh) do not mention the particle *ki* specifically, but their understanding of the new future significance of the name Jezreel is very similar to that of McComiskey. See also TWOT (#976), which mentions that the assertive use of *ki* is relatively rare compared to the other uses.

However, some scholars think that 1:11d is not a logical reason or explanation for 1:11a–c. If that is true in your language, you may want to follow interpretation (2). With either interpretation, it is recommended that you give the other interpretation in a footnote.

great: Some other ways to translate the word *great* are “important” or “wonderful.”

the day of Jezreel: The word Jezreel referred to the name of a valley in Israel. It was also the name of Hosea’s son (see 1:4a). It literally means “God scatters.” In 1:4–5, it had the bad connotation that God would scatter Israel among the nations. Here it means “scatters/sows (seed).” The expression *day of Jezreel* probably refers to a time in the future when the LORD will figuratively “plant” the people of Israel in their own country after their exile.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

- Use the literal expression *day of Jezreel* in your translation.
- Use the literal expression *day of Jezreel* in your translation along with the meaning. For example:

the day of Jezreel, the day when God will again plant his people in his land
Adapted from the NLT.

- Use the name Jezreel in your translation, but adjust the expression *day of*. For example:

the day called Jezreel

Whichever way you translate the expression *day of Jezreel*, it is recommended that you add a footnote to explain the meaning. Here is a possible footnote:

Jezreel means “God scatters.” In 1:4–5 it implied that God would punish his people by scattering them far from their own country. Here it implies that God will scatter his people like a sower scatters seed and will cause them to grow once again in their own country.

Hosea 2:1

Section 1:10–2:1: The LORD promised to make the people of Israel his own again

The Hebrew text has a chapter break here. It has different verse and chapter numbers from the majority of English translations. These Notes follow the system of most English versions (unlike the NJPS and the NJB, which follow the Hebrew numbering system). You need to decide which system you are going to follow and be consistent throughout your translation. Usually it is good to follow the same chapter and verse numbering that is used by most other translations in your area.

In the previous section, 1:2–9, the LORD said that he no longer considered the people of Israel to be his people. In this section, 1:10–2:1, the LORD continued to speak to the people of Israel. He told them that there was still hope. He would make them a great and mighty nation in the future.

The BSB does not start a new section here, but TN and some other versions do.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God’s Promise to Israel (NCV)

Hope for Israel (CEV)

The Restoration of Israel (NRSV)

Paragraph 1:10–2:1

The message of future hope for Israel in this paragraph contrasts with the messages of judgment that precede it. The Israelites had been unfaithful to the LORD. They had broken the covenant he made with them through Moses at Mt. Sinai. In spite of that, the LORD reminded them here that he still intended to keep the promise of the earlier covenant that he had made with their ancestor Abraham. In the future, he will once again bless the nation of Israel. He will increase their numbers and reunite the northern kingdom of Israel with the southern kingdom of Judah.

2:1**“Say of your brothers, ‘My people,’ and of your sisters, ‘My loved one.’**

- People of Israel, call your^(plur) brothers ‘My People’ and your sisters ‘The one I love.’
- So call your fellow Israelites ‘Yahweh’s People’ and ‘Loved by Yahweh.’
- At that time, you Israelites will be able to say to each other that they are again Yahweh’s people, the people he loves.

This verse refers back to the LORD’s messages of judgment in 1:6 and 1:9. In those verses, the LORD told Hosea to name his children “Not Loved” and “Not My People” (see notes on 1:9b). In this verse, he uses the same words as in 1:6 and 1:9 to promise a renewal of his covenant with them.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

Say of your brothers, **‘My people,’**

and of your sisters, **‘My loved one.’**

These two parallel statements are a poetic way to emphasize that the LORD is restoring his covenant relationship with all the people.

brothers...sisters: Both of these terms refer to the same people, that is, Israelites. They do not refer to literal brothers and sisters. In languages that do not use gender-specific terms for brothers and sisters, you may need to use phrases such as “male siblings” and “female siblings.”

‘My people’...‘My loved one’: In Hebrew, the name of Hosea’s daughter was Lo-ruhamah “Not Loved” and the name of his son was Lo-ammi “Not My People.” (See 1:6 and 1:9) The word lo in Hebrew means “not.” In this verse, the Hebrew words are literally ruhamah and ammi. These are the exact same words as in 1:6 and 1:9, except that they are not preceded by the word “not.” If it is possible in your language, you should translate these expressions in a way that makes this connection to 1:6 and 1:9 clear.

To do that, use the same method to express My people and My loved one in your translation as you used to express the meaning of Lo-Ruhamah in 1:6b and Lo-ammi in 1:9a. For example, if you used the Hebrew name, lo-ruhamah in your translation of 1:6 and gave the meaning in a footnote, then use the Hebrew word ruhamah here and give the meaning loved in a footnote. Or, if you translated the name Lo-ruhamah as

“Not Loved” in your translation of 1:6, then here you should translate “Loved.”

It is also important that in your translation the pronoun referent of “my” will be understood as the LORD and not as the Israelite who is speaking to his brother or sister. In other words, My people means “the LORD’s people” and My loved one means “the LORD’s loved one.” In some languages, it may be clearer to make the pronoun referent explicit. For example:

“the LORD’s People” and “Loved-by-the-Lord.”

General Comment on 2:1

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine the parallel ideas into one line. For example:

So call your fellow Israelites “the LORD’s People” and “Loved-by-the-LORD.” Adapted from the GNT.

Hosea 2:2**Section 2:2–13: The LORD promised to punish the people of Israel**

In this section, the LORD described the crisis that resulted from Israel being unfaithful to him by following other gods. He warned Israel about the punishment that he would inflict on them if they continued their unfaithfulness. There is a sharp contrast between the negative tone in this section and the positive tone in the previous one.

The first words of this section seem to be a command by Hosea to his children. He commanded them to rebuke their mother (2:2a). However, the words “declares the LORD” in 2:13c indicate that the LORD is the speaker throughout this section. The reason for this double reference is that this section has both literal and figurative meanings. Literally, it applies to the relationship between Hosea, his wife Gomer, and their children. Figuratively, it expresses the relationship between the LORD and Israel. In a complex metaphor, the nation of Israel is compared to the LORD’s wife. At the same time, the entire nation of Israel is compared to a mother, and the individual Israelites that made up the nation are compared to her children. Andersen and Freedman (pages 219–220) and Wood (page 175).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The LORD’s future punishment of Israel

Israel is the Lord’s unfaithful wife (GW)

Unfaithful Gomer—Unfaithful Israel (GNT)

Paragraph 2:2–5

This paragraph contains the first examples in Hosea of Hebrew poetry, including the use of parallel lines. See The form in the Introduction for more information on formatting poetry and translating parallel lines.

2:2a

Rebuke your mother, rebuke her,

- ¶ “Accuse/Rebuke your^(plur) mother, accuse/rebuke her of/for committing adultery,
- ¶ “My children, bring a serious charge against your mother for her crime of unfaithfulness to me.

Rebuke your mother, rebuke her: In Hebrew, the word rebuke means “to fight with words,” as in a quarrel or a legal case. There are two ways to interpret the word here:

1. It means to accuse. The children were told to accuse their mother of adultery. This expression would be appropriate for an accusation in a trial for adultery (Stuart, page 47). According to ancient documents, an adulterous wife was sometimes punished by stripping her naked and turning her away. The children typically performed this legal act. It was intended to humiliate a wife who had abandoned her husband to live with another man (IVP Bible Background Commentary). For example:

Accuse! Accuse your mother! (CEV) (BSB, CEV, NAB, NASB, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB)

1. It means to plead. The children were told to plead with their mother to stop her adultery. For example:

Plead with your mother, plead (NRSV) (ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NET, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most lexicons and commentaries. The Hebrew verb used in this verse is not used elsewhere in the Old Testament to describe an appeal that someone change his ways.

Some English versions use an expression that refers to an actual trial. For example:

take your mother to court (NJB)

But this verse may also refer to an informal accusation or rebuke, so if possible, use a more general expression, as in the NIV or CEV.

Rebuke...rebuke: In Hebrew and in some English versions, the word is repeated to emphasize the seriousness of this command. Another way to give emphasis is to add a word that intensifies the meaning. For example:

Sternly accuse your mother

Use a natural way in your language to emphasize this command.

your mother: This phrase refers literally to Gomer, the mother of Hosea’s children. At the same time, Gomer represented the entire nation of Israel. Her children represented the individual Israelites whom the LORD commanded to rebuke the nation.

If possible, translate this phrase in a general way that allows both meanings to be understood. If the figurative meaning is not clear from the context, you may want to explain it in a footnote. For example:

In this verse, Hosea told his children to accuse their mother Gomer of committing adultery. This was a symbol of the LORD telling individual Israelites to accuse their mother, the nation of Israel, of committing spiritual adultery by worshipping idols.

2:2b

for she is not My wife,

- because now she does not consider herself to be my wife,
- She no longer acts like she is my wife.

2:2c

and I am not her husband.

- and/so now I do not consider myself to be her husband.
- As a result, I no longer act like I am her husband.

2:2b–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{2b}for she is **not My wife,**

^{2c}and I am **not her husband.**

for: This word introduces the reason that the children are told to rebuke their mother. They should rebuke her because she is no longer behaving like a wife. The GNT is the only version that indicates concession rather than reason. It has “plead with your mother—

though she is no longer a wife...” TN recommends that you not follow the GNT here.

not My wife...not her husband: Together these two statements emphasize that Israel had broken its covenant with the LORD, just as Gomer had broken her marriage covenant with Hosea. As a result, the LORD could no longer treat Israel as his people, and Hosea could no longer act as Gomer’s husband.

These statements probably indicate a broken relationship rather than divorce. Macintosh (page 41) and McComiskey (page 32). This is because in the next verses the husband continues to urge his wife, through the children, to stop her adulterous behavior and to reconcile with him.

One way to avoid implying divorce is to make it clear that these statements refer to actions or attitudes, not to an actual legal status. For example:

^{2b}She no longer acts like my wife. (GW)

^{2c}And I no longer act like I am her husband.

Be careful not to imply that the husband had been unfaithful to his wife and had broken their relationship.

2:2d–e (combined/reordered)

- Tell/Command^(plur) her to stop her prostitution and adultery.
- She must stop sleeping with men who are not her husband.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{2d}Let her remove the adultery **from her face**

^{2e}and the unfaithfulness **from between her breasts.**

the adultery...the unfaithfulness: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as adultery is literally “her immoralities.” The word “immoralities” means sexual activity that is contrary to God’s law. It is the same word that was used in 1:2b.

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as unfaithfulness is literally “her adulteries.” The word “adulteries” refers to sexual intercourse with someone other than her husband.

Both these plural terms describe the woman’s character. They indicate repeated or habitual behavior, as in

the NCV and NET quoted below. Biblical Hebrew Reference Grammar for Students, NET footnote.

from her face...from between her breasts: In Hebrew, it is common to refer to behavior by mentioning the parts of the body (face, breasts) that are associated with this behavior. These figurative expressions refer to the shameless attitude and behavior of a woman who is openly immoral and unfaithful to her husband. According to Macintosh (page 39), biblical Hebrew commonly refers to particular parts of the body to describe both attitudes and actions. He mentions Jeremiah 3:3 and Ezekiel 23, both of which describe prostitutes in language that is similar to Hosea 2:2. Keil, Wood, and Lange also favor the view that these figurative expressions refer primarily to the woman’s behavior. Stuart, Andersen and Freedman, and Davies suggest that the expressions may (also) refer to the makeup and/or jewelry that a prostitute wore. The NLT translates the first expression as “makeup.” No other versions use terms such as makeup or jewelry.

Here are some other ways to translate these expressions:

to stop acting like a prostitute, to stop behaving like an unfaithful wife. (NCV)

put an end to her adulterous lifestyle, and turn away from her sexually immoral behavior (NET)

2:2d

Let her remove the adultery from her face

- Tell/Command^(plur) her to stop behaving like a prostitute.
- I want her to turn from her prostitution.

Let her remove: In Hebrew, this verb phrase is an indirect third-person wish or command that the woman stop committing adultery. Hosea is instructing his children to tell their mother to stop being unfaithful to him.

If it is not natural to use a third-person command in your language, here are some other ways to translate this command:

Tell her to stop... (GW)

I want her to stop...

She must stop...

General Comment on 2:2d–e

These two statements emphasize one main point. If parallel statements imply two different points in your language, consider combining them into a single statement. For example:

She must stop her adultery and prostitution.

2:2e

and the unfaithfulness from between her breasts.

- Tell/Command^(plur) her to stop committing adultery.
- She must no longer have sex with other men.

Hosea 2:3

Section 2:2–13: The LORD promised to punish the people of Israel

In this section, the LORD described the crisis that resulted from Israel being unfaithful to him by following other gods. He warned Israel about the punishment that he would inflict on them if they continued their unfaithfulness. There is a sharp contrast between the negative tone in this section and the positive tone in the previous one.

The first words of this section seem to be a command by Hosea to his children. He commanded them to rebuke their mother (2:2a). However, the words “declares the LORD” in 2:13c indicate that the LORD is the speaker throughout this section. The reason for this double reference is that this section has both literal and figurative meanings. Literally, it applies to the relationship between Hosea, his wife Gomer, and their children. Figuratively, it expresses the relationship between the LORD and Israel. In a complex metaphor, the nation of Israel is compared to the LORD’s wife. At the same time, the entire nation of Israel is compared to a mother, and the individual Israelites that made up the nation are compared to her children. Andersen and Freedman (pages 219–220) and Wood (page 175).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The LORD’s future punishment of Israel

Israel is the Lord’s unfaithful wife (GW)

Unfaithful Gomer—Unfaithful Israel (GNT)

Paragraph 2:2–5

This paragraph contains the first examples in Hosea of Hebrew poetry, including the use of parallel lines.

See The form in the Introduction for more information on formatting poetry and translating parallel lines.

2:3a–b (combined/reordered)

- If she does not stop her shameless behavior/conduct, I will shame her by making her as naked as she was on the day she was born.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{3a}I will strip her **naked**

^{3b}and expose her **like the day of her birth**.

Both lines refer to the punishment of taking off the clothes of the adulteress so that she will be naked in public.

These statements also illustrate what the LORD threatens to do to the nation of Israel. To “strip her naked” may indicate that the LORD will remove everything he has given to her since the time he rescued her from Egypt. The “day of her birth” may refer to the time in the wilderness before Israel entered the Promised Land. Macintosh (page 44) and Andersen and Freedman (page 225). Compare to Ezekiel 16. In some translations, it may be appropriate to explain this symbolic meaning in a footnote.

2:3a

Otherwise, I will strip her naked

- If she does not obey, I will remove her clothes from her body,
- If she refuses, I will humiliate her by taking off her clothes.

Otherwise: This word introduces a list of ways (2:3a–e) that the wife will be punished if she does not stop her immoral behavior.

Here are some other ways to express this relationship in 2:3a:

lest I strip her naked (RSV)

or else I shall strip her bare (REB)

If she refuses, I will strip her. (GW)

Use a natural way in your language to express this relationship.

2:3b

and expose her like the day of her birth.

- and she will be completely naked like on the day when she was born.
- I will cause her nakedness to be seen just like on the day of her birth.

expose her like the day of her birth: When a child is born, it is bare/naked. Instead of making explicit the idea of exposing the woman in public, some versions make explicit the idea of being naked to make the meaning clearer in English. For example:

make her as bare as on the day... (NIV)

strip her as naked as she was on the day... (GNT)

General Comment on 2:3a–b

In some languages, it may be clearer to combine the parallel ideas into one line. For example:

I will strip her as naked as she was on the day she was born. (GNT)

2:3c–d (combined/reordered)

- I will make her like a dry land/wilderness that has no water.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{3c}I will make her like **a desert**

^{3d}and turn her into **a parched land**,

In these lines, the husband threatens to deprive his wife of food and water as if she were in a dry desert/wilderness area. The BART interlinear glosses this term as “wilderness.” TWOT (#399l) also uses the term “wilderness.” A “parched land” is a land that has no water. These statements are figures of speech. They illustrate what the LORD will do to the nation of Israel.

General Comment on 2:3c–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these parallel statements. For example:

I will make her like a dry and barren land. (GNT)

2:3c I will make her like a desert

- Then I will make her like a dry desert,

2:3d and turn her into a parched land,

- like land where there is no water.

2:3e and I will let her die of thirst.

- And I will allow/cause to her to die from thirst.
- She will become so thirsty that she dies.

and I will let her die of thirst: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “I should make her die with thirst.” The phrase “let her die of thirst” may refer to the wife or to the people of Israel (Andersen and Freedman, page 227; McComiskey, page 33). It may also refer to the land of Israel becoming infertile (Macintosh, pages 44–45). Some versions do not state explicitly that the LORD will cause her death. For example:

she will die of thirst (GNT)

This may be a good option in some languages, if the context clearly implies that the LORD will cause this to happen.

General Comment on 2:3c–e

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these lines. For example:

I will leave her to die of thirst, as in a dry and barren wilderness. (NLT)

Hosea 2:4

Section 2:2–13: The LORD promised to punish the people of Israel

In this section, the LORD described the crisis that resulted from Israel being unfaithful to him by following other gods. He warned Israel about the punishment that he would inflict on them if they continued their unfaithfulness. There is a sharp contrast between the negative tone in this section and the positive tone in the previous one.

The first words of this section seem to be a command by Hosea to his children. He commanded them to rebuke their mother (2:2a). However, the words “declares the LORD” in 2:13c indicate that the LORD is the speaker throughout this section. The reason for this double reference is that this section has both literal and figurative meanings. Literally, it applies to the relationship between Hosea, his wife Gomer, and their children. Figuratively, it expresses the relationship between the LORD and Israel. In a complex metaphor, the nation of Israel is compared to the LORD’s wife. At

the same time, the entire nation of Israel is compared to a mother, and the individual Israelites that made up the nation are compared to her children. Andersen and Freedman (pages 219–220) and Wood (page 175).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The LORD's future punishment of Israel

Israel is the Lord's unfaithful wife (GW)

Unfaithful Gomer—Unfaithful Israel (GNT)

Paragraph 2:2–5

This paragraph contains the first examples in Hosea of Hebrew poetry, including the use of parallel lines. See The form in the Introduction for more information on formatting poetry and translating parallel lines.

2:4a

I will have no compassion on her children,

- I will also not show my love/pity to you^(plur), her children,

I will have no compassion on her children: Here the topic changes from the mother to her children. Some versions indicate this change by adding a word such as “also.” For example:

Upon her children also I will have no mercy (ESV)

You may want to do the same thing to help your readers notice the change of topic.

her children: This phrase refers literally to Gomer's children. It also refers symbolically to the individual Israelites.

I will have no compassion: In Hebrew, the verb have... compassion is the same verb that was used in 1:6c. See how you translated it in that verse.

on her children: In 2:2a, the LORD says, “your mother” when he speaks to the children. Here in 2:4a, he speaks to the same group of people, but he refers to them as her children instead of “you children.” In some languages, it may be clearer to use the pronoun “you” here. For example:

You children..., I'll show you no pity. (CEV)

2:4b

because they are the children of adultery.

- because your^(plur) mother is a prostitute.
- because you are the children of a woman who sleeps with other men.

because: This conjunction introduces the reason that the LORD will not show his love to her children. Some English versions translate it as “for” or because. Other versions leave this conjunction implied. Use a natural way in your language to introduce a reason.

they are the children of adultery: This is the reason that the LORD will not show his love to her children. The children were born to an immoral mother and shared the disgrace of their association with her.

In Hebrew, this expression is almost identical to the phrase “children of adultery” in 1:2b. The only difference is that a different Hebrew word for children is used. You should translate it in a way that is consistent with your translation there.

Here is another way to translate this clause here:

they are the children of a prostitute (NCV)

General Comment on 2:4a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of these verse parts. Notice that if the order is changed, it may be necessary to use a different conjunction between 2:4a and 2:4b. For example:

^{4b}As for you children, your mother is a prostitute,

^{4a}so I will show you no pity.

Hosea 2:5

Section 2:2–13: The LORD promised to punish the people of Israel

In this section, the LORD described the crisis that resulted from Israel being unfaithful to him by following other gods. He warned Israel about the punishment that he would inflict on them if they continued their unfaithfulness. There is a sharp contrast between the negative tone in this section and the positive tone in the previous one.

The first words of this section seem to be a command by Hosea to his children. He commanded them to rebuke their mother (2:2a). However, the words “declares the LORD” in 2:13c indicate that the LORD is the speaker throughout this section. The reason for this double reference is that this section has both literal and figurative meanings. Literally, it applies to the relationship between Hosea, his wife Gomer, and their children. Figuratively, it expresses the relationship between the LORD and Israel. In a complex metaphor,

the nation of Israel is compared to the LORD's wife. At the same time, the entire nation of Israel is compared to a mother, and the individual Israelites that made up the nation are compared to her children. Andersen and Freedman (pages 219–220) and Wood (page 175).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The LORD's future punishment of Israel

Israel is the Lord's unfaithful wife (GW)

Unfaithful Gomer—Unfaithful Israel (GNT)

Paragraph 2:2–5

This paragraph contains the first examples in Hosea of Hebrew poetry, including the use of parallel lines. See The form in the Introduction for more information on formatting poetry and translating parallel lines.

2:5a–b

(combined/reordered)

- Indeed, the one who gave birth to you^(plur) has been acting like a prostitute. What she is doing is shameful!
- For your very own mother has been acting shamefully by selling her body to other men.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{5a}For their mother **has played the whore**; (NRSV)

^{5b} she who conceived them **has acted shamefully**. (NRSV)

Both lines mean that the mother of the children has acted like a prostitute. The NRSV has been used as the source line, because it shows the parallel parts more clearly.

2:5a

For their mother has played the harlot

- Yes, your^(plur) mother has behaved like a prostitute.

(NRSV) For their mother has played the whore: The Hebrew word that the NRSV translates as For indicates here that the parallel statements in 2:5 are an explanation. They explain the way in which the mother's children are the children of adultery.

Here are some other ways to introduce this explanation in 2:5a:

Yes, their mother... (NJB)

What I mean is that their mother...

Some English versions leave this Hebrew conjunction implied. Use a natural way in your language to introduce an explanation.

their mother: See the note on “on her children” in 2:4a. Here there is a similar change of pronoun from “your” to their. As in 2:4a, the husband (symbolizing the LORD) is still speaking to the children. So in some languages, it may be clearer to use the same pronoun as in 2:2a. For example:

your mother

has played the whore: The Hebrew expression that the NRSV translates as has played the whore is literally “she has committed fornication.” The word “fornication” can refer to adultery or prostitution. The latter part of the verse indicates that she received pay for her acts of adultery. So prostitution is the meaning in this context. For example:

acted like a prostitute (GW)

Some versions use a more general expression. For example:

has been unfaithful (NIV)

Use an expression in your language that fits the context.

2:5b

and has conceived them in disgrace.

- This woman who became pregnant with you^(plur) has behaved disgracefully.

(NRSV) she who conceived them: This phrase is a more specific way to refer to the parallel part “their mother” in 2:5a. Both expressions refer to the same person.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

The woman who became pregnant with them (GW)

the one who gave birth to them

(NRSV) has acted shamefully: This phrase describes the mother's behavior as a prostitute in 2:5a. It was considered shameful or disgraceful for a married woman to engage in prostitution.

Here is another way to translate this expression:

did shameful things (GW)

General Comment on 2:5a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine the parallel parts. For example:

Yes, your mother, the one who gave birth to you, has behaved like a shameless prostitute.

For your very own mother has been acting shamefully, selling her body to other men.

2:5c

For she thought, 'I will go after my lovers,

- She said, 'I will go look for other men to sleep with.
- She decided to give herself to her sexual partners instead of her husband.

For: In Hebrew, this verse part begins with a word that the BSB and many versions translate as For. It indicates that the statements that follow give an explanation. They explain the way in which the mother has acted like a shameless prostitute. Other versions leave this connection implied. Use a natural way in your language to introduce an explanation.

she thought, 'I will go after my lovers: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as thought is literally "said" In this statement, the husband used a direct quote to tell his children what their mother had said, thought or decided. According to Keil (page 37), the verb "said" may indicate either speaking or thinking. Both McComiskey (page 34) and Andersen and Freedman (page 230) say that this quote represents a decision on the part of the wife. It is not clear whether she spoke these words to her husband or merely made a decision, using these words, in her mind. In some languages, it may be more natural to use indirect speech for the statement. For example:

she said/decided that she would go after her lovers...

I will go after my lovers: This clause means that the woman will go and look for men who will pay her to have sex with them. It emphasizes her deliberate in-

tention to be unfaithful to her husband. Symbolically, it refers to Israel's deliberate worship of the gods of other nations, such as Baal, rather than her own God.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I shall chase after my lovers (NJB)

I will seek out my lovers (NET)

I will search for men who are willing to have sex with me

2:5d

who give me bread and water, wool and linen, oil and drink.'

- They supply me with what I eat and drink. They also give me my clothing made of wool and linen, my olive oil, and wine.'
- She depended on them to pay her with the food, water, and clothes that she needed, as well as olive oil and wine.

who give me bread and water, wool and linen, oil and drink: This verse part describes her "lovers" in terms of the payments a prostitute expected them to offer in exchange for sexual relations.

Here is another way to translate this verse part:

She herself said, "I will go to my lovers—they give me food and water, wool and linen, olive oil and wine." (GNT)

give: The word give refers here to payment. It does not refer to gifts. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this clear. For example:

I'll...sell myself to them for food and water... (NLT)

they pay me with food and water...

bread and water: This expression refers to the basic requirements of life. In Hebrew, the word bread is often a figure of speech that represents food.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

what I eat and drink

the food and water that I need

wool and linen: wool is the hair of sheep. linen is thread made from a plant called flax. Some versions translate this as “flax” (NRSV). These were the basic materials that the Israelites used to make their clothing. Some versions make this purpose explicit. For example:

for clothing of wool and linen (NLT)

If your language does not have specific terms for wool and linen, you may use a more general word or phrase. For example:

my clothing

the clothes that I wear

oil: The word oil is a general term that refers to oil from plants or from animal fat. Here it probably refers to olive oil. It was used mainly for cooking, but also for perfume and incense. Andersen and Freedman (page 233). For example:

olive oil (GNT)

In areas where olive oil is not known, you may use a more general term that refers to cooking oil.

drink: In Hebrew, the word drink can refer in general to any drink, but it probably refers here to alcoholic drinks. Hubbard (page 74), Keil (page 54), and Andersen and Freedman (page 48). Some versions, including the GNT, have:

wine (GNT)

Hosea 2:6

Section 2:2–13: The LORD promised to punish the people of Israel

In this section, the LORD described the crisis that resulted from Israel being unfaithful to him by following other gods. He warned Israel about the punishment that he would inflict on them if they continued their unfaithfulness. There is a sharp contrast between the negative tone in this section and the positive tone in the previous one.

The first words of this section seem to be a command by Hosea to his children. He commanded them to rebuke their mother (2:2a). However, the words “declares the LORD” in 2:13c indicate that the LORD is the speaker throughout this section. The reason for this

double reference is that this section has both literal and figurative meanings. Literally, it applies to the relationship between Hosea, his wife Gomer, and their children. Figuratively, it expresses the relationship between the LORD and Israel. In a complex metaphor, the nation of Israel is compared to the LORD’s wife. At the same time, the entire nation of Israel is compared to a mother, and the individual Israelites that made up the nation are compared to her children. Andersen and Freedman (pages 219–220) and Wood (page 175).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The LORD’s future punishment of Israel

Israel is the Lord’s unfaithful wife (GW)

Unfaithful Gomer—Unfaithful Israel (GNT)

Paragraph 2:6–7

In this paragraph, the husband (symbolizing the LORD) continued talking to his children about the unfaithfulness of their mother (symbolizing the nation of Israel). He told them that he will discipline her so that she will change her behavior and return to him.

2:6

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{6a}Therefore, behold, I will hedge up her path with thorns;

^{6b} I will enclose her with a wall so she cannot find her way.

In 2:6b, the parallelism implies that thornbushes will also be used to wall in the woman. The purpose of blocking her path or making a wall around her with thornbushes is to keep her from going to her lovers.

2:6a–b (combined/reordered)

- ¶ “That is why I will soon make a wall/fence of thornbushes to keep her from going to her lovers.
- ¶ “So this is what I will do now: I will be like a person who makes a thorn fence/wall around his animal. Then she will not be able to do what she decided.

I will hedge up her path with thorns; I will enclose her with a wall: The MT has “your path.” The LXX and Syriac both have “her path.” All English versions consulted have “her.” It is recommended that you follow the LXX. The pronoun “her” fits the parallelism. The

speaker is addressing the children. He is not talking to the wife directly. It was a common practice to make a fence, hedge, or wall out of thornbushes either to protect a vineyard or to keep an animal from wandering off. Here the two lines are used figuratively. The husband will restrain his wife from leaving home to look for other lovers just like a person fences in an animal to keep it from wandering away.

If the figurative meaning is not clear, it may be necessary to change the metaphors to similes and to make some of the points of comparison explicit. For example:

It is as if I will hedge up her path with thorns. I will restrain her like a person fences in an animal.

I will keep her from leaving home. She will be like an animal whose owner plants thornbushes across its path or builds a wall around it so that it cannot wander away.

General Comment on 2:6a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine the parallel ideas into one line. For example:

I, the Lord will build a fence of thorns to block her path. (CEV)

2:6a

Therefore, behold, I will hedge up her path with thorns;

- ¶ “Therefore/So I will now place thornbushes across her path.
- ¶ “That is the reason I will restrain her like a person blocks an animal’s path with thornbushes.

Therefore: In Hebrew, this word introduces the husband’s response that results from the immoral behavior of his wife.

Here are some other ways to introduce this result:

That is why (REB)

So (GNT)

Some versions leave the connection implied. Use a natural way in your language to introduce this result.

behold: In Hebrew, the next word in this sentence is *hinneh*. Some versions translate this word as *behold*, as the BSB does. Some other versions leave this word

implied. The usual function of *hinneh* is to direct the attention of the reader or listener to what follows. Here, the LORD described what will happen immediately or in the near future. The Hebrew word expresses “the immediacy, the here-and-now-ness, of the situation” (Lambdin, page 168). For example:

Therefore, I will soon fence her in with thorns
(NET)

Use a natural way in your language to produce this sense of immediate action.

2:6b

I will enclose her with a wall, so she cannot find her way.

- I will make a wall so that she cannot find the way to her lovers.
- I will treat her like a person who fences/walls in his animal so that it cannot wander away.

Hosea 2:7

Section 2:2–13: The LORD promised to punish the people of Israel

In this section, the LORD described the crisis that resulted from Israel being unfaithful to him by following other gods. He warned Israel about the punishment that he would inflict on them if they continued their unfaithfulness. There is a sharp contrast between the negative tone in this section and the positive tone in the previous one.

The first words of this section seem to be a command by Hosea to his children. He commanded them to rebuke their mother (2:2a). However, the words “declares the LORD” in 2:13c indicate that the LORD is the speaker throughout this section. The reason for this double reference is that this section has both literal and figurative meanings. Literally, it applies to the relationship between Hosea, his wife Gomer, and their children. Figuratively, it expresses the relationship between the LORD and Israel. In a complex metaphor, the nation of Israel is compared to the LORD’s wife. At the same time, the entire nation of Israel is compared to a mother, and the individual Israelites that made up the nation are compared to her children. Andersen and Freedman (pages 219–220) and Wood (page 175).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The LORD’s future punishment of Israel

Israel is the Lord's unfaithful wife (GW)

Unfaithful Gomer—Unfaithful Israel (GNT)

Paragraph 2:6–7

In this paragraph, the husband (symbolizing the LORD) continued talking to his children about the unfaithfulness of their mother (symbolizing the nation of Israel). He told them that he will discipline her so that she will change her behavior and return to him.

2:7a–b (combined/reordered)

- Then, when she tries to meet with her lovers, she will not succeed.
- Her repeated efforts to go and sleep with other men will not be successful.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{7a} She will pursue **her lovers but not catch them**;

^{7b} she will seek **them but not find them**.

The underlined parts indicate the woman's persistence in trying to have sex with her lovers. The parts in italics indicate the failure of her efforts.

2:7a She will pursue her lovers but not catch them;

- Then, when she pursues/chases her lovers, she will not catch them.
- Even though she continues to try to have sex with other men, she will not be able to do it.

She will pursue her lovers but not catch them: This verse describes what the woman will do after her husband has figuratively enclosed her with a wall of thornbushes. In Hebrew, a conjunction is used at the start of this verse to introduce the woman's action. Some versions, such as the BSB, do not translate this conjunction explicitly. Other versions use an explicit conjunction. For example:

then if she chases her lovers she will not catch them (NJB)

Use a natural word or phrase in your language to introduce the next thing that will happen.

but not catch them: This phrase describes an intended result that will not happen. The woman will try to catch her lovers, but she will not succeed.

Here is another way to express this relationship:

Though she pursues her lovers, she will not overtake them (REB)

This line has a similar meaning to 2:5c. It refers to the woman's persistent efforts to go and have sex with other men. In some languages, a literal translation may wrongly imply that the lovers are trying to run away or that the woman cannot run fast enough to catch them. Use an expression in your language that gives the right meaning. For example:

Then, although she keeps trying to go and have sex with other men, she will not succeed.

If it is inappropriate to refer directly to having sex, use an acceptable euphemism in your language. For example:

sleep with other men

2:7b she will seek them but not find them.

- She will search for them, but she won't find them. (GW)
- Though she repeatedly looks for opportunities to meet these other men, she will fail.

she will seek them but not find them: This line is very similar in meaning to 2:7a. It describes the woman's persistent searching for her lovers. In some languages, a literal translation may wrongly imply that the lovers are lost and that the woman is trying to find them. The correct meaning is that she tries hard to find opportunities to have sex with them. For example:

she will look carefully/diligently for opportunities to go and meet with her lovers.

General Comment on 2:7a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these two verse parts. For example:

Then, her repeated efforts to go and sleep with other men will not succeed.

2:7c Then she will say, 'I will return to my first husband,

- Then/Finally she will say to herself, 'I will return to my own husband,
- At last she will decide to go back to her true husband,

Then she will say, ‘I will return: See the note on the direct quote in 2:5c. In some languages, it may be more natural to use indirect speech. For example:

Then she will say to herself that she will return to her first husband...

Then she will decide to go back to her first husband...

Then: The Hebrew word that the BSB and some other versions translate as Then introduces the woman’s next action or decision. Here is another way to translate this:

At last (REB)

I will return: This phrase emphasizes her deliberate, willful intention to return. It contrasts with her willful intention to be unfaithful in 2:5c.

to my first husband: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “to my man/husband the original/former.” It refers to the woman’s true, original husband in contrast to the many men she had slept with since she first got married. McComiskey (page 36), Stuart (page 49), and Macintosh (pages 52–53).

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

to my husband as at first (NIV)

The word first does not imply that she had actually married other men. Some versions leave first implied to avoid implying this wrong meaning. For example:

my husband (NET)

Translate this verse part in a way that clearly refers to Gomer’s/Israel’s intention to return to Hosea/the LORD.

2:7d

for then I was better off than now.’

- because my situation was better then than it is now.’
- because her life was better when she lived with him than it is now.

for: This word introduces the reason that she will decide to return to her husband. Some versions leave it implied. Use a natural way in your language to introduce a reason. See the note on 2:4b.

then I was better off than now: The word then indicates the time in her past when she lived with her husband. Her memory of that better time was the reason she decided to return to her husband.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it was better for me then than now (ESV)

my life with him was better than my life now

Hosea 2:8

Section 2:2–13: The LORD promised to punish the people of Israel

In this section, the LORD described the crisis that resulted from Israel being unfaithful to him by following other gods. He warned Israel about the punishment that he would inflict on them if they continued their unfaithfulness. There is a sharp contrast between the negative tone in this section and the positive tone in the previous one.

The first words of this section seem to be a command by Hosea to his children. He commanded them to rebuke their mother (2:2a). However, the words “declares the LORD” in 2:13c indicate that the LORD is the speaker throughout this section. The reason for this double reference is that this section has both literal and figurative meanings. Literally, it applies to the relationship between Hosea, his wife Gomer, and their children. Figuratively, it expresses the relationship between the LORD and Israel. In a complex metaphor, the nation of Israel is compared to the LORD’s wife. At the same time, the entire nation of Israel is compared to a mother, and the individual Israelites that made up the nation are compared to her children. Andersen and Freedman (pages 219–220) and Wood (page 175).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The LORD’s future punishment of Israel

Israel is the Lord’s unfaithful wife (GW)

Unfaithful Gomer—Unfaithful Israel (GNT)

Paragraph 2:8–13

In this paragraph, Hosea continues to use the image of an adulterous wife to represent the unfaithful nation of Israel. The LORD will punish the Israelites for their worship of the false god Baal. They trusted Baal to provide for their needs instead of trusting the LORD.

Similarly, Hosea will punish Gomer, because she was unfaithful to him.

The notes and translation advice in this paragraph focus mainly on the way that the LORD intends to punish Israel. So you may want to add a footnote to remind your readers that this paragraph also refers to the way that Hosea will punish his wife Gomer.

2:8a

For she does not acknowledge

- ¶ “Before this time, she/Israel did not admit
- ¶ “Until now the Israelites have not accepted the fact

she does not acknowledge: The Hebrew verb that is used here can mean either “know” or “acknowledge/admit.” BDB (#3045, page 394), sense 1.f. (page 394). BDB does not cite Hosea 2:8. So there are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. “She does not acknowledge.” She (Israel) knew the truth, but she refused to admit that her husband (the LORD) was the one who supplied her needs. For example:

she would never acknowledge (GNT)

she has refused to acknowledge (NET) (BSB, GNT, NET, NIV, NJPS)

1. “She did not know.” She (Israel) was not aware that her husband (the LORD) provided her food. For example:

she did not know (NRSV)

she had never realized before (NJB) (CEV, ESV, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most commentaries. This interpretation is supported by Andersen and Freedman (page 242), McComiskey (page 36), Macintosh (page 54), Wood (page 176), Lange (page 37), and Pusey (page 32). Lange points out that the Israelites “must have been inwardly conscious” that God was the Giver” and “could have known it from the law, but they ignored this truth, denied it.” Verse 2:7d implies that Israel did know that the LORD had been her provider in the past.

2:8b

that it was I who gave her grain, new wine, and oil,

- that it was I who provided her with the grain, wine, and olive oil that she needed.
- that I was the one who made their crops grow and gave them wine and cooking oil

that it was I who gave her: In Hebrew, the pronoun I that is used here indicates emphasis. The BSB expresses this emphasis by using special wording.

Other languages may be able to use an emphatic pronoun. Use a natural way in your language to express this emphasis.

grain, new wine, and oil: These three items are often listed together in the Old Testament (for example, Deuteronomy 7:13). They were basic products of agriculture that the nation depended upon to sustain them. Together they represented everything that the LORD had provided for the Israelites.

grain: This word refers to any kind of grain. In languages that do not have a general word for grain, here are two other options:

- Use the word for a specific grain crop, such as wheat or rice.
- Use a more general term, such as “crop” or “what is harvested.”

new wine: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as new wine refers to wine that has been pressed recently from grapes. It is not yet fermented or is just beginning to ferment.

Here is another way to translate this word:

fresh wine

Some versions do not specify new wine, probably because the emphasis is on the LORD’s provision of the wine, not on its age. If it is awkward to express the concept of newly made wine, you may want to use a more general term. For example:

wine (NRSV)

wine: wine is an alcoholic drink. It is made from the juice of a fruit called grapes. When grape juice ferments, it becomes wine.

In some areas, people may not be familiar with grapes or with wine.

If that is true in your area, here are some other ways to translate wine:

- Use a specific term for another alcoholic drink made from fruit. For example:

pomegranate wine

a drink like palm wine

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

fruit juice/water

grape juice

oil: See the note in 2:5d.

2:8c

who lavished on her silver and gold—which they crafted for Baal.

- I also gave her/Israel much silver and gold, but she used these things for Baal!
- and also much silver and gold. But they used that silver and gold to worship the false god Baal.

who lavished on her: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as lavished is literally “multiplied.” It indicates that the LORD gave it generously.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

giving her more and more (NJB)

I gave her much (NCV)

silver and gold—which they crafted for Baal: These two phrases describe the unexpected way in which the people used the silver and gold that the LORD gave them. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as crafted is a somewhat general verb for action taken on an item. It could mean “to do,” “to use,” or “to make.” It does not indicate specifically how the people used silver and gold for Baal. They may have used it to make idols of Baal, but they may also have used it in other ways that were related to Baal worship. For that reason, you should use a general phrase to translate this statement. For example:

which they used for Baal (NIV)

which they have spent on Baal (NJB)

which they used in worshiping Baal (NET)

Some versions use punctuation marks to emphasize the fact that the Israelite’s behavior was unexpected. It was the LORD who gave them these gifts, but

instead they used the gifts to honor a false god. For example, the NET uses a hyphen and exclamation mark for emphasis:

silver and gold—which they used in worshiping Baal! (NET)

The NCV creates similar emphasis by using the word “but”:

I gave her much silver and gold, but she used it for Baal. (NCV)

Use a natural way in your language to emphasize that this behavior was unexpected.

they: The preceding pronouns “she/her” in 2:8a–c refer to the nation or people of Israel. The following pronouns in 2:9b–10a are the same. Here in 2:8c, the pronoun they is used. You should use a phrase or pronoun in your language that clearly refers to the nation or people of Israel.

Hosea 2:9

Section 2:2–13: The LORD promised to punish the people of Israel

In this section, the LORD described the crisis that resulted from Israel being unfaithful to him by following other gods. He warned Israel about the punishment that he would inflict on them if they continued their unfaithfulness. There is a sharp contrast between the negative tone in this section and the positive tone in the previous one.

The first words of this section seem to be a command by Hosea to his children. He commanded them to rebuke their mother (2:2a). However, the words “declares the LORD” in 2:13c indicate that the LORD is the speaker throughout this section. The reason for this double reference is that this section has both literal and figurative meanings. Literally, it applies to the relationship between Hosea, his wife Gomer, and their children. Figuratively, it expresses the relationship between the LORD and Israel. In a complex metaphor, the nation of Israel is compared to the LORD’s wife. At the same time, the entire nation of Israel is compared to a mother, and the individual Israelites that made up the nation are compared to her children. Andersen and Freedman (pages 219–220) and Wood (page 175).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The LORD’s future punishment of Israel

Israel is the Lord's unfaithful wife (GW)

Unfaithful Gomer—Unfaithful Israel (GNT)

Paragraph 2:8–13

In this paragraph, Hosea continues to use the image of an adulterous wife to represent the unfaithful nation of Israel. The LORD will punish the Israelites for their worship of the false god Baal. They trusted Baal to provide for their needs instead of trusting the LORD. Similarly, Hosea will punish Gomer, because she was unfaithful to him.

The notes and translation advice in this paragraph focus mainly on the way that the LORD intends to punish Israel. So you may want to add a footnote to remind your readers that this paragraph also refers to the way that Hosea will punish his wife Gomer.

2:9a–b (combined/reordered)

- So when the times/seasons to harvest grain and grapes arrive, I will keep her/them from getting/enjoying any of the ripe grain and wine that I have been giving her/them.

In this verse, the LORD responds to Israel's refusal to acknowledge him as the source of their blessings. Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{9a}Therefore I will take back My grain **in its time**,

^{9b}and My new wine **in its season**;

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted word) in 2:9b. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing verb from 2:9a. For example:

^{9b}and I will take back My new wine **in its season**;

in its time and...in its season: These parallel phrases are more literally "at its appropriate time...at its appointed time." These phrases refer to the different times/seasons of the year when the grain and grapes were ripe and ready to be harvested. Hubbard (page 77) notes that grain was harvested in May-June and grapes in July-September.

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

at harvest time (NCV)

when it is the right season/time

2:9a

Therefore I will take back My grain in its time

- So at the time/season of year when ripe grain is normally harvested in Israel, I will prevent her/them from harvesting anything.
- That is why I will not allow Israel/them to have any of the grain crop that I intended to give her/them.

Therefore: This word introduces the result of the people's refusal to acknowledge the LORD.

Here are some other ways to introduce this result:

That is why (NJB)

So (GNT)

Use a natural way in your language to introduce a result in this context.

I will take away: This phrase indicates here that the LORD will withhold the products that he intended to provide for the nation of Israel. It probably means that he will keep Israel from harvesting or using these products that they previously enjoyed. In Hebrew, this verb is literally "I shall return and I shall take." It is an example of hendiadys, meaning "take back." In the case of the LORD and Israel, it is possible that the LORD planned to withhold these products by causing them not to grow or not to be harvested (McComiskey, page 36). He may have caused this by lack of rain (Andersen and Freedman, page 245; Wood, page 177) or warfare or other kinds of disruption (Stuart, pages 50–51).

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

I will withhold from Israel

I will prevent the people of Israel from harvesting

2:9b

and My new wine in its season;

- I will also prevent her/them from making any grapes into wine during the season when grapes are ready to harvest/pick.
- And at the time when she/they expects/expect to enjoy wine from another crop of grapes, I will make sure that there is none.

new wine: See the note on 2:8b. Here (in 2:9b) it refers by metonymy to the crop of grapes that is ready to be harvested and made into wine. For example:

the ripe grapes that they usually made into new wine

General Comment on 2:9a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the parallel parts in these two lines. For example:

So I'll hold back the harvest of grain and grapes.
(CEV)

2:9c

I will take away My wool and linen, which were given to cover her nakedness.

- I will also snatch away the wool and flax that I gave her before/previously so that she could cover/clothe her naked body.
- I will also strictly prevent her from getting the various kinds of clothing that she used to wear.

I will take away My wool and linen: See the note on 2:5d for wool and linen. In Hebrew, the verb I will take away is more literally “I will snatch away.” It means that the LORD will forcibly withdraw the materials that the nation of Israel needed for clothing.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I will snatch away my wool and my flax (NAB)

I shall withdraw my wool and my flax (NJB)

which were given to cover her nakedness: In Hebrew, the form of the verb cover that is used here implies the intention to cover. The BSB has made this explicit by saying which were given to.

Here is another way to translate this idea:

that I gave her to cover her naked body (GW)

Use a natural way in your language to indicate intention.

her nakedness: If it is not natural in your language to say that clothing “covers nakedness,” here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

which I have provided in order to clothe her (NET)

I gave her for clothing (GNT)

Hosea 2:10

Section 2:2–13: The LORD promised to punish the people of Israel

In this section, the LORD described the crisis that resulted from Israel being unfaithful to him by following other gods. He warned Israel about the punishment that he would inflict on them if they continued their unfaithfulness. There is a sharp contrast between the negative tone in this section and the positive tone in the previous one.

The first words of this section seem to be a command by Hosea to his children. He commanded them to rebuke their mother (2:2a). However, the words “declares the LORD” in 2:13c indicate that the LORD is the speaker throughout this section. The reason for this double reference is that this section has both literal and figurative meanings. Literally, it applies to the relationship between Hosea, his wife Gomer, and their children. Figuratively, it expresses the relationship between the LORD and Israel. In a complex metaphor, the nation of Israel is compared to the LORD’s wife. At the same time, the entire nation of Israel is compared to a mother, and the individual Israelites that made up the nation are compared to her children. Andersen and Freedman (pages 219–220) and Wood (page 175).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The LORD’s future punishment of Israel

Israel is the Lord’s unfaithful wife (GW)

Unfaithful Gomer—Unfaithful Israel (GNT)

Paragraph 2:8–13

In this paragraph, Hosea continues to use the image of an adulterous wife to represent the unfaithful nation of Israel. The LORD will punish the Israelites for their worship of the false god Baal. They trusted Baal to provide for their needs instead of trusting the LORD. Similarly, Hosea will punish Gomer, because she was unfaithful to him.

The notes and translation advice in this paragraph focus mainly on the way that the LORD intends to punish Israel. So you may want to add a footnote to remind your readers that this paragraph also refers to the way that Hosea will punish his wife Gomer.

2:10a

And then I will expose her lewdness in the sight of her lovers,

- Then I will remove her clothes and show her naked body to her lovers.
- Soon I will cause her to be naked, and the men/ones that she sleeps with will see her in that shameful condition.

And then: In Hebrew, the phrase And then connects the LORD's action in 2:9c with the next action that he will take to punish Israel.

Here are some other ways to make this connection clear:

So now (NIV)

Soon (NET) According to the NET footnote (a), the particle used here (ʾattah) "normally introduces imminent judgment" in Hosea.

Some versions, such as the GNT and NLT quoted below, leave the connection implied. Use a natural way in your language to introduce the next action that a person will take.

I will expose her lewdness in the sight of her lovers:

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as lewdness can refer specifically to a woman's genitals. BDB (#5040), also HALOT (electronic edition, page 664). NIDOTTE (#5578), citing this verse specifically, says the noun "refers to the private parts of a woman." Stuart (vol. 31, page 51). says that the Hebrew word is used here by metonymy for the woman's "nakedness, and perhaps even genitalia." This figurative clause probably indicates here that the LORD (the husband) will remove Israel's (his wife's) clothing so that her lovers will see her naked body, specifically her private parts. The purpose of this punishment was to publicly shame the woman.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I will strip her naked in front of her lovers (GNT)

I will strip her naked in public, while all her lovers look on. (NLT)

I will show her naked body to her lovers (GW)

Translate this clause in a way that is appropriate in your culture and language.

her lovers: This phrase could refer to the Baal gods or other idols that Israel worshiped. It could also refer to other nations that were her allies. Only a few

commentaries specify the identity of the lovers. Wood (page 177) says that Israel's "lovers" are "the neighboring nations." Hubbard (page 78) and Lange (page 37) understand the Baals, or more generally, the idols, as the "lovers." If possible, use a general word or phrase that could refer to either kind of lovers.

2:10b

and no one will deliver her out of My hands.

- No one will rescue/save her from my powerful hands.
- No one will be able to rescue her from me.

no one will deliver her out of My hands: In Hebrew, the phrase deliver her out of means "rescue her from." Here the term My hands is a figure of speech that represents the LORD (the husband) or his power. In some languages, it may be clearer to translate only the meaning and not keep the figure of speech. For example:

and no one will rescue her from me (REB)

and no one will be able to save her from my power (GNT)

Hosea 2:11

Section 2:2–13: The LORD promised to punish the people of Israel

In this section, the LORD described the crisis that resulted from Israel being unfaithful to him by following other gods. He warned Israel about the punishment that he would inflict on them if they continued their unfaithfulness. There is a sharp contrast between the negative tone in this section and the positive tone in the previous one.

The first words of this section seem to be a command by Hosea to his children. He commanded them to rebuke their mother (2:2a). However, the words "declares the LORD" in 2:13c indicate that the LORD is the speaker throughout this section. The reason for this double reference is that this section has both literal and figurative meanings. Literally, it applies to the relationship between Hosea, his wife Gomer, and their children. Figuratively, it expresses the relationship between the LORD and Israel. In a complex metaphor, the nation of Israel is compared to the LORD's wife. At the same time, the entire nation of Israel is compared to a mother, and the individual Israelites that made up the nation are compared to her children. Andersen and Freedman (pages 219–220) and Wood (page 175).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The LORD's future punishment of Israel

Israel is the Lord's unfaithful wife (GW)

Unfaithful Gomer—Unfaithful Israel (GNT)

Paragraph 2:8–13

In this paragraph, Hosea continues to use the image of an adulterous wife to represent the unfaithful nation of Israel. The LORD will punish the Israelites for their worship of the false god Baal. They trusted Baal to provide for their needs instead of trusting the LORD. Similarly, Hosea will punish Gomer, because she was unfaithful to him.

The notes and translation advice in this paragraph focus mainly on the way that the LORD intends to punish Israel. So you may want to add a footnote to remind your readers that this paragraph also refers to the way that Hosea will punish his wife Gomer.

2:11a

I will put an end to all her exultation:

- I will end all the special/religious events that she celebrates:
- I will make her stop celebrating all the festivals that I previously/originally told her to keep/observe.

I will put an end to all her exultation: In Hebrew, the phrase all her exultation is literally “all her joy/rejoicing.” Some versions translate this phrase literally as “mirth,” “merrymaking,” or “gaiety.” In many languages, general terms like these may be wrongly interpreted as rejoicing in general. However, the parallel line (2:11b) specifies that this rejoicing refers to all the special festivals, feasts, and days that the LORD originally told the Israelites to celebrate in order to honor him. McComiskey (page 39), Keil (page 59), and Hubbard (page 78).

Translate in a way that makes this connection clear. For example:

I will end all the religious celebrations that she enjoys.

cause her to stop all the special events that I previously told her to celebrate.

2:11b

her feasts, New Moons, and Sabbaths—all her appointed feasts.

- her annual festivals, her celebration at the time of the new moon and her weekly celebration of the Sabbath, all of them.
- There will be no more celebrations each year or each month. There will also be no more celebrations of the weekly day for resting. I will cause them all to end.

her feasts, New Moons, and Sabbaths: The first three terms refer to annual, monthly, and weekly celebrations. The last term summarizes the preceding terms. Macintosh (page 62) and Lange (page 37).

her feasts: The nation of Israel celebrated three main festivals once each year; the feasts of Passover, Pentecost, and Tabernacles (see Exodus 23:14–19). They also celebrated a number of other less important festivals. The Hebrew word that is used here refers to all yearly festivals. Andersen and Freedman (page 250).

New Moons: In addition to yearly festivals, the people celebrated the feast of the New Moon at the beginning of each month (see 1 Samuel 20:5).

Here is another way to translate this term:

monthly new moon celebrations (NET)

In some languages, it may be more natural to use a general term to translate the name of this festival and to combine the first two festivals into one phrase. For example:

her annual and monthly festivals (GNT)

and Sabbaths: The “Sabbath” celebration was observed on Saturday, the seventh day of each week. This was the special day in the week when the people of Israel rested and worshiped God.

Here are some ways to translate Sabbaths:

weekly Sabbath festivities (NET)

celebration each week of the day for resting

all her appointed feasts: In Hebrew, this phrase begins with a conjunction that some versions translate as “and.” For example:

and all her appointed feasts (ESV)

However, this last term serves as a final summary rather than a separate item, so the BSB and some other versions leave it untranslated. Davies (page 76). For example:

—all her religious meetings (GNT)

I will stop all of her special feasts. (NCV)

This phrase refers to all the festivals that Israel celebrated at set times, either yearly, monthly, or weekly. These festivals included feasts, but they included other activities also. Some versions make this clear by using a description other than feasts. For example:

all her festive seasons (NJPS)

all her appointed festivals (NLT)

Hosea 2:12

Section 2:2–13: The LORD promised to punish the people of Israel

In this section, the LORD described the crisis that resulted from Israel being unfaithful to him by following other gods. He warned Israel about the punishment that he would inflict on them if they continued their unfaithfulness. There is a sharp contrast between the negative tone in this section and the positive tone in the previous one.

The first words of this section seem to be a command by Hosea to his children. He commanded them to rebuke their mother (2:2a). However, the words “declares the LORD” in 2:13c indicate that the LORD is the speaker throughout this section. The reason for this double reference is that this section has both literal and figurative meanings. Literally, it applies to the relationship between Hosea, his wife Gomer, and their children. Figuratively, it expresses the relationship between the LORD and Israel. In a complex metaphor, the nation of Israel is compared to the LORD’s wife. At the same time, the entire nation of Israel is compared to a mother, and the individual Israelites that made up the nation are compared to her children. Andersen and Freedman (pages 219–220) and Wood (page 175).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The LORD’s future punishment of Israel

Israel is the Lord’s unfaithful wife (GW)

Unfaithful Gomer—Unfaithful Israel (GNT)

Paragraph 2:8–13

In this paragraph, Hosea continues to use the image of an adulterous wife to represent the unfaithful nation of Israel. The LORD will punish the Israelites for their worship of the false god Baal. They trusted Baal to provide for their needs instead of trusting the LORD. Similarly, Hosea will punish Gomer, because she was unfaithful to him.

The notes and translation advice in this paragraph focus mainly on the way that the LORD intends to punish Israel. So you may want to add a footnote to remind your readers that this paragraph also refers to the way that Hosea will punish his wife Gomer.

2:12a

I will destroy her vines and fig trees, which she thinks are the wages paid by her lovers.

- I will destroy the grape vines and fig trees that she said her lovers had given her as payment.
- She said, ‘These vineyards and fruit trees are the wages that my lovers, the Baal gods, paid me for worshiping them.’ But I am going to destroy those vineyards and fruit trees.

I will destroy her vines and fig trees, which she thinks are the wages paid by her lovers:

This verse refers back to 2:5, which lists gifts from the woman’s lovers in payment for the sexual relations she had with them. Old Testament authors often used the terms vines and fig trees together to represent peace and prosperity. (1 Kings 4:25; Isaiah 36:16). By using these terms together here, the LORD indicated that he was destroying the peace and prosperity that Israel claimed came from Baal. You may want to add a footnote that explains this figurative information. Here her lovers may refer to the Baal idols that Israel worshiped in various shrines. Israel considered her vines and fig trees as wages from these Baals in exchange for her worship. Hubbard (page 78) and Wood (page 177) understand Israel’s lovers as the Baals. McComiskey (page 39) refers to Hosea 8:10 as an example of Israel “hiring allies among the nations.”

If grapes and fig trees are unknown in your language group, you may want to add pictures. You may also want to include descriptions in a footnote.

vines: This word refers to grape vines. Grapes were one of the most important crops for the people of Israel. Wine was made from the juice of this fruit. Some versions make the kind of vine explicit. For example:

grapevines (GNT)

vineyards (NLT)

A vineyard is a farm where grape vines grow and produce grapes.

Here are some other ways to translate “vineyard”:

grape farm

field of grape vines

fig trees: Fig trees produced another very important and useful fruit for the Israelites. Figs were very nourishing and were also used as medicine (2 Kings 20:7).

In language areas where fig trees are not known, here are some other ways to translate this term:

General Comment on 2:12a

- Use a more general term. For example:

orchards (NLT)

fruit trees

- Use a loan word(s) from a major language in your area. For example:

igo trees (from Spanish higo) If you use this option, people should clearly understand that the loan word refers to a kind of fruit tree.

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder the two clauses within this verse part. For example:

She said that her lovers paid her for sex by giving her grapevines and fig trees. But I am going to destroy those vines and fig trees.

In some languages, it may also be necessary to use a direct quote instead of an indirect quote. For example:

I will lay waste her vines and her fig trees, of which she said, ‘These are my wages, which my lovers have given me.’ (ESV)

2:12b

So I will make them into a thicket, and the beasts of the field will devour them.

- I will turn them into a neglected/tangled thicket, and wild animals will eat them.

- I will let all kinds of other plants and trees grow there. Then wild animals will eat them.

So I will make them into a thicket: The word that the BSB translates as thicket refers to a tangled area of plants and trees.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase

I shall leave them to grow wild (REB)

I will let them grow into tangled thickets (NLT)

Use an expression in your language that describes an area that once was cultivated, but later was allowed to grow wild.

Hosea 2:13

Section 2:2–13: The LORD promised to punish the people of Israel

In this section, the LORD described the crisis that resulted from Israel being unfaithful to him by following other gods. He warned Israel about the punishment that he would inflict on them if they continued their unfaithfulness. There is a sharp contrast between the negative tone in this section and the positive tone in the previous one.

The first words of this section seem to be a command by Hosea to his children. He commanded them to rebuke their mother (2:2a). However, the words “declares the LORD” in 2:13c indicate that the LORD is the speaker throughout this section. The reason for this double reference is that this section has both literal and figurative meanings. Literally, it applies to the relationship between Hosea, his wife Gomer, and their children. Figuratively, it expresses the relationship between the LORD and Israel. In a complex metaphor, the nation of Israel is compared to the LORD’s wife. At the same time, the entire nation of Israel is compared to a mother, and the individual Israelites that made up the nation are compared to her children. Andersen and Freedman (pages 219–220) and Wood (page 175).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The LORD’s future punishment of Israel

Israel is the Lord’s unfaithful wife (GW)

Unfaithful Gomer—Unfaithful Israel (GNT)

Paragraph 2:8–13

In this paragraph, Hosea continues to use the image of an adulterous wife to represent the unfaithful nation of Israel. The LORD will punish the Israelites for their worship of the false god Baal. They trusted Baal to provide for their needs instead of trusting the LORD. Similarly, Hosea will punish Gomer, because she was unfaithful to him.

The notes and translation advice in this paragraph focus mainly on the way that the LORD intends to punish Israel. So you may want to add a footnote to remind your readers that this paragraph also refers to the way that Hosea will punish his wife Gomer.

2:13a–b

Notice the parallelism in this verse:

^{13a} I will punish her for the days **of the Baals when she burned incense to them,**

^{13b} **when she decked herself with rings and jewelry, and went after her lovers. But Me she forgot,”**

Both lines describe the sins for which the LORD will punish Israel. Verse 2:13a describes Israel's attempts to please Baal by offering incense to him. It is also possible that Gomer burned incense to Baal when she engaged in prostitution (Andersen and Freedman, page 258). Verse 2:13b describes this spiritual adultery in terms of a woman's attempts to attract her lovers by wearing jewelry.

2:13a

I will punish her for the days of the Baals when she burned incense to them,

- I will punish her because she burned incense to Baal on the feast days.
- I will punish her for all the times/days when she worshiped the Baal idols and burned incense to them.

the days of the Baals when she burned incense to them: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “the days of the Baals when she made smoke to them.” There are two main ways that English versions translate this phrase. Either way is acceptable:

- As specific festival days for Baal. For example:

the festival days of the Baals, when she offered incense to them. (NRSV)

- As unspecific times, whenever people worshiped Baal. These times included the feast days for Baal, but may have included other times also. The BSB above is one example. Another example is the GNT:

the times that she forgot me, when she burned incense to Baal. (GNT)

the Baals: Baal was the name of the main Canaanite god. The Hebrew word here is plural. The plural form may indicate multiple Baal shrines Stuart on Hosea 2:13[15]. dedicated to different local Baal gods. Macintosh (page 66). However, it is also possible that the plural form refers to just one Baal. So English versions translate this term in two ways. Either way is acceptable:

- As plural Baals. This is how the BSB and most English versions have translated it.
- As singular “Baal.” This is how the GNT has translated it.

2:13b

when she decked herself with rings and jewelry, and went after her lovers. But Me she forgot,”

- At those times, she decorated herself with her nose-ring/earrings and other jewelry to attract her lovers, but she intentionally forgot me!”
- She put on rings and jewelry. She did everything she could to persuade her lovers, the Baal gods, to give her their benefits. But as for me, she decided to forget me.”

she decked herself with rings and jewelry: The verb decked indicates here that the woman put on rings and jewelry in order to make herself look attractive.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

she put on her rings and jewelry (NCV)

rings: In Hebrew, this word can refer to either rings, “earrings,” or “nose-ring.” Any of these terms is acceptable.

and went after her lovers: See how you translated her lovers in 2:12a.

But Me she forgot: The BSB translates the Hebrew conjunction used here as But. In this context, there is a contrast between Israel pursuing lovers but forgetting the LORD. So “but” is an appropriate translation. Some versions leave this conjunction implied. Use a natural way in your language to express this contrast.

In Hebrew, the word order of the pronoun Me within this clause gives it strong emphasis. The BSB shows this emphasis by using the word order Me she forgot instead of the more common English word order “she forgot me.” Another way that English versions show this emphasis is by using an exclamation mark. For example:

but she forgot me! (NET)

Use a natural way in your language to express this emphasis.

2:13c declares the LORD.

- This is Yahweh’s message to you^(sing/plur).
- I, Yahweh, have said this to you.

declares the LORD: This phrase is literally “the utterance/oracle of the LORD.” This phrase emphasizes that the prophet’s message was directly from the LORD.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

The Lord has spoken (GNT)

I, the Lord, have spoken (CEV)

This is the word of the Lord (REB)

You should determine the best way to say this in your language.

General Comment on 2:13a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder some of these verse parts. For example:

^{13a}I will punish her for all the times ^{13b}she deserted me, ^{13a}when she burned incense to her images of Baal, ^{13b}put on her earrings and jewels, and went out looking for her lovers,” ^{13c}says the Lord. (NLT)

Hosea 2:14

Section 2:14–23: The LORD promised to renew his covenant with them

The purpose of the punishment in 2:1–13 was to make the people of Israel realize that their worship of false gods would result in harm. In this section, 2:14–23, the LORD showed that he continued to love the people of Israel. If they worshiped him, he would bless them and not harm them. In spite of their past sins, he would reestablish a covenant with them. In this section, the tone switches from negative to positive, so there is a

sharp contrast between the previous section and this one.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Future Repentance and Restoration of Israel (NET)

The Lord’s Love for Unfaithful Israel (NLT)

Paragraph 2:14–15

In this paragraph, the LORD described his intention to reestablish a covenant relationship with Israel. He used the image of a man courting a woman in the desert to illustrate it. This image referred to Israel’s past. After the Israelites left Egypt, they wandered for forty years in the desert of Sinai. It was there that the LORD first established his covenant with the Israelites.

2:14a

“Therefore, behold, I will allure her

- ¶ “However this is what I will now do. I will woo/court her.

Therefore, behold, I will allure her: In Hebrew, the word Therefore introduces the result of something that was said previously. It indicates here that because she (Israel) forgot the LORD 2:13b, he would respond by winning her back to himself. This gracious response is not expected. Andersen and Freedman (page 269) and Garrett (pages 87–88). It is a surprising contrast to Israel’s bad behavior.

There are two main ways to translate this result and contrast:

- Keep explicit (as in the Hebrew) that the response of the LORD is a direct result of Israel’s bad behavior. Leave implied the contrast between the bad behavior of Israel and the gracious response of the LORD. For example:

Therefore, I will now allure her... (NRSV)

That is why I’m going to win her back. (GW)

So I am going to take her into the desert again... (GNT)

- Make explicit the contrast between the bad behavior of Israel and the gracious response of the LORD. Leave implied that the response of the LORD is a direct result of Israel’s bad behavior. For example:

But now I shall woo her... (REB)

However, in the future I will allure her... (NET)

If possible, translate in a way that indicates both result and contrast. If it is not possible to indicate both these relationships in a natural way in your language, it is recommended that you choose the first option above.

behold: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as behold is *hinneh*. The usual function of *hinneh* is to direct the attention of the reader or listener to what follows. Some versions leave this word implied. Here, it probably draws attention to something that is new or unexpected that will happen immediately or in the near future. NIDOTTE article on Particles: Theology. According to Lambdin (page 168), the Hebrew word expresses “the immediacy, the here-and-now-ness of the situation.” The NET footnote (a) is similar. For example:

I will now allure her (NRSV)

behold, I will allure her (NASB)

allure her: The Hebrew verb used here means “entice, seduce, persuade.” BDB (#6601, page 834b) sense 1. The NJB has “seduce,” which has a bad (negative) connotation. Here, however, it is used in a positive, honorable way. Andersen and Freedman (page 272). It means “to court a woman in order to win her affection.” For example:

speak coaxingly to her (NJPS)

attract her (NCV)

Choose a term in your language that expresses this positive use.

2:14a–b (combined/reordered)

- ¶ “So now I will do something unexpected. I will lead her into the desert. There I will speak lovingly/gently to her so that I persuade her to love me again.

2:14b

and lead her to the wilderness, and speak to her tenderly.

- I will take her into the desert once again, and speak words of love to her there.

and lead her to the wilderness, and speak to her tenderly: This clause describes in more detail how the husband will allure his wife. He will persuade her

to love him again by leading her into the desert and speaking to her lovingly.

wilderness: The word refers to a dry desert or wilderness. Here it is a historical reference to the desert of Sinai. If you have translated the book of Exodus or other verses that refer to that desert you should translate it the same way here.

speak to her tenderly: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as speak to her tenderly is literally “I will speak to her heart.” It describes a man who uses kind and affectionate words to win the love of a woman.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and speak kindly to her (NASB)

and speak gently to you (CEV)

General Comment on 2:14a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder some parts of this verse. For example:

^{14b}So I am going to take her into the desert again;
^{14a}there I will win her back ^{14b}with words of love.
(GNT)

Hosea 2:15

Section 2:14–23: The LORD promised to renew his covenant with them

The purpose of the punishment in 2:1–13 was to make the people of Israel realize that their worship of false gods would result in harm. In this section, 2:14–23, the LORD showed that he continued to love the people of Israel. If they worshiped him, he would bless them and not harm them. In spite of their past sins, he would reestablish a covenant with them. In this section, the tone switches from negative to positive, so there is a sharp contrast between the previous section and this one.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Future Repentance and Restoration of Israel (NET)

The Lord’s Love for Unfaithful Israel (NLT)

Paragraph 2:14–15

In this paragraph, the LORD described his intention to reestablish a covenant relationship with Israel. He used the image of a man courting a woman in the

desert to illustrate it. This image referred to Israel's past. After the Israelites left Egypt, they wandered for forty years in the desert of Sinai. It was there that the LORD first established his covenant with the Israelites.

2:15a

There I will give back her vineyards

- From there I will return her vineyards to her.
- I will make her vineyards grow again.

There I will give back her vineyards: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as There is literally “From there,” as in the NRSV. In this context, it refers to the same image of Israel in the wilderness as 2:14b. It was from this desert that the LORD promised to restore to Israel her vineyards. Andersen and Freedman (page 272), Stuart (page 53), and McComiskey (page 42). Andersen and Freedman comment that “there” and “from there” often differ only slightly in meaning. This promise referred to the future restoration of vineyards in Israel. Some versions leave the word “there” or “from there” implied.

I will give back her vineyards: In 2:12, the LORD said that he would destroy Israel's vineyards, but here in 2:15, he promised to restore them. Some versions indicate this idea of restoration explicitly. For example:

I will give back to her the vineyards she had (GNT)

I shall restore her vineyards to her (REB)

I will return her vineyards to her (NLT)

Other versions leave it implied. For example:

From there I will give her her vineyards (NRSV)

Be sure that the idea of restoration is clear in your translation.

2:15b

and make the Valley of Achor into a gateway of hope.

- And I will make the Valley of Trouble into a Gateway/Door of Hope.
- And she will not have to experience trouble/danger any longer. I will give her hope for a better life.

and make the Valley of Achor into a gateway of hope: The Hebrew word Achor means “trouble, disturbance.” BDB (#5911), TWOT (#1621a). The Valley of Achor was the place where Achan disobeyed the LORD. As a result, the LORD allowed the enemies of Israel to

defeat them. This happened when they were entering the promised land of Canaan (Joshua 7:1–26).

Hosea probably uses the Valley of Achor as a figure of speech (synecdoche) that represents the whole land. Macintosh (pages 74–75). He means that the LORD will change Israel from a nation that experienced trouble to a nation where people have hope.

Some versions translate the meaning rather than the actual place name. For example:

Valley of Trouble (NET)

Trouble Valley (GNT)

Some versions include a footnote that gives the Joshua reference and a brief explanation as above. Consider whether any of these options will help your readers better understand the meaning.

a gateway of hope: The change from a place of disaster to a gateway of hope illustrated that Israel's disastrous relationship with the LORD could be changed. Here, hope means “expectation, optimistic outlook.” HALOT (#10282).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

gateway of hope (NLT)

Opportunity for Hope (NET)

Notice that the NET uses capital letters to show that this phrase is parallel to “Valley of Trouble.” Consider whether capital letters will help your readers to understand the parallelism.

If it is necessary to specify an object of hope, you may use a phrase that refers to prosperity or a better life. For example:

a place where people have hope for a good life

2:15c

There she will respond

- And she will respond by loving me
- And she will say ‘Yes’ to me there

There: This word refers to the same place as it does in 2:15a. Some versions leave it implied.

she will respond: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as respond:

1. It means respond. When the nation of Israel was young, she responded to the LORD's love by accepting his covenant and obeying him. In this verse, the LORD said that she will respond like this again. For example:

There she will respond (NJB) (BSB, CEV, GNT, GW, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. It means sing. When the LORD rescued the nation of Israel from the Egyptians at the Red Sea, they sang a song of thanksgiving (Exodus 15). For example:

There she will sing (NET) (KJV, NASB, NET, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. Wood (page 179), feels that "sing" is an appropriate meaning here, because the context calls for a joyful response. Keil (page 42), mentions Israel's song of praise at the Red Sea as one of her responses, but says that the verb means "answer" rather than "sing." Stuart (page 53), says that the verb indicates a range of positive responses, and Andersen and Freedman (page 276), argue that "respond" is more appropriate in the context of the husband speaking. "Respond" is the usual meaning of this verb. It also allows for more kinds of responses than just singing.

In some languages, it may be more natural to use direct speech to express her response. For example, here is a slight adaptation of the CEV:

she will say 'Yes' to me

In some languages, a verb such as respond is used only in the context of answering a question. If that is true in your language, you may need to use a different expression. For example:

She will give herself to me there (NLT)

As a result, she will accept my love for her

2:15d

as she did in the days of her youth, as in the day she came up out of Egypt.

- just as she did when she was a young woman, when she came out of Egypt."
- as she did when she left Egypt long ago when she was young.

Notice the parallelism:

as she did in the days of **her youth**,

as in the day **she came up out of Egypt**

The first line describes a period of time in the past. The second line describes an event that happened during that time.

days...day: These words refer here to periods of time, not to literal 24-hour days. In some languages, it may be more natural to use different expressions. For example:

as in her youth,

as when she came up from Egypt. (REB)

youth: This word refers here to Israel as a young nation, when the LORD established his covenant with her at Mt. Sinai. It also refers figuratively to a young lady of marriageable age. Do not use a term that applies only to small children.

Hosea 2:16

Section 2:14–23: The LORD promised to renew his covenant with them

The purpose of the punishment in 2:1–13 was to make the people of Israel realize that their worship of false gods would result in harm. In this section, 2:14–23, the LORD showed that he continued to love the people of Israel. If they worshiped him, he would bless them and not harm them. In spite of their past sins, he would reestablish a covenant with them. In this section, the tone switches from negative to positive, so there is a sharp contrast between the previous section and this one.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Future Repentance and Restoration of Israel (NET)

The Lord's Love for Unfaithful Israel (NLT)

Paragraph 2:16–20

Verses 16–17 describe a future time when the LORD will cause the Israelites to stop worshiping the gods they call Baals. The LORD alone will be the one they worship and serve.

In return for their devotion, he promised to protect them and their crops from wild animals and from war (verses 18–20). Compare the similar promise to the Israelites in Leviticus 26:5–6.

2:16a

In that day,” declares the LORD,

- יְהוָה Yahweh says, “In that coming/future day/time
- יְהוָה “I, Yahweh, declare: At that time

In that day: This is the same phrase that Hosea used in 1:5. Here in 2:16a, it refers to a time that is farther in the future than the lifetime of Hosea or his audience. Stuart.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

At that time (NET)

In the future (NCV)

When that day comes (NLT)

declares the LORD: The Hebrew phrase here is the same as in 2:13c. See the note there. In some languages, it may be more natural to put this phrase at the beginning of the verse. For example:

The Lord says, “In the future... (NCV)

2:16b–c (combined/reordered)

- you^(sing)/she will no longer call me, ‘My Baal,’ but rather ‘My husband.’

Notice the parallelism. Verse 2:16b gives a positive command. Verse 2:16c gives a corresponding negative command.

^{16b} you will call Me **‘my Husband’**; HOTTP suggests that the verb translated here as “call” has a double meaning. It means both “call for help” and “call/address by name.” Most, if not all, versions follow the second meaning only.

^{16c} and no longer call Me **‘my Master’**.

‘my Husband,’...‘my Master.’ These parallel terms involve a play on words. The Hebrew word *ʾiš*, which the BSB translates as Husband, connotes an affectionate relationship between a man and his wife. The Hebrew word *baʿal*, which the BSB translates as Master, has the meanings “owner/master” and “husband.”

Women commonly used this word to refer to their husbands, but it had a more formal or legal connotation. It was also the name of the Canaanite god, “Baal.” NET footnote, NIDOTTE (#1251), and Davies (page 82).

In the context of this metaphor, the LORD (Israel’s God) was pictured as Israel’s husband. People who spoke Hebrew would have understood two things from this verse:

1. The LORD wanted Israel to be loyal to him alone. He did not want her to refer to him by the name of the heathen god Baal or to confuse him in any way with the worship of Baal.
2. The LORD wanted to have an intimate relationship with Israel. He wanted Israel to think of him as her beloved husband (*ʾiš*), not just her master (*baʿal*).

In most languages, it will not be possible to reproduce this play on words so that both meanings can be understood. There are two options:

- Translate *baʿal* as a proper name. For example:

My Baal (NJB) (GNT, KJV, NASB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NRSV, REB)

- Translate *baʿal* as a title. For example:

My master (NET) (BSB, GW, NET, NIV, NLT)

The first option fits better with the following context, especially 2:17a. The second option fits better with the preceding context, especially 2:14 and 2:15c. The Display will follow the first option, but you may choose either option. It is recommended that you add a footnote to explain the play on words.

Here is a possible footnote:

There were two words for “husband” in Hebrew: *ish* and *baal*. The word *baal* also meant “master.” The LORD wanted Israel to no longer use the word *baal*, because Baal was also the name of one of the Canaanite gods. Instead, they should use the word *ish*.

you: Up through 2:15, the LORD used the pronoun “she” to refer to Israel. But in this verse, he used the pronoun you to address the nation of Israel directly. There is a textual variant here. The MT (Hebrew) has “you will call” and ancient versions (Greek, Syriac, Vulgate) all have, “she will call me.” Most English versions follow the reading of the MT (BSB, CEV, KJV, NASB, NIV, NLT, NRSV), but some follow the

ancient versions and read the third person “she” (GNT, NAB, NCV). In Hebrew poetry, it is common for an author to alternate pronouns in this way, even though the pronoun referent remains the same. It happens frequently in this chapter. In the MT (Hebrew) from 2:2 to 2:15, the LORD spoke about the people of Israel using third person (“she”). In this verse, he uses second person singular (“you”). In 2:17, he uses third person (“her”). Then, in 2:19, it is back to second person (“you”), and in 2:23, it is third person (“her”) again.

One way that versions reduce the potential confusion to readers is by reducing the number of times the pronouns alternate. For example, the NLT changes to “you” in this verse (2:16) and continues to use “you” until 2:20. The GNT does it differently. It continues to use “she” in this verse:

Then once again she will call me her husband—
she will no longer call me her Baal. (GNT)

It changes to “you” in 2:19. In some languages, it may be more natural to use “they” when referring to the Israelites.

You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to translate the pronouns here and in 2:17–18. The Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line.

General Comment on 2:16b–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to put the negative statement before the positive statement. For example:

^{16c}you will no longer call me by the name of your god, Baal. ^{16b}Instead, you will acknowledge that I am your husband.

In some languages, it may also be more natural to combine the parallel verbs. For example:

husband is the word that you will use when you speak to me, not Baal

2:16b

“you will call Me ‘my Husband,’

- you^(sing) will acknowledge me as your husband.
- she will once more say to me, ‘My husband.’

2:16c

and no longer call Me ‘my Master.’

- You^(sing) will no longer call me your god, Baal.

- She will not say to me again, ‘My Baal.’

Hosea 2:17

Section 2:14–23: The LORD promised to renew his covenant with them

The purpose of the punishment in 2:1–13 was to make the people of Israel realize that their worship of false gods would result in harm. In this section, 2:14–23, the LORD showed that he continued to love the people of Israel. If they worshiped him, he would bless them and not harm them. In spite of their past sins, he would reestablish a covenant with them. In this section, the tone switches from negative to positive, so there is a sharp contrast between the previous section and this one.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Future Repentance and Restoration of Israel (NET)

The Lord’s Love for Unfaithful Israel (NLT)

Paragraph 2:16–20

Verses 16–17 describe a future time when the LORD will cause the Israelites to stop worshiping the gods they call Baals. The LORD alone will be the one they worship and serve.

In return for their devotion, he promised to protect them and their crops from wild animals and from war (verses 18–20). Compare the similar promise to the Israelites in Leviticus 26:5–6.

2:17

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{17a}For I will remove from her lips **the names of the Baals;**

^{17b} no longer will **their names** be invoked.

This verse explains why Israel will no longer use the names of Baal to refer to her husband, the LORD. It is because the LORD will stop Israel from doing so.

The first line means that the LORD will cause Israel to stop saying the various names of Baal. The second line indicates the result of the LORD’s action. The result is that the nation of Israel will no longer use the names of Baal, especially in prayers or vows. Andersen and Freedman (page 279).

Some versions, such as the BSB, leave this reason-result relationship implied. Other versions make it explicit. For example:

For I will remove the names of the Baal idols from your lips, so that you will never again utter their names! (NET)

Express this relationship in a natural way in your language.

2:17a

For I will remove from her lips the names of the Baals;

- I will keep her from saying the names of Baal
- For I will cause you^(sing) to stop worshiping the Baal idols/gods.

For I will remove from her lips the names of the Baals: This is a figure of speech in which the phrase her lips (literally “her mouth,” as in the NRSV) represents the action (of speaking) performed by the mouth. The line as a whole means that the LORD will not allow the Israelites to speak the names of the Baals. For example:

I will never let her say the names of Baal again (NCV)

her lips: The Hebrew uses the pronoun her and not “your,” even though the pronoun refers to the same person here as in the previous verse. See the note on the pronoun “you” in 2:16b–c for translation advice.

Baals: The word Baals is plural. See the note on 2:13a. You should translate it the same way in both verses.

2:17a–b (combined/reordered)

- I will never let her/you^(sing) speak the name of Baal again.

2:17b

no longer will their names be invoked.

- so that she never speaks their names again.
- You^(sing) will never mention their names or call out to them for help again.

no longer will their names be invoked: This is a passive clause. In some languages, it may be necessary to use an active clause and to make explicit a subject of the verb. For example:

people won’t use their names anymore (NCV)

General Comment on 2:17a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the parallel parts. For example:

I will never let her speak the name of Baal again. (GNT)

Hosea 2:18

Section 2:14–23: The LORD promised to renew his covenant with them

The purpose of the punishment in 2:1–13 was to make the people of Israel realize that their worship of false gods would result in harm. In this section, 2:14–23, the LORD showed that he continued to love the people of Israel. If they worshiped him, he would bless them and not harm them. In spite of their past sins, he would reestablish a covenant with them. In this section, the tone switches from negative to positive, so there is a sharp contrast between the previous section and this one.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Future Repentance and Restoration of Israel (NET)

The Lord’s Love for Unfaithful Israel (NLT)

Paragraph 2:16–20

Verses 16–17 describe a future time when the LORD will cause the Israelites to stop worshiping the gods they call Baals. The LORD alone will be the one they worship and serve.

In return for their devotion, he promised to protect them and their crops from wild animals and from war (verses 18–20). Compare the similar promise to the Israelites in Leviticus 26:5–6.

2:18a

On that day I will make a covenant for them with the beasts of the field and the birds of the air and the creatures that crawl on the ground.

- At that time I will make an agreement with the wild animals, the birds, and the reptiles for their sake.
- I will cause all the animals to agree not to harm you^(plur).

On that day: This is the same phrase that was used in 2:16a, and it refers to the same future time. For that reason, some versions do not repeat it here but leave it implied. That is an acceptable option as long as it is clear that the time period is the same.

I will make a covenant for them: The word covenant is an important theological word that is used many times in the book of Hosea. Usually it refers to an agreement between God and people. Here it refers to an agreement that the LORD made with the animals for the benefit of the Israelites. If your key term for covenant does not allow this use, you may need to use a different term. For example:

I will make an agreement (NCV)

I shall make a treaty (NJB)

I will cause...to agree

for them: In this context, the Hebrew word that most versions translate as for means “for the benefit of” or “on behalf of.” Hubbard (page 86), McComiskey (page 44), Macintosh (page 81), and Davies (page 83). For example:

on Israel’s behalf (REB)

Some versions leave the phrase for them implied. Most of these versions use other phrases to clarify the kind of benefits that Israel will enjoy. For example:

I will make a covenant with all the wild animals and birds, so that they will not harm my people. (GNT)

them: Here in 2:18a, the pronoun them refers to the Israelites. The GNT uses the phrase “my people.” The CEV continues to use “you.”

with the beasts of the field and the birds of the air and the creatures that crawl on the ground: In this context, these three phrases represent all animals that could cause harm to people or crops. Hubbard (page 85) and Stuart. The same three phrases occur in Genesis 1:30, although the context is different. See how you translated the same phrases there.

the beasts of the field: This phrase refers to untamed animals that are often dangerous to people. Andersen and Freedman (page 281).

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the wild animals (NJB)

the birds of the air: This phrase refers to flying creatures. In English, the words of the air are redundant,

because the word birds includes this idea. So some English versions leave the words of the air implied. For example:

the birds (GW)

the creatures that crawl on the ground: This phrase refers to small animals, including reptiles. Ibid. Also, Hubbard (page 85) and Macintosh (page 82). In English, the category “wild animals” can include small animals. That is perhaps why some English versions, as the GNT, leave this phrase implied.

In other languages, it may be necessary to use two categories to express the meaning of this phrase. For example:

crawling things and slithering things

Use categories that are natural in your language for describing the same kinds of living creatures. You may need to use more or less than three categories.

2:18b

And I will abolish bow and sword and weapons of war in the land,

- I will bring an end to war, to every bow and sword and battle in the/their land,
- I will also destroy every weapon of war in your^(plur) country,

And I will abolish bow and sword and weapons of war in the land: This clause expresses an additional promise from the LORD. It is not related to the covenant with the animals in 2:18a. In some languages, it may be necessary to clarify that this is a separate promise. For example:

I will also remove... (GNT)

abolish: In Hebrew, this word is literally “break.” It means “to break” the weapons in order to end warfare. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

remove (GNT)

destroy (GW)

bow and sword and weapons of war: The bow and the sword were the two main weapons of war during the time of Hosea. Here these weapons are used as a figure of speech (synecdoche) that represents all weapons of war. The phrase weapons of war then

summarizes and extends the figure to mean “warfare” or “battle” (NIV, ESV, RSV)

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

weapons of war (CEV)

all weapons of war from the land, all swords and bows (GNT)

the bow, the sword, and war from the land (ESV)

2:18c

and will make them lie down in safety.

- so that when they go to sleep, they will not fear danger.
- so that you^(plur) will have safe and peaceful lives.

and: The Hebrew conjunction *waw* that the BSB translates as *and* can have many different functions. Most English versions translate it here as *and*. But in this context, it probably introduces the purpose or intended result of the LORD’s previous actions. McComiskey (page 44) and Macintosh (page 82). The purpose/result is that the people of Israel can live in safety.

This conjunction probably refers back to two actions: making the covenant (2:18a) and abolishing war (2:18b). Use a natural way in your language to introduce the purpose or intended result of the LORD’s previous actions.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

so that (NIV)

The result will be that (T4T)

them lie down in safety: This statement tells what happens after the LORD makes the covenant with the animals and abolishes war. To lie down in safety means to sleep without fear of danger. It is a figure of speech that represents a safe life, not only safe sleep. In some languages, it may be clearer to translate this meaning directly and not keep the figure of speech. For example:

and will let my people live in peace and safety (GNT)

so people can live safely (GW)

so that they will have no cause to fear

Hosea 2:19

Section 2:14–23: The LORD promised to renew his covenant with them

The purpose of the punishment in 2:1–13 was to make the people of Israel realize that their worship of false gods would result in harm. In this section, 2:14–23, the LORD showed that he continued to love the people of Israel. If they worshiped him, he would bless them and not harm them. In spite of their past sins, he would reestablish a covenant with them. In this section, the tone switches from negative to positive, so there is a sharp contrast between the previous section and this one.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Future Repentance and Restoration of Israel (NET)

The Lord’s Love for Unfaithful Israel (NLT)

Paragraph 2:16–20

Verses 16–17 describe a future time when the LORD will cause the Israelites to stop worshiping the gods they call Baals. The LORD alone will be the one they worship and serve.

In return for their devotion, he promised to protect them and their crops from wild animals and from war (verses 18–20). Compare the similar promise to the Israelites in Leviticus 26:5–6.

2:19–20

These two verses are one unit. The word that the BSB translates as “betroth” is repeated three times. This term refers figuratively to the LORD’s restored relationship with the people of Israel. Although the people had been unfaithful to him, he will restore their relationship as if he will get married to them again.

In Hebrew, the three repetitions of “I will betroth you” in 2:19–20 emphasize the image of a new marriage. Andersen and Freedman (page 283). If this kind of repetition expresses the same emphasis in a natural way in your language, you may want to maintain it. You may also want to format these verses to show the poetic structure more clearly. For example, the following fairly literal Hebrew translation indents the parallel lines.

^{19a}I will betroth you to me

forever;

^{19b}I will betroth you to me

in righteousness and in justice,

in love and compassion.

^{20a}I will betroth you to me

in faithfulness,

^{20b}and you will know the LORD.

2:19a

So I will betroth you to Me forever;

- People of Israel, I promise to take you^(plur/sing) as my wife forever.
- I will be your husband and you will be my wife forever.

I will betroth you to Me forever: The word that the BSB translates here as betroth refers to a legally binding commitment to begin a marriage relationship. In Hebrew culture, a betrothed couple did not sleep together until after the wedding, but in other ways they were considered to be legally married. In this context, it is a promise to be married forever.

Here are some other ways to translate this meaning:

I will make you my wife forever. (NLT)

I will commit myself to you forever (NET)

you: In Hebrew, verse 2:18a uses the pronoun “them.” Verse 2:19a uses the pronoun you, because the LORD is speaking directly to the Israelites. In Hebrew, this pronoun is singular, because it compares the nation of Israel as a group to the LORD’s unfaithful wife.

Some versions add the vocative “Israel” to make clear who the LORD is speaking to. For example:

Israel, I will make you my wife forever. (GW)

to Me: In Hebrew, this phrase occurs following each of the three occurrences of “betroth.” This repetition emphasizes the personal relationship that the LORD will have with his people. Andersen and Freedman (page 282). Use a natural way in your language to emphasize the personal nature of this relationship.

2:19b–20a

I will betroth you in righteousness and justice, in loving devotion and compassion: The phrases in righteousness and justice, in loving devotion and compassion and “in faithfulness” refer to the qualities that the LORD promises to show to Israel. Some scholars say these are qualities the LORD promises to demonstrate in his relationship with Israel (Davies, pages 85–86; Hubbard, page 87; Macintosh, page 83). Others say these are qualities the LORD promises to give to Israel so that Israel as well as the LORD will demonstrate them in their relationship (Andersen and Freedman, page 283). Still other scholars feel that both aspects are in view or that some of the qualities (such as love and compassion), apply more to the LORD, whereas faithfulness refers primarily to Israel’s response. Stuart (page 59), Wood (page 179), and Keil (page 43).

betroth you in...: In Hebrew, this phrase normally refers to a bride price, a gift that the husband gives to the bride’s father or to his bride. In this context, it probably refers to the qualities that the LORD promises to show to his bride, Israel. The CEV is one version that uses the term “bride price.” It has: “instead of a bride price I will give you justice, fairness,...”

Here are some other ways to translate these lines:

I will be true and faithful; I will show you constant love and mercy and make you mine forever. I will keep my promise and make you mine (GNT)

I will be good and fair; I will show you my love and mercy. I will be true to you as my promised bride (NCV)

righteousness and justice: The words that the BSB translates as righteousness and justice have similar meanings in this context. They refer here to the LORD’s promise to meet all his legal obligations as a figurative husband and to treat Israel fairly and properly.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

I will be good and fair (NCV)

The way I treat you will be right and just/proper

loving devotion and compassion: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates here as loving devotion refers to the loyal love and kindness that the LORD shows to the people with whom he has made a covenant.

The word that the BSB translates here as compassion refers to a strong feeling of mercy and kindness.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

constant love and mercy (GNT)

in steadfast love, and in mercy (NRSV)

2:19b

I will betroth you in righteousness and justice, in loving devotion and compassion.

- I promise to treat you^(plur/sing) with righteousness and justice, constant love, and mercy. These will be my gifts to you, my bride.
- As your husband, I will do what is right and fair toward you. I will always love you and be kind to you.

Hosea 2:20

Section 2:14–23: The LORD promised to renew his covenant with them

The purpose of the punishment in 2:1–13 was to make the people of Israel realize that their worship of false gods would result in harm. In this section, 2:14–23, the LORD showed that he continued to love the people of Israel. If they worshiped him, he would bless them and not harm them. In spite of their past sins, he would reestablish a covenant with them. In this section, the tone switches from negative to positive, so there is a sharp contrast between the previous section and this one.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Future Repentance and Restoration of Israel (NET)

The Lord's Love for Unfaithful Israel (NLT)

Paragraph 2:16–20

Verses 16–17 describe a future time when the LORD will cause the Israelites to stop worshiping the gods they call Baals. The LORD alone will be the one they worship and serve.

In return for their devotion, he promised to protect them and their crops from wild animals and from war (verses 18–20). Compare the similar promise to the Israelites in Leviticus 26:5–6.

2:20a

And I will betroth you in faithfulness,

- I also promise to be faithful to you^(plur/sing).

- As your husband, I will also keep all my promises to you.

2:20b

and you will know the LORD.”

- Then you^(plur/sing) will truly know me, I who am Yahweh.
- Then you will be devoted to me, Yahweh.

And: In this context, the Hebrew conjunction *waw* that the BSB translates as *And* introduces a result. As a result of the marriage relationship that is based on the qualities in 2:19b and 2:20a, Israel will know the LORD.

Here are some other ways to introduce this result:

Then you will know the Lord. (GW)

The result is that you will know the LORD.

Introduce this result in a natural way in your language.

you will know the LORD: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as *know* has more than one meaning related to knowing, experiencing, and understanding. There are two main ways to interpret this word in this context:

1. It means that Israel knows the LORD in an intimate, personal way. The verb “to know” is frequently used in the Old Testament as a euphemism for sexual intimacy between a man and his wife. Here it refers to Israel intimately knowing and experiencing God and his ways. There is no sexual component. In the context of a betrothal covenant, it implies that Israel understands and enjoys the LORD's character, as described in 2:19b–20a. For example:

you will truly know who I am (CEV)

you will finally know me as the Lord (NLT) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. It means that Israel acknowledges or agrees that he is the LORD. For example:

you will acknowledge me as Lord (GNT) (GNT, NET, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries. In a marriage, symbolic or otherwise, a wife (Israel) knows

her husband (the LORD) in a personal way. She does not just recognize or admit who he is.

Some languages have different words for knowing someone personally and knowing facts about someone. If that is true in your language, you should use the word that refers to a personal relationship. In some languages, it may be necessary to use a different phrase. For example:

you shall be devoted to the Lord (NJPS)

the LORD: Here the LORD speaks of himself using third person the LORD. If it is not natural in your language for a person to refer to himself in that way, you may use the pronoun “I” or “me,” as the CEV has done (quoted above).

Hosea 2:21

Section 2:14–23: The LORD promised to renew his covenant with them

The purpose of the punishment in 2:1–13 was to make the people of Israel realize that their worship of false gods would result in harm. In this section, 2:14–23, the LORD showed that he continued to love the people of Israel. If they worshiped him, he would bless them and not harm them. In spite of their past sins, he would reestablish a covenant with them. In this section, the tone switches from negative to positive, so there is a sharp contrast between the previous section and this one.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Future Repentance and Restoration of Israel (NET)

The Lord’s Love for Unfaithful Israel (NLT)

Paragraph 2:21–22

The overall meaning of this paragraph is that the LORD will respond to the situation in the land of Israel and will send rain, causing the earth to produce good crops. Wood (page 180). This response contrasts with the earlier agricultural disasters with which the LORD punished Israel. (2:9, 2:12).

2:21a

“On that day I will respond—” declares the LORD—

- ¶ “In that coming/future day/time, I will respond. I, Yahweh, declare it.
- ¶ “I, Yahweh, say this: This is what I will do at that time.

On that day: This is the same expression that Hosea used in 2:18a. See how you translated the expression there.

I will respond: There is a textual issue here:

1. The Masoretic Text includes the verb phrase I will respond after the phrase “in that day.” For example:

When that day comes, I shall respond—declares Yahweh— (NJB) (BSB, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The LXX and Syriac do not have this phrase. For example:

And in that day, says the Lord (RSV) (CEV, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and commentaries.

This is the first time that the phrase I will respond occurs in 2:21–22. The text does not identify who the LORD will respond to. There are two main ways to interpret the function of this statement here:

1. It indicates that the LORD will respond to the heavens. For example:

On that day I will answer, says the Lord, I will answer the heavens (NRSV) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. It indicates that the LORD will respond to the prayers of the Israelites. For example:

I will answer the prayers of my people Israel (GNT) (GNT, GW, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries. Some versions indicate that this is a general request that introduces other requests. The BSB does this by inserting a long dash. Another way to indicate this is to reorder the phrases in this verse part and use a colon. For example:

The LORD says, “At that time I will respond:

In some languages, it may not be possible to use a statement such as I will respond without indicating who the LORD is responding to. If that is true in your language, you may need to use a different phrase. For example:

The LORD says, “At that time this is what I will do:

declares the LORD: This phrase emphasizes that the message was directly from the LORD. This is the same phrase as in 2:13c. See the note there.

2:21b

“I will respond to the heavens, and they will respond to the earth.

- I will answer the sky that is pleading for clouds. The sky will then answer the earth that is pleading for rain.
- I will make rain fall on the dry ground/earth.

I will respond to the heavens: This is a figurative statement. It means that the LORD will do something in response to the implied request from the heavens that he send clouds or rain. In some languages, it may be necessary to clarify this figure of speech by making some of the implied information explicit. For example:

I will answer the sky as it pleads for clouds (NLT)

the heavens: In this context, the phrase that the BSB and many versions translate as the heavens refers to the sky, that is, the atmosphere above the earth.

they will respond to the earth: This is a figurative statement. It means that the skies will respond to the implied request of the earth for rain. In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of the implied information explicit. For example:

which will pour down water on the earth in answer to its cries for rain. (NLT96)

they: The plural pronoun they refers back to “the heavens.” If you translated “heavens” with a form such as “sky/heaven,” then you will need to use a singular form here. For example:

I will speak to the sky, it will speak to the earth (GW)

General Comment on 2:21b

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine the parts of this verse. For example:

The earth needs rain, so I will tell the sky to cause rain to fall.

I will command the sky to send rain on the earth (CEV)

I will make rain fall on the earth (GNT)

Hosea 2:22

Section 2:14–23: The LORD promised to renew his covenant with them

The purpose of the punishment in 2:1–13 was to make the people of Israel realize that their worship of false gods would result in harm. In this section, 2:14–23, the LORD showed that he continued to love the people of Israel. If they worshiped him, he would bless them and not harm them. In spite of their past sins, he would reestablish a covenant with them. In this section, the tone switches from negative to positive, so there is a sharp contrast between the previous section and this one.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Future Repentance and Restoration of Israel (NET)

The Lord’s Love for Unfaithful Israel (NLT)

Paragraph 2:21–22

The overall meaning of this paragraph is that the LORD will respond to the situation in the land of Israel and will send rain, causing the earth to produce good crops. Wood (page 180). This response contrasts with the earlier agricultural disasters with which the LORD punished Israel. (2:9, 2:12).

2:22a

And the earth will respond to the grain, to the new wine and oil,

- Then the earth will answer the grain, the grapevines, and the olive trees that plead for moisture.
- And the ground throughout Israel will produce a good harvest of grain, grapes for making wine, and olives for making oil.

And the earth will respond to the grain, to the new wine and oil: This figurative statement implies that

the earth will respond to a request from its produce (grain, wine, and oil) that it provide the moisture or fertile soil that the plants need.

Here are some other ways to translate this figurative statement:

- Make some of the implied information explicit. For example:

Then the earth will answer the thirsty cries of the grain, the grapes, and the olive trees for moisture. (NLT96)

- If the figure of the earth answering a request from its crops is not meaningful in your language, translate the meaning directly. For example:

and the earth will produce grain and grapes and olives. (GNT)

The first option forms a better parallel with 2:21b. For the terms grain, new wine, and oil, see the notes in 2:8b.

the new wine: Here the term new wine is probably a figure of speech that represents the grapevines or grapes that were the source of the wine. For example:

grapevines (NLT)

grapes (GNT)

Translate this term in a way that makes good sense in this context.

2:22b

and they will respond to Jezreel.

- And they will answer the request of my people, Jezreel for an abundant harvest.
- This good harvest will satisfy the desires/needs of my people, who are called Jezreel.

and they will respond to Jezreel: This figurative statement implies that the crops mentioned in 2:22a will respond to the request from Jezreel for a plentiful harvest. Here the name Jezreel represents the nation or people of Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this figurative statement:

- Make some of the implied information explicit. For example:

They will answer the request of my people, Jezreel, for a plentiful harvest.

- If the figure of crops answering a nation is not meaningful in your language, translate the meaning directly. For example:

These crops will supply the desire of my people, Jezreel, for a good harvest.

Jezreel: Hosea's audience understood three things from the term Jezreel: NET footnote.

1. The Hebrew word sounds like the word for "Israel" and refers to it. Wood (page 180) and NET footnote.
2. The Hebrew word in the context of the following verse means "God plants."
3. This is the name of Hosea's first son. His name referred to the bloodshed of Jehu in the Jezreel Valley. Here the positive use of the word Jezreel changes the negative use of the same word in 1:4-5.

You may want to include this information in a footnote. Following is an example based on the NET footnote:

The Hebrew word "Jezreel" implies three things here: (1) The name "Jezreel" sounds similar to the name "Israel." So to respond to Jezreel means to respond to Israel. (2) The name "Jezreel" here means "God plants." (3) This good meaning of "Jezreel" changes the bad meaning of "Jezreel" in 1:4-5 (bloodshed of Jehu in the Jezreel Valley).

Hosea 2:23

Section 2:14-23: The LORD promised to renew his covenant with them

The purpose of the punishment in 2:1-13 was to make the people of Israel realize that their worship of false gods would result in harm. In this section, 2:14-23, the LORD showed that he continued to love the people of Israel. If they worshiped him, he would bless them and not harm them. In spite of their past sins, he would reestablish a covenant with them. In this section, the tone switches from negative to positive, so there is a sharp contrast between the previous section and this one.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Future Repentance and Restoration of Israel (NET)

The Lord's Love for Unfaithful Israel (NLT)

2:23a

And I will sow her as My own in the land,

- ¶ "I will plant my people in the land of Israel, and they will be mine.
- ¶ "I will accept them as my people, and they will prosper in the land. They will be like crops that I plant in the ground.

And I will sow her as My own in the land: One meaning of the name Jezreel (2:22) is "God plants." Here the LORD states that he will sow the people of Israel in the land of Israel. This figurative statement

means that he will again establish the Israelites as a strong and prosperous nation.

If it is not possible to keep this metaphor in your language, here are some other ways to translate it:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

The people of Israel will be like crops that I plant in the land. They will be my people and I will cause them to grow and become strong.

- Translate the meaning directly without using a figure of speech. For example:

I will establish my people in the land and make them prosper. (GNT)

Try to keep the figurative idea of planting if possible. It will help your readers to understand the connection with the name “Jezreel” in the previous verse.

her: The NRSV translates this pronoun as “him” since it refers to Jezreel, which is normally masculine in gender. However, in Hebrew, this pronoun is feminine, probably since Jezreel represents Israel, the LORD’s bride.

In many languages, there is no distinction between masculine and feminine pronouns. Translate this pronoun so that it refers clearly to the people of Israel. In some cases, it may be clearer to use a more specific phrase. For example:

At that time I will plant a crop of Israelites and raise them for myself! (NLT)

as My own: This phrase indicates that the LORD will once more accept the Israelites as his own people.

2:23b

and I will have compassion on ‘No Compassion.’

- I will once again show my love to the one I called/named ‘Not Loved/Pitied.’
- I will show Lo-Ruhamah that I love her.

2:23c

I will say to those called ‘Not My People,’ ‘You are My people,’

- And those whom I called ‘Not My People’ I will once again say to them, ‘You^(plur) are my people.’
- And I will say to Lo-Ammi, ‘You are my people.’

2:23b–c

Notice the parallelism:

^{23b} and I will have compassion on ‘**No Compassion.**’

^{23c} I will say to those called ‘**Not My People,**’ ‘You are My people,’

These parallel lines refer back to the names of Hosea’s second and third children given in 1:6–9. Each of these names had a negative meaning. In 1:10 and 2:1, the LORD said that he would give those names a positive meaning. In this verse, he spoke about the fulfillment of that promise. The LORD’s covenant with Israel will be restored and the Israelites will once more be his people.

Some versions, such as the NJB, keep the names Lo-Ruhamah and Lo-ammi here. Others, such as the GNT, replace these Hebrew names with their meanings “Not my loved one” and “Not my people.” The NET includes both the meanings and the Hebrew names:

I will have pity on ‘No Pity’ (Lo-Ruhamah). (NET)

I will say to ‘Not My People’ (Lo-Ammi), ‘You are my people!’

See the discussion in 1:6b and 1:9a on how to translate these names and their meanings. Depending on how you translated the names there, you may be able to translate them the same way here. But notice that the BSB transliterated the Hebrew names in 1:6b and 1:9, but it used the meanings of the names here in 2:23. That is because the names in chapter 1 referred to the literal children of Hosea and Gomer. Here in chapter 2, they refer to the people of Israel. You will need to decide whether it is appropriate to treat these names in the same way as you did in 1:6–9. You may want to add a footnote that cross-references these verses.

2:23d

and they will say, ‘You are my God.’”

- And my people will say, ‘You^(sing) are my God.’”
- And they will say to me, ‘And you^(sing) O Yahweh are the God that we^(excl) worship/serve.’”

and they will say: The Hebrew pronoun that the BSB translates as they is literally “he,” as in the NRSV. This pronoun refers back to Lo-Ammi. Here Lo-Ammi clearly refers to the people of Israel, not to the literal son of Hosea. Use a pronoun or phrase that refers clearly to the people of Israel.

You are my God: You should translate this clause in a way that clearly shows the contrast with the words

“I am not your God” in 1:9b. Compare 1:9b and 2:23d in the Display for examples.

Hosea 3:1

Section 3:1–5: Hosea redeemed Gomer as the LORD will redeem Israel

In this section, the LORD commanded Hosea to take Gomer back as his wife. This probably occurred later in their marriage after Gomer had left Hosea and became an adulteress. There are two main views about how the events of chapters 1 and 2 relate to those of chapter 3. One view is that the events described in chapter 3 follow those described in chapters 1 and 2. (This is the view taken by this Translators Notes publication.) Another view is that in chapter 3, Hosea is describing most of the same events but from a different perspective and for a different purpose. Once more Hosea communicated the LORD’s message by his action as well as his words. His action was an illustration of the LORD’s unfaithful love for the nation of Israel. Israel had been unfaithful to the LORD and had been worshipping other gods. In the same way, Gomer had been unfaithful to Hosea and had left him for other lovers. And just as Hosea was commanded to take Gomer back as his wife, so the LORD planned to restore Israel to himself.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

An Illustration of God’s Love for Idolatrous Israel (NET)

Hosea Redeems His Wife (ESV)

Hosea’s Reconciliation With His Wife (NIV)

3:1a

Then the LORD said to me, “Go show love to your wife again,

- ¶ Then Yahweh said to me, “Go again and show/demonstrate your^(sing) love for your wife,
- ¶ Then Yahweh said to me, “Go and take back your wife. Show her that you love her,

Then the LORD said to me, “Go show love to your wife again: In this sentence, the Hebrew word order is “said the LORD to me again go show...” There are two ways to interpret the connection of the word again:

1. Go again. The word again modifies the verb Go or the phrase Go show.... For example:

The Lord said to me, “Go again and show your love...” (GNT) (BSB, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, RSV)

1. said again. The word again modifies the verb said. This interpretation may indicate that the LORD is continuing the series of speeches described in 1:2–9. Andersen and Freedman (page 294). For example:

The Lord said to me again, “Go, love... (NRSV) (CEV, NCV, NJPS, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most English versions. Interpretation (1) is also supported by the LXX, Vulgate, and Peshitta. Commentaries that support this interpretation include Macintosh (page 93), Wood (page 181), and Keil (page 66). Interpretation (2) is supported by Stuart, Hubbard (page 90), and Andersen and Freedman (page 294). This command probably refers back to 1:2b, where the LORD told Hosea, “Go, take a prostitute as your wife...” Here the meaning is that Hosea should go and take back his wife so that he can once again show his love to her as her husband.

show love: The Hebrew word translated as love has a broad range of meaning. In this context, it probably means for Hosea to use words and acts of love to reaffirm his marriage. It probably does not mean to “court,” that is, to try to persuade the woman to respond, as in 2:16. Andersen and Freedman (page 295).

your wife: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as your wife is literally “a woman.” For example:

Go again, love a woman (ESV)

Most scholars think that this phrase refers to Hosea’s wife, Gomer. Versions that specify “your wife” include the BSB, GW, NET, NIV, and NLT. Most versions translate this phrase literally. These versions include the CEV, ESV, GNT, NASB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NRSV, REB, and RSV. Most of these versions are ambiguous, but the ESV, NASB, and NJB indicate by means of a heading or a footnote that they understand the word “woman” to refer to Hosea’s wife, Gomer. Of the commentaries, Stuart thinks this phrase probably refers to a different woman. McComiskey (page 50), Macintosh (page 97), Hubbard (page 54), Wood (page 181), Andersen and Freedman (page 295), Dorsey (page 265), and Bush (page 336) think that it refers to Gomer. This has not been discussed in the Notes as an interpretation issue, because no versions clearly specify that the word “woman” clearly refers to a different woman.

The “woman” is further described as an adulteress. This accurately describes Gomer. It is unlikely that the LORD would command Hosea to commit adultery by marrying a different woman who was also an adulteress. A specific reference to Gomer also fits the symbolism of the LORD again showing his love to Israel, the nation that he first chose as his own. Some of the commentators that support the first view are McComiskey, Macintosh, Hubbard, and Bush.

In some languages, a literal translation of the Hebrew phrase may imply that God commanded Hosea to show his love to a different woman. You should translate this phrase so that it refers clearly to Hosea’s wife.

Here are some other ways to translate the whole clause:

Go and love your wife again (NLT)

Go and take back your wife so that you can show her again that you love her.

3:1b

though she is loved by another and is an adulteress.

- although another man loves her and your^(sing) wife continues to commit adultery.
- even though she is an adulteress and is even now having an affair.

though she is loved by another: There is a textual issue here:

1. The Masoretic Text uses a passive form. It has “woman who is loved by...” In other words, another person is the one who loves, and the woman receives the love. For example:

loved by someone else (NCV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJPS, NRSV, REB) The CEV, NRSV, and GNT have, “woman who has (who is committing adultery with) a lover.” Even though they do not retain the Hebrew passive form, they do retain the same meaning. The word “lover” indicates a person who loves the woman.

1. The LXX uses an active form. It has “woman who loves...” In other words, the woman is the one who loves, and another person receives the love. For example:

loves another man (NJB) (NET, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions.

If it is not natural to use a passive form in your language, here are two other ways to translate this clause:

- Use an active form that has the same meaning. For example:

love your wife although another man loves her

- Use a different expression that does not focus on who loves whom. For example:

love your wife even though she is having an affair

adulteress: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as adulteress is literally “[who] commits adultery.” BART interlinear. It is more specific than a general term such as “immoral.” It refers to a married person who is unfaithful to his or her spouse.

3:1c

Love her as the LORD loves the Israelites,

- You^(sing) must love her just as I, Yahweh, love Israel.
- Show her your love as I, Yahweh, show my love to the people of Israel.

Love her as the LORD loves the Israelites: In Hebrew, the words Love her are only implied. The BSB and some other versions supply these words to make explicit that this statement is part of the command “love” in 3:1a. You may want to do the same in your translation.

the Israelites: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the Israelites is literally “sons of Israel.” It refers here to the entire nation.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Israel (NLT)

the people of Israel (GNT)

3:1d

though they turn to other gods and offer raisin cakes to idols.”

- I love them even though they turn away from me to worship other gods. Instead of loving me they love the cakes made of raisins that they use in their false worship.”
- For I love them dearly even though they turn away from me. What do they love? They love to worship other gods!”

though they turn to other gods and offer raisin cakes to idols: The word that the BSB translates as offer is literally “love.” This verse part indicates that loving raisin cakes is in some way connected to the worship of other gods. Worshipers may have eaten the cakes as a part of their worship of these false gods, or they may have given the cakes as offerings as the BSB indicates. Macintosh (page 97) and Andersen and Freedman (page 298).

The repetition of the word love (in Hebrew) in this verse effectively contrasts the selfless love the LORD has toward the people of Israel and the self-centered, idolatrous love of the people. Hubbard (pages 91–92).

In Hebrew and also in many English versions, a single word for “love” is used in four places in this verse: “show love to your wife,” “loved by another,” “as the LORD loves the Israelites,” and (NIV:) “love the sacred raisin cakes.” In some languages, a single word can be used in all these contexts. If that is true in your language, consider using it in all four places to show the contrasts. Otherwise, you may need to use more than one word.

offer...to idols: In Hebrew, the words offer...to idols do not occur here. The BSB supplies them to make explicit that these raisin cakes were used in idol worship. Some versions also make explicit how the cakes were used. For example:

take offerings of raisins to idols (GNT)

enjoy the offering cakes made with fruit (CEV)

raisin cakes: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “cakes of grapes.” Raisin cakes were made of dried grapes pressed into a solid mass. Andersen and Freedman (page 298).

If you have no expression for raisin cakes in your language, here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use a more general term. For example:

dried grapes

cakes made with fruit (CEV)

choice gifts (NLT96)

- Omit the reference to a fruit or a gift and use an expression that refers more generally to worshipping other gods. For example:

love to worship them (NLT)

Hosea 3:2

Section 3:1–5: Hosea redeemed Gomer as the LORD will redeem Israel

In this section, the LORD commanded Hosea to take Gomer back as his wife. This probably occurred later in their marriage after Gomer had left Hosea and became an adulteress. There are two main views about how the events of chapters 1 and 2 relate to those of chapter 3. One view is that the events described in chapter 3 follow those described in chapters 1 and 2. (This is the view taken by this Translators Notes publication.) Another view is that in chapter 3, Hosea is describing most of the same events but from a different perspective and for a different purpose. Once more Hosea communicated the LORD’s message by his action as well as his words. His action was an illustration of the LORD’s unfailing love for the nation of Israel. Israel had been unfaithful to the LORD and had been worshipping other gods. In the same way, Gomer had been unfaithful to Hosea and had left him for other lovers. And just as Hosea was commanded to take Gomer back as his wife, so the LORD planned to restore Israel to himself.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

An Illustration of God’s Love for Idolatrous Israel (NET)

Hosea Redeems His Wife (ESV)

Hosea’s Reconciliation With His Wife (NIV)

Paragraph 3:2–3

In this paragraph, Hosea bought Gomer. Although they were still married, he told her that they would not be intimate with each other, nor would she be intimate with anyone else. This situation was probably a symbol that the LORD would restore his relationship with Israel and purify her.

3:2

So I bought her for fifteen shekels of silver and a homer and a lethech of barley.

- ¶ So I went and bought her. I paid fifteen pieces of silver and 330 liters of barley.

- ¶ After Yahweh said that, I went and redeemed her with fifteen silver coins and ten bushels/measures of grain.

So I bought her for fifteen shekels of silver and a homer and a lethech of barley: Some scholars say that the value of the barley added to the fifteen shekels of silver made Hosea's total expense approximately thirty shekels. It is not clear why Hosea paid this specific amount. He may have redeemed her from a debt that she could not pay. IVP Bible Background Commentary. This price was equal to the value of a slave in Exodus 21:32, so it is possible that Gomer had sold herself into slavery to be someone's mistress. Wood (page 182) and Macintosh (page 99).

Here are some other ways to translate this idea:

I paid...to buy her (GNT)

I redeemed her with...

fifteen shekels of silver: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally "fifteen silver." The word shekels is not in the Hebrew text.

Here are some ways to translate this amount of money:

- Add the word "shekels" for clarity. The shekel was the standard unit of measure for silver, so it is implied. For example:

fifteen shekels of silver (NJB)

- Add the word "pieces" for clarity instead of shekels. For example:

fifteen pieces of silver (GNT)

- Some versions give the total weight in the text. They do not translate fifteen or add the word shekels or "pieces." For example:

six ounces of silver (NCV)

Any of these translation options are acceptable. It is recommended that you add a footnote that gives the equivalent weight in units of measurement that the readers will understand. For example:

The Hebrew literally says "fifteen silver." This amount of silver money weighed about 6 ounces or 170 grams.

a homer and a lethech of barley: There is a textual issue here:

1. The Masoretic Text has "a homer of barley and a lethech of barley." For example:

a homer and a half of barley (NASB) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, RSV)

1. The LXX has "a homer of barley and a measure of wine." For example:

a homer of barley and a skin of wine (NJB) (NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions.

Both homer and lethech were units of dry measure. According to tradition, a lethech equaled half a homer. Andersen and Freedman (page 300). Scholars disagree on the size of a homer. Estimates vary from 100 liters to 394 liters. HALOT (#2994) suggests 394 liters. NIDOTTE (#2818) suggests 100 liters. Other sources suggest amounts in between these two. As a result, versions disagree on the amount of barley that is equivalent to a homer and a lethech. Some versions have "seven bushels" (GNT and NET). Others have "ten bushels" (CEV, NCV, NIV, and GW). You may want to use an amount that agrees with a major language translation used in your area.

There are two main options for translating this amount of barley:

- Transliterate the Hebrew words homer and lethech. An example is the BSB above. You can also include a footnote that gives the equivalent amount, using the unit of measurement that is most common in your area for measuring grain. For example:

That is, probably about 10 bushels (about 330 liters) (NIV footnote)

- Do not transliterate the Hebrew words homer and lethech in the text of the translation. Instead, state the equivalent amount using the unit of measurement that is most common in your area for measuring grain. For example, a bushel is a common English unit of measure, so the CEV has "ten bushels."

barley: If barley is unknown in your area, here are some ways to translate it:

- Use a more general term. For example:

grain (CEV)

- If there is no general term, you may use a specific kind of grain that is known in your area. For example:

rice

Hosea 3:3

Section 3:1–5: Hosea redeemed Gomer as the LORD will redeem Israel

In this section, the LORD commanded Hosea to take Gomer back as his wife. This probably occurred later in their marriage after Gomer had left Hosea and became an adulteress. There are two main views about how the events of chapters 1 and 2 relate to those of chapter 3. One view is that the events described in chapter 3 follow those described in chapters 1 and 2. (This is the view taken by this Translators Notes publication.) Another view is that in chapter 3, Hosea is describing most of the same events but from a different perspective and for a different purpose. Once more Hosea communicated the LORD's message by his action as well as his words. His action was an illustration of the LORD's unfailing love for the nation of Israel. Israel had been unfaithful to the LORD and had been worshipping other gods. In the same way, Gomer had been unfaithful to Hosea and had left him for other lovers. And just as Hosea was commanded to take Gomer back as his wife, so the LORD planned to restore Israel to himself.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

An Illustration of God's Love for Idolatrous Israel (NET)

Hosea Redeems His Wife (ESV)

Hosea's Reconciliation With His Wife (NIV)

Paragraph 3:2–3

In this paragraph, Hosea bought Gomer. Although they were still married, he told her that they would not be intimate with each other, nor would she be intimate with anyone else. This situation was probably a symbol that the LORD would restore his relationship with Israel and purify her.

3:3

^{3a}You are to live with me many days;

^{3b}you must not be a prostitute or be intimate with any man,

^{3c}and I will live with you.

The overall meaning of this verse is that Gomer is to remain in Hosea's home and be loyal to him as his wife for a long time. During this time she must not sleep with other men, nor will Hosea sleep with her.

3:3a

Then I said to her, "You must live with me for many days;

- Then I said to her, "You^(sing) must stay/live here in our^(incl) house for a long time.

You must live with me: In Hebrew, this clause is literally "you will remain for me." It functions here as a command. This command implies three things in the context of the rest of the verse:

1. Gomer must remain living with Hosea in his home.
2. She must remain loyal to him.
3. She must wait for him to resume sexual relations with her.

Most English versions make only some of this implied information explicit in this part of the verse. For example:

You will live in my house (REB)

You must wait for me (GW)

Now you are mine! You will have to remain faithful to me (CEV)

Use a command that will imply as many of these meanings as possible.

for many days: This expression refers to a long period of time.

3:3a–c

(combined/reordered)

- Then I said to her, "Much time will pass before we^(dual) have sexual relations together, but until then, you^(sing) must live with me here as my wife. You must not be a prostitute, and you must not have sexual relations with any other man."

3:3b**you must not be promiscuous or belong to another,**

- You^(sing) must never again be a prostitute or have sexual relations with any other man,

belong to another: In Hebrew, this phrase means to have sexual relations with a man.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

have sexual relations with any other man (NCV)

belong to another man (ESV)

committing adultery (GNT)

giving yourself to any man (NJB)

3:3c**and I will do the same for you.”**

- and for a long time I will not have sexual relations with you^(sing).”

and I will do the same for you: In Hebrew, this statement is literally “and also I to you.” BART interlinear. The Hebrew words “and also I” indicate a similarity between what Hosea will do and what Gomer does. However, since there is no verb in the Hebrew, it is not clear what the similar action refers to. There are two ways to interpret this statement:

1. It means that both of them will refrain from sexual activity. In 3:3b, Hosea told Gomer to refrain from sexual activity. Here Hosea said that he too will refrain from sexual activity with her. For example:

you shall not have intercourse with a man, nor I with you (NRSV) (CEV, NLT, NJPS, NRSV, REB)

1. It means that both of them will live in the same home. In 3:3a Hosea told Gomer to “live with” him. One implication of that command is that she must continue to live with Hosea in his home. Here Hosea promised that he will also continue to live with her. For example:

I will live with you (NIV) (NIV)

Some versions (GNT, GW, NET, NJB) use a phrase such as “wait for.” In the context of 3:3b, this probably implies that Hosea and Gomer will need to wait before having sexual relations with each other. The NIV2011

says: “I will behave the same way toward you.” The NCV is similar. It has: “I will act the same way toward you.” The BSB has a similar translation. These versions do not specify a particular behavior or action, but in light of the preceding commands, they may imply sexual activity. Other versions (ESV, NASB, RSV) translate the Hebrew phrase quite literally. They are more ambiguous.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries. This interpretation better fits the two preceding commands in 3:3b. These commands refer clearly to refraining from sexual activity. The long period without sexual intimacy between Gomer and Hosea is probably symbolic of the long period in 3:4 without a close relationship between Israel and the LORD. It may also symbolize a time of purification.

General Comment on 3:3a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine the parts of this verse in order to make the overall meaning clearer. For example:

Now you are mine! You will have to remain faithful to me, though it will be a long time before we sleep together. (CEV)

In some languages, it may be more natural to express the direct quote in this verse as an indirect quote. For example:

I told her that for a long time she would have to wait for me without being a prostitute or committing adultery; and during this time I would wait for her. (GNT)

Hosea 3:4**Section 3:1–5: Hosea redeemed Gomer as the LORD will redeem Israel**

In this section, the LORD commanded Hosea to take Gomer back as his wife. This probably occurred later in their marriage after Gomer had left Hosea and became an adulteress. There are two main views about how the events of chapters 1 and 2 relate to those of chapter 3. One view is that the events described in chapter 3 follow those described in chapters 1 and 2. (This is the view taken by this Translators Notes publication.) Another view is that in chapter 3, Hosea is describing most of the same events but from a different perspective and for a different purpose. Once more Hosea communicated the LORD’s message by his action as well as his words. His action was an illustration of the

LORD's unfailing love for the nation of Israel. Israel had been unfaithful to the LORD and had been worshipping other gods. In the same way, Gomer had been unfaithful to Hosea and had left him for other lovers. And just as Hosea was commanded to take Gomer back as his wife, so the LORD planned to restore Israel to himself.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

An Illustration of God's Love for Idolatrous Israel (NET)

Hosea Redeems His Wife (ESV)

Hosea's Reconciliation With His Wife (NIV)

Paragraph 3:4-5

In this paragraph, Hosea's words predicted that the LORD will judge/punish the nation of Israel (3:4). But after the LORD punishes them, they will seek him again (3:5).

Verse 4 gives details of the LORD's punishment. He will punish Israel by keeping them from having three things: its own government, worship, and supernatural guidance. These things are arranged in three pairs. In Hebrew, the first five items in these pairs are introduced with a negative existential "there is no/not" ("without" in English versions): Lange (page 47) and Davies (page 103) think that both "ephod" and "idols" may have represented idols that were used in pagan worship. McComiskey (page 53) says that Hosea may have omitted the word "without" before "idols" to indicate that Israel's syncretistic religion was actually totally pagan. Macintosh (pages 106-107) also comments on the close association of these two terms, but concludes that the Israelites used the ephod in the context of the idolatrous cult to consult Yahweh. Wood (page 138) and Pusey (page 43) both make a distinction between the ephod, used by the high priest to consult Yahweh, and the idols (teraphim) used to consult pagan deities. Hubbard (page 93) also associates the ephod with the high priestly garment that contained the Urim and Thummim used to obtain guidance from Yahweh. Of the English versions used in TN, only the NJPS and KJV follow the Hebrew repetition of the word "without."

^{4a} without king and without prince

^{4b} without sacrifice and without pillar

^{4c} without ephod and idols

3:4a

For the Israelites must live many days without king or prince,

- ¶ In the same way, it will be a long time until the people of Israel have their own kings or officials.
- ¶ This will show/illustrate what will happen to the people of Israel. They will have no king or other leaders for a long time.

For: In Hebrew, this word introduces the reason that the LORD told Hosea to stop having sexual relations with Gomer in 3:3. The reason was to illustrate that the LORD will refrain from closeness to Israel. Some versions use a phrase that makes this connection between 3:3 and 3:4 more explicit. For example:

This shows that.... (NLT)

In just this way.... (GNT)

Use a natural way in your language to introduce this connection.

the Israelites: See the note on the same phrase in 3:1c.

must live many days: This is the same phrase as in 3:3a. You should translate this phrase in a way that shows the parallel between Gomer and Israel. For example, the GNT has "for a long time" in both verses.

without king or prince: During the time that the people of Israel are in exile, the Assyrians will rule them. They will not be able to govern themselves anymore. In Hebrew, the word prince refers here to any leader, chief, or official who serves in the government of the king, the highest ruler. BDB (#8269), Pusey (page 43), and Macintosh (page 105).

Here are some other ways to translate these terms:

without kings or leaders (GNT)

without king and without officials (NJPS)

3:4b

without sacrifice or sacred pillar,

- During that time, they will not be able to make sacrifices. Nor will they have the opportunity to worship other gods at sacred stone pillars.

- They will also have no way to sacrifice animals to Yahweh, and they will have no statues that they have set up to worship idols.

without sacrifice: When the people are in exile, they will no longer be able to make animal sacrifices. This term can refer to sacrifices to the LORD or sacrifices to idols. At that time, the people worshiped both the LORD and idols, so if possible, translate it so that it can refer to either kind of sacrifice. For example:

there will be no animal sacrifices

they will not be able to make sacrifices

If you need to specify the LORD or idols, you should specify the LORD. This gives a better contrast with the pagan worship indicated by the next term. Commentaries that support a contrast between sacrifices (made to Yahweh) and pagan worship involving stone pillars include Pusey, Wood, McComiskey, and Davies. Wood (page 183) says that the Israelites would be “without proper or improper means of worship.” Pusey (page 43) says: “not following after idolatries, yet cut off from the sacrificial worship which he had appointed for forgiveness of sins.”

sacred pillar: In Hebrew, this word is literally “a pillar.” It refers to a tall, thin pillar or column made of stone that was placed vertically in the ground. Some scholars think that these pillars were statues or idols of pagan gods that the people used in their worship. Lange (page 47) uses the word “statues.” Hubbard (page 94) says that they were “Canaanite columns that symbolized male deities.” Pusey (page 43) identifies them as “images,...the visible form of the beings, whom they worshiped instead of God.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

sacred stone pillars (GNT)

stones that they set up for worshiping idols

3:4c

and without ephod or idol.

- And during that time, there will not be an ephod or any teraphim.
- Moreover, there will be no High Priest with the embroidered vest/garment that has objects to use to get answers/guidance from Yahweh. There will also be no household idols/gods for the people to consult.

- There will be nothing for people to use if they want Yahweh’s guidance or even guidance from the small idols in their homes.

without ephod: The ephod that is mentioned here was probably used by the High Priest. Other types of ephod mentioned in the OT include 1) a simple linen garment worn by priests (1 Samuel 2:18) and 2) an object used for divination that sometimes accompanied household idols (Judges 8:27). It was an embroidered sleeveless vest to which was attached a breast piece that contained the Urim and Thummim. The High Priest used these objects to ask the LORD for guidance (Exodus 28:6-15, 28-30).

Here are some ways to translate this term:

- Transliterate the Hebrew term ephod. The BSB and many other versions do not add any details that describe the ephod or its intended function.
- Translate a brief description of an ephod along with its function. For example:

without any embroidered garment that has objects to use to get answers from the LORD.

- Translate the function of an ephod or the High Priest in obtaining guidance from the LORD. For example:

without anything to use to contact the LORD

without a High Priest to ask the LORD for guidance

With any of these options, consider adding a footnote that gives more information. Here is a suggested footnote:

In Hebrew, the word ephod refers here to an embroidered vest/garment that the High Priest wore. In a pocket/pouch attached to this garment were two small objects called Urim and Thummim. (Exodus 28:6-15, 28-30). He used them to find out what the LORD wanted the nation of Israel to do.

idol: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as idol is literally “teraphim.” It refers to small household idols that represented pagan gods or the spirits of dead ancestors. The people consulted them for guidance. Davies (page 104) says that these idols represented either “household gods or the spirits of dead ancestors.” Hubbard (page 94) says they were “small figures of deities thought to grant protection and guidance.”

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

- Transliterate the Hebrew term teraphim, as in the REB.
- Translate a brief description of teraphim. For example:

family idols (GW)

household gods (ESV)

Hosea 3:5

Section 3:1–5: Hosea redeemed Gomer as the LORD will redeem Israel

In this section, the LORD commanded Hosea to take Gomer back as his wife. This probably occurred later in their marriage after Gomer had left Hosea and became an adulteress. There are two main views about how the events of chapters 1 and 2 relate to those of chapter 3. One view is that the events described in chapter 3 follow those described in chapters 1 and 2. (This is the view taken by this Translators Notes publication.) Another view is that in chapter 3, Hosea is describing most of the same events but from a different perspective and for a different purpose. Once more Hosea communicated the LORD's message by his action as well as his words. His action was an illustration of the LORD's unfailing love for the nation of Israel. Israel had been unfaithful to the LORD and had been worshiping other gods. In the same way, Gomer had been unfaithful to Hosea and had left him for other lovers. And just as Hosea was commanded to take Gomer back as his wife, so the LORD planned to restore Israel to himself.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

An Illustration of God's Love for Idolatrous Israel (NET)

Hosea Redeems His Wife (ESV)

Hosea's Reconciliation With His Wife (NIV)

Paragraph 3:4–5

In this paragraph, Hosea's words predicted that the LORD will judge/punish the nation of Israel (3:4). But after the LORD punishes them, they will seek him again (3:5).

Verse 4 gives details of the LORD's punishment. He will punish Israel by keeping them from having three things: its own government, worship, and supernatural

guidance. These things are arranged in three pairs. In Hebrew, the first five items in these pairs are introduced with a negative existential "there is no/not" ("without" in English versions): Lange (page 47) and Davies (page 103) think that both "ephod" and "idols" may have represented idols that were used in pagan worship. McComiskey (page 53) says that Hosea may have omitted the word "without" before "idols" to indicate that Israel's syncretistic religion was actually totally pagan. Macintosh (pages 106–107) also comments on the close association of these two terms, but concludes that the Israelites used the ephod in the context of the idolatrous cult to consult Yahweh. Wood (page 138) and Pusey (page 43) both make a distinction between the ephod, used by the high priest to consult Yahweh, and the idols (teraphim) used to consult pagan deities. Hubbard (page 93) also associates the ephod with the high priestly garment that contained the Urim and Thummim used to obtain guidance from Yahweh. Of the English versions used in TN, only the NJPS and KJV follow the Hebrew repetition of the word "without."

^{4a} without king and without prince

^{4b} without sacrifice and without pillar

^{4c} without ephod and idols

3:5a

Afterward, the people of Israel will return and seek the LORD their God and David their king.

- When that time has ended, the Israelites will again turn to Yahweh who is their God and to a descendant of David their king.
- But afterwards, the people of Israel will repent of their idolatry and they will again worship/serve Yahweh their God. They will also worship/serve a descendant of David their king.

Afterward: This word refers to a future time after the "many days" referred to in 3:4a.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

But the time will come when... (GNT)

But later (CEV)

the people of Israel will return and seek the LORD their God: In Hebrew, the phrase return and seek is literally "will turn...and will seek." This combination of

phrases probably means “they will again seek.” Macintosh (page 108) and Andersen and Freedman pages (306–307). It means that they will turn their hearts again to the LORD in order to follow or worship him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

will once again turn to the Lord their God (GNT)

will return to the Lord their God and follow him (NCV)

will again worship and serve the LORD their God

Be careful not to translate seek in a way that implies that God is lost and they are not able to find him.

and David their king: This phrase does not refer to David himself, but to one of David’s descendants. This descendant would be king over a united Israel and Judah as David was. Stuart (page 68). In many languages, it will be helpful to make explicit that this phrase refers to a descendant of David. For example:

and to a descendant of David their king (GNT)

3:5b

They will come trembling to the LORD and to His goodness in the last days.

- At that future time, they will feel/have awe/reverence for Yahweh, and he will bless them with good gifts.
- They will tremble with fear and respect for Yahweh, and he will be good to them.

They will come trembling to the LORD: In Hebrew, this clause means here that the people will feel awe and reverence for the LORD. Andersen and Freedman (page 308) understand this term to refer to “admiration and appreciation,” and Davies (page 105) defines it as “thankful exhilaration.” Their comments support the NJPS rendering “they will thrill over the Lord.” However, TWOT, NIDOTTE, McComiskey, Macintosh, Hubbard, Lange, and Pusey all support the renderings found in every other English version used in TN. These versions all use words or phrases that emphasize fear, trembling, awe, and reverence.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they will tremble in awe of the Lord (NLT)

turn with reverence to the Lord (REB)

they will submit to the Lord in fear (NET)

and to His goodness: This probably refers to the good things that the LORD promised to give the Israelites when they returned to him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and he will be good to them (CEV)

and will receive his good gifts (GNT)

and he will bless them (NCV)

in the last days: This phrase is parallel to the word “Afterward” in 3:5a. It probably refers to an indefinite time in the future when the LORD has finished judging the people of Israel. Andersen and Freedman (page 309) and Hubbard (page 95). It probably does not refer here to the time at the end of the world.

Here are some different ways to express this period of time:

in the days to come (NJPS)

in the future (NET)

General Comment on 3:5a–b

The word “Afterward” in 3:5a and the phrase “in the last days” in 3:5b are parallel. In some languages, it may be more natural to make explicit that these time phrases refer to the same period of time. For example:

But the time will come...Then (GNT)

But later...At that time (CEV)

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these phrases into one phrase. For example:

But when that time has ended, the Israelites will turn again to the LORD their God...They will tremble with awe...

In Division 1:2–3:5, Hosea’s relationship with his unfaithful wife, Gomer, was used as an illustration of the relationship between the LORD and Israel. In Division 4:1–10:15, Israel’s spiritual unfaithfulness continues to be described figuratively as prostitution. But the rela-

relationship between Hosea and Gomer is not mentioned again. These chapters describe the LORD's response to his people's unfaithfulness. The LORD condemned Israel and announced his plans to punish them. He also expressed his disappointment at their refusal to repent.

Hosea 4:1

Section 4:1–3: The LORD brought a charge against the people of Israel

The words “Hear the word of the LORD” in 4:1 indicate the beginning of a new prophecy. In 4:1–3, the LORD brought an accusation or charge against the people of Israel. The charge consisted of three parts. First, the LORD stated their crimes (4:1). Second, he presented the evidence of their crimes (4:2). Third, he announced the resulting judgment (4:3). The charge serves as a general introduction to the messages that follow in the remainder of chapter 4.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord's Legal Case Against Israel (GW)

The Lord Accuses Israel (ESV)

4:1a

Hear the word of the LORD, O children of Israel,

- ¶ People of Israel, hear these words from Yahweh,
- ¶ You^(plur) Israelites, listen to what Yahweh has to say!

Hear the word of the LORD: In the Old Testament, this command was a standard way to introduce a prophetic message or warning of judgment. It emphasized that the message that followed was important because it was from the LORD. Hosea told the message to the people, but the LORD was the source of the message.

Here is another way to translate this command:

hear what Yahweh says (NJB)

O children of Israel: See the note on “the Israelites” in 3:1c. The same phrase also occurs in 3:4a. Hosea used this phrase here to address the Israelites directly.

Here is another way to translate this vocative:

O people of Israel (NRSV)

Use a term of address (vocative) that is natural in your language when a person speaks to a group of people.

4:1b

for the LORD has a case against the people of the land:

- because he has a serious accusation/charge to make against you^(plur) who live in this land/country:
- Yahweh/He has accused all of you who live here in the land of Israel.

for the LORD has a case against the people of the land:

In Hebrew, the word *for* probably introduces the reason or motivation for the Israelites to listen carefully to the LORD's message. According to McComiskey (page 56), Macintosh (page 56), and Wood (page 184), the Hebrew word *ki* here introduces the reason for the command to listen. Keil's translation (page 50) supports this view. Follingstad disagrees with this traditional causal interpretation of *ki*. According to his analysis in *Deictic Viewpoint of Biblical Hebrew Text* (on TW), which focuses on passages that are not analogous to Hosea and does not comment on this or other passages in Hosea, the primary function of *ki* is to shift the listener's viewpoint to the content of the following proposition. However, Follingstad admits that “there often is a causal connection between the semantic contents of the clauses” (10.2.3). For example:

Israel, hear the word of the LORD; for the Lord has a charge to bring against the inhabitants of the land: (REB)

Hear the word of the LORD, O people of Israel; for the Lord has an indictment against the inhabitants of the land. (NRSV)

Some versions leave this connection implied. For example:

Listen to the word of the LORD, you Israelites. The Lord has brought these charges against those who live in the land: (GW)

Use a natural way in your language to translate the relationship between 4:1a and 4:1b.

for the LORD has a case against the people of the land: This statement indicates that the LORD was making a very serious accusation against the people of Israel.

case: This is the same word that the BSB translated as “rebuke” in 2:2. In Hebrew, it means “to fight with words,” as in a quarrel or a legal case.

Some English versions use an expression that refers to an actual trial. For example:

The Lord has filed a lawsuit against you (NLT96)

But this verse may also refer to an informal accusation, so it is better to use a more general expression. For example:

The Lord has an accusation to bring against the people who live in this land. The GNT translation could refer either to a legal accusation as part of a court case or to a non-trial setting. (GNT)

the people of the land: This phrase refers to the inhabitants of the land of Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

citizens of the country (NJB)

you (NLT)

The NLT probably left the rest of the phrase implied because it is clear from both the preceding and following context.

General Comment on 4:1a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder these two clauses. For example:

^{1b}The Lord has an accusation to bring against the people who live in this land. ^{1a}Listen, Israel, to what he says: (GNT)

4:1c–d

There is no truth, no loving devotion, and no knowledge of God in the land: In 4:1c–d, the LORD stated his charge. The people of Israel were guilty of these three crimes.

In some languages, it may be more natural to make explicit a human subject here. For example:

No one is faithful or loyal or truly cares about God. (CEV)

4:1c

“There is no truth, no loving devotion,

- “There is not one faithful/dependable person here, no one who shows love,

- This is what he says: “In this entire nation, none of you Israelites are trustworthy in your dealings with your fellowmen. You^(plur) have no kindness or love for others

There is no truth, no loving devotion: In Hebrew and in most versions, the object of no truth and no loving devotion is left implied. Two possible objects are other people and God:

- There is no truth and no love towards other people.
- There is no truth and no love towards God.

If possible, you should translate in a way that allows either or both objects to be understood. If you need to make an object explicit in your language, it is recommended that you specify other people. Macintosh (page 127). This better fits the context of 4:2 that lists cursing, lying, murder, stealing, and adultery. These are sins that the people committed against other people. Hubbard (page 97).

truth: In Hebrew, this word describes a person who is honest and dependable in what he says and does. Some languages may have a single expression that has these meanings. In other languages, it may be appropriate to use more than one expression.

Here are some other ways to translate the statement “There is no truth”:

No one is faithful (CEV)

There are no trustworthy people

No one tells the truth or can be trusted

loving devotion: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as loving devotion has several aspects of meaning:

1. steadfastness, loyalty
2. love
3. kindness, mercy

A number of versions translate one aspect of the meaning. For example:

love (GNT)

loyalty (NET)

kindness (NLT)

Some versions have two aspects. For example:

faithful love (NJB)

steadfast love (ESV)

In some languages, it may be possible to express all three aspects. For example:

consistent/unchanging love and kindness

Translate this term in a way that fits naturally in the context. Here it may refer particularly to showing a concern for the needs of others. The LORD's covenant with Israel required them to have this concern in response to the love that the LORD had shown to them. Hubbard (page 97). TWOT (#698a) says God was obviously in a covenant relationship with Israel, and he expressed this relationship in eternal *hesed*, but *hesed* does not necessarily involve a covenant nor does it mean loyalty to a covenant. Rather, it is a kind of love, including mercy, close to the KJV rendering "lovingkindness." Vine (page 142) insists that three basic meanings of the word always interact: kindness, steadfastness, and love. He says that *hesed* is not only a matter of obligation within a relationship; it is also generosity. It is not only a matter of loyalty, but also of mercy.

4:1d

and no knowledge of God in the land!

- no one who knows and obeys God anywhere in your^(plur) land/country.
- and no one knows me or acknowledges my authority as God.

no knowledge of God: The phrase knowledge of God means that a person knows God and has a relationship with him. He also knows who God is and what God wants his people to do. It is implied that a person who knows God will obey him. He will acknowledge God's authority by his actions.

In verses such as 2:20b, there is a difference of interpretation between "know" and "acknowledge." Here (4:1d), both senses fit the context. Most English versions choose one sense or the other. For example:

no knowledge of God (ESV)

people do not acknowledge me as God (GNT)

If possible, translate in a way that allows or includes both senses of meaning. See the meaning lines in the Display for 4:1d for two examples.

God: The Hebrew word here is *ʾelohim* and not *Yahweh*. Versions indicate this by translating this word as *God* and not as "LORD."

in the land: This phrase also occurs in 4:1b. In some languages, it may be natural to translate this phrase explicitly both here and in 4:1b, as in the BSB. In other languages, it may be better to translate this phrase explicitly in only one of these places. For example, the CEV makes this phrase explicit only in 4:1b:

^{1b}the Lord accuses everyone in the land! ^{1c}No one is faithful or loyal ^{1d}or truly cares about God. (CEV)

The NLT makes this phrase explicit only in 4:1d:

^{1b}The Lord has brought charges against you,
^{1c}saying: There is no faithfulness, no kindness,
^{1d}no knowledge of God in your land. (NLT)

With any of these options, make sure that the meaning is clear in the context.

Hosea 4:2

Section 4:1–3: The LORD brought a charge against the people of Israel

The words "Hear the word of the LORD" in 4:1 indicate the beginning of a new prophecy. In 4:1–3, the LORD brought an accusation or charge against the people of Israel. The charge consisted of three parts. First, the LORD stated their crimes (4:1). Second, he presented the evidence of their crimes (4:2). Third, he announced the resulting judgment (4:3). The charge serves as a general introduction to the messages that follow in the remainder of chapter 4.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord's Legal Case Against Israel (GW)

The Lord Accuses Israel (ESV)

4:2a–b

Cursing and lying, murder and stealing, and adultery: These are five specific examples of the sins that the people had committed. These five sins are forbidden in the Ten Commandments. If you already translated the Ten Commandments in a different book of the Bible, you should translate these five sins in a similar way here.

The statement in 4:2a–b indicates that people frequently committed sins like these. It does not indicate that people committed only these sins.

Here are some other ways to translate this statement:

You curse and lie and kill and steal and commit adultery. (NLT96)

There is cursing, lying, murdering, stealing, and adultery. (GW)

Cursing, dishonesty, murder, robbery, unfaithfulness—these happen all the time. (CEV)

4:2a

Cursing and lying, murder

- People curse, lie, kill,
- All you^(plur) do is curse other people, deceive them, and commit murder.

Cursing: The commandment against cursing is in Exodus 20:7 and Deuteronomy 5:11. Here Cursing probably means to put curses on people using God's name as part of the curse. It does not mean to use profane or vulgar words, a common meaning of "cursing" in English.

Some English versions use expressions that refer to making a false promise. For example, the GNT has: "make promises and break them." The NJB has: "perjury." But making a false promise is also a type of lying. Since lying is the next sin listed in this verse, you should translate "cursing" in a way that clearly shows the difference between it and lying. According to Macintosh (page 129), the word "cursing" is one in a series of five distinct terms. It should not be understood in combination with "lying." It does not mean that "oaths are imposed and broken." In this context it means "to invoke a curse upon someone from God. When a person invokes such curses improperly, he makes wrongful use of God's name. (Exodus 20:7).

lying: The commandment against lying is in Exodus 20:16 and Deuteronomy 5:20. Here lying means to be dishonest in ways that are harmful to other people. This meaning includes deceiving people in order to cheat them and giving false testimony in a legal case.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

dishonesty (CEV)

deception (NASB)

murder: The commandment against murder is in Exodus 20:13 and Deuteronomy 5:17. In this context, murder refers to killing a person illegally. It does not refer to executing a criminal or killing an enemy soldier in battle. The word can refer to killing a person either intentionally or accidentally.

4:2b

and stealing, and adultery

- steal, and commit adultery.
- You^(plur) steal and have sexual relations with people who are not your spouse.

stealing: The commandment against stealing is in Exodus 20:15 and Deuteronomy 5:19.

adultery: The commandment against adultery is in Exodus 20:14 and Deuteronomy 5:18.

4:2c

are rampant;

- There is no limit to their many sins.
- You^(plur) commit more and more crimes everywhere.

are rampant: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as are rampant is literally "they have broken out." It refers figuratively here to breaking through "moral barriers and restraints." NET footnote (a) on 4:1.

There are two main ways to interpret the meaning of the verb and what it refers to:

1. The verb means that the five sins listed in 4:2a–b have greatly increased. It implies that people commit these sins everywhere in the land. For example:

Swearing, lying, and murder, and stealing and adultery break out (NRSV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NAB, NCV, NIV, NJPS, NRSV) The ESV and NIV have been listed here because the punctuation, with a semicolon after the first five sins, points to the first interpretation. In normal English usage, the pronoun "they" would refer to the preceding sins. There is no other referent. The GNT, NJPS, and CEV have been listed here, because they refer generically to the five sins or crimes just mentioned, some of which are not violent.

1. The verb means that violence has greatly increased. It implies that people commit violent crimes everywhere in the land. HALOT (#7754, sense #6a, c). Of the versions listed here in support of the second interpretation, only the NLT makes explicit the idea of violence increasing or spreading everywhere. The others merely mention violence without further detail. For example, the REB has: "there is violence." For example:

You make vows and break them; you kill and steal and commit adultery. There is violence everywhere— (NLT) (NASB, NET, NJB, NLT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most English versions. Some commentaries (e.g., Davies and Hubbard) simply give alternatives. See Macintosh (pages 129–130) for arguments in favor of the first interpretation based on the five infinitive absolutes (also mentioned by Wood). His translation speaks of the five sins that “inundate [the land].”

Here is another way to translate 4:2a–c:

Cursing, lying, killing, stealing and adultery are everywhere. (NCV)

In some languages, it may be more natural to use a general term for the five sins. For example:

crimes increase (GNT)

People break my laws (GW)

4:2d

one act of bloodshed follows another.

- One murder follows another. (NCV)
- You^(plur) never stop wounding and killing other people.

one act of bloodshed follows another: This clause is a continuation of interpretation (1) in 4:2c. It focuses on repeated crimes that involve bloodshed in addition to the five sins that “are rampant” (4:2a–c). It means that murders and similar bloody crimes occur one after another.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and there is one murder after another (GNT)

One murder follows another. (NCV)

Most versions that follow this interpretation translate this clause with a word such as bloodshed or “murder,” a specific kind of bloodshed. If your language has an expression that refers to bloody crimes in general, you may want to use it here.

Hosea 4:3

Section 4:1–3: The LORD brought a charge against the people of Israel

The words “Hear the word of the LORD” in 4:1 indicate the beginning of a new prophecy. In 4:1–3, the LORD brought an accusation or charge against the people of Israel. The charge consisted of three parts. First, the LORD stated their crimes (4:1). Second, he presented the evidence of their crimes (4:2). Third, he announced the resulting judgment (4:3). The charge serves as a general introduction to the messages that follow in the remainder of chapter 4.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord’s Legal Case Against Israel (GW)

The Lord Accuses Israel (ESV)

4:3a

Therefore the land mourns,

- Because of all these wicked things that they have done, the land will experience/undergo drought,
- And so a terrible drought will soon make the land/ground groan with thirst. It will become dry and barren.

Therefore: In Hebrew, this phrase introduces the result of something that was said previously. The meaning here is that because of all the sins mentioned in 4:1–2, the land mourns.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

And so (GNT)

This is why (NJB)

Therefore (NASB)

the land mourns: There are two ways to interpret this clause:

1. The land of Israel is undergoing drought. The word land is literal and refers to the land of Israel. The word “mourn” is figurative and refers to drought. For example:

And so the land will dry up (GNT) (CEV, GNT, GW, NCV, NJPS, REB)

1. The people of Israel are mourning. The word land is figurative and refers to the people living in the land of Israel. The word “mourn” is literal and refers to people mourning. For example:

This is why the country is in mourning. Here the term “country is in mourning” is assumed to refer to the people of the country. (NJB) (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. It better fits the following context that describes animals dying. Drought is a logical cause of their death.

The Hebrew form of the verb “mourn” (the imperfect) can indicate either present or future. So there are two ways to interpret this verse:

1. It refers to the future. This is an announcement of future judgment. The imperfect tense indicates that the mourning had not yet begun. For example:

And so the land will dry up (GNT) (GNT, NET, REB)

1. It refers to the present. The imperfect tense indicates that the mourning was already occurring at that time. For example:

Therefore the land mourns (NRSV) (BSB, GW, NCV, NIV, NJB, The NJB translates “mourns” as present tense but translates the final verb in the sentence as future, “the fish in the sea will disappear.” NLT, NRSV)

The majority of versions use present tense here. However, interpretation (1) is recommended. This interpretation is supported by the occurrence of the same pattern elsewhere. For example, in Amos 3:2 as well as here, the word “therefore” is followed by an imperfect tense verb. In the Amos passage it is clear that the reference is to future judgment. Wood (page 184) supports a present judgment. Davies (page 116–117), McComiskey (page 58), Andersen and Freedman (page 340), and Macintosh (page 132–133) support the idea of a future judgment, though Andersen and Freedman do not exclude the idea of an actual drought.

In some languages, the verbs have either past or nonpast tense. Nonpast verbs refer to either present or future, as in Hebrew. If that is true in your language, a nonpast verb would be appropriate here.

4:3b

and all who dwell in it will waste away

- and everything that lives here will die.
- Nothing will survive/live,

and all who dwell in it will waste away: In Hebrew, a preposition that is attached to each group of animals in 4:3c indicates that all the animals will waste away along with the people. Van der Merwe (Biblical Hebrew Reference Grammar, 39.6 3iii beth comitantiae) and Waltke and O'Connor (Introduction to Biblical Hebrew Syntax. “The Subordination of Nouns to the Verb by means of Prepositions,” page 119). English versions make this clear in different ways:

- Use a word or phrase such as “with,” “together with,” or “even.” The BSB and others do this. For example:

all who live in it languish; together with the wild animals... (NRSV)

...everyone is wasting away. Even the wild animals...are disappearing. (NLT)

- Use the same word, such as “die” for both people and animals. For example:

...everything that lives on it will die. All the animals...will die. (GNT)

- Combine the terms in 4:3b–c. For example:

Every living creature is dying—people and wild animals, birds and fish. (CEV)

Use a natural way in your language to make it clear that both people and animals are included in this judgment.

waste away: Versions translate this term in two main ways:

- To become weak and exhausted. This is the literal meaning of the term. For example:

will languish (REB)

- To die. This Hebrew term probably refers to weakness that results in death. TWOT (#140) and Macintosh (page 133). Some versions make this result explicit. For example:

will die (GNT)

Either option is acceptable.

4:3c

with the beasts of the field and the birds of the air; even the fish of the sea disappear.

- The wild animals, the birds, and even the fish will disappear/die.”
- not animals, not birds, not even the fish.”

with the beasts of the field and the birds of the air; even the fish of the sea disappear: These three types of animals, beasts, birds, and fish, are listed together to emphasize the animals that live in the three large regions of the earth—the land, the air, and the water. Andersen and Freedman (pages 340–341). This list of three types of animals is probably a figure of speech (synecdoche) that represents all animals.

the beasts of the field: This phrase usually refers to untamed animals. However, in this context, it may refer to all animals that live on the land.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

wild animals (NJB)

animals (GNT)

the birds of the air: As in 2:18a the phrase of the air may be redundant. So some English versions leave the words of the air implied. For example:

birds (GW)

the fish of the sea: In Hebrew, a word that some versions translate as “even” precedes the phrase fish of the sea. This word emphasizes the great extent of the drought. It will be so severe that even bodies of water will dry up. As a result, the fish in them will die. Some versions do not include this emphasis. Others do include it. For example:

even the fish in the sea will perish. (NET)

It is recommended that you include this emphasis in your translation.

The Hebrew word translated as sea sometimes refers to the Mediterranean Sea, which forms the western boundary of the land of Israel. However, it can also refer to rivers and lakes as well as the sea. Here it probably means that the drought will affect the fish that live in the rivers and lakes within the land of Israel. Macintosh (page 133).

In English, the words of the sea are redundant, because the word fish implies this idea. So some English versions leave the words of the sea implied. For example:

fish (CEV)

disappear: In Hebrew, the word that the BSB translates as disappear can mean to perish or be removed. BART interlinear.

Here is another way to translate it:

and the fish of the sea are dying (NIV)

In this verse, “to die” or disappear are different ways of saying the same thing. The way in which the animals disappear is through death. Use a natural expression in your language to translate the idea of death in this context.

Hosea 4:4

Section 4:4–11a: The Sinful Priests

In this section, the LORD promised to punish the priests more severely than anyone else, because they were the ones who led the people to worship false gods.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Accuses the Priests (GNT)

Against the Priests (NJB)

Paragraph 4:4–6

In this paragraph, the LORD, speaking through Hosea, told the people not to blame one another, because the priests were responsible for leading the people astray.

4:4a

But let no man contend; let no man offer reproof;

- ¶ “But none of you^(plur) should blame your fellow people! Do not say that this person or that person is guilty,
- ¶ Yahweh also says, “Nevertheless, do not accuse one another.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

“But let no man **contend**;

let no man **offer reproof**,

In these lines the LORD tells the people not to blame one another for the sins that will result in his judgment.

But: This word introduces an unexpected response to what was said previously. The LORD said in 4:1–3 that the people had committed terrible sins and that everything living in the land of Israel would undergo judgment. It would be reasonable to expect the LORD to blame the people. But instead, he gave a command not to blame them.

Here is another way to introduce this unexpected response:

Don't accuse just anyone! Not everyone is at fault.
(CEV)

Use a natural way in your language to emphasize that this response was unexpected.

contend...offer reproof: The Hebrew word translated contend is the verb form of the noun translated “case” in 4:1b. See the note on that verse. The meaning is similar here. The words offer reproof are a synonym of contend.

In some languages, it may be helpful to make explicit that the LORD is giving the command. For example:

The Lord says, “Let no one accuse the people or reprimand them (GNT)

General Comment on 4:4a

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine these parallel parts into one line. For example:

“But don't blame other people!

“No one should accuse or blame another person.
(NCV)

4:4b

for your people are like those who contend with a priest.

- because I am charging you^(plur) priests with these crimes!
- You, the priests, are the ones I consider to be responsible/guilty!

The ESV has been used as the source line for 4:4b, because it follows the recommended textual option.

for: This word introduces the reason for the LORD's command in 4:4a that the people should not accuse

one another. The reason was that the LORD blamed the priests rather than the people. Some versions express this relationship explicitly. For example:

don't accuse each other, because it is the priests who are the guilty ones

Other versions leave the relationship implied. For example:

No one should accuse other people or bring charges against them. My case is against you priests. (GW)

Use a natural way in your language to introduce the reason that the people were not to blame one another.

(ESV) with you is my contention, O priest: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some scholars think that the original text was “against you is my charge, O priest.” See Andersen and Freedman (pages 346–350). This option requires no change to the ancient Hebrew consonantal text. The only change that is needed is to repoint the vowels that the Masoretes inserted in the Masoretic Text. The BHS editors favor this change, but HOTP prefers the MT. The LORD blamed the priest or priests instead of the people. For example:

my complaint is against you priests (GNT) (CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NAB, NET, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The Masoretic Text has “your people are like those who bring charges against a priest.” The LORD placed blame on the people as a group, because they rebelled against the priest (as in Deuteronomy 17:12–13). For example:

your people are like those who contend with a priest (BSB) (BSB, KJV, NASB, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and many commentaries. Stuart (page 70), Andersen and Freedman (page 342), Macintosh (page 134), and Dearman (page 157). This option offers a logical reason for the “But” in 4:4a. It also makes good sense in the context of 4:6, where the LORD then rejected the priest.

(ESV) contention: See the note on 4:1b where the same Hebrew word is used.

(ESV) priest: In Hebrew, the word priest is singular here and in 4:6. However, in 4:7 and 4:8, Hebrew uses plural forms for the same referent. So versions translate priest in two ways:

- As plural priests. The plural form makes explicit that the LORD is speaking to the priests as a group rather than to just one priest. For example:

my complaint is against you priests (GNT)

- As singular priest. The singular form does not make explicit whether the LORD is speaking to just one priest or to priests as a group. The singular form can mean either. For example:

it is you, priest, that I denounce (NJB)

Use a natural way in your language to indicate the LORD is speaking to priests as a group.

Hosea 4:5

Section 4:4–11a: The Sinful Priests

In this section, the LORD promised to punish the priests more severely than anyone else, because they were the ones who led the people to worship false gods.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Accuses the Priests (GNT)

Against the Priests (NJB)

Paragraph 4:4–6

In this paragraph, the LORD, speaking through Hosea, told the people not to blame one another, because the priests were responsible for leading the people astray.

4:5a

You will stumble by day, and the prophet will stumble with you by night;

- Day and night I will punish you. You will be like people who stumble and fall, and the prophets will stumble and fall with you^(plur).
- Throughout the day and the night I will punish/destroy you^(plur) along with the false prophets.

You will stumble: The word stumble is used here as a figure of speech (metaphor). There are two ways to interpret the meaning of this metaphor:

1. stumble refers to punishment. The LORD will destroy the priests and prophets. Their punishment is

compared to stumbling and falling. Hubbard (page 100), Keil (page 77), Andersen and Freedman (page 351), Stuart (page 77), and Macintosh (page 137). For example:

As a sentence for your crimes, you will stumble in broad daylight, just as you might at night, and so will your false prophets. (NLT96) (BSB, CEV, ESV, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NLT96, NRSV)

1. stumble refers to sin. The priests and prophets figuratively stumble by failing to teach the people correctly. Wood (page 185). For example:

Night and day you blunder on, and the prophets do no better than you. (GNT) (GNT, GW, NET, NIV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. Some versions that use the word “stumble” have been listed under interpretation (1), others under interpretation (2). If a version uses the future tense “will/shall stumble” (e.g., BSB, CEV, ESV, NJB, RSV) or specifies a future consequence of sin by using the word “so,” (e.g., NASB, NJPS), it has been listed under interpretation (1). If a version uses the present tense (e.g., GW, NET, NIV), it has been listed under interpretation (2). and commentaries.

The figurative meaning of stumble is that the priests and prophets will be punished by the LORD. Specifically, they will be destroyed.

If the metaphor of stumbling does not clearly express this meaning in your translation, here are some other ways to translate it:

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make it explicit that stumble refers to punishment. For example:

I will punish you day and night. You will be like a person who stumbles and falls.

- Omit the figure of stumbling, and translate the meaning directly. For example:

You will be ruined in the day, and your prophets will be ruined with you in the night. (NCV)

by day...by night: In this context, the contrasting words day and night are probably a figure of speech that means “all the time.” The time includes the night, when people might be expected to stumble, and also

the day when people should be able to see. Keil (page 77) and Hubbard (page 100).

the prophet: In Hebrew, the word prophet is singular. However, it follows the same pattern as “priest” in 4:4b. Use a natural way in your language to indicate the LORD is speaking to prophets as a group.

The context of judgment suggests that these are false prophets. Some versions make this explicit. For example:

your false prophets (NLT)

4:5b

so I will destroy your mother—

- And I will destroy Israel your^(plur) mother.
- I will also destroy your mother, the nation of Israel.

so: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as so:

1. It introduces another group of people that will be punished by the LORD. The LORD will cause the priests and prophets to stumble (punishment). In addition to that, he will destroy their mother. For example:

and I will destroy... (ESV) (ESV, KJV, NASB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV) Versions that are not listed under either interpretation leave the connection implied.

1. It introduces a result. The priests and prophets will stumble (sin), so the LORD will punish their mother. For example:

So I will destroy... (NIV, BSB) (GW, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. This interpretation fits the recommended interpretation in 4:5a.

I will destroy your mother: The phrase your mother is a figure of speech that represents the entire nation of Israel. Lange (page 52) and Wood (page 185). See the note on 2:2a.

Some versions make the meaning explicit. For example:

I am going to destroy Israel, your mother. (GNT)

Some versions explain the meaning in a footnote. For example:

Here “mother” refers to the nation of Israel. (NCV footnote)

These are both good options to help your readers better understand the meaning.

Hosea 4:6

Section 4:4–11a: The Sinful Priests

In this section, the LORD promised to punish the priests more severely than anyone else, because they were the ones who led the people to worship false gods.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Accuses the Priests (GNT)

Against the Priests (NJB)

Paragraph 4:4–6

In this paragraph, the LORD, speaking through Hosea, told the people not to blame one another, because the priests were responsible for leading the people astray.

4:6a

My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge.

- Yes, my people are already being destroyed, because they do not know and obey me.
- My people do not know me or acknowledge my authority as God, so their destruction is certain.
- I will certainly destroy my people, because they do not know me. They also refuse to obey me.

My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge:

This verse part gives the reason for the words “I will destroy your mother” in 4:5b. It explains that the nation of Israel will be destroyed because of their lack of knowledge.

This is a passive clause. In some languages, you may need to use an active verb and supply the implied subject. For example:

I will destroy them because of their lack of knowledge.

are destroyed: In Hebrew, the form of this verb indicates that destruction will certainly occur. Some versions, such as the BSB, express this certainty by using present tense, as if the destruction has already begun. For example:

My people perish (NJB)

Other versions use future tense. For example:

will be destroyed (NCV)

Use a natural way in your language to indicate that the nation of Israel will certainly be destroyed.

for lack of knowledge: The phrase lack of knowledge has a similar meaning to “no knowledge” in 4:1d (see the note there). It indicates that the people do not know God. They also refuse to obey him. They do not show by their actions that they acknowledge his authority.

for: This word introduces the cause of the people’s destruction. They are destroyed because of their lack of knowledge of God.

Here are some other ways to translate this relationship:

because they do not acknowledge me (GNT)

by refusing to obey (CEV)

General Comment on 4:6a

In some languages, it will be more natural to put the cause of destruction in the first part of the clause. For example:

Since my people do not know or obey me, they will certainly be destroyed.

4:6b–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{6b} Because you have rejected knowledge, **I will also reject you as my priests;**

^{6c} Since you have forgotten the law of your God, **I will also forget your children.**

In these lines, the LORD told the priests that he will no longer allow them or their descendants to serve as his priests.

4:6b

Because you have rejected knowledge, I will also reject you as My priests.

- Because you^(plur) refuse to know and obey me, I refuse to allow you to be my priests.
- Since you priests have rejected me and my commands, I, Yahweh, now reject you as my priests.

- As for you priests, I will not allow you to serve me any longer, because you do not know me and you refuse to acknowledge my authority as God.

Because: This word introduces the reason that the LORD will reject the priests. He rejects them because they have rejected knowledge.

you have rejected knowledge, I will also reject: The repetition of the word reject emphasizes that the LORD’s response matches the priest’s offense. The REB further highlights this equality by using the words “as” and “so.” As the priests rejected, so the LORD will reject.

As you have rejected knowledge,

so will I reject you as a priest to me.

rejected knowledge: The meaning of rejected knowledge here is similar to 4:1d and 4:6a. See how you translated the similar phrases in those verses.

I will also reject you as My priests: This statement means that the LORD will take away their status as his priests. He will not allow them to serve in that role.

Here are some other ways to translate this statement:

I shall reject you from my priesthood (NJB)

I will refuse to let you be my priests (GW)

you: Most scholars understand the word you here to be the priests who were first mentioned in 4:4b. Some scholars such as Lange (page 52) and Keil (page 78) suggest that “you” refers to the whole nation of Israel as a kingdom of priests. This interpretation is unlikely, since up to this point in this section the LORD has addressed the priests, and the pronoun “you” has consistently referred to the priests. Most other commentators understand “you” to refer to the priests. For example, see Wood (pages 185–186), Stuart (page 78), Macintosh (page 139), and Andersen and Freedman (page 353). Some versions make the pronoun referent explicit. For example:

You priests have refused to acknowledge me (GNT)

In Hebrew, the pronoun you is singular. However, it probably refers to priests as a group, as in 4:4b. See the note there.

General Comment on 4:6b

In some languages, it is more natural to put the statement of rejection before the reason. For example:

I reject you from being my priests, because you have rejected knowledge of me.

4:6c

Since you have forgotten the law of your God, I will also forget your children.

- Because you^(plur) have refused to follow the law of your God, I will also refuse to let your children serve me as priests after you.
- Since you priests have rejected my teachings/laws, I, Yahweh, will reject your sons as my future priests.
- I will also not allow your sons/descendants to serve as my priests, because you refuse to obey what I have taught you.

Since: The word that the BSB translates as Since introduces the reason that the LORD will ignore the children of the priests. He ignores them because the priests have ignored God's law.

you have forgotten the law of your God, I will also forget: The repetition of the word forget emphasizes that the LORD's response matches the priest's offense. See how you translated the similar situation in 4:6b.

forgotten: Here the word forgotten means to deliberately reject the instruction of the LORD. It does not mean to forget accidentally or temporarily. According to TWOT (#2383), to forget God is similar to not knowing God. Forgetting is not simply a lapse of memory. To forget God is to ignore his commandments (Deuteronomy 8:11). To forget God is to follow other gods (Deuteronomy 8:19); to forget God is to stand in fear of harm and danger, to live fretfully and timidly (Isaiah 51:13). To forget God is to challenge him (Psalm 106:13).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

rejected (GNT)

refuse to obey (NET)

forsake (REB)

the law of your God: In Hebrew, the word law means "teaching" or "instruction." Although the word is singular it does not refer to only one law. It refers to the many instructions of the LORD.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the laws of your God (NLT)

my teaching (GNT)

the teachings of your God (NCV)

I will also forget your children: The phrase forget your children probably means that the LORD will not allow the sons of the priests to become priests. Andersen and Freedman (page 354), Macintosh (page 139), and Hubbard (page 101). Some versions make this idea explicit. For example:

I...will not acknowledge your sons as my priests (GNT)

I will reject your descendants (NET)

your children: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally "your sons." In some Old Testament contexts, the word "sons" refers to both sons and daughters. Here most versions translate this word as children. However, if your language requires you to specify the gender of the child, you should use "sons." In this context, "your sons" can only refer to male descendants, because only men could become priests.

General Comment on 4:6c

In some languages, it is more natural to put the result before the reason. For example:

I will ignore your children, because you have ignored the law of your God.

General Comment on 4:6b–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine the parallel parts in these two lines. For example:

You priests have refused to acknowledge me and have rejected my teaching, and so I reject you and will not acknowledge your sons as my priests. (GNT)

Hosea 4:7**Section 4:4–11a: The Sinful Priests**

In this section, the LORD promised to punish the priests more severely than anyone else, because they

were the ones who led the people to worship false gods.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Accuses the Priests (GNT)

Against the Priests (NJB)

Paragraph 4:7–11a

In this paragraph, the LORD gave more details about the sinful behavior of the priests (4:7–8). He then described his response to that behavior (4:9–11a).

As in chapter 2, the Hebrew pronouns alternate between “you” and “she.” In 4:4–6 the LORD used “you” when speaking to the priests, but in 4:7–10, he referred to the same priests as “they.” The BSB uses the pronoun “they.” The GNT continues to use “you.” Use a natural way in your language to refer to the priests. Be consistent throughout this paragraph. It should be clear in your translation that the LORD is speaking here to the same group of priests as in 4:4–6.

4:7a

The more they multiplied, the more they sinned against Me;

- ¶ “As the priests increased, their sins against me also increased.
- ¶ “Whenever you^(plur) priests became more numerous and more important, you also sinned more against me.

The more they multiplied, the more they sinned against Me: There is a close connection here between the priests increasing and their sins increasing.

Here are some other ways to express this connection:

Whenever the priests increased, their sins also increased.

The priests kept increasing. When that happened, they also sinned more and more.

they: The pronoun they refers to the priests.

multiplied: The word multiplied refers partly to an increase in the number of priests. Some versions make this idea explicit. For example:

The more of you priests there are, the more you sin against me (GNT)

However, the word multiplied probably also refers to an increase in their prestige and power. As their power grew, so did their sin and so did their influence to corrupt the people. Stuart (pages 78–79) and Macintosh (pages 141–142).

Here is another way to express their increase in both numbers and prestige:

The more their numbers and influence grew, the more their sins against me grew.

sinned: In Hebrew, the form of the verb sinned indicates here that the sinful behavior of the priests was habitual. Some versions, such as the BSB, use past tense to indicate this. Other versions use present tense. For example:

the more they sin against me (NLT)

Use a natural way in your language to indicate that the sinful pattern of behavior of the priests was already established.

4:7b

they exchanged their Glory for a thing of disgrace.

- I will take away their high status as my priests, and they will be humiliated/disgraced.
- So I will change your^(plur) dignity/honor into shame/disgrace.

This verse part is the result of 4:7a. The result of the priests’ increasing sinfulness is that the LORD will humiliate them. For example:

therefore will I change their glory into shame (KJV)

So I’ll turn their honor into disgrace (Voice)

Most versions leave this relationship implied.

The ESV has been used as the source line for 4:7b, because it follows the textual recommendation regarding the pronoun “I” or “they.” It also follows the recommended interpretation regarding “glory” or “Glory.” Notice that the NET and NRSV followed textual option (2), but chose interpretation (1).

(ESV) I will change their glory into shame: There is a textual issue here:

1. The Masoretic Text has “I will exchange their glory.” The MT is supported by Hubbard (page 102), Keil (page 78), Macintosh (page 141), and Pusey

(page 49). Wood (page 186) and McComiskey (page 63) follow the MT, but do not discuss the textual issue. This statement continues the pattern that was set in 4:6. The pattern is that the LORD responds to the sin of the priests with a statement of judgment. Here the LORD's judgment is that he will take away the glory of the priests and give them something disgraceful instead. (CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NJPS, REB, RSV)

2. An ancient scribal tradition has "They have exchanged their glory." According to the NET footnote on this verse, the Masoretic scribes intentionally made this change, because they believed that the received consonantal text was corrupt. This variant is also supported by Andersen and Freedman (page 355) and Stuart (page 72). This tradition is followed by the Targum and by the ancient Syriac translation. In this context, it indicates that the priests rejected their Glory (God) and accepted something disgraceful instead. (BSB, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and commentaries. The MT makes good sense and fits the overall context of the LORD's punishment of the priests.

(ESV) their glory: There are two main ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It refers to the glory or honor of the priests. It may refer to their wealth and power or to the high status they enjoyed in the eyes of the people. For example:

their dignity (NJPS)

your honor (GNT) (CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NJPS, NRSV, REB) Notice that the NRSV preferred "their" to "I" in the textual issue, but here it followed "glory" (small g). The NET also changed their preference in the interpretation issue. It has "their glorious calling."

1. It refers to God, the Glory of Israel. This is the way this phrase is understood in Psalm 106:20 and Jeremiah 2:11. For example:

their Glory (NIV)

the glory of God (NLT) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries. This interpretation better fits the context, because the

previous high status of the priests contrasts with their shameful removal from the priesthood.

(ESV) shame: In Hebrew, this word here means disgrace, humiliation, or dishonor. It is the opposite of glory and honor. TWOT (#2024a, qalon). See also BDB (#3519, page 459). It identifies sense 3 "honour, dignity of position" as being an antithesis to qalon in Hosea 4:7.

Here are some other ways to translate this whole verse part:

I will take away their honor and give them shame.
(NCV)

and so I will turn your honor into disgrace (GNT)

Hosea 4:8

Section 4:4–11a: The Sinful Priests

In this section, the LORD promised to punish the priests more severely than anyone else, because they were the ones who led the people to worship false gods.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Accuses the Priests (GNT)

Against the Priests (NJB)

Paragraph 4:7–11a

In this paragraph, the LORD gave more details about the sinful behavior of the priests (4:7–8). He then described his response to that behavior (4:9–11a).

As in chapter 2, the Hebrew pronouns alternate between "you" and "she." In 4:4–6 the LORD used "you" when speaking to the priests, but in 4:7–10, he referred to the same priests as "they." The BSB uses the pronoun "they." The GNT continues to use "you." Use a natural way in your language to refer to the priests. Be consistent throughout this paragraph. It should be clear in your translation that the LORD is speaking here to the same group of priests as in 4:4–6.

4:8a–b (combined/reordered)

- You^(plur) are greedy for my people to sin, so you can eat meat from their sin offerings until you are full.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{8a}They feed on **the sins of My people**

^{8b}and set their hearts **on iniquity**.

Line 4:8a is the reason for 4:8b. The reason that the priests set their hearts on iniquity (4:8b) is that the priests feed on their sins (4:8a). The priests wanted the sins of the people to increase, in order that they might receive a greater supply of sacrificial meat to eat. Keil (pages 78–79). Some versions make explicit that 4:8a is the reason for 4:8b. For example:

^{8a}Since the priests live off the sin offerings of the people, ^{8b}they want the people to sin more and more. (NCV)

4:8a

They feed on the sins of My people

- They eat meat from the sin offerings of my people,
- Since you^(plur) get full from eating the priest's share of the sacrifices that my people bring,

They feed on the sins of My people: In Hebrew, the word sins has a double meaning here. One meaning is sins, and a second meaning is “sin offerings.” Sin offerings were animals that the people brought to the priest to be sacrificed for sin. The laws in the book of Leviticus allowed the priests to eat a portion of these sacrificial animals. See Leviticus 6:24–30.

The double meaning of sins makes this clause a play on words. The priests were feeding on the people's sins by eating the sin offerings that the people brought. Stuart (page 79). The NLT96 translates both parts of the double meaning:

The priests get fed when the people sin and bring their sin offerings to them (NLT96)

Most versions do not include both meanings of this word play. Instead, they translate one of the meanings and leave the other meaning implied. For example:

they feed on the sin of my people (NRSV)

They feed on the sin offerings of my people (NET)

The clause may imply that the priests were eating large quantities of the meat from the sacrifices. For example:

you can stuff yourselves on their sin offerings (CEV)

It may also be a figure of speech (synecdoche) that represents a prosperous lifestyle. This idea is supported by Macintosh (pages 143–144). For example:

You grow rich from the sins of my people (GNT)

4:8b

and set their hearts on iniquity.

- so they strongly desire that the people will do wicked things.
- you^(plur) are eager for them to sin more and more.

set their hearts on iniquity: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as set their hearts is literally “they lift up their throat/appetite.” This is a Hebrew idiom that emphasizes a person's desire or greed. Hubbard (pages 102–103) says that the literal translation of “set their hearts” is ‘lift his throat’ in eagerness to swallow.’ Keil (page 78–79) defines “directed their soul” as a “longing desire.” The BART interlinear has “they lift up its desire.” In this phrase, it means that they intensely desired the people to sin against the LORD.

Some versions keep a figurative word such as “appetite” or “greed” because of the connection with eating the sin offerings (4:8a). For example:

their appetites long for their iniquity (NET)

they are greedy for their iniquity (NRSV)

Other versions translate the meaning without using a figurative term. For example:

you want them to sin more and more (GNT)

they want them to do wicked things (GW)

General Comment on 4:8a–b

In some languages, it will be more natural to put 4:8b first and the reason second. For example:

^{8b}You encourage others to sin, ^{8a}so you can stuff yourselves on their sin offerings. (CEV)

Hosea 4:9

Section 4:4–11a: The Sinful Priests

In this section, the LORD promised to punish the priests more severely than anyone else, because they were the ones who led the people to worship false gods.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Accuses the Priests (GNT)

Against the Priests (NJB)

Paragraph 4:7–11a

In this paragraph, the LORD gave more details about the sinful behavior of the priests (4:7–8). He then described his response to that behavior (4:9–11a).

As in chapter 2, the Hebrew pronouns alternate between “you” and “she.” In 4:4–6 the LORD used “you” when speaking to the priests, but in 4:7–10, he referred to the same priests as “they.” The BSB uses the pronoun “they.” The GNT continues to use “you.” Use a natural way in your language to refer to the priests. Be consistent throughout this paragraph. It should be clear in your translation that the LORD is speaking here to the same group of priests as in 4:4–6.

4:9a

And it shall be like people, like priest.

- In the future, the proverb will come true that says, ‘There will be no difference between what the priests experience and what the people experience.’
- The time is coming when the same thing will happen to the priests and the people.

And it shall be like people, like priest: This verse part focuses on the LORD’s judgment against the priests because of their sins described in 4:8. It affirms along with 4:9b that he will punish them in the future in the same way as the people. There are three main ways to interpret the connection of 4:9a with 4:8.

1. It indicates a change of topic from the sins of the priests to the LORD’s future punishment. The specific relationship with 4:8 is left implied. For example:

And it shall be like people, like priest (NRSV) (BSB, ESV, GNT, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT, NRSV)

1. Verse 4:9a gives the expected result of 4:8. It is normal to punish sins. This result is specified with a word such as “So” or “Therefore.” For example:

So the priests will be punished like the people. (GW) (CEV, GW, NJPS)

1. Verse 4:9a gives the unexpected result of 4:8. Most did not consider it normal for priests to be pun-

ished. This unexpected result is specified with the word “But.” For example:

But people and priest will fare alike. (REB) (NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. This interpretation will allow your readers to understand either of the two results in addition to the change of topic.

And it shall be: Here are some other ways to indicate the future fulfillment of this verse:

In the future,...

A time is coming when...

like people, like priest: This is a Hebrew proverb. It means that the people and the priests are alike in some way. In this context, it indicates that the LORD will judge the priests in the same way as the people.

Here are some other ways to translate this proverb:

the priests will be punished just like the people

the priests will have no advantage over the people

You will suffer the same punishment as the people! (GNT)

The GNT uses the pronoun “you” as if the LORD is speaking directly to the priests. You will need to decide whether it is more natural here to use indirect speech or direct speech in your language.

4:9b–c (combined/reordered)

- I will judge them because of the evil they have done.
- In the future, I will punish you^(plur) priests and give you what you deserve for your wicked/sinful deeds.

The ESV has been used as the source line for 4:9b, because it allows for the recommended interpretation. Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{9b} I will punish them for **their ways** (ESV)

^{9c}and repay them for **their deeds**.

The parallelism emphasizes the LORD's punishment for their sinful behavior.

4:9b

I will punish both of them for their ways

- I will punish them for their wicked way of life.
- I will show no favoritism when I judge you^(plur) priests for your sinful behavior.

them: In Hebrew, this pronoun is literally “him.” The immediately preceding referent is “priest” in 4:9a. It refers to the priests as a group. Hubbard (page 101) says the singular pronoun refers to the chief priest, but on page 103 he says that the proverb refers to the “priesthood.” Most English versions and commentaries use plural forms, regardless of the interpretation they follow. But the preceding context also mentions the people, so there are two ways to interpret the referent of them:

1. It refers to the priests. For example:

I will punish you and make you pay for the evil you do. (GNT) (GNT)

1. It refers to both the priests and the people. For example:

I will punish them both for what they have done (NCV) (BSB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT)

Most versions are ambiguous. They use the pronoun them. These versions include the ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NJB, NRSV, and REB. If you can maintain the ambiguity in your language, you may do so. Otherwise, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This entire section (4:4-11a) focuses on the sinful priests and their punishment.

The first meaning lines in the Display will use an ambiguous pronoun. The second meaning lines will follow the recommended interpretation.

punish...repay them: The term repay means to do something in exchange for what another person has done. Here repay is another way to say punish. In response to the evil behavior of the priests, the LORD will respond with punishment that is a fair exchange for their evil deeds.

General Comment on 4:9b-c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the parallel parts in these two lines. For example:

I will punish them for all their wicked deeds.

See 4:9b-c (combined/reordered) in the Display for other examples.

4:9c

and repay them for their deeds.

- I will give them what they deserve for the evil they have done.
- Your^(plur) punishment will be appropriate for your wicked deeds.

Hosea 4:10

Section 4:4-11a: The Sinful Priests

In this section, the LORD promised to punish the priests more severely than anyone else, because they were the ones who led the people to worship false gods.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Accuses the Priests (GNT)

Against the Priests (NJB)

Paragraph 4:7-11a

In this paragraph, the LORD gave more details about the sinful behavior of the priests (4:7-8). He then described his response to that behavior (4:9-11a).

As in chapter 2, the Hebrew pronouns alternate between “you” and “she.” In 4:4-6 the LORD used “you” when speaking to the priests, but in 4:7-10, he referred to the same priests as “they.” The BSB uses the pronoun “they.” The GNT continues to use “you.” Use a natural way in your language to refer to the priests. Be consistent throughout this paragraph. It should be clear in your translation that the LORD is speaking here to the same group of priests as in 4:4-6.

4:10a-11a

These verses will follow the same interpretation as in 4:9b-c. The focus of these verses is still on the priests.

4:10a-b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{10a} They will eat but **not be satisfied**;

^{10b} they will be promiscuous but **not multiply**,

The underlined parts each describe something that the priests will continue to do. The parts in bold print each describe an unexpected result. The result that

the priests expected will not happen. Stuart (page 80) understands the punishments here to be similar to the covenant curses in Deuteronomy. He identifies “unfulfilled expectation” as the style of the curse.

4:10a

They will eat but not be satisfied;

- Even though they eat, they will remain hungry.
- You^(plur) will eat, but you will not have enough to fill your stomachs.

They will eat but not be satisfied: This line means that the amount of food the priests eat will not be enough to satisfy their hunger. According to Macintosh (page 149), verse 4:10a may refer back to 4:3a, which tells of the drought that the nation is suffering.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

Even though they eat, they will always remain hungry

They eat, but there is not enough to fill their stomachs

Their food won't satisfy (CEV)

4:10b

they will be promiscuous but not multiply.

- Even though they often sleep with prostitutes, they will father no children.
- You^(plur) have sex with many people that are not your spouse, but you^(plur) will remain childless,

they will be promiscuous but not multiply: The meaning of this line is that no children will be born as a result of the immoral behavior of the priests.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

Although they frequently sleep with prostitutes, their numbers will not increase

They are sexually promiscuous but they will remain childless

They will...resort to prostitutes and never have children (REB)

be promiscuous: In Hebrew, this term means to have sexual relations that were against the law of the LORD. It included prostitution that was part of worship in false religions. Stuart (page 80), Andersen

and Freedman (page 362), Chisholm (page 1389), and Wood (page 186). Here the term may refer partly to this type of prostitution. For example:

You will worship the fertility gods (GNT)

However, it probably refers more generally to any kind of prostitution as well as to other immoral behavior, such as adultery and fornication. Use a natural term in your language that refers to prostitution or to sexual immorality in general.

Here as elsewhere in the book of Hosea, the term variously translated as promiscuous or some form of harlotry or prostitution can be understood both literally and figuratively at the same time. It refers literally to sexual sin and figuratively to the worship of false gods. If possible, translate the phrase so that the literal and figurative meanings can both be understood.

not multiply: This phrase probably means to not multiply in numbers. According to Stuart (page 80), it may have a figurative meaning: they will not increase “in honor, prestige, or wealth.” The NLT phrase “gain nothing from it” probably includes this figurative meaning. Other versions normally cited in TN probably support the literal meaning “not increase in number” or “not have any children.”

4:10c

For they have stopped obeying the LORD.

- These things will happen because they have abandoned Yahweh
- because you^(plur) have forsaken me

For they have stopped obeying the LORD: The word For introduces the reason for the results in 4:10a-b. The priests will experience the unexpected results of 4:10a-b, because they had deserted the LORD. In some languages, it may be more natural to put the reason before the results. For example:

^{10c-11a}They have stopped obeying the LORD for promiscuity. ^{10a-b}Therefore, although they eat, they will not be satisfied. Although they frequently sleep with prostitutes, their numbers will not multiply.

they have stopped obeying the LORD: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

My people have rebelled (CEV)

for they have abandoned the Lord (REB)

you have turned away from me (GNT)

the LORD: Here the LORD speaks of himself using a third person reference: the LORD. If it is not natural in your language for someone to refer to himself in this way, you may make a first person pronoun (I/me) explicit. For example:

you have turned away from me (GNT)

have been unfaithful to me, their Lord (CEV)

4:10d–12a

These lines contain interpretation issues that involve verse and paragraph boundaries as well as differences in the object(s) of the verb. Here is a comparison of the verse and paragraph breaks in the BSB, NIV, and the NRSV. The BSB has:

^{10c}For they have stopped obeying the LORD.
^{11a}Promiscuity, ^{11b}wine, and new wine take away understanding. ^{12a}My people consult their wooden idols (BSB)

The NIV has:

^{10d}to give themselves ^{11a}to prostitution, ^{11b}to old wine and new, which take away the understanding ^{12a}of my people. They consult a wooden idol (NIV)

The NRSV has:

^{10d}to devote themselves to ^{11a}whoredom.
^{11b}Wine and new wine take away the understanding. ^{12a}My people consult a piece of wood, (NRSV)

TN will first discuss the interpretation issue in 4:10d–11b. It will then discuss the issue in 4:11b–12a.

4:10d–11b

The NRSV has been used as the source line for 4:10d–11b, because it allows for the recommended interpretation.

(NRSV) to devote themselves to whoredom. Wine and new wine take away the understanding: There are three ways to interpret the object(s) of the Hebrew verb that the NRSV translates as devote themselves to:

1. The object of the verb is the first term that follows it (prostitution). The LXX and Syriac follow this interpretation. With this interpretation, the next two terms (old wine and new wine), are the subject of the next verb (take away). For example:

they have forsaken the Lord to devote themselves to whoredom. Wine and new wine take away the understanding. (NRSV) (GNT, NAB, NJB, NJPS, NRSV, REB) The GNT has the same structure as the other versions that follow interpretation (1). However, the GNT understands “prostitution” symbolically. It has: “you have turned away from me to follow other gods.”

1. The objects of the verb are the three terms that follow it (prostitution, old wine, and new wine). With this interpretation, all three terms are also the subject of the next verb (take away). For example:

they have left the Lord to give themselves to prostitution, to old and new wine, which take away their ability to understand. (NCV) (ESV, NCV, NIV)

1. The object of the verb is the term that precedes it (the LORD). With this interpretation, the three terms that follow the verb (prostitution, old wine, and new wine) are the subject of the next verb (take away). For example:

they have stopped giving heed to the Lord. Harlotry, wine and new wine take away the understanding. (NASB) (BSB, GW, KJV, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. It better fits the way that prostitution and wine are described in Hosea and the rest of the Old Testament.

Throughout the OT, Israel’s rejection of the LORD is closely linked with prostitution, both literal and spiritual. Wine is not connected with rejecting the LORD. Moreover, wine is often described as something that keeps people from thinking clearly. Prostitution is not usually described in those terms. Another reason to follow interpretation (1) is that it has fewer grammatical difficulties than the other interpretations. The verb “take away” is singular in Hebrew. With interpretation (1), the nouns “new wine” and “old wine” agree with the verb, because they function as a single unit. With interpretations (2) and (3), all three nouns would not agree with the singular verb unless all three function as a single unit. That is improbable.

4:10d–11a

(NRSV) to devote themselves to: In Hebrew, this phrase is a single word. Here it indicates that the priests enthusiastically gratify their sexual desires and worship idols.

(NRSV) whoredom: This word is a noun form related to the verb that the BSB translated as “be promiscuous” in 4:10b. See the note there.

4:10d–11a**Promiscuity,**

- in order to devote themselves to prostitution instead.”
- in order to sleep with prostitutes and to worship other gods.”

Hosea 4:11**Section 4:11b–19: The Sinful People**

This section shows how much the people of Israel were committed to sexual sin and idolatry. They were stubborn and refused to return to the LORD. As a result, the LORD promised to discipline them so that in time they would be ashamed of their idolatry.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Condemns Pagan Worship (GNT)

Worship in Israel is idolatrous and debauched (NJB)

The previous section focused primarily on the priests. This section focuses on the people as a group. A section heading may be appropriate here if you chose interpretation (1) in 4:10d–11b. In that case this section would begin with a new sentence. A section heading is not recommended if you chose interpretation (2) or (3), because the heading would interrupt a sentence.

4:11b–12a

(NRSV) Wine and new wine: In this phrase, the two terms for wine function together as a unit. The repetition emphasizes the intoxicating effect of wine. The distinction in meaning between the two words for wine is not important here. So some versions have only “wine.” For example:

Wine has robbed my people of their understanding. (NLT)

For translation advice on the word wine, see the note on 2:8b.

(NRSV) Wine: The Hebrew word that many English versions translate as Wine is the normal word for “wine.” It does not refer to wine that has been aged for a long time. In some languages, a phrase such as “old wine” may have a wrong connotation. If that is true in your language, you should simply use your term for “wine,” as the NLT has done.

(NRSV) take away the understanding. My people

consult...: There are two ways to interpret the possible connection of the phrase My people to the word understanding. This issue of interpretation overlaps with a textual issue that involves the verse numbering. The Masoretic Text places the phrase My people at the beginning of 4:12. The LXX places the phrase at the end of 4:11. Unfortunately, the differences in verse numbering do not line up with the differences in meaning in the English versions. For example, the NIV places the phrase “of my people” at the start of 4:12, but connects it to the word “understanding” at the end of 4:11. The NET also translates this phrase as “understanding of my people,” but it places the entire phrase at the end of 4:11. To minimize confusion over differences in verse numbering, the Notes will discuss this issue in terms of the way it affects the meaning. The English versions will be listed according to how they connect the phrase “my people,” not according to where they divide the verse numbers.

1. The phrase My people does not connect to the previous word understanding. The phrase My people serves as the subject of the verb consult that follows it. For example:

take away the understanding. My people consult... (NRSV) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NRSV)

1. The phrase My people connects to the previous word understanding. They are parts of a larger phrase: “understanding of my people.” For example:

take away the understanding of my people. They consult... (NET) (CEV, GNT, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In Hebrew, the position of the phrase My people in relation to the verb consult highlights the fact that it is God’s own people that consult idols.

Here is another way to express this emphasis:

My own people consult a piece of wood!

(NRSV) take away the understanding: The Hebrew idiom that the NRSV translates as take away the understanding is literally “take away the heart.” The people of Israel considered the heart to be the center of thought and knowledge. To take away the heart meant to interfere with clear thinking. In this context, it meant that the people’s habit of drunkenness led to their lack of clear thinking regarding the LORD and his standards. See “lack of knowledge” under 4:6a.

In some languages, it may be necessary to make explicit whose understanding is being referred to. One way to do this is to refer to people in general. For example:

Wine takes away people’s ability to understand.

Wine keeps a person from thinking clearly.

4:11b wine, and new wine take away understanding.

- ¶ “Wine takes away the ability of a person to understand right from wrong.
- ¶ Yahweh continued to say, “Too much wine destroys good sense.
- ¶ “People cannot think clearly/properly when they are drunk with wine.

Hosea 4:12

Section 4:11b–19: The Sinful People

This section shows how much the people of Israel were committed to sexual sin and idolatry. They were stubborn and refused to return to the LORD. As a result, the LORD promised to discipline them so that in time they would be ashamed of their idolatry.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Condemns Pagan Worship (GNT)

Worship in Israel is idolatrous and debauched (NJB)

The previous section focused primarily on the priests. This section focuses on the people as a group. A section heading may be appropriate here if you chose interpretation (1) in 4:10d–11b. In that case this section would begin with a new sentence. A section heading is not recommended if you chose interpretation (2) or (3), because the heading would interrupt a sentence.

4:12a–b (combined/reordered)

- My own people expect wooden idols and other objects of wood to give them advice.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{12a} My people consult **their wooden idols**

^{12b} and **their divining rods** inform them.

These lines show that the people of Israel no longer sought guidance from the LORD. Instead they turned to idols and divination to guide them.

4:12a My people consult their wooden idols,

- My own people ask for guidance from their wooden idols.
- Indeed, even my own people ask a piece of wood to guide/advice them!

My people consult their wooden idols: To consult their wooden idols means to ask an idol carved from wood to guide them. For example:

ask their wooden idols for help (GW)

4:12b and their divining rods inform them.

- They rely on their wooden sticks/rods to tell them what to do.
- They use their divining rods for guidance.

and their divining rods inform them: The people did some kind of divination using a wooden stick or rod to obtain an answer to their requests.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

A piece of wood tells them what to do (GW)

they ask those sticks of wood to advise them (NCV)

General Comment on 4:12a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and combine the parallel parts. For example:

You expect wooden idols and other objects of wood to give you advice. (CEV)

4:12c–d (combined/reordered)

- They have rejected me as their God. They are now doing what is wrong, because they enjoy prostitution/immorality and idolatry.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{12c}For a spirit of prostitution **leads them astray**

^{12d}and they have played the harlot **against their God.**

In these lines the LORD said that the people's devotion to prostitution had led them away from devotion to him. See the General Comment on 4:12c-d at the end of 4:12d for ways to translate the literal and figurative meanings of prostitution in these parallel lines.

4:12c

For a spirit of prostitution leads them astray

- For their desire to be immoral has caused them to do what is wrong.
- They long to have sex with prostitutes and to worship false gods. So they have gone astray.

For: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as For introduces the reason why the people seek guidance from wooden idols and divination instead of the LORD. It is because a spirit of prostitution has led them away from him. Other translations leave this connection implied. Use a natural way in your language to introduce this reason.

a spirit of prostitution: In this context, this phrase probably refers to a strong desire to be immoral. It probably does not refer to a demon or evil spirit. NIDOTTE (#8120), Macintosh (page 152), Davies (page 124), McComiskey (page 66), and Stuart (page 81) understand *ruah* "spirit" as a strong desire or tendency to act in a certain way. Andersen and Freedman (pages 366-367) prefer the idea of a demonic spirit that deceives people and "incites...promiscuity." For example:

an urge to go whoring (NJB)

leads them astray: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as leads them astray is literally "has-caused-to-wander." It indicates here that the people's desire to be immoral has led or caused them to do what is wrong. The form of the Hebrew verb indicates that the people had been led astray in the past and were still being led astray. The BSB uses present tense to translate this idea. Some versions use past tense forms. For example:

an urge to go whoring has led them astray (NJB)

4:12d

and they have played the harlot against their God.

- They have abandoned me in order to worship false gods.
- They have turned away from me, their God, and have rejected my authority.

and they have played the harlot against their God:

In Hebrew, this clause is literally "and they have committed fornication." The BART interlinear for 4:12d glosses this qal form of the verb *zanah* as "they have prostituted themselves." NIDOTTE (#2388) glosses the qal form as "commit fornication, act as a harlot, have illicit intercourse." TWOT (#563) and BDB (#2181) are similar. In 4:12d the verb refers figuratively to religious immorality or unfaithfulness to God. from under their God." It means here that the people rejected the authority of the LORD and devoted themselves to idolatry and self-indulgence instead.

General Comment on 4:12c-d

Some verse parts in the following context (4:13a-c) focus on idolatry. Other verse parts (4:13d-e) focus on the literal prostitution that was part of idol worship. If possible, your translation of "spirit of prostitution" and "played the harlot against their God" in 4:12c-d should include both meanings.

It is suggested that you use at least one expression that refers to sexual unfaithfulness between people. Use other expressions that refer to idolatry or unfaithfulness to God. In the following examples, sexual unfaithfulness will be marked with an underline. Idolatry or unfaithfulness to God will be marked with bold print:

^{12c}Their strong desire for sexual pleasure and **idol worship** has led them to abandon what is right.

^{12d}They **have left their God to serve other gods.**

^{12c}Their uncontrolled lusts have caused them to sin. ^{12d}They are no longer faithful to one another or **to God**.

^{12c}Like prostitutes, they have **chased after other gods** ^{12d}and **have left their own God.** (NCV)

^{12c}A spirit of prostitution leads them astray. ^{12d}They commit adultery by **giving themselves to other gods.** (GW)

You may also want to clarify the relationship between literal and figurative prostitution in a footnote. Here is a suggested footnote:

People who worshiped idols at mountain shrines sacrificed animals and incense to the idols. As part of the ritual, they often had sex with the prostitutes who worked at the shrines (see 4:13–14). When they did this, they were acting immorally. They were also being unfaithful to God by worshiping other gods.

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine the parallel parts in 4:12c–d. For example:

Their longing for the pleasures of sexual immorality and idolatry has led them to abandon me, their God.

Hosea 4:13

Section 4:11b–19: The Sinful People

This section shows how much the people of Israel were committed to sexual sin and idolatry. They were stubborn and refused to return to the LORD. As a result, the LORD promised to discipline them so that in time they would be ashamed of their idolatry.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Condemns Pagan Worship (GNT)

Worship in Israel is idolatrous and debauched (NJB)

The previous section focused primarily on the priests. This section focuses on the people as a group. A section heading may be appropriate here if you chose interpretation (1) in 4:10d–11b. In that case this section would begin with a new sentence. A section heading is not recommended if you chose interpretation (2) or (3), because the heading would interrupt a sentence.

4:13a–b (combined/reordered)

- They continually worship false gods. They offer animals and incense to them on the tops of mountains and hills.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{13a}They sacrifice **on the mountaintops**

^{13b}and burn offerings **on the hills**

These lines describe one of the ways that the people and priests were unfaithful to God. At that time the only acceptable way to offer sacrifices was as he described in the book of Leviticus. The only acceptable place of worship was Jerusalem. See Deuteronomy 12:5–7, 15–27. They sacrificed to idols at pagan shrines. These shrines were frequently located on the tops of mountains or hills.

sacrifice...burn offerings: These parallel terms refer here to two kinds of offerings that people made when they worshiped Baal or other idols. The form of the Hebrew verbs indicates that they sacrificed regularly or repeatedly.

The word sacrifice refers to killing an animal and eating portions of it as part of a worship ceremony. The phrase burn offerings is literally “they make smoke.” It refers primarily to the smoke from burning incense. See the note on this verb at 2:13a. In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

They sacrifice animals and burn incense as an offering to their idols

on the mountaintops...on the hills: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as hills usually refers to areas that are slightly lower than mountains. Here no distinction is intended between these two parallel terms. The parallel lines do not imply that people offered one kind of sacrifice on mountains and another kind on hills.

General Comment on 4:13a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine the parallel parts into one line. For example

They never stop offering sacrifices on mountaintops and hills (CEV)

4:13a They sacrifice on the mountaintops

- They repeatedly sacrifice animals to their idols on the mountaintops,
- They often offer animal sacrifices to false gods on the tops of mountains.

4:13b and burn offerings on the hills,

- and they burn incense offerings on the hills,

- They regularly burn incense on the hills as offerings to them.

4:13c

under oak, poplar, and terebinth, because their shade is pleasant.

- in the shady places under trees called oak, poplar, and terebinth.
- They offer these things under large trees, because they enjoy the shade there.

under oak, poplar, and terebinth, because their shade is pleasant: This phrase gives a further description of the places on the mountaintops and hills where the Israelites made sacrifices. Oak, poplar, and terebinth are three kinds of large trees that give good shade. If these trees are unknown in your area, you may use borrowed terms from another translation in your area. You may also use a descriptive phrase instead of stating the names of specific kinds of trees. For example:

under tall, spreading trees, because the shade is so pleasant (GNT)

4:13d–e

(combined/reordered)

- ¶ “And so, your^(plur) daughters and daughters-in-law behave immorally.
- ¶ Therefore/So the young women sleep with many men who are not their husbands.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{13d}And so your daughters **turn to prostitution**

^{13e}and your daughters-in-law **to adultery**

In addition to offering sacrifices, another part of the people’s idol worship was getting drunk and sleeping with prostitutes. These lines describe a result of this idol worship. The immoral behavior of the men motivated young women to behave immorally also.

And so: This word introduces the response of the young women to the idol worship described in 4:13a–b. They became sexually immoral.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

As a result (GNT)

That is why (REB)

In some languages, it may not be clear that the young women’s response is due to idol worship. If that is true in your language, you may want to make the connection explicit. For example:

Because of the rituals that accompany idol worship, your daughters...

your daughters...your daughters-in-law: In 4:12c–4:13b, “they” pronouns are used. Here in 4:13d–e, the pronouns change to your. This change of pronouns may help the hearers to realize what is happening to the young women in their own families.

The parallel phrases your daughters...your daughters-in-law function as a pair. They represent all the young women of Israel. Stuart (page 82). In some languages, it may be more natural to refer to these two groups with a more general term. For example:

your female children

your young women

daughters-in-law: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as daughters-in-law:

1. It means “daughters-in-law.” For example:

daughters-in-law (NJB) (BSB, CEV, GNT, GW, NAB, NCV, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. It means “brides.” For example:

brides (ESV) (ESV, KJV, NASB, REB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. This interpretation better fits the parallel term “daughters” in 4:13d.

turn to prostitution...to adultery: These parallel terms function together to indicate sexual immorality in general. This verse does not imply a distinction between one group of women who are prostitutes and another group who commit adultery.

General Comment on 4:13d–e

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine the parallel parts in these two lines. For example:

Your own daughters and daughters-in-law sell themselves for sex. (CEV)

4:13d

And so your daughters turn to prostitution

- ¶ “For that reason, your^(plur) daughters become prostitutes
- ¶ “Because of the rituals that accompany idol worship, your daughters behave immorally

4:13e

and your daughters-in-law to adultery.

- and your^(plur) daughters-in-law commit adultery.

Hosea 4:14

Section 4:11b–19: The Sinful People

This section shows how much the people of Israel were committed to sexual sin and idolatry. They were stubborn and refused to return to the LORD. As a result, the LORD promised to discipline them so that in time they would be ashamed of their idolatry.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Condemns Pagan Worship (GNT)

Worship in Israel is idolatrous and debauched (NJB)

The previous section focused primarily on the priests. This section focuses on the people as a group. A section heading may be appropriate here if you chose interpretation (1) in 4:10d–11b. In that case this section would begin with a new sentence. A section heading is not recommended if you chose interpretation (2) or (3), because the heading would interrupt a sentence.

4:14a–b

(combined/reordered)

- But these young women are not the ones I will punish.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{14a}I will not punish your daughters when they **prostitute themselves**,

^{14b}nor your daughters-in-law when they **commit adultery**.

There is an ellipsis in 4:14b. In some languages, it will be necessary to supply the missing verb from 4:14a. For example:

^{14b}nor will I punish your daughters-in-law when they **commit adultery**,

In Hebrew, the parallel parts in these lines are identical to the parallel parts in 4:13d–e. In some languages, it is unnatural to repeat the same noun phrases two verses in a row. If that is true in your language, you could use one or more pronouns instead. For example:

Yet I will not punish them for this (GNT)

I will not punish: In this clause the pronoun I refers to the LORD. Some versions introduce this phrase with a word that indicates that this result is unexpected. For example:

Yet I will not punish (GNT)

But I won't punish (NCV)

Use a natural way in your language to introduce this unexpected result.

when...when: The word when in these parallel lines introduces the behavior that the LORD will not punish. He will not punish them when they are immoral. Another way to express this relationship is to use the word “for.” For example:

But I will not punish your daughters for becoming prostitutes (NCV)

General Comment on 4:14a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine these parallel statements into one line. For example:

But I won't punish them. (CEV)

Notice that the CEV leaves the reason for the punishment (their immorality) implied in 4:14a–b. The CEV states their immoral behavior explicitly in 4:13d–e (quoted above).

4:14a

I will not punish your daughters when they prostitute themselves,

- Yet/But I will not punish your^(plur) daughters for becoming prostitutes.

4:14b

nor your daughters-in-law when they commit adultery.

- I will also not punish your^(plur) daughters-in-law for committing adultery.

4:14c–d (combined/reordered)

- No! It is you^(plur) men whom I will punish, because you regularly eat with the prostitutes when you sacrifice at the shrines, and then you have sex with them.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{14c}For the men themselves go off with **prostitutes**

^{14d}and offer sacrifices with **shrine prostitutes**.

4:14c

For the men themselves go off with prostitutes

- Because you^(plur) yourselves continue to go aside/off to have sex with prostitutes
- You men are the ones who go sleep with prostitutes.

For: This word introduces the reason that the LORD will not punish the young women for their immoral behavior. It is because he places the blame on the men of Israel. The men led the nation into idolatry, and their immoral behavior influenced the young women to become immoral.

the men themselves: The Hebrew pronoun that the BSB translates as the men themselves is literally “they^(masc).” The pronoun refers to the men of Israel. The following examples show different ways to translate the pronoun. All are acceptable:

- “the men.” An example is the BSB above.
- “your men.” For example:

your men resort to whores (REB)

- “you men” or “you.” For example:

You men are to blame (CEV)

Many versions also give emphasis by adding a word such as themselves. The BSB above is an example. Another example is the GNT:

you yourselves go off with temple prostitutes
(GNT)

Express this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

go off with prostitutes: This phrase probably means that each of the men separated from a larger group to be alone with a prostitute.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

go aside with harlots (RSV)

wandering off with whores (NJB)

This phrase implies that the men had sexual relations with the prostitutes. Some versions make this explicit. For example:

have sexual relations with prostitutes (NCV)

4:14d

and offer sacrifices with shrine prostitutes.

- at the shrines and to offer sacrifices with them.
- They are with you^(plur) when you sacrifice animals at the places where people worship idols.

and offer sacrifices with shrine prostitutes: As part of the ritual, the worshiper offered an animal sacrifice at an altar and later ate some of the meat from the sacrificed animal. Shrine prostitutes were part of that ritual. She and the worshiper may have shared the sacrificial meal together. She also had sexual intercourse with him as part of the ritual.

shrine prostitutes: This term refers to prostitutes who worked at the shrines where people worshiped idols.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

temple prostitutes (NCV)

prostitutes who work at the pagan shrines

General Comment on 4:14c–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine these parallel statements into one line. For example:

you men accompany temple prostitutes to offer pagan sacrifices.

4:14e

So a people without understanding will come to ruin.

- Indeed, people with no understanding of Yahweh and his commands will be destroyed.

- My people refuse to understand what is right. And so, their destruction is certain.
- Yes, your^(plur) own foolishness will result in your ruin.

So a people without understanding will come to ruin: This is a statement of judgment against the people. It is very similar to the statement “My people are destroyed from lack of knowledge” in 4:6a, although the context here is different. See the note on that passage.

This expression may have been a proverb that was familiar to the people of that time. Some versions make this explicit. For example:

As the proverb says, ‘A people without sense will be ruined.’ (GNT)

a people without understanding: This phrase refers here to people who do not have spiritual or moral understanding. Such people refuse to understand God and the way he acts. This lack of understanding is equivalent to moral or spiritual foolishness.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Your own foolishness... (CEV)

O foolish people! You refuse to understand (NLT)

A people without sense (GNT)

will come to ruin: This phrase refers here to the destruction of the nation of Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

is doomed (NJB)

will be destroyed (NLT)

Hosea 4:15

Section 4:11b–19: The Sinful People

This section shows how much the people of Israel were committed to sexual sin and idolatry. They were stubborn and refused to return to the LORD. As a result, the LORD promised to discipline them so that in time they would be ashamed of their idolatry.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Condemns Pagan Worship (GNT)

Worship in Israel is idolatrous and debauched (NJB)

The previous section focused primarily on the priests. This section focuses on the people as a group. A section heading may be appropriate here if you chose interpretation (1) in 4:10d–11b. In that case this section would begin with a new sentence. A section heading is not recommended if you chose interpretation (2) or (3), because the heading would interrupt a sentence.

Paragraph 4:15–19

This paragraph gives more details about the immorality, drunkenness, and idol worship of the people of Israel.

4:15a

Though you prostitute yourself, O Israel, may Judah avoid such guilt!

- ¶ “Even though you^(plur) people of Israel are unfaithful, may the people of Judah not become guilty of the same sin.
- ¶ “You, Israel, are guilty of immorality and idolatry! But I do not want Judah to follow your example.

Though you prostitute yourself, O Israel, may Judah avoid such guilt: In this verse part the LORD mentioned the sexual immorality and idolatry of the people of Israel as a basis for giving an indirect warning to the people of Judah. He warned them not to become guilty of the same sins.

These two clauses have a number of probable implications. It may be helpful to make some of the logical relationships explicit.

1. The LORD knew that the people of Israel were prostituting themselves.
2. He expected that the people of Judah would follow Israel’s example and become guilty of the same sins.
3. But he did not want this to happen, so he warned Judah not to commit those sins.

There is an implied contrast between what the LORD expected and his warning. In some languages, it may be more natural to express this contrast with a word such as “but.” For example:

You Israelites prostitute yourselves, but Judah must not become guilty of the same sin.

you prostitute yourself: The word that the BSB translates as prostitute is a different form of the same word that it translates as “be promiscuous” in 4:10b (see

the note there). It probably refers here to both sexual immorality and unfaithfulness towards God.

O Israel: In this context, the direct form of address O Israel implies a rebuke. Use a form of address in your language that is natural to use in a rebuke.

may Judah avoid such guilt: In this context, this phrase is an indirect command or warning to the people of Judah. It expresses the LORD's desire that they not become guilty of the same sin as the people of Israel. It may also imply a rebuke. It is likely that some people from Judah already worshiped at idol shrines in Israel.

This phrase is not a command to Israel that Israel must prevent Judah from becoming guilty. It is an indirect command to Judah. A command to Israel to prevent Judah's guilt would use a second person verb addressed to Israel here. However, this verb is a third person jussive addressed indirectly to Judah. The jussive expresses the speaker's desire that a situation will occur or in this case, will not occur.

Here are some other ways to express this meaning:

Though you, Israel, play the whore, there is no need for Judah to sin too. (NJB)

Even though you people of Israel are unfaithful to me, may Judah not be guilty of the same thing. (GNT)

4:15b

Do not journey to Gilgal, do not go up to Beth-aven,

- Do not travel to the shrines at Gilgal or Beth Aven.
- Don't worship at Gilgal or Bethaven, (GNT)

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

Do not journey to **Gilgal**,

do not go up to **Beth-aven**,

Gilgal and Bethel (here called Beth-aven) were the names of two cities that were major centers of idolatry. The LORD told his people not to worship at these two places.

Do not journey to Gilgal, do not go up to Beth-aven: The LORD may have given this command to the people of Israel, the people of Judah, or both groups of people. Most English versions, including the BSB, are ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow the

example of these versions and not specify who the command refers to.

Beth-aven: Bethel means "house of God." The name Beth-aven means "house of wickedness." The LORD used the name Beth-aven here to emphasize how evil Bethel had become. Years earlier Bethel was a place for worshiping the LORD. Later Jeroboam set up a shrine with a golden calf there (see 1 Kings 12:20-33). From that time on it became a place for worshiping false gods. See also 5:8 and 10:5.

It is recommended that you use the name Beth-aven in your translation and not "Bethel." Some other ways that versions spell this name are Beth Aven and Bethaven.

It is also recommended that you add a footnote to explain that the LORD substituted Beth-aven for "Bethel." For example:

Bethel means "house of God." Here the LORD called it Beth-aven, which means "house of wickedness."

Do not journey...do not go up: The second of these parallel phrases is more specific than the first. It often refers to going uphill. Many verses speak of "going up" to Jerusalem, and Bethel was located at an even higher elevation. If your language uses a specific term for traveling uphill, you may want to use it here. However, in this context the uphill direction is not in focus. Both phrases refer to travel to a shrine for the purpose of worship.

Here are some other ways to translate this idea:

Do not come to Gilgal, Do not make pilgrimages to Beth-aven (NJPS)

Don't worship at Gilgal or Bethaven (GNT)

4:15c

and do not swear on oath, 'As surely as the LORD lives!'

- And do not say, 'I will keep my oath/promise as surely as Yahweh lives.'
- and do not make promises that you^(plur) confirm by using my name, the name of Yahweh who lives.
- And do not say, 'I will certainly fulfill my oath/promise. It is just as certain as the truth that Yahweh is alive.'

and do not swear on oath, 'As surely as the LORD lives!': As the BSB clarifies, in this context, to swear

means to make an oath or a promise. The Israelites used the expression As surely as the LORD lives as part of the oath. It was a guarantee that they would do what they promised. In the past, the LORD allowed them to use his name in this way because of his covenant relationship with them (see Deuteronomy 6:13, 10:20).

However, the Israelites broke that covenant when they turned away from the LORD to worship idols instead. Since they did not honor him, the LORD told them to stop using his name to make an oath.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

And quit making promises in my name—the name of the living Lord (CEV)

Do not...take oaths there in the Lord's name. (NLT)

Hosea 4:16

Section 4:11b–19: The Sinful People

This section shows how much the people of Israel were committed to sexual sin and idolatry. They were stubborn and refused to return to the LORD. As a result, the LORD promised to discipline them so that in time they would be ashamed of their idolatry.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Condemns Pagan Worship (GNT)

Worship in Israel is idolatrous and debauched (NJB)

The previous section focused primarily on the priests. This section focuses on the people as a group. A section heading may be appropriate here if you chose interpretation (1) in 4:10d–11b. In that case this section would begin with a new sentence. A section heading is not recommended if you chose interpretation (2) or (3), because the heading would interrupt a sentence.

Paragraph 4:15–19

This paragraph gives more details about the immorality, drunkenness, and idol worship of the people of Israel.

4:16a

For Israel is as obstinate as a stubborn heifer.

- Since the Israelites are as stubborn as a young cow that refuses to be led,
- You^(plur) are like a stubborn cow/mule.

For Israel is as obstinate as a stubborn heifer: In Hebrew, this verse part begins with a word that the BSB and some other versions translate as For. There are two ways to interpret the function of this word:

1. It introduces the reason for something that follows. Israel is stubborn. For that reason, the LORD will no longer care for the people as a shepherd cares for his sheep. For example:

^{16a} Since Israel is stubborn Like a stubborn heifer,

^{16b} Can the Lord now pasture them Like a lamb in a large field? (NASB) (NASB, NIV, NRSV, REB)

1. It introduces the explanation for a previous statement. It was because of Israel's stubbornness that they were forbidden to use the LORD's name. It was also because of their stubbornness that they were immoral and worshiped idols. For example:

for Israel is as stubborn as a stubborn heifer (NJB) (BSB, KJV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It fits well with the logic of the verse, that Israel's stubbornness is the reason for the LORD's response in 4:16b. Many versions leave the reason implied. For example:

Like a stubborn heifer, Israel is stubborn (NRSV)

The Israelites are stubborn, like a stubborn heifer. (NIV)

If is natural in your language to express this reason implicitly, you may do so.

as obstinate as a stubborn heifer: This is a simile that compares the behavior of the people of Israel to that of a stubborn heifer/cow. A stubborn heifer refuses to follow the person that tries to lead it. Similarly, the people of Israel refuse to follow the LORD and obey him. It is recommended that you keep this comparison if the meaning is clear. If the meaning is not clear in your language, you may substitute a different comparison that has the same meaning and impact. For example:

as stubborn as mules (GNT)

heifer: This word refers to a young cow that has not given birth to a calf. Some languages may have a word that refers specifically to this kind of cow. In other

languages, it may be necessary to use a more general word or phrase. For example:

like a stubborn young cow (NCV)

like a stubborn cow (NJPS)

4:16b

Can the LORD now shepherd them like lambs in an open meadow?

- can Yahweh shepherd them like lambs in a broad pasture? No, he cannot.
- You are so stubborn that I, Yahweh, cannot feed you^(plur) like lambs in a large field of grass.

Can the LORD now shepherd them like lambs in an open meadow?:

Here the LORD gave his response to the stubbornness of Israel by using another simile. He compared the people of Israel to lambs in a large pasture. There are two ways to interpret this comparison:

1. It is a rhetorical question. The implied negative answer is: "He cannot." The Israelites were so stubborn that the LORD could not provide and care for them as a shepherd would lead and care for his sheep. Macintosh (page 165), Wood (page 188), and Hubbard (page 109). For example:

can the Lord now feed them like a lamb in a broad pasture? (NRSV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NAB, NASB, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV) This same interpretation can also be expressed as a statement. For example:

so stubborn that I, the Lord, cannot feed you like lambs in an open pasture (CEV) (CEV)

1. It is a statement of the LORD's judgment. He compared the people of Israel to sheep in a wide land. The meaning is that he will scatter them to places where they would not be under his care and protection. Keil (page 83), McComiskey (page 71), and Pusey (page 54). For example:

so the Lord will put her out to pasture. She will stand alone and unprotected, like a helpless lamb in an open field. (NLT96) (KJV, NCV, NET, NJPS, NLT96)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. The image of a shep-

herd caring for sheep is a common one in the Old Testament. The image almost always has a positive connotation. Support for interpretation (2) is also reasonable. The most important points in its favor are that this clause lacks an interrogative marker and that it is introduced by a Hebrew word "now" or "soon" that generally introduces a judgment. Nevertheless, these points are not conclusive. It is not unusual, even in Hosea, for a rhetorical question to be unmarked. Also, the word "now" does not always indicate a judgment. It can simply indicate a conclusion. Another argument against interpretation (2) is that there are no definitive examples in the Old Testament of the image of a shepherd caring for sheep in a wide place being used in a negative sense.

Hosea 4:17

Section 4:11b–19: The Sinful People

This section shows how much the people of Israel were committed to sexual sin and idolatry. They were stubborn and refused to return to the LORD. As a result, the LORD promised to discipline them so that in time they would be ashamed of their idolatry.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

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Paragraph 4:15–19

This paragraph gives more details about the immorality, drunkenness, and idol worship of the people of Israel.

4:17a

Ephraim is joined to idols;

- The people of Ephraim have decided to be associated/allied with idols.
- The people of Israel have chosen to worship idols.

Ephraim: Ephraim was one of the largest tribes of the northern kingdom of Israel. Here the name Ephraim is a figure of speech (synecdoche) that represents all the people of Israel. In some languages, it may be clearer

to translate only the meaning and not keep the figure of speech. For example:

The Israelites have chosen to worship idols (NCV)

is joined to idols: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as joined to means to be allied with something or someone. Here it indicates that the people of Israel were allied with idols instead of the LORD.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Ephraim has made a pact with idols (NJB)

The people of Ephraim have chosen to worship idols (GW)

In some contexts, this verb can mean “to be charmed” or “to be put under a spell.” Some versions translate this idea. For example:

The people of Israel are under the spell of idols (GNT)

However, this is probably not the meaning here.

4:17b leave him alone!

- Do not interfere.
- No one can persuade them to stop, so just allow them to continue!

leave him alone: This clause means to allow the people of Israel to continue their worship of idols. The purpose of the clause is not to command a specific person to leave the people of Israel alone. Rather, it indicates that Israel’s situation is hopeless. Nothing can be done to stop the people of Israel from worshipping idols.

Hosea 4:18

Section 4:11b–19: The Sinful People

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Here are some other examples of section headings:

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Paragraph 4:15–19

This paragraph gives more details about the immorality, drunkenness, and idol worship of the people of Israel.

4:18a–19b

There is a slight change in reference from 4:18a to 4:18b. Verse 4:18a refers to the people in general, whereas 4:18b specifies the rulers. The pronouns “them/their” in 4:19a–b probably refers to the rulers as well as the people, because both groups were taken into exile.

4:18a

When their liquor is gone, they turn to prostitution;

- They finish their drinks, then eagerly go to find a prostitute.
- After they are drunk with wine, they can think about nothing except having sex with a prostitute.

When their liquor is gone, they turn to prostitution:

The RSV has “A band of drunkards, they give themselves to harlotry.” The MT has “[when] it has come to an end their drink, they have continually prostituted themselves.” HOTP recommends following the MT here as in the NRSV “When their drinking is ended, they indulge in sexual orgies.” These clauses describe the Israelites’ regular pattern of behavior. As part of their idol worship, the people regularly became drunk and then had sexual relations with prostitutes.

Here are some other ways to translate these clauses:

You get drunk, then sleep with prostitutes (CEV)

They consume their alcohol, then engage in cult prostitution (NET)

they turn to prostitution: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “committing fornication they have committed fornication.” The purpose of this repetition is to emphasize the meaning.

Here are some ways to express this emphasis:

they delight in their prostitution (GNT)

they continue to have sex with the prostitutes (GW)

they indulge in sexual orgies (NRSV)

Use a natural way in your language to emphasize their immoral behavior.

4:18b

their rulers dearly love disgrace.

- Their rulers/leaders very much love shameful behavior.
- Their rulers/leaders have a strong desire to do what is immoral/shameful.

their rulers dearly love disgrace: There is a textual issue here. The Notes will discuss the two main options:

1. The Masoretic Text probably has “its shields have loved, love shame.” The word “shields” here is figurative. It means rulers or “leaders.” For example:

Their rulers dearly love to act shamefully. (GW)

their rulers dearly love shame (ESV) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NIV)

1. The LXX has “they love disgrace more than their pride.” It means that the people love shameful behavior more than honorable behavior. For example:

preferring disgrace to honor (GNT) (CEV, GNT, NJB, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). Both options have some unusual word forms or uses, but the MT makes reasonable sense. The guideline for TN is to follow the MT unless there is strong reason to do otherwise. The Hebrew text is uncertain here. The word that the BSB translates as “disgrace” may be taken to read “of shame/insolence” instead. For example, the NET has: “they dearly love their shameful behavior.” Other versions that understand the Hebrew text to say “of shame/insolence” are the NCV and NJPS. The HOTTB recommends the MT with a B rating (almost certain). It suggests “shields/princes.” However, both options have good version support, so it is recommended that you give the other option in a footnote. Here is a possible footnote:

This is what the Masoretic Text probably means. The LXX (Septuagint) means that the people love shameful behavior more than their honor or pride.

dearly love: In Hebrew, the repeated words “have loved, love” may intensify the meaning of love. This is the explanation given by McComiskey (page 72) and Wood (page 189).

disgrace: This phrase refers to immoral behavior.

Hosea 4:19

Section 4:11b–19: The Sinful People

This section shows how much the people of Israel were committed to sexual sin and idolatry. They were stubborn and refused to return to the LORD. As a result, the LORD promised to discipline them so that in time they would be ashamed of their idolatry.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Condemns Pagan Worship (GNT)

Worship in Israel is idolatrous and debauched (NJB)

The previous section focused primarily on the priests. This section focuses on the people as a group. A section heading may be appropriate here if you chose interpretation (1) in 4:10d–11b. In that case this section would begin with a new sentence. A section heading is not recommended if you chose interpretation (2) or (3), because the heading would interrupt a sentence.

Paragraph 4:15–19

This paragraph gives more details about the immorality, drunkenness, and idol worship of the people of Israel.

4:19a–b

Notice the similarity between these two parallel lines:

^{19a}The whirlwind has wrapped them in its wings,

^{19b}and their sacrifices will bring them shame.

Both lines indicate the result of the sinful behavior described in the previous verses. Verse 4:19a describes the punishment of being taken away into captivity. Verse 4:19b describes the shame that they will feel.

Most English versions do not indicate explicitly that this verse is a result. In some languages, it may be

clearer to introduce this result with a word such as “Therefore” or “So.” For example:

So a mighty wind will sweep them away (NLT)

4:19a

The whirlwind has wrapped them in its wings,

- A strong wind will take all of them far away from their land,
- Therefore I will punish all of them. It will be as though a wind picks them up with strong wings like a bird and carries them away.

The whirlwind has wrapped them in its wings: This figure of speech probably means that enemy armies will take the people and their leaders captive and remove them from the land of Israel.

The Hebrew verb form used here normally indicates that the action is already complete. For that reason the BSB and some other versions use past tense.

However, in prophecies, the completed form can indicate that a future event will certainly take place. That is probably what it indicates here.

Use a natural way in your language to indicate that this is a future event.

4:19b

and their sacrifices will bring them shame.

- and their sacrifices to idols will cause them to be shamed/disgraced.”
- The final result of their idol worship will be their humiliation.”

and their sacrifices will bring them shame: There is a textual issue here regarding the word that the BSB translates as sacrifices:

1. The Masoretic Text has sacrifices. For example:

they will be ashamed because of their sacrifices (NASB) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB)

1. The LXX has “altars.” For example:

they shall be ashamed because of their altars (NRSV) (NAB, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions.

The meaning of this clause is that their sacrifices will cause them shame. Here are some other ways to express this relationship:

their sacrifices will lead to their shame

The result of their idol worship will be their humiliation

sacrifices: Here the word sacrifices is a figure of speech (metonymy) that represents idol worship.

Here are some other ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Make “idols” explicit. For example:

Their sacrifices to idols (NLT)

- Refer to idol worship directly. For example:

their idolatrous worship (NET)

shame: Because the people of Israel continue to worship idols, the LORD will send enemy armies to defeat them in battle and take them captive. This will cause them to feel shame or disgrace.

Hosea 5:1

Section 5:1–7: The LORD will judge the people of Israel and Judah

In 5:1–4, the LORD condemned the people of Israel and Judah, including the priests and leaders, for their corruption, immorality, and idolatry. In 5:5–7, he warned them that he would leave them and allow them to be destroyed.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel and Judah will be judged (CEV)

Punishment Coming for Israel and Judah (ESV)

Paragraph 5:1–4

In this paragraph, the LORD made an accusation against the people of Israel. He made it clear that he knew everything they did. Nothing was hidden from him. He concluded by declaring that his people no longer knew him.

Since this paragraph occurs at the beginning of a new section, it may be helpful in some languages to make

explicit that the LORD is the one who was speaking. For example, the CEV begins this paragraph with:

The Lord said (CEV)

Here is another way to introduce the paragraph:

The LORD continued to speak. He said

5:1a

“Hear this, O priests! Take heed, O house of Israel! Give ear, O royal house!”

- ¶ Yahweh said, “Priests, hear this! Israelites, listen carefully! Members of the king’s family, hear these words!
- ¶ “Israelites, especially you^(plur) priests, and family of the king: Listen carefully to my words!

Hear this, O priests! Take heed, O house of Israel! Give ear, O royal house!: The clauses Hear this, Take heed, and Give ear are three ways of saying the same thing. This repetition called attention to what the LORD was about to say.

Here the LORD addressed three groups in Israel:

1. the priests
2. the people of the nation of Israel
3. the royal family

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the phrases in these three lines. For example:

- Name the group of people before the verb:

“Priests, hear this! Israelites, pay attention! Royal house/family, listen!”

- List all of the groups together:

Priests, people of Israel, and royal house of Israel, pay attention to my words.

- Reorder the groups. For example, here is a list in a different order:

Listen, Royal house! Hear this, Priests! Pay attention, Israelites!

Use the order and forms of address that are most natural in your language for groups like these.

Hear this: This phrase refers to the words of the LORD that follow.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Hear these words that I am about to say.

priests: These are the same priests as in 4:4b. See the notes at 4:4b.

house of Israel: This phrase refers to the entire nation of the northern kingdom of Israel.

royal house: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “house of the king.” It refers here to the king and his family.

O: There is no Hebrew word here for the word O. In the past, O was used as a formal way to address someone in English, so the BSB and some other versions have added it here. Use a term of address that is appropriate in your language for this context.

5:1b

For this judgment is against you

- Because this is a judgment against you!^(plur)
- I am going to punish you.

this judgment is against you: In Hebrew, this clause is literally “the judgment belongs to you.” It can be interpreted in two ways:

1. It means that the LORD will judge the nation of Israel. For example:

because you will all be judged (NCV) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NLT, NIV, NRSV, REB)

1. It means that Israel is responsible to act justly. For example:

Justice was your duty (CEV) (CEV, GNT, NJB, NJPS).

In some versions, both interpretations (1) and (2) are made explicit. For example:

You are supposed to judge with justice—so judgment will fall on you! (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

5:1c

because you have been a snare at Mizpah, a net spread out on Tabor.

- You^(plur) have been like a bird trap at Mizpah. Yes, you have been like a net on Mount Tabor that is spread out for its prey.
- For you have snared people like people snare birds at Mizpah and Tabor.
- Because you have led the people away from me and into idolatry.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

because you have been a snare at **Mizpah**,

a net spread out on **Tabor**.

There is an ellipsis in the second line. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from the first line. For example:

You have been a net spread out on **Tabor**.

Each line is a metaphor. Both metaphors compare the leaders and influential people of Israel to traps used for catching birds. The birds represent the people. The meaning is that the leaders have led the people to worship false gods.

you have been a snare...a net spread out: The words that the BSB translates as snare and net refer to two kinds of bird traps. The difference of meaning between the two words is not important here. Both represent people who enticed others away from the LORD and into false worship.

If it is confusing or unnatural in your language to use metaphors like this, here are some other options:

- Change the metaphors into similes. For example:

You have been like a trap at Mizpah and like a net spread out at Mount Tabor. (NCV)

- Translate the meaning directly without using a figure of speech. For example:

For you have led the people to worship idols.

- Use a different idiom or figure of speech that conveys the right meaning in your language.

at Mizpah...on Tabor: Mizpah and Tabor are two locations in Israel where people worshiped idols. Here they are probably used as a figure of speech (synecdoche) that represents all the places in Israel where the people worshiped false gods.

Tabor is a site on a mountain. For that reason some versions make that explicit. For example:

like a net spread out at Mount Tabor. (NCV)

Hosea 5:2

Section 5:1–7: The LORD will judge the people of Israel and Judah

In 5:1–4, the LORD condemned the people of Israel and Judah, including the priests and leaders, for their corruption, immorality, and idolatry. In 5:5–7, he warned them that he would leave them and allow them to be destroyed.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel and Judah will be judged (CEV)

Punishment Coming for Israel and Judah (ESV)

Paragraph 5:1–4

In this paragraph, the LORD made an accusation against the people of Israel. He made it clear that he knew everything they did. Nothing was hidden from him. He concluded by declaring that his people no longer knew him.

Since this paragraph occurs at the beginning of a new section, it may be helpful in some languages to make explicit that the LORD is the one who was speaking. For example, the CEV begins this paragraph with:

The Lord said (CEV)

Here is another way to introduce the paragraph:

The LORD continued to speak. He said

5:2a

The rebels are deep in slaughter;

- These rebels have murdered many of their fellow countrymen.
- You^(plur) have revolted against me. You have caused many people to be killed.

The rebels are deep in slaughter: There is a textual issue here:

1. The Masoretic Text has “and rebels have made deep slaughter/corruption.” For example:

And the revolvers have gone deep into slaughter (ESV) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NET, NCV, NIV)

1. Some scholars think that the original Hebrew text was “they have made deep the pit of Shittim.” This is a figure of speech that is similar to the trap metaphors in 5:1c. The meaning is also similar. For example:

They have dug the ditch deep at Shittim (NJB) (CEV, GNT, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. It makes sense, fits the context, and does not require a different original text. Scholars agree that the Masoretic Text is difficult to understand. Two of the three words, *šēʾim* “rebels” and *šāḥaṣah* “slaughter/corruption” occur only once in the OT, and the derivation of the second word is uncertain. However, option (2) involves at least three changes to the text, for which there is no clear evidence. For more details, see the NET footnote on TW or Macintosh (pages 178–181).

The rebels: In this context, The rebels implies people who have rebelled against the LORD. It refers to the same groups of people that are referred to in 5:1a.

are deep in slaughter: There are different ways to interpret the Hebrew noun that the BSB translates as slaughter:

1. The Hebrew noun comes from a verb root that means “kill, slaughter.” The phrase deep in slaughter means that they are responsible for killing many people. For example:

The revolvers are deeply involved in slaughter (NKJV)

The rebels have caused many people to be killed. (BSB, ESV, NET, NIV, NKJV)

1. The Hebrew noun comes from a verb root that means “corrupt.” According to TWOT (#2362b), “many modern commentators” suggest that *šāḥaṣah* “slaughtering” in the Masoretic Text should be changed to *šāḥatah* “destruction/corruption.” Morag, quoted in Macintosh (pages 179–180), gives another alternative. He argues that *šāḥaṣah* is simply a variant spelling of *šāḥatah*. None of the commentaries used in preparing these Notes recommended the textual change mentioned by TWOT.

Of the lexicons consulted, HOL lists this word with the meaning “corruption.” BDB, TWOT, HALOT, and NIDOTTE list it with the meaning “slaughter.” The phrase “deep in corruption” means that they are responsible for many evil deeds. It does not refer specifically to officials who take bribes or other government corruption. For example:

You are deeply involved in sin. (GW)

The rebels have done many evil things (NAB, NASB, NCV)

Interpretation (1) will be used in the Display. It is supported by most of the lexicons. It also offers the most straightforward explanation of the word that is used in the Masoretic Text.

However, you may also use interpretation (2). This interpretation is easier to apply to the people of Israel as a whole. It also closely matches a very similar expression in Hosea 9:9 that uses forms of the same Hebrew words.

5:2b

but I will chastise them all.

- Therefore I will discipline them all.
- So I am going to punish all of you^(plur).

I will chastise: In this context, the word chastise means to punish someone in order to correct their bad behavior. The same word is used of a parent who disciplines a child. For example:

punish (GNT)

them all: This phrase refers to both the leaders and the people of Israel. The GNT says “all of you” instead of them all. That is because the Hebrew text in 5:1 uses the pronoun “you” to refer to the leaders and people. The GNT uses the same pronoun here, since the LORD is speaking to the same people as in 5:1. Translate this phrase in a natural way in your language.

Hosea 5:3

Section 5:1–7: The LORD will judge the people of Israel and Judah

In 5:1–4, the LORD condemned the people of Israel and Judah, including the priests and leaders, for their corruption, immorality, and idolatry. In 5:5–7, he warned them that he would leave them and allow them to be destroyed.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel and Judah will be judged (CEV)

Punishment Coming for Israel and Judah (ESV)

Paragraph 5:1–4

In this paragraph, the LORD made an accusation against the people of Israel. He made it clear that he knew everything they did. Nothing was hidden from him. He concluded by declaring that his people no longer knew him.

Since this paragraph occurs at the beginning of a new section, it may be helpful in some languages to make explicit that the LORD is the one who was speaking. For example, the CEV begins this paragraph with:

The Lord said (CEV)

Here is another way to introduce the paragraph:

The LORD continued to speak. He said

5:3a–b (combined/reordered)

- I see every evil thing that the people of Israel secretly do.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{3a} I know all about **Ephraim**,

^{3b} and **Israel** is not hidden from Me.

In Hebrew and in the BSB, the parallel parts are arranged in the form of a chiasm. The parts in 5:3a occur in the opposite order from the parallel parts in 5:3b. Some versions do not use a chiasm. For example:

^{3a} **Ephraim** have I known,

^{3b} **Israel** is not hidden from me; (NJB)

Use an order that is natural in your language.

In these lines the LORD indicated that he knows everything that the people of Israel do. In some languages, it may be helpful to make explicit what the LORD knows about the people. For example:

^{3a} I know Ephraim all too well;

^{3b} the evil of Israel is not hidden from me. (NET)

I know all about...is not hidden from Me: Each of these two phrases has a similar meaning. In this context, the meaning is that the LORD knows all about the evil deeds of the people. They may think that they are doing evil in secret, but he sees everything they do. The REB interprets these parallel phrases in a positive sense. It has: “I have cared for Ephraim and not neglected Israel.” The NJB is more literal. It has: “Ephraim have I known, Israel is not hidden from me.” However, it probably follows the same interpretation as the REB, because it introduces the next two lines (5:3c–d) as a contrast, similar to the REB.

Ephraim...Israel: In these parallel lines, Ephraim is probably a figure of speech (synecdoche) that represents all the people of the nation of Israel.

General Comment on 5:3a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine one or more of the parallel parts. For example:

I know what Israel is like—she cannot hide from me. (GNT)

I know what you are like, O Israel! (NLT96)

5:3a

I know all about Ephraim,

- I know what the descendants/people of Ephraim are like.
- I see everything that you^(plur) Israelites do.

5:3b

and Israel is not hidden from Me.

- Yes, I know the evil secrets of the Israelites.
- Nothing you^(plur) do is hidden from me.

5:3c–d

(combined/reordered)

- Yes, the Israelites are like a prostitute. They are not fit to worship me.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{3c}For now, O Ephraim, you have **turned to prostitution**;

^{3d} Israel **is defiled**.

There are at least two ways to interpret the connection between 5:3c–d and 5:3a–b:

1. Line 5:3c begins with two Hebrew words that indicate emphasis. These words introduce parallel statements (5:3c-d) that explain in more detail what the LORD said in 5:3a-b. The two Hebrew words are *ki 'attah*. A number of English versions, including the RSV, NASB, and ESV, translate these words as “for now.” These versions may intend these words to have an explanatory relationship to 5:3a-b. Commentaries do not support a causal relationship. These statements specify that Ephraim has turned to prostitution and Israel is corrupt. For example:

Behold, you have fornicated, O Ephraim; Israel has defiled himself! (NJPS) (BSB, NJPS)

1. Line 5:3c begins with two Hebrew words that indicate a contrast. These words introduce parallel statements (5:3c-d) that contrast with what the LORD said in 5:3a-b. According to this interpretation, the LORD knew and cared for Ephraim/Israel, but they responded by turning to immorality and defiling themselves. For example:

but now Ephraim has become promiscuous and Israel has brought defilement on himself (REB) (NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The some versions leave the connection between 5:3c-d and 5:3a-b implied.

Ephraim...Israel: See the note for 5:3a-b.

you have turned to prostitution: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as you have turned to prostitution is the same word as in 4:10 and 4:18. It means “fornication” with a person or “unfaithfulness” towards God. Here it probably means both at the same time.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

she has been unfaithful (GNT)

Ephraim has become promiscuous (REB)

is defiled: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as is defiled is literally “it has made itself unclean.” The word refers to the people’s moral impurity. It also refers to their spiritual impurity that was caused by breaking the commands of their covenant with the LORD. The people were guilty of both kinds of impurity.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

Israel is corrupt (NIV)

I find you unacceptable (CEV)

her people are unfit to worship me (GNT)

General Comment on 5:3c-d

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the parallel parts. For example:

Now that Israel acts like a prostitute, it has made itself unclean. (NCV)

Israel has defiled herself like a prostitute!

5:3c

For now, O Ephraim, you have turned to prostitution;

- Indeed! You^(plur) descendants/people of Ephraim are unfaithful to me like an adulteress is unfaithful to her husband.

5:3d

Israel is defiled.

- You^(plur) people of Israel are defiled!

Hosea 5:4

Section 5:1-7: The LORD will judge the people of Israel and Judah

In 5:1-4, the LORD condemned the people of Israel and Judah, including the priests and leaders, for their corruption, immorality, and idolatry. In 5:5-7, he warned them that he would leave them and allow them to be destroyed.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel and Judah will be judged (CEV)

Punishment Coming for Israel and Judah (ESV)

Paragraph 5:1-4

In this paragraph, the LORD made an accusation against the people of Israel. He made it clear that he knew everything they did. Nothing was hidden from him. He concluded by declaring that his people no longer knew him.

Since this paragraph occurs at the beginning of a new section, it may be helpful in some languages to make

explicit that the LORD is the one who was speaking. For example, the CEV begins this paragraph with:

The Lord said (CEV)

Here is another way to introduce the paragraph:

The LORD continued to speak. He said

5:4a

Their deeds do not permit them to return to their God,

- Their evil deeds prevent them from returning to their God.
- Because of their evil deeds, they will not return to me, their God.
- You^(plur) refuse to stop doing what is wicked and return to me, your God.

Their deeds do not permit them to return to their God: This clause is a figure of speech (personification). It describes evil deeds as if they have the ability to control a person.

Here are some ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the figure of speech. This is the best option if the figure is natural in your language and people will understand the meaning correctly. For example:

Their wicked deeds do not allow them to return to their God. (NET)

- Translate the meaning without using the figure of speech. This is a good option if the figure of speech is unnatural or confusing in your language. For example:

They will not give up their deeds and return to their God. (NCV)

Your evil deeds are the reason you won't return to me (CEV)

They do not want to stop doing evil, so they are not able to return to their God.

deeds: The word deeds refers here to the evil things that people do.

5:4b

for a spirit of prostitution is within them,

- They constantly want to commit immorality.

- A strong urge to be unfaithful is what motivates them.
- Your^(plur) intense desire to be immoral and to worship idols affects all your thoughts and decisions.

for a spirit of prostitution is within them: This clause means that their thoughts and decisions are motivated by their strong desire to be immoral and to worship idols.

spirit of prostitution: See the note on spirit of prostitution in 4:12c.

is within them: This phrase refers to attitudes and thoughts. Some languages use a body organ, such as the liver, to signify attitudes and thoughts. Use an expression that is natural in your language for this purpose.

Here is another way to translate this line:

A spirit of prostitution is in their heart (NIV)

5:4c

and they do not know the LORD.

- They do not know Yahweh or acknowledge his authority.
- You^(plur) do not know and obey me, Yahweh.

and they do not know the LORD: In Hebrew, this clause is literally “the LORD they do not know.” It means that they do not know the LORD or have a relationship with him. They do not know what the LORD wants his people to do. It is implied that they do not acknowledge his authority or obey him. See the note on “no knowledge of God” in 4:1d, where it probably has the same meaning.

Hosea 5:5

Section 5:1–7: The LORD will judge the people of Israel and Judah

In 5:1–4, the LORD condemned the people of Israel and Judah, including the priests and leaders, for their corruption, immorality, and idolatry. In 5:5–7, he warned them that he would leave them and allow them to be destroyed.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel and Judah will be judged (CEV)

Punishment Coming for Israel and Judah (ESV)

Paragraph 5:5–7

In this paragraph, the LORD told the people of Israel and Judah that because they arrogantly refused to stop their sin, he would withdraw from them and allow them to be destroyed. This withdrawal and destruction is part of the discipline he spoke about in 5:2.

5:5a**Israel's arrogance testifies against them;**

- ¶ “Israel’s arrogance is like a witness who accuses him.
- ¶ “The people of Israel are proud of their nation. Their pride is like a witness who accuses him of doing wrong,
- ¶ “You people of Israel are so proud! Your^(plur) pride shows/proves that you^(plur) are guilty. You refuse to rely on Yahweh.

Israel's arrogance testifies against them: In this clause, the people of Israel are described figuratively as if they are on trial in a courtroom. Israel's arrogance is personified as a witness that makes an accusation against them.

Here are some ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the personification. This is the best option if this figure of speech is natural in your language and people will understand the meaning correctly. For example:

Israel's arrogance is his accuser. (NJB)

- Change the personification into a simile. For example:

Israel's pride is like a witness who accuses him of wrong.

- Translate the meaning directly. This is a good option if a figure of speech is unnatural or confusing in your language. For example:

The arrogance of the people of Israel shows that they are guilty of not relying on the Lord.

Israel's arrogance: The verse itself does not specify the nature of Israel's arrogance. This phrase probably refers to the people's pride in the history, wealth, and strength of their nation. Because of their proud attitude, they did not realize that their nation was actually very weak, so they refused to turn from their sin and acknowledge the LORD. McComiskey (page 78) and Andersen and Freedman (page 392) agree that

Israel is proud of its own wealth and achievements as a nation. McComiskey comments that Israel is unaware that this source of pride is actually “in a state of decay.” Hubbard (page 115) identifies this pride as “self-reliance, failure to depend on God utterly,” and Andersen and Freedman mention “the belief that there is no need for repentance.” According to Lange (page 60), their pride resulted in “presumptuous self-reliance,” and Pusey (page 58) mentions that Israel's pride showed itself in their refusal to turn to God.

This phrase occurs in a similar context in 7:10.

5:5b–c**(combined/reordered)**

- Because of their sins, Yahweh will severely punish Israel and Judah.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{5b} Israel and Ephraim **stumble in their iniquity;**

^{5c}even Judah **stumbles** with them

5:5b**Israel and Ephraim stumble in their iniquity;**

- Israel will stumble. Yes, the people of Ephraim will stumble when Yahweh judges them because of their sins.
- and Israel will stumble and fall because of it.
- You^(plur) will suffer because of your sin.

Israel and Ephraim: The two names probably refer to the same group of people, the people of Israel. The repetition may be for poetic effect or emphasis. See the note on “Ephraim...Israel” at 5:3a–b.

stumble in their iniquity: The word stumble is a figure of speech (metaphor). In this context, it probably refers to future punishment or judgment. The LORD will punish his people because of their sin. This judgment is compared to stumbling and falling.

Some versions make this meaning more explicit. For example:

Israel and Ephraim will be overthrown because of their iniquity. (NET)

The same word was used in 4:5a.

5:5c**even Judah stumbles with them.**

- The people of Judah will stumble with them.
- Judah too will collapse.

- Even you, people of Judah, you^(plur) also will suffer for your sins.

even Judah stumbles with them: The people of the kingdom of Judah are also guilty. Therefore the LORD will judge them also.

Here is another way to translate this line:

Even Judah will be brought down with them. (NET)

General Comment on 5:5b–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine these parallel statements into one line. For example:

Israel and Judah will stumble and fall because of the LORD's severe judgment.

Hosea 5:6

Section 5:1–7: The LORD will judge the people of Israel and Judah

In 5:1–4, the LORD condemned the people of Israel and Judah, including the priests and leaders, for their corruption, immorality, and idolatry. In 5:5–7, he warned them that he would leave them and allow them to be destroyed.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel and Judah will be judged (CEV)

Punishment Coming for Israel and Judah (ESV)

Paragraph 5:5–7

In this paragraph, the LORD told the people of Israel and Judah that because they arrogantly refused to stop their sin, he would withdraw from them and allow them to be destroyed. This withdrawal and destruction is part of the discipline he spoke about in 5:2.

5:6

In this verse, Hosea describes one aspect of the coming judgment. When the people go to a place of worship to ask for the LORD's help, he will not be there.

5:6a

They go with their flocks and herds to seek the LORD, but they do not find Him;

- When they go with their flocks of sheep and herds of cattle to sacrifice to Yahweh and ask for his help, they will not find him.
- Although you^(plur) offer many sheep and cattle to me, Yahweh, it is useless,

The BSB follows the Hebrew by not having a conjunction here, but in some languages it may be helpful to use a word to introduce the clause.

Here are some ways to introduce the clause:

- Leave the time of the event implied. For example:

With their flocks and herds they shall go to seek the Lord (NRSV)

- Use a word such as “when” or “whenever” to indicate that this event has not yet occurred. For example:

When they come with their flocks and herds to offer sacrifices to the Lord (NLT)

- Use a word such as “though” or “although” here. For example:

Though they go in search of Yahweh with their sheep and cattle, they will not find him (NJB)

Any of these translation options accurately describes the relationship between these two clauses. Use an option that is natural in your language.

They go with their flocks and herds to seek the LORD: This clause describes a time when the people go to a shrine or other place of worship to ask the LORD for help or guidance.

They: This pronoun probably refers to the people of both kingdoms of Israel and Judah.

go with their flocks and herds to seek the LORD: The people bring their flocks and herds so that they can offer them in worship as sacrifices to the LORD. In some languages, it may be helpful to make some of this information explicit. For example:

They go with sacrifices of sheep and cattle to seek the Lord (REB)

They will come to worship the Lord, bringing their flocks and herds (NCV)

flocks and herds: The word flocks refers to small animals such as sheep and goats. The word herds refers to large animals such as cows or oxen. Hubbard (page 115). These words also imply large numbers of animals.

they do not find Him: This phrase means that the LORD will not be present in their times of worship.

Even though they offer many animal sacrifices, the LORD will reject the people and will not answer their prayers.

5:6b

He has withdrawn Himself from them.

- He has left them.
- because I have abandoned you^(plur).

He has withdrawn Himself from them: This is the reason the people will not find the LORD. It is because he has withdrawn himself from them. He has abandoned them and will no longer accept their sacrifices or help them.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

for he has left them (GNT)

It is suggested that you add a footnote here that gives the LORD's warnings in Deuteronomy 31:17-18, 32:20 as a cross-reference.

Hosea 5:7

Section 5:1-7: The LORD will judge the people of Israel and Judah

In 5:1-4, the LORD condemned the people of Israel and Judah, including the priests and leaders, for their corruption, immorality, and idolatry. In 5:5-7, he warned them that he would leave them and allow them to be destroyed.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel and Judah will be judged (CEV)

Punishment Coming for Israel and Judah (ESV)

Paragraph 5:5-7

In this paragraph, the LORD told the people of Israel and Judah that because they arrogantly refused to stop their sin, he would withdraw from them and allow them to be destroyed. This withdrawal and destruction is part of the discipline he spoke about in 5:2.

5:7a

They have been unfaithful to the LORD;

- They have been treacherous/deceitful toward Yahweh.
- They have betrayed Yahweh. (NJB)
- You^(plur) have not been faithful to me.

They have been unfaithful to the LORD: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as unfaithful means to deal treacherously with someone. Here it is a figure

of speech (metaphor) in which the people's unfaithfulness to the LORD is compared to unfaithfulness in a marriage. The people are unfaithful in the sense that they have broken their vow that they will worship only the LORD in order to worship Baal instead.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

They have betrayed Yahweh (NJB)

They have dealt treacherously against the Lord (NASB)

5:7b

for they have borne illegitimate children.

- Their children are like bastards, for they do not belong to him.
- This is true, because they have given birth to children who worship idols like they do.
- For your^(plur) children do the evil things that you do. I am not their father.

they have borne illegitimate children: This is a metaphor. The children are illegitimate in the sense that they do not belong to the LORD, the figurative husband of their mother. Instead, they worship Baal/idols like their mother did. McComiskey (pages 78-79) and Wood (page 90).

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor of illegitimate children. For example:

for they have borne illegitimate children (NRSV)

for their children are bastards (REB)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. Consider making the similarity of the children to bastards explicit. For example:

Their children are like bastards. They do not belong to him.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

their children do not belong to him (GNT)

If you use the third option, consider adding a footnote that gives the figure of speech. If you use one of the first two options, consider using a footnote that

explains the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

In this verse, the people of Israel are compared to a wife whose husband is the LORD. The wife has been unfaithful. She has worshiped idols rather than the LORD. The children of the Israelites are called illegitimate children, because they also worship idols like their parents do.

5:7c

Now the New Moon will devour them along with their land.

- So now their New Moon festivals will be the reason that they and their crops are destroyed.
- So because of the sinful/wicked way that they celebrate the New Moon festivals, Yahweh will cause them and their crops/lands to be destroyed.
- Therefore, very soon, the hypocritical rituals that you perform at the time of the New Moon celebrations will result in your^(plur) downfall. You and your crops will experience ruin.

Now the New Moon will devour them along with their land: This sentence describes the LORD's judgment against the people of Israel. It indicates that he will cause the people and their fields to be destroyed as a result of the sinful way that they celebrate the New Moon festivals. See the examples at the end of this note for some ways to translate this sentence.

Now: The word Now indicates that the judgment will start at that time or very soon. For example:

Soon the new moon festival... (NET)

This judgment is the result of the people's unfaithfulness in 5:7a-b. Some versions make explicit that this is the result. For example:

So now (GNT)

the New Moon: This probably refers here, as in 2:11b, to the monthly religious celebrations that the people held on the first day of each month. There is no scholarly consensus on the meaning of *hodesh* "new moon." Some English versions, such as the RSV, NJB, ESV, and NASB) simply translate the Hebrew literally as "a new moon shall/will devour them..." The CEV interprets the word as a time phrase, "at the New Moon Festival." The NLT and NCV generalize the idea of "new moon festival" to "false religion/worship." The REB follows an emended text that has "a new people" instead of

"a new moon." It has: "an invader." McComiskey (page 79), Keil (page 89), and Wood (page 190) support the interpretation followed in the Notes. At these festivals they offered sacrifices to the LORD, as they were originally commanded in Numbers 10:10, Numbers 28:11-15, and other passages.

It is implied from the context that the people angered the LORD by the way they celebrated these festivals. They may have done so hypocritically, as external rituals, while they continued to live wicked lives (see Isaiah 1:13-14). They may also have adopted Canaanite rituals as part of the festival. According to Andersen and Freedman (page 396), the Canaanites also celebrated New Moon festivals as part of their pagan religion.

In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this implied information explicit. For example:

the wicked/hypocritical way that they celebrate the New Moon festivals

will devour them: In Hebrew, the word devour is literally "eat." In this context, it is used figuratively to mean "destroy." The destruction can be caused by drought, famine, disease, or human enemies. NIDOTTE (#430). Here it probably refers to enemy armies that will destroy the people and their fields. Try not to specify exactly how the people will be destroyed. For example:

will cause them to be destroyed

will bring destruction upon them

along with their land: In Hebrew, this phrase refers to either land or fields. In this context, the meaning is similar. Both land and fields refer to places where grain is grown and where animals are raised.

Here are some other ways to translate 5:7c:

Therefore, you and your crops will soon be destroyed. This will happen because of your new moon rituals.

So now, as a result of the wrong/false way that they worship me when it is time for the new moon, I will bring destruction on them and their lands.

Hosea 5:8

Section 5:8–15: The LORD will judge the people by war

In 5:8–11, the LORD warned Israel and Judah that he would soon destroy them by means of the enemy that had come to wage war against them. He also accused them of various kinds of sin. In 5:12–15, the LORD compared his judgment to destructive things like a moth, wood rot, and a lion. He assured the people that they would be destroyed in spite of their attempt to get help from Assyria. We do not know with certainty the date and the details of the war. However, some scholars believe that this is the war that is mentioned in 2 Kings 16:5–9 and 2 Chronicles 28:5–23. This may be the Syro-Ephraimite war, 735–732 B.C.E. In that war the kingdoms of Israel and Syria united to fight against the kingdoms of Assyria and Judah. The war greatly harmed both Israel and Judah. Israel and Syria lost the war, and the king of Assyria took control of most of the land of Israel. See Andersen and Freedman (pages 402–403), Hubbard (pages 118–122), Stuart (page 101), and Macintosh (page 194) for more details.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

War between Judah and Israel (GNT)

The Lord warns Israel and Judah (CEV)

5:8a–c (combined/reordered)

- ¶ “Your^(plur) enemies are coming! Blow the horns/trumpets to warn everyone in Gibeah, Ramah, and Beth-aven!”

The ESV has been used as the source line in 5:8a–c, because it follows the interpretation that is recommended for 5:8c.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{8a} Blow the horn in **Gibeah**, (ESV)

^{8b} the trumpet in **Ramah**. (ESV)

^{8c} Sound the alarm at **Beth-aven** (ESV)

These actions signaled that an enemy army was approaching. When an enemy army was near a city, the watchmen or soldiers who guarded the city blew a horn or a trumpet or in some way sounded an alarm.

These three parallel lines emphasize that it was a time of war.

(ESV) Blow the horn...the trumpet...Sound the alarm: In this verse, the purpose of all three actions is the same. There are two main ways to interpret this purpose:

1. Their purpose was to warn the people. They gave a signal to the people that they should move to the safety of their city along with their flocks and cattle. Macintosh (page 194). For example:

“Blow the horn in Gibeah and the trumpet in Ramah. Give the warning at Beth Aven (NCV) (CEV, ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NJPS, NRSV) Most of these versions have “sound the alarm.” The implicit purpose of “sound the alarm” in these versions is probably to warn. However, it is also possible to interpret the purpose as a call to do battle.

1. Their purpose was to summon their soldiers to fight against the enemy. For example:

“Sound the trumpet in Gibeah, the horn in Ramah. Raise the battle cry in Beth Aven. (NIV) (BSB, GNT, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries. However, it is possible that the purpose was both to warn the people and also to summon their troops into battle.

horn: The horn or “shophar” was an instrument made from a ram’s horn.

trumpet: The trumpet was a long, slender instrument made of metal.

Sound the alarm: This command may refer to blowing into one of the instruments. It may also refer to shouting an alarm. In some languages, it may be necessary to indicate what the warning or alarm was about. If that is true in your language, try to use an expression that will allow for both interpretations (1) and (2). For example:

Warn the people...that their enemies are coming.

Give a signal to the people...that they need to prepare for war.

(ESV) Gibeah...Ramah...Beth-aven: These three cities were located in the territory of the tribe of

Benjamin. This territory was located between the northern kingdom of Israel and the southern kingdom of Judah. According to Wood (page 191), Gibeah and Ramah were located near the northern border of Judah. Bethel was located near the southern border of Israel. See 1 Kings 12:28–29.

Beth-aven: Here Beth-aven probably refers to Bethel. The name Beth-aven means “house of wickedness.” Some alternate ways that versions spell this name are Beth Aven and Bethaven. See also the note on Beth-aven in 4:15b.

General Comment on 5:8a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these parallel statements. For example:

Blow the horns and trumpets to warn your fellow residents that war is about to begin. Give/Shout the alarm in Gibeah, Ramah, and Beth-aven.

Signal everyone in Gibeah, Ramah, and Beth-aven to prepare for the arrival of their enemies.

5:8a

Blow the ram’s horn in Gibeah,

- יל “The enemy is coming! Blow^(plur) the horn in the city of Gibeah to warn the people of danger.

5:8b

the trumpet in Ramah;

- Blow the trumpet in the city of Ramah.

5:8c

raise the battle cry in Beth-aven:

- Warn the people of Beth-aven that their enemies are coming.”
- Shout/Signal to the people in/at the city of Beth Aven to prepare for battle.”

5:8d

Lead on, O Benjamin!

- “We^(excl) will follow you^(plur) in battle, men of Benjamin.”
- The allies of Benjamin said, “Warriors of Benjamin, you go first, we will follow.”

Lead on, O Benjamin: There is a textual issue here as well as an interpretation issue. First the Notes will discuss the textual issue:

1. The Masoretic Text has a phrase that means “after/ behind you, Benjamin!” For example:

We are behind you, Benjamin! (NJB) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The LXX has a phrase that means “Tremble, O Benjamin!” For example:

Tremble in fear, O Benjamin! (NET) (NET, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow textual option (1) along with most English versions.

There are three ways to interpret the Hebrew phrase that is literally “after/behind you, Benjamin:”

1. The Hebrew phrase “after/behind you, Benjamin!” is a promise. The people shouting this phrase are promising to follow the soldiers of Benjamin into battle. They will be allies with the tribe of Benjamin against a common enemy. For example:

we follow you, O Benjamin! (ESV) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB)

1. The Hebrew phrase “after/behind you, Benjamin!” is a rallying cry. The people shouting this phrase are giving a signal to the army of Benjamin to begin fighting. For example:

Into battle, men of Benjamin! (GNT) (GNT, NCV)

1. The Hebrew phrase “after/behind you, Benjamin!” is a warning. The people shouting this phrase are warning the people of Benjamin that the enemy army is located behind them. The enemy is at their border and is about to attack. For example:

look behind you, Benjamin! (NRSV) (CEV, NAB, NASB, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). However, interpretation (2) is also acceptable. Both interpretations indicate that it was time to fight the enemy. The expression “after/behind you, Benjamin” is from the song of war of Deborah in Judges 5:14. The people of Hosea’s time probably knew the expression well. However, the historical situation is different, so the participants may not be the same.

General Comment on 5:8a–d

In 5:8a–c the LORD is the speaker. He told the sentries to warn the people. In 5:8d there is a change of speaker. We do not know who promised to follow Ben-

jamin, but clearly they were friends or allies. In some languages, it may be necessary to make the change of speaker explicit. For example:

^{8d} The friends/allies of the people of Benjamin said, “Men of Benjamin, we will follow you.”

Hosea 5:9

Section 5:8–15: The LORD will judge the people by war

In 5:8–11, the LORD warned Israel and Judah that he would soon destroy them by means of the enemy that had come to wage war against them. He also accused them of various kinds of sin. In 5:12–15, the LORD compared his judgment to destructive things like a moth, wood rot, and a lion. He assured the people that they would be destroyed in spite of their attempt to get help from Assyria. We do not know with certainty the date and the details of the war. However, some scholars believe that this is the war that is mentioned in 2 Kings 16:5–9 and 2 Chronicles 28:5–23. This may be the Syro-Ephraimite war, 735–732 B.C.E. In that war the kingdoms of Israel and Syria united to fight against the kingdoms of Assyria and Judah. The war greatly harmed both Israel and Judah. Israel and Syria lost the war, and the king of Assyria took control of most of the land of Israel. See Andersen and Freedman (pages 402–403), Hubbard (pages 118–122), Stuart (page 101), and Macintosh (page 194) for more details.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

War between Judah and Israel (GNT)

The Lord warns Israel and Judah (CEV)

5:9

In this verse, the LORD is again the speaker. He describes what will certainly happen to the land and people of Israel when he punishes them.

5:9a

Ephraim will be laid waste on the day of rebuke.

- “Indeed, the day of judgment/punishment is coming, and the nation of Israel will be completely destroyed.
- Yahweh said, “When it is time for me to punish the people of Israel, I will destroy their land/country. The sight of it will be horrifying.

Ephraim will be laid waste: In Hebrew, this clause is literally “Ephraim will become a waste/horror.” According to NIDOTTE (#9014), the basic meaning of

this Hebrew word is “that which causes horror” when someone sees it. TWOT (#2409d) similarly defines this word as “waste, horror, appallment,” and says that it “stresses the horror caused by the desolation of judgment.” It indicates that an enemy will destroy the cities and fields of Israel, leaving the land deserted. It also indicates that when people see the terrible destruction, the sight will cause them to feel horrified.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Israel will be ruined (GNT)

you will become a heap of rubble (NLT)

the destruction of Israel will cause horror in anyone who sees it

Ephraim: In this context, the word Ephraim is probably a figure of speech (synecdoche) that represents the land of Israel. This use of the word is slightly different from its use in 5:3a, 5:3c, and 5:5b, where it represents the people rather than the land. See the note on “Ephraim...Israel” at 5:3a–b.

on the day of rebuke: In Hebrew, the phrase day of rebuke could also be translated as the “day of punishment.” The BART interlinear has “rebuke.” NIDOTTE (#9349) glosses this word as “rebuke, correction, punishment.” It refers to the time when the LORD will punish the people. In this context, the word day refers to a period of time. It does not refer to a literal day.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the time for punishment (GW)

the day of punishment (GNT)

In some languages, it may be more natural to place this phrase at the beginning of the clause. It may also be necessary to make explicit the one who will punish the people. For example:

When the time comes for me to punish the people of Israel, I, the Lord, will destroy their land.

5:9b

Among the tribes of Israel I proclaim what is certain.

- These words that I, Yahweh, am telling all the people of Israel are indeed true.

- What I say in the hearing of all of you^(plur) tribes of Israel will certainly happen.

Among the tribes of Israel I proclaim what is certain: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

This is the certain doom I have decreed for Israel's tribes. (REB)

What I am declaring to the tribes of Israel will certainly take place! (NET)

People of Israel, this will surely happen! (GNT)

I proclaim: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “I make known.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

I will make...known (GW)

I tell (NCV)

Hosea 5:10

Section 5:8–15: The LORD will judge the people by war

In 5:8–11, the LORD warned Israel and Judah that he would soon destroy them by means of the enemy that had come to wage war against them. He also accused them of various kinds of sin. In 5:12–15, the LORD compared his judgment to destructive things like a moth, wood rot, and a lion. He assured the people that they would be destroyed in spite of their attempt to get help from Assyria. We do not know with certainty the date and the details of the war. However, some scholars believe that this is the war that is mentioned in 2 Kings 16:5–9 and 2 Chronicles 28:5–23. This may be the Syro-Ephraimite war, 735–732 B.C.E. In that war the kingdoms of Israel and Syria united to fight against the kingdoms of Assyria and Judah. The war greatly harmed both Israel and Judah. Israel and Syria lost the war, and the king of Assyria took control of most of the land of Israel. See Andersen and Freedman (pages 402–403), Hubbard (pages 118–122), Stuart (page 101), and Macintosh (page 194) for more details.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

War between Judah and Israel (GNT)

The Lord warns Israel and Judah (CEV)

5:10

In this verse, the focus shifts from the northern kingdom of Israel to the southern kingdom of Judah.

5:10a

The princes of Judah are like those who move boundary stones;

- The leaders of Judah are like a person who moves the stones that mark property boundaries to steal the land of their neighbors.
- I am also very angry with the people who rule Judah. They are like criminals who steal other people's land.

The princes of Judah are like those who move boundary stones: This statement is a simile. In this simile, the princes of Judah are compared to people who move a “landmark” (ESV) or “boundary markers” (NET). This was clearly prohibited in Deuteronomy 19:14 and Deuteronomy 27:17.

Scholars do not know specifically how Judah's princes were similar to people who moved boundary markers. Most scholars think that this verse refers to a wartime event in which Judah annexed land that belonged to Israel. These scholars include Andersen and Freedman, Macintosh, Stuart, Hubbard, and Davies. The GNT has followed this interpretation. It has: “the leaders of Judah have invaded Israel and stolen land from her.” Unfortunately, it is not possible to identify a particular historical event. Some scholars think that this verse refers instead to figurative/spiritual boundaries (Keil, Wood) or to other violations of human rights (McComiskey). Because of this uncertainty, it is recommended that you not follow a specific interpretation, as the GNT has done. However, we do know that people did this in order to steal land from their neighbors.

Here are some ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Make explicit that moving boundary stones was illegal. For example:

Judah's leaders are like crooks who move boundary markers (CEV)

- Translate the significance of the action but omit the specific reference to boundary stones. For example:

The leaders of Judah are like those who steal other people's land. (NCV)

The leaders of Judah have become like thieves (NLT)

The princes of Judah: This phrase refers to those who rule the kingdom of Judah. It includes the king, his officials, and military leaders.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The rulers of Judah (NJB)

Those who govern/rule Judah

5:10b

I will pour out My fury upon them like water.

- So I will also punish them. It will be as if they are carried away by a great flood of water.
- Therefore, I will punish them severely like a flood destroys everything that it reaches.

I will pour out My fury upon them like water: This verse part describes the LORD's response to the sin of the leaders of Judah. As a result of their sin, he will punish them severely. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this connection explicit. For example:

So... (GNT)

that's why... (CEV)

The LORD's fury is compared here to water. In this context, it implies a large quantity of water, such as in a flood. Here are some of the ways in which his anger is like water:

1. The amount of both is great and overwhelming.
2. Both cause great destruction.

Here are some other ways to translate this simile:

I will pour out punishment on them like a flood (GNT)

I will pour out my wrath on them like a flood of water (NIV)

I will flood them with my anger (CEV)

In some languages, verbs like pour out cannot be used with words like "wrath" or "punishment."

Here are some other ways to translate this simile:

I will punish them severely. It will be as if a terrible flood carries them away.

I am very angry at them. I will destroy them like a flood.

fury: This word refers here to the LORD's fierce anger that he expresses when he judges or punishes people.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

punishment (GNT)

rage (NET)

Hosea 5:11

Section 5:8–15: The LORD will judge the people by war

In 5:8–11, the LORD warned Israel and Judah that he would soon destroy them by means of the enemy that had come to wage war against them. He also accused them of various kinds of sin. In 5:12–15, the LORD compared his judgment to destructive things like a moth, wood rot, and a lion. He assured the people that they would be destroyed in spite of their attempt to get help from Assyria. We do not know with certainty the date and the details of the war. However, some scholars believe that this is the war that is mentioned in 2 Kings 16:5–9 and 2 Chronicles 28:5–23. This may be the Syro-Ephraimite war, 735–732 B.C.E. In that war the kingdoms of Israel and Syria united to fight against the kingdoms of Assyria and Judah. The war greatly harmed both Israel and Judah. Israel and Syria lost the war, and the king of Assyria took control of most of the land of Israel. See Andersen and Freedman (pages 402–403), Hubbard (pages 118–122), Stuart (page 101), and Macintosh (page 194) for more details.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

War between Judah and Israel (GNT)

The Lord warns Israel and Judah (CEV)

5:11

In this verse, the focus shifts from the southern kingdom of Judah back to the northern kingdom of Israel.

5:11a

Ephraim is oppressed, crushed in judgment,

- And as for the people of Israel, their enemies oppress and trample/crush them. This is my judgment against them,
- The time for me to punish the people of Israel has come. I will soon send their enemies to cause them severe hardship and suffering,

Ephraim is oppressed, crushed in judgment: This verse part implies that the people of Israel are oppressed by their enemies. This oppression is the means by which the LORD judges them.

In the preceding context, the judgment on Ephraim clearly refers to a future event (see 5:7, 5:9). The following context (5:14) also refers to a future event. Here in 5:11a, Hosea describes the judgment as if it has already begun. Scholars have not been able to identify the exact historical context. So we do not know if this judgment refers to the same future event as in 5:9a or if it refers to a different event that has already begun. Scripture records three invasions of Israel by Assyria: one during the reign of Menahem (2 Kings 15:19–20), one during the reign of Pekah (2 Kings 15:29), and the final defeat and exile of Israel during the reign of Hoshea (2 Kings 17:5–6). Hosea served as a prophet during this entire time. Examples of both options are given in the following note on “oppressed, trampled.” You may choose either option.

Ephraim: In this context, the tribe of Ephraim probably represents all the people of the nation of Israel. See the note on Ephraim...Israel at 5:3a–b.

oppressed, crushed: The words that the BSB translates as oppressed and crushed have almost the same meaning in this context. Both words are passive forms that refer to people who are being mistreated or caused hardship by their enemies.

The translations crushed and “trampled” are both figurative. They do not refer here to literal crushing or trampling. Use one or more literal or figurative terms in your language that refer to oppression.

Here are some other ways to translate this whole clause using passive forms:

Israel is crushed by the punishment (NCV)

The people of Israel will be crushed and broken by my judgment (NLT)

In some languages, it may be necessary to use active forms and to make explicit who oppresses the people of Israel and who judges them.

Here are some ways to translate this clause using active forms:

The time for me to punish the people of Israel has arrived. I will send their enemies to cause them great hardship and suffering.

The enemies of Israel oppress and mistreat them as a result of my judgment against them.

in judgment: This phrase indicates that the LORD allows an enemy to oppress and trample the people as his judgment or punishment against them.

5:11b
for he is determined to follow worthless idols.

- because they persist in worshiping idols.
- for they have decided to do what is worthless. They follow/worship false gods.

for he is determined to follow worthless idols: The reason Israel is oppressed and trampled in judgment is because they are intent on pursuing idols. Some versions translate this word as “because” (RSV). Other versions leave it implied. Use a natural way in your language to introduce this reason.

determined to follow: In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally “he was determined to walk after.” It means that the people had made a deliberate decision to follow something. BART interlinear.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

having deliberately followed (NJB)

decided to follow (NCV)

worthless idols: There are several textual and interpretation issues involving the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as worthless idols. Textual options followed by one or more English versions are: 1) The LXX, Targum, Peshitta, and Vulgate follow an emended text (šaw) that means “vanity,” “emptiness,” “futility,” or “worthlessness.” The NRSV, NJPS, and REB follow this text. 2) The ESV and NAB have “filth,” derived from the assumed root šw’ “filthy” (TWOT #1884). 3) The MT has šaw. This anomalous form occurs elsewhere only in Isaiah 28:10, 13, where it may represent a nonsense syllable or mimicry. The NASB and KJV understand it to mean “command” (derived from šawah), perhaps referring to Jeroboam’s establishment of idol worship at Bethel and Dan in 1 Kings 12:28–29. See TWOT (#1887c). (See the preceding and following footnote for details).

None of the textual choices literally means idols. However, in this context, most of the choices refer to idol worship, which was both worthless and filthy in the sight of God. Most English versions, including the BSB, CEV, GW, NCV, NET, NIV, and NLT, interpret one of the textual options to refer to idols. In other passages, idol worship is described as being worthless and filthy, and Jeroboam's command resulted in the people of Israel turning to idol worship. The NJB has "a Lie." The GNT has "going for help to those who had none to give." Both of these versions may be specific applications of the text followed by the LXX.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

worshiping useless idols (CEV)

pursuing what is worthless (REB)

follow idols (NCV)

determined to go after filth (ESV)

Hosea 5:12

Section 5:8–15: The LORD will judge the people by war

In 5:8–11, the LORD warned Israel and Judah that he would soon destroy them by means of the enemy that had come to wage war against them. He also accused them of various kinds of sin. In 5:12–15, the LORD compared his judgment to destructive things like a moth, wood rot, and a lion. He assured the people that they would be destroyed in spite of their attempt to get help from Assyria. We do not know with certainty the date and the details of the war. However, some scholars believe that this is the war that is mentioned in 2 Kings 16:5–9 and 2 Chronicles 28:5–23. This may be the Syro-Ephraimite war, 735–732 B.C.E. In that war the kingdoms of Israel and Syria united to fight against the kingdoms of Assyria and Judah. The war greatly harmed both Israel and Judah. Israel and Syria lost the war, and the king of Assyria took control of most of the land of Israel. See Andersen and Freedman (pages 402–403), Hubbard (pages 118–122), Stuart (page 101), and Macintosh (page 194) for more details.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

War between Judah and Israel (GNT)

The Lord warns Israel and Judah (CEV)

5:12a–b (combined/reordered)

- ¶ I will destroy Israel and Judah like a moth ruins clothes or like termites/disease cause(s) trees/wood to decay.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{12a}So I am like a moth **to Ephraim**,

^{12b}and like decay **to the house of Judah**.

These lines contain parallel similes. In these similes, the LORD compares himself to things that destroy. He will destroy the people of Ephraim and Judah like a moth destroys clothing or like wood or other things weaken and decay. See the General Comment on 5:12a–b for other ways to translate these parallel similes.

moth: The word moth refers here to a destructive kind of moth that makes holes in clothing. Some scholars (e.g., Stuart, page 105; Macintosh, page 207) think that this word is derived here from an Arabic root that means "pus." For example, the REB translates it as "festered sore." However, this meaning does not occur elsewhere in the OT. It is recommended that you follow the normal meaning for this Hebrew word. In some languages, there may not be a word for this kind of moth. If that is true in your language, you may use a word that refers to something with a similar function. For example:

worm/insect

decay: There are two ways to interpret the parallel word decay here:

1. It refers to something that causes wood to decay, become soft, or fall apart. For example:

wood rot (NET)

rot that destroys wood (GW) (BSB, NIV, ESV, GW, NET, NLT, RSV)

1. It refers to something that causes a part of the body to decay or become weak. For example:

gangrene (NJB) (NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. Many English versions use a general term such as “rot” or “rottenness.” These versions could refer to either interpretation. They include the CEV, KJV, NASB, NCV, NIV, and NRSV. The Display will follow this interpretation. However, you may also follow interpretation (2). In three out of five other verses that use the same Hebrew for “rot/rottenness,” it refers to rottenness of the bones. The Hebrew word *raqab* occurs five times in the OT. Proverbs 12:4 and 14:30 and Habakkuk 3:16 refer specifically to rot or decay of the bones. Job 13:28 and Hosea 5:12 do not specify. According to the Hebrew viewpoint in OT times, the bones were the source of bodily health and strength. People sometimes described physical or emotional suffering in terms of weakness or rottenness in their bones (NIDOTTE, #6795).

Ephraim...the house of Judah: The word Ephraim has the same meaning here as in 5:11a. The parallel phrase refers to the people of the nation of Judah.

General Comment on 5:12a–b

If these similes are not clear in your language, here are some other translation options:

- Make explicit the way in which the LORD is like a moth and like rot. For example:

^{12a}I will destroy Ephraim as a moth destroys clothing. (GW)

^{12b}I will destroy the nation of Judah as rot destroys wood.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

I will bring destruction on Israel and ruin on the people of Judah. (GNT)

- Use similar figures of speech that convey the right meaning in your language. For example:

^{12a}I will cause the people of Israel to be destroyed like locusts/grubs destroy plants.

^{12b}I will destroy the people of Judah like termites destroy wood.

In some languages, it may be clearer or more natural to combine and/or reorder the parallel parts, using one or more of the preceding options. For example:

I will destroy the nations of Israel and Judah like moths destroy clothes or dry rot weakens wood.

5:12a

So I am like a moth to Ephraim,

- ¶ “I will destroy the nation of Israel like a moth that destroys clothing/wool.
- ¶ “What I do to the people of Israel will be like locusts that destroy plants.

5:12b

and like decay to the house of Judah.

- I will destroy the nation of Judah like wood rot weakens/destroys trees.
- The way that I punish the people of Judah will be like termites that weaken and destroy wood/trees.

Hosea 5:13

Section 5:8–15: The LORD will judge the people by war

In 5:8–11, the LORD warned Israel and Judah that he would soon destroy them by means of the enemy that had come to wage war against them. He also accused them of various kinds of sin. In 5:12–15, the LORD compared his judgment to destructive things like a moth, wood rot, and a lion. He assured the people that they would be destroyed in spite of their attempt to get help from Assyria. We do not know with certainty the date and the details of the war. However, some scholars believe that this is the war that is mentioned in 2 Kings 16:5–9 and 2 Chronicles 28:5–23. This may be the Syro-Ephraimite war, 735–732 B.C.E. In that war the kingdoms of Israel and Syria united to fight against the kingdoms of Assyria and Judah. The war greatly harmed both Israel and Judah. Israel and Syria lost the war, and the king of Assyria took control of most of the land of Israel. See Andersen and Freedman (pages 402–403), Hubbard (pages 118–122), Stuart (page 101), and Macintosh (page 194) for more details.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

War between Judah and Israel (GNT)

The Lord warns Israel and Judah (CEV)

5:13a–b

(combined/reordered)

- When the leaders of Israel and Judah became aware that their nations were like a person who had a terrible disease or had many infected sores/wounds,

- When the people who ruled Israel and Judah saw/ noticed that their countrymen were experiencing hardship and suffering,

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{13a}When Ephraim saw **his sickness**

^{13b}and Judah **his wound**,

These lines contain parallel metaphors. In these metaphors the LORD compares the hardship of the people of Israel and Judah to the suffering caused by a sickness and a wound.

When: This word introduces what happened at that time, following the start of the LORD's judgment. At that time, Ephraim and Judah realized their difficult situations. This word also introduces the reason that they turned to the king of Assyria for help in 5:13c-d.

Ephraim...Judah: Here these names probably refer particularly to the leaders of the kingdoms of Israel and Judah. The leaders are the ones who would turn to Assyria for help. If it will be clearer or more natural to make this information explicit in your language, you may do so. For example:

the leaders of Israel...the leaders of Judah

saw: In this context, this word means "became aware of" or "realized." For example:

when Ephraim became aware of his sickness
(NJPS)

When the leaders of Ephraim realized that their nation was sick

his sickness...his wound: The first of these parallel terms can refer to any illness or disease. The second term is more specific. It refers to an infected wound or to an oozing ulcer or boil. Here both terms are figurative. They probably refer to hardships or weakness that the people were experiencing as a result of war.

General Comment on 5:13a-b

In some languages, the metaphors in these parallel lines may be incorrectly understood as literal sickness or wounds.

If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate these metaphors:

- Change the metaphors to similes. If necessary, make explicit what is being compared. For example:

^{13a} The hardship that the people of Israel were experiencing was like a sickness.

^{13b} The people of Judah were suffering like a person who has infected/oozing sores/boils. When they saw this,

^{13a}When the leaders of Israel realized that the hardship of their people was like a sickness,

^{13b}and when the rulers of Judah found out that the people were as if covered with infected sores,

- Translate the meaning without using figures of speech. For example:

^{13a}When the people of Israel noticed the troubles that they were facing,

^{13b}when the people of Judah saw how weak their country had become,

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine these parallel statements. For example:

When Israel and Judah saw how sick they were
(NLT)

The leaders of Israel and Judah realized that their countries had become very weak and their people were undergoing great hardship.

5:13a

When Ephraim saw his sickness

- The leaders of Israel saw how weak their country was, like a very sick person.

5:13b

and Judah his wound,

- The leaders of Judah also realized how much their countrymen were suffering, like a person covered with sores.

5:13c-d

(combined/reordered)

- they asked the great king of Assyria for help.

- they sent messengers to request help from the powerful ruler in Assyria.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{13c}then Ephraim **turned to Assyria**,

^{13d}and **sent to the great king**.

These lines give the result of the action described in 5:13a–b. There it says that Ephraim and Judah saw their sicknesses.

Ephraim turned to Assyria and sent to the great king: There are two ways to interpret the subject of the verb sent in these parallel verse parts:

1. Both Ephraim and Judah turned to the king of Assyria for help. Judah is the implied subject of the verb sent in 5:13d. For example:

^{13c} Ephraim went to Assyria,

^{13d}and Judah sent to the great king. (NAB) (NAB)

1. Ephraim turned to the king of Assyria for help. Ephraim is the implied subject of the verb sent in the second line. For example:

^{13c}then Ephraim went to Assyria,

^{13d}and sent to the great king. (NRSV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NCV, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a slight majority of commentaries. Commentaries that support Judah as the subject of 5:13d include Andersen and Freedman, Davies, Hubbard, Macintosh, Stuart, and Pusey. Commentaries that support Ephraim/Israel as the subject of 5:13d as well as 5:13c include Keil, Wood, McComiskey, Lange, and probably Dearman. However, most versions follow interpretation (2). You may decide to follow (2) if it will be more acceptable to your readers.

The parallelism, pronoun use, and historical context all favor interpretation (1). To be more specific:

1. Ephraim and Judah occur as a parallel pair in both the preceding and following contexts (5:5b–c, 5:12a–b, 5:13a–b, and 5:14a–b).

2. The plural pronoun “you” in 5:13e–f suggests that both Ephraim and Judah are referred to here. Plural pronouns are also used in 5:6–7 and 5:15, where the context indicates both Ephraim and Judah. See Andersen and Freedman (page 413). Where the context refers to a single tribe or nation, singular pronouns, both second person and third person, are used consistently throughout this chapter. See especially 5:8d and 5:3c, where you^(sing) is used to refer to a single group.
3. Historically, King Hoshea of Israel and King Ahaz of Judah both sought the help of Assyria in situations that fit the context of these verses. Davies, Hubbard, and Stuart (cited above) all identify Hoshea and Ahaz as the kings that are referred to here.

turned to Assyria and sent to the great king: These two parallel phrases refer to the same event. They indicate that the leaders of Israel and Judah requested help from the king of Assyria. The KJV and NASB have “king Jareb” rather than “great king.” A large majority of commentators and versions support the meaning, “great king.” The king of Assyria was very powerful at that time.

In context, it is implied that the leaders sent for help. In some languages, it may be helpful to make this information explicit. For example:

and sent to the great king for help (NIV)

It is implied that the leaders sent representatives to request this help. In some languages, it may be helpful to make this information explicit. For example:

sent messengers (NJB)

General Comment on 5:13c–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these parallel statements. For example:

they each asked the king of Assyria to help them

5:13c

then Ephraim turned to Assyria

- So the leaders of Israel sent representatives to Assyria.

5:13d

and sent to the great king.

- The leaders/representatives of Judah also asked the great king there for help.

5:13e–f (combined/reordered)

- But he cannot heal what is wrong with you^(plur).
- But that ruler is not able to rescue you from your troubles/difficulties.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{13e}But he cannot cure **you**

^{13f}or heal **your wound**.

These lines continue to use the metaphors from 5:13a–b. Here the LORD compares the king's inability to relieve the people's hardships to a doctor's inability to cure an illness or an infected wound.

But: This word introduces a negative conclusion to the leaders' request for help in 5:13c–d. They hoped that the king of Assyria could help them, but he could not. Use a natural way in your language to introduce this kind of negative contrast.

he cannot cure you or heal your wound: These parallel lines both refer to the same situation. The king does not have the ability to cure their figurative sicknesses and wounds. He cannot deliver them from the hardships that result from the LORD's judgment.

you or...your: In Hebrew, these pronouns are plural. They probably refer to both Israel and Judah.

General Comment on 5:13e–f

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these parallel statements. For example:

But he is not able to rescue you from my punishment.

5:13e But he cannot cure you

- But the king cannot cure your^(plur) sicknesses.

5:13f or heal your wound.

- It is not possible for him to heal your^(plur) sores.

Hosea 5:14

Section 5:8–15: The LORD will judge the people by war

In 5:8–11, the LORD warned Israel and Judah that he would soon destroy them by means of the enemy that had come to wage war against them. He also accused them of various kinds of sin. In 5:12–15, the LORD

compared his judgment to destructive things like a moth, wood rot, and a lion. He assured the people that they would be destroyed in spite of their attempt to get help from Assyria. We do not know with certainty the date and the details of the war. However, some scholars believe that this is the war that is mentioned in 2 Kings 16:5–9 and 2 Chronicles 28:5–23. This may be the Syro-Ephraimite war, 735–732 B.C.E. In that war the kingdoms of Israel and Syria united to fight against the kingdoms of Assyria and Judah. The war greatly harmed both Israel and Judah. Israel and Syria lost the war, and the king of Assyria took control of most of the land of Israel. See Andersen and Freedman (pages 402–403), Hubbard (pages 118–122), Stuart (page 101), and Macintosh (page 194) for more details.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

War between Judah and Israel (GNT)

The Lord warns Israel and Judah (CEV)

5:14a–b (combined/reordered)

- For I myself will attack the people/nations of Israel and Judah. I will be like a fearsome lion/panther that kills his prey.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{14a}For I am like a lion **to Ephraim**,

^{14b}and like a young lion **to the house of Judah**

These lines contain parallel similes. In these similes, the LORD compares himself to a lion that attacks and destroys his prey.

For: This word introduces the reason that the king of Assyria cannot heal Ephraim and Judah. It is because the LORD himself is the one who attacks and destroys them like a powerful animal. No one is able to rescue them from the LORD's judgment.

I: In Hebrew, I is an emphatic pronoun. For example:

It is I who will be like a lion

Use a natural way in your language to indicate this emphasis on the LORD.

lion...young lion: In Hebrew, there is no clear difference in meaning between these parallel terms. The BSB translates the second word as young lion, but

the word probably has nothing to do with the lion's age. Hubbard (page 124). See also TWOT (#2363a) for the first term and TWOT (#1025a) for the second term.

There is no need to translate these two terms in different ways unless it is desirable for poetic style. In this context, the two terms function together to convey the idea of a dangerous and powerful animal that the Hebrew people greatly feared.

The word lion occurs figuratively in both the OT and NT, so it is recommended that you keep this figure of speech if possible. If lions are not known in your language group, you could substitute a similar animal that has the same figurative meaning and impact, such as a panther, leopard, or tiger.

General Comment on 5:14a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these parallel statements. For example:

For it is I who am like a fierce lion to Israel and Judah.

For I am the one that attacks Israel and Judah like a strong lion.

5:14a

For I am like a lion to Ephraim

- That is because I am the one that attacks Israel like a lion.

5:14b

and like a young lion to the house of Judah.

- I am like a fierce lion that pounces on Judah.

5:14a–d

(combined/reordered)

- You^(plur) people of Israel and Judah, there is no one who can rescue you from my punishment, for I am like a lion who tears you into pieces and carries you away.

5:14c

I, even I, will tear them to pieces and then go away.

- I myself will rip them apart and leave.
- It is I who will tear them to pieces/shreds and go off.
- I, yes I, will tear them apart!

5:14d

I will carry them off where no one can rescue them.

- I will carry them off as I go, and no one will be able to rescue them.
- They are my prey that I carry away, and there is no one who can save them.

5:14c–d

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning: These lines form a chiasm. The first part of 5:14c is “I, even I, will tear them to pieces.” This is similar to the second part of 5:14d “no one can rescue them.” The second part of 5:14c is “[I will] go away.” This is similar to the first part of 5:14d “I will carry them off.”

^{14c}I, even I, will tear them to pieces and then **go away**.

^{14d}I **will carry them off** where no one can rescue them.

In these lines, the LORD continues to compare himself to a lion who kills and carries off his prey. As in 5:14a–b, he emphasizes that he is the one who will destroy them. Since he is in control, no one is able to rescue them from his judgment.

I: In Hebrew, the pronoun I is repeated, literally “I, I.” It also occurs in an emphatic position in the clause. These two factors give it very strong emphasis.

Here is another way to indicate this emphasis:

I myself will tear them to pieces and then leave them. (GNT)

Translate this emphasis in a natural way in your language.

tear them to pieces...no one can rescue them: The first phrase describes what a lion does to its prey. The next phrase continues this description. No one will be able to rescue them from the lion that tears them to pieces. A lion kills and destroys. Similarly, the LORD will cause the people of Israel and of Judah to suffer and die. He will do that by giving their enemies the power to defeat them in war.

go away...carry them off: The parallel phrases go away and carry them off describe the same event. If they imply two separate events in your language, here are some translation options:

General Comment on 5:14a–d

- Make it clear that the two phrases refer to the same event. For example:

^{14c}I will tear them to pieces and go away,

^{14d} Yes, I will carry them off, with no one to rescue them.

^{14c} I, I will attack and stride away,

^{14d} Carrying the prey that no one can rescue (NJPS)

- Do not translate the phrase go away. This idea is already implied in the phrase carry them off. For example:

^{14c} I will tear them to pieces!

^{14d} I will carry them off, and no one will be left to rescue them. (NLT)

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these four verse parts. See 5:14a–d (combined/reordered) in the Display for an example.

Hosea 5:15

Section 5:8–15: The LORD will judge the people by war

In 5:8–11, the LORD warned Israel and Judah that he would soon destroy them by means of the enemy that had come to wage war against them. He also accused them of various kinds of sin. In 5:12–15, the LORD compared his judgment to destructive things like a moth, wood rot, and a lion. He assured the people that they would be destroyed in spite of their attempt to get help from Assyria. We do not know with certainty the date and the details of the war. However, some scholars believe that this is the war that is mentioned in 2 Kings 16:5–9 and 2 Chronicles 28:5–23. This may be the Syro-Ephraimite war, 735–732 B.C.E. In that war the kingdoms of Israel and Syria united to fight against the kingdoms of Assyria and Judah. The war greatly harmed both Israel and Judah. Israel and Syria lost the war, and the king of Assyria took control of most of the land of Israel. See Andersen and Freedman (pages 402–403), Hubbard (pages 118–122), Stuart (page 101), and Macintosh (page 194) for more details.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

War between Judah and Israel (GNT)

The Lord warns Israel and Judah (CEV)

5:15a

Then I will return to My place

- Then I will return to the place that is my home
- I will go back to my place in heaven

Then I will return to My place: In Hebrew, the word Then does not occur here. The BSB and some other versions have supplied it to introduce the next event. The word Then makes explicit that this event happens after the LORD completes the judgment of 5:14. Some versions leave this sequence implied. For example:

I will return again to my place (ESV)

Indicate this sequence of events in a natural way in your language.

I will return to My place: This clause concludes the figure of speech in which the LORD compares himself to a lion. A lion returns to its “lair” (NET) after killing its prey. Similarly, the LORD will return to his place in heaven after he punishes Israel and Judah. Since this clause does not continue to use figurative terms about a lion, it may be better to translate the term My place in a way that does not refer specifically to a lion’s den.

Here are some ways to translate My place:

- Use a general term that can refer to either the dwelling place of a lion or of the LORD. For example:

my place (NLT)

the place where I live/stay

- Use a specific term that refers to the dwelling place of the LORD. For example:

my home in heaven

- Translate the meaning without referring to a place. For example:

I will abandon my people (GNT)

5:15a–c

(combined/reordered)

- I will return to my place/home. I will remain there until they have suffered for their sin and they finally turn to me sincerely to worship me.”

5:15b

until they admit their guilt and seek My face;

- until they undergo the punishment for their sin and turn to me again to follow/worship me.

- and remain there until their suffering has led/caused them to seek my presence.

5:15c**in their affliction they will earnestly seek Me.”**

- They will become so distressed that they will eagerly look for me.”
- Because of their misery/suffering, they will long to worship me again.”

5:15b–c

The NCV has been used as the source line for 5:15b–c, because it follows the recommended interpretation and sentence structure. Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{15b}until they suffer for their guilt and **turn back to me.** (NCV)

^{15c}In their trouble **they will look for me.** (NCV)

(NCV) until: This word introduces the event that will end the time of the LORD’s withdrawal from the people of Israel and Judah. In some languages, it may be helpful to make some of this information explicit. For example:

I will go back to my place. I will remain there until...

(NCV) they suffer for their guilt: In this context, there are two ways to interpret the Hebrew word that the NCV translates as they suffer for their guilt:

1. It means “to bear the consequences of guilt or sin.” For example: I will abandon my people (GNT) (GNT, NAB, NCV, NET)
2. It means “to acknowledge that they are guilty of sin.” For example:

I will return again to my place, until they acknowledge their guilt and seek my face. (ESV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most lexicons and commentaries. However, most versions follow interpretation (2), so it is suggested that you give this interpretation in a footnote.

Here are some reasons to follow interpretation (1):

1. This word is not translated as “admit/acknowledge guilt” elsewhere in the Old Testament. Davies (page 158). In Leviticus 5:3–5 and 6:4, the NRSV and a few

other versions translate this word as “realize guilt” or “become aware of guilt.” But these verses refer to a situation in which a person finds out that he has become unclean or committed a sin. It is not a matter of admitting a wrong that the person knew about all along. In Leviticus 5:5 a different Hebrew word is used for “confess sin.”

2. This word occurs elsewhere in Hosea with the sense “bear the consequences of guilt.” See 10:2 and 13:16.
3. This sense fits the message of Hosea very well. In the preceding chapters the people have been informed repeatedly of the nature of their sin. The LORD has also warned them repeatedly that he was going to punish them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

until they have suffered their punishment (NET)

until they have borne the consequences of their sin

(NCV) In their trouble: This phrase is parallel to the clause “they suffer for their guilt.” These parallel ideas both refer to the suffering of the people of Israel and Judah. Their suffering is a result of the LORD’s judgment against them. See 5:12–14.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in their misery (NIV)

in their suffering (GNT)

(NCV) turn back to me...they will look for me: These statements are more literally:

they will seek my face...they will earnestly seek me (NIV)

These parallel statements refer to a time when the people will turn to the LORD to follow him. They will earnestly desire to worship and serve him. For more information on what it means to “seek the LORD,” see the note on 3:5a.

The meaning of the second term is more intense or emphatic than the first, as is often the case in Hebrew poetry.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

search diligently for me (REB)

seek me eagerly (NJB)

(NCV) me...me: The first word is literally “my face” in Hebrew. It is a figurative way to say me.

General Comment on 5:15b–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the parallel parts. For example:

until they have suffered for their sin and they finally seek me earnestly.

Hosea 6:1

Section 6:1–3: The people will urge one another to repent

In the last paragraph of chapter 5, the LORD warned the people of Israel and Judah that he would abandon them until they turned to him and earnestly desired to worship and serve him. Section 6:1–3 is closely connected to this paragraph. It contains the people’s response to the LORD’s warning.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The people will respond to the LORD’s warning

An invitation to repent

Some versions indicate in their section headings that these words of repentance are insincere or temporary. However, the words themselves appear to exemplify the true repentance that the LORD described in 5:15c. It was prophesied that this repentance would take place in the “last days” (3:5). The last chapter (14:1–7) describes the blessings that will result from this repentance. So it is recommended that you not imply in a section heading that this call to repentance is insincere or superficial. You may also want to add a footnote that cross-references the other verses in Hosea that describe this kind of repentance.

Paragraph 6:1–3

This paragraph gives the words that the people will say to each other when they repent and seek the LORD.

6:1a

Come, let us return to the LORD.

- ¶ The people will say, “Come, let us^(incl) return to Yahweh.
- ¶ They will say, “Listen, we must turn away from evil and turn again to Yahweh.

Come, let us return to the LORD: This verse part is a plea in which one or more of the people urge one

another to turn away from evil. They must turn to the LORD to do what is right and good.

In many languages, it will be necessary to specify the speaker(s) of these words. For example:

The people say, “...

They will say, “...

Come: In this context, the word Come has more than one function:

1. It is an exclamation that encourages people to listen.
2. It strengthens the invitation “let us return to the LORD.”

It does not mean that the people are to move closer to the speaker.

If the word Come is not understood correctly in your language, here are some other ways to translate it:

- Leave it implied. For example:

Let’s return to the Lord. (CEV)

- Substitute a different word that has the same function in your language. For example:

Listen!

let us return: In Hebrew, this phrase expresses a plea. This phrase does not mean “allow us to return.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

We^(incl) should return

It will be good if we^(incl) return

6:1b

For He has torn us to pieces, but He will heal us;

- For it is he who tore us^(incl) into pieces, but now he will heal us.
- He is the one who tore us apart like a lion tears its prey, but he will also restore our health.

6:1c

He has wounded us, but He will bind up our wounds.

- He caused us injury, but he will bandage our^(incl) wounds.

- Yes, he injured/wounded us, but he will also bandage/treat our^(incl) wounds.

6:1b–c

The clauses in this verse contrast with the similar ones in 5:13. In that verse, the people turned to the king of Assyria to heal their wounds, but the king could not heal them. Here the people understand that no human king can heal them, only the LORD.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{1b}For He has torn us to pieces, **but He will heal us;**

^{1c} he has wounded us, **but He will bind up our wounds.**

In these lines, the people acknowledge that the LORD has punished them (underlined parts). At the same time, they express confidence that the LORD will show compassion and heal them (parts in bold print).

Verse 6:1b–c gives the reason for the plea in 6:1a. The reason that the people should return to the LORD is because he will heal them. The BSB follows the Hebrew in using a conjunction to indicate that 6:1b–c is the reason for the plea.

Some versions let the context imply the correct relationship. Use a natural way in your language to indicate that 6:1b–c is a reason for the plea in 6:1a.

He has torn us to pieces...He has wounded us: These parallel clauses refer back to 5:14, where the LORD compared himself to a lion. A lion tears apart his prey. Similarly, the LORD had caused them to suffer severe punishment for their sins.

In Hebrew, He (in 6:1b) is an emphatic pronoun. For example:

He himself has torn us to pieces, but he will heal us! (NET)

Use a natural way in your language to indicate this emphasis on the LORD.

but He will heal us...but He will bind up our wounds:

There are several ways to interpret the relationship between the underlined parallel parts (He has torn us to pieces...he has wounded us) and the parts in bold print (**He will heal us...He will bind up our wounds**). Most versions use the same relationship in both lines, so the examples will show only the first line (6:1b).

1. The LORD will heal the people. This is a contrast with the hurt that the LORD caused them. For example:

He has hurt us but he will heal us (NCV) (BSB, CEV, GNT, NAB, NASB, NET, NIV, REB)

1. Although the LORD caused hurt, yet he will heal. Some versions use a conjunction to indicate that this is a concession. For example:

Even though he has torn us to pieces, he will heal us. (GW) (GW)

1. The LORD will heal the people. This is in addition to the hurt that the LORD caused them. For example:

He has rent us and he will heal us (NJB) (KJV, NJB, NJPS, NRSV)

1. The LORD will heal the people. This is the purpose of the hurt the LORD caused them. Some versions use a conjunction to indicate that this is the purpose. For example: The ESV has “and” in 6:1c.

for he has torn us, that he may heal us (ESV) (ESV, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. But interpretation (2) is also acceptable. Both interpretations clearly show the contrast between hurting and healing. McComiskey's translation (page 83) uses “but.” Pusey (page 67) prefers “purpose.” Davies (page 160) says that in prose this construction would indicate purpose but that in poetry it may indicate “a simple future.” Macintosh (page 216) translates 6:1b as “he who has mauled us shall heal us.” Hubbard (page 125) favors a concessive relationship.

In some languages, it may be more natural to leave the relationship implied and not have an explicit conjunction here. For example:

He has torn us to pieces; now he will heal us. (NLT)

Use a natural way in your language to show the contrast between the LORD hurting the people and healing them.

heal us...bind up our wounds: These parallel phrases refer to healing a person who is sick or caring for a

person who is injured. In this context, they indicate that the LORD will restore the people to good health.

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

heal us...bandage us (NASB)

make us well and bandage our wounds (CEV)

Hosea 6:2

Section 6:1–3: The people will urge one another to repent

In the last paragraph of chapter 5, the LORD warned the people of Israel and Judah that he would abandon them until they turned to him and earnestly desired to worship and serve him. Section 6:1–3 is closely connected to this paragraph. It contains the people's response to the LORD's warning.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The people will respond to the LORD's warning

An invitation to repent

Some versions indicate in their section headings that these words of repentance are insincere or temporary. However, the words themselves appear to exemplify the true repentance that the LORD described in 5:15c. It was prophesied that this repentance would take place in the "last days" (3:5). The last chapter (14:1–7) describes the blessings that will result from this repentance. So it is recommended that you not imply in a section heading that this call to repentance is insincere or superficial. You may also want to add a footnote that cross-references the other verses in Hosea that describe this kind of repentance.

Paragraph 6:1–3

This paragraph gives the words that the people will say to each other when they repent and seek the LORD.

6:2a

After two days He will revive us;

- After two days, he will give us^(incl) good health again.
- In just a short time, he will cause us to be well/healthy again.

6:2b

on the third day He will raise us up,

- After three days, he will give us^(incl) life again,
- He will restore our lives.

6:2a–b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning: In the Hebrew MT these lines form a chiasm in which the first line is literally "he will restore us to life from two days." English versions reorder the parts in the first line to say: "after two days he will restore us to life." This order sounds more natural in English and matches the order in the second line.

^{2a} After two days **He will revive us;**

^{2b} on the third day **he will raise us up,**

These two lines express the people's trust that the LORD can heal them in a short period of time.

After two days...on the third day: These parallel expressions are figurative ways to say "in a short time." Some versions translate the meaning directly. For example:

^{2a}He will restore us in a very short time; ^{2b}he will heal us in a little while (NET)

He will revive us...He will raise us up: In this context, both expressions mean to restore someone to health. McComiskey (page 88). Here they are figurative ways to say that the LORD will make Israel a strong, prosperous nation again.

In some contexts, these same words can refer to restoring life to a dead person. It is possible that this may be a secondary meaning here also. If your language has words that can mean both to restore health and to restore life to dead people, you could use them here.

6:2c

that we may live in His presence.

- so that we^(incl) can have fellowship/companionship with him.
- His purpose in doing this is that we will experience his blessing and protection.

that: Verse 6:2c gives the purpose for which the LORD revives and restores the people in 6:2a–b. The purpose is so that the people could live in his presence. Some versions use a word or phrase to indicate purpose here. For example:

so that we may live in his presence (NCV)

to live in his presence (REB)

Use a natural way in your language to introduce this purpose clause.

we may live in His presence: In Hebrew, this clause is literally “we will live before him.” This phrase means that the people will have a relationship with God in which He protects and blesses them. Ibid.

Here are some other ways to express this meaning:

we will have fellowship with him

we will enjoy his blessing and protection

General Comment on 6:2a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these verse parts. For example:

^{2a-b}In just a short time he will restore us, ^{2c}so that we may live in his presence. (NLT)

Hosea 6:3

Section 6:1–3: The people will urge one another to repent

In the last paragraph of chapter 5, the LORD warned the people of Israel and Judah that he would abandon them until they turned to him and earnestly desired to worship and serve him. Section 6:1–3 is closely connected to this paragraph. It contains the people’s response to the LORD’s warning.

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Paragraph 6:1–3

This paragraph gives the words that the people will say to each other when they repent and seek the LORD.

6:3a–b (combined/reordered)

- We^(incl) should make every effort to know Yahweh personally and learn who he is.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{3a}So let us know—

^{3b} let us press on to know the LORD.

In these two lines, the speaker urges the people to know the LORD. Some versions have moved the LORD to the first line, because it is more natural English.

let us...let us: These phrases express a plea. See the note on “let us return” in 6:1a.

know...to know: The Hebrew verbs that the BSB translates as know have more than one meaning related to knowing, experiencing, and understanding. There are two main ways to interpret the word know here:

1. It means that the people should know the LORD in an intimate, personal way. It implies that they should understand the LORD’s character. For example:

Let us know, let us strive to know Yahweh (NJB)

Let’s learn about the LORD. Let’s get to know the Lord. (GW) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NAB, NASB, NCV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. It means that the people should acknowledge or agree that he is the LORD. For example:

So let us acknowledge him! Let us seek to acknowledge the Lord! (NET) (NET, NIV) The NJPS has: “Let us pursue obedience to the Lord, and we shall become obedient.” To “acknowledge” the LORD involves obedience, so perhaps NJPS could be listed under this interpretation.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. This is the same interpretation as in 2:20b, although the context there focuses more on a marriage relationship.

Some languages have different words for knowing someone personally and knowing facts about someone. If that is true in your language, you should use the word that refers to a personal relationship.

let us press on to know the LORD: The phrase that the BSB translates as let us press on is literally “let us pursue” It means to fervently strive to know him. For example:

let us strive to know Yahweh (NJB)

General Comment on 6:3a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these lines. For example:

Let’s do our best to know the Lord. (CEV)

6:3a

So let us know—

- We^(incl) must do all that we can to know Yahweh!

6:3b

let us press on to know the LORD.

- Let us^(incl) try hard to know him!

6:3c–e

(combined/reordered)

- He will come to us^(incl) as surely as the day dawns, like the spring rains that irrigate/water the soil.”

Notice the parallel partsThe first and second lines form a chiasm. The phrase “He will appear” is the second phrase of the first line. The matching phrase “He will come” is the first phrase of the second line. that are similar in meaning:

^{3c} As surely as the sun rises, **He will appear**;

^{3d} **He will come** to us like the rain,

^{3e} like the spring showers that water the earth.

These three lines are similes. In each simile, the coming of the LORD is compared to natural events. His coming is as certain as the sunrise. It is also as welcome and beneficial as the rain that people in Israel depended on for their crops.

6:3d

He will come to us like the rain,

- Yes, we^(incl) know that he will come just as the rains do.
- His coming to us is like the arrival of the rainy season.

6:3c–d

He will appear; He will come: These clauses imply that the LORD will come to help and bless his people. No difference in meaning is intended between the parallel words appear and come.

6:3c

As surely as the sun rises, He will appear;

- The sun always rises. Similarly, he will certainly come/appear.
- There is no doubt that he will appear to help us^(incl). It is as certain as the sunrise.

As surely as the sun rises, He will appear: Here are some other ways to translate these clauses:

his coming is as sure as the dawn (NRSV)

His coming is as certain as the morning sun (CEV)

He will come to us as sure as the morning comes. (GW)

6:3e

like the spring showers that water the earth.

- He will be like the rain that arrives in the spring that waters the earth.”
- We^(incl) eagerly look forward to it just as we look forward to the rain that come right when the crops need it.”

6:3d–e

like the rain, like the spring showers that water the earth: The terms that the BSB translates as rain and spring showers are each one word in Hebrew. The first word is literally rain. It usually refers to rain in general, whereas spring showers refers specifically to rain that falls at a particular time of year. There are two ways to interpret the first word:

1. It refers to rain or showers in general. It does not indicate the time of year when it rains. For example:

he will come to us like rain (NCV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, REB, NRSV)

1. It refers specifically to autumn or winter rains. For example:

He will come to us like the autumn rains (GW) (GW, NET, NIV)

The BSB follows interpretation (1), but you may follow either interpretation. There are several reasons why either interpretation is valid:

1. In Hebrew parallelism, a general statement commonly precedes a specific one.
2. The general term rain probably includes both the earlier and later times of rain. In Israel, rain commonly fell at planting time in October-November and also when the crops were ripening in March or April. According to Macintosh (page 225), the word *gešem* (rain) “is a comprehensive term denoting rainfall and therefore includes the phenomena of Israel/Palestine, viz. the former and the latter rains, respectively of winter and spring. Of these the latter rain *malqoš* (‘spring showers’) alone is here named.” See also Pusey and Wood, who both mention the two seasons of rainfall in Israel. However, many other commentaries focus on the spring rains as the primary reference of the general term. These include Hubbard, Stuart, Dearman, and McComiskey. See also TWOT (#1127b).
3. With either interpretation, the point of the simile (the regularity and benefits of rain) is the same.

In different areas of the world, periods of rainfall are referred to in different ways. People may also expect rain at different times of the year. If that is true in your language area, you may use more general terms. For example:

He will come to us like the rain/showers that the crops need.

General Comment on 6:3c–e

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine some of the verse parts. For example the GNT combines 6:3d and 6:3e:

^{3c}He will come to us as surely as the day dawns, ^{3d–e}as surely as the spring rains fall upon the earth. (GNT)

Hosea 6:4

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people’s future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns (“you”) and sometimes third person pronouns (“they” or “he”) to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5–10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use “you” in 6:11 and “they” in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on “you” in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment (NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

Paragraph 6:4–6

This paragraph contrasts with the previous one (6:1–3). That paragraph described a time when the people would truly repent. Here in 6:4–6, the LORD told the people of Israel and Judah how unreliable their love was. He expressed his despair over the way that the people truly behaved. He also told them what he desired from them.

In some languages, it may be helpful to make explicit the contrast between this paragraph and 6:1–3. For example:

But you, Ephraim, What am I to do with you?

Yet you people of Ephraim do not seek to know me. What can I do with you?

6:4a–b (combined/reordered)

- ¶ But Yahweh says, “You^(plur) people of Israel and Judah will not seek me. What can I do with you?”

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{4a} What shall I do with you, **O Ephraim?**

^{4b} What shall I do with you, **O Judah**?

In many languages, it will be necessary to specify that the LORD is now the speaker. For example:

“O Israel and Judah, what should I do with you?”
asks the Lord. (NLT96)

What shall I do with you...What shall I do with you: These two clauses are rhetorical questions. Their function is to express the LORD’s frustration and hopelessness with the people of Israel and Judah. They are not requests for information.

Here are some ways to translate these rhetorical questions:

- As rhetorical questions. You may use slightly different questions if that is more natural in your language. For example:

^{4a}How shall I deal with you, Ephraim? (REB)

^{4b}What should I do with you, Judah? (GW)

- As statements. For example:

^{4a}Ephraim, how frustrating you are!

^{4b}Judah, I don’t know what I should do with you!

O Ephraim...O Judah: The name Ephraim is a figure of speech (synecdoche) that represents the people of the northern kingdom of Israel. Judah refers to the people of the southern kingdom of Judah. Some versions translate Ephraim as Israel here. For example:

The Lord says, “Israel, what should I do with you?
Judah, what should I do with you? (NCV)

General Comment on 6:4a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine these parallel lines into one. For example:

People of Israel and Judah, what can I do with you? (CEV)

6:4a

What shall I do with you, O Ephraim?

- ¶ “O people of Ephraim, what can I do with you?”^(plur)

- ¶ But Yahweh says, “You Israelites, if only you sought to know me like this. But you do not. What should I do with you?”

- ¶ Yahweh says, “You people of Israel, how frustrating you are!”

6:4b

What shall I do with you, O Judah?

- And you^(plur) people of Judah, what can I do with you?
- You descendants of Judah, what should I do with you?
- You people of Judah, you are so exasperating!

6:4c–d

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{4c}For your loyalty is like a morning mist,

^{4d} like the early dew that vanishes.

There is an ellipsis (deliberate omission) of the first three words in 6:4d. In many languages, these words will need to be supplied from 6:4c. For example:

^{4d} your loyalty is like the early dew that vanishes.

These lines explain the source of the LORD’s frustration with the people of Israel and Judah. They contain figures of speech (similes) in which he compared their love to morning mist and dew. The love that the people had for him and others was not dependable. It was similar to morning mist and dew because it quickly disappeared. It did not last long.

6:4c

For your loyalty is like a morning mist,

- Your^(plur) love lasts no longer than the mist in the morning.
- Your love for me does not endure. It is like a fog/cloud

For your loyalty: The word that the BSB translates here as loyalty refers to faithful love within a covenant relationship. Here it refers mainly to the people’s love and loyalty to the LORD, but it also includes their kindness to one another. Keil understands *hesed* to refer here “to goodwill towards other men flowing out of love to God” (page 98). McComiskey (page 91) and Hubbard (page 126) give similar definitions. However, both the immediate context and the overall theme of Hosea focus on the people’s unfaithfulness to their covenant relationship with God. NIDOTTE (#2876) specifically cites Hosea 6:4 as an example of “the human response to God.” Wood (page 194) also notes

that the basis of the indictment against Israel and Judah is that their love “for God” was unstable.

a morning mist: This phrase probably refers to low-lying clouds or fog that disappears by the time the morning is over.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a morning cloud (NRSV)

like fog in the morning (GW)

6:4d

like the early dew that vanishes.

- It is like the dew that disappears early in the day.
- or dew that can be seen early in the morning, but soon it vanishes.

the early dew that vanishes: In some languages, it may be redundant to make the word early explicit.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the dew that quickly disappears (NJB)

disappears like dew in the sunlight (NLT)

General Comment on 6:4c–d

Some versions make explicit the point of comparison in both similes. For example:

For your love vanishes like the morning mist and disappears like dew in the sunlight. (NLT)

Hosea 6:5

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people’s future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns (“you”) and sometimes third person pronouns (“they” or “he”) to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5–10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the

speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use “you” in 6:11 and “they” in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on “you” in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

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This paragraph contrasts with the previous one (6:1–3). That paragraph described a time when the people would truly repent. Here in 6:4–6, the LORD told the people of Israel and Judah how unreliable their love was. He expressed his despair over the way that the people truly behaved. He also told them what he desired from them.

In some languages, it may be helpful to make explicit the contrast between this paragraph and 6:1–3. For example:

But you, Ephraim, What am I to do with you?

Yet you people of Ephraim do not seek to know me. What can I do with you?

6:5a–c

This verse describes the result of the people’s undependable love described in 6:4. Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{5a}Therefore I have hewn them **by the prophets**;

^{5b} I have slain them **by the words of My mouth**,

^{5c}and **my judgments** go forth like lightning. This shows one way that 6:5c may be parallel to 6:5a and 6:5b. Another possibility is that the phrase “My judgments” in 6:5c is parallel with “I have

hewn them” in 6:5a and “I have slain them” in 6:5b.

In this verse, the LORD told the people how he responded to their lack of love. He disciplined them severely.

The historical context indicates that he disciplined the people many times over a period of many years. Some English versions use past tense verbs here to allow this understanding. However, the Hebrew verbs in this verse have imperfect tense/aspect, which commonly indicates a present or future time reference.

Translate this in a natural way in your language to indicate it happened regularly over a long period of time and will continue to happen.

Verse 6:4 used the second person pronoun “you” to refer to Ephraim and Judah. In that verse, the LORD addressed the people directly. Here in 6:5, the pronoun changes from “you” to “them.” See the summary of Section 6:4–7:16 above for more information.

6:5a

Therefore I have hewn them by the prophets;

- So I caused you^(plur) to die through the words of my prophets.
- That is why I have sent my prophets to say that I would punish you with death.

Therefore: In Hebrew and in some English versions, this verse begins with a word that indicates result. For example:

That’s why I slaughtered you with the words of my prophets. (CEV)

Some versions do not introduce the verse with a specific word here. Instead, they let the context imply the relationship between the previous verse and this one. For example:

I sent my prophets to cut you to pieces—to slaughter you with my words (NLT)

Use a natural way in your language to indicate that the LORD’s actions here in 6:5 are the result of the people’s undependable love in 6:4.

I have hewn them by the prophets: This clause is a figure of speech that compares the LORD’s prophets to instruments of death. It means that the words the LORD spoke through his prophets announced his judgment against the people. His judgment was a death

sentence. The clause does not mean that the LORD used his prophets to literally cut people in pieces.

6:5a–b (combined/reordered)

- Because you^(plur) are like that, I repeatedly sent my prophets to tell you that I would judge and destroy you.

6:5b

I have slain them by the words of My mouth,

- They spoke to you^(plur) my words of judgment that destroyed you.
- They repeatedly warned you that I would destroy you.

I have slain them by the words of My mouth:

The figure of speech in this clause is similar to the previous clause. It means that the words the LORD spoke through his prophets announced his judgment of death against the people. It is left implied that the phrase the words of My mouth are words that the LORD spoke through his prophets.

General Comment on 6:5a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine the parallel lines. It may also be clearer to translate the nonfigurative meaning. For example:

I have sent my prophets to you with my message of judgment and destruction. (GNT)

I have warned you by my prophets that I will kill you and destroy you. (NCV)

6:5c

and My judgments go forth like lightning.

- The arrival of my judgment will be like the light.
- I will punish you^(plur) as certainly as the dawn comes.

and My judgments go forth like lightning: This clause is a simile. There is a textual issue here: (1) The LXX, Syriac Peshitta, and Aramaic Targum have “my judgment goes forth like light.” (2) The Hebrew MT has “and your judgments [are] light [which] goes forth.” It is recommended that you follow the LXX here along with HOTTP, most commentaries and English versions. The plural subject “your judgments” in the MT does not fit the singular verb “goes forth.” For more details, see Andersen and Freedman (page 429), Hubbard (page 127), Keil (page 99), McComiskey (pages 91–92), and the NET footnote. It compares the way that the LORD’s judgment goes forth to lightning.

In Hebrew, the word the BSB translates here as lightning can refer to the light of day, dawn, lightning, or a lamp, among other things. The way in which the LORD's judgment is similar to light is not obvious. There are at least three interpretations:

1. The simile indicates that the LORD's judgment will certainly occur. For example:

My judgment will strike you as surely as day follows night. (NLT96) (NET, NLT96, NLT)

1. The simile indicates that the LORD's judgment/justice is clear and obvious for all to see. For example:

My justice comes out like bright light. (NCV) (GNT, NCV) It is possible that the NJB ("my sentence will blaze forth like the dawn") and the CEV ("my judgments blazed like the dawning sun") follow this interpretation, but the implication of these similes is not clear in English. Scholars who support interpretation (2) understand the point of similarity to be "brilliance and pervasiveness" (McComiskey, pages 91–92), "clear" (Pusey, page 66), or "public recognition" (Davies, page 168).

1. The simile indicates that the LORD's judgment destroys people. For example:

My judgments flashed like lightning upon you. (NIV) (NIV)

Most versions leave the similarity between judgment and light implicit. For example:

and my judgment goes forth as the light (NRSV)

It is recommended that you translate in a way that allows your readers to understand more than one point of similarity. If you need to make the similarity between judgment and lightning/light explicit, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation is similar to 6:3c, which compares the LORD's coming to the certainty of dawn.

Here is another way to translate this interpretation:

I will punish you as certainly as the arrival of the dawn/daylight.

Hosea 6:6

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people's future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns ("you") and sometimes third person pronouns ("they" or "he") to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses "they" in 6:5–10, "you" in 6:4 & 11, and "they" or "he" in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use "you" in 6:11 and "they" in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on "you" in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment
(NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

Paragraph 6:4–6

This paragraph contrasts with the previous one (6:1–3). That paragraph described a time when the people would truly repent. Here in 6:4–6, the LORD told the people of Israel and Judah how unreliable their love was. He expressed his despair over the way that the people truly behaved. He also told them what he desired from them.

In some languages, it may be helpful to make explicit the contrast between this paragraph and 6:1–3. For example:

But you, Ephraim, What am I to do with you?

Yet you people of Ephraim do not seek to know me. What can I do with you?

6:6a-b (combined/reordered)

- For it is not your^(plur) animal sacrifices that I care about. What I want is for you to know me, your God, and to show love to me and others.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{6a}For I desire mercy, **not sacrifice**,

^{6b}and the knowledge of God **rather than burnt offerings**.

For: In this verse, the LORD explained to the people of Israel what he wanted from them. He told them the reason for his frustration and the motive for his discipline. The Hebrew text and some English versions indicate explicitly that this verse is an explanation or reason. For example:

For I desire steadfast love.... (NRSV)

Some versions rely on the context to clarify the relationship between the previous verses and this one. They do not indicate the relationship explicitly. For example:

I want your constant love, not your animal sacrifices. (GNT)

Use a natural way in your language to indicate that this verse tells the reason for the LORD's feelings and actions in the previous verses.

I desire mercy, not sacrifice, and the knowledge of God rather than burnt offerings: In these lines, the LORD told the people of Israel what was important to him. He wanted them to faithfully love him and one another. He also wanted them to show by their attitudes and actions that they truly knew him. Otherwise, he would not accept their sacrifices and burnt offerings.

It is implied from the previous context that the people did not show that they truly knew him. It is also implied that the kind of sacrifices and burnt offerings that the LORD rejected were mere rituals. He did not want the people to offer sacrifices at all, if the sacrifices were not accompanied by a loving relationship with him.

You may want to add a footnote that cross-references 1 Samuel 15:22 and Psalm 51:16–19. These verses have similar ideas.

mercy: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as mercy is the same word that it translates as “loving devotion” in 4:1c. See the note on that verse for the different aspects of meaning. Here it may refer particularly to faithful love for God that results in a concern for others. Translate this term in a way that fits naturally in the context.

the knowledge of God: See the notes on 4:1d and 5:4c, where this phrase has the same meaning.

God: The Hebrew word here is *elohim* and not *Yahweh*. Versions indicate this by translating this word as *God* and not as “LORD.”

sacrifice...burnt offerings: The parallel terms sacrifice and burnt offerings refer to animal sacrifices that the people offered to God.

The word sacrifice is the general word for an offering to God. The phrase burnt offerings refers to animals that were completely burned as offerings to God.

General Comment on 6:6a-b

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine the parallel parts in these two lines. For example:

It is not your animal sacrifices that I care about.
What I want is for you to know me, your God, and to show love to me and others.

6:6a

For I desire mercy, not sacrifice,

- For I desire that you love me. I do not desire the sacrifices that you offer with insincere hearts.
- What I want is your loyal/unchanging love for me and others, not the animals that you sacrifice.

6:6b

and the knowledge of God rather than burnt offerings.

- I want you^(plur) to know and obey me as your God rather than to burn animals as offerings to me.
- I also want you to know me and to acknowledge my authority as God. I am not pleased with the offerings that you burn to me that are only rituals.

Hosea 6:7

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people's future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to com-

mit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns (“you”) and sometimes third person pronouns (“they” or “he”) to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5–10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use “you” in 6:11 and “they” in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on “you” in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment
(NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

Paragraph 6:7–7:2

In this paragraph, the LORD gave examples of how the people of Israel had failed to know him and had failed to show love to him and others.

6:7a–b

The NRSV has been used as the source line for 6:7a, because it follows the recommended textual option. Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{7a}But at Adam, **they transgressed the covenant;**
(NRSV)

^{7b} there **they were unfaithful to me.**

6:7a

But they, like Adam, have transgressed the covenant;

- ¶ “But at Adam, the people of Israel refused to be loyal to my covenant with them.
- ¶ “You^(plur) Israelites broke our^(incl) agreement at the town of Adam.

(NRSV) But: This verse gives an example of what the people did that was in contrast to what the LORD wanted. Some versions indicate this contrast explicitly. For example:

But they broke the covenant at Adam (NJB)

Some versions do not indicate this contrast explicitly. Instead they let the context imply the relationship between the previous verse and this one. For example:

At Adam they broke the covenant (NET)

Use a natural way in your language to indicate this contrast.

(NRSV) at Adam: There are several textual and interpretation issues here. See footnote (a) in the NET for details. The notes will discuss only the main options. It will be helpful to remember that in Hebrew, the word Adam (ʾadam) does not have a capital letter.

1. Some scholars think that the original text had the phrase “at-Adam.” It means that the people had broken the covenant at the town of Adam. For example:

At a place named Adam (CEV) (CEV, GNT, NABRE, NET, NIV2011, NJB, NRSV) The REB also understands this as a place name. It has “At Admah....”

1. The Masoretic Text has “like Adam.” It means that the people had broken the covenant like the first man Adam. This option (“Adam” a person’s name) is supported by the Latin Vulgate. did when he disobeyed God in the garden of Eden. For example:

But like Adam they transgressed the covenant
(ESV) (BSB, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NIV, NLT)

1. The Masoretic Text has “like Adam.” It means that the people had broken the covenant like all sinful men do. This option (“man/mankind”) is supported by the Septuagint (LXX). For example:

But they like men have transgressed the covenant
(KJV) (KJV, NJPS)

The Display will follow option (1) along with many versions and scholars. It forms a better parallel with the word “there” in 6:7b. It also fits well with the place names that Hosea mentions in the two following verses. According to several scholars, the OT does not

use the word “covenant” in relation to God’s command to Adam, nor do any OT prophets use Adam and Eve’s disobedience in the Garden of Eden as an example of God’s judgment on sin. In addition, outside of Genesis 1–5, the person’s name Adam almost never occurs. See NIDOTTE (#132), Davies (page 171), Macintosh (pages 236–239), and Hubbard (page 128).

However, option (2) is also supported by many versions and scholars. You may want to follow this option if it is followed by a major language translation in your area.

Whichever option you choose, it is recommended that you put the other option in a footnote. For example, if you choose option (1), here is a suggested footnote:

Some scholars think that the original Hebrew text had “at Adam.” The Masoretic Text has “like Adam.” In Hebrew, the word “like” looks almost the same as the word “at.” According to Joshua 3:16, the Jordan River backed up as far as Adam. Adam was a town in the Jordan Valley on the way to Shechem.

If you choose option (2), here is a suggested footnote:

The Masoretic Text has “like Adam.” In Hebrew, the word “like” looks almost the same as the word “at,” so another way to translate this phrase is “at Adam.” According to Joshua 3:16, the Jordan River backed up as far as Adam. Adam was a town in the Jordan Valley on the way to Shechem.

(NRSV) they transgressed the covenant: The word covenant probably refers to the covenant that the LORD made with Moses on Mount Sinai. That covenant included the people’s promise that they would obey his laws. See Exodus 19:5–8. This clause means that the people disobeyed the laws that they and their ancestors had promised to obey.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they violated my covenant (REB)

breaking our agreement (CEV)

they: The pronoun they probably refers to the people of Israel. Hosea makes it explicit elsewhere that the people are guilty of breaking the LORD’s covenant with them. See 8:1. However, it is also possible that it refers to the priests who are mentioned in 6:9. If possible, translate the pronoun in a way that can refer to both the people and the priests.

6:7b

there they were unfaithful to Me.

- They betrayed me there.
- There at Adam you^(plur) were disloyal to me.

there they were unfaithful to Me: This clause refers to the event mentioned in 6:7a. When the people broke the LORD’s covenant with them at the town of Adam (6:7a), they were unfaithful to him.

unfaithful: This word means “to act treacherously” toward someone or “to betray” someone’s trust. It describes someone who does not honor an agreement.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

there they have betrayed me (NJB)

Hosea 6:8

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people’s future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns (“you”) and sometimes third person pronouns (“they” or “he”) to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5–10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use “you” in 6:11 and “they” in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on “you” in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment (NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

Paragraph 6:7-7:2

In this paragraph, the LORD gave examples of how the people of Israel had failed to know him and had failed to show love to him and others.

6:8

Gilead is a city of evildoers, tracked with footprints of blood.

- Gilead is also a city filled with evil people. Everywhere they walk they leave bloody footprints.
- And you^(plur) people in the city of Gilead are wicked murderers.

Gilead is a city of evildoers, tracked with footprints of blood: This verse indicates that many evil people lived in the city of Gilead. Many of them were murderers.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

Gilead is a city full of evildoers (NET)

tracked with footprints of blood: This phrase is a metaphor. It means that many people murdered others there. Many versions keep the metaphor. For example:

their footprints are bloody (NCV)

its streets are stained with bloody footprints
(NET)

Some versions translate the meaning directly. For example:

Gilead is a city full of evil people and murderers
(GNT)

Hosea 6:9**Section 6:4-7:16: The people persisted in their sins**

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people's future repentance (6:1-3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns ("you") and sometimes third person pronouns ("they" or "he") to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage.

It uses "they" in 6:5-10, "you" in 6:4 & 11, and "they" or "he" in 7:1-16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use "you" in 6:11 and "they" in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5-10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5-10. In 6:7-10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on "you" in 2:16b-c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment
(NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

Paragraph 6:7-7:2

In this paragraph, the LORD gave examples of how the people of Israel had failed to know him and had failed to show love to him and others.

6:9

This verse gives an example of the wicked behavior of the priests. Groups of priests murdered people who were traveling to a place of worship.

6:9a

Like raiders who lie in ambush, so does a band of priests;

- Like robbers who ambush their victims, bands/groups of priests do the same.
- You^(plur) priests are like gangs of thieves who wait in a hiding place to ambush others.

Like raiders who lie in ambush, so does a band of priests: This verse part is a simile. It compares the actions of groups of priests to the actions of raiders who ambush and kill their victims.

Here are some other ways to translate this simile:

The priests are like gangs of robbers who lie in ambush for a person. (GW)

The priests are like robbers waiting to attack people (NCV)

raiders: In Hebrew, this word refers to groups of robbers who stole from people and often murdered them.

a band of priests: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “association of priests.” It refers to priests of Israel who gathered into groups to do evil things.

6:9b

they murder on the way to Shechem; surely they have committed atrocities.

- They commit murder on the road to Shechem. Their crimes are truly shameful.
- You^(plur) kill people on the road that leads/goes to Shechem. How terrible are the crimes you commit!

they murder: This phrase refers to the groups of priests who killed people deliberately. The form of the Hebrew verb indicates that they murdered people regularly or repeatedly.

on the way to Shechem: Shechem was located on an important road that many people used. The road led from Samaria, the capital of the northern kingdom of Israel, to Bethel, an important place of worship. The location of the murders was on this road, not within the city of Shechem. Scholars have different views regarding the significance of this particular location. Some versions (for example, the NCV) include a footnote indicating that the city of Shechem was one of the cities of refuge where people could go to be safe, if they had accidentally killed someone (see Joshua 20:1–9). However, it is not clear how or if that is connected to the murders. Several commentators suggest that Hosea 6:8–9 may be referring to Pekah’s assassination of King Pekahiah spoken of in 2 Kings 15:25. That passage speaks of a group of 50 men from Gilead who participated in the assassination. For more discussion see IVP Bible Background Commentary: 6:8–9, Hubbard (page 129), and Macintosh (page 243). Another possibility is simply that this well-travelled road offered many victims for robbers.

surely they have committed atrocities: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “they have done wickedness.” The word “wickedness” is a strong word for sin of various kinds. Try to express the severity of this evil in your translation. For example:

they commit a monstrous crime (NRSV)

their behaviour is an outrage (REB)

In Hebrew, this phrase begins with a word the word that the BSB translates as surely to give emphasis. Some versions leave this word implied.

Here are some other ways to translate it explicitly:

Certainly, they have committed a crime. (GW)

How terrible is the evil they have done!

General Comment on 6:9a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder some of the parts within these two lines. For example:

Like so many robbers in ambush, a gang of priests commits murder on the road to Shechem—what infamous behavior!

The priests are like a gang of robbers who wait in ambush for someone. Even on the road to the holy place at Shechem they commit murder. And they do all this evil deliberately! (GNT)

Hosea 6:10

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people’s future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns (“you”) and sometimes third person pronouns (“they” or “he”) to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5–10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use “you” in 6:11 and “they” in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on “you” in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment
(NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

Paragraph 6:7–7:2

In this paragraph, the LORD gave examples of how the people of Israel had failed to know him and had failed to show love to him and others.

6:10a

In the house of Israel I have seen a horrible thing:

- I have seen the horrible things that people are doing in Israel!
- I have seen something disgusting in the nation of Israel.

In the house of Israel: The expression house of Israel is a figure of speech that probably refers to the land of the northern kingdom of Israel. The NJB and the REB have “At Bethel” here. This translation is apparently based on the interpretation that the “horrible thing” is the golden calf at Bethel. However, this interpretation is not adequate evidence to support a textual change from “house of Israel” to “house of God” (Bethel). Most commentaries do not even mention this option. See Macintosh (page 245) and Stuart (page 112), who both mention it but do not support the change.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in Israel (GNT)

in the nation of Israel (GW)

See how you translated this phrase in 1:6c.

I have seen: These words indicate that the LORD personally witnessed the evil that the people did.

a horrible thing: This phrase refers to something disgusting that people react to with horror. In this context, it probably refers to all kinds of wickedness, including the shameful crimes in 6:9 and also the prostitution in 6:10b–c. Use a general term for something disgusting or horrible that can refer to all these sins. For example:

terrible thing (NASB)

disgusting thing (NET)

something horrible (NLT)

6:10b–c

(combined/reordered)

- The people of Israel are unfaithful to me. They are like a woman who sleeps with different men.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{10b} Ephraim **practices prostitution** there,

^{10c} and Israel **is defiled**.

Ephraim...Israel: In this context, the parallel names Ephraim and Israel are used for poetic effect. They both refer to the people of Israel. Some versions make only the name Israel explicit here. For example:

Look at Israel’s prostitution; Israel has become unclean. (NCV)

6:10b

Ephraim practices prostitution there,

- There the people of Ephraim behave like a prostitute.
- You^(plur) are unfaithful, like a woman who sells her body to men.

practices prostitution: This phrase is similar to the phrase “be promiscuous” in 4:10b. (See that note for more discussion.) It refers literally to the people committing sexual sin. It also refers symbolically to their worship of false gods. If possible, translate this phrase in a way that can refer to both referents. For example:

Ephraim is acting like a prostitute (GW)

you are unfaithful (CEV)

there: This word refers back to the phrase “in the house of Israel” in 6:10a. Some versions leave this word implied. For example:

Ephraim is acting like a prostitute (GW)

6:10c

and Israel is defiled.

- Yes, the people of Israel are impure/unclean.
- You^(plur) are not fit to worship me.

is defiled: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as is defiled is literally “it has made itself unclean.” The BSB translated it the same way in 5:3c–d. The word refers to the people’s moral impurity. It also refers to their becoming spiritually impure by breaking

the commands of their covenant with the LORD. The people were guilty of both kinds of impurity.

Here are some other ways to translate this Hebrew word:

has become unclean (NCV)

have defiled themselves (NLT96)

General Comment on 6:10b–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine the parallel parts into one line. For example:

you are unfaithful and unfit to worship me (CEV)

Hosea 6:11

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people's future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns ("you") and sometimes third person pronouns ("they" or "he") to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses "they" in 6:5–10, "you" in 6:4 & 11, and "they" or "he" in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use "you" in 6:11 and "they" in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on "you" in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment
(NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

Paragraph 6:7–7:2

In this paragraph, the LORD gave examples of how the people of Israel had failed to know him and had failed to show love to him and others.

6:11a

Also for you, O Judah, a harvest is appointed,

- As for you^(plur), people of Judah, I have set a time/day when you also will harvest punishment because of your evil deeds.
- And you people of Judah, you as well as the people of Israel will be punished for the evil things you are doing. I have already decided when this will happen.

In 6:7–10, the LORD spoke about the sins of people in the northern kingdom of Israel. Here in 6:11a, he spoke to the people of the southern kingdom of Judah.

Also for you, O Judah, a harvest is appointed: In this sentence, the LORD warned the people of Judah that he had set a time to judge them.

Also: This word indicates that the LORD had set a time to judge Judah as well as Israel. The judgment for Israel was not made explicit in 6:7–10, but the word **Also** implies it here. For more discussion, see McComiskey (pages 97–98).

you, O Judah: The LORD addressed the people of Judah directly through the prophet Hosea.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

as for you, people of Judah (GNT)

For you also, O Judah (NRSV)

Use a term of address (vocative) that is natural in your language when a person speaks to a group of people.

a harvest: In this context, the word harvest has a figurative meaning. It refers to the consequences of a person's behavior. Here it refers to the consequences that the people of Judah will experience when the LORD judges them for their sin. Andersen and Freedman (pages 443–444), Macintosh (page 248), McComiskey (page 97), and Wood (page 195).

Here are some other ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the figure of speech and make the meaning of judgment explicit. For example:

a harvest of punishment is also waiting for you
(NLT)

- Omit the figure of harvest and translate the meaning directly. For example:

I have set a time to punish you also for what you are doing (GNT)

is appointed: This phrase means that a time is set for the harvest to happen. This is a passive form. It is a Qal perfect form used in a passive sense. Keil (page 102) and McComiskey (page 97). In some languages, it may be necessary to use an active verb and make the agent explicit. For example:

I have appointed a time to reap judgment (NET)

Notice that the NET and GNT both use active verbs. They differ in that the NET keeps the figure of reaping whereas the GNT translates the meaning non-figuratively. Express the meaning clearly and naturally in your language.

6:11b–7:1a

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{6:11b}when I restore **My people** from captivity.

^{7:1a}When I heal **Israel**,

There are two main ways to interpret the relationship between the clauses in 6:11b and 7:1a:

1. The clauses are parallel. Both clauses refer to occasions when the LORD desired to bless his people. These clauses are the first part of a sentence that continues in 7:1. For example:

^{6:11b}When I would restore the fortunes of my people, ^{7:1a}when I would heal Israel, (NRSV) (CEV, GNT, NAB, NET, NIV, NJPS, NRSV, REB)

1. The clauses are not parallel. The first clause refers back to the appointed harvest for Judah in 6:11a. That harvest would happen when the LORD restored the fortunes of his people. With this interpretation, this clause is the final part of the sentence that began with 6:11a. The second clause starts a new sentence. For example:

^{6:11a}For you too, Judah, a harvest is in store, ^{6:11b}when I restore my people's fortunes.

^{7:1a}Whenever I would heal Israel, (NJB) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NASB, NCV, NJB)

Interpretation (1) is recommended. It best fits the context of the surrounding verses that focus on the sins of the people. Interpretation (2) makes good sense only if the “harvest” mentioned in 6:11a is understood as the LORD’s blessing. However, here it probably refers to his judgment.

6:11b

when I restore My people from captivity.

- At the very times when I want to give back to my people their prosperity,
- I greatly desire to bless my people, and make them strong and prosperous once more.

when I restore My people from captivity: In Hebrew, the phrase when I implies that the LORD desires to do something and that his desire is not fulfilled. The phrase restore My people from captivity is literally “turn back the captivity of my people.” This is a Hebrew idiom. It refers here to the LORD’s desire to restore the prosperity and stability that his people enjoyed in earlier times. In some contexts, this idiom refers to the return of the LORD’s people from exile. However, that is probably not in focus in this context. See McComiskey (page 100).

Here are some ways to make explicit the idea of unfulfilled desire:

Whenever I want to restore the fortunes of my people (NET)

At the same time that I desire to restore the fortunes of my people...

Hosea 7:1

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people’s future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns (“you”) and sometimes third person pronouns (“they” or “he”) to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5–10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use “you” in 6:11 and “they” in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on “you” in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment
(NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

Paragraph 6:7–7:2

In this paragraph, the LORD gave examples of how the people of Israel had failed to know him and had failed to show love to him and others.

7:1a

When I heal Israel,

- when I want to restore Israel’s health and strength,
- I want to heal their relationship with me, but

When I heal Israel: For the phrase When I, see the note on the parallel phrase in 6:11b. The phrase I heal Israel is a metaphor. It refers to the LORD’s desire to restore Israel’s relationship with him and restore their prosperity as a nation. It is implied from 7:1b–c that the LORD is unable to fulfill this desire due to the wickedness of the people.

Here are some ways to make explicit the idea of unfulfilled desire:

whenever I want to heal Israel... (NET)

at the same time as I desire to heal Israel...

General Comment on 6:11b–7:1a

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine the parallel parts. For example:

Whenever I want to heal my people Israel and make them prosperous again, (GNT)

I, the Lord, would like to make my nation prosperous again and to heal its wounds. (CEV)

See the following notes on 7:1b–c for more details on how these two versions express the connection with the following verse parts.

7:1b–c (combined/reordered)

- that is when I see the wickedness throughout the land of Israel.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{1b} the iniquity of Ephraim **will be exposed**

^{1c}as well as the crimes of Samaria.

There is an ellipsis in 7:1c. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing verb from 7:1b. For example:

^{1c} the crimes of Samaria will also be exposed.

Following the recommended interpretation, these lines conclude the sentence that starts in 6:11b. They express the reason that God’s desire to bless and heal Israel is not fulfilled. It is because the sins of the people are clearly seen.

the iniquity...the crimes: In Hebrew, the word iniquity is a general word for sin and guilt. The word crimes is literally “evils.” It refers to actions that are against God’s will, such as dishonest or immoral behavior. In this context, these parallel words are used for poetic effect. These words draw attention to the people’s disobedience of God’s laws and the harm the people cause.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

the corruption...the wicked deeds (NRSV)

the guilt...the wickedness (REB)

their wickedness...the evil they do (GNT)

Ephraim...Samaria: Ephraim, the main tribe of Israel, is used as a figure of speech to represent the entire nation of Israel. Samaria, the capital of Israel, is also a figure of speech that represents all the people of the nation. Since both names refer to Israel, some versions make only the name “Israel” explicit. For example:

Whenever I want to heal my people Israel and make them prosperous again, all I can see is their wickedness and the evil they do. (GNT)

7:1b

the iniquity of Ephraim will be exposed,

- that is when the sin/guilt of the people of Ephraim becomes known
- I cannot do it, because I can clearly see their evil way of life throughout Israel
- the guilt of the people of Israel is obvious,

will be exposed: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as exposed is a form of the same word that describes exposing the lewdness of Gomer in 2:10a. It means to be uncovered or exposed.

This is a passive clause. In some languages, it may be necessary to use an active verb and to make the agent explicit. Probably the agent here is the sins themselves. Sinful actions show themselves through their own harmful results. For example:

When I would heal Israel,

The guilt of Ephraim reveals itself (NJPS)

Another way to translate this idea using active verbs is to express who sees the sins instead of expressing what agent exposed them. For example:

Whenever I want to heal Israel, all I can see is Ephraim's sin and Samaria's wickedness. (GW)

General Comment on 7:1b–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine the parallel parts. For example, the CEV combines “sins” with “crimes”:

but then I see the crimes in Israel and Samaria. (CEV)

General Comment on 6:11b–7:1c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder some of the parts in these clauses. It may also be more natural to express the relationships between the parts in a different way. For example:

Although I long to heal my people and make them prosperous again, I cannot. That is because their sins and evil deeds are so obvious.

I want to restore the prosperity of my people. I want to heal Israel. But then I see before me the corruption of Ephraim and the wickedness of Samaria. It is too much!

7:1c

as well as the crimes of Samaria.

- and the crimes of Samaria can be clearly seen.
- and in their capital city of Samaria.
- and the wicked things that the people of Samaria do, clearly show that they strongly desire to continue sinning.

7:1d–f

These verse parts further explain the statements in 7:1b–c by giving examples of the sins that are clearly seen. In Hebrew and in some English versions, these examples are introduced with a conjunction as in the BSB.

Many versions do not have a conjunction here. Instead they let the context imply the relationship of these verse parts to the previous clauses. For example:

People cheat each other. (GW)

Use a natural way in your language to introduce explanatory examples.

7:1d

For they practice deceit

- For the people deceive each other.
- Yes, people tell lies and cheat one another.

they practice deceit: In Hebrew, this clause is literally “they do [a] falsehood/lie.” It refers to words and actions that are false. It includes telling lies, giving false testimony in court, and cheating, or deceiving others. TWOT (#2461), NIDOTTE (#9214), and Keil (page 104).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they deceive one another

People cheat each other. (GW)

7:1e–f

combined/reordered

- Groups of thieves rob people everywhere and even murder them.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{1e}and thieves **break in**;

^{1f} bandits **raid in the streets**.

The contrasting locations, inside and outside, are probably a figure of speech (merism). This figure of speech uses the contrast of inside and outside to mean “everywhere.” It means that people commit these crimes everywhere in the nation of Israel. Stuart (page 118). Some versions make the contrast more explicit. For example:

Thieves are on the inside and bandits on the outside! (NLT)

thieves...bandits: In Hebrew, the word that the BSB translates here as bandits describes a group of robbers who steal from people and often murder them. It is a different form of the same word that the BSB translates as “raiders” in 6:9a.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

Thieves...robbers (NCV)

break in...raid in the streets: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as break in is literally “enters.” The idea of breaking into houses to steal from people is implied in the context.

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as raid in the streets is literally “attacks...outside.” The word “attacks” means to assault or even murder someone and take their clothing and possessions. HALOT (#7788, sense #2) and Andersen and Freedman (page 445).

7:1e
and thieves break in;

- They enter houses to steal,
- Inside people’s houses thieves steal.

7:1f
bandits raid in the streets.

- and they rob people in the streets.
- Outside in the streets, gangs of robbers attack.

Hosea 7:2

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people’s future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced

that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns (“you”) and sometimes third person pronouns (“they” or “he”) to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5–10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use “you” in 6:11 and “they” in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on “you” in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment
(NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

Paragraph 6:7–7:2

In this paragraph, the LORD gave examples of how the people of Israel had failed to know him and had failed to show love to him and others.

7:2a–b

This verse continues the description of the deceitful people. Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{2a}But they fail to consider in their hearts that I remember all their evil.

^{2b}Now their deeds are all around them; they are always before My face.

The first clauses in 7:2a and 7:2b indicate that the people are unaware of the true results of their sins. The second clauses indicate that the LORD knows about all their sins and remembers them.

7:2a

But they fail to consider in their hearts that I remember all their evil.

- They are not aware that I remember every evil thing they do.

- They do not stop and think that I know about all their sins.

But they fail to consider in their hearts that I remember all their evil: In Hebrew, 7:2a begins with a conjunction that connects the people's wickedness in 7:1d-f and their failure to realize the true situation in 7:2a-b. The preceding context describes people who live deceitfully as if the LORD did not care. But the true situation in 7:2a-b is that God does indeed care.

Here are some ways to indicate this relationship:

- Use an explicit conjunction, as the BSB does. For example:

and the bandits raid outside. But they do not consider that I remember all their wickedness... (NRSV)

marauders raid in the open; and they never pause to consider that I remember all their wicked deeds... (NJB)

- Do not use an explicit conjunction. Allow the context to imply the relationship. For example:

and gangs rob people out in the streets. They do not realize that I remember all of their wicked deeds... (NET)

and robbers are in the streets. It never enters their minds that I remember all their evil deeds... (NCV)

Use a natural way in your language to indicate this relationship.

they fail to consider: This phrase means "they are unaware" or "they do not think about."

that I remember: In this context, these words mean "I notice" or "I think about," or "I don't forget." They indicate that the LORD knows about their evil deeds. They are not hidden from him.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

I have seen (CEV)

I am watching (NLT)

all their evil: This phrase refers to actions that are against God's will, such as dishonest or immoral behavior.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

all the evil things they've done (GW)

all their wickedness (NRSV)

7:2b

Now their deeds are all around them; they are before My face.

- But the truth is that their sins surround them. They are constantly in my sight.
- Their sins are like an army that encircles/surrounds them. I do not forget even one.

Now their deeds are all around them: This is a figure of speech (personification). It describes the people's evil deeds as enemy soldiers who have surrounded and captured them. Hubbard (pages 131-132) and McComiskey (page 101). This figure of speech may imply two things:

1. They have many sins.
2. The people cannot free themselves from their sin and its consequences.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Keep the personification. For example:

their misdeeds encircle them (REB)

- Make explicit the implied comparison to enemy soldiers. For example:

Their wicked deeds are like enemies who have surrounded them.

Now: This conjunction may indicate a time reference or introduce a contrast. For example:

Their evil deeds have now surrounded them (NET)

It never enters their heads that I will remember all this evil; but their sins surround them (GNT)

In some languages, it may be more natural to allow the context to imply the relationship between this clause and the previous one and not have a conjunction here. For example:

Its people don't realize I am watching them. Their sinful deeds are all around them (NLT)

Any of these options are acceptable. Use a natural way in your language to indicate one of these relationships.

they are before My face: This clause is parallel to the clause “I remember all their evil” in 7:2a. The meaning is related. God always sees every evil deed the people do, and he does not forget them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they are right in front of me (NCV)

I see them all (NLT)

their own deeds...stare me in the face (NJB)

Hosea 7:3

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people’s future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns (“you”) and sometimes third person pronouns (“they” or “he”) to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5–10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use “you” in 6:11 and “they” in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on “you” in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment (NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

7:3a–b (combined/reordered)

- ¶ “When the people tell lies and do other wicked things, they make the king and his officials very happy.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{3a} They delight the king **with their evil**,

^{3b}and the princes **with their lies**.

There is an ellipsis in 7:3b. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing verb from 7:3a. For example:

^{3b} they delight the princes **with their lies**.

These lines both indicate that the wicked deeds of the people of Israel delighted their rulers.

king...princes: See how you translated “king or prince” in 3:4a.

their evil...their lies: The word evil refers to actions that are against God’s will, such as dishonest or immoral behavior. See how you translated “evil” in 7:2a.

The word lies refers here to lies or deceit. TWOT (#975a). The words evil and lies are parallel here. This may indicate that deceit was the specific kind of wickedness that delighted the king and the other officials.

Here are some other ways to translate these parallel words:

sin...deceit (CEV)

evil schemes...lies (NET)

wickedness...treachery (REB)

7:3a

They delight the king with their evil,

- ¶ “The people please the king of Israel when they do these evil things.
- ¶ “Their sins make kings happy.

They delight the king: The word delight is literally “make glad.” It means that the people’s wicked actions caused the king to be happy. For 7:3 the GNT has: “...People deceive the king and his officers by their evil plots.” No commentaries or other versions used

in preparing these Notes mentioned a textual option or interpretation that involved the word “deceive.” It is recommended that you follow other versions. Probably this ruler was glad because the evil deeds benefited him. McComiskey (pages 101–102).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they make the king happy (NCV)

they make the king glad (NRSV)

the king: In Hebrew, there is no article the here. It is possible that this lack of an article indicates any king, not a specific king. McComiskey (page 101). For example:

They make kings happy (GW)

They make a king merry (NJPS)

7:3b

and the princes with their lies.

- They delight his officials with their lies.
- Their deceit makes other leaders/rulers glad.

the princes: The word princes probably refers here to the rulers and officials that serve under a king.

Here are some ways to translate this word:

the king and his officials (CEV)

their rulers (NCV)

chief men (NJB)

General Comment on 7:3a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine the parallel parts. For example:

The people’s deceit pleases their rulers.

Hosea 7:4

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people’s future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced

that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns (“you”) and sometimes third person pronouns (“they” or “he”) to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5–10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use “you” in 6:11 and “they” in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on “you” in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment
(NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

7:4a

They are all adulterers,

- All the Israelites are adulterers.
- All of them are disloyal/unfaithful to me.

They are all adulterers: The pronoun They refers to all the people of Israel. It includes the king and his officials.

Here the term adulterers probably refers to marital unfaithfulness and also unfaithfulness to God. Keil (page 104) regards “adulterers” to refer primarily to spiritual adultery – apostasy from the Lord and secondarily to literal adultery that is part of Baal worship. McComiskey (page 104) regards literal marital unfaithfulness as the most probable referent. If possible, translate the phrase in such a way that both literal and spiritual adultery can be understood.

One way to do that is to describe the characteristics of an adulterer. For example:

They are all treacherous and disloyal. (GNT)

7:4b

like an oven heated by a baker

- Their desire to do evil burns within them like the fire/coals in an oven.
- They strongly desire to do evil.

like an oven heated by a baker: This phrase is a simile that compares the people of Israel to a hot oven. In this simile, the heat of the oven represents the people's strong desire for doing evil. Their desire burns hot within them just as fire burns hot in an oven.

oven: In Hebrew, this word refers to a small oven used for baking bread. It was made from clay. It had openings for air near the bottom, and it had a large door on top. It usually had a stone floor.

A baker placed wood, dried grass, or dung inside the oven and lit it on fire. It burned until the interior of the oven was glowing hot and the fuel had burned down to hot coals or ash. The baker then pressed the dough onto the inside surface of the oven walls or laid it among the coals. The baker then sealed the door at the top of the oven and waited for the bread to bake. Macintosh (page 258) and Stuart (page 119).

In some cultures, people may not be familiar with ovens. If that is true in your area, an option is to substitute a different comparison that has the same meaning and impact. For example:

cooking pot

7:4c

who needs not stoke the fire from the kneading to the rising of the dough.

- The oven stays hot while the baker prepares the dough. He doesn't even need to stir up the coals before baking the bread.
- Their desire is so strong it never lessens.
- Their desire is like a hot cooking pot. It stays hot during the entire time the food is being prepared for cooking. It is so hot that no one needs to make the fire hotter when it is time to cook the food.

who needs not stoke the fire from the kneading to the rising of the dough: This sentence part describes the intense heat in the oven. The fire in the oven is so hot that the baker does not need to stir the coals (stoke) to keep it going or to make the oven any hotter. In this simile, the intensity of heat represents the intensity of the people's desire for evil. Some versions make it explicit that the extreme heat is the reason that the fire does not need to be stirred. For example:

They are like a heated oven, an oven so hot that a baker doesn't have to fan its flames when he makes bread. (GW)

If this simile is not clear in your language, see the General Comment on 7:4b–c for some translation options.

from the kneading to the rising of the dough: This phrase describes a period of time during which a baker prepares dough in order to bake bread. The time starts when the baker kneads the bread dough and ends after the dough rises from the effect of yeast. At that point, the bread is ready to place in the oven. Normally a baker needed to stir the fire at that time to make it hot enough to bake the bread. However, this oven is already hot enough, so there is no need for the baker to stir the fire.

The processes of kneading dough and using yeast to make the dough rise may not be known in some cultures. If that is true in your language group, here are some other ways to describe this period of time:

until the dough is ready to bake (GNT)

when he makes bread (GW)

the kneading of the dough: To knead dough means to fold, press, and stretch the bread dough. This process mixes all the ingredients well and makes the dough smooth.

the rising of the dough: To make dough rise, a baker adds yeast to the dough. He then places it undisturbed in a warm place for a while. The yeast causes the bread to expand in size in preparation for baking.

General Comment on 7:4b–c

If the simile of the oven is not clear in your language, here are some other translation options:

- Make explicit the way in which the people are like an oven. For example:

Their desire to do evil burns like an oven whose fire is so hot the baker does not need to stir the coals from the time when he kneads the dough until it rises.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

Their desire for evil is so intense that it never diminishes.

- Use similar figures of speech that convey the right meaning in your language. For example:

They have a strong desire to do evil. Their desire is like a cooking pot that is red-hot. It is already so hot that a cook doesn't need to stir-up the fire when the food is ready to cook.

Hosea 7:5

Section 6:4-7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people's future repentance (6:1-3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns ("you") and sometimes third person pronouns ("they" or "he") to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses "they" in 6:5-10, "you" in 6:4 & 11, and "they" or "he" in 7:1-16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

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Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment
(NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

7:5a

The princes are inflamed with wine on the day of our king;

- ¶ "On the day the king was honored, the king and his officials got sick from drinking too much wine.

- ¶ "At the king's celebration, the rulers get very drunk,

The princes are inflamed with wine: Some versions specify that other people caused the princes to become drunk. These versions include the CEV, KJV, and GNT. For example the CEV has: "his officials got him drunk." This interpretation is unlikely and is not recommended. The subject of the clause is probably the princes themselves. Keil (page 105) notes that the form of the Hebrew verb used here indicates that they caused themselves to become sick by drinking too much. In Hebrew, this clause is literally "the princes became sick with heat from wine." This clause describes the effects of drinking a lot of wine.

The words "became sick" NIDOTTE (#655) identifies both physical and emotional conditions for this Hebrew root, including illness, wounds, and grief. Neither it nor BDB, TWOT, or HALOT identifies the specific nature of the "sickness" caused by the wine here in Hosea 7:5. may imply that the princes were so drunk that they vomited (see the description in Isaiah 28:7-8). The word "heat" may also imply that their faces were flushed. McComiskey (page 104) mentions both vomiting and a flushed face as possibilities. However, it is more likely that these two descriptions are simply figurative ways to indicate that the princes were very drunk. English versions that use words such as inflamed or "heat" may do so to fit the simile of a hot oven in 7:4 and 7:6.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use a natural way in your language to describe the effect of drunkenness. For example:

The rulers became crazy with wine (NCV)

The leaders were overcome with wine.

- Translate the idea of drunkenness directly. Leave the effects of drunkenness implied. For example:

the princes get drunk. (NLT)

on the day of our king: This refers to a celebration of some kind. The celebration may have been the king's coronation day, his birthday, or some other special day to honor him. Many versions do not specify the kind of celebration it was.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

On the day of the king's celebration (GW)

At the holiday for our king (NJB)

7:5b

so he joins hands with those who mock him.

- He joined people who were mocking what is good.
- and the king joins them in showing his arrogance and scorn for others.

so he joins hands with those who mock him: This clause probably means that the king participated with his officials and other wicked people in showing scorn and mockery for God or for other people. The historical context is not known, so it is not possible to determine who the mockers were or what they were saying or doing to show their scorn.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the king joins mockers. (GW)

the king joined in with others who were showing their scorn

those who mock him: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as those who mock him refers to people who are arrogant as well as scornful. But the focus of this word is on the disdainful way that mockers treat others rather than their feelings of pride. In the context of 7:1–4, they are people who reject God and refuse to follow his wise commands. The book of Proverbs describes a “mockers” or “scorners” as haughty, unwise and resistant to correction (21:24; 14:6; 9:7). See TWOT (#1113) for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

scoffers (NASB)

arrogant people who show their scorn/contempt for others

Hosea 7:6

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people’s future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns (“you”) and sometimes third person pronouns (“they” or “he”) to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5–10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use “you” in 6:11 and “they” in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on “you” in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment (NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

7:6a

For they prepare their heart like an oven while they lie in wait;

- Yes, their hearts are hot like an oven as they make secret plans to murder the king.
- Now as for those who are plotting to kill the king, their feelings are very strong.
- When they make their evil plans to kill the king, their anger is hot like a blazing cooking fire.

This verse further explains the simile of the oven in 7:4. In Hebrew and in some English versions, this verse begins with a word that introduces this explanation. For example:

For like an oven their hearts burn with intrigue (RSV)

Yes, they burned like an oven with their plotting. (GNT)

Other versions simply let the context imply this relationship. Use a natural way in your language to indicate that this verse adds more details to the oven simile in 7:4.

they prepare their heart like an oven while they lie in wait: In Hebrew, this verse part is literally “they

have brought near like (the) oven their heart in their deceit.”BART interlinear. There are two main ways to interpret it:

1. It means that people have intense anger or other emotions as they make plans to assassinate the king. For example:

Their hearts are like an oven as they plot. (NJB)
(BSB, ESV, GNT, KJV, NASB, NLT, NJB, NRSV, REB)

1. It means that people approach the king with intense anger or other emotions in order to assassinate him. For example:

the plotters approach with hearts like ovens
(NAB) (NAB, NET, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It best fits the Hebrew grammar. McComiskey (page 105) points out that qerbu (“they bring”) is understood as a piel in the MT, so “it has the sense of bringing near rather than drawing near.” Here the idea is that they bring their heart like an oven into their treachery. It also seems more logical that a period of intense planning (7:6a) would precede the waiting (7:6b) and eventual action (7:6c). It is less likely that the plotters would approach and then allow their emotions to smolder all night.

This statement is a simile. In this simile, the hearts of people are compared to an oven. Their strong feelings as they treacherously make evil plans is like the extreme heat of the oven. See the General Comment on 7:6a–c following 7:6c for other ways to translate this simile and the related figures of speech in this verse.

they: This pronoun probably refers to the princes in 7:5.

heart: The people of Israel considered the heart to be the center of attitudes and thoughts. Some languages use a different body organ, such as the liver, to signify attitudes and thoughts. Use an expression that is natural in your language for this purpose.

lie in wait: In Hebrew, this word usually refers to an ambush in which people wait in hiding in order to kill their enemies or victims. It probably refers here to a treacherous plan to murder the king. See NIDOTTE (#741) or TWOT (#156) for a more complete description of the contexts in which this Hebrew root is used. Stuart (page 120), McComiskey (page 105), Andersen and Freedman (pages 459–460), Hubbard (page 135), and Macintosh (page 265) all understand this verse to refer to a conspiracy to murder the king.

7:6b

all night their anger smolders;

- The heat of their anger/emotions is like coals that smolder all night.
- For a time they control their feelings/anger as they wait to do what they have planned.
- The flames die down and the coals glow through the night.

all night their anger smolders: There is a textual issue here: (1) The Syriac and Targum have “their anger/passion.” For example, the NRSV says, “All night their anger smolders.” All English versions except the NJPS follow this text. It is supported by Stuart (pages 116, 120) and Kidner (page 70). (2) The MT has “their baker.” For example, the NJPS says, “Through the night Their baker has slept.” This text is supported by Andersen and Freedman (page 449), Hubbard (page 135), Keil (page 106), Macintosh (page 263), and McComiskey (page 105). See McComiskey for grammatical reasons in favor of this text. It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with almost all English versions. In option (2) the phrase “their baker” would have to be understood figuratively as part of the oven metaphor. It is difficult to find a figurative meaning that fits logically in the context. This clause is a metaphor that continues the simile of the oven in 7:6a. In this metaphor, the people’s anger or passion is compared to the coals in an oven. During the night the coals are allowed to smolder or die down. Similarly, the intensity of the people’s emotion is at a low level during the night. They are waiting for the right time to put their plans into action.

Here are some other ways to express this similarity:

All night long their anger is low (NCV)

Their plot smolders through the night (NLT)

all night: In the metaphor of the smoldering coals, the phrase all night refers to a literal night. In terms of the people’s anger or plotting, it may refer to an actual night. It may also refer to a longer period of time during which the people waited to take action.

7:6c

in the morning it blazes like a flaming fire.

- In the morning it becomes raging hot again like a flaming/blazing fire.
- When the opportunity comes, they energetically put their plans into action.
- When the morning comes, they fan the coals and the fire blazes hotter than before.

in the morning it blazes like a flaming fire: In the morning, after the coals have smoldered all night, the person who tends the oven causes the fire to burn brightly again. This figure of speech indicates that after a period of relative calm, the people suddenly and vigorously put their evil plans into action.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

then flares up at dawn (CEV)

in the morning it breaks out like a raging fire (NLT96)

General Comment on 7:6a–c

If the figures of speech that relate to the heat of an oven are not clear in your language, here are some other translation options:

- Make explicit the way in which the people's hearts are like an oven. For example:

^{6a}Yes, their hearts become hot like an oven in their evil schemes. ^{6b}The heat of their anger/emotions smolders all night. ^{6c}In the morning it blazes hot like a flaming fire.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

^{6a}The feelings of those who are plotting against the king are very strong. ^{6b}For a time they restrain their anger. ^{6c}When the opportunity comes they energetically put their plans into action.

- Use similar figures of speech that convey the right meaning in your language. For example:

^{6a}When they make their evil plans to kill the king, their livers are hot like a roaring cooking fire. ^{6b}The flames die down and the coals glow through the night. ^{6c}When the morning comes they fan the coals and the fire blazes hotter than before.

Hosea 7:7

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people's future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced

that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns ("you") and sometimes third person pronouns ("they" or "he") to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses "they" in 6:5–10, "you" in 6:4 & 11, and "they" or "he" in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use "you" in 6:11 and "they" in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on "you" in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment (NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

7:7a–d

This verse consists of two sets of parallel lines. In the first set, 7:7b gives the expected result of the people's angry desire in 7:7a. In the second set, 7:7d gives the unexpected result of the deaths of their kings in 7:7c.

^{7a}All of them are hot as an oven,

^{7b}and they devour **their rulers**.

^{7c}All **their kings** fall;

^{7d}not one of them calls upon Me.

Notice that 7:7b and 7:7c are similar to each other in meaning. However, 7:7b describes the murders primarily from the standpoint of those who committed the murders. Verse 7:7c describes the murders from the standpoint of the kings who were murdered.

7:7a

All of them are hot as an oven,

- Yes, their anger/emotion is like a hot oven/fire.
- Due to their strong/hot feelings,

All of them are hot as an oven: This statement repeats the simile of the oven from 7:4 and 7:6. The word “hearts” is not made explicit here as it was in 7:6a, but the function of the simile is the same. It compares the people’s angry desire to do harm to the heat of an oven. Their intense emotions lead them to commit the specific acts of murder described in 7:7b–c.

Here are some other ways to translate this simile:

Their anger/emotion is like a hot oven.

In the heat of their anger (GNT)

All of them: This phrase may refer specifically to the people who are involved in the plot to murder the leaders of Israel. It may also refer more generally to the people of Israel. If possible, translate this phrase so that it can refer to either group.

All: This word refers here to the group as a whole, not necessarily to every individual in the group. Notice that the GNT (quoted above) does not make the word All explicit. You should use a natural way in your language to emphasize that the whole group was burning with anger.

7:7b

and they devour their rulers.

- And like a fire that destroys what it burns, they destroy their rulers.
- they murder their leaders.

they devour their rulers: In Hebrew, the word devour often refers literally to eating food. It also refers figuratively to a fire that “consumes” what it burns or a sword that “devours” those that it kills (see Leviticus 6:10, 10:2; Deuteronomy 32:42). In this context, it probably continues the figurative idea of the blazing flames and hot oven. A fire destroys what it burns or consumes. Similarly, the people referred to in 7:7a destroy or kill their rulers. BDB (#398, sense 1a4) and HALOT (#473, sense 3) give the word the figurative sense of “destroy” in this context. Andersen and Freedman (pages 460–461) understand a connection to the imagery of the oven. Stuart (page 120) says that 7:7 marks the climax of the oven simile.

Here are some ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Use a figure of speech. For example:

They consume their judges [like a fire]. (GW)

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

they murdered their rulers (GNT)

their rulers: In Hebrew, the word rulers is literally judges. It can refer to any leader who governs or rules a group of people and is responsible for carrying out justice. BDB (#8199, sense 1a), TWOT (#2443). In this context, the phrase their rulers is a poetic parallel with their kings. It probably describes the same leaders. Andersen and Freedman (page 460), Keil (page 106), McComiskey (page 106), and Stuart (page 120) all identify the “judges” in 7:7b with the “kings” in 7:7c. Hubbard (pages 135–136) acknowledges that “judges (rulers) is an appropriate term to describe the kings whose responsibility was to enforce justice.” But he says that the word more likely refers here to the “princes” or “courtiers” who were responsible to carry out the king’s orders.

7:7c

All their kings fall;

- The kings of Israel fall/die one after another.
- Yes, they assassinate king after king.

All their kings fall: This expression is similar in meaning to the previous clause. It means that the kings of Israel are murdered. Keil (page 106) and McComiskey (page 106).

All: In this context the word All is a figure of speech (hyperbole). This figure of speech emphasizes that people kill many of the kings. It does not refer literally to every king of Israel. It probably refers to the kings of Israel who were assassinated following the death of Jeroboam II. Four of the six kings during that period were assassinated. McComiskey (page 106).

In some languages, a literal translation of this hyperbole may not be understood correctly.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

Their kings have been assassinated one after another (GNT)

They kill their kings one after another (NLT)

So many of their kings have died!

7:7d

not one of them calls upon Me.

- And even in this terrible situation, no one calls to me for help.
- Yet/But no one prays to me.

and: The phrase “none of them” contrasts with the phrases “all of them” in 7:7a and “All their kings” in 7:7c. Verse 7:7d also gives the unexpected result of the series of murders described in 7:7b–c. According to McComiskey, verse 7:7d expresses Hosea’s amazement that no one recognized the seriousness of their situation and asked God to deliver them (page 106). This line also expresses the LORD’s bitter disappointment that no one turned to him (Stuart, page 120). Hebrew the BSB and some other versions do not use a conjunction here. Some other versions use the word and or “but.” Use a natural way in your language to indicate that 7:7d is an unexpected result.

not one of them: This phrase may refer in a general way to none of the people of Israel. It may also refer specifically to none of the kings or government officials. If possible, translate this phrase so that it can refer to either group.

calls upon Me: This phrase means to pray to God.

Here are some other ways to translate 7:7d:

but no one prays to me for help (GNT)

and no one cries out to me for help (NLT)

Hosea 7:8

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people’s future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns (“you”) and sometimes third person pronouns (“they” or “he”) to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5–10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use “you” in 6:11 and “they” in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and

least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on “you” in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment (NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

Paragraph 7:8–9

The previous verses spoke of the evil within the kingdom of Israel. This paragraph starts a new topic. It describes the relationships between the kingdom of Israel and other nations and the ungodliness that results from those relationships. Some versions use a heading here to indicate the change of topic. For example:

Israel and the Nations (GNT)

Israel Turns to Other Nations for Help (GW)

If you decide to use a heading here, you may need to indicate that the LORD is still speaking. For example:

Then the LORD said, “...

7:8–11

In 7:8, 7:9, and 7:11, the Hebrew pronoun that refers to the nation or people of Israel is “he.” In 7:10, the Hebrew pronoun is “they.” Some versions use “he” throughout these verses. Other versions use “they.” Use whatever pronoun or pronoun referent is natural in your language to refer to a nation or the people of a nation.

7:8a–b (combined/reordered)

- ¶ Then Yahweh also said, “The people of Israel are worthless. They are like bread that is baked on only one side. They mix with ungodly foreigners and learn their evil ways.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{8a} Ephraim **mixes with the nations;**

^{8b} Ephraim is an unturned cake.

Both lines describe the ruined condition of Ephraim. The first line gives a literal description of behavior that resulted in ruin. The second line describes Ephraim's ruin with a metaphor.

7:8a

Ephraim mixes with the nations;

- ¶ "The people of Ephraim mingle with the ungodly nations nearby.
- ¶ "The people of Israel do not separate themselves from the people of other nations. They adopt wicked customs.

Ephraim: The word Ephraim here is a figure of speech that represents the nation or people of Israel. In some languages, it may be clearer to translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

Israel mixes with other nations (NCV)

mixes: The word mixes is commonly used in the context of baking. Here, however, the word indicates that the nation of Israel has adopted the customs of nations around them. It implies that the people of Israel did not keep themselves holy. Some versions make this implied information explicit. For example:

My people of Israel mingle with godless foreigners, picking up their evil ways. (NLT96)

nations: In Hebrew, this word is literally "peoples." Here it refers to various people groups in that region with whom the Israelite people interacted. This included the Assyrians, Egyptians, and probably Canaanite groups. Andersen and Freedman (page 463).

7:8b

Ephraim is an unturned cake.

- They are like a half-baked loaf of bread.
- They have become worthless.
- They are as worthless as ruined food, burned on one side and uncooked on the other side.

Ephraim is an unturned cake: This statement is a metaphor. In this metaphor, the nation of Israel is compared to an unturned cake of bread. An unturned cake is a flat, round loaf of bread that is hard and burned on one side and uncooked on the other side. The way in which Israel is like an unturned cake is that it is ruined and worthless.

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

General Comment on 7:8a–b

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Ephraim is a half-baked cake (NJB)

they are a thin piece of bread scorched on one side (CEV)

- Change the metaphor into a simile. For example:

Now they have become as worthless as a half-baked cake! (NLT)

he is like a pancake cooked only on one side (NCV)

Ephraim is like a ruined cake of bread that is scorched on one side. (NET)

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

Israel has become worthless.

- Use a similar figure of speech that conveys the right meaning in your language. For example:

Israel is as useless as burned food.

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine the parallel parts. For example:

^{8b}Then the LORD said, "The people of Israel are worthless. They are like a flat loaf of bread that is baked on only one side. ^{8a}They mix with ungodly foreigners and learn their evil ways."

Hosea 7:9

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people's future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns ("you") and sometimes third person pronouns ("they" or "he") to refer to the people

of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5–10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use “you” in 6:11 and “they” in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on “you” in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment
(NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

Paragraph 7:8–9

The previous verses spoke of the evil within the kingdom of Israel. This paragraph starts a new topic. It describes the relationships between the kingdom of Israel and other nations and the ungodliness that results from those relationships. Some versions use a heading here to indicate the change of topic. For example:

Israel and the Nations (GNT)

Israel Turns to Other Nations for Help (GW)

If you decide to use a heading here, you may need to indicate that the LORD is still speaking. For example:

Then the LORD said, “...

7:9a–b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{9a} Foreigners consume his strength, **but he does not notice.**

^{9b} Even his hair is streaked with gray, **but he does not know.**

Both lines describe the weakened condition of the nation of Israel and their lack of awareness of it. The

first line gives a literal description of what has weakened Israel. The second line describes its weakness with a metaphor.

7:9a

Foreigners consume his strength, but he does not notice.

- Foreign nations have taken away their strength, but they are not aware of it.
- They do not notice that these people from other countries have made them weak.

Foreigners consume his strength: This clause refers to the harmful and weakening effect that other nations had on Israel. For example, the king of Assyria reduced Israel’s strength by capturing cities, sending people into exile, and requiring the payment of large amounts of money (2 Kings 15:19–31).

consume his strength: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “consumed/eaten his strength.” In this context, it means to weaken Israel or reduce Israel’s strength as a country.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Foreigners are using up your strength (GW)

Other nations made them weak

but: The statement that follows contrasts with the previous statement. Many versions introduce the contrast with a word such as but. Use a natural way in your language to introduce a contrast with the previous statement.

he does not notice: In Hebrew, this clause is literally “he knows not.” In this context, it indicates that the people of Israel fail to perceive or recognize that they have become weak. It may also imply that they are not willing to admit it.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they don’t even know it (NLT)

he is unaware (REB)

he has taken no notice (NJPS)

7:9b

Even his hair is streaked with gray, but he does not know.

- The people of Israel are like a weak old man with gray hair, but they do not realize it.
- The nation of Israel is like a gray haired man who does not know how old and feeble he is.
- Israel does not understand that the end of the nation is near.

his hair is streaked with gray: This statement is a metaphor. In this metaphor, the nation of Israel is compared to a man with gray hair.

Here are some ways in which they are similar:

1. Both are nearing the end of their lifetime.
2. Both are weak.

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor along with the following clause:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

even his hair is turning grey but he is unconscious of it. (NJB)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

The people of Israel are like a man whose hair is grey.

- Change the metaphor into a simile and make explicit one or more of the similarities. For example:

Israel is like an old man with graying hair, unaware of how weak and old he has become. (NLT)

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

Their days are numbered, but they don't even know it. (GNT)

but he does not know: In Hebrew, these words are the same as the words “he does not notice” in 7:9a.

Hosea 7:10

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people's future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns (“you”) and sometimes third person pronouns (“they” or “he”) to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5–10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use “you” in 6:11 and “they” in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on “you” in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment (NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

7:10a

Israel's arrogance testifies against them,

- ¹⁰“Israel's arrogance is like a witness who accuses him.
- ¹⁰“The people of Israel are proud of their nation. Their pride is like a witness who accuses him of doing wrong,

Israel's arrogance testifies against them: This clause is identical to 5:5a. See the notes there.

7:10b–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{10b}yet they do not **return to the LORD their God**

^{10c}despite all this, they do not **seek Him**.

Both lines describe the result of Israel's arrogance.

7:10b

yet they do not return to the LORD their God;

- The people of Israel refuse to return to Yahweh, their God
- they will not turn from their sin and turn to me, Yahweh, their God.

yet: In Hebrew, there is no word here that means yet. However, the context indicates that the statement

that follows contrasts with the previous statements. The BSB and most versions supply the word yet or “but” to indicate this contrast. For example:

but even after all this (GW)

yet they do not return (NRSV)

return to the LORD their God: This phrase means to repent of sin and do what God approves. TWOT (#2340).

7:10c

despite all this, they do not seek Him.

- Even though all these things are true, they do not seek/desire him.
- But in spite of their bad/weak condition, their desire to worship me is completely gone.

despite all this: This phrase indicates a concessive idea. Although Israel’s deteriorating circumstances should motivate the people to turn to God, nevertheless they do not do that.

Here are some other ways to express this idea:

even after all this (GW)

In spite of everything that has happened (GNT)

all this: These words probably refer back to 7:8-10a: Israel’s ruined condition, their weakness, and the pride that kept them from perceiving or acknowledging these things. Andersen and Freedman (page 468).

they do not seek Him: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as they do not seek Him means to earnestly desire the LORD, his promises, and his requirements. TWOT (#276). For more information, see the note on “return and seek the LORD their God” in 3:5a and the note on “turn back to me...they will look for me” in 5:15b-c.

Hosea 7:11

Section 6:4-7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people’s future repentance (6:1-3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns (“you”) and sometimes third person pronouns (“they” or “he”) to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5-10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1-16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use “you” in 6:11 and “they” in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5-10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5-10. In 6:7-10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on “you” in 2:16b-c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment (NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

7:11a

So Ephraim has become like a silly, senseless dove

- ¶ “The people of Israel are not able to think clearly and are easily deceived. They are like a dove
- ¶ “They are as foolish as a senseless bird, easy to trick.

So Ephraim has become like a silly, senseless dove:

This statement is a simile. In this simile, Ephraim is compared to a dove. The way in which Ephraim is like a dove is that both lack sense and are silly or easy to deceive. Try to keep this simile in your translation if possible, since a similar figure of speech also occurs in the next verse.

However, if this simile is not natural in your language, here are some other possible ways to translate it:

- Translate the figure of speech using a substitute for dove. See the options under the note on dove below.
- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

Israel has been gullible and stupid.

Ephraim: The tribe of Ephraim here probably represents all the people of the nation of Israel. See the note on Ephraim at 7:8a.

silly: This phrase refers to people who are naive or gullible. Such people quickly believe anything they are told, so it is easy to persuade them to do something that is foolish or wrong.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

easily deceived (NIV)

easy to fool (NCV)

senseless: This word means “lack good judgment.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

stupid (NCV)

lacking discernment (NET)

dove: In Hebrew, this word refers to either a dove or a pigeon. These are domesticated birds that are easily frightened. They also flutter from one place to another without a clear reason.

If doves and pigeons are unknown in your area, here are some other options:

- Use a general word instead of dove. For example:

Israel is a senseless bird fluttering back and forth (CEV)

- Substitute a different bird with similar characteristics that is known in your area.

7:11b–c

calling out to Egypt, then turning to Assyria.

- that flutters back and forth. At one moment they call to Egypt. The next moment they go to Assyria.
- They request help from one enemy after another, first the Egyptians and then the Assyrians.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{11b} calling out **to Egypt**,

^{11c} then turning **to Assyria**.

These lines continue the simile that compares Ephraim to a dove. Together the lines explain the way in which Ephraim was silly and senseless. The leaders of Israel did not call to God or seek him in their distress. Instead they sought alliances with enemy nations. The way they went back and forth

between Egypt and Assyria, asking for help, was like a dove that flutters unpredictably from one place to another. McComiskey (page 111).

calling out to Egypt, then turning to Assyria: These parallel lines probably indicate that the leaders of Israel requested an alliance with Egypt. They then broke that alliance in order to make an alliance with Assyria.

Some versions add a word such as now to each line to express a sense of change from one thing to another. At one moment, Ephraim is allied with one country. At the next moment, he is allied with another country.

Here are some other ways to express this sense of change:

First they call to Egypt for help. Then they run to Assyria. (NCV)

now calling to Egypt, now turning to Assyria. (NIV)

fluttering back and forth between Egypt and Assyria (CEV)

calling out...turning: In this context, the phrase calling out and the word turning both mean to request help. Specifically, calling out to Egypt and turning to Assyria probably indicate that Israel requested alliances with those wealthy and powerful countries. These alliances would ensure military and other assistance.

Hosea 7:12

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people's future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns (“you”) and sometimes third person pronouns (“they” or “he”) to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5–10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use “you” in 6:11 and “they” in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on “you” in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment
(NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

7:12a–b

As they go, I will spread My net over them;

- But on their way there, I will trap them as a hunter traps birds in a net.
- But I will stop the Israelites as they attempt to go to Assyria and Egypt.

7:12a

As they go: This clause probably implies “As they go to Assyria” or “As they go to Assyria and Egypt.” The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as *As* has various possible meanings, depending on the context.

Here are some other ways to translate the clause:

When they go (NIV)

while they are flying (NET)

Wherever they turn (NJB)

7:12c

I will bring them down like birds of the air.

- I will catch/net them as they take off.
- I will not let them go far.

7:12b–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{12b} I will spread My net over **them**;

^{12c} I will bring **them** down like birds of the air.

These lines expand the simile that compares Ephraim to a dove. Here the people of Israel are compared to a flock of birds that the LORD will capture in a net. The

nonfigurative meaning is that the LORD will stop the Israelites as they attempt to go to Assyria and Egypt to negotiate alliances.

I will spread My net over them; I will bring them down like birds of the air: These lines figuratively describe the LORD as a bird trapper. A trapper throws a net over the birds just as they are beginning to take off. The net prevents them from flying away so that he can capture them.

birds of the air: In Hebrew, this phrase is a common way to refer to birds. In many languages, it is not natural to make the phrase of the air explicit. For example:

birds (REB)

7:12d

I will chastise them when I hear them flocking together.

- Yes, when I hear them gathering like a flock of birds, I will capture them.
- When the news spreads that they have gathered to negotiate an alliance, I will discipline them.

I will chastise them when I hear them flocking together: In Hebrew, this verse part is literally “I will chasten them at/when (or: “according to”) a report about/to their assembly.” There is a textual issue here:

1. The Masoretic Text has the words “report” and “assembly.” For example:

I shall take them captive when I hear them gathering. The REB expresses the Hebrew nouns “report” and “assembly” as verbs: “hear” (a report) and “gathering” (in an assembly). (REB) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NASB, NET, NIV, NJPS, NRSV, REB)

1. Some versions delete the word “report” and change the word “assembly” to “wicked.” For example:

I will chastise them for their wicked deeds. (RSV) (GW, GNT, NCV, NJB, NLT, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with all the commentaries used in preparing these Notes. The LXX and Vulgate both support the use of these words. See Macintosh (pages 275–279) for more details.

There are two main ways to interpret the Hebrew word that precedes “report”:

1. The word means “at” or when. McComiskey (page 112), Macintosh (page 276), and HALOT (#4305, sense 7b temporal). With this meaning, verse 7:12d refers to the time when the LORD will hear about the Israelites gathering together like a flock of birds. At that time, he will discipline them. For example:

I will discipline them when I hear them flocking together. (NET) (BSB, NET, NIV, NJPS, REB)

1. The word means “according to.” With this meaning, verse 7:12d indicates that the LORD will discipline the Israelites. He will do this in a way that accords with a report that is made to an assembly of people. For example:

I will discipline them according to the report made to their congregation. (ESV) (ESV, KJV, NASB, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation continues the figurative description of the LORD as a trapper who catches birds in a net.

I will chastise them: In Hebrew, the word chastise is literally “chasten.” This word can refer to moral instruction, rebuke, or punishment. The purpose is to correct wrong behavior. In this context, it indicates that the LORD will discipline or punish the people of Israel. NIDOTTE (#3579) and Davies (page 140). He will probably do this by allowing Assyria to capture them and take them into exile. McComiskey (page 112) and Keil (page 109).

Here are some ways to translate 7:12d:

- Use one or more metaphors that continue the figurative language of 7:12b–c. See the NIV, REB, and NET (quoted above).
- Change one or more of the metaphors to a simile. For example:

When I hear them gathering together like a flock of birds, I will punish them.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

I will chastise them when I hear their bargaining. (NJPS)

when I hear them flocking together: This clause translates the Hebrew words in a figurative way. It describes the time when a trapper hears the noise of birds that have gathered together in a flock.

This clause refers to the time when the LORD hears news about a group of people who have gathered together. This gathering may refer to Israel’s leaders who meet with representatives of Egypt and/or Assyria to seek aid from them. See Wood (page 199) and Macintosh (page 276).

Hosea 7:13

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people’s future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns (“you”) and sometimes third person pronouns (“they” or “he”) to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5–10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use “you” in 6:11 and “they” in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5–10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5–10. In 6:7–10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on “you” in 2:16b–c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment (NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

7:13a–b (combined/reordered)

- ¶ They have rebelled against me and left me. Therefore they will undergo severe suffering.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{13a} Woe to them, for **they have strayed from me!**

^{13b} Destruction to them, for **they have rebelled against me!**

In the first parallel pair in each line, the LORD declares that the people will experience disaster. The second parallel pair gives the reasons for this disaster.

Woe to them...Destruction to them: The first expression, Woe to them, predicts or threatens terrible trouble or sorrow for the people of Israel. The second expression identifies the Woe as Destruction or disaster. It warns the people that someone will destroy them.

Neither of these expressions has a verb. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply verbs. For example:

They will experience great trouble...Destruction will come to them

They will have great sorrow...They will die

Some languages may also express threats or warnings of this nature with an expression or exclamation that emphasizes the awfulness of the disaster. TWOT (#42) and NIDOTTE (#208) point out that “woe” functions as an exclamation of despair when it occurs with a first person pronoun (Woe to me/us!). It functions as a threat of judgment when it occurs with a second or third person pronoun (Woe to you/them!). For example:

What sorrow awaits...! (NLT)

How horrible it will be... (GW)

for: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces each of the parallel reasons for their destruction. In some languages, these reasons may be implied without a conjunction. For example:

Woe to them, they have strayed from me! Ruin to them, they have sinned against me! (NAB)

they have strayed from Me...they have rebelled against Me: The word strayed often refers to people who literally run away. Here it indicates that the people intentionally left or deserted God. The word rebelled indicates here that the people of Israel rebelled or revolted against the LORD, their divine ruler. They

transgressed by breaking the terms of the covenant between them and the LORD. TWOT (#1846).

Here are some other ways to translate these parallel reasons:

They left me...they turned against me (NCV)

those who have deserted me...they have rebelled against me (NLT)

They have run away from me...they've rebelled against me (GW)

General Comment on 7:13a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine the parallel parts. For example:

Trouble and destruction will be their reward for rejecting me! (CEV)

In some languages, it may also be more natural to put the reasons before the results. For example:

^{13a} They have turned away from me. Therefore they will experience great trouble.

^{13b} They have revolted against me, so they will be destroyed.

7:13a

Woe to them, for they have strayed from Me!

- ¶ “They will have great trouble, because they abandoned me.
- ¶ “The people will soon suffer horribly, because they left me.

7:13b

Destruction to them, for they have rebelled against Me!

- They will experience disaster, for they have turned against me.
- Yes, they rejected me! Therefore an enemy will destroy them.

7:13c

Though I would redeem them, they speak lies against Me.

- I am willing to rescue them from their troubles, but they tell lies about/against me.
- As for me, I want to save them, but as for them, they just lie to me.

Though I would redeem them, they speak lies against Me: In this sentence, the LORD contrasts the good he is willing to do for the people with the evil that the people do against him. He is willing to save the people. But the lies that the people tell about him stop him from doing so.

I would redeem them: In Hebrew, this clause is literally “I will redeem them.” In this context, it probably refers to rescuing the people from enemy armies.

Some versions translate this clause as completed action. But here it probably expresses a current wish or desire, as in the BSB above. Here is another example:

I want to deliver them (NET)

I...they: In Hebrew, the independent pronouns I and they emphasize the contrast between the LORD’s readiness to restore the people and the people’s rebellious attitude. Davies (page 189). If possible, translate in a way that expresses this strong contrast. For example:

As for me, I am ready to save them, but as for them, they only tell lies against me.

they speak lies against Me: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as against Me can also be translated here as “about me” or “to me.” The following options are all acceptable ways to translate this clause:

- “about me” or “against me.” The clause means that the people give false information “about” the LORD. They do not tell the truth when they speak against him. For example:

they speak lies against me (ESV)

they tell lies about me (REB)

- “to me.” The clause means that the people are insincere when they pray. They do not tell the truth when they speak to the LORD. For example:

they have lied to me (NET)

their worship of me was false. (GNT) This option may be the basis for the GNT translation. In 7:14 the GNT has: “They have not prayed to me sincerely.”

Hosea 7:14

Section 6:4–7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people’s future repentance (6:1–3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns (“you”) and sometimes third person pronouns (“they” or “he”) to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5–10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1–16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

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Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment (NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

7:14a

They do not cry out to Me from their hearts

- They refuse to pray to me sincerely.

They do not cry out to Me from their hearts: In Hebrew, cry out means to call for help in a time of distress. TWOT (#570). Another way to translate cry out to Me is “pray to me.” For example:

They do not pray to me (NET)

from their hearts: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “in their heart.” For Hebrew speakers, the heart was the center of reason and emotion. To fail to cry out to God “in” or “from their heart” indicates that the people refused to sincerely request help from God.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

They don't pray to me sincerely (GW)

They do not cry out to me with sincere hearts (NLT)

7:14a-b (combined/reordered)

- They weep loudly on their beds in their despair, but they refuse to believe in me or call to me for help.

7:14b when they wail upon their beds.

- Instead, they just lie on their beds and wail/howl.

but: This word introduces a contrast with the previous statement.

Here is another way to introduce this contrast:

Instead, they sit on their couches and wail (NLT)

Use a natural way in your language to introduce a contrast with the previous statement.

when they wail upon their beds: This part of the sentence describes what the people do instead of sincerely crying out to God in prayer. They lie on their beds and wail because of their hopeless despair or sorrow. These words may also indicate that they cry out in pain from slashing themselves as part of idol worship. Keil (page 109) and McComiskey (page 115). See the note on “they slash themselves” in 7:14c.

beds: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as beds describes a place where people normally lie down and sleep. It can refer to a sleeping mat as well as a piece of furniture. NIDOTTE (#5435). Here in Hosea 7:14, beds may be associated with the ritual sexual activity that was part of idol worship. Stuart (page 123).

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

They just lie on their beds and cry (NCV)

They howl in distress on their beds (NET)

7:14c They slash themselves for grain and new wine,

- They cut themselves when they pray to false gods for grain and wine.
- They slash themselves as they plead to Baal for good crops.

They slash themselves for grain and wine: There is a textual issue here:

1. The LXX and some Hebrew manuscripts have “For grain and new wine they cut themselves.” For example:

They slash themselves for grain and new wine (NET) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NAB, NET, NIV2011, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The Masoretic Text has “For grain and new wine they assemble themselves.” For example:

They come together to ask for grain and new wine. (NCV) (NASB, KJV, NCV, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It makes good sense and fits the context well. It is also easy to explain how the Masoretic Text could be a variant form of the Hebrew word for “cut themselves.” In Hebrew, the letters r (ר) and d (ד) are very similar. A scribe might easily have written r instead of d, so that MT's ytgwrrw (“assemble themselves”) may have come from an original ytgwddw (“cut themselves”). See McComiskey (page 115), ICC (page 280), and Andersen and Freedman (page 475).

They slash themselves: The act of gashing or cutting oneself was a pagan Canaanite custom. The people hoped that Baal would respond to their self-mutilation by providing good crops. Davies (pages 190–191) and NET (footnote b on 7:14). Some versions make this pagan connection explicit. For example:

and slashed themselves, in the hope that Baal will bless their crops. (CEV)

for grain and new wine: This phrase gives the reason that the people cut themselves. They were motivated by a desire to obtain the food and drink they needed to live. For more information on this phrase, see the notes on “grain, new wine, and oil” in 2:8b.

7:14d but turn away from Me.

- They turn from/against me.
- But they renounce/reject me.

but turn away from Me: This verse part may function as a summary or a conclusion to the previous statement. It may also function as a transition to the next verse. Stuart (page 123) suggests that this statement is the first part of a chiasm that continues in verse 15.

but: In Hebrew and in some English versions, this verse part does not begin with a conjunction. The connection with 7:14c is implied. For example:

They have turned against me. (GW)

In other versions, a contrast is made explicit. For example:

^{14c}They slash themselves for grain and new wine,
^{14d}but turn away from me. (NET)

turn away from Me: There is a textual issue here:

1. The Masoretic Text has “they turn away from me.” For example:

They turn away from Me (NASB) (BSB, NASB, NET, NCV, NIV, NLT, REB)

1. The Syriac and Targum have “they rebel against me.” For example:

They are still rebelling against me (NJB) (ESV, GNT, KJV, NAB, NJB, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The Masoretic Text makes good sense and fits the context. It carries both the ideas of turning away from God and turning against God. An argument in favor of option (2) is that the preposition *bā* “against,” which occurs here, fits better with the verb “rebel” than with “turn.” See Davies (page 191). However, according to Hubbard (page 141), the preposition can indicate separation. Keil (page 110) also prefers the MT. According to him, the verb with this preposition implies “depart and turn against God.” “McComiskey (page 115) agrees that the preposition may add a sense of hostility to the people’s departure from God.”

Hosea 7:15

Section 6:4-7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people’s future repentance (6:1-3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to commit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns (“you”) and sometimes third

person pronouns (“they” or “he”) to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses “they” in 6:5-10, “you” in 6:4 & 11, and “they” or “he” in 7:1-16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use “you” in 6:11 and “they” in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5-10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5-10. In 6:7-10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on “you” in 2:16b-c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment
(NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

7:15a-b

Although I trained and strengthened their arms, they plot evil against Me: In this sentence, the LORD contrasts the good he has done for the people with the evil that the people do against him. The BSB and a number of other versions express this contrast by using a concessive clause in 7:15a. For example:

Though I trained them and gave them strength,
they have made evil plans against me. (NCV)

I...they: The sentence that the BSB translates as shown above is literally “And I, I instructed...but against me, they plot evil.” The Hebrew text emphasizes the contrast between the LORD and the people of Israel. If possible, translate in a way that expresses this strong contrast. For example:

It was I who trained and strengthened their arms,
yet they plot evil against me. (NRSV)

7:15a

Although I trained and strengthened their arms,

- ¶ “It was I who taught them and made them into a strong nation,
- ¶ “Even though I was the one who instructed and strengthened them,

I trained and strengthened their arms: In Hebrew, the word trained can refer to moral instruction, rebuke, or punishment. In 7:12d, the same word referred primarily to punishment. Here, in combination with strengthened, it refers primarily to teaching or training. For example:

I taught them what they know (CEV)

The phrase strengthened their arms is a figure of speech that most often means to encourage someone. It is frequently used in the context of battle. Here it may indicate that God gave the people of Israel encouragement or strength to fight and overcome their enemies. TWOT (#636), Keil (page 110), and McComiskey (page 116). It does not mean that God literally strengthened their arms.

Some versions translate their arms as the object of both verbs. For example:

I trained and strengthened their arms (NRSV)

If a literal translation of these figures of speech is not correctly understood, it is recommended that you use the nonfigurative meaning, as in the NIV or the NCV.

7:15b

they plot evil against Me.

- yet they made evil plans against me.
- they nevertheless plan to do me harm.

they plot evil against Me: This clause means that the people make evil plans that are offensive and disloyal to God. Macintosh (page 284). Some suggest it may refer specifically to the worship of false gods Davies (page 191), Keil (page 110), Wood (page 199), and Stuart (page 124). or to making alliances with other nations instead of relying on God. McComiskey (page 116), and Stuart (page 124). However, the verse itself gives only a general statement. It leaves implicit the details of the people's evil plans.

Here are some other ways to translate this statement:

they have made evil plans against me (NCV)

Hosea 7:16

Section 6:4-7:16: The people persisted in their sins

In this section, the LORD again spoke to the people of Israel and Judah. In contrast to the people's future repentance (6:1-3), he gave examples of their current disloyalty and corruption, including their reliance on other nations instead of him. They continued to com-

mit sins, and they refused to seek him. He announced that he would judge them, and he illustrated his coming judgment in various ways.

In this section, the Hebrew text sometimes uses second person pronouns ("you") and sometimes third person pronouns ("they" or "he") to refer to the people of Israel. The BSB follows the Hebrew pronoun usage. It uses "they" in 6:5-10, "you" in 6:4 & 11, and "they" or "he" in 7:1-16. Throughout these verses the LORD is the speaker, and he either addresses the people directly or speaks about them.

English versions all use "you" in 6:11 and "they" in chapter 7, but they differ in the way they use the pronouns in 6:5-10. You should use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to handle the pronouns in 6:5-10. In 6:7-10, the Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line and give another pronoun choice in the second meaning line. See the note on "you" in 2:16b-c, where the pronoun changes are similar.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Transitory Faithfulness and Imminent Judgment (NET)

Impenitence of Israel and Judah (NRSV)

7:16a

They turn, but not to the Most High;

- They turn to a false god that is not the Most High God.
- They refuse to trust again in God, who is the Most High.

They turn, but not to the Most High: There is a textual issue here:

1. The Masoretic Text is literally "they turn to not height." This clause probably means that the people turn to something that is not the Most High God. It implies that they do not turn to God. For example:

They did not turn to the Most High God. (NCV)
(BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV)

1. Some English versions have "they turn to Baal." The text in option (2) is not supported by the LXX or other early translations. For example:

They turn to Baal (RSV) (NET, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and scholars. The Masoretic Text presents a number of difficulties, including the position of the word *lo* “not” before the word “height” rather than before the verb “turn” and the unusual use of the word “height.” According to Andersen and Freedman (pages 477–478), the Hebrew word *‘al* “height” may be a shortened variant of *‘eli*, *‘elyon* “The Most High God,” which is made negative here. A similar negative name, *lo’el*, which means “a not-god, something that is not a god,” occurs in Deuteronomy 32:21. These factors have led to three main interpretations: (1) They turn to a non-God (or “False Most High”); (2) They do not turn to the Most High; and (3) They turn/return but not upward. These interpretations have been presented as translation options in the Notes, because they all represent slightly different aspects of the same situation. For more information, see TWOT (#1624p), Hubbard (page 142), and Keil (page 110). For more discussion on the use of the Hebrew negative, see Biblical Hebrew Reference Grammar: The Syntax of Word Order §46.1. Verbal Clauses (2). Here are some other ways to translate this option:

They keep on turning away from me to a god that is powerless. (GNT)

They turn to a false god

They don’t return to the Most High (GW)

They return, but not upward (ESV) The translation “Most High” is an explicit reference to God. The translation “upward” is not explicit, but it can also refer to God (Keil, page 110).

In some languages, words such as turn or “return” refer only to physical movement, not to a change of belief.

If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate this clause:

They refuse to worship the Most High God.

They decide to trust a god who does not really exist.

7:16b

they are like a faulty bow.

- They are like a bow with a defect.

- They are unreliable like a crooked/warped bow that cannot be trusted to shoot an arrow straight.

they are like a faulty bow: This clause is a simile. It compares the people of Israel to a bow that is used to shoot arrows at enemy soldiers. The similarity between the people and a bow depends on the meaning of the Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as faulty bow. This phrase is more literally “deceitful/treacherous bow” or “slack bow.” Scholars do not agree on the derivation of this Hebrew word. It may be derived from one root with two meanings (HALOT, #8840) or from two homonyms (TWOT, #2169a). There are two main ways to interpret this phrase:

1. The word faulty comes from a Hebrew word that means “deceitful” or “treacherous.” It refers to a bow that is unreliable, perhaps because it is warped. It cannot be trusted to shoot an arrow accurately and hit the target. Macintosh (pages 285–286), McComiskey (page 116), Wood (page 199). The simile indicates that the people were untrustworthy and deceitful. God could not rely on them to worship him sincerely and do what he wanted. For example:

they are like an unreliable bow (NET)

They are like a defective bow. (GW) (BSB, ESV, GNT, KJV, NAB, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NRSV)

1. The word faulty comes from a Hebrew word that means “slack.” It refers to a bow that has a loose bowstring. It is weak or useless, because the arrows do not reach their target. The simile indicates that the people were weak and helpless as a nation. Stuart (page 124). For example:

They are like a loose bow that can’t shoot. (NCV) (NCV, NJPS, REB)

The Display will follow interpretation (1), but both interpretations are appropriate similes for the people of Israel.

In the BSB, NET, and GW, the way in which the bow is “deceitful” is left implied. Some versions are more specific. For example:

They are as unreliable as a crooked bow. (GNT)

Some versions allow or combine aspects of both interpretations. For example:

They are as useless as a crooked bow. (NLT)

If you can translate in a similar way, it will be very acceptable.

If a term for bow is not known in your language area, you may use a general term. For example:

They are like a broken weapon

7:16c

Their leaders will fall by the sword for the cursing of their tongue;

- Their rulers will die with/by the sword because of their angry, arrogant words.
- Their leaders speak defiantly, so they will be killed.

Their leaders: The word that the BSB translates here as leaders probably refers to government or military rulers or officials. See the notes on 7:3a–b and 7:5a, where the BSB translated the same Hebrew word as “princes.”

will fall by the sword: This phrase means that someone will use a sword to kill their leaders. Stuart (page 125). The leaders will probably be assassinated or else killed in battle. Andersen and Freedman (page 479). Some versions state explicitly that they will die in battle, but the verse itself does not make that explicit. It is better to leave this detail unstated in the translation, as the BSB has done.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

they will die a violent death (GNT)

the cursing of their tongue: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “the indignation of their tongue.” BART interlinear. This phrase refers to the anger expressed by their words. In this context, it is likely that the leaders’ anger was associated with their arrogance. Macintosh (page 286). and was directed against the LORD. McComiskey (pages 116–117) and Keil (page 110). The BSB above is one way to describe this anger.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

their angry talk (REB)

the insolence of their tongues (NAB)

their leaders talk arrogantly (GNT)

7:16d

for this they will be ridiculed in the land of Egypt.

- Because of this, the people of Egypt will mock them.
- When the Egyptians hear about the death of these leaders, they will laugh at the people/Israelites.

for this they will be ridiculed in the land of Egypt:

This clause indicates that people in Egypt will mock or laugh at the misfortune of the Israelites after the leaders of Israel are killed.

for this: The pronoun this refers to the death of the leaders of Israel. In some languages, the pronoun reference may need to be made explicit. For example:

Because of their death, the Egyptians will ridicule them

they will be ridiculed: This is a passive clause. In some languages, it may be preferable to change this into an active clause. For example:

Egyptians will laugh at them. (CEV)

So people will disdain them in the land of Egypt. (NET)

in the land of Egypt: This phrase indicates that the Egyptians are the ones who will ridicule the Israelites. It does not imply that the leaders were killed in Egypt. To make this clear some versions use a phrase such as “The Egyptians” instead of the phrase in the land of Egypt. For example:

The Egyptians will laugh (GNT)

The people in Egypt will ridicule them for this. (GW)

Hosea 8:1

Section 8:1–14: The Israelites will be punished for rejecting the LORD

In this section, the LORD warned the nation of Israel that enemies were ready to attack them, because they had rejected him and broken their agreement to obey his laws (8:1–3). They disobeyed him by choosing their own leaders (8:4a–b) and making idols (8:4c–6). Their alliance with Assyria failed, and they became weak agriculturally and also politically as a nation. Verse 8:10 predicts their future punishment as slaves in Assyria (8:7–10). The LORD did not accept the sacrifices they offered to him, because they continued to

sin, so their cities faced total destruction (11–14). The TN analysis of this section follows the paragraph divisions used in a majority of English versions. The summary combines ideas from McComiskey (page 118), Davies (page 193), and Stuart (pages 126–127).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Will Punish Israel for Its Rebellion (GW)

The LORD warned Israel that enemies would attack them

Warning that Israel will be Punished

Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. He referred to himself using first person pronouns (“I/me/my”) except for verse 13b–d, which has “he.” In this section, the Hebrew text almost always uses “they” or “he/it” to refer to the people or nation of Israel. The only exceptions are 8:1 and 8:5, which use the pronoun “your.” The CEV uses “you/your” consistently to refer to Israel. Most other versions use third person pronouns. The Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line. It will often use “you/your” in the second meaning line.

Paragraph 8:1–3 and 8:4–6

TN will divide these verses into 8:1–3 and 8:4–6 along with many English versions. In the first paragraph, the LORD warns Israel that they will be punished, because they had rejected his covenant. In the second paragraph, he specifies two ways that Israel had rejected him. In other versions the first paragraph in this chapter is 8:1–6. You should follow a paragraph structure that is natural in your language.

8:1a

Put the ram’s horn to your lips!

- ¶ “Blow^(sing) a warning on a ram’s horn!
- ¶ Yahweh says, “Warn the people that their enemies are coming.

Put the ram’s horn to your lips!: The LORD is the implied speaker of these words. In some languages, it will be helpful to make this explicit. For example:

The Lord says, “.... (GNT)

The clause that the BSB translates as Put the ram’s horn to your lips! is literally “to your mouth a horn.” This clause implies that the person should blow the horn. This clause is similar to the cultural gesture “Blow the ram’s horn” in 5:8. In both contexts, the

purpose of blowing the horn is to warn the people of danger. Here the danger is specified as an approaching enemy (8:1b).

Here are some ways to translate this cultural gesture:

- Keep the gesture. This option is appropriate if the gesture has the same meaning in your culture. For example:

Put a ram’s horn to your mouth (NJPS)

- Keep the gesture and add the purpose of the gesture. For example:

“Sound the alarm on the ram’s horn (GW)

Blow the ram’s horn to sound the alarm! (Voice)

- Translate the purpose or meaning of the gesture. For example:

“Sound the alarm! (NLT)

“Warn the people that their enemies are coming.

ram’s horn: If people in your culture do not blow instruments made from an animal’s horn, The Hebrew word used here is šōpar. A different Hebrew word, ḥāṣōṣrah, is used to refer to a metal trumpet. you may use a word like “trumpet” that has a similar function, as many English versions have done.

8:1b

An eagle looms over the house of the LORD,

- The enemy is about to attack Israel like an eagle that attacks its prey,
- They are swooping down on my land like eagles! (adapted from GNT)

An eagle looms over the house of the LORD: In the BSB, this clause is a metaphor. In Hebrew, it is a simile: “like the eagle over the house of the LORD.” Both figures of speech compare the implied topic (an enemy) to an eagle that flies or circles over the house of the LORD. An enemy army and an eagle are similar, because both are large, strong, and swift. An army and an eagle also attack their opponents or prey.

Here are some ways to translate these figures of speech:

- Use a metaphor. Make the similarity explicit if it will be helpful. For example:

Now an eagle is swooping down to attack my land.
(CEV)

- Use a simile. Make the topic or the similarity explicit if it will be helpful. For example:

The enemy descends like an eagle on the people of the Lord (NLT)

A powerful army will soon attack my people like an eagle.

eagle: In Hebrew, this word can refer to an eagle, a vulture, or a similar kind of large bird that eats other birds or small animals. English versions interpret this word in two ways:

1. The word refers here to an eagle. For example:

Like an eagle (NASB) (BSB, CEV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB)

1. The word refers here to a vulture. For example:

One like a vulture (ESV) (ESV, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries. Eagles attack and eat live animals. Most vultures eat only dead animals.

If eagles are not known in your area, here are two ways to translate the word:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

a large fierce bird

- Substitute another large bird that attacks and eats smaller birds or animals.

over the house of the LORD: This phrase indicates that the eagle is ready to attack or has already started to attack the house of the LORD. There are two main ways to interpret the meaning of the phrase the house of the LORD in this context:

1. It refers to the nation of Israel. For example:

Enemies are swooping down on my land like eagles! (GNT) (CEV, GNT, NCV, NLT) Versions like the NJB (“disaster is swooping on Yahweh’s home”) or the BSB (“the house of the LORD”) have not been

listed, because they could be interpreted either way.

1. It refers to the temple. For example:

The enemy swoops down on the Lord’s temple like an eagle. (GW) (GW, NET, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In this context, it is the northern kingdom of Israel that is threatened by Assyria. The identity of the enemy is not stated. However, according to Jewish tradition the eagle refers to the Assyrian army that was about to attack the northern kingdom of Israel. Hubbard (page 145) and Dearman (pages 216–217). The temple of the LORD was in Jerusalem, in the southern kingdom of Judah.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

An eagle flies/circles over Israel, ready to attack

The enemy swoops down on the Lord’s people like an eagle. (NCV)

8:1c

because the people have transgressed My covenant

- because the people of Israel have violated my agreement with them,
- The reason is that you^(plur) have broken/disobeyed my covenant

8:1d

and rebelled against My law.

- and they have turned away from the law/commands that I gave to them.
- and you^(plur) have refused to obey my instructions/teaching.

8:1c–d

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{1c}because the people have transgressed My covenant

^{1d}and rebelled against My law.

In these lines, the LORD gives the reason why an enemy will soon attack Israel.

because: The Hebrew text and many versions introduce this reason with a conjunction. For example:

for they have broken their covenant with me, and have rebelled against my law. (NET)

In some languages, it may be more natural to introduce the reason without a conjunction. For example:

they have violated my covenant (REB)

Use a natural way in your language to introduce the reason.

the people have transgressed My covenant: In this clause, the words the people refer to the people of Israel. In some languages, it may be helpful to make this explicit. For example:

The Israelites have broken my agreement (NCV)

Israel, you broke our agreement (CEV)

My covenant...My law: In this context, the phrase My covenant probably refers to the covenant that the LORD made with Moses on Mount Sinai. McComiskey (page 119). That covenant included the people's promise that they would obey his laws. See Exodus 19:5-8. In Hebrew, the word law also means "instruction" or "teaching." Macintosh (page 293), Davies (page 197), and TWOT (#910d).

Here are some other ways to translate these clauses:

they have violated my covenant and rebelled against my instruction (REB)

The Israelites have broken my agreement and have turned against my teachings. (NCV)

Hosea 8:2

Section 8:1-14: The Israelites will be punished for rejecting the LORD

In this section, the LORD warned the nation of Israel that enemies were ready to attack them, because they had rejected him and broken their agreement to obey his laws (8:1-3). They disobeyed him by choosing their own leaders (8:4a-b) and making idols (8:4c-6). Their alliance with Assyria failed, and they became weak agriculturally and also politically as a nation. Verse 8:10 predicts their future punishment as slaves in Assyria (8:7-10). The LORD did not accept the sacrifices they offered to him, because they continued to sin, so their cities faced total destruction (11-14). The TN analysis of this section follows the paragraph

divisions used in a majority of English versions. The summary combines ideas from McComiskey (page 118), Davies (page 193), and Stuart (pages 126-127).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Will Punish Israel for Its Rebellion (GW)

The LORD warned Israel that enemies would attack them

Warning that Israel will be Punished

Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. He referred to himself using first person pronouns ("I/me/my") except for verse 13b-d, which has "he." In this section, the Hebrew text almost always uses "they" or "he/it" to refer to the people or nation of Israel. The only exceptions are 8:1 and 8:5, which use the pronoun "your." The CEV uses "you/your" consistently to refer to Israel. Most other versions use third person pronouns. The Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line. It will often use "you/your" in the second meaning line.

Paragraph 8:1-3 and 8:4-6

TN will divide these verses into 8:1-3 and 8:4-6 along with many English versions. In the first paragraph, the LORD warns Israel that they will be punished, because they had rejected his covenant. In the second paragraph, he specifies two ways that Israel had rejected him. In other versions the first paragraph in this chapter is 8:1-6. You should follow a paragraph structure that is natural in your language.

8:2

Israel cries out to Me, "O our God, we know You!"

- They call to me, saying, 'O our^(excl) God, we know you^(sing) and follow you.'
- You^(plur) plead with me to help you. You say, 'You are our God. We^(excl) personally know you and obey you.'

Israel cries out to Me, "O our God, we know You!":

This clause indicates that the people of Israel continued to call out to God. They continued to claim that they had a close relationship with him. However, this claim was not consistent with their rejection of God that is described in the verses before and after this one.

Some versions make explicit the contrast between what the people said and what they did. For example:

²Even though they call me their God and claim that they are my people and that they know me,
³they have rejected what is good. (GNT)

²They cry out to me, ‘Our God, we in Israel know you!’ ³But Israel has rejected what is good (NCV)

²Predictably, Israel cries out, ‘My God! We know you!’ But they don’t act like it. ³Israel will have nothing to do with what’s good (MSG)

If the contrast is not clear in your language, you may want to make it explicit as in one of the above versions. Be sure to consider the connection with 8:3, which also contrasts with 8:2.

Israel cries out to Me: In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally “They cry out to Me” (NASB). The Hebrew sentence is literally “to me they cry out my God we know you Israel.” In the view of some Hebrew scholars the word “Israel” is the subject of the verb “cry out” even though the verb and the subject are at opposite ends of the sentence. This yields: “Israel cries out, ‘My God, we know you,’” (Macintosh, page 294). This is an instance of a split subject (Van der Merwe. Biblical Hebrew Reference Grammar, GLOSSARY, SPLIT PHRASE). It is clear from the preceding and following verses that the words “they” and Israel both refer to the people of Israel.

The verb cries out means “cry out or call for help in time of distress.” TWOT (#570a) points out that the verb form used here almost always refers to a call for help. Some versions make explicit that the people are asking for help. For example:

Now Israel pleads with me, ‘Help us...

O our God: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “My God.” Some scholars emend this word to make it “God of” and link it to the word “Israel” at the end of the sentence. This yields: “God of Israel.” Stuart (page 131), McComiskey (pages 120–121), and Andersen and Freedman (page 490). This is one way to resolve the apparent conflict in the Hebrew grammar between the plural “they” in “they cry out” followed by the singular “my” in “my God.” (We would expect their cry to be, “our God”). However, there are alternative ways to explain the discrepancy that do not require emending the text (see note). The BSB adds the vocative O to introduce this phrase.

The singular “my” in Hebrew may indicate that each person says these words. Keil (page 112), and Macin-

tosh (page 294). Versions such as the BSB above may have used our because it sounds more natural in English to say our God when a group of people cries out.

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

My God (NRSV)

Our God (NCV)

You^(sing) who are our^(excl) God

Use a phrase that is natural in your language when a group of people calls out to God.

God: In Hebrew, this word is ʾelohim, not Yahweh. Versions indicate this by translating the word as God rather than “LORD.”

we know You!: In this context, this probably means that the people claimed to know God in a personal way. They were his people. Davies (page 198) and McComiskey (page 121). It implies that they knew how he wanted them to live and that they obeyed him. It does not imply that they only recognized him or understood who he was. See the note on “you will know the LORD” in 2:20b, where it probably has the same meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

we—Israel—know you. In the view of some Hebrew scholars, the word “Israel” at the end of the sentence is in apposition to the subject (“we”) of the previous verb, “we know you.” This yields, “we, Israel, know you.” See Macintosh (page 294) and Keil (page 112). (NRSV)

you are our God! (NLT)

we^(excl) consider you to be our God whom we know and obey

General Comment on 8:2

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this verse using indirect speech. For example:

...they call me their God and claim that they are my people and that they know me (GNT)

Hosea 8:3

Section 8:1–14: The Israelites will be punished for rejecting the LORD

In this section, the LORD warned the nation of Israel that enemies were ready to attack them, because they had rejected him and broken their agreement to obey his laws (8:1–3). They disobeyed him by choosing their own leaders (8:4a–b) and making idols (8:4c–6). Their alliance with Assyria failed, and they became weak agriculturally and also politically as a nation. Verse 8:10 predicts their future punishment as slaves in Assyria (8:7–10). The LORD did not accept the sacrifices they offered to him, because they continued to sin, so their cities faced total destruction (11–14). The TN analysis of this section follows the paragraph divisions used in a majority of English versions. The summary combines ideas from McComiskey (page 118), Davies (page 193), and Stuart (pages 126–127).

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Paragraph 8:1–3 and 8:4–6

TN will divide these verses into 8:1–3 and 8:4–6 along with many English versions. In the first paragraph, the LORD warns Israel that they will be punished, because they had rejected his covenant. In the second paragraph, he specifies two ways that Israel had rejected him. In other versions the first paragraph in this chapter is 8:1–6. You should follow a paragraph structure that is natural in your language.

8:3a

But Israel has rejected good;

- But it is not true! The people of Israel have rejected what is good,
- Yet you^(plur) have turned away from my good teachings and the good agreement/covenant that I made with you.

This verse repeats part of the warning given in Deut. 28:15–68. If the people disobey the LORD, he will cause them to be defeated by their enemies. McComiskey (page 121).

But: This word is not in the Hebrew text. The BSB and some other versions add it to make explicit the contrast between what the people said (8:2) and what the people did (8:3a).

Israel has rejected good: This clause probably refers back to 8:1. That verse says that the people had broken the covenant of the LORD and rebelled against his law. So here the word good probably refers specifically to his covenant and his law. McComiskey (page 121) says that the “good” includes fertile fields and national security and prosperity. Macintosh (page 295) agrees that such blessings are “attendant” on keeping the covenant. Most other commentaries define rejection of what is good as rejection of God’s covenant with his people. In other words, they have turned their backs on “knowing and serving God” (Wood, page 201) and their “basic relationship with God” (Kidner, page 76). See also Anderson and Freedman, Hubbard, and Carson. HALOT (electronic ed., page 371) defines “good” more broadly as “moral good.” The CEV makes this meaning explicit:

But your enemies will chase you for rejecting our good agreement. (CEV)

It also refers to the blessings that the LORD gave to people who kept them. Macintosh (page 296), Hubbard (page 145). Those blessings included fertile fields and a secure and prosperous nation. McComiskey (page 121). When the people rejected the covenant, they also caused those good blessings to be taken away.

8:3b

an enemy will pursue him.

- so an enemy is coming to pursue them.
- Because of this an enemy will chase you^(plur).

an enemy will pursue him: This clause gives the result of Israel rejecting what is good. Israel’s enemy will pursue them. Some versions make explicit that this is a result. For example:

They have rejected what is good. Because of this their enemies will pursue them. (GNT)

The word pursue implies here that Israel's enemies will defeat them in battle. They will chase the survivors to capture or kill them or plunder their possessions. Stuart (page 131) comments that the enemy's pursuit of Israel indicates that Israel is on the losing side. Macintosh (page 297) says that "pursue" indicates that Israel is a defeated foe that is "put to flight."

Some versions, such as the GNT quoted above, use the pronoun "them" instead of him to refer to Israel. Use whatever is natural in your language to refer to a nation or the people of a nation.

Hosea 8:4

Section 8:1-14: The Israelites will be punished for rejecting the LORD

In this section, the LORD warned the nation of Israel that enemies were ready to attack them, because they had rejected him and broken their agreement to obey his laws (8:1-3). They disobeyed him by choosing their own leaders (8:4a-b) and making idols (8:4c-6). Their alliance with Assyria failed, and they became weak agriculturally and also politically as a nation. Verse 8:10 predicts their future punishment as slaves in Assyria (8:7-10). The LORD did not accept the sacrifices they offered to him, because they continued to sin, so their cities faced total destruction (11-14). The TN analysis of this section follows the paragraph divisions used in a majority of English versions. The summary combines ideas from McComiskey (page 118), Davies (page 193), and Stuart (pages 126-127).

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The LORD warned Israel that enemies would attack them

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Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. He referred to himself using first person pronouns ("I/me/my") except for verse 13b-d, which has "he." In this section, the Hebrew text almost always uses "they" or "he/it" to refer to the people or nation of Israel. The only exceptions are 8:1 and 8:5, which use the pronoun "your." The CEV uses "you/your" consistently to refer to Israel. Most other versions use third person

pronouns. The Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line. It will often use "you/your" in the second meaning line.

Paragraph 8:4-6

This paragraph gives two specific examples of ways that Israel disobeyed the covenant and rejected what is good.

8:4a-b (combined/reordered)

- When they/you^(plur) chose their/your kings and other officials/leaders, they/you did not inform me or ask my permission.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{4a} They set up kings, **but not by Me.**

^{4b} They make princes, **but without My approval.**

These parallel lines give the first example of Israel's disobedience. They chose their own kings and other government leaders without consulting the LORD. According to Davies (page 199), Hosea presupposes that kings should have a divine appointment. The way the LORD appointed them was through the mediation of a prophet. See 1 Sam. 10:1-2; 16:12-13.

8:4a

They set up kings, but not by Me.

- ¶ "They chose their own kings without my authority/advice.
- ¶ "It was you^(plur) who caused your own kings to rule, not I.

They set up kings: This phrase means "they chose kings" or "they caused kings to rule." BART interlinear "they have made kings," TWOT (#1199) "become king or queen."

They: The pronoun They refers to the people of Israel as a group. In Hebrew, there are two pronouns here. These two pronouns emphasize that it was They who chose their leaders and not the LORD who chose them. Andersen and Freedman (page 491), Macintosh (page 297), and Kidner (page 77). If possible, try to express this emphasis in your translation. For example:

They chose their own kings (NCV)

It was they themselves who decided what person would rule as king.

but not by Me: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “and not from me.” This indicates that the LORD had nothing to do with the process of choosing these kings.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

not by my authority (NAB)

they did it on their own (GNT)

without asking my permission (NCV)

8:4b

They make princes, but without My approval.

- They also decided/established the other leaders of the government, but they never informed/consulted me.
- You^(plur) also chose other rulers/officials to serve the king, but you did not ask me to approve the leaders that you chose.

They make princes: This phrase means “they chose/appointed officials/leaders” or “they have caused officials/leaders to rule.” NIDOTTE (#8906) “cause to rule,” NIDOTTE (#5385) “official, chieftain, leader, prince.”

princes: In Hebrew, this word refers to government officials or leaders other than kings. It does not refer here to the sons of kings.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they set up rulers (REB)

they appointed other leaders in the government

but without My approval: In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally “but I did not know.” In this context, the phrase implies that the people chose their leaders without informing the LORD or asking him for his approval. Keil (page 112) and Hubbard (page 146).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

without my knowledge (NRSV)

but they did not consult me

General Comment on 8:4a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the parallel parts. For example:

You chose kings and leaders without consulting me (CEV)

The people have appointed kings and princes, but not with my consent. (NLT96)

8:4c

With their silver and gold they make themselves idols, to their own destruction.

- They used their silver and gold to make idols. Because of this evil that they did, they will be destroyed.
- You^(plur) made silver and gold idols, so someone will destroy you.

With their silver and gold they make themselves idols: This verse part gives another example of Israel’s disobedience. They used their own silver and gold materials to make themselves idols to worship.

to their own destruction: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew word that the BSB translates here as to:

1. It indicates that the result of making idols was destruction. For example:

Because of this, they will be destroyed. (GW)

You made silver and gold idols that led to your downfall (CEV) (BSB, CEV, GW, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT)

1. It indicates that the purpose of making idols was destruction. For example:

they made idols for their own destruction (NRSV)

that they may be cut off (KJV) (ESV, GNT, KJV, NASB, NJB, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The LXX supports this interpretation. This interpretation is more logical, because destruction was the normal result of idol worship. Commentaries that prefer interpretation (2) agree that the purpose of destruction was not what the people themselves intended. According to McComiskey (page 123), this purpose was probably not what the people intended, but it may have been the way that Hosea perceived it. Macintosh (page 298) says that it indicates purpose, but admits that sometimes an undesigned course of action is portrayed “ironically as if it were designed.”

Andersen and Freedman (page 492) also say that it may indicate irony.

their own destruction: There are two ways to interpret this phrase: In the Masoretic Text, the phrase is literally “it will be cut off.” The Septuagint and Syriac translate the singular pronoun “it” as plural “they/their.” All modern versions also translate it as a plural.

1. The phrase refers to someone destroying the people of Israel. For example:

you made silver and gold idols that led to your downfall. (CEV) (BSB, CEV, GNT, GW, NCV, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB) The BSB, ESV, GNT, NIV, NLT, and NRSV all have the phrase “their own destruction.” Since the people are clearly the subject of the sentence (they are ones the one who make the idols), the word “own” has to refer back to the people themselves.

1. The phrase refers to someone destroying the idols. For example:

With their silver and gold, they have made themselves idols, but only to be destroyed. (NJB) (NET, NJB) The NET translation “they will be destroyed” can refer to either people or idols, but it has a footnote that supports the interpretation of idols. The KJV and NASB have not been listed under either interpretation. They have: “that they may/might be cut off,” which could refer to either interpretation.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with the Septuagint and most versions. Commentaries that support this interpretation include Hubbard, Andersen and Freedman, McComiskey, and Keil. It best fits the overall theme of the chapter (a warning that the LORD will punish Israel). It also fits the following context of 8:5 (the LORD’s anger against Israel), and the various punishments that are specified in 8:7–14).

Here are some other ways to translate 8:4c:

By making idols for themselves from their silver and gold, they have brought about their own destruction. (NLT)

Of their silver and gold they have made themselves images, to their own undoing. (NJPS)

Hosea 8:5

Section 8:1–14: The Israelites will be punished for rejecting the LORD

In this section, the LORD warned the nation of Israel that enemies were ready to attack them, because they had rejected him and broken their agreement to obey his laws (8:1–3). They disobeyed him by choosing their own leaders (8:4a–b) and making idols (8:4c–6). Their alliance with Assyria failed, and they became weak agriculturally and also politically as a nation. Verse 8:10 predicts their future punishment as slaves in Assyria (8:7–10). The LORD did not accept the sacrifices they offered to him, because they continued to sin, so their cities faced total destruction (11–14). The TN analysis of this section follows the paragraph divisions used in a majority of English versions. The summary combines ideas from McComiskey (page 118), Davies (page 193), and Stuart (pages 126–127).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Will Punish Israel for Its Rebellion (GW)

The LORD warned Israel that enemies would attack them

Warning that Israel will be Punished

Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. He referred to himself using first person pronouns (“I/me/my”) except for verse 13b–d, which has “he.” In this section, the Hebrew text almost always uses “they” or “he/it” to refer to the people or nation of Israel. The only exceptions are 8:1 and 8:5, which use the pronoun “your.” The CEV uses “you/your” consistently to refer to Israel. Most other versions use third person pronouns. The Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line. It will often use “you/your” in the second meaning line.

Paragraph 8:4–6

This paragraph gives two specific examples of ways that Israel disobeyed the covenant and rejected what is good.

8:5a–b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{5a} He has rejected **your calf, O Samaria.**

^{5b} My anger burns **against them.**

8:5a**He has rejected your calf, O Samaria.**

- O people of Samaria, I reject/hate your^(plur) calf idol!
- You who reside in the land/country of Israel, your false god that resembles a bull calf is hateful/disgusting to me.

He has rejected your calf, O Samaria: There is a textual issue here:

1. The Masoretic Text has “he has rejected your calf Samaria.” This is a statement that the LORD has rejected the calf idol that the people of Samaria worshiped. For example:

“O Samaria, he has rejected your calf idol. (NET) (BSB, ESV, GNT, NASB, NCV, NET, NJB, NLT, REB, RSV)

1. The LXX has “Reject your calf Samaria.” This is a command that the people of Samaria should reject their calf idol. For example:

Throw out your calf-idol, O Samaria! (NIV) (GW, NAB, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow textual option (1) along with most English versions and commentaries.

He: Many English versions use the pronoun “I” here, because it is not natural in English for someone to refer to himself using “he.” McComiskey (page 124) comments: “The change from third person to first person in the clausal structure is stylistic. Hosea does this frequently....” Translate this pronoun in a natural way in your language.

has rejected: This verb indicates strong dislike or disapproval. TWOT (#564) “reject, spurn, cast off.”

Here are some ways to translate the phrase “he has rejected”:

he has rejected (NASB)

I have spurned (ESV)

In some languages, it may be more natural to leave the pronoun implied. For example:

your calf-god is loathsome (REB)

Your calf is rejected (NRSV)

your calf: This phrase refers to an idol in the shape of a bull calf. It may have been made of wood and covered with a thin layer of gold. Stuart (page 133). It probably refers specifically to the gold calf idol that was at Bethel. King Jeroboam I set up this idol for the people of the northern kingdom of Israel to worship. Jeroboam also set up a second calf idol at Dan, but according to Macintosh (page 303) and Keil (page 114), that idol had already been destroyed. That explains the reason for the singular “calf.” (see 1 Kings 12:25–33).

O Samaria: Here the LORD, speaking through Hosea, addressed the people of Samaria directly. Some versions have added the word O to make it clear that O Samaria is a term of address (vocative). Use a vocative that is natural in your language when a person speaks to a group of people.

Samaria was the capital city of the northern kingdom of Israel. In this context, the name Samaria is a figure of speech that represents the nation or people of Israel. McComiskey (page 124) and Davies (page 201).

Here are some other ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the name Samaria and add the meaning. For example:

O people of Samaria, I have rejected your idol that is like a bull calf.

- Translate the meaning of Samaria. For example:

You Israelites, I hate your gold calf.

8:5b**My anger burns against them.**

- My anger burns like a hot fire against these people!
- I am furious with you^(plur).

My anger burns against them: In Hebrew, this line emphasizes that the LORD became very angry with TWOT (#736) “burn, be kindled (of anger).” the people of Israel because of their idolatry.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

I am very angry with the people. (NCV)

I am furious with them. (GNT)

them: This pronoun refers to the people of Israel. Macintosh (page 302). Since in 8:5a the LORD spoke directly to the people, it may be more natural

in some languages to use a “you” pronoun here. For example:

My fury burns against you. (NLT)

8:5c

How long will they be incapable of innocence?

- How long will it be before they are free from sin/guilt?
- I am sad/frustrated that you^(plur) insist on worshiping idols and refuse to do what is right!

How long will they be incapable of innocence?: This is a rhetorical question. Its function is to express the LORD’s sorrow and frustration that the people of Israel will never be free from sin. McComiskey (page 125), Hubbard (page 147), Macintosh (page 303), and Stuart (page 132).

Here are some other ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a rhetorical question. Here are some other rhetorical questions with a similar meaning:

When will you ever be innocent again? (CEV)

How long must they remain guilty? (REB)

- As a statement. For example:

I grieve that they cannot stop sinning!

innocence: This word refers to a person who does no wrong. That person is honest and free from guilt. TWOT (#1412c) “innocency.” In this context, the word may refer particularly to being innocent of idolatry. The GNT makes that idea explicit:

How long will it be before they give up their idolatry? (GNT)

Hosea 8:6

Section 8:1–14: The Israelites will be punished for rejecting the LORD

In this section, the LORD warned the nation of Israel that enemies were ready to attack them, because they had rejected him and broken their agreement to obey his laws (8:1–3). They disobeyed him by choosing their own leaders (8:4a–b) and making idols (8:4c–6). Their alliance with Assyria failed, and they became weak agriculturally and also politically as a nation.

Verse 8:10 predicts their future punishment as slaves in Assyria (8:7–10). The LORD did not accept the sacrifices they offered to him, because they continued to sin, so their cities faced total destruction (11–14). The TN analysis of this section follows the paragraph divisions used in a majority of English versions. The summary combines ideas from McComiskey (page 118), Davies (page 193), and Stuart (pages 126–127).

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The LORD warned Israel that enemies would attack them

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Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. He referred to himself using first person pronouns (“I/me/my”) except for verse 13b–d, which has “he.” In this section, the Hebrew text almost always uses “they” or “he/it” to refer to the people or nation of Israel. The only exceptions are 8:1 and 8:5, which use the pronoun “your.” The CEV uses “you/your” consistently to refer to Israel. Most other versions use third person pronouns. The Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line. It will often use “you/your” in the second meaning line.

Paragraph 8:4–6

This paragraph gives two specific examples of ways that Israel disobeyed the covenant and rejected what is good.

8:6a

For this thing is from Israel—a craftsman made it, and it is not God.

- I am angry because that calf idol was made here in Israel. It was made by a human craftsman. It certainly is not God!
- The reason for my anger is that a skilled workman made that calf of yours^(plur) right here in Israel. How foolish you are to think that it is God!

For this thing is from Israel—a craftsman made it, and it is not God: This verse part probably gives the reason why the LORD was angry with the people of Israel. He was angry because they worshiped a calf idol that a person from Israel had made. McComiskey (page 125) and Keil (page 114).

For this thing is from Israel: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “For from Israel.” There are two main interpretations of this phrase:

1. This phrase refers to the calf idol that was made in Israel. For example:

The calf was made in Israel (REB) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NASB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. This phrase refers to the people of Israel. For example:

They are from Israel! (NIV) (NET, NIV, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most English versions. McComiskey (page 125) states that the calf is the theme of the entire section (verses 5–6) and is in all likelihood the theme of the clause in 6a as well. He lists several grammatical features that support this interpretation.

Here is another way to translate this verse part:

For it is the product of Israel (NJB)

For: In Hebrew, this phrase begins with a conjunction that the BSB and many other versions translate as For. It probably introduces the reason for the LORD's anger. Macintosh (page 307) suggests that it has an emphatic meaning such as "indeed," but the NIV is only version that may possibly convey this particular emphasis. Some versions do not have an explicit word to introduce the reason. Instead, they leave it implied. Versions with no explicit conjunction do not necessarily introduce the reason for the LORD's anger. The reader has to determine the implied relationship from the context. Use a natural way in your language to introduce this reason.

a craftsman made it, and it is not God: In Hebrew, these words emphasize that the idol was made by a person. Therefore, it cannot be God. Try to give the same emphasis in your translation. For example:

This thing—it was made by a human workman!
How can it be God?

The idol is something a craftsman made; it is not God. (NCV)

8:6b

It will be broken to pieces, that calf of Samaria.

- That calf that the people of Samaria worship will be smashed/broken to pieces!
- Your calf will be utterly destroyed!

It will be broken to pieces, that calf of Samaria:

This clause means that the calf idol will be completely destroyed. In Hebrew, this clause begins with a conjunction. There are three main ways to interpret the function of this conjunction:

1. It introduces what will happen to the calf idol. The idol will be completely destroyed. The relationship between this clause and the preceding verse part is left implied. For example:

The calf of Samaria shall be broken to pieces. (ESV) (BSB, ESV, GNT, GW, NET, NIV, NJB, NRSV, REB)

1. It indicates result. The people worship a manmade idol that is not God. As a result, it will be destroyed. For example:

Therefore, it must be smashed to bits. (NLT) (CEV, NLT)

1. It indicates certainty. The people worship a manmade idol that is not God. It is certain that it will be destroyed. For example:

Surely the calf of Samaria will be broken to pieces. (NASB) (NASB, NCV, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

broken to pieces: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as broken to pieces occurs only once in the OT.

Another way to translate it is to use a more general phrase. For example:

completely destroyed

A few versions suggest an alternate meaning in a footnote. The NAB has "Destined for the flames." It is the only version used in TN that has this meaning in the translation itself. For example:

smashed to pieces: Or "destroyed by fire." (CEV footnote)

Consider whether a similar footnote will be useful for your readers.

Hosea 8:7

Section 8:1–14: The Israelites will be punished for rejecting the LORD

In this section, the LORD warned the nation of Israel that enemies were ready to attack them, because they had rejected him and broken their agreement to obey his laws (8:1–3). They disobeyed him by choosing their own leaders (8:4a–b) and making idols (8:4c–6). Their alliance with Assyria failed, and they became weak agriculturally and also politically as a nation. Verse 8:10 predicts their future punishment as slaves in Assyria (8:7–10). The LORD did not accept the sacrifices they offered to him, because they continued to sin, so their cities faced total destruction (11–14). The TN analysis of this section follows the paragraph divisions used in a majority of English versions. The summary combines ideas from McComiskey (page 118), Davies (page 193), and Stuart (pages 126–127).

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Paragraph 8:7–10

This paragraph describes the agricultural and political weakness that resulted from Israel’s unsuccessful alliance with Assyria. It also predicts Israel’s future punishment as exiles in Assyria.

8:7

This verse uses terms from farming to describe the current agricultural weakness of Israel and its partial conquest by foreign troops.

8:7a–b

For they sow the wind, and they shall reap the whirlwind.

- ¶ The people of Israel have planted the wind. They will harvest a typhoon/tornado.
- ¶ “It is as if they have planted the wind. Soon it will be as if they harvest a hurricane/cyclone.
- ¶ “Indeed, you^(plur) are like foolish farmers who plant a crop of wind. The only thing it will produce is a terrible/destructive wind storm!

Notice the parallel parts that form a saying:

^{7a}For they sow **the wind**,

^{7b}and they shall reap **the whirlwind**.

The Bible has various sayings about sowing and reaping. This saying is a complex metaphor about the undesirable consequences of the people’s actions. This metaphor compares the people to farmers who habitually plant a small crop (“the wind”) and harvest a much larger and undesirable crop (“the whirlwind”).

they sow the wind, and they shall reap the whirlwind: In this metaphor, the wind represents the people’s foolish, worthless behavior. the whirlwind represents the severe punishment that they will receive as a result. Stuart (page 134).

Here are some other ways to translate this complex metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

“The people of Israel plant the wind, but they harvest a storm. (GW)

- Change the metaphor of sowing and reaping to a simile. For example:

“What they habitually plant is like a wind, and what they will harvest is like a whirlwind.

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make the meaning of the wind and/or the whirlwind explicit. For example:

“Israel’s foolish actions are like planting the wind, but their punishment will be like harvesting a terrible storm.

In Hebrew, this saying begins with a conjunction that can be understood in at least two different ways in this context. Any of the following options is acceptable:

- It introduces a statement that refers back to the people's idol worship. For example:

For they sow the wind, and they shall reap the whirlwind. (BSB, RSV)

Indeed, they have planted wind and will harvest a storm!

- It introduces the reason they will reap a whirlwind. The reason is because they have sown the wind. For example:

Since they sow the wind, they will reap the whirlwind (NJB)

In some languages, it may be more natural to leave the connection with the preceding verse(s) implied. Many versions, including the GW (quoted above) do this. Use a natural way in your language to indicate the relationship of 8:7a–b to the surrounding context.

whirlwind: In Hebrew, the word whirlwind in the metaphor refers to a wind storm that causes severe destruction.

If whirlwinds are not known in your language area, here are some ways to translate the word:

- Use a descriptive term. For example:

violent wind storm

- Use a word in your language for a similar storm that occurs in your area. For example:

typhoon

hurricane

sandstorm

cyclone

8:7c–d

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning: Andersen and Freedman (page 499) consider these two lines to be parts of a conditional (“if”) statement: “If standing grain has no growth, it will produce no flour.” See also Stuart (page 134). The CEV, GNT, and GW combine these lines with the first part of the verse in different ways that suggest a similar

condition. However, most scholars and versions treat these lines as parallel statements with the first line expressing an existing fact rather than a hypothetical condition.

^{7c} **There is no** standing grain;

^{7d} what sprouts **fails to yield flour**.

These lines continue to use farming terms, as in 8:7a–b. They describe a particular crop that does not produce grain.

8:7c

There is no standing grain;

- The plants/stalks have no heads of grain/wheat.
- No grain/wheat has grown on the tall plants/stalks.

There is no standing grain: This clause refers to a wheat or barley plant. According to HALOT (electronic edition, p. 1108), the plant described here is probably wheat, but may also be barley. This kind of plant has a head at the top of the stalk that produces kernels of grain. The grain plant that is described here has grown tall in a field. But it has no grain on it, so there is nothing to harvest.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

There are no heads on the standing grain (REB)

A field of grain that does not ripen (GW)

No grain/wheat has grown on the tall plants

8:7d

what sprouts fails to yield flour.

- There is nothing to grind to make flour.
- Your^(plur) crop is like a wheat plant with no head/grain. It produces nothing to eat.

what sprouts fails to yield flour: This clause means that what sprouts will not produce any grain. As a result, there will be nothing to grind into flour.

flour: In Hebrew, this word can refer to either flour or grain/wheat that is ready to be ground into flour. HALOT (electronic edition, p. 1108), Keil (page 114), Macintosh (page 312), and McComiskey (page 128) understand the meaning to be grain ready to be ground into flour. TWOT (#2033a) and Andersen and Freedman (page 499) understand the meaning to be flour. You may translate it either way. If you translate it as flour (as in the BSB), make sure that the connec-

tion between the plant and flour is clearly understood. In some cases, it may be clear from your translation of 8:7c.

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

The result is that there is no flour.

so there is nothing to use for making flour

there is no wheat to grind into flour

You may also translate in a more general way. For example:

it produces nothing (NCV)

8:7e

Even if it should produce, the foreigners would swallow it up.

- Even if it could/did produce grain/something, foreigners would eat it.
- But/And if there is something to harvest, people from other countries will eat/take all of it.

Even if it should produce, the foreigners would swallow it up: In Hebrew, the first clause functions like a conditional (if) statement. It describes a hypothetical situation. Even if the plants did produce some grain, foreigners would eat it.

Here are some other ways to translate both clauses:

Even if it did produce grain, foreigners would eat it all. (GW)

And even if there is any grain, foreigners will eat it. (NLT)

Even if it should produce: In Hebrew, the object of produce is only implied. Some versions translate this clause in a general way. For example:

But even if it did (GNT)

Even if it produced something (NCV)

Other versions make what it produces explicit. For example:

it will produce no flour (NIV)

Even if you harvest grain (CEV)

the foreigners would swallow it up: The Hebrew word for foreigners is literally “strangers.” It refers here to people from enemy nations who have invaded the land of Israel. HALOT (electronic edition, p. 279) identifies the “strangers” as people who are not Israelites.

Here is another way to translate this line:

people from other countries would take it and eat it

Hosea 8:8

Section 8:1–14: The Israelites will be punished for rejecting the LORD

In this section, the LORD warned the nation of Israel that enemies were ready to attack them, because they had rejected him and broken their agreement to obey his laws (8:1–3). They disobeyed him by choosing their own leaders (8:4a–b) and making idols (8:4c–6). Their alliance with Assyria failed, and they became weak agriculturally and also politically as a nation. Verse 8:10 predicts their future punishment as slaves in Assyria (8:7–10). The LORD did not accept the sacrifices they offered to him, because they continued to sin, so their cities faced total destruction (11–14). The TN analysis of this section follows the paragraph divisions used in a majority of English versions. The summary combines ideas from McComiskey (page 118), Davies (page 193), and Stuart (pages 126–127).

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Paragraph 8:7–10

This paragraph describes the agricultural and political weakness that resulted from Israel's unsuccessful alliance with Assyria. It also predicts Israel's future punishment as exiles in Assyria.

8:8a–b

This verse describes Israel's destruction by foreign nations (8:8a) and its lack of value as a result (8:8b).

^{8a}Israel is swallowed up!

^{8b}Now they are among the nations like a worthless vessel.

There is an obvious connection with the previous verse. In 8:7e foreigners literally swallow grain or flour. In 8:8a foreigners figuratively swallow Israel.

8:8a**Israel is swallowed up!**

- It is as if foreigners are swallowing the nation of Israel itself.
- There is no doubt that Israel will be completely destroyed!

Israel is swallowed up: This line is a metaphor. It compares the destruction of Israel by foreign nations to a person who swallows all the food in a dish. The similarity is that Israel and the food are no longer there. Most commentaries, including Stuart (page 134), understand this figure of speech to refer to Israel's destruction as an independent nation. Davies (page 204) indicates that the similarity between the nation and a dish of food is that "nothing remains except for the dish." The tense of the verb indicates either that the destruction has already begun or that it is certain to happen. The verb is perfect tense. This could be a prophetic perfect (indicating what will certainly happen) or a normal historic perfect. See Macintosh (page 315).

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Israel is eaten up. (NCV)

Israel will be swallowed up. (GW)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

It is as if Israel is being swallowed by other nations.

Foreigners will destroy the nation of Israel like a person swallows the food on a plate.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

Israel, you are ruined (CEV)

8:8b**Now they are among the nations like a worthless vessel.**

- Even now, its people have mixed with those of other nations. Israel is as worthless as a broken pot/tool!
- Already some of the people have been sent to live in the countries of foreigners. Israel has become like something that no one wants.

Now they are among the nations like a worthless vessel:

This statement describes the condition of Israel when it is swallowed up by foreign nations. It has lost its value as an independent nation. There are three ways to interpret this statement:

1. It describes the worthless status of Israel when its people no longer live in their land. They are now scattered among foreign people. For example:

It has already mixed in with the other nations. It has become worthless. (GW) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV)

1. It does not speak about whether the people live in the land of Israel or not. It describes the worthless status of Israel a) in the viewpoint of other nations or b) in comparison with other nations. For example:

and now the nations consider you worthless (CEV)
(CEV, GNT, NAB, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation is similar to 7:8, which says that Israel mixes with the nations and is like a worthless cake of bread. It is also an accurate description of Israel's history. Historically, the Assyrians conquered Israel and sent the people to live in other nations. Stuart (page 134) and Davies (page 204).

Now: In this context the word Now probably indicates present time.

Here is another way to translate it:

already they are among the nations (RSV)

In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate this word explicitly if the meaning is implied from the context.

like a worthless vessel: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “like a vessel [that has] not pleasure in it.” In this phrase the word vessel can refer to a utensil, tool, or pot. This phrase is a simile in which the nation of Israel is compared to a piece of pottery that no one wants. The similarities are that both are destroyed and useless.

Here are some other ways to translate this simile:

- Keep the specific simile and make explicit one or more of the similarities. For example:

like a worthless piece of pottery (NET)

as useless as a broken pot (GNT)

like an old discarded pot (NLT)

- Translate the simile more generally. For example:

like something no one wants (NJB)

like a thing of no value (REB)

- Translate the meaning without a figure of speech. For example:

It has become worthless. (GW)

Hosea 8:9

Section 8:1–14: The Israelites will be punished for rejecting the LORD

In this section, the LORD warned the nation of Israel that enemies were ready to attack them, because they had rejected him and broken their agreement to obey his laws (8:1–3). They disobeyed him by choosing their own leaders (8:4a–b) and making idols (8:4c–6). Their alliance with Assyria failed, and they became weak agriculturally and also politically as a nation. Verse 8:10 predicts their future punishment as slaves in Assyria (8:7–10). The LORD did not accept the sacrifices they offered to him, because they continued to sin, so their cities faced total destruction (11–14). The TN analysis of this section follows the paragraph divisions used in a majority of English versions. The summary combines ideas from McComiskey (page 118), Davies (page 193), and Stuart (pages 126–127).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Will Punish Israel for Its Rebellion (GW)

The LORD warned Israel that enemies would attack them

Warning that Israel will be Punished

Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. He referred to himself using first person pronouns (“I/me/my”) except for verse 13b–d, which has “he.” In this section, the Hebrew text almost always uses “they” or “he/it” to refer to the people or nation of Israel. The only exceptions are 8:1 and 8:5, which use the pronoun “your.” The CEV uses “you/your” consistently to refer to Israel. Most other versions use third person pronouns. The Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line. It will often use “you/your” in the second meaning line.

Paragraph 8:7–10

This paragraph describes the agricultural and political weakness that resulted from Israel’s unsuccessful alliance with Assyria. It also predicts Israel’s future punishment as exiles in Assyria.

8:9a–b

This verse has two similar figures of speech. The simile in 8:9a and the metaphor in 8:9b both describe Israel’s efforts to persuade Assyria to help them. Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning: McComiskey (page 129) and Davies (pages 204–205).

^{9a}For they have gone up **to Assyria like a wild donkey on its own.**

^{9b} Ephraim **has hired lovers.**

8:9a

For they have gone up to Assyria like a wild donkey on its own.

- Because they/Israel rejected their agreement with me and went to Assyria to request help. They are like a wild donkey/ass that stubbornly goes away by itself!
- The reason that this happened to them/Israel is that its leaders went to Assyria to ask for their help. They refused to trust me. They are like an untamed animal that is all alone.

For they have gone up to Assyria like a wild donkey on its own: This simile compares the people of Israel

to a wild donkey that has left the herd. The similarities are that the donkey stubbornly decided to do what it wanted and refused to follow the leader of the herd. It left the protection of the herd and went away by itself.

Similarly, the people of Israel decided not to obey the LORD or trust him to protect them. Instead, they stubbornly rejected their covenant with God, and their leaders went to the foreign nation of Assyria to request help.

Another way to translate this simile is to make explicit one or more points of similarity. For example:

Stubborn as wild donkeys, the people of Israel go their own way. They have gone off to seek help from Assyria (GNT)

Because Israel is like a wild ass that refuses to follow its leader. The people have disobeyed the Lord and decided to go by themselves to ask Assyria for help.

For: In Hebrew, this word probably introduces the reason or explanation for the result in 8:8b that Israel had become worthless. McComiskey (page 129) says that *ki* introduces the reason for 8:8b. Macintosh (page 317) agrees that Israel's political "bankruptcy" in 8:8a-b was the result of her appeals to Assyria for help.

Here are some ways to introduce this reason/explanation:

- Use a conjunction. For example:

For/Because they traveled to Assyria

- Use an explanatory phrase. For example:

The reason that this has happened to Israel is that their leaders went to Assyria

Use a natural way in your language to indicate that 8:9a is a reason or explanation for 8:8b.

they: In this context, *they* refers mainly to the leaders or official representatives of the nation of Israel. According to Dearman, Stuart, Andersen and Freedman, Macintosh, Wood, Lange, and Davies, the ones who went up to Assyria were government leaders or official representatives who were sent to pay tribute or make other arrangements to keep Israel from further conquest. Davies (page 193) summarizes the topic of verses 8-9 as "conduct of foreign relations by

the leaders." These leaders represented the people as a whole.

Here are some other ways to translate this pronoun:

- Refer to the nation or people of Israel. For example:

Israel (NCV)

the people of Israel (GNT)

- Refer more specifically to the leaders. For example:

their leaders

the leaders/representatives of Israel

In Hebrew, there are two pronouns here. The Hebrew is literally "they, they have gone up..." The two pronouns emphasize that the leaders themselves had decided to go to Assyria.

have gone up to Assyria: To go to Assyria, people from Israel needed to first travel north to Damascus. They then went a long ways to the east following the Euphrates River. The words *have gone up* do not refer here to going uphill or to going straight north. It is suggested that you translate these words in a more general way, as in the preceding notes on the word "for." The emphasis here is not on the exact direction of travel.

like a wild donkey: A wild donkey or "wild ass" is an untamed animal that is similar to a small horse. It normally lives in a herd in dry, wilderness areas. NIDOTTE (#7234) says the Hebrew word can refer to a "zebra or wild ass." According to Stuart (page 134), it "was either a wild donkey, onager, or zebra." Stuart also says that wild donkeys normally traveled in herds and lived in barren, wilderness areas. Dearman (pages 128-129) agrees that wild donkeys lived "in herds as a sociable animal."

In languages that do not have a term for "ass" or donkey, here are some ways to translate the term:

- Use the name of a similar animal in your culture. For example:

wild horse/buffalo

- Use a general term. For example:

untamed animal

on its own: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “isolated/alone to itself.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

all by itself (NCV)

all alone (NJB)

8:9b

Ephraim has hired lovers.

- Ephraim is like a prostitute that hires/pays men to have sex with her.
- Israel has given money to other nations so that those nations would help/protect them. She is like a prostitute who pays men so that they will sleep with her.

Ephraim has hired lovers: The name Ephraim here is a figure of speech that refers to the nation of Israel. See how you translated this name in 7:8.

This statement is a metaphor that compares Ephraim to a prostitute. The word hired here refers to an unusual situation in which the prostitute “hires” or pays her lovers to have sex instead of the lovers paying the prostitute.

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor (BSB).
- Change the metaphor to a simile. Add the nonfigurative meaning if necessary. For example:

Ephraim is like a prostitute who pays men to have sex with her.

Israel has given money to other nations to protect her. She is like a prostitute who hires lovers to sleep with her.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

They...have paid other nations to protect them (GNT)

You’ve...hired them as allies. (CEV)

lovers: This word refers here to the nation of Assyria and probably also Egypt. See the notes on 7:11b–c.

Hosea 8:10

Section 8:1–14: The Israelites will be punished for rejecting the LORD

In this section, the LORD warned the nation of Israel that enemies were ready to attack them, because they had rejected him and broken their agreement to obey his laws (8:1–3). They disobeyed him by choosing their own leaders (8:4a–b) and making idols (8:4c–6). Their alliance with Assyria failed, and they became weak agriculturally and also politically as a nation. Verse 8:10 predicts their future punishment as slaves in Assyria (8:7–10). The LORD did not accept the sacrifices they offered to him, because they continued to sin, so their cities faced total destruction (11–14). The TN analysis of this section follows the paragraph divisions used in a majority of English versions. The summary combines ideas from McComiskey (page 118), Davies (page 193), and Stuart (pages 126–127).

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Paragraph 8:7–10

This paragraph describes the agricultural and political weakness that resulted from Israel’s unsuccessful alliance with Assyria. It also predicts Israel’s future punishment as exiles in Assyria.

8:10a–c

Verse 10a describes Israel’s attempts to get help from foreign nations. Verse 10b says that God will respond by gathering them to be punished. Verse 10c describes what that punishment will be like.

^{10a}Though they hire allies among the nations,

^{10b}I will now round them up,

^{10c}and they will begin to diminish under the oppression of the king of princes.

8:10a-b

There are two main ways to interpret the relationship between 8:10a and 8:10b:

1. Verse 8:10a describes an existing situation that leads to the unexpected result in 8:10b. Israel paid other nations to protect them and expected to receive their help. They thought that they would be safe. In spite of what Israel expected, God will still gather them to be punished. When the first of two clauses is introduced by “although,” the relationship between the clauses is sometimes known as concessive (contrary to expectation). For example:

^{10a}Though they hire allies among the nations, ^{10b}I will soon gather them up. (ESV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. Verse 8:10a describes a reason for the expected result in 8:10b. Because of the fact that Israel paid other nations to protect them, the expected result is that God will gather them to be punished. For example:

^{10a}because they have so bargained among the nations, ^{10b}I will now round them up. (REB) (NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries.

Here are some other ways to translate the relationship between these two lines:

Even though...I will gather them (GW)

They have hired...but I will gather them anyway

8:10a

Though they hire allies among the nations,

- But even though she/they hired/paid other nations to help them,
- The people of Israel think that their situation/status will be good/safe,

they hire allies among the nations: This statement refers back to 8:9b. See the note there. In 8:9b, “lovers”

is part of a metaphor that refers to the nations. Here the word nations is used literally.

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

they hire allies among the nations (ESV)

they have hired other countries to protect them

In some languages, it may not be natural to repeat the same idea from 8:9b. If that is true in your language, you may leave parts of this statement implied. For example:

they did this

8:10b

I will now round them up,

- I will now gather them together and punish them.
- but I will soon bring them together for judgment.

I will now round them up: In the OT, the LORD sometimes rounds the people up to do something positive. Here he rounds them up for the purpose of judgment. Some versions make the purpose of rounding up explicit. For example:

I will soon gather them together for judgment.
(NET)

now: This word probably indicates here that the LORD will gather the people soon, as in the previous NET quote.

General Comment on 8:9b–10b

If you translated 8:9b similar to the GNT, it may be more natural to combine that verse part with 8:10a-b. For example:

...paid other nations to protect them (8:9b). But now I am going to gather them together and punish them. (GNT)

8:10c

and they will begin to diminish under the oppression of the king of princes.

- They will start to become fewer/weaker when the great king oppresses them.
- When the great king causes them to endure terrible/extreme hardship/suffering, their numbers will start to decrease.

- The powerful king of Assyria will cause them to suffer greatly/severely, and gradually they will become fewer and weaker.

they will begin to diminish: There are textual and interpretation issues in this part of the clause. The notes will first discuss the referent of they. Other issues will be discussed separately.

they: There are two ways to interpret the referent of this pronoun:

1. It refers to the people of Israel in general. It includes the common people as well as the king and princes. For example:

they (NJPS)

you (CEV) (BSB, CEV, GW, GNT, KJV, NABRE, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. It refers only to the king and princes of Israel. For example:

the king and princes (ESV) (ESV, NAB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries.

will begin to diminish: The issues in this part of the clause involve textual differences between the Hebrew (MT) and Greek (LXX) texts. They also involve textual and interpretation differences in the words used in the MT. Here is a summary of the main issues:

1. One combination of words in the MT means “will begin” + “to diminish” or “to be few.” It refers to a future decrease in numbers or strength. This textual/interpretation option is supported by Macintosh, Delitzsch, and Wood. The BART interlinear glosses this phrase as “will begin [to be] few/less.” NIDOTTE (#2725) says that the Hiphil form of the root *halal* is frequently used as “to begin.” It does not mention Hosea 8:10 specifically. McComiskey (page 127) translates this phrase as “they will begin in a little while [to suffer].” See TWOT (#1228a) for more information on the Hebrew adjective *ma’at* that it glosses as “Little, few, small.” It does not mention this verse specifically. For example:

and they will begin to diminish (BSB, NASB)

They will become weaker and weaker (NCV) (BSB, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS)

1. Another combination of words in the MT means “will writhe/suffer” + “soon” or “a short while.” It refers to future pain and suffering. The Lexham Discourse Hebrew Bible (interlinear) in Logos glosses this phrase as “will writhe soon.” There is no consensus regarding the word that many versions translate as “writhe.” It may come from changing the vowels in the Hiphil form of *halal*. TWOT (#623) has a verb *hul* that can mean “be in anguish” and a noun (#623b) *hil* that can mean “pain.” In combination with one of these words, the adjective *ma’at* is given the sense “soon,” perhaps from the idea of “a little while.” For further discussion, see McComiskey (page 130). Commentaries that support this textual/interpretation option include: Dearman, Hubbard, Stuart, and Andersen and Freedman. For example:

They shall soon writhe (NRSV)

They will suffer for a while (GW) (CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NABRE, NJB, NLT, NRSV)

1. The LXX has “they will cease” + “a little” + “from anointing.” It refers to a future period of time when the people will no longer appoint their leaders. See Davies (page 206) for discussion of possible derivations of “cease” and “anointing” in the LXX. McComiskey (page 130) has a similar discussion. For example:

And they shall cease for a little while from anointing (RSV) (REB, RSV)

The Display will follow textual/interpretation option (1) along with many versions and commentaries. This option requires no change in the vowels or consonants of the MT. It also allows for the normal meaning of the second word (“few”).

However, you may also follow option (2). This option is supported by a majority of versions and commentaries. Whichever option you choose, it is suggested that you put the other option in a footnote.

under the oppression of the king of princes: In Hebrew, the phrase under the oppression is literally “from the burden.” Here the word “burden” refers figuratively to various kinds of suffering and hardship that the people will experience in Assyria.

of the king of princes: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “king princes.” The phrase “king princes” is not used anywhere else in the OT. (For the word princes,

see the note on 8:4b.) There are three main ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It means “king of princes.” This expression indicates the greatest king. For example:

the great king (NLT) (BSB, GNT, NET, NCV, NIV, NJB, NLT)

1. It means “kings and princes.” For example:

kings and rulers (CEV) (CEV, GW, NRSV)

1. It means “king and princes.” For example:

king and officers (NJPS) (NABRE, NJPS, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a majority of versions and commentaries. Macintosh, Keil, Wood, McComiskey, and Hubbard suggest that this is a construct phrase, “king of princes,” similar to the expression “king of kings.” Here it refers to the king of Assyria. See Macintosh for a helpful description of the historical context. Andersen and Freedman, Davies, and Stuart prefer the view that this is a coordinate phrase, “king and/or princes,” in spite of the absence of a conjunction in the MT. The Hebrew word for “king” is singular, so the plural “kings” in the NRSV and similar versions is evidently not based on exegetical or grammatical reasons. This interpretation best fits the historical context in which the people of Israel were deported to Assyria.

Some versions make explicit that this phrase refers to the king of Assyria. For example:

the great king of Assyria (NCV)

the emperor of Assyria (GNT)

In many languages, it will be helpful to make this information explicit.

Hosea 8:11

Section 8:1–14: The Israelites will be punished for rejecting the LORD

In this section, the LORD warned the nation of Israel that enemies were ready to attack them, because they had rejected him and broken their agreement to obey his laws (8:1–3). They disobeyed him by choosing their own leaders (8:4a–b) and making idols (8:4c–6).

Their alliance with Assyria failed, and they became weak agriculturally and also politically as a nation. Verse 8:10 predicts their future punishment as slaves in Assyria (8:7–10). The LORD did not accept the sacrifices they offered to him, because they continued to sin, so their cities faced total destruction (11–14). The TN analysis of this section follows the paragraph divisions used in a majority of English versions. The summary combines ideas from McComiskey (page 118), Davies (page 193), and Stuart (pages 126–127).

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Paragraph 8:11–14

This paragraph describes how the people of Israel sinned when they offered sacrifices to the LORD. There is a contrast between the many altars that the people built for sinning (8:11) and the many teachings that the LORD wrote for the people’s good (8:12). In both situations, the people rejected what God wanted them to do. As a result, the LORD did not accept their sacrifices (8:13), so their cities faced total destruction (8:14).

8:11

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{11a}“Though Ephraim multiplied the altars **for sin**,

^{11b} they became his altars **for sinning**.

In Hebrew, these clauses are more literally:

^{11a}...Ephraim has multiplied altars **for sinning**,

^{11b} they have become for him altars **for sinning**.

The same Hebrew word, “sinning,” is used in each line. However, in 11a, the word probably means “to sacrifice an animal as a sin offering.” In 11b, it probably means “to sin.” This interpretation assumes that the original Hebrew word form of the first occurrence of the word “sinning” was Piel. However, in the Masoretic Text the word form is Qal. These forms are distinguished by different vowels.

8:11a

Though Ephraim multiplied the altars for sin,

- ¶ “Even though the people of Israel built many altars for offering sacrifices to take away their sin,
- ¶ “Because/Since they sacrificed animals on many altars, they expected that I would forgive their sins.

8:11a–b

There are two main ways to interpret the relationship between 8:11a and 8:11b:

1. Verse 8:11a describes an existing situation that led to the unexpected result in 8:11b. The people built many altars as places to offer their sin offerings, so they expected the Lord to take away their sin. Instead, the altars became places where their sin increased. Davies, Dearman, Hubbard, and McComiskey are among the commentaries that imply a direct correlation between the increased number of altars and increased sin/sinning. For example:

^{11a}“Although Israel built more altars to remove sin,
^{11b}they have become altars for sinning. (NCV) (BSB, CEV, GNT, GW, NAB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. Verse 8:11a describes the situation that caused the result in 8:11b. There is no emphasis on whether the result was expected or not. For example:

^{11a}Because Ephraim has multiplied altars for sinning, ^{11b}they have become to him altars for sinning. (ESV) (ESV, KJV, NASB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

Here are some other ways to translate the relationship between 8:11a and 8:11b:

- Emphasize the unexpected consequence in 8:11b. For example:

Although Ephraim has built many altars for sin offerings, these have become altars for sinning! (NET)

When Ephraim multiplied altars to expiate sin, they became to him altars for sinning. (NRSV)

Israel has built many altars to take away sin, but these very altars became places for sinning!

- Emphasize the direct relation between the number of altars and the number of places for sinning. For example:

The more altars the people of Israel build for removing sin, the more places they have for sinning! (GNT)

Use a natural way in your language to indicate one of these options.

8:11b

they became his altars for sinning.

- these same altars became places where their sin increased.
- But they disobeyed what I commanded them, so whenever they offered sacrifices on their altars, they caused their sins to become more.

they became his altars for sinning: Here are some other ways to translate this line:

they became places where people’s sins increased when they offered sacrifices

they became altars where people committed various kinds of sin when they sacrificed

became: The word became indicates that the function of the altars changed. They were now places that violated God’s original command. In Deuteronomy 12, God repeatedly commanded that all twelve tribes worship him at one location with one altar. The people disobeyed God’s command in at least two ways: they built many altars, and they often sacrificed to false gods on these altars. Stuart, Keil, McComiskey, and Wood all draw attention to these two areas of disobedience.

In some languages, it may be helpful to make some of this information explicit. For example:

these altars became places where people increased their sins by disobeying God’s commands.

It may also be helpful to add a footnote that gives some of the OT context. Here is a suggested footnote:

See Deuteronomy 12:5–6, 11, 13–14. In these verses, God commanded that the people from all twelve tribes of Israel worship him in one location and offer sacrifices to him on one altar. He wanted them to be different from the Canaanite people around them who worshiped false gods at many different altars.

Hosea 8:12

Section 8:1–14: The Israelites will be punished for rejecting the LORD

In this section, the LORD warned the nation of Israel that enemies were ready to attack them, because they had rejected him and broken their agreement to obey his laws (8:1–3). They disobeyed him by choosing their own leaders (8:4a–b) and making idols (8:4c–6). Their alliance with Assyria failed, and they became weak agriculturally and also politically as a nation. Verse 8:10 predicts their future punishment as slaves in Assyria (8:7–10). The LORD did not accept the sacrifices they offered to him, because they continued to sin, so their cities faced total destruction (11–14). The TN analysis of this section follows the paragraph divisions used in a majority of English versions. The summary combines ideas from McComiskey (page 118), Davies (page 193), and Stuart (pages 126–127).

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Paragraph 8:11–14

This paragraph describes how the people of Israel sinned when they offered sacrifices to the LORD. There is a contrast between the many altars that the people built for sinning (8:11) and the many teachings that the LORD wrote for the people’s good (8:12). In both situations, the people rejected what God wanted them to do. As a result, the LORD did not accept their sacrifices (8:13), so their cities faced total destruction (8:14).

8:12

These two lines contrast the LORD’s provision of the law with the people’s refusal to follow it:

^{12a}Though I wrote for them the great things of My law,

^{12b}they regarded them as something strange.

8:12a–b

There are two main ways to interpret the relationship between 8:12a and 8:12b:

1. Verse 8:12a describes an existing situation that led to the unexpected result in 8:12b. For example:

^{12a}Though I write for him the multitude of my instructions, ^{12b}they are regarded as a strange thing. (NRSV) (BSB, CEV, GNT, GW, KJV, NAB, NCV, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. Verse 8:12a describes a hypothetical or imagined situation. If this situation happened, then it would lead to the unexpected result in 8:12b. For example:

^{12a}Were I to write for him my laws by the ten thousands, ^{12b}they would be regarded as a strange thing. (ESV) (ESV, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries.

Here are some other ways to indicate this relationship:

^{12a}Though I give him many written laws, ^{12b}they are treated as irrelevant; (REB)

^{12a}I have written many things for them in my teachings, ^{12b}but they consider these things strange and foreign. (GW)

Use a natural way in your language to indicate this relationship.

8:12a**Though I wrote for them the great things of My law,**

- I wrote/gave to them many laws to teach/help them,
- Although I caused a collection of many instructions/teachings to be written for their benefit,

Though I wrote for them the great things of My law:

There is a textual issue here with the phrase (one word in Hebrew) that the BSB translates as great things. There are two options for this phrase in the Masoretic Text: This textual issue involves the difference between the reading/pronunciation recommended by the Masoretes (Qere), option (1), and what is written in the MT (Kethib), option (2). See Soulen (page 100) for more information on Qere/Kethib issues.

1. The first option is the phrase “many things.” For example:

The many teachings I wrote for him (NJPS) (BSB, CEV, GNT, GW, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The second option is the phrase “ten thousand.” For example:

Though I wrote for him ten thousand precepts of My law (NASB) (ESV, NASB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. This option is also followed by the LXX, Peshitta, and Targum.

I wrote: The form of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as I wrote can indicate either a present or past action. The Hebrew form of the word “I wrote” is imperfect. The imperfect normally indicates incomplete action, which is often translated using present or future tense. However, in this context, it refers to the “torah,” which was already written at Hosea’s time. So here, many versions translate it as completed action using a past tense form. This use of the imperfect to signify preterite situations sometimes occurs in poetic texts recounting history. See Waltke and O’Connor, Introduction to Biblical Hebrew Syntax, Chapter 31.1.1 A Historical View. For example:

I have written many teachings for them (NCV)

I write down countless teachings for the people (GNT)

Here the word refers to the teachings or laws that were already written before the time of Hosea. Translate in a way that makes this historical situation clear.

The word does not imply here that the LORD personally wrote the words. It probably refers to the normal way in which he caused/inspired his people to write them.

Here are some ways to translate this line:

I gave them all my laws (NLT)

I caused people to write my many teachings/laws

for them: This phrase indicates that God wrote his teachings for the benefit of his people. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as for them is literally “for him.” The pronoun “him” refers back to Ephraim in the previous verse. Translate this word in a way that clearly refers to the people of Israel.

the great things of My law: In Hebrew, the word that the BSB translates as law is literally “torah” (singular). It refers here to a set of laws rather than a single law. Keil (page 116) and McComiskey (page 132). The phrase great things of My law refers to the many written teachings contained in the torah. These include instructions about how to conduct religious ceremonies such as offering sacrifices. They also include instructions about how to live in a moral way. TWOT (#910d).

8:12b**they regarded them as something strange.**

- but they ignored them, as if these were laws/teachings from a foreign country.
- the people rejected them as if they were written for someone else.

they regarded them as something strange: The people responded to the laws that the LORD gave them as if they were something foreign or unknown. This clause implies that the people ignored or rejected God’s laws.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they reject them as strange and foreign (GNT)

they act as if those laws don’t apply to them (NLT)

but you ignored them (CEV)

they consider them to be irrelevant

Hosea 8:13

Section 8:1-14: The Israelites will be punished for rejecting the LORD

In this section, the LORD warned the nation of Israel that enemies were ready to attack them, because they had rejected him and broken their agreement to obey his laws (8:1-3). They disobeyed him by choosing their own leaders (8:4a-b) and making idols (8:4c-6). Their alliance with Assyria failed, and they became weak agriculturally and also politically as a nation. Verse 8:10 predicts their future punishment as slaves in Assyria (8:7-10). The LORD did not accept the sacrifices they offered to him, because they continued to sin, so their cities faced total destruction (11-14). The TN analysis of this section follows the paragraph divisions used in a majority of English versions. The summary combines ideas from McComiskey (page 118), Davies (page 193), and Stuart (pages 126-127).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Will Punish Israel for Its Rebellion (GW)

The LORD warned Israel that enemies would attack them

Warning that Israel will be Punished

Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. He referred to himself using first person pronouns (“I/me/my”) except for verse 13b-d, which has “he.” In this section, the Hebrew text almost always uses “they” or “he/it” to refer to the people or nation of Israel. The only exceptions are 8:1 and 8:5, which use the pronoun “your.” The CEV uses “you/your” consistently to refer to Israel. Most other versions use third person pronouns. The Display will follow the BSB pronoun choice in the first meaning line. It will often use “you/your” in the second meaning line.

Paragraph 8:11-14

This paragraph describes how the people of Israel sinned when they offered sacrifices to the LORD. There is a contrast between the many altars that the people built for sinning (8:11) and the many teachings that the LORD wrote for the people’s good (8:12). In both situations, the people rejected what God wanted them to do. As a result, the LORD did not accept their sacrifices (8:13), so their cities faced total destruction (8:14).

8:13a-b

The first two lines contrast the sacrifices that the people offered to the LORD with the LORD’s refusal to accept them.

^{13a}Though they offer sacrifices as gifts to Me, and though they eat the meat,

^{13b}and the LORD does not accept them.

8:13a

Though they offer sacrifices as gifts to Me, and though they eat the meat,

- They give to me the sacrifices that they offer, and they eat the meat of the animals.
- As for the sacrifices that they offer me, their desire is only to eat the meat.

Though they offer sacrifices as gifts to Me: There is a textual issue with the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as gifts to Me: The Hebrew word *habhabay* occurs only here in the Old Testament.

1. This word in the Masoretic Text comes from a verb that means “give.” The whole phrase is literally “the sacrifices of my gifts.” This phrase means that the sacrifices that the people offered to the LORD are their gifts to him. For example:

They offer up sacrificial gifts to me (NET) (BSB, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NRSV) The ESV, GNT, GW, NJPS, and NRSV do not specifically use the words “gifts” or “given,” but in the context of offering sacrifices, it is clearly implied that the sacrifices are given or offered to the LORD.

1. Some scholars think that this word comes from a verb that means “love.” They propose that the original Hebrew phrase meant that the people love to offer sacrifices. This proposed phrase requires two different words in the Masoretic Text. Instead of the construct form “sacrifices of” in the MT, the proposed word is the absolute form “sacrifices.” And instead of the noun with 1st person singular suffix “my gifts” in the MT, the proposal is to use the verb plus 3rd person plural suffix, “they love.” For example:

They love sacrifice (RSV) (NLT, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It provides the most straightforward understanding of the Masoretic Text and does not require changes to the words.

In the Hebrew clause “they sacrifice the sacrifices of my gifts,” the phrase “sacrifices of my gifts” is the topic of the sentence.

Here are some ways to focus the reader's attention on this topic:

As for My sacrificial gifts (NASB)

Concerning the gifts that the people offer to me

Some versions leave it implicit that the sacrifices were gifts to the LORD. For example, the NJB does not use the word gifts explicitly. It has:

They offer sacrifices to me

and though they eat the meat: This whole statement (8:13a) probably implies that the people were not sincere when they offered these sacrifices to the LORD. They cared only about eating the meat of the animals that they offered. Hubbard (page 153), Keil (page 117), and Wood (page 202). Some versions make explicit this implied information. For example:

When they present sacrifices to Me, It is but flesh for them to eat (NJPS)

8:13b the LORD does not accept them.

- Even though they do this, those sacrifices have no value to me.
- But I, Yahweh, do not accept their sacrifices.

the LORD does not accept them: There are two ways to interpret the referent of the pronoun them:

1. The word them refers to the sacrifices. The LORD was not pleased with the sacrifices that the people offered. Keil (page 117) and Stuart (page 136). For example:

but I, the Lord, do not accept these sacrifices. (GW) (CEV, GW, NET, NLT)

1. The word them refers to the people. The LORD was not pleased with the people who were making the sacrifices. Andersen and Freedman (page 510) and McComiskey (page 133). For example:

They offer sacrifices to me and eat the meat, they do not win Yahweh's favour. (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Many versions, including the BSB, leave the pronoun

referent implicit. In these versions, either interpretation is possible.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

but I, the Lord, refuse your offerings (CEV)

but to me their sacrifices are all meaningless. (NLT)

8:13c Now He will remember their iniquity

- The time has come for me to respond to their evil behavior/actions
- I will now do something about the wrong things that they have done.

8:13d and punish their sins:

- and punish them for their sins.
- I will give them an appropriate punishment.

8:13c-d
Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{13c}Now He will remember **their iniquity**

^{13d}and punish **their sins**:

Now: This word indicates here that it is time for the LORD to judge.

He will remember their iniquity and punish their sins: In this context, these words mean that he will respond to their disobedience in an appropriate way. McComiskey (page 133). His response will be to punish them for their sins.

8:13e They will return to Egypt.

- They were once/previously slaves in Egypt. Soon they will become slaves again.
- I will cause them to be slaves again like their situation in Egypt long ago.

They will return to Egypt: This clause tells how the LORD will punish the people. It should probably be understood figuratively as a return to slavery. It means that the people will become slaves again. McComiskey (page 133), Stuart (page 137), Wood (page 202), Hubbard (page 153), and Keil (page 117). It does not mean here that the people will literally return to Egypt.

Hosea 8:14

Section 8:1-14: The Israelites will be punished for rejecting the LORD

In this section, the LORD warned the nation of Israel that enemies were ready to attack them, because they had rejected him and broken their agreement to obey his laws (8:1-3). They disobeyed him by choosing their own leaders (8:4a-b) and making idols (8:4c-6). Their alliance with Assyria failed, and they became weak agriculturally and also politically as a nation. Verse 8:10 predicts their future punishment as slaves in Assyria (8:7-10). The LORD did not accept the sacrifices they offered to him, because they continued to sin, so their cities faced total destruction (11-14). The TN analysis of this section follows the paragraph divisions used in a majority of English versions. The summary combines ideas from McComiskey (page 118), Davies (page 193), and Stuart (pages 126-127).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

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Paragraph 8:11-14

This paragraph describes how the people of Israel sinned when they offered sacrifices to the LORD. There is a contrast between the many altars that the people built for sinning (8:11) and the many teachings that the LORD wrote for the people’s good (8:12). In both situations, the people rejected what God wanted them to do. As a result, the LORD did not accept their sacrifices (8:13), so their cities faced total destruction (8:14).

8:14

Some versions, such as the GNT and CEV, make this verse a separate paragraph. The notes will follow most

versions and make 8:14 the last verse of 8:11-14. You may do whatever is more natural in your language.

8:14a-b (combined/reordered)

- The people of Israel and Judah have forgotten the one who made them into a nation. They built sturdy palaces and high/thick walls around their towns to protect them from their enemies.

These lines describe another sin that the LORD will judge. The people trusted in palaces and fortified towns instead of trusting in the LORD who made them. Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{14a} Israel has forgotten his Maker and **built palaces**;

^{14b} Judah has **multiplied its fortified cities**.

The parallelism implies that the people in both Israel and Judah have “forgotten” their “Maker.” It also implies that both groups of people “built palaces” and “multiplied its fortified cities.”

Maker: This word implies here that the LORD made the people into a nation. In some languages, it may be helpful to make this information explicit. For example:

the one who made it/them into a nation

and built palaces: The word palaces refers here to the residences of the kings. Palaces were also fortified. Andersen and Freedman (page 512) and Macintosh (page 332). This is also supported by the use of the parallel word “citadels” in 14d.

Judah has multiplied its fortified cities: The phrase multiplied its fortified cities means that the people built thick stone walls around the towns to protect them from enemy attacks.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Judah has built many strong, walled cities. (NCV)

Judah has many cities with sturdy walls around them

8:14a

Israel has forgotten his Maker and built palaces;

- The country of Israel has forgotten who made them. They built palaces for their kings.

- The people of Israel built sturdy houses for their kings, but they have forgotten me who caused them to become a nation.

8:14b**Judah has multiplied its fortified cities.**

- The country of Judah also built strong walls around many of their towns.
- It is the same with the people of Judah. They surrounded many of their towns with high stone walls to protect them.

8:14a–d**(combined/reordered)**

- You^(plur) people of Israel and Judah, I made you into a nation, but you have forgotten me. You built strong/fortified cities and palaces to protect you. But I will destroy them with fire.”

8:14c–d**(combined/reordered)**

- But I will send their enemies to burn their fortified/strong cities and palaces and completely destroy them.”

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning: 8:14a–d is a chiasm. The words “palaces” and “cities” in 14a–b occur in the opposite order from “cities” and “citadels” in 14c–d.

^{14c}But I will send fire upon **their cities**,

^{14d}and it will consume **their citadels**.

These lines describe the way that the LORD will judge the people. He will “send fire” to destroy the strong walls and palaces that the people depended on to protect them.

But: Verse 14c begins with a conjunction that contrasts the people’s efforts to protect their cities (14a–b) with the fact that the LORD will destroy those cities. Introduce this verse part in a way that indicates this contrast in your language.

I will send fire upon their cities, and it will consume their citadels: These parallel clauses mean that the LORD will send enemy armies to set fire to the cities. The fire will destroy them, including the citadels (fortified palaces). Kidner (page 82), Hubbard (page 154), Wood (page 202), and Stuart (page 137).

General Comment on 8:14a–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine the parallel parts. For example:

^{14a}Israel, I created you, but you forgot me. ^{14a–b}You and Judah built palaces and many strong cities. ^{14c–d}Now I will send fire to destroy your towns and fortresses. (CEV)

See also 8:14a–b, 8:14c–d, and 8:14a–d (combined/reordered) in the Display.

8:14c**But I will send fire upon their cities,**

- But I will send fire to burn down those walled cities/towns of theirs
- Even though they did this, I will send their enemies to burn down their cities/towns

8:14d**and it will consume their citadels.**

- and destroy their palaces.”
- along with the fortified/sturdy houses that their kings live in.”

Hosea 9:1**Section 9:1–9: The LORD will punish the Israelites**

This section warns the people of Israel that the LORD will punish them because they have been unfaithful to him. When that happens, the people will no longer be able to celebrate at harvest time or enjoy the crops from their land. The section describes aspects of daily life that the people in Israel would clearly understand. Some examples are harvest festivals (9:1, 5), threshing grain and making wine (9:2), unclean food (9:3–4), offerings and sacrifices (9:4), briars and thorns (9:6), and prophets (9:7–8). There is also an indirect reference to Israel’s past (9:9).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Will Punish Israel (ESV)

Hosea announces Israel’s Punishment (NLT)

Israel Will Be Punished (CEV)

The Sorrows of Exile (NJB)

Paragraph 9:1–6

This paragraph tells about joyful activities that the people will no longer experience when they are in exile in Assyria. In exile, they will no longer have joyful harvests or be able to offer acceptable sacrifices to God. Instead of rejoicing, they will mourn.

9:1a–b (combined/reordered)

- ¶ O people of Israel, do not rejoice as other nations do. (NLT)

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{1a} Do not rejoice, O Israel,

^{1b} with exultation like the nations,

The speaker of these lines is probably Hosea. The pattern of second or third person references to Yahweh in 9:1–5 suggests that Hosea was the speaker. For example, “your god,” “Yahweh’s land,” “to Yahweh,” etc. See Stuart (pages 141–142). He tells the people of Israel to stop rejoicing at harvest time.

There is a textual issue in 9:1b. It affects the parallel line structure in 9:1a–b.

1. The LXX has “Do not rejoice, O Israel! And do not exult/delight like the peoples.” The Syriac, Vulgate, and Targum also have two parallel commands. The Syriac has “Rejoice not, O Israel, leap not for joy as others do.” The Vulgate (line 2) has “nor exult...” (Macintosh, page 339). For example:

Do not rejoice, O Israel! Do not exult as other nations do (NRSV) (CEV, ESV, GW, NAB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NRSV, REB)

1. The Masoretic Text has “Do not rejoice O Israel to/with rejoicing/exultation like the peoples.” The HOTTP gives the MT a C rating, indicating considerable doubt. The phrase “rejoice with exultation” means to rejoice greatly. McComiskey, Macintosh, and Lange all appeal to Job 3:22, the only other verse where a similar word combination (rejoice unto exultation) occurs. However, according to Davies (page 213), that passage may be corrupt. With this option, there is a single intensified command rather than two parallel commands. For example:

O Israel, do not rejoice jubilantly like the nations (NET) (BSB, KJV, NASB, NET)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. Commentaries that support option (1) include Davies, Stuart, Hubbard, and Wood. See Stuart (page 140) for more discussion.

rejoice...with exultation: These words mean “be glad/joyful.” Both words can express joy of various kinds and of various degrees of intensity. TWOT (#2268) and TWOT (#346a).

Here are some other ways to translate the negative commands:

do not rejoice; don’t shout for joy (NCV)

don’t rejoice. Don’t celebrate (GW)

like the nations: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “like the peoples.” It refers here to people who live in nations other than Israel.

General Comment on 9:1a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the parallel parts in these two lines. For example:

People of Israel, stop celebrating your festivals like pagans. (GNT)

9:1a

Do not rejoice, O Israel,

- ¶ Israel, do not rejoice^(sing).
- ¶ People of Israel, do not be full^(plur) of gladness.

9:1b

with exultation like the nations,

- Do not celebrate^(sing) as other nations do.
- Do not shout because of your^(plur) joy like people of other nations.

9:1c–d

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{1c}for you **have been played the harlot your God;**

^{1d}you **have made love for hire** on every threshing floor.

In these lines, Hosea begins to explain why the people of Israel must not rejoice. The reason is that they were unfaithful to God and will soon experience the consequences of their unfaithfulness. God will send them into exile.

9:1c

for you have played the harlot against your God;

- Because you^(sing) have left your God to sell yourself to other lovers.

- You^(plur) have been like a prostitute! You have turned away from your God.

for you have played the harlot against your God:

The nation of Israel is compared to a harlot/prostitute, because the people were not faithful to God.

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

For you have played the harlot, forsaking your God. (NASB)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

You have been like a prostitute against your God. (NCV)

- Translate the meaning directly without using a figure of speech. For example:

For you have been unfaithful to your God; (NIV)

The Hebrew phrase “from beside your God” indicates that the people’s unfaithful behavior distanced them from God. Some versions make this information explicit. For example:

You have turned away from your God and have been unfaithful to him. (GNT)

for you have deserted your God to play the whore (NJB)

your God: In some languages, the phrase your God may imply that Israel’s God is not the same as Hosea’s God. One way to avoid this wrong meaning is to translate the phrase as “our^(incl) God.”

9:1d

you have made love for hire on every threshing floor.

- You^(sing) loved the wages you earned as a prostitute there on every threshing floor.
- In the places where people thresh grain, you^(plur) gladly offer your body to others for the money they will give you.

you have made love for hire on every threshing floor: This line again compares the Israelites to a harlot/prostitute. A prostitute earns wages by hiring herself to make love. Likewise, Israel gave herself to Baal and other false gods by worshipping them.

The people wrongly thought that those false gods provided their grain and other needs as wages for their worship. See also Hosea 2:5, 2:8.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

You have loved the wages you made as a prostitute there on every threshing floor.

Everywhere that people thresh grain, you are like prostitutes who are delighted with the fee you receive for selling yourself to others.

love for hire: This phrase refers to the fee that a client pays to a prostitute. In this context, the wages are the grain on the threshing floor.

on every threshing floor: Threshing floors were large open areas where the farmers removed the kernels of grain from the husk. Some scholars believe that threshing floors were also areas where the people worshiped Baal or other idols.

Hosea 9:2

Section 9:1–9: The LORD will punish the Israelites

This section warns the people of Israel that the LORD will punish them because they have been unfaithful to him. When that happens, the people will no longer be able to celebrate at harvest time or enjoy the crops from their land. The section describes aspects of daily life that the people in Israel would clearly understand. Some examples are harvest festivals (9:1, 5), threshing grain and making wine (9:2), unclean food (9:3–4), offerings and sacrifices (9:4), briars and thorns (9:6), and prophets (9:7–8). There is also an indirect reference to Israel’s past (9:9).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Will Punish Israel (ESV)

Hosea announces Israel’s Punishment (NLT)

Israel Will Be Punished (CEV)

The Sorrows of Exile (NJB)

Paragraph 9:1–6

This paragraph tells about joyful activities that the people will no longer experience when they are in exile in Assyria. In exile, they will no longer have joyful

harvests or be able to offer acceptable sacrifices to God. Instead of rejoicing, they will mourn.

9:2

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{2a} The threshing floor and winepress **will not feed them**,

^{2b} and the new wine **will fail them**.

This verse tells about one of the consequences of the people of Israel rejecting the LORD. He will take away their grain and wine. This consequence probably resulted from their worship of the false god Baal. They believed that Baal gave them their grain and wine. This warning is similar to the words in Hosea 2:8. See the note in 2:8b on “the grain, the new wine and oil” for more details.

9:2a

The threshing floor and winepress will not feed them,

- But soon the threshing floors and winepresses will not produce enough food and drink to feed everyone.
- Soon your people will go hungry. Your^(sing) grain and wine will not be sufficient for them.

The threshing floor and winepress will not feed them: This clause has two related figures of speech (metonymy). They represent the products, grain and wine, that are produced at the threshing floor and winepress. It means that there will not be enough grain for the people to eat or enough wine for them to drink. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate the meaning directly. For example:

There won't be enough grain to feed people. There won't be enough wine to go around. (GW)

winepress: There are two main interpretations of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as winepress:

1. The word means winepress. A winepress is a device that presses the juice from grapes. For example:

The threshing-floor and wine-press will not feed them (NJB) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NET, NJPS, NCV, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The word means “olive-press.” An olive-press is a device that presses the oil from olives. For example,

the GNT lists the products associated with a threshing-floor and an olive-press:

But soon you will not have enough grain and olive oil (GNT) (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

9:2a-b

(combined/reordered)

- But there will not be enough grain and wine for everyone.

9:2b

and the new wine will fail them.

- The new/fresh wine will be inadequate.
- There will be no more grapes to press/squeeze into wine.

the new wine will fail them: This clause indicates that the amount of new wine will not be enough to meet the needs of the people. Wood (page 204), Davies (page 214).

Here is another way to translate this clause:

there won't be enough new wine (NCV)

new wine: See the note on this same product in 2:8b for more details. If new wine is not familiar in your language area, you may use a more general term. For example:

there will be no wine (GNT)

them: There is a textual difference here that involves the word them:

1. The LXX and other ancient versions have them. them refers to the people of Israel. For example:

the new wine shall fail them (RSV) (BSB, ESV, NAB, NASB, NET, NIV, NRSV, REB)

1. The Masoretic Text has “her.” “Her” refers to the nation of Israel. For example:

the new wine shall betray her (NJPS) (NJPS)

Options (1) and (2) are two ways to refer to Israel. It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions.

General Comment on 9:2a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the parallel parts. For example:

But you will run short of grain and wine (CEV)

Hosea 9:3

Section 9:1–9: The LORD will punish the Israelites

This section warns the people of Israel that the LORD will punish them because they have been unfaithful to him. When that happens, the people will no longer be able to celebrate at harvest time or enjoy the crops from their land. The section describes aspects of daily life that the people in Israel would clearly understand. Some examples are harvest festivals (9:1, 5), threshing grain and making wine (9:2), unclean food (9:3–4), offerings and sacrifices (9:4), briars and thorns (9:6), and prophets (9:7–8). There is also an indirect reference to Israel's past (9:9).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Will Punish Israel (ESV)

Hosea announces Israel's Punishment (NLT)

Israel Will Be Punished (CEV)

The Sorrows of Exile (NJB)

Paragraph 9:1–6

This paragraph tells about joyful activities that the people will no longer experience when they are in exile in Assyria. In exile, they will no longer have joyful harvests or be able to offer acceptable sacrifices to God. Instead of rejoicing, they will mourn.

9:3

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{3a} They will not remain **in the land of the LORD**;

^{3b} Ephraim will return **to Egypt**

^{3c} and eat unclean food **in Assyria**.

This verse explains why the people will not have grain to eat or wine to drink in Israel. It is because their enemy will take them from Israel to live in exile in Assyria. Hubbard (page 157). The first line states the

general fact. The second and third lines give more specific details. Andersen and Freedman (page 524).

9:3a

They will not remain in the land of the LORD;

- They will not continue to live in the land of Yahweh.
- You^(plur) will leave Yahweh's land.

They will not remain in the land of the LORD: This line states that the people will not continue to live in Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

You may no longer stay here in the Lord's land.
(NLT)

and you will have to leave

the land of the Lord (CEV)

the land of the LORD: This phrase occurs only here in the Old Testament. It indicates that the land of Israel belongs to the LORD, not to the people. It is his choice to give his land to people as a blessing or to take it away from them as a judgment. Davies (page 215).

9:3b

Ephraim will return to Egypt

- Israel will return to being captives as they were in Egypt, (NCV)
- Just as our^(incl) ancestors were once slaves in Egypt, you^(plur) will become slaves

Ephraim will return to Egypt: This line is an indirect reference to Israel's past. Long ago the people were slaves in the land of Egypt. Here the phrase return to Egypt does not mean that the people will literally return to that land. Rather, it means that the people of Israel will become slaves in a foreign land as they were in Egypt. Commentaries that express this view include Stuart, Macintosh, Wood, Hubbard, Davies, Keil, and McComiskey.

The NCV makes this meaning explicit:

Israel will return to being captives as they were
in Egypt (NCV)

Ephraim: Again, the name Ephraim is a figure of speech that refers to the nation of Israel. Some versions translate it as "Israel" (NCV). Others use a pronoun such as "you" (NLT) or "they" (GW).

9:3c and eat unclean food in Assyria.

- and in Assyria they will have to eat food that Yahweh says is unclean/taboo.
- in Assyria. There you^(plur) will eat the food that they provide, even food that our^(incl) tradition forbids us to eat.

and eat unclean food in Assyria: In this line, Hosea makes explicit that Assyria is the foreign country where the people will become slaves. In Assyria, the Israelites will depend on their captors for their food. This will include some food that the LORD told the people not to eat. See Leviticus 11.

Hosea 9:4

Section 9:1–9: The LORD will punish the Israelites

This section warns the people of Israel that the LORD will punish them because they have been unfaithful to him. When that happens, the people will no longer be able to celebrate at harvest time or enjoy the crops from their land. The section describes aspects of daily life that the people in Israel would clearly understand. Some examples are harvest festivals (9:1, 5), threshing grain and making wine (9:2), unclean food (9:3–4), offerings and sacrifices (9:4), briars and thorns (9:6), and prophets (9:7–8). There is also an indirect reference to Israel's past (9:9).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Will Punish Israel (ESV)

Hosea announces Israel's Punishment (NLT)

Israel Will Be Punished (CEV)

The Sorrows of Exile (NJB)

Paragraph 9:1–6

This paragraph tells about joyful activities that the people will no longer experience when they are in exile in Assyria. In exile, they will no longer have joyful harvests or be able to offer acceptable sacrifices to God. Instead of rejoicing, they will mourn.

9:4a–b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{4a} They will not pour out wine offerings **to the LORD,**

^{4b}and their sacrifices will not **please Him,**

These lines indicate that in Assyria the people will no longer have the opportunity to offer acceptable sacrifices to the LORD. Stuart (pages 143–144) states that in captivity there will be neither a legitimate nor illegitimate Yahwistic worship center where sacrifices may be offered. Other commentaries that hold this view include Wood, Polkinghorne, Hubbard, Keil, Andersen and Freedman, and McComiskey.

9:4a

They will not pour out wine offerings to the LORD,

- They will no longer have an opportunity to pour out wine offerings to Yahweh
- There in exile/slavery you^(plur) will not be able to offer wine to Yahweh as you could do in Israel.

They will not pour out wine offerings to the LORD:

In Hebrew, the phrase wine offerings is literally wine. The BSB has supplied the word offerings to clarify the meaning. Offerings of wine often accompanied a burnt offering or other animal sacrifice. See Exodus 29:40; Numbers 15:5.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

The Israelites will not give offerings of wine to the Lord (NCV)

There you will make no offerings of wine to the Lord. (NLT)

9:4b

and their sacrifices will not please Him,

- or be able to please him with sacrifices.
- You^(plur) will not be able to make any sacrifices there that will please him.

and their sacrifices will not please Him: According to Macintosh (page 343), an alternative view was that the wine offerings would not be pleasing to him. For example, the KJV has “They shall not offer wine [offerings] to the Lord, neither shall they be pleasing unto him.” There is a textual issue concerning the word that the BSB translates as please:

1. The Masoretic Text has “not will they be pleasing to him.” For example:

and their sacrifices shall not please him (ESV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NASB, NET, NJB, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. Some scholars have proposed that the original text was “not will they bring/give to him.” For example:

they will not give him sacrifices (NCV) (GNT, NAB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. It makes sense and fits the context. There is no evidence that the Masoretic Text is incorrect.

Here is another way to translate this line:

None of your sacrifices there will please him. (NLT)

9:4c

but will be to them like the bread of mourners;

- Any sacrifices that people offer in Assyria will be just like the bread that they eat when they are mourning.
- If you make such sacrifices there, they will not be acceptable to Yahweh. The sacrifices will affect you^(plur) the same as the food that mourners eat.

but will be to them like the bread of mourners: In Hebrew, this clause is literally “likeTN follows the majority of commentators and modern versions that understand the Hebrew word to indicate a comparison, that is, “like bread of mourning.” Some scholars interpret the word to indicate emphasis, that is, “indeed it is bread of mourning.” See Anderson and Freedman (page 526). Still others interpret the word to indicate possession, that is, “to them it is bread of mourning.” See Macintosh (page 344). bread of mourning(s) to them.” Hebrew syntax allows the Hebrew word translated as “their sacrifices” to be connected either to this clause or to the preceding clause. The majority of modern commentators and versions connect it to the preceding clause, which results in “their sacrifices will not be pleasing to him.” The subject of the Hebrew clause is left implicit. As a result, there are two main interpretations:

1. The subject is sacrifices. 9:4a–b says that the people will not offer sacrifices to the LORD. This clause continues to describe those sacrifices. Davies (page 217), Wood (page 204). For example:

Such sacrifices shall be like mourners’ bread (NRSV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The subject is bread or food. This refers to the bread/food that the exiles eat in Assyria. This clause introduces a new topic. Keil (page 120). For example:

Their bread shall be like mourners’ bread (RSV) (GNT, NASB, NJPS, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. It makes good sense to understand this simile as a continuation of the topic of sacrifices. It begins to explain why the peoples’ sacrifices would not be pleasing to the LORD.

to them: This phrase refers back to the people who offer the sacrifices.

like the bread of mourners: This phrase is a simile that compares the peoples’ sacrifices to food that people ate at a funeral.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

like food eaten at funerals (GNT)

like food touched by a person in mourning (NLT)

9:4d

all who eat will be defiled.

- Whoever eats it becomes ritually/ceremonially unclean according to the laws of Moses.
- Anyone who eats such food will be unclean/defiled in Yahweh’s sight.

all who eat will be defiled: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “all [those who] eat it will make themselves unclean.” There are two main interpretations of the pronoun “it”:

1. “It” refers to the mourners’ bread. The mourners’ bread is the nearest preceding noun. For example:

Their sacrifices will be like the food that mourners eat. All who eat this food will be unclean. (GW) (ESV, GNT, GW, NAB, NCV, NASB, NRSV, REB)

1. “It” refers to the sacrifices. The pronoun refers back to the subject of the clause. A difficulty is a mismatch in number between the singular pronoun and the plural referent. For example:

All who present such sacrifices will be defiled. (NLT) (NET, NIV, NJB, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Both the pronoun and the noun to which it refers are singular. With this interpretation, the line continues the description of the bread of mourners.

defiled: This word refers to spiritual uncleanness. Old Testament laws described activities and objects that were ritually unclean. Therefore they were not acceptable for worship of the LORD. See Deut 26:14; Num 19:11–13, 22. Stuart (pages 143–144).

General Comment on 9:4c–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine these verse parts. For example:

they will be ^{4d}unclean ^{4c}like food offered to the dead (CEV)

9:4e

For their bread will be for themselves;

- This food will only be useful to satisfy their hunger.
- You^(plur) can use the food for yourselves,

For their bread will be for themselves: In Hebrew, this clause begins with the word *ki*. In this context, one possible function of this word is to indicate the reason for the preceding statement. Versions that use the word “for” to indicate the reason for the preceding statement include the BSB, ESV, KJV, NASB, NET, NJB, and NRSV. BART identifies *ki* as a deictic marker that gives emphasis. This interpretation is also preferred by Hubbard (page 158). No versions follow this approach. The NJPS introduces the clause with the word “but,” indicating a contrast. It is the only version that follows this approach. The reason that this food is considered to be unclean is that it is only for themselves. For example:

for their food will be for themselves alone (NJB)

However, in many languages, this clause does not give a logical reason for the preceding statement. Andersen & Freedman (page 527) say that it does not provide a recognizable reason for either what precedes or follows. Many versions leave the relationship between the clauses implied. For example:

It will be used only to satisfy their hunger (GNT)

Your food will only be used to satisfy your hunger (CEV)

An advantage of leaving the connection implied is that it allows the reader to supply the connection that makes the most sense in a particular language.

their bread: The phrase *their bread* refers to the food in the sacrifices that are like mourner’s bread. The

LORD regards this food to be unclean and those that eat it to be unclean. It will be food for those that eat it, but it is not fit to use for worship.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

this food will be for themselves alone

this food will serve only to satisfy their appetite

9:4f

it will not enter the house of the LORD.

- Such food will not be allowed in the temple of Yahweh.
- but not for the worship of Yahweh.

it will not enter the house of the LORD: This clause means that the LORD does not want this food to be offered to him in the temple.

it will not enter: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “it will not go.” This phrase is probably a prohibition. The LORD will not allow unclean bread in his house. It is not just a statement that it will not happen. Davies (218) describes this statement as a “prohibition.” Stuart (page 144) says the bread is “ritually excluded.” Some versions make it explicit that this is a prohibition. For example:

they cannot sacrifice it in the Temple. (NCV)

it must not be offered in the house of the Lord (REB)

house of the LORD: This refers to the temple in Jerusalem. Macintosh (page 345), Davies (page 218), McComiskey (page 141). The NCV and some other versions capitalize “Temple” to indicate that this refers to the temple in Jerusalem. It was the only worship center where the LORD allowed sacrifices to be offered.

Hosea 9:5

Section 9:1–9: The LORD will punish the Israelites

This section warns the people of Israel that the LORD will punish them because they have been unfaithful to him. When that happens, the people will no longer be able to celebrate at harvest time or enjoy the crops from their land. The section describes aspects of daily life that the people in Israel would clearly understand. Some examples are harvest festivals (9:1, 5), threshing grain and making wine (9:2), unclean food (9:3–4), offerings and sacrifices (9:4), briars and thorns (9:6), and

prophets (9:7–8). There is also an indirect reference to Israel’s past (9:9).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Will Punish Israel (ESV)

Hosea announces Israel’s Punishment (NLT)

Israel Will Be Punished (CEV)

The Sorrows of Exile (NJB)

Paragraph 9:1–6

This paragraph tells about joyful activities that the people will no longer experience when they are in exile in Assyria. In exile, they will no longer have joyful harvests or be able to offer acceptable sacrifices to God. Instead of rejoicing, they will mourn.

9:5

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{5a} What will you do **on the appointed day**,

^{5b} **on the day of the LORD’s feast?**

In Hebrew, there is an ellipsis (deliberate omission) of the words “What will you do” in the second line. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words to make the meaning clearer. For example:

^{5b} What will you do **on days of feasting in the Lord’s presence?** (NLT96)

These lines warn the people that in Assyria they will no longer be able to celebrate special feast days.

9:5a

What will you do on the appointed day,

- There in exile/slavery, what will you^(plur) do to observe/hold your appointed feasts? Nothing!
- When you are captives/slaves, you will no longer be able to have your yearly feasts.

What will you do on the appointed day: In this verse, Hosea speaks directly to the people, using the pronoun you. He uses a rhetorical question with the implied negative answer “Nothing.” It means that the people will definitely not be able to celebrate the feasts. Macintosh, Andersen and Freedman, Hubbard, McComiskey, and Wood all agree on the function of

this rhetorical question. It emphasizes that no rejoicing will be possible.

This rhetorical question can also be expressed as a statement. For example:

You will no longer be able to celebrate the festival of the Lord. (CEV)

the appointed day: This phrase refers to the regular times when the people celebrated feasts. The word day is not necessarily literal here, since some feasts lasted longer than a day.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

when the time comes for the appointed festivals (GNT)

These appointed feast days included Passover, The Feast of Unleavened Bread, The Feast of Weeks and The Feast of Tabernacles/Booths. The Hebrew word here is an indefinite singular, literally “an appointed feast.” According to Macintosh (page 347), it is used collectively to refer to the nation’s major festivals. See Leviticus 23.

9:5a–b

(combined/reordered)

- And when the time comes for the appointed festivals/feasts when you^(plur) honor Yahweh, what will you do then? You will not be able to do anything!

9:5b

on the day of the LORD’s feast?

- Will you^(plur) be able to have times of joyous celebration to honor Yahweh? No!
- There will be no more festival days to honor Yahweh.

on the day of the LORD’s feast?: Since this phrase is parallel to “appointed day,” it probably refers to those same feasts. Andersen and Freedman (page 529), Keil (page 121), and McComiskey (page 141). However, it is possible that this phrase refers especially to the feast of Tabernacles/Shelters/Booths, which was held each autumn. Stuart (page 144), Macintosh (page 347), Davies (page 218), and Hubbard (page 158). Some versions give this information in a footnote. For example, here is a footnote from the CEV:

festival of the Lord: Probably the Festival of Shelters. (CEV)

Consider adding a similar footnote if you think it will be helpful to your readers.

General Comment on 9:5a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine these verse parts. For example:

^{5a-b}And when the time comes for the appointed festivals in honor of the LORD, ^{5a}what will you do then? (adapted from GNT)

Hosea 9:6

Section 9:1–9: The LORD will punish the Israelites

This section warns the people of Israel that the LORD will punish them because they have been unfaithful to him. When that happens, the people will no longer be able to celebrate at harvest time or enjoy the crops from their land. The section describes aspects of daily life that the people in Israel would clearly understand. Some examples are harvest festivals (9:1, 5), threshing grain and making wine (9:2), unclean food (9:3–4), offerings and sacrifices (9:4), briars and thorns (9:6), and prophets (9:7–8). There is also an indirect reference to Israel's past (9:9).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Will Punish Israel (ESV)

Hosea announces Israel's Punishment (NLT)

Israel Will Be Punished (CEV)

The Sorrows of Exile (NJB)

Paragraph 9:1–6

This paragraph tells about joyful activities that the people will no longer experience when they are in exile in Assyria. In exile, they will no longer have joyful harvests or be able to offer acceptable sacrifices to God. Instead of rejoicing, they will mourn.

9:6a

For even if they flee destruction,

- ¶ Some of the people will not be killed/destroyed. But when they try to escape,
- ¶ For look! The people will flee from destruction. But even so,
- ¶ Because even if some are able to escape from their devastated/ruined country/land,

For even if they flee destruction: In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally “for look/ behold they have gone from devastation.” The RSV follows a proposed Hebrew text that supposedly had “Assyria” here in-

stead of the word meaning “from devastation.” This yields “they are going to Assyria.” However, this proposal has no support from ancient texts or versions. See Davies (page 218) and Andersen and Freedman (page 530). Hosea uses the past tense “have gone” here to indicate that fulfillment of this prophecy is absolutely certain. Some versions use past tense. For example:

What a scene of devastation they have left! (NJB)

For look, the people have fled from a scene of devastation (REB)

In most languages, it will be clearer to use non-past or future verbs as Hebrew does in 9:6b–e. The meaning lines in the Display will do the same.

This verse part means that when their enemy destroys their cities and land, the people of Israel who are still alive will try to escape. But if they do escape, the event(s) in 6:b–c will still happen.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Even if they escape without being destroyed (GW)

When the disaster comes and the people are scattered (GNT)

In Hebrew, the first two words of this clause are literally “For look,” as in the REB quoted above.

The word For introduces the reason the people will not be able to celebrate their feasts (see 9:5). It is because Israel will be destroyed, and the people who escape the destruction will never live there again. For example:

For even if they escape destruction (NRSV)

The word “look” draws attention to the statement that follows it. McComiskey (page 141) identifies the functions of both Hebrew words. Some versions translate the word literally here. For example:

Look! Even if they flee from the destruction (NET)

Some English versions leave the words For and “look” implied.

9:6b–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{6b} Egypt **will gather them**

^{6c}and Memphis **will bury them.**

These lines indicate that the people of Israel will die in a land that is foreign to them. Egypt and Memphis probably refer indirectly here to Israel's past, when the people died in the foreign land of Egypt. Keil (page 121), McComiskey (page 141), and Wood (page 204). Hosea compares their future exile and death in Assyria to their slavery and death in Egypt in the past. This is similar to 9:3b. Another possibility is that these lines refer to literal Egypt and Memphis. See Davies (page 218), Macintosh (page 350), Andersen and Freedman (page 530), Hubbard (page 158), and Stuart (page 144).

9:6b

Egypt will gather them

- it is as though the land of Egypt will gather them to face punishment/exile,
- the Egyptians will gather/capture them and lead them to their final destination in exile.

Egypt will gather them: There are two ways to interpret the word gather here:

1. It refers here to gathering people together to be punished. They will be captured and sent/guided to their destination in exile. The captives will later die in exile and be buried. For example:

Egypt will capture them (NCV)

Egypt will round them up (NJB) (CEV, GW, NAB, NCV, NET, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB) The NLT has "Egypt will conquer you." Although conquering an enemy does not necessarily imply rounding them up and sending them into exile, it has been listed here, because this rendering could not refer to gathering people for burial.

1. It refers here to gathering up dead bodies. The bodies will then be buried. For example:

Egypt will gather them up (NASB)

The Egyptians will gather them up—gather them for burial... (GNT) (BSB, ESV, GNT, KJV, NASB, NIV, NRSV) The BSB, ESV, NIV, and NRSV all have "gather them." They have been listed here because of the parallel phrase "bury them," but these versions are technically ambiguous. In contrast to the KJV, NASB, and GNT, which unambiguously translate

"gather up," they could also refer to gathering the people for punishment.

The Display will follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. It fits better with the preceding context in chapter 8 and with 9:6a. However, interpretation (2) fits better with the parallel phrase "will bury them." According to Davies (page 219), "gather" refers here to gathering up bodies in order to bury them. Keil and Hubbard follow the same view. However, McComiskey (page 142) understands the verb to mean "gather for punishment," as in 8:10. Wood (page 204) also supports the second interpretation. He says that "the people will be taken captive; they will be gathered by Egypt...and buried by Memphis." According to footnote (c) in the NET, the verb has the implication "grab hold" in this context. It "pictures a personified Egypt taking the fugitives prisoner." Whichever interpretation you follow, it is suggested that you put the other interpretation in a footnote.

9:6c

and Memphis will bury them.

- and the city of Memphis will bury them.
- They will be buried in the graveyards of Memphis!

and Memphis will bury them: Memphis was an important city in the country of Egypt. It was well known for its large burial grounds and pyramid tombs. Davies (page 219), Macintosh (page 349), Andersen and Freedman (page 530), Hubbard (page 158), Stuart (page 144), and Wood (204).

Hosea describes Memphis as if it is a person who buries dead bodies. This is a figure of speech (personification). In some languages, it may not be clear or natural to say that a country or a city buries people.

Here are some other ways to express the meaning:

Memphis will be their grave (REB)

they will be buried in the city/graveyards of Memphis

the people of Memphis will bury them

9:6d-e

(combined/reordered)

- Their treasures of silver and the places where their homes once stood will be overgrown with weeds and thorn bushes. (GNT)

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{6d} Their precious silver **will be taken over by thistles**,

^{6e}and **thorns will overrun** their tents.

These lines describe what will happen to the former possessions and property of the people of Israel after the Assyrians take the people into exile. It will be abandoned and weeds will grow there. McComiskey (page 142).

9:6d

Their precious silver will be taken over by thistles,

- Nettles/Thistles will become like the new owners of the silver that they love/value so much.
- The silver articles/objects that they treasure/value will be left behind to be overgrown with briars.

Their precious silver will be taken over by thistles:

In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “nettles will take possession of their treasure of silver.” Normally it is people who take possession of things. Andersen and Freedman (page 531). Also see TWOT (#920) for information on “take possession of.” However, in this clause, it is thorny weeds that figuratively take possession of the treasures of the people.

Their precious silver: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as precious refers to something that is pleasant or desirable. TWOT (#673d). The Hebrew word for silver can refer to literal silver or money. TWOT (#1015a). Here the phrase precious silver may be a figure of speech that refers to wealth. Stuart (page 144) and McComiskey (page 141). Either way, it refers to treasures that are precious to the people.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the silver they treasure (NET)

thistles: In Hebrew, this word means “thistle” or “nettle.” TWOT (#2037). These are thorny weeds.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Nettles shall possess their precious things of silver (ESV)

Weeds will grow over their silver treasures. (GW)

9:6e

and thorns will overrun their tents.

- Thorn bushes will grow inside their tents.

- Thorns will grow in the places where their homes were once located.

and thorns will overrun their tents: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “thorn[s] [will be] in their tents.” The Hebrew word for tents can also mean “dwellings.” TWOT (#32a). It probably refers to the former homes of the people of Israel. McComiskey (page 141) and Davies (page 220). Thorns will grow where their homes were once located.

thorns: In Hebrew, this word means “brier” or “bramble.” TWOT (#620a). It is a thorny weed similar to “nettle” in the previous clause.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Thorns will grow over their tents. (GW)

and thorn-bushes will invade their homesteads (NJB)

General Comment on 9:6d–e

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the parallel parts in these two lines. See 9:6d–e (combined/reordered) in the Display for an example.

Hosea 9:7

Section 9:1–9: The LORD will punish the Israelites

This section warns the people of Israel that the LORD will punish them because they have been unfaithful to him. When that happens, the people will no longer be able to celebrate at harvest time or enjoy the crops from their land. The section describes aspects of daily life that the people in Israel would clearly understand. Some examples are harvest festivals (9:1, 5), threshing grain and making wine (9:2), unclean food (9:3–4), offerings and sacrifices (9:4), briars and thorns (9:6), and prophets (9:7–8). There is also an indirect reference to Israel’s past (9:9).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Will Punish Israel (ESV)

Hosea announces Israel’s Punishment (NLT)

Israel Will Be Punished (CEV)

The Sorrows of Exile (NJB)

Paragraph 9:7–9

In this paragraph, Hosea warns the people that God's judgment is certain because of their many sins. This judgment will involve the total destruction of their cities (See Paragraph 8:11–14). Because of this devastation, few if any people will be able to live in the land. Those who escape death will face future punishment as slaves/exiles in Assyria (See the notes on 8:10b and 8:10c).

9:7a–b (combined/reordered)

- It is almost the time when you^(plur) will be punished by Yahweh to pay for your sins.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{7a} The days of punishment **have come**;

^{7b} the days of retribution **have arrived**—

These lines are a warning. The underlined parts refer to the time when the LORD will begin to punish the people to pay for their sins. The parts in bold print indicate that this will happen very soon. See the first note on 9:6a. According to Keil (page 122), McComiskey (page 144), and Andersen and Freedman (page 532), this is probably another instance of “prophetic perfect.” Here it indicates certainty that the days of punishment will come.

The days of punishment...days of retribution: These parallel phrases both describe the same time and the same event(s). They refer to the suffering that the people of Israel will experience in exile. The first phrase indicates that this suffering is a punishment. The second phrase indicates that the LORD will require them to suffer as payment for the wrongs they have done. TWOT (#2401g). McComiskey (page 144), Hubbard (page 158), and Stuart (page 145).

days...days: In Hebrew and in many English versions, these words are identical. They refer here to an indefinite period of time. Stuart (page 145).

Here are some acceptable ways to translate these parallel terms:

- Use the same term in both lines. For example:

The days...the days (NJB)

The time...the time (GNT)

- Use different terms in each line. For example:

The time...the day (NLT)

Here are some other ways to translate the parallel lines:

^{7a}The time for them to be punished will come.

^{7b}The time for them to pay for their sins will come.
(GW)

^{7a}The time of punishment is about to arrive! ^{7b}The time of retribution is imminent! (adapted from NET)

General Comment on 9:7a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these two parallel lines. See 9:7a–b (combined/reordered) in the Display for an example.

9:7a

The days of punishment have come;

- ^{7a} The days of punishment are very near.
- ^{7a} Very soon it will be time for Yahweh to punish you^(plur).

9:7b

the days of retribution have arrived—

- The days/time when Yahweh will require payment for your^(plur) sins have/has almost arrived.
- At that time you will pay for the evil you have done.

9:7c

let Israel know it.

- The people of Israel know this.
- When that happens, you^(plur) Israelites will know/realize it.

let Israel know it: There is a textual issue here:

1. The Masoretic Text has let Israel know. For example:

Let Israel know this! (NASB) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, RSV)

1. The LXX has “Israel cries out.” For example: Israel cries (NRSV) (NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and scholars. With this option, the clause let Israel know it functions as a conclusion to the preceding lines (9:7a–b).

There are two main ways to interpret this conclusion:

1. Hosea informs the people of Israel that they will know when the time of punishment begins. For example:

The time for them to be punished will come...
When this happens, Israel will know it. (GW) (CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NJB, NLT, REB, RSV)

1. Hosea urges/admonishes the people of Israel that they need to know when the time of punishment will begin. For example:

...The time of retribution is imminent! Let Israel know! (NET) (BSB, NAB, NASB, NET, NIV, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a majority of versions and scholars. Scholars who support interpretation (1) include Davies, McComiskey, Keil, and Pusey. According to Davies (page 220), this rendering is more straightforward. Scholars who support interpretation (2) include Wood, Hubbard, and possibly Andersen and Freedman. However, interpretation (2) is also well supported. If you decide to follow interpretation (2), it is recommended that you give the other interpretation in a footnote. Here is a suggested footnote:

Another way to interpret this part of the verse is:
“Israel will know it” or “Israel knows this!”

9:7d

The prophet is called a fool,

- you^(plur) consider prophets to be fools,
- that you say, “Prophets are stupid.

9:7e

and the inspired man insane,

- and people who are filled with the spirit of Yahweh, you call madmen.
- Men who speak what Yahweh causes them to say are insane.”

9:7d–e

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{7d} The prophet **is called a fool**,

^{7e} and the inspired man **insane**.

The prophet is called a fool, and the inspired man insane: In Hebrew, these clauses are more literally “the prophet a fool the person of the spirit mad.” In

many languages, one or more verbs must be supplied to make the meaning clear. For example, the BSB supplies the verb phrase is called. In addition, some versions make the speaker explicit. For example:

You think the prophet is a fool, and you say the spiritual person is crazy (NCV)

“The prophets are crazy!” the people shout. “The inspired men are mad!” So they taunt (NLT 96)

Most commentaries think that the words in 7d–e were spoken by Hosea’s hearers. Davies (page 220), Hubbard (page 159), Wood (page 204), McComiskey (page 144), Andersen and Freedman 532, Macintosh (page 353), and Stuart (page 146). These words indicate that they did not believe Hosea’s warning that the LORD would soon begin to punish them. Dearman (pages 242–244) and Keil (page 122) suggest an alternative view, that these words were spoken by Hosea and refer to false prophets. However, few if any versions follow that view. Their response to Hosea was to discredit him (and perhaps all true prophets) by comparing him to a crazy person.

fool...insane: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as fool means “stupid.” It describes someone whose words are not worth listening to. Stuart (page 145) and Davies (page 220). The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as insane is literally “mad/crazy.” TWOT (#2328). Here the people probably used the word to mock Hosea because of what he said.

The prophet...the inspired man: In these parallel phrases, the second phrase further describes a prophet in terms of the source of the prophet’s message.

the inspired man: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “the man of the spirit.” This phrase occurs only here in the Old Testament. It indicates that the person’s words are inspired by the spirit of the LORD.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the man whose words come from the LORD

a person whom the spirit of the LORD causes to speak

9:7f

because of the greatness of your iniquity

- Because of your^(plur) many sins
- It is because you are filled with sin

9:7g and hostility.

- and your^(plur) intense hatred/hostility,
- and great anger

9:7f–g

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{7f}because of the greatness of **your iniquity**

^{7g}and **hostility**.

because of the greatness of your iniquity and hostility: In Hebrew, the words are literally “on the multitude of your iniquity and great animosity.” There are two main interpretations of the function of the Hebrew preposition “on” that the BSB translates here as because:

1. The preposition introduces reasons why the people call the prophet a fool and a madman. They call him that because they are filled with sin and hatred. Stuart (page 146), Andersen and Freedman (page 532), McComiskey (pages 144–145), Hubbard (page 159), and Wood (page 204). For example:

The prophet is a fool; the man of the spirit is mad, because of your great iniquity and great hatred. (ESV) (BSB, ESV, NASB, NET, NIV, NLT, REB, RSV)

1. The preposition introduces the reason for their great hostility. They have great hostility because they have many sins. Macintosh (page 352). For example:

Because of your great iniquity, your hostility is great. (NRSV) (GNT, NJB, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and scholars.

your...hostility: In Hebrew, this word probably means “to have animosity” or “to hold a grudge.” It refers here to the hostility that the people of Israel have against Hosea, or perhaps against both Hosea and Yahweh. Stuart (page 146), Macintosh (page 352), Andersen and Freedman (page 532), McComiskey (page 145), Davies (page 220), and Hubbard (page 159).

Hosea 9:8

Section 9:1–9: The LORD will punish the Israelites

This section warns the people of Israel that the LORD will punish them because they have been unfaithful

to him. When that happens, the people will no longer be able to celebrate at harvest time or enjoy the crops from their land. The section describes aspects of daily life that the people in Israel would clearly understand. Some examples are harvest festivals (9:1, 5), threshing grain and making wine (9:2), unclean food (9:3–4), offerings and sacrifices (9:4), briars and thorns (9:6), and prophets (9:7–8). There is also an indirect reference to Israel’s past (9:9).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Will Punish Israel (ESV)

Hosea announces Israel’s Punishment (NLT)

Israel Will Be Punished (CEV)

The Sorrows of Exile (NJB)

Paragraph 9:7–9

In this paragraph, Hosea warns the people that God’s judgment is certain because of their many sins. This judgment will involve the total destruction of their cities (See Paragraph 8:11–14). Because of this devastation, few if any people will be able to live in the land. Those who escape death will face future punishment as slaves/exiles in Assyria (See the notes on 8:10b and 8:10c).

9:8a

The prophet is Ephraim’s watchman, along with my God,

- The prophet watches over Ephraim as a representative of my God,
- My God sent me, his prophet, to warn you^(plur) Israelites,

The prophet is Ephraim’s watchman, along with my God: There is a textual issue with the division of clause parts that affects the identity of the watchman:

1. The watchman is the prophet. The Hebrew clause is literally “a watchman Ephraim with my God a prophet.” For example:

The prophet is a watchman over Israel for my God (NLT) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The watchman is Ephraim. The Hebrew clause is literally “a watchman Ephraim with my God.” The next clause begins with “A prophet....” For example:

Ephraim watches for my God. As for the prophet...
(NJPS) (NASB, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and scholars. Additional support for this interpretation: 1) Jeremiah (6:17) and Ezekiel (3:17) also use the metaphor of prophets as God's watchman in a way that is comparable to its use here in Hosea 9:8. See Hubbard (page 159). 2) The metaphor of wicked people as trappers is compatible with the metaphor Hosea uses earlier in 5:1-2. 3) The repetition of the rare word "animosity" in both 9:7 and 9:8 suggests a pattern. Andersen and Freedman (page 534) says: "Since animosity is parallel to iniquity in 7b, and parallel to the trap in 8b, the word is probably intended to describe hostility against the prophet."

prophet: Here the prophet is probably Hosea. The phrase "my God" in this clause suggests that Hosea is referring to himself here. The GW translates "prophet" as "prophets." "Prophets are God's watchmen over Ephraim." However, in Hebrew the word "prophet" is singular. In some languages, it may be confusing for Hosea to refer to himself as the prophet.

If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

God has sent me as a prophet to warn his people Israel. (GNT)

My LORD sent me, his prophet, to watch over you.

along with my God: There is a textual issue with the Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as along with my God:

1. The original phrase was with my God. It indicates that the prophet was associated with God, and that God and the prophet watched over Ephraim. McComiskey (page 145). For example:

The prophet is a watchman over Ephraim on behalf of God (NET)

Israel, the Lord sent me to look after you. (CEV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NAB, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. Some scholars suggest that the original phrase was "the people of my God." For example:

The prophet is the watchman of Ephraim, the people of my God (RSV) (RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and scholars.

my God: Hosea says my God rather than "your God" or "our God." Hosea may intend to imply that his God is no longer their God. Andersen and Freedman (page 534).

watchman: In the time of the Old Testament, a watchman was a person who was stationed on the large wall that surrounded a town. His job was to keep watch and inform people of any danger that he saw. TWOT (#1950). In this context, this term is used as a metaphor to describe God's prophet. Stuart (page 146).

9:8b-c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{8b} yet the snare of the fowler lies **on all his paths.**

^{8c} Hostility **is in the house of his God!**

These lines indicate that the people of Israel responded to Hosea's warnings with hostility.

yet the snare of the fowler lies on all his paths. Hostility is in the house of his God!: These verse parts are literally "a trap of a fowler on all his ways animosity in the house of his God." There are two main ways to interpret the identity of the trapper:

1. The trapper is the people of Israel. For example:

yet traps are laid in front of him wherever he goes. He faces hostility even in the house of God. (NLT) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NET, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. The trapper is the prophet. For example:

but the prophet is a snare of a fowler in all his ways, and hatred in the house of his God (KJV) (KJV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and scholars.

9:8b

yet the snare of the fowler lies on all his paths.

- yet traps are set to catch him everywhere he goes.
- but wherever I go, you^(plur) try to trap me like a bird.

yet the snare of the fowler lies on all his paths: This line is a metaphor that compares the people of Israel to people who trap birds. A bird trapper catches birds. Similarly, the people want to trap Hosea to cause him harm. McComiskey (page 145). Hosea uses a similar metaphor in 5:1.

In some versions, such as the BSB above, the identity of the bird trapper is left implied. Some versions make explicit that Israel is the trapper. For example:

Israel, the Lord sent me to look after you. But you trap his prophets. (CEV)

his paths: This phrase refers to Hosea's regular activities as a prophet. Ibid.

9:8c

Hostility is in the house of his God!

- Even in the temple/house of God he faces hostility.
- You^(plur) show me hatred in the very temple/house of God.

Hostility is in the house of his God!: This clause repeats the word Hostility from 9:7g. The repetition here may reinforce how intense their hatred was of Hosea and his warnings. They expressed their hatred even in the temple, the house of God. The NET has "animosity rages against him in the land of his God." Other versions all refer specifically to the temple, not to the land of Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

He faces hostility even in the house of God. (NLT)

Even in God's Temple the people are the prophet's enemies. (GNT)

There is enmity in the very temple of God. (REB)

Hosea 9:9

Section 9:1-9: The LORD will punish the Israelites

This section warns the people of Israel that the LORD will punish them because they have been unfaithful to him. When that happens, the people will no longer be able to celebrate at harvest time or enjoy the crops from their land. The section describes aspects of daily life that the people in Israel would clearly understand. Some examples are harvest festivals (9:1, 5), threshing grain and making wine (9:2), unclean food (9:3-4), offerings and sacrifices (9:4), briars and thorns (9:6), and

prophets (9:7-8). There is also an indirect reference to Israel's past (9:9).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Will Punish Israel (ESV)

Hosea announces Israel's Punishment (NLT)

Israel Will Be Punished (CEV)

The Sorrows of Exile (NJB)

Paragraph 9:7-9

In this paragraph, Hosea warns the people that God's judgment is certain because of their many sins. This judgment will involve the total destruction of their cities (See Paragraph 8:11-14). Because of this devastation, few if any people will be able to live in the land. Those who escape death will face future punishment as slaves/exiles in Assyria (See the notes on 8:10b and 8:10c).

9:9a

They have deeply corrupted themselves as in the days of Gibeah;

- The people have become extremely corrupt. They are as bad as the people of Gibeah in the past.
- You^(plur) are completely corrupt/evil, just like the men of Gibeah were!

They have deeply corrupted themselves: In Hebrew, these words are literally "they have made deep they have dealt corruptly." Together these words emphasize the extreme depravity of the people. Stuart (page 146).

as in the days of Gibeah: These words further clarify the extreme degree of corruption. They compare the people of Hosea's day to the men of Gibeah who had committed terrible sexual perversion and murder. See Judges 19-20.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

The things my people do are as depraved as what they did in Gibeah long ago. (NLT)

You are brutal and corrupt, as were the men of Gibeah. (CEV)

9:9b-c

He will remember their guilt; He will punish their sins.

- So God will now respond to their evil behavior/actions. Yes, he will punish them for their sins.”
- God will now do something about the wrong things that you^(plur) have done. He will punish you for all your sins.”

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{9b} He will remember **their guilt**;

^{9c} He will punish **their sins**.

He will remember their guilt; He will punish their sins: These lines are very similar to Hosea 8:13c–d. The words He will remember their guilt mean that he will respond to their disobedience in an appropriate way. The words punish their sins includes here the punishment of their exile to Assyria. Stuart (page 146).

These lines are the conclusion to section 9:1–9.

Hosea 9:10

Section 9:10–17: The sins of the Israelites and the response of the LORD

This section describes the joyful beginning of the LORD’s relationship with the people of Israel and the shocking way that they responded by betraying him. Because of their sin and betrayal, it is necessary for the LORD to judge them.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel’s Sin and Its Consequences (GNT)

Sin’s Terrible Results (CEV)

Paragraph 9:10–13 and 9:14

In the BSB and some other versions, 9:10–14 are one paragraph. TN will divide 9:10–14 into two paragraphs. In the first paragraph, the LORD is the speaker. He contrasts his love toward Israel with Israel’s betrayal of him in return. In the second paragraph, Hosea offers a prayer to the LORD in response to the LORD’s words.

9:10a

I found Israel like grapes in the wilderness.

- ¶ “When I first chose Israel, it was as if I had just found refreshing grapes growing in the desert.
- ¶ Yahweh said, “When I chose your^(plur) ancestors to be my people, I was delighted with them. I was like a weary traveler who finds delicious grapes in the desert

9:10b

I saw your fathers as the firstfruits of the fig tree in its first season.

- When I first watched/observed your^(plur) ancestors, it was like finding the first tender figs of the season.
- or fruit that has just/recently become ripe on a fig tree.

9:10a–b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{10a} I found Israel **like grapes in the wilderness**.

^{10b} I saw your fathers **as the firstfruits of the fig tree in its first season**.

The underlined parts refer to the time when Israel was a young nation. The parts in bold print are similes that compare the LORD’s delight with them to the delight of a person who finds delicious fruit that he was not expecting to find.

I found Israel...I saw your fathers: These parallel phrases refer to the time in the desert of Sinai when the LORD chose Israel to be his people. The second phrase clarifies that he chose their fathers, meaning their “ancestors.” Keil (page 124). Make sure that your translation does not imply that the people were lost or that the LORD did not know where they were and was looking for them.

Here are some other ways to translate these parallel phrases:

I came upon Israel...I looked on their forefathers with joy (REB)

When I first found Israel...When I first saw your ancestors (GNT)

like grapes in the wilderness...as the firstfruits of the fig tree in its first season: Both these similes describe uncommon situations that give pleasure to a traveler or to any person who discovers them. Grapes do not usually grow in a desert, and the figs that appear early in the season or in the tree’s first year (see interpretation below) are more delicious and less common than figs that ripen later. Wood (page 206) and McComiskey (page 148).

Here are some other ways to translate these parallel similes:

it was like finding fresh grapes in the desert...it was like seeing the first ripe figs of the season (NLT)

It was like finding grapes in the desert...like seeing early fruit on a fig tree (NJB)

There are two main interpretations of the phrase that the BSB translates as firstfruits of the fig tree in its first season:

1. This phrase means the first figs of the season that appear on the tree in late spring or early summer. Davies (page 223) and Macintosh (page 360). That fruit ripens on sprouts of the previous year. These figs are especially delicious. The more common figs appear in late summer on new sprouts. Stuart (page 151). For example:

it was like seeing the first ripe figs of the season (GNT) (GNT, GW, NIV, NLT, NJB)

1. This phrase means the very first year/season that the fig tree bears fruit. McComiskey (page 148), Andersen and Freedman (page 540), Hubbard (page 164), and Keil (page 124). These words imply that the tree is five or six years old. Hubbard (page 164). For example:

Like the first fruit on the fig tree, in its first season (NRSV) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NASB, NET, NRSV)

Some versions are ambiguous and have not been listed above. TNN follows interpretation (1). However, either interpretation is acceptable and makes good sense in this context.

9:10c

But they went to Baal-peor, and consecrated themselves to Shame;

- But then they came to Baal Peor, and they consecrated/devoted themselves to that false god named "Shame."
- But when they journeyed to Mount Peor, they began to worship the false god Baal. They devoted themselves to that shameful thing/idol,

But they went to Baal-peor, and consecrated themselves to Shame: The relationship between the LORD and Israel changed when the people came to Baal-peor, located at "Mount Peor" (GNT). There the people turned away from the LORD to worship Baal. (See Numbers 25:1-11.)

This verse part contrasts strongly with 9:10a-b. The Masoretic Text has the pronoun "they" here. Literally it is "they they-came Baal Peor." Macintosh (page 362) identifies the function of the pronoun as a strong adversative. In 9:10a-b, the LORD was delighted with the people of Israel. Here in 9:10c-d, he was disgusted with them. Stuart (page 151). Many English versions indicate the contrast with the word But. Use a natural way in your language to indicate a contrast.

and consecrated themselves to Shame: The LORD used the negative term Shame as the name of the idol Baal. Stuart (page 151), Dearman (pages 251-252), Davies (page 226), Macintosh (page 360), Hubbard (page 164), Andersen and Freedman (page 541), McComiskey (page 148), Wood (page 206), and Keil (page 124). See also Jeremiah 11:13.

Here are some other ways to translate the name of the idol:

thing of shame (ESV)

shameful idol (NIV)

It is recommended that you add a footnote to explain that the LORD substituted the word Shame for the name "Baal." For example:

Here the LORD used the word "Shame" as the name of the idol Baal.

9:10d

so they became as detestable as the thing they loved.

- They became as detestable/loathsome as the thing they loved.
- and they became as disgusting as the idol they loved.

so they became as detestable as the thing they loved: This clause means that the people of Israel became as detestable as the Baal idol that they loved. Macintosh (page 361), McComiskey (page 148), Davies (page 227), and Dearman (pages 251-252).

In some contexts, the term "Baal" can refer to more than one idol (see the note on 2:13a). That may be true here as well. English versions translate this term in two ways. Either way is acceptable:

- As singular. For example:

and became detestable like the thing they loved (NRSV)

- As plural. For example:

and soon became as disgusting as the gods they loved (GNT)

Hosea 9:11

Section 9:10–17: The sins of the Israelites and the response of the LORD

This section describes the joyful beginning of the LORD's relationship with the people of Israel and the shocking way that they responded by betraying him. Because of their sin and betrayal, it is necessary for the LORD to judge them.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel's Sin and Its Consequences (GNT)

Sin's Terrible Results (CEV)

Paragraph 9:10–13 and 9:14

In the BSB and some other versions, 9:10–14 are one paragraph. TN will divide 9:10–14 into two paragraphs. In the first paragraph, the LORD is the speaker. He contrasts his love toward Israel with Israel's betrayal of him in return. In the second paragraph, Hosea offers a prayer to the LORD in response to the LORD's words.

9:11a

Ephraim's glory will fly away like a bird,

- Just like a bird, the glory of Israel will fly away.
- Israel, the best thing about you^(sing/plur) is about to vanish like a bird that flies away.

Ephraim's glory will fly away like a bird: This clause is a simile that compares the glory of Ephraim to a bird that flies away. It indicates that Israel will lose its glory. The context of 9:11b through 9:14 suggests that Ephraim's glory probably refers here to the population of Israel. McComiskey (page 149), Wood (page 206) and Keil (page 125). The LORD will punish the people by withdrawing his blessing of fertility. Their population will decrease because they can no longer have children.

glory: In this context, the word glory probably means "abundant" in reference to the number of people. NIDOTTE (#3883). NIDOTTE (page 578) says "When a group of people is called heavy, it has the nuance numerous or abundant."

9:11b

with no birth, no pregnancy, and no conception.

- No one will give birth. No one will become pregnant. No one will conceive.
- No more children will be born. None of your^(sing/plur) women will be pregnant. Not one will be able to conceive a child.

with no birth, no pregnancy, and no conception:

These phrases are more literally "no child bearing and no womb and no conception." They further explain what will happen when "Ephraim's glory" flies away. Hubbard (page 165). The women of Israel will be barren.

Note the order of the phrases no birth, no pregnancy, no conception. This is a reversal of the natural order, which is conception, pregnancy and then birth. This reverse order may indicate increasing severity of the punishment. Davies (page 228). None of the steps necessary for Israel to survive as a nation will occur: not birth, not pregnancy, not even conception. Hubbard (page 165).

Some versions change the order of these phrases. It is recommended that you keep the order as it is here unless there is good reason in your language to change it. Andersen and Freedman (page 543) adds that rearranging the order here ignores the subtlety and originality of the prophet.

In some languages, it may be helpful to use phrases instead of single words to make the meaning clearer. For example:

there will be no more children born to them,
no more women pregnant, no more children conceived (GNT)

Hosea 9:12

Section 9:10–17: The sins of the Israelites and the response of the LORD

This section describes the joyful beginning of the LORD's relationship with the people of Israel and the shocking way that they responded by betraying him. Because of their sin and betrayal, it is necessary for the LORD to judge them.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel's Sin and Its Consequences (GNT)

Sin's Terrible Results (CEV)

Paragraph 9:10–13 and 9:14

In the BSB and some other versions, 9:10–14 are one paragraph. TN will divide 9:10–14 into two paragraphs. In the first paragraph, the LORD is the speaker. He contrasts his love toward Israel with Israel's betrayal of him in return. In the second paragraph, Hosea offers a prayer to the LORD in response to the LORD's words.

9:12a

Even if they raise their children, I will bereave them of each one.

- Even if they were able to raise children, I would take them all away.
- And even if somehow you^(plur) were able to have children, I would cause them all to die.

Even if they raise their children, I will bereave them of each one: This clause continues the description of Israel's punishment from 9:11b. This is a conditional clause. When the condition, they raise their children, is true, the result is that the LORD will bereave them of every one.

This clause is probably a figure of speech that adds emphasis to the previous statement in 9:11b. McComiskey (page 149). Andersen and Freedman (page 542) indicate that this continues a figure of speech, pseudo-sorites, that begins in 11b. The complete figure of speech is "11:b [There will be] no birth, no pregnancy, no conception. 12a [But] Even if they bring up children, I will take them all away." It indicates how complete and serious the punishment from the LORD will be. Verse 9:11b says that no more children will be born. This verse part, 9:12a, describes an imagined situation in which someone was still able to give birth to and raise children. Another possibility is that this clause speaks of children already born, a different group from that in 11b. However, the particles translated as "even if" more strongly suggest that this clause is a continuation of the same description that begins in 11b. Even if that could happen, the LORD would take them away.

I will bereave them of each one: In Hebrew, this clause is literally "and I will bereave them from every-one/man." The words I will bereave them mean to make them childless or to make them miscarry. TWOT (#2385). However, there are different interpretations of the meaning of the entire clause, "I will bereave them from everyone/man":

1. This clause means that every child will die. McComiskey (page 149), Hubbard (page 165), and Keil (page 125). For example:

I will bereave them until no one is left. (NRSV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NRSV, REB)

1. This clause means that there will be no future generations. Macintosh (page 369). The population will dwindle until Israel ceases to be a nation. For example:

I will make them childless, without posterity. (REB) (REB)

1. This clause means that the children will never grow up to become adults. Andersen and Freedman (page 543) and Wood (page 206). It refers to children that will die while still young. For example:

I shall take them away before they grow up! (NJB) (GW, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries.

9:12b

Yes, woe be to them when I turn away from them!

- They will indeed have great sorrow when I turn away from them.
- How terrible it will be for you^(plur) Israelites when I forsake/abandon you!

Yes, woe be to them when I turn away from them!:

In this clause, the LORD announces that the people will soon experience terrible sorrow. He will abandon them. This will fulfill the warning he gave them through Hosea in chapter 5:6, 15. Davies (page 228). He will no longer be their God. Macintosh (page 369). He will no longer protect and guide them. McComiskey (page 150).

woe be to them: See the note on this expression for 7:13a. Here the Hebrew clause begins with two particles that give strong emphasis to the clause. Davies (page 228), Macintosh (page 367), McComiskey (page 150), and Keil (page 125). The BSB shows emphasis here by using an exclamation mark. The NRSV does this also and adds an emphasis word: "Woe to them indeed...!" Show this emphasis in a natural way in your language.

Some languages may not have a word similar to woe.

Here are some other ways to translate this warning:

Yes, how horrible it will be for them when I leave them. (GW)

It will be a terrible day when I turn away and leave you alone. (NLT)

Hosea 9:13

Section 9:10–17: The sins of the Israelites and the response of the LORD

This section describes the joyful beginning of the LORD's relationship with the people of Israel and the shocking way that they responded by betraying him. Because of their sin and betrayal, it is necessary for the LORD to judge them.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel's Sin and Its Consequences (GNT)

Sin's Terrible Results (CEV)

Paragraph 9:10–13 and 9:14

In the BSB and some other versions, 9:10–14 are one paragraph. TN will divide 9:10–14 into two paragraphs. In the first paragraph, the LORD is the speaker. He contrasts his love toward Israel with Israel's betrayal of him in return. In the second paragraph, Hosea offers a prayer to the LORD in response to the LORD's words.

9:13

Notice the contrast between the parallel parts in bold print:

^{13a}I have seen Ephraim, like Tyre, **planted in a meadow.**

^{13b}But Ephraim **will bring out his children for slaughter.**

There is a strong contrast between Ephraim's desirable situation in the past and what will happen to their people in the future.

9:13a

I have seen Ephraim, like Tyre, planted in a meadow.

- I once saw Ephraim, like the city of Tyre, planted in fertile soil that was ideal for his growth.
- You^(plur) Israelites are like the people of Tyre. You were plants growing in beautiful pastureland.

I have seen Ephraim, like Tyre, planted in a meadow: There is a textual issue here:

1. The Masoretic Text has "Ephraim just as I have seen Tyre [is] planted in pastureland." According to Davies (page 228), the MT in the first clause is "unintelligible." Dearman (pages 253–254) says that

"there is no consensus...for sorting out either misunderstood terms or errors in the text's transmission. Andersen and Freedman (page 543) and Stuart (page 152) have similar comments. For example:

Ephraim, as I have seen, is planted in a pleasant meadow like Tyre! (NASB) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. The LXX has "Ephraim, as I saw, presented their children for prey." For example: Ephraim's sons, as I have seen, are destined for a prey (RSV) (GNT, NET, REB, RSV) The NET and the REB apparently follow a different Hebrew source text that has the Hebrew phrase "as lion cubs" instead of the phrase "I have seen Ephraim...children."

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and commentaries.

As in 9:10, the LORD uses terms from agriculture to describe Israel's good situation in its early days. The phrase planted in a meadow suggests fertility and growth. This description contrasts with what Ephraim will become later, a nation whose children will be killed. Hubbard (page 166) and Dearman (pages 253–254).

I have seen: This phrase is similar to the phrase "I saw your fathers" in 9:10.

Here is another way to translate it:

I have watched (NLT)

Ephraim, like Tyre, planted in a meadow: This verse part is a simile. The meaning of the simile is affected by the meaning of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Tyre. There are two main interpretations:

1. The Hebrew word means the city of Tyre. The simile compares Ephraim to the prosperous Phoenician city of Tyre, located on the coast of the Mediterranean Sea. McComiskey (page 152), Wood (page 206), and Keil (page 126). For example:

I have seen Israel, like Tyre, given a pleasant place. (NCV) (BSB, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT)

1. The Hebrew word means "palm tree." The simile compares Ephraim to a palm tree. This meaning is based on an Arabic word with the same consonants. Macintosh (page 372). For example:

Once I saw Ephraim as a young palm planted in a lovely meadow. (NRSV) (CEV, ESV, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This Hebrew word does not mean “palm tree” anywhere else in the Old Testament.

Ephraim: In this verse, as elsewhere in Hosea, the name Ephraim refers to the nation of Israel. Some versions make Israel explicit here. For example:

If have seen Israel, like Tyre, given a pleasant place. (NCV)

planted in a meadow: This phrase is literally “planted in pastureland.” The word for “pastureland” describes a green meadow that has plenty of water. It is an ideal place for plants to grow. Macintosh (pages 371–372). Here the phrase is used figuratively. It is a metaphor that compares the people of Tyre and Israel to a crop or a garden that is planted in good pastureland. The land provided the people who lived there with opportunities to grow strong and prosperous. Wood (page 206), Keil (page 126), and Macintosh (page 372).

9:13b

But Ephraim will bring out his children for slaughter.

- But now Ephraim will/must take/bring out his children to be killed.”
- Yet you^(plur) will experience disaster. You will be forced to take your own children to a place where someone will kill them.”

But Ephraim will bring out his children for slaughter: In Hebrew, this verse part is more literally “and Ephraim to bring out to one who kills his sons/children.” BART interlinear.

This clause indicates that the children of the people of Israel will be murdered. There are various opinions as to the historical event(s) to which this clause refers. It could refer specifically to the time when the Assyrian army will attack Israel and kill children or it could refer to others who will kill them. McComiskey (page 152) suggests that this statement is metonymy for the Assyrians. Wood (page 206) suggests that this statement connotes frequent murders, civil strife, and also warfare. If possible, translate this statement in a general way that does not indicate who will kill the children.

But: This statement describes a horrible situation that contrasts strongly with the good situation described in 9:13a. Many English versions introduce the contrast

with a word such as But. Indicate this contrast in a natural way in your language.

will bring out: In Hebrew, the form of this verb may indicate that the people were forced to bring their children somewhere to be killed. According to Macintosh (page 371), the infinitive construct with lamed expresses obligation, compulsion. He refers to Gesenius’ Hebrew Grammar, 114 The Infinitive Construct, Remark 2. Lange (page 76) says that this construction = “must lead forth.” Versions that explicitly indicate compulsion include ESV, NJPS, NRSV, and REB. Versions that do not specify compulsion but simply indicate what the people will do include CBSB, EV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT. McComiskey (page 150) uses the wording “will lead out,” but does not comment further. Some versions indicate this explicitly. For example:

must lead out (NRSV)

must bring out (NJPS)

Other versions indicate that the people will bring out their children to be killed. They do not indicate that they are forced to do so. For example:

will bring out (NASB)

will soon bring out (NCV)

You may translate either way.

The Hebrew word for “children” here is masculine plural. This form can refer either to male children or to children in general, including male and female children. In this context of judgment on the entire nation, the word probably refers to all children. Most versions have “children” here.

for slaughter: The form of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as for slaughter can be translated in several acceptable ways: The Hebrew word form is Qal Participle.

- Translate with a verb that means “to be killed.” For example:

But the people of Ephraim will bring out their children to be killed (GW)

But now Israel will bring out her children to be slaughtered. (NLT96)

- Translate with a noun that means “one who kills.” For example:

so Ephraim will present his children to the slaughterer (NJB)

but Ephraim shall bring forth his children to the murderer (KJV)

- Translate with a noun that means “the act of killing.” For example:

But now Israel will bring out her children for slaughter. (NLT)

Hosea 9:14

Section 9:10–17: The sins of the Israelites and the response of the LORD

This section describes the joyful beginning of the LORD’s relationship with the people of Israel and the shocking way that they responded by betraying him. Because of their sin and betrayal, it is necessary for the LORD to judge them.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel’s Sin and Its Consequences (GNT)

Sin’s Terrible Results (CEV)

Paragraph 9:14

This paragraph gives Hosea’s prayer.

9:14

Give them, O LORD—what will You give? Give them wombs that miscarry and breasts that dry up!: This verse is a prayer of Hosea. There are two main ways to interpret the intent of the prayer:

1. This is a prayer directed against the people. The technical name for such a prayer is “imprecatory.” To imprecate means to invoke evil or to curse something. See Merriam-Webster “Imprecate.” Hosea asks the LORD to fulfill the punishment of 9:13b in this way. Stuart (page 153), Andersen and Freedman (page 544), Keil (page 126), and Wood (page 207). For example:

Lord, give them what they deserve. Make the women miscarry, or else make them unable to nurse their babies. (GW) (GNT, GW, NCV, REB)

1. This is a prayer on behalf of the people. Hosea asks the LORD to make the punishment of 9:13b less severe in this way. If fewer children are born, then fewer children will be slaughtered later. For example:

O Lord, what should I request for your people? I will ask for wombs that don’t give birth and breasts that give no milk. (NLT) (CEV, NLT) Both these versions use the phrase, “for your people.” This implies that the prayer is for something positive rather than negative. However, neither version makes explicit what is positive about the request.

In many versions, the intent of this prayer is left implied. In those versions, either of the interpretations above could apply. In some languages, it may be preferable to make the intent of the prayer explicit. If that is true in your language, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). There are at least two reasons:

1. This verse matches the pattern used elsewhere in the OT of a rhetorical question followed by a curse. Davies (page 229).
2. Hosea 9:16 has similar expressions, and that verse is clearly directed against the people. Andersen and Freedman (page 544) states that Hosea “is urging YHWH to proceed with the extreme penalties, endorsing what YHWH says in verses 12 and 16 about murdering the children.”

9:14a

Give them, O LORD—what will You give?

- ¶ “O Yahweh, give them what is fitting. What will you^(sing) give them?
- ¶ Then Hosea said, “O Yahweh, what will you do to these people?

Give them, O LORD—what will You give?: Here the sentence that begins with the request, Give them is interrupted by a rhetorical question. The object of the phrase, Give them is not stated until the phrase is repeated in 9:14b. This interrupted sentence structure is a poetic literary device. The purpose of the device may be to create suspense. Hubbard (page 166).

In some languages, this poetic structure may be confusing and unnatural.

If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

- Supply an object of Give them that describes the curse in 14b in a general way. For example:

Lord, give them what they should have. What will you give them? (NCV)

- Do not include the first phrase, Give them. Instead, start the sentence with the rhetorical question. For example:

What shall I ask you to do to these people? (GNT)

what will You give?: This is a rhetorical question. This is not a request for information. Its function is probably to state, “I know what you should give.” Andersen and Freedman (page 544). Some versions express this as a statement instead of a question. For example:

Our Lord, do just one thing for your people— (CEV)

9:14b–c

Give them wombs that miscarry and breasts that dry up!

- Give them stillborn babies and breasts without milk!”
- Prevent them from giving birth to children who are alive, and take away their ability to nurse/breast-feed their babies!”

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{14b}Give them wombs **that miscarry**

^{14c}and breasts **that dry up!**

Together these lines are a curse. Stuart (page 153) and Davies (page 229). They are the opposite of a traditional blessing for many healthy, nursing children (see Genesis 49:25). Macintosh (page 374) and Dearman (pages 254–255).

Give them: The pronoun them is masculine here. It indicates that the curse is against the men and women of the nation, not the women only. Andersen and Freedman (page 544).

There is an ellipsis of the words Give them in 9:14c. In some languages, this phrase may need to be supplied from 9:14b. For example:

Give them wombs that miscarry and give them breasts that are dry.

wombs that miscarry: There are two ways to interpret the form of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as miscarry:

1. The phrase means wombs that miscarry. It refers to women whose babies die in the womb. The babies are born dead. For example:

Make the women miscarry (GW) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NRSV, REB)

1. The phrase means “womb that is barren.” It refers to a woman who is unable to have children. For example:

Make their women barren! (GNT) (CEV, GNT, NAB, NCV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and all lexicons. TWOT, NIDOTTE, HALOT, and BDB all identify the Hiphil participle used here as indicating miscarriage. They all mention Hosea 9:14 specifically. McComiskey, Andersen and Freedman, and Macintosh favor miscarriage. Dearman, Stuart, Pusey, and Keil favor barrenness.

breasts that dry up!: This phrase indicates that women have no breast milk to nurse a child.

In some languages, it may be more natural to speak of wombs and breasts in other ways. For example, it may be more natural to refer specifically to women or to refer only to the functions of giving birth and nursing. Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Make the wombs of their women miscarry and make their breasts dry.

make their children die before they are born and make them unable to nurse their babies.

Hosea 9:15

Section 9:10–17: The sins of the Israelites and the response of the LORD

This section describes the joyful beginning of the LORD’s relationship with the people of Israel and the shocking way that they responded by betraying him. Because of their sin and betrayal, it is necessary for the LORD to judge them.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel’s Sin and Its Consequences (GNT)

Sin’s Terrible Results (CEV)

Paragraph 9:15–16 and 9:17

In the BSB and some other versions, 9:15–17 are one paragraph. TN will divide these verses into two paragraphs. In the first paragraph, the LORD is the speaker. He describes his punishment against Israel. In the second paragraph, Hosea is the speaker. He prophesies about Israel's future situation.

9:15a–b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{15a} All their evil appears at Gilgal, **for there I hated them.**

^{15b} **I will drive them from My house** for the wickedness of their deeds.

9:15a

All their evil appears at Gilgal, for there I hated them.

- ¶ Yahweh says, “All the evil that they did at Gilgal caused me to hate them there.
- ¶ “They turned away from me at Gilgal, and there I rejected them.

All their evil appears at Gilgal, for there I hated them: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “all their wickedness at Gilgal for/indeed. In Hebrew, there is a conjunction here that commonly indicates causation “for/because” or emphasis “indeed.” In both interpretations, the conjunction is assumed to give emphasis. However, most versions leave it implicit. there I hated them on the wickedness of their deeds.” There are two main ways to interpret this clause:

1. Because of all the wickedness of the people at Gilgal, God hated the people there. For example:

All their wickedness at Gilgal aroused my hatred.
(REB)

Because of all their evil in Gilgal, I hate them there. (NET) (NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, REB)

1. All the wickedness of the people was at Gilgal. That is where their wickedness began and/or that is where the LORD began to hate them. The Lord's hatred of evildoers was not limited to one place and time. For that reason, this interpretation understands Gilgal to be the starting place of the people's evil and of the Lord's hatred of the evildoers. Versions indicate this by supplying the word “began.” This word is not in the Hebrew. See McComiskey

(page 155), Macintosh (page 375), and Keil (page 127). For example:

Every evil of theirs is in Gilgal; there I began to hate them. (ESV)

All their evildoing began in Gilgal. It was there that I began to hate them. (GNT) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NASB, NLT, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The city of Gilgal was well known as a place where people worshiped idols, but it was not the only center for idol worship.

Gilgal: The city of Gilgal was a major center of idol worship among the Israelites. Wood (page 207), Kidner (page 90), McComiskey (page 154), and Stuart (page 153). See the note for 4:15b.

I hated them: This phrase means that the LORD opposed, detested, and rejected them. Hate separates people and keeps them distant. TWOT (#2272). Here the hatred is intense. The word indicates that the LORD broke off his relationship with the people of Israel. Dearman (pages 255–257), Kidner (page 90), Andersen and Freedman (page 545), and McComiskey (page 154).

9:15b

I will drive them from My house for the wickedness of their deeds.

- Because of the sinful things that they have done, I will expel them from my household/family.
- On account of their sinful/wicked behavior, I will disown them.

I will drive them from My house for the wickedness of their deeds: This line probably refers to the people of the entire nation of Israel. The people of Israel are very wicked like those in Gilgal. As a consequence, the LORD will drive them out of his house.

I will drive them from My house: This clause probably means that the LORD will expel the people from his family. They will no longer enjoy the LORD's blessings that he provided as part of his covenant relationship with them. McComiskey (page 155), Keil (page 127), Kidner (page 90), and Wood (page 207). This clause is similar to the statement “you are not my people, and I am not your God” in Hosea 1:9.

One aspect of this broken relationship will be physical separation. The LORD will expel the people from the land of Israel (The GNT has: “out of my land.”). However, this translation unnecessarily limits the in-

tended meaning. The land is only one privilege of the covenant that they will lose.

Most versions use the literal word house to translate this clause. But in Hosea, the LORD's house usually refers to the temple. It is recommended that you use a different word or phrase here to avoid this wrong meaning. For example:

I will expel them from my household/family.

I will disown them.

wickedness of their deeds: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

evil (GNT)

evil actions (NLT)

wickedness of their deeds (NRSV)

9:15c

I will no longer love them; all their leaders are rebellious.

- I will not love them any more. All their rulers have rebelled/revolted against me.
- I will no longer show love to Israel. Their leaders stubbornly/repeatedly refuse to be loyal to me.

I will no longer love them: The LORD's love for the people of Israel is another privilege of the covenant they will lose. This statement expresses the same idea as "I hated them" in 9:15a. Wood (page 207). See the note there for more information on the meaning and implications of this statement. This statement is very similar to "I will no longer have compassion on the house of Israel" in 1:6. Hosea 1:6 uses a different Hebrew word for love than in Hosea 9:15. However, there is no clear meaning difference between the clauses in each verse.

all their leaders are rebellious: The leaders of Israel repeatedly refused to follow the demands of the LORD. Their stubborn attitude was probably a major cause of the nation's rebellion against the LORD. But the focus here is on the leaders themselves. McComiskey (page 156) says that the princes' "unbending attitude was reflected in the nation as well. Andersen and Freedman (page 545) say that the princes represented the people as a whole.

The word leaders refers to those who rule the kingdom of Israel. It includes the king, his officials, and military leaders. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

all their princes are rebels (NJB)

all their rulers are in revolt (REB)

all their officials are disloyal (NJPS)

Hosea 9:16

Section 9:10–17: The sins of the Israelites and the response of the LORD

This section describes the joyful beginning of the LORD's relationship with the people of Israel and the shocking way that they responded by betraying him. Because of their sin and betrayal, it is necessary for the LORD to judge them.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel's Sin and Its Consequences (GNT)

Sin's Terrible Results (CEV)

Paragraph 9:15–16 and 9:17

In the BSB and some other versions, 9:15–17 are one paragraph. TN will divide these verses into two paragraphs. In the first paragraph, the LORD is the speaker. He describes his punishment against Israel. In the second paragraph, Hosea is the speaker. He prophesies about Israel's future situation.

9:16a

Ephraim is struck down;

- Ephraim is like a dying plant
- The people of Israel are like diseased/injured plants.

9:16b

their root is withered;

- that has withered all the way down to its root.
- Even their roots have dried up.

9:16c

they cannot bear fruit.

- It does not produce any fruit.
- They cannot bear fruit.

9:16a–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{16a} Ephraim **is stuck down;**

^{16b} their root **is withered**;

^{16c} they **cannot bear fruit**.

These lines describe the northern kingdom of Israel in its final years as a nation. The description is a metaphor that compares Israel to an injured or diseased plant that cannot reproduce. Wood (page 206), Dearman (page 257), Stuart (page 154), McComiskey (page 156), and Macintosh (page 378).

Ephraim is struck down: In the context of this plant metaphor, struck down probably means that a disease or a pest, such as a wood rot or a worm, has injured it. Macintosh (page 278) and McComiskey (page 156). The verb tense indicates certainty that this action will soon happen. The verbs “struck” and “withered” are prophetic perfects. Keil (page 127) says that “the perfects are a prophetic expression, indicating the certain execution of the threat.”

their root is withered: The root of the plant is dried up. The injury to the plant is so severe that the root has died or begun to die.

they cannot bear fruit: In this blighted and withered condition, the plant is unable to bear fruit. TOTC (page 168), Wood (page 207), and Davies (page 231). This line of the metaphor indicates that the people of Israel will not be able to have children.

General Comment on 9:16a–c

In this metaphor, the Hebrew text uses a combination of singular and plural forms to refer to the plant and its root. The referent of the singular forms is to the nation of Israel as a whole. The referent of the plural forms is to the individual people of Israel. This use of both singular and plural forms to refer to a plant may be unnatural in some languages.

If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Israel is beaten down; its root is dying and it has no fruit (NCV)

The people of Ephraim are like sick plants. Their roots are dried up. They have no fruit. (GW)

9:16d

Even if they bear children, I will slay the darlings of their wombs.

- Even if they could have children, I would kill those children whom they love so much.”

- But if they do somehow give birth, I will take their precious/dear children from their mothers and fathers.”

Even if they bear children, I will slay the darlings

of their wombs: This part of the verse adds to the previous statement in 9:16c that “they cannot bear fruit.” This clause is very similar to Hosea 9:12a that has “Even if they raise their children, I will bereave them of each one.” This clause in 9:16d is probably another instance of the same figure of speech that is used there. The figure of speech here is probably a “pseudosorities” as in 9:12a. It indicates how complete and serious the punishment from the LORD will be. See the note on 9:12a for more details.

they...their: In the Hebrew phrases “they bear children” and “the darlings of their wombs,” the pronouns they and their are masculine. The masculine form indicates that these phrases refer to both the men and women of Israel, not just the mothers. Andersen and Freedman (page 546).

slay: This word means “to cause to die, kill.” TWOT (#1169).

the darlings of their wombs: The Hebrew phrase here is more literally “the precious things of their womb.” It refers to newly born babies that are precious to the people of Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

beloved children (RSV)

dear children (GW)

Hosea 9:17

Section 9:10–17: The sins of the Israelites and the response of the LORD

This section describes the joyful beginning of the LORD’s relationship with the people of Israel and the shocking way that they responded by betraying him. Because of their sin and betrayal, it is necessary for the LORD to judge them.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel’s Sin and Its Consequences (GNT)

Sin’s Terrible Results (CEV)

Paragraph 9:17

In this paragraph, Hosea prophesies about God’s response to the people’s disobedience. God will re-

ject them and scatter them among the nations of the earth. These words are much like the curse in Deuteronomy 28:62–64.

9:17a

My God will reject them because they have not obeyed Him;

- ¶ My God will reject them, because they refuse to listen to him.
- ¶ My God will send you^(plur) away, because you will not do what he tells you to do.

My God: Hosea says My God instead of God or “their God.” By using this phrase, Hosea may be indicating that he no longer considered the LORD to be the God of the people of Israel. Hubbard (page 169), McComiskey (page 157), Macintosh (page 381), and Dearman (pages 257–258).

because: This word introduces the reason that the LORD will reject them. It is because they have not obeyed him. Use a natural way in your language to introduce this reason.

they have not obeyed Him: The Hebrew clause here is more literally “they have not listened to him.” In this context the word “listen” implies “obey.” Andersen and Freedman (page 546), McComiskey (page 157), Stuart (page 154), and Dearman (pages 257–258).

Here are some other ways to translate this meaning:

they refused to listen to him (GW)

Israel, you disobeyed my God. (CEV)

9:17b

and they shall be wanderers among the nations.

- They will wander from place to place in different nations.
- You^(plur) will be people who wander/roam from nation to nation. No country will be your permanent homeland.

and they shall be wanderers among the nations:

This verse part explains what will happen to the people when the LORD rejects them. They will be forced to leave their homeland of Israel. They will no longer own property there to pass on to their descendants. Instead they will live in other nations of the world and will not have their own permanent homeland. Stuart (page 154) and Andersen and Freedman (page 546) both use the word “homeless” to describe the people’s status as wanderers.

wanderers: In Hebrew, this word refers to someone who flees, moves or wanders abroad. TWOT (#1300).

Here are some other ways to translate it:

they will be fugitives among the nations (NET)

Now he will force you to roam from nation to nation. (CEV)

They will be wanderers, homeless among the nations. (NLT)

Hosea 10:1

Section 10:1–8: Why Israel should be punished

In this section, Hosea gives examples of the sins of Israel. The examples show why it is fair for the LORD to judge them. This section has a similar pattern to section 9:10–17. Both sections give examples from agriculture to illustrate the joyful beginning of the relationship between the LORD and the people of Israel and their shocking response of betrayal against him. In this section, Hosea is the speaker.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Retribution for Israel’s Sin (NASB)

The Lord’s judgment against Israel (NLT)

Hosea warns Israel that it will be punished

Paragraph 10:1–2

In this paragraph, Hosea describes the changes that have occurred in Israel. In the past, Israel was prosperous and productive. But the people turned away from the LORD to worship false gods. As a result of their sin, the LORD will cause their places of worship to be destroyed.

10:1a

Israel was a luxuriant vine, yielding fruit for himself.

- ¶ Israel was like a healthy vine that had many branches and produced much/many fruit/grapes.
- ¶ The people of Israel prospered. They were like a grapevine that had lots of grapes/fruit.

Israel was a luxuriant vine, yielding fruit for himself:

This verse part is a metaphor that compares the nation of Israel to a grape vine that produced

fruit. The meaning of the metaphor is that Israel was prosperous. Wood (page 208).

Some versions use present tense to translate this verse part. However, it makes better sense to translate it as a description of a prosperous time in Israel's past. 10:1b–c uses verb forms that normally indicate completed events.

Another way to translate this metaphor is to change it to a simile. For example:

The people of Israel are like vines that used to produce fruit. (GW)

luxuriant: In this verse, the word refers to a healthy plant that is growing well. The Hebrew word has two homonyms. One homonym occurs only in Hosea 10:1. It means “luxuriant.” See TWOT (#272), BDB (#1238), and HALOT (electronic ed., page 150–151). Another homonym means “empty.” See TWOT (#273). Versions that correspond to this meaning include the NJPS “Israel is a ravaged vine,” GW “used to produce fruit,” and KJV “empty vine.”

yielding fruit: The precise meaning of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as yielding is debated. HALOT (electronic ed., page 1437) indicates that there is textual uncertainty concerning this word. For the meaning in this verse, HALOT cites ancient translations with the meaning “to produce/make.” This contrasts with the meaning “to ripen,” which some modern scholars suggest. For example, the Vulgate and Peshitta have: “which brought forth fruit.” However, Rudolf suggests: “that makes fruit ripen over and over again.” Here the meaning is probably “to produce” or “to make.” Most modern versions follow the meaning “to produce/make” as in the ancient versions. See the Vulgate and Peshitta example in the previous footnote. HALOT (electronic ed., page 1437) also cites Gesenius-Buhl as supporting the verb *shawah* II “to make, produce.”

Here are some ways to translate it:

- Use words that focus on producing or making fruit. For example:

Israel is like a large vine that produced plenty of fruit.

Israel was a fertile vine that yielded fruit. (ESV)

- Use words that focus on the amount of fruit. For example:

How prosperous Israel is—a luxuriant vine loaded with fruit! (NLT)

The people of Israel were like a grapevine that was full of grapes. (GNT)

for himself: The phrase for himself indicates that Israel benefitted from the fruit. McComiskey (page 159). Some versions leave this phrase implicit.

10:1b–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{1b} The more his fruit increased, **the more he increased the altars.**

^{1c} The better his land produced, **the better he made the sacred pillars.**

In these lines, the metaphor of Israel as a vine with fruit is replaced by a more literal description of Israel's past. Both lines describe how Israel used their wealth to honor idols instead of the LORD.

Some versions indicate an explicit contrast between these lines and the previous one. These lines (1b–c) imply that the LORD made Israel prosperous, yet Israel gave credit for their prosperity to idols. Some versions express this contrast with the word “but.” For example:

But the richer the people get, the more pagan altars they build. (NLT)

Indicate this contrast in a natural way in your language.

10:1b

The more his fruit increased, the more he increased the altars.

- But the more fruit Israel had, the more altars he built.
- They used their wealth to build many altars to worship false gods

The more his fruit increased, the more he increased the altars: In Hebrew, the first clause is more literally “according to [the] abundance of his fruit.” It introduces a comparison. In this comparison, an increase in fruit results in an increase in the number of altars.

Here are some other ways to translate this comparison:

The more fruit they produced, the more altars they built. (GW)

Since/Because his supply of fruit increased, he was able to increase the number of his altars.

He used his wealth to build more altars.

altars: This word refers here to altars that were built for the worship of idols. McComiskey (page 159), Hubbard (page 169), Wood (208), Macintosh (page 388), and Stuart (page 159). Some versions make this information explicit. For example:

As the people became richer, they built more altars for idols. (NCV)

10:1c

The better his land produced, the better he made the sacred pillars.

- The more the land/nation prospered, the more he decorated his sacred stone pillars.
- and to make their sacred stone pillars beautiful.

The better his land produced, the better he made the sacred pillars: This verse part is more literally “according to [the] prosperity of his land they made good sacred pillars. The first clause introduces a comparison. In this comparison, an increase in prosperity results in improvement in the sacred pillars.

Here are some other ways to translate this comparison:

Since/Because their land became more prosperous, they put up better sacred pillars.

They used the wealth from their bountiful harvests to make their stone pillars even more attractive.

the better he made the sacred pillars: In Hebrew, the term sacred pillars is literally “stone pillars.” It refers here to stone pillars that were set up for the worship of idols. TWOT (#1398g). Some versions make this information explicit. For example:

stone markers they set up to honor other gods (GW)

See how you translated this term in 3:4b.

In Hebrew, the word translated better he made means “to do something well.” HALOT (electronic ed., page 408). Here it describes pillars that the people built well or that they made attractive in some way.

Here are other ways to translate this word:

he improved his pillars (NRSV)

the more beautiful they made the sacred stone pillars they worship (GNT)

put up better stone pillars to honor gods (NCV)

General Comment on 10:1a–c

Some cultures may not use figures of speech from agriculture in this way. If that is true in your language, it may be preferable to translate the meanings directly. For example:

The people of Israel were prosperous and increased in number. As their wealth increased, they built more altars. As their land prospered, they improved their sacred stone pillars.

Hosea 10:2

Section 10:1–8: Why Israel should be punished

In this section, Hosea gives examples of the sins of Israel. The examples show why it is fair for the LORD to judge them. This section has a similar pattern to section 9:10–17. Both sections give examples from agriculture to illustrate the joyful beginning of the relationship between the LORD and the people of Israel and their shocking response of betrayal against him. In this section, Hosea is the speaker.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Retribution for Israel's Sin (NASB)

The Lord's judgment against Israel (NLT)

Hosea warns Israel that it will be punished

Paragraph 10:1–2

In this paragraph, Hosea describes the changes that have occurred in Israel. In the past, Israel was prosperous and productive. But the people turned away from the LORD to worship false gods. As a result of their sin, the LORD will cause their places of worship to be destroyed.

10:2a

Their hearts are devious; now they must bear their guilt.

- Their heart is insincere/false, and now they will suffer for their guilt.
- They are hypocrites, and now is the time for them to receive the consequences for their sin.

Their hearts are devious: This expression indicates that being deviousSee Macintosh (pages 388–389) for further discussion. was a characteristic of the people that resulted from their faulty and perverse reasoning.Macintosh (page 389) and McComiskey (page 160).

Here are other ways to translate this expression:

Their heart is false (NRSV)

They have an insincere heart

Their heart is deceptive

Their hearts: The people of Israel considered the heart to be the center of attitudes and thoughts. Some languages use a different body organ, such as the liver, to signify the center of attitudes and thoughts. Use an expression that is natural in your language for this purpose.

In Hebrew, the word *Their* is plural but “heart” is singular. The phrase *Their heart* indicates that the people share in common a deceitful way of thinking. In some languages, it may be unnatural to refer to a group of people as having one heart. If so, it may be necessary to make the word “heart” or other body organ plural. For example:

The people whose hearts are deceitful (GNT)

In some languages, it may be preferable to express the same meaning without reference to a body organ. For example:

They are hypocrites (GW)

You are deceitful and disloyal (CEV)

now they must bear their guilt: This clause indicates that the time has arrived for the LORD to punish the nation. He will make them pay or suffer for their guilt.HALOT (electronic ed., pages 95–96), McComiskey

(page 160). The word *now* indicates that he will not wait any longer.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they are guilty and must be punished (NLT)

The people whose hearts are deceitful must now suffer for their sins. (GNT)

They will be punished for their sins.

10:2b

The LORD will break down their altars

- Yahweh himself will break down their altars
- Yahweh will cause your^(plur) altars to be destroyed.

10:2c

and demolish their sacred pillars.

- and destroy their sacred shrines.
- He will cause your stone pillars to be smashed.

10:2b–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{2b}The LORD will break down **their altars**

^{2c}and demolish **their sacred pillars.**

The LORD will break down their altars and demolish their sacred pillars: These lines describe what the LORDThe Hebrew word is literally the pronoun “he.” Some rabbinic scholars of the past interpreted the pronoun referent to be “their heart.” Jerome, however, interpreted the pronoun referent to be “the LORD.” See Macintosh (pages 389–390) for more details. Most modern scholars and versions follow Jerome’s interpretation. will do to the altars and sacred pillars that Hosea described in 10:1b–c. He will destroy them. The form of the Hebrew pronoun that is used here emphasizes the LORD as the agent of destruction. Some versions make this emphasis explicit. For example:

He himself will hack down their altars and wreck their sacred pillars. (NJB)

The Lord himself will break down their altars and demolish their sacred pillars.

Hosea 10:3

Section 10:1–8: Why Israel should be punished

In this section, Hosea gives examples of the sins of Israel. The examples show why it is fair for the LORD to judge them. This section has a similar pattern to section 9:10–17. Both sections give examples from agriculture to illustrate the joyful beginning of the relationship between the LORD and the people of Israel and their shocking response of betrayal against him. In this section, Hosea is the speaker.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Retribution for Israel's Sin (NASB)

The Lord's judgment against Israel (NLT)

Hosea warns Israel that it will be punished

Paragraph 10:3–4

In this paragraph, Hosea describes the people's response to the loss of their king.

10:3a

Surely now they will say, "We have no king, for we do not revere the LORD.

- ¶ Very soon they will say, "We^(incl) have no king, because we did not fear Yahweh.
- ¶ Indeed, the time is coming soon when they will admit that they failed to honor Yahweh, so now they have no king.

Surely: This phrase begins with a word that may indicate emphasis. The Hebrew word *ki* begins this phrase. One function of this word is to indicate emphasis. For more details on this use of *ki*, see Van der Merwe, *A Biblical Hebrew Reference Grammar*, chapter 6. §40.9.2.5. Functions as a modal word (electronic ed., pages 303–304). Some versions leave this word implied. The BSB and other versions make the emphasis explicit. Some other versions translate the Hebrew word *ki* as "for" here, which introduces cause. This translation is not recommended here. Although *ki* can introduce cause in other contexts, it is unlikely that the words the people are about to speak could be the cause of the previous destruction. For example:

Truly, now they say (NJPS)

Surely now they will say (NASB)

now they will say: Here Hosea describes the future response of the people after the altars are destroyed and their king has been captured. Wood (page 208).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

These people will soon be saying (GNT)

So they'll say (GW)

We have no king: This statement is a direct quote of what the people say. The direct quote continues to the end of the verse.

This statement indicates that the people of Israel no longer have a king. It probably refers to the capture of Hoshea, the last king of Israel, by the Assyrians. See McComiskey (page 161) and Stuart (pages 160–161). Two alternative suggestions are that the king is the LORD, see Andersen and Freedman (page 553), or that the king is ineffective and powerless, see Wood (page 208). However, these alternative suggestions are difficult to support from versions.

for we do not revere the LORD: In this clause, the people give the reason why they have no king. They acknowledge that they failed to revere the LORD. In Hebrew, the word for revere is literally "fear." For people to fear the LORD means that they have a relationship with him in which they submit to him, they are awed by him, and they are afraid to offend him. McComiskey (page 161).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

because we didn't fear the Lord (NLT)

because we didn't honor the Lord (NCV)

10:3b

What can a king do for us?"

- But for example, even if we^(incl) had a king, could he help us now? No!"
- And they will realize that no king could benefit them now.

What can a king do for us?: This statement expresses the people's despair as they imagine what their situation would be like if they had a king. They did not believe that any king was able to save or help them. Wood (page 208), McComiskey (page 161), and Stuart (page 161).

Their words in this verse part contrast with their previous statement in 10:3a that they had no king. Indicate this contrast in a natural way in your language.

This is a rhetorical question. The expected answer to this question is “nothing.” This rhetorical question is one way to express an attitude of hopelessness. This rhetorical question can also be translated as a statement. For example:

As for the king, he couldn’t do anything for us.
(NCV)

This statement is hypothetical. It does not describe a real situation. Here is another way to indicate this imagined situation:

But would it help us to have a king?

a king: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “the king.” The name of the king is not given. This may indicate that “the king” refers to kings as a group. No human king could help them. It is not recommended that you give the name of a specific king here. It is also possible that the people thought of King Hoshea when they said “the king.” See McComiskey (page 161).

Hosea 10:4

Section 10:1–8: Why Israel should be punished

In this section, Hosea gives examples of the sins of Israel. The examples show why it is fair for the LORD to judge them. This section has a similar pattern to section 9:10–17. Both sections give examples from agriculture to illustrate the joyful beginning of the relationship between the LORD and the people of Israel and their shocking response of betrayal against him. In this section, Hosea is the speaker.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Retribution for Israel’s Sin (NASB)

The Lord’s judgment against Israel (NLT)

Hosea warns Israel that it will be punished

Paragraph 10:3–4

In this paragraph, Hosea describes the people’s response to the loss of their king.

10:4a

They speak mere words; with false oaths they make covenants.

- They make promises that they do not keep. They tell lies and then swear that they are telling the truth. They make agreements/covenants that they do not plan to fulfill/keep.
- They speak many words, but they do not mean what they say. Even when they make/swear an oath to keep their promises and their agreements, they break them.

They speak mere words; with false oaths they make covenants: There are two main ways to interpret the referent of the pronoun They:

1. They refers to the people of Israel. Versions that follow this interpretation describe the last phrase in terms of the “agreements” or covenants that they make mainly with each other. For example:

They utter empty words, taking false oaths and making empty agreements. (NET) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. They refers to the king/kings of Israel. Versions that follow this interpretation describe the last phrase in terms of the “treaties” or “alliances” that they make with other nations. For example:

They utter empty words and make false promises and useless treaties. (GNT) (GNT, NAB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. However, a slight majority of commentaries favor interpretation (2). The plural word forms in 10:3–5 support the understanding that the pronoun “they” in v.4 refers to the people. Most English versions also end the quote of what the people say about the king at the end of 3b. But Hosea is the speaker throughout these verses, and Hosea could be referring to either people or kings in general. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include McComiskey, Wood, and Hubbard. Commentaries that support (2) include Stuart, Macintosh, Keil, Lange, and possibly Dearman. See Dearman (pages 263–265) for discussion of both points of view and the ambiguities involved. Both the people of Israel and their kings break their promises and fail to keep their agreements, so if possible, translate in a way that will allow either interpretation. The meaning lines in the Display will follow this approach.

Hosea uses three phrases to describe the behavior of the people of Israel. These phrases are more literally “They speak words, swearing falsehood, making covenant[s].” The wording in some versions implies that there are three separate actions. It is not stated

explicitly whether these actions are part of the same event. The wording in other versions implies one main action with further details in the next two phrases. These actions may or may not be part of the same event. For example:

They utter mere words; with empty oaths they make covenants (ESV)

You may arrange these phrases either way in your translation. There is no significant difference in meaning. The meaning lines in the Display will give an example of each.

They speak mere words: This is a Hebrew idiom. It means that the people do not intend to do what their words say. See McComiskey (page 164) and the NET footnote on “utter empty words.”

Here are some other ways to translate it:

They make many promises (NIV)

they utter empty words (NET)

with false oaths: In Hebrew, this phrase means that a person makes a very serious promise that he or she does not intend to keep. The oath in this context probably refers to any serious promise. Alternatively, some versions understand this phrase to refer specifically to an oath sworn as part of making a covenant. For example, the RSV has, “with empty oaths they make covenants.”

Here are some other ways to translate it:

make false promises (GNT)

they lie when they take oaths (GW)

they make covenants: In Hebrew, the word “covenant” refers to a formal agreement that has mutual obligations. Commentaries that favor limiting the referent to an international treaty are Stuart, Keil, Macintosh, and Andersen and Freedman. Commentaries that favor a wider application of the term that perhaps may include international treaties but also other kinds of agreements are: Dearman, Hubbard, Wood, McComiskey, and Davies.

Here are four things this word can refer to in different contexts:

1. Agreements that the people of Israel make with one another.
2. An agreement that a king makes with the people.
3. A treaty or alliance that Israel makes with another nation.
4. A covenant that God makes with a person or a nation.

In this context, it refers mainly to agreements that the people of Israel make with one another. This phrase implies that the people do not keep their agreements.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

making empty agreements (NET)

make covenants they don't intend to keep (NLT)

10:4b

So judgment springs up like poisonous weeds in the furrows of a field.

- Therefore/So their lack of justice keeps increasing like poisonous weeds that grow/sprout in a plowed field.
- The unfair/unjust way people treat one another is like poisonous weeds that spread in the furrows of a farmer's field.
- Because of these things that they do, there are more and more unfair decisions in court. The situation is like harmful/poisonous weeds that grow where good crops should be.
- Unfair/Harmful lawsuits and other court cases continually increase. They are like poisonous weeds that cover/overgrow people's gardens.

So judgment springs up like poisonous weeds in the furrows of a field: This clause is a simile. It compares the increasing injustice (see below) and other bitter disputes to poisonous weeds.

This clause gives the consequence of the people's many promises that they do not keep, their false oaths, and broken covenants. The consequence is injustice. Andersen and Freedman (page 554), McComiskey (page 164) and Keil (page 84). Some versions express this relationship with a specific word such as so or “therefore.” Other versions leave it implied. Translate the connection between 10:4a and 10:4b in a natural way in your language.

judgment: The Hebrew word for judgment here is literally “justice.” It has a broad range of meanings related to what is right and just, including laws, lawsuits, legal decisions, and judgment. TWOT (#2443c). Wood (page 208) says the term refers to lawsuits that

arise due to denial of people's legal rights. Macintosh (page 395) concludes that Rashi's interpretation of "justice" as "litigation" is the most likely. The BART interlinear suggests that the appropriate sense in BDB (page 1048b, sense 1.c) is "litigation before judges." It also mentions HALOT sense 2, "probably dispute, case, litigation." NIDOTTE (#5477) says that *mišpat* refers most frequently "to a judicial decision or verdict...as well as the execution of the sentence in punishment." It can involve the government, the courts, and any legal transactions between people in general. According to Hubbard (page 173), justice involves regulating the rights of the citizens. McComiskey (page 165) says there was a lack of fairness in the "legal transactions of Hosea's day." He further comments that in the Prophets, "justice is not limited only to kings or other judicial officials...The prophets most frequently apply it to the people."

In the context of "justice" growing "like poisonous weeds," it is clear that "justice" should be understood in the sense of injustice or justice that has degenerated into decisions or transactions that are unfair. Pusey (page 100) calls it "injustice." Dearman (page 265) refers to it as a "lack of justice."

There are three ways to interpret this word in this context:

1. It refers to any kind of injustice. For example:

Justice has become injustice, growing like poisonous weeds in a plowed field. (GNT)

and so-called justice spreads like a poisonous weed along the furrows of the fields (NJB) (CEV, GNT, NJB, NJPS, NLT)

1. It refers more specifically to legal disputes, lawsuits, and other legal transactions. It implies that these legal transactions are unjust or harmful. For example:

and litigation spreads like a poisonous weed along the furrows of the fields (REB)

Therefore legal disputes sprout up like poisonous weeds in the furrows of a plowed field. (NET) (GW, NCV, NET, NIV, NRSV, REB)

1. It refers specifically to judgment, probably meaning a sentence of punishment. Hosea has many references to the LORD's judgment of the nation of Israel. These references describe the many different

ways he will punish the nation. For two examples of the identification of judgment with punishment, see the paragraph summary for 9:6–9 and the Section summary for 10:9–15. It implies that the judgment is unfair. For example:

so judgment springs up like poisonous weeds in the furrows of the field (ESV) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NASB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretations (1) or (2). Both these interpretations have good commentary support. The first interpretation is more general, so it may apply to more situations. The second interpretation is supported by more lexicons. If possible, choose terms in your language that will fit either interpretation. The Display will give two examples of each.

poisonous weeds: This phrase refers to a poisonous plant that grows in place of a desirable plant.

in the furrows of a field: The furrows of a field are shallow trenches or hollows that farmers dig in the places where they plant their crops.

In areas that are not familiar with plowed fields, here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in a farmer's field (NLT)

where good plants/crops should grow

in their gardens

Hosea 10:5

Section 10:1–8: Why Israel should be punished

In this section, Hosea gives examples of the sins of Israel. The examples show why it is fair for the LORD to judge them. This section has a similar pattern to section 9:10–17. Both sections give examples from agriculture to illustrate the joyful beginning of the relationship between the LORD and the people of Israel and their shocking response of betrayal against him. In this section, Hosea is the speaker.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Retribution for Israel's Sin (NASB)

The Lord's judgment against Israel (NLT)

Hosea warns Israel that it will be punished

Paragraph 10:5–8

In this paragraph, Hosea tells how the LORD will punish the people of Israel. He will cause the Assyrian army to take away the calf idol at Bethel and destroy the altars where they worshiped idols. The Assyrians will also take captive the king of Samaria. Macintosh (page 392). The people's response will be to mourn the loss of their calf idol and to beg to die.

10:5a

The people of Samaria will fear for the calf of Beth-aven.

- ¶ The residents of Samaria are full of fear concerning their calf-idol at Beth-aven.
- ¶ The people of Israel are afraid of what will happen to their calf idol in Beth Aven.

The people of Samaria: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “the inhabitant of Samaria.” Andersen and Freedman and Hubbard suggest that this singular form refers to the calf idol. Other scholars and all versions used in TN understand it to refer collectively to the people of Samaria. In this verse, Samaria, the capital of Israel, is a figure of speech that represents the nation of Israel. Some versions make the name “Israel” explicit here. For example:

The people from Israel (NCV)

will fear for the calf: The expression fear for means to be concerned about someone or something. McComiskey (page 165) “dread or awe or fear for,” Macintosh (page 339) “be in dread concerning,” Davies (page 237) “trembled” or “trembled in fear,” Wood (page 208) “anxious about.” The calf refers to an idol shaped like a calf. Here it refers to the people's concern about their calf-idol. Two ancient versions, the LXX and the Peshitta, translate the Hebrew verb as “dwell” instead of “fear.” Either sense is possible for this verb. The context determines which sense is intended. McComiskey (page 165) points out that “dwell” does not make sense in this context. In addition, the collocation “dwell for” does not occur anywhere else in the Old Testament. However, the collocation “fear/afraid for” does occur elsewhere. For example, Job 19:29 has: “be afraid for yourselves of the sword.” They are fearful that the Assyrians will take it away from them. The phrase does not mean that the calf-idol frightens them.

Here are some other ways to translate 10:5a:

The people of Samaria tremble in fear for their calf idol (NLT96)

the people from Israel are worried about the calf-shaped idol (NCV)

Beth-aven: The term Beth-aven means “house of wickedness.” This is the name that Hosea normally uses for “Bethel.” See also the note on Beth-aven in 4:15b.

10:5b–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{5b}Indeed, its people **will mourn**

^{5c}**with** its idolatrous priests—

There is an ellipsis (deliberate omission) in 10:5c. In some languages, it will be necessary to supply the missing verb from 10:5b. For example:

^{5c}and its idolatrous priests will mourn **over it also**,

Priests as well as people mourned over the loss of the calf-idol. Stuart (page 156) and Hubbard (page 173).

10:5b

Indeed, its people will mourn

- They will mourn over it,
- Indeed, they will mourn when it is taken away,

Indeed, its people will mourn: In Hebrew, this clause begins with the word *ki*. In this context, some scholars think that it indicates emphasis. See Keil (page 85), Stuart (page 156), and Hubbard (page 173). Another function of *ki* is to introduce a reason for the preceding clause. For example, the KJV begins this clause with “for.” No other version takes this approach here, so the notes have not treated this as an interpretation issue. The BSB indicates this emphasis explicitly.

Most versions leave the relationship implied. You may follow either approach. The Display will give an example of each.

its people: There are two main ways to interpret this phrase:

1. The pronoun *its* refers to Samaria. Unambiguous versions understand the antecedent of “it” to be Samaria. The phrase *its people* refers to Samaria's people, the residents there. For example:

the people there will mourn for it (NJB) (CEV, GNT, NCV, NET, NJB, NLT, REB)

1. The pronoun its refers to the calf. No versions unambiguously translate the antecedent of “it” to be the calf. However, many commentaries support this understanding. They include Stuart, Keil, McComiskey, Macintosh, Andersen and Freedman, Wood, and Davies. The phrase its people refers to the calf’s people, the people who worship the calf. For example:

those that worship the calf will mourn over it

The Notes and Display will follow interpretation (1). However either interpretation is acceptable. Both interpretations describe the same people. Verse 10:5a says unambiguously that the inhabitants of Samaria fear for the idol. These same people also mourn for it. The difference is that interpretation (1) focuses more on their place of residence. Interpretation (2) focuses more on their devotion to the idol. Many versions are ambiguous.

will mourn: This phrase means that the people will express their sorrow over the loss of their calf idol. Normally people mourn when a family member or other loved one dies. Mourning was usually expressed in a way that others could see and hear. TWOT (#6 I).

10:5b–d (combined/reordered)

- All the people and priests who habitually shout with joy because of the great value and godlikeness of the calf-idol will soon mourn over it.

10:5c with its idolatrous priests—

- and the idolatrous priests of Samaria will also mourn.
- and Samaria’s pagan priests will also mourn,

with its idolatrous priests: In Hebrew, the phrase idolatrous priests is a single word. It is used only for pagan priests. McComiskey (page 166). This line refers to the priests that were associated with the worship of the calf idol.

The pronoun referent in the phrase its idolatrous priests is parallel to the phrase “its people” in 10:5b, so the referent of both phrases is probably Samaria. For example:

^{5b} Samaria’s people mourn over it

^{5c} and Samaria’s pagan priests wail for it

10:5d those who rejoiced in its glory—

- Everyone who used to rejoice over its beauty will mourn.
- though they exult now in its splendor and great value.

those who rejoiced in its glory: In Hebrew, this line is a clause that is more literally “they rejoice on its glory.” Some versions translate this as a clause as it is in the Hebrew. For example, the NCV has: “They used to shout for joy about its glory.” This line further describes the mourners in 10:5b–c. They normally rejoice over the calf’s splendor.

The rejoicing of the people in 10:5d contrasts with their mourning in 10:b–c. In Hebrew, the form of the verb “rejoice” here indicates incomplete or continuous action. In this context, it may refer to habitual rejoicing in the past or in the present.

Here are some ways to show this contrast:

- Use past tense. One example is the BSB above. Here are other examples:

those who rejoiced over it and over its glory (ESV)

They used to shout for joy about its glory (NCV)

- Use a clause that indicates an unexpected result. For example:

Those that worship the calf will mourn over it, although they now praise its glory with joy.

those who rejoiced: The last antecedent of those is “its idolatrous priests.” But since “its people” and “its idolatrous priests” are parallel terms, it probably refers to both these groups, not only to the priests. Hubbard (page 173). The LXX and Syriac also support the reference to both people and priests. Many versions are ambiguous. You should either translate in a way that is ambiguous or in a way that can refer to both these groups.

rejoiced: There is a textual issue with this word:

1. The Hebrew word in the Masoretic text means “re-joyce.” For example:

They used to shout for joy about its glory (NCV) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NCV, NIV, NJB, NJPS)

1. Some scholars think that the original text was “cry/wail.” For example:

They will wail when it is stripped of its golden splendor. (GNT) (CEV, GNT, GW, NABRE, NASB, NET, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The LXX also supports this option. There is no support for option (2) from Hebrew manuscripts or ancient versions.

its glory: This refers to the glory or splendor of the calf. In Hosea 4:7 “their Glory” is a title or designation for the LORD. McComiskey (page 166) and Keil (page 85) suggest that the people attributed divinity, perhaps Yahweh’s divinity to the calf-idol. Similarly, Dearman (pages 265–266) suggests that the people may have regarded the calf as a representative of divinity/Yahweh. Hubbard (page 174) identifies its glory as the esteem shown by those who worshiped it. Macintosh (pages 399–400) regards its glory as wealth. The term glory here could indicate that those who worshiped the calf thought that it was a deity. It could also refer to a physical attribute such as beauty or to its monetary value.

Here are some other ways to translate its glory:

its deity/godlikeness

its beauty/magnificence

its great value

In some languages, it may be appropriate and natural to use more than one of these terms.

General Comment on 10:5b–d

10:5b–c describes action in the near future. 10:5d describes action in the past or perhaps both past and present. In some languages, it may be more natural to rearrange the verse parts to first describe past and present action before speaking of future action. For example:

^{5b–c}The people and priests ^{5d}rejoice now over the glory of the calf-idol ^{5b–c}but they will soon mourn over it.

10:5e–6a

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning.

^{10:5e}for it has been taken from them **into exile**.

^{10:6a}Yes, it will be carried **to Assyria as tribute to the great king**.

These lines give the reason why the people mourned and why they could no longer rejoice over the glory of the calf. It is because that glory will be taken away when the calf is taken into exile.

10:5e

for it has been taken from them into exile.

- Because its beauty is gone. It has been taken from them into another country.
- They will mourn, because the enemy will take its splendor and godlikeness away from them to their own country.

for it has been taken from them into exile: In Hebrew, this clause begins with the word *ki* (see 10:5b). Here *ki* introduces the reason that the people mourned. Many versions translate it with the word *for* or “because.” Use a natural way in your language to introduce this reason.

The Hebrew clause is more literally: “it has departed (or “gone into exile”) from it.” Each pronoun has more than one possible referent. Also the Hebrew verb can mean either “depart/leave” or “go into exile.” BDB (#1540) 2. remove, depart. 3. go into exile. HALOT (electronic ed., page 191) 2a. to (have to) leave, disappear. 2b. to go into exile. For these reasons, there are various ways to interpret this clause.

Here are two main interpretations:

1. “It” (the glory) has left “it” (the calf idol). McComiskey (page 166) comments that it is best to understand the subject of this verb to be “its glory” which has departed from the calf, rather than the calf itself which has departed from the people. For example:

its glory will be taken away into captivity. (GW)

the glory that has departed from it. (NRSV) (GNT, GW, NASB, NET, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. “It” (the calf idol) has gone into exile from “it” (Beth-aven or Israel). Andersen and Freedman (page 556) comments that this clause describes physical removal, not just the loss of splendor. It says almost the same thing as Hosea 10:6a. Stuart (pages 161–162) and Keil (page 85) also support this view. All three commentators assume that “glory” is a designation that refers to the idol. The idol is

taken to Assyria either as plunder or as a gift for the king of Assyria. For example:

for the image of their god which is carried away into exile. (REB) (BSB, CEV, ESV, NIV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a majority of versions. It makes good sense to understand the Hebrew pronouns here to refer to the calf and the calf's glory as in 10:5d. It also makes good sense of the introductory phrase "It also" in the next verse. The phrase refers to the calf that is carried to Assyria in addition to the departure of the glory of the calf. See the following note for more information. However, interpretation (2) is also acceptable. It makes good sense if 10:6a is understood to be parallel to 10:5e.

Hosea 10:6

Section 10:1–8: Why Israel should be punished

In this section, Hosea gives examples of the sins of Israel. The examples show why it is fair for the LORD to judge them. This section has a similar pattern to section 9:10–17. Both sections give examples from agriculture to illustrate the joyful beginning of the relationship between the LORD and the people of Israel and their shocking response of betrayal against him. In this section, Hosea is the speaker.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Retribution for Israel's Sin (NASB)

The Lord's judgment against Israel (NLT)

Hosea warns Israel that it will be punished

Paragraph 10:5–8

In this paragraph, Hosea tells how the LORD will punish the people of Israel. He will cause the Assyrian army to take away the calf idol at Bethel and destroy the altars where they worshiped idols. The Assyrians will also take captive the king of Samaria. Macintosh (page 392). The people's response will be to mourn the loss of their calf idol and to beg to die.

10:6a

Yes, it will be carried to Assyria as tribute to the great king.

- The calf-idol will be taken to Assyria to be Samaria's present to the great king there.

- They will bring the idol to Assyria and give it to the great king as a gift.

Yes, it will be carried to Assyria: This Hebrew clause part is more literally "also it to Assyria it will be carried." The Hebrew phrase "also it" introduces additional information and gives emphasis to it. See BDB (#1571) gam "addition," which states that gam followed by a pronoun begins a sentence with emphasis. Here it probably indicates that in addition to the glory of the calf departing, the calf itself will also be taken away. For example:

The thing itself shall be carried to Assyria (ESV)

It too shall be brought to Assyria (NJPS)

Some versions leave this information implied.

This clause part is passive. In some languages, it may be more natural to use an active verb and to make the agent explicit. There are two possible agents:

- The Israelites. Andersen and Freedman (page 557). After the Assyrians defeat Israel, the Assyrians will force the Israelites to bring their calf idol to Assyria to give to their king. For example:

The Israelites will carry it to Assyria as a gift for the great king.

The Assyrians will make the Israelites carry it to Assyria as tribute for the great king.

- The Assyrians. Dearman (pages 266–267) and Stuart (page 162). After the Assyrians defeat Israel, the Assyrians will bring the calf idol to Assyria to give to their king. For example:

The Assyrians will carry it home to Assyria as a gift for the great king.

If you need to make an agent explicit in your translation, you may choose either of these options.

as tribute to the great king: In this context, a tribute is a gift that someone gives to a superior person, particularly to a king. It shows an attitude of submission to that person. TWOT (#1214a).

The phrase the great BART and some versions regard the Hebrew word *yareb* to be the proper name "Jareb" both here and in Hosea 5:13. The majority of scholars, however, regard the meaning to be "great." See the

NET footnote on “the great king” in this verse for more information. king refers to the king of Assyria who ruled at that time. Dearman and Stuart suggest that the “great king” was either Tiglath-Pileser III or Shalmanezar V. Hubbard suggests he was either Shalmanezar V or Sargon II.

10:6b

Ephraim will be seized with shame;

- Ephraim will be shamed.
- Assyria will make Ephraim look foolish.

10:6b–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{6b} Ephraim **will be seized with shame;**

^{6c} Israel **will be ashamed** of its wooden idols.

These lines talk about the shame that Israel will have when their idol is captured by Assyria.

Ephraim...Israel: In these parallel lines, Ephraim and Israel are figures of speech that represent all the people of the nation of Israel.

will be seized with shame...will be ashamed: The words translated as shame and ashamed are forms of the same Hebrew word. They mean “to be shamed,” and describe a sense of confusion, embarrassment, and dismay. TWOT (#222).

Here are other ways to translate these parallel lines:

Ephraim shall be put to shame and Israel shall be ashamed (NRSV)

Ephraim will be ridiculed and Israel will be shamed (NLT)

10:6c

Israel will be ashamed of its wooden idols.

- Israel will be embarrassed that he trusted in its own foolish plans.
- The people of Israel will be ashamed that they believed their own advice.

of its wooden idols: There are textual issues and interpretation differences of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as of its wooden idols.

Here are the textual issues:

1. The Masoretic Text has “from its own counsel/plans.” For example:

and Israel will be ashamed of its own counsel.
(NASB) (GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NJB, NJPS, REB)

1. Some scholars think that the original text was “from its own image.” This suggestion was initially proposed by Wellhausen. See Macintosh (page 404) and Davies (page 238). The word “image” refers to the calf idol. For example:

Israel shall be ashamed of his idol. (ESV) (CEV, ESV, NLT, RSV)

1. Other scholars think that the original text was “from its own disobedience.” This suggestion, based on Syriac and Arabic parallels, was initially proposed by G. R. Driver. See Macintosh (page 404) and Davies (page 238). For example:

and the people will be ashamed for not obeying.
(NCV) (NCV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with the majority of modern commentaries and versions.

Here are the main interpretations of the word “from its own counsel/plans:”

1. The word means: “from its own counsel/plans.” For example:

Israel shall be dismayed because of its plans.
(NJPS) (GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NJB, NJPS, REB)

1. The word means: “from its own wood.” Favored by Andersen and Freedman and Hubbard. Scholars use two different methods to derive the meaning “wood:” 1) The word in the MT is an unusual form of the word for “wood.” 2) The word for “wood” has been proposed as an original Hebrew text that is different from the MT. See Davies (page 238). The word “wood” refers to the calf idol. For example: (NET)

Israel will be put to shame because of its wooden idol. (BSB, NET, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It makes sense and it is followed by ancient and many modern versions. The “counsel/plans” that Israel will be ashamed of probably refers to the unwise national policies that the nation of Israel followed. McComiskey (page 167).

Hosea 10:7

Section 10:1–8: Why Israel should be punished

In this section, Hosea gives examples of the sins of Israel. The examples show why it is fair for the LORD to judge them. This section has a similar pattern to section 9:10–17. Both sections give examples from agriculture to illustrate the joyful beginning of the relationship between the LORD and the people of Israel and their shocking response of betrayal against him. In this section, Hosea is the speaker.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Retribution for Israel's Sin (NASB)

The Lord's judgment against Israel (NLT)

Hosea warns Israel that it will be punished

Paragraph 10:5–8

In this paragraph, Hosea tells how the LORD will punish the people of Israel. He will cause the Assyrian army to take away the calf idol at Bethel and destroy the altars where they worshiped idols. The Assyrians will also take captive the king of Samaria. Macintosh (page 392). The people's response will be to mourn the loss of their calf idol and to beg to die.

10:7

Samaria will be carried off with her king like a twig on the surface of the water.

- Israel's king in Samaria will be destroyed like debris that floats away on the water.
- The Assyrians will carry off the last Israelite king from Samaria like a piece of wood is carried off by rushing/flood water.

Samaria will be carried off with her king like a twig on the surface of the water: This clause is a simile. It compares the king of Samaria to a piece of wood or floating debris that a river or ocean current carries away. The simile is probably a figurative way to describe the king of Israel when the Assyrians defeat him and take him into exile. He is helpless and unable to escape.

The clause is literally "[will] be destroyed Samaria its king like a twig on [the] surface of [the] waters." There are three main interpretations of this clause:

1. Samaria's king will be destroyed. Favored by Dearman (pages 266–267), Davies (page 238), Macintosh (page 406), McComiskey (page 168), and possibly Keil (page 85). Andersen and Freedman (page 558)

and Hubbard (page 175) agree that the clause refers to the king of Samaria. However, they differ from the others in their proposal that "Samaria's king" refers to the calf idol, not a human king. The Hebrew phrase "Samaria her king" means the "king of Samaria." The Hebrew phrase "Samaria its king" is unusual. The expected construction is "king of Samaria." Some commentators categorize this phrase as a "casus pendens," also called "topic and comment." It could be translated "As for Samaria, its king will be destroyed." See Macintosh (page 406), McComiskey (page 168) and Hubbard (page 175). For example:

The king of Samaria will be carried away, like a piece of wood on water. (GW) (CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NJPS, NRSV)

1. Samaria will be destroyed. Initially proposed by Wolff, cited in Davies (239). Favored by Stuart (pages 162–163) and possibly Keil (page 85). The Hebrew text should be understood as two clauses. The first clause says, "Samaria will be destroyed." The second clause says, "Its king [will be] like a twig on the surface of the waters." A difficulty is gender mismatch. The Hebrew verb "will be destroyed" is masculine. However, the phrase "her king" indicates that "Samaria" is feminine. For example:

Israel will be destroyed; its king will be like a chip of wood floating on the water. (NCV) (NCV, NJB, NLT96)

1. Both Samaria and Samaria's king will be destroyed. Favored by Wood (page 209). Macintosh (page 406) prefers interpretation (1) but he lists this option as possible. The technical term for coordinated words that lack a coordinating conjunction, such as "and," is "asyndeton." The Hebrew text should be understood to say, "Samaria [and] her king." A difficulty is number mismatch. In this interpretation the two subjects, "Samaria and her king" require that the verb "will be destroyed" be plural. However, it is marked as singular in the MT. For example:

Samaria and its king will be carried off like a twig on the surface of the waters. (NET) (BSB, NASB, NET, NIV, NLT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a majority of versions and commentaries.

will be carried off: The Hebrew word is literally “will be destroyed.” It is a passive form of the word that means “destroy” or “perish.” It refers to a violent end. TWOT (#438 II).

Here the word may refer to the death of a specific king. Rabbinic scholar Kimchi suggests that this verse refers to Hoshea, the king of Israel, following his imprisonment by Shalmaneser V in 725 BC. Cited in Macintosh (page 408). Or the word may refer to the end of the monarchy in Israel. There would be no future kings of Israel. Keil (page 85).

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

Samaria's king shall perish (NRSV)

Their king will be carried off (GNT)

The king of Samaria shall disappear (NAB)

twig: The Hebrew word for twig has two main interpretations:

1. The word means a piece of wood. The same word is in Joel 1:7, where it describes a fig tree. Ancient versions that translate this word as “wood” include the LXX, Theodotion and Syriac Peshitta. See the NET footnote on “twig” for this verse. Also, Macintosh (page 406) and McComiskey (page 168). For example:

The king of Samaria will be carried away like a piece of wood on water. (GW) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The word means foam/froth. The word is related to a verb that means, “to be angry.” Here it refers to the churning of water that produces foam/froth. Macintosh (page 406). Some ancient versions that appear to have this understanding are Aquila, Symmachus, Vulgate and Targum. For example:

As for Samaria, her king is cut off as the foam upon the water. (KJV) (KJV, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with the majority of versions. It has good support from Joel 1:7 and other related Hebrew words.

Here are some other ways to translate this simile:

Like a stick on the surface of the water (NASB)

like a chip of wood floating on the water. (NCV)

Hosea 10:8

Section 10:1–8: Why Israel should be punished

In this section, Hosea gives examples of the sins of Israel. The examples show why it is fair for the LORD to judge them. This section has a similar pattern to section 9:10–17. Both sections give examples from agriculture to illustrate the joyful beginning of the relationship between the LORD and the people of Israel and their shocking response of betrayal against him. In this section, Hosea is the speaker.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Retribution for Israel's Sin (NASB)

The Lord's judgment against Israel (NLT)

Hosea warns Israel that it will be punished

Paragraph 10:5–8

In this paragraph, Hosea tells how the LORD will punish the people of Israel. He will cause the Assyrian army to take away the calf idol at Bethel and destroy the altars where they worshiped idols. The Assyrians will also take captive the king of Samaria. Macintosh (page 392). The people's response will be to mourn the loss of their calf idol and to beg to die.

10:8a

The high places of Aven will be destroyed—it is the sin of Israel;

- The hilltop shrines of Aven will be totally destroyed. This worship of idols is the main sin of Israel.
- Enemy armies will turn the idol/pagan places of worship in/at Aven into ruins. These shrines on the top of mountains/hills are the places where Israel commits such terrible sin.

The high places of Aven will be destroyed: The LORD will use the Assyrian army to destroy the shrines and altars in Israel. The Hebrew word for destroyed indicates severe destruction. McComiskey (page 169). See also Leviticus 26:30, which has the same Hebrew word.

high places of Aven: This phrase refers to places on the tops of mountains or hills where the people worshiped idols. high places were shrines that included altars for sacrificing animals. McComiskey (page 169), Dearman (pages 267–268), Stuart (pages 163–164) and Davies (page 239).

The Hebrew word that the BSB transliterates as Aven is 'awen. There are two main interpretations of this Hebrew word in this context:

1. This word is a place name. It is a short form of "Beth-aven," the name that Hosea uses for Bethel. Commentaries that support this interpretation include McComiskey, Dearman, Keil, Hubbard, Wood, and Macintosh. See also the note on Beth Aven under 4:15b. For example:

The hilltop shrines of Aven, where the people of Israel worship idols, will be destroyed. (GNT) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NET, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. This is the regular Hebrew word for "wickedness" or "falseness." Commentaries that support interpretation (2) include Stuart and Davies. It is not a place name here. For example:

The places of false worship will be destroyed (NCV) (NCV, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries.

A cross-reference to Hosea 10:5 or a footnote such as the following one may be helpful here:

Aven is a reference to Beth-aven; see 10:5a and the note there. (NLT)

it is the sin of Israel: The full Hebrew clause is literally "[the] high places of Aven the sin of Israel." Here Hosea describes the high places of Aven as the sin of Israel. The technical term is "apposition." Merriam Webster defines apposition as: "an arrangement of words in which a noun or noun phrase is followed by another noun or noun phrase that refers to the same thing." The phrase the sin does not imply that Israel had only one sin. Rather, it indicates that idol worship at Aven was the chief sin of the people of Israel. Stuart (pages 163–164), Keil (pages 85–86), McComiskey (page 170) and Hubbard (page 176).

Here are other ways to translate this verse part:

The illegal worship sites of Aven will be destroyed. Israel sins there. (GW)

And the pagan shrines of Aven, the place of Israel's sin, will crumble. (NLT)

10:8b thorns and thistles will overgrow their altars.

- Their broken/abandoned altars will be overgrown with thorns and thistles.
- Prickly/Thorny weeds will grow in the places where the altars used to be.

thorns and thistles will overgrow their altars: This clause indicates that the destruction of the high places will be complete. The expression thorns and thistles is a poetic way to describe a place that is ruined and deserted. Stuart (pages 163–164), Keil (page 85–86) and Wood (page 209). In Genesis 3:18, the same expression describes God's curse on the land. See Dearman (pages 267–268). Hosea also uses a similar description of weeds in 9:6d–e to describe desolation and God's displeasure.

Thorns and thistles are undesirable plants with sharp barbs that cause pain when touched. If you do not have words for plants like these, use a word for an undesirable plant that grows in deserted places. For example:

Thorns and weeds will grow up over their altars. (GNT)

their altars: This phrase probably refers to altars that were widespread throughout Israel, such as in 10:1–2. Macintosh (page 391) and Davies (page 240). It is also possible that the reference may be specifically to the altars at Bethel. Wood (page 209).

10:8c–d (combined/reordered)

- Then they will plead with the mountains and hills to cover/bury them with a landslide.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{8c} Then they will say to the mountains, **"Cover us!"**

^{8d} and to the hills, **"Fall on us!"**

There is an ellipsis in 10:8d. In some languages, it will be necessary to supply the missing verb phrase from 10:8c. For example:

^{8d} and they will say to the hills, **"Fall on us!"**

In these lines, the people of Israel express their desire to die. It is a desperate cry that indicates their suffering is so severe that they want to die quickly to end it.

Then they will say to the mountains, “Cover us!” and to the hills, “Fall on us!”: These requests to the mountains and the hills imply that the people want a landslide to bury them under rock and dirt. Stuart (pages 163–164).

Some versions make the people’s desperation more explicit by using words such as “plead” or “call out” instead of say. For example:

The people will call out to the mountains, “Hide us!” and to the hills, “Cover us!” (GNT)

They will beg the mountains, “Bury us!” and plead with the hills, “Fall on us!” (NLT)

General Comment on 10:8c–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these parallel lines. See 10:8c–d (combined/reordered) in the Display for an example.

10:8c

Then they will say to the mountains, “Cover us!”

- They will beg the mountains, “Bury us!” (NLT)
- Then they will call out to the mountains to cover them with a landslide

10:8d

and to the hills, “Fall on us!”

- and plead with the hills, “Fall on us!” (NLT)
- and implore the hills to bury them under rocks and dirt!

Hosea 10:9

Section 10:9–15: The LORD will punish Israel

In this section, the LORD (10:9–11) and Hosea (10:12–15) warn the people of Israel that the LORD will punish them because of their past and current sin. This section includes figures of speech from agriculture that the Israelites in Hosea’s time would clearly understand. Some examples are comparisons of the people to farm animals (10:11) and to farmers (10:12–13).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Pronounces Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord Promises to Punish Israel (CEV)

Paragraph 10:9–10

In this paragraph, the LORD is the speaker. He traces the sin of the people of Israel back to their ancestors

in the city of Gibeah. Verse 10:10 is a warning that punishment will come as a result of their past and present sin.

10:9a–b

Since the days of Gibeah you have sinned, O Israel, and there you have remained: This verse describes how long the people of Israel have continued to sin.

10:9a

Since the days of Gibeah you have sinned, O Israel,

- ¶ “You Israelites continue to sin just as your ancestors did at Gibeah.
- ¶ Yahweh said, “The people of Israel have been sinful and defiant ever since the incident at Gibeah.

Since the days of Gibeah: the days of Gibeah refers back to a tragic incident in Israel’s past. Gibeah is a city in the territory of the tribe of Benjamin. Some residents there committed extreme sexual perversion and murder. The people of Gibeah were defiant against the LORD and against the rest of Israel. See Judges 19–20 and Hosea 9:9. The phrase Since the days of Gibeah refers to the time period from that sinful act to the time of Hosea.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Israel, you have sinned since the time of Gibeah (NCV)

Israel, you have sinned ever since the incident at Gibeah (GW)

you have sinned, O Israel: In this context, these words imply that the people of Israel sinned in a way that was similar to the sins of the people of Gibeah. Hubbard (page 176).

O Israel: Here, the LORD, speaking through Hosea, addresses the people of Israel directly.

Here are other ways to translate this expression:

Israel (CEV)

You Israelites

Use a vocative that is natural in your language when a person speaks to a group of people.

The GNT translates this accusation as indirect speech:

The LORD says, “The people of Israel have not stopped sinning against me since the time of their sin at Gibeah. (GNT)

However, indirect speech is not recommended here. Direct address is preferable, since in this situation the LORD is confronting the people, not just speaking about them.

10:9b
and there you have remained.

- You keep following the same sinful behavior.
- They have not changed at all.

and there you have remained: This statement indicates that Israel continued to follow same kind of sinful behavior as the terrible sin committed at Gibeah. Hubbard (page 177), Macintosh (page 411), and Keil (page 86). Another standard meaning of the Hebrew word is “stood” or “took a stand.” If that is the intended meaning here, it may refer to the eleven tribes of Israel that took a stand in battle against the people of Gibeah and the tribe of Benjamin.

Here are some other ways to translate this statement:

You never change (GW)

You have made no progress whatsoever (NLT)

10:9c
Did not the battle in Gibeah overtake the sons of iniquity?

- Will not war overwhelm those who do evil in Gibeah?
- War will overtake the wicked people in Gibeah. (GW)

Did not the battle in Gibeah overtake the sons of iniquity?: This clause is more literally “not will war overtake them in the gibeah on the sons of injustice.” There are three main interpretations of this clause:

1. A future war will overtake evildoers in Gibeah. Stuart (page 168), Macintosh (page 411), and Hubbard (page 177). For example:

Shall not war overtake them in Gibeah? (NRSV)
(CEV, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NRSV, REB)

1. A past war overtook evildoers in Gibeah. Andersen and Freedman (page 564). For example:

Did not war overtake the evildoers in Gibeah?
(NET) (BSB, NET, NIV, NLT)

1. A war did not overtake evildoers in Gibeah. McComiskey (page 171) and Keil (page 86). For example:

the battle in Gibeah against the children of iniquity did not overtake them. (KJV) (KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and a slight majority of commentaries. It is the most accepted way to understand the difficult Hebrew text. In all three interpretations, Gibeah/hills symbolize moral depravity in Israel. All three interpretations imply that a future war will be fought against the moral depravity in Israel. It will be analogous to the past war fought in Gibeah. Interpretation (1) states this most directly. Interpretation (2) implies it by way of comparison with the past war in Gibeah. Just as the sins in Gibeah resulted in war in the past, so too the sins of Israel will result in a future war. Interpretation (3) implies it in a different way. The past war against Gibeah did not eradicate moral depravity. The people of Israel continued to sin in similar ways. In Hosea’s time a war against the moral depravity of Israel had not yet been fought. But it will come.

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- As a rhetorical question. The expected answer is “yes.” For example:

Will not war overtake them in Gibeah? (REB)

- As a statement. For example:

War will overtake the wicked people in Gibeah.
(GW)

But war will surely overwhelm them in Gibeah, because of the evil they have done there. (NCV) The NCV shows an alternative understanding of two Hebrew words. The Hebrew word for “not” is understood here to be a particle meaning, “surely” or “indeed.” Thus instead of saying, “will not war overwhelm them” it is, “war will surely overwhelm them.” For more detail see Andersen and Freedman (page 564) and Hubbard (page 177). Secondly, the Hebrew word for “against” is understood here to indicate, “because of.” Thus, instead of saying a war is “against evildoers” it is a war “because of the evil they have done there.” See Hubbard (page 177).

overtake: The Hebrew word here means to “catch up to” or to “take hold upon” something or someone.TWOT (#1422). Here are other ways to translate this word:

overwhelm them (NCV)

catch up with them (GNT)

will soon experience

the sons of iniquity: The Hebrew phrase is literally, “sons of injustice.” The Hebrew word for “injustice” means to act contrary to what is right.TWOT (#1580b). The Hebrew word in the Masoretic text has two letters transposed. That word is unknown. But other Hebrew manuscripts have this word, so most scholars assume that this is the correct word here. See Macintosh (page 412). Here the expression refers to people that are as evil as those at Gibeah.

in Gibeah: The word “gibeah” literally means “hills.” Here the word Gibeah is probably a word play. It refers both to the city of Gibeah and also to the hills that Hosea calls “high places” in 10:8a, where the Israelites worshiped idols.If so, this would be similar to the word play on Jezreel in 1:11d and 2:22–23. This understanding is supported by Stuart (page 168) who suggests that Gibeah may be a double-entendre, which could be translated as “in the hills.” Also Hubbard (page 176) suggests that the accusation, “you have sinned,” together with the name Gibeah itself which means ‘hill,’ serves to connect v 9 to v 8, where Bethel is called the sin of Israel and the hills are summoned to fall on the Israelites.

It is recommended that you add a footnote to explain the meaning. For example:

Gibeah means “hills.” See Hosea 10:8.

Hosea 10:10

Section 10:9–15: The LORD will punish Israel

In this section, the LORD (10:9–11) and Hosea (10:12–15) warn the people of Israel that the LORD will punish them because of their past and current sin. This section includes figures of speech from agriculture that the Israelites in Hosea’s time would clearly understand. Some examples are comparisons of the people to farm animals (10:11) and to farmers (10:12–13).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Pronounces Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord Promises to Punish Israel (CEV)

Paragraph 10:9–10

In this paragraph, the LORD is the speaker. He traces the sin of the people of Israel back to their ancestors in the city of Gibeah. Verse 10:10 is a warning that punishment will come as a result of their past and present sin.

10:10a

I will chasten them when I please;

- I will discipline them according to what I decide.
- When I am ready, I will punish them.

I will chasten them when I please: There is a textual issue regarding the Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as when I please:

1. The Masoretic text has “according to my desire.” This phrase indicates that the LORD will discipline or punish them at a time and in a manner that he determines.McComiskey (page 173), Keil (page 86), Macintosh (page 414), Wood (page 210), Kidner (page 96), and Davies (page 244). For example:

Now whenever it fits my plan, I will attack you, too. (NLT) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NET, NIV, NLT)

1. The LXX has “I have come.” This phrase indicates that the LORD has come or will come in order to punish them. For example:

I am coming to punish them (NJB) (NAB, NJB, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with the majority of versions. Here is another way to translate this verse part:

I will punish them when I’m ready. (GW)

I will chasten them: This clause is literally, “and I will discipline them.” The Hebrew word “discipline” means to correct someone in order to educate them.TWOT (#877).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I will discipline them (NET)

I will chastise them (NASB)

10:10b

nations will be gathered against them to put them in bondage for their double transgression.

- I will cause nations to war against them and tie them with chains because of their two sins.
- Because of their many sins, nations will send their armies to attack and imprison them.

nations will be gathered against them: This is a passive clause. It is implied that the LORD will cause nations to gather. In some languages, it may be more natural to use an active verb here. For example:

I will gather nations together to attack them (NET)

nations: The Hebrew word often means “peoples” or nations. TWOT (#1640a). The word can also mean “armies” or “troops.” DCH (page 431). In this context of war, the word specifically refers to armies or troops that are gathered and ready to attack Israel.

Here the word is plural. The plural form may indicate that this word refers to the Assyrian army, which consists of fighting men from various nations. It may also indicate that the LORD will use people from ungodly nations to discipline his own people. Macintosh (page 416).

Most English versions translate the word as nations here. It is implied that the reference is to the gathered armies of the nations. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this word as “armies” or “troops” or a similar word instead of a generic word such as nations or “people.” For example:

Armies will gather to attack them. (GW)

to put them in bondage: There is a textual issue regarding this phrase:

1. The Masoretic text has “to bind.” Also Targum. See McComiskey (page 173), Keil (pages 86–87), Macintosh (page 415), and Kidner (page 96). The word means “to tie, bind, harness or imprison.” TWOT (#141). For example:

to bind them in chains (NET) (BSB, CEV, ESV, NASB, NET, NIV)

1. The LXX has “to chastise.” Also Vulgate and Peshitta. It requires a change from *’ōsr* to *ysr*. See Andersen and Freedman (page 566), Hubbard (page 178), Davies (page 244), and Stuart (page 165). The word is the same as “chasten” in 10:10a. For example:

they will be punished for their many sins. (GNT)
(GNT, GW, NCV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It makes sense, fits the context, and does not require any changes to the Hebrew text.

for their double transgression: In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally “for their two iniquities.” This phrase is the reading/pronunciation recommended by the Masoretes (Qere). It is supported by all modern versions as well as the LXX and Peshitta. The phrase that is written in the MT (Kethib) is “for their two eyes.” The word “eyes” might refer to “rings.” The Targum mentions “its two rings.” No versions follow this option. See Soulen (page 100) for more information on Qere/Kethib issues.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

for their two sins (NET)

for their two crimes (NJB)

for: This word introduces the reason that the people of Israel will be bound. It is because of their sin. Use a word in your language that introduces a reason.

their double transgression: It is possible to understand this phrase literally or figuratively. If a literal meaning was intended, it is possible that the people knew implicitly which two sins these were. Commentators offer numerous suggestions. Some examples are: idolatry and reliance on foreign nations, rejection of God and David, Israel’s past and present sins. See Kidner (page 96). However there is no consensus among scholars on this issue. If the intended meaning was figurative, this phrase may be an idiom that meant their sins were serious and/or numerous. Stuart (page 169) suggests that the phrase may state metaphorically that Israel’s wickedness was extreme. Kidner (page 96) suggests that the phrase may mean Israel’s repeated or persistent acts of disobedience.

Here are two translation options for this phrase:

- Translate literally. For example:

their two sins (NET)

their double sins (NCV)

- Translate figuratively. For example:

their many sins. (GW)

your multiplied sins. (NLT)

Hosea 10:11

Section 10:9–15: The LORD will punish Israel

In this section, the LORD (10:9–11) and Hosea (10:12–15) warn the people of Israel that the LORD will punish them because of their past and current sin. This section includes figures of speech from agriculture that the Israelites in Hosea's time would clearly understand. Some examples are comparisons of the people to farm animals (10:11) and to farmers (10:12–13).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Pronounces Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord Promises to Punish Israel (CEV)

Paragraph 10:11

In this paragraph, the LORD continues to speak. He describes Israel by using an extended animal metaphor.

10:11a

Ephraim is a well-trained heifer that loves to thresh;

- ¶ “In the past, Israel was like a well-trained young cow that enjoyed threshing grain.
- ¶ “Israel was like an obedient heifer. She knew how to do the work, and she enjoyed the easy work of walking on the grain.

Ephraim is a well-trained heifer that loves to thresh: This clause is a metaphor that compares Ephraim to a heifer. Ephraim in its early years was similar to a well-trained heifer. Both of them were willing to obey and both had easy lives with only light work to do.

Here are some ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Use a metaphor. Make one or more similarities explicit if it will be helpful. For example:

Ephraim was a well-trained heifer that loved to thresh grain (NET)

Israel was a young heifer that loved the easy work of threshing grain.

- Use a simile. Make one or more similarities explicit if it will be helpful. For example:

Israel was like an obedient heifer. She was well-trained and enjoyed the easy work of treading out the grain.

In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “and Ephraim a trained heifer lover of to thresh.” The clause could refer to past, present or future.

Here are the two main interpretations:

1. It refers to a time in the past. Favored by Macintosh (page 420), Stuart (pages 169–170), Hubbard (page 180), and Davies (page 245). For example:

“Israel was once like a well-trained young cow, ready and willing to thresh grain. (GNT) (CEV, ESV, GNT, NET, NJPS, NRSV)

1. It refers to the present. McComiskey (page 176) suggests that the analogy is to depict Israel in the long period before the exile. For example:

Ephraim is a well-trained heifer that loves to tread the grain. (NJB) (BSB, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It matches the pattern of other metaphors in the chapters and verses surrounding this one. Those metaphors depict Israel in her early years, when the LORD chose her to be his people. The metaphors contrast this with Israel in her later years, when the people rebelled against the LORD. For example, see Hosea 9:10; 10:1; 11:1–5.

Ephraim: The tribe of Ephraim is probably a figure of speech (synecdoche) that represents all the people of the nation of Israel. Some versions make “Israel” explicit here. For example:

Israel was once like a well-trained young cow (GNT)

well-trained heifer: The word heifer refers to a young (female) cow that has not yet given birth. A well-trained heifer is gentle, follows commands, and is easy to control. See Hubbard (page 180), Macintosh (page 417), and Andersen and Freedman (page 567).

loves to thresh: Probably the heifer separated stalks from grain by walking on them. Some commentators

suggest that the calf may have pulled a sledge or other device. For example, Kidner (page 98). This is not likely, however, since the next clause suggests that only later was the calf harnessed, probably for the first time. It enjoyed threshing, because the work was easy and it was able to eat while it threshed. See Macintosh (page 418), Keil (page 87), Hubbard (page 179), Wood (page 210), and Kidner (page 98).

10:11b

but I will place a yoke on her fair neck.

- But I will place a yoke for plowing on her fine/sleek, strong neck.
- But now I will attach a harness for doing hard work to her firm, beautiful neck, even though she is not accustomed to it.

but I will place a yoke on her fair neck: This clause continues the metaphor of the heifer. There is a textual issue here:

1. Some scholars think that the original text was “and I put a yoke on its fair neck.” Halévy, Rudolph: ‘I passed a yoke over (her neck),’ cited in Macintosh (page 421). Also Stuart (page 165). This may be the basis for the Peshitta (Lamsa translation): “I bent her neck under the yoke.” For example:

But I decided to put a yoke on her beautiful neck (GNT) (BSB, CEV, The CEV has: “harness” here instead of “yoke.” The word “harness” is apparently taken from the following clause. GNT, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, The NET has: “put a fine yoke on her neck” instead of “put a yoke on her fine neck.” NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT)

1. The Masoretic Text has “and I passed over the fairness of its neck.” This clause refers to the time before a yoke was placed on the heifer’s neck. Favored by Hubbard (page 180) and Davies (page 245). For example:

and I spared her fair neck (NRSV) (ESV, NRSV)

Some versions are ambiguous. For example, the KJV may or may not imply that a yoke was placed upon the heifer’s neck: Keil (page 87) suggests that the MT word means “to treat harshly” and that it refers to putting a heavy yoke upon the neck. This meaning would correspond to option (1) rather than (2). The ASV and KJV may reflect this meaning.

but I passed over upon her fair neck (KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with the most versions. The main distinction between option (1) and option (2) is the time period in view. In option (1) the time reference is to the period when the yoke is placed on the calf. It marks the time when the calf’s life of ease has ended. In option (2) the time reference is to the period before the yoke is placed on the calf. It continues to describe the calf’s life of ease when it loved to thresh. There is no disagreement that the work of plowing depicted in the next clause requires that the calf will have a yoke or harness at that time. This clause indicates that the easy life of the heifer is finished. It introduces the time for heavy work to begin.

but I: In this context, there are two main ways to interpret the function of the word that begins this clause:

1. The word indicates contrast. For example:

But I will put a heavy yoke on her tender neck. (NLT) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, NASB, NJB, NLT, NRSV) The ESV and NRSV introduce this clause with “and.” They have been listed here as indicating contrast because they introduce the next clause with “but,” so the overall meaning is contrastive.

1. The word indicates result. For example:

so I will put a yoke on her fair neck (NIV) (NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. Several versions leave the connection implied. These versions have not been listed.

yoke: A yoke is a bar or frame that is attached to the necks of (normally) two work animals. In the context of 11c–e, the yoke is attached by a harness so that they can pull a plow or harrow. Webster’s New World Dictionary “yoke,” “harness.”

fair neck: This phrase is literally “goodness of its neck.” It refers to the neck of an animal that has not yet been yoked to do hard work, but is well suited for it. Versions translate “goodness” in a variety of ways:

- Most versions use a term that refers mainly to appearance. For example:

fair (ESV)

beautiful (GNT)

sleek (NJPS)

- The NJB has “fine.” This term could refer to appearance or strength.
- The CEV has “powerful.”

Try to use a term or combination of terms that can refer to both appearance and strength. Commentaries define “goodness of neck” in a variety of ways. Stuart (page 169–170) focuses entirely on strength. Hubbard (page 180) says it is “strong, well-proportioned.” Macintosh (page 418) suggests “firmness of her neck” and specifies “not so much beautiful but well formed and apt for his purpose.” McComiskey (page 176) focuses more on appearance: “the sleek beauty of the animal’s neck.” Lange (page 81) also focuses on appearance: “beauty, alluding to her fatness.”

10:11c–e

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning: Andersen and Freedman (page 568) suggest that these are three parallel lines of a tricolon.

^{11c} I will harness **Ephraim**,

^{11d} **Judah** will plow,

^{11e} and **Jacob** will break the hard ground.

I will harness Ephraim, Judah will plow, and Jacob will break the hard ground: This part of the metaphor compares Ephraim, Judah and Jacob implicitly to farm animals that do heavy work. The similarity is that their lives will soon become more difficult.

Here are some ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Use a metaphor. Make the implicit similarity explicit if it will be helpful. For example:

I will harness her for harder work. I will make Judah pull the plow and Israel pull the harrow.

- Use a simile. Make one or more similarities explicit if it will be helpful. For example:

Like hard-working farm animals I will make Ephraim break up the hard ground. Judah must plow, and Jacob must harrow.

Ephraim, Judah...Jacob: These three names represent all the people of Israel. Ephraim represents those in the northern kingdom. Judah represents those in the southern kingdom. Jacob may represent the entire

kingdom, both north and south. Hubbard (pages 180–181).

10:11c

I will harness Ephraim,

- Yes, I will make Ephraim/Israel plow,
- I will make her life difficult, like animals that have to pull a plow to break up the hard ground.

I will harness Ephraim: This clause is literally “I will cause to draw/harness Ephraim.” It means to attach the yoke and harness to the plow and then make the animal pull it. It implies that a farmer drives or directs the animal. See McComiskey (page 177), Davies (page 245), and BDB (page 939a, sense 2).

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

I will make Ephraim break the ground (NRSV)

I shall put Ephraim into harness (NJB)

...make her work hard in the field (NCV)

10:11d

Judah will plow,

- and I will also force Judah to plow.
- I will also make Judah’s life difficult in the same way.

Judah will plow: To plow is to drag a farm implement that digs into the hard soil and breaks it into bigger chunks that can then be harrowed. NIDOTTE (#3086), ISBE (plow).

10:11e

and Jacob will break the hard ground.

- Then I will make Jacob harrow the soil/ground to make it smooth/level.”
- I will force both Israel and Judah to break up the clods/chunks of dirt and level the ground to prepare it for planting.”

Jacob will break the hard ground: The Hebrew phrase is more literally, “Jacob will harrow for itself.” To harrow is to break up the clods after plowing and to level the soil to prepare it for planting. Kimchi cited in Macintosh (page 419).

In the Masoretic Text, this clause ends with the Hebrew phrase “for/by himself.” This phrase may mean for his own benefit or that he is alone. See McComiskey (page 177). You may translate it either way. You may follow versions that leave implicit the Hebrew phrase “for/by himself.” Or you may follow versions that translate it literally. For example:

Jacob must harrow for himself. (NRSV)

Hosea 10:12

Section 10:9–15: The LORD will punish Israel

In this section, the LORD (10:9–11) and Hosea (10:12–15) warn the people of Israel that the LORD will punish them because of their past and current sin. This section includes figures of speech from agriculture that the Israelites in Hosea's time would clearly understand. Some examples are comparisons of the people to farm animals (10:11) and to farmers (10:12–13).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Pronounces Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord Promises to Punish Israel (CEV)

Paragraph 10:12–15

Hosea is the speaker in this paragraph. He speaks to the people directly, using second person pronouns such as “you” and “yourselves.” He urges the people to seek the LORD instead of sinning as in their past. He also warns them how terrible the future judgment will be.

10:12–13

In 10:12–13, there is a new metaphor that compares Israel to a farmer. This replaces the metaphor of Israel as a heifer in 10:11.

10:12a–c (combined/reordered)

- ¶ I/Hosea said, “Break up your^(plur) hard ground that needs to be plowed. Plant seeds of righteousness. Harvest a crop of faithful love.

10:12a–c is a saying about sowing and reaping. It has a different purpose from the saying about sowing and reaping in Hosea 8:7a–b. Here Hosea urges the people to begin living righteous lives. Stuart (page 170) suggests that these words are a call to the people to return to “a status that should have existed all along (see Deut 4:31; Lev 26:45).” McComiskey (177) says the meaning is that “people are to guide their actions in life by righteousness.”

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning: Stuart (page 170) suggests that these are three lines of a triplet.

^{12a} Sow for yourselves **righteousness**

^{12b} and reap **the fruit of loving devotion**;

^{12c} break up **your unplowed ground**.

10:12a–b

Sow for yourselves righteousness and reap the fruit of loving devotion: This is a metaphor. It compares people who live in righteous ways to people who plant seeds and then harvest a crop. Stuart (page 170) suggests that the prepositions which precede the terms “righteousness” and “loving devotion” may function virtually as direct object markers. Examples: Gen 1:5; Jer 40:2; 1 Chr 16:37. See also BDB (#3926) 3. b. and Gesenius (page 366, chap. 117n). People who plant seeds of righteousness will harvest a crop of unfailing love. These commands are more literally “sow for yourselves to righteousness reap according to love.” All versions except the KJV and NASB interpret these commands as referring to what people should sow and reap. The KJV has: “Sow...in righteousness, reap in mercy.” The NASB has: “Sow with a view to righteousness, reap in accordance with kindness.” These versions appear to focus on manner or intent of sowing and reaping. Macintosh (page 422) suggests that the prepositions “to” and “according to” denote the principle with regard to which an action is accomplished. Hubbard (page 181) states similarly that “righteousness” and “love” describe the manner in which true sowing and reaping take place.

Here are some ways to translate these two commands:

Sow for yourselves righteousness; reap steadfast love (NRSV)

Sow justice, and reap loyalty. (REB)

Here are three ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

I said, ‘Plant the good seeds of righteousness, and you will harvest a crop of love. (NLT)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

You should be people who are righteous, like someone who plants good seeds. The crop that you harvest later will be like a crop of love.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

Live righteous lives and love will be the result.

10:12a

Sow for yourselves righteousness

- ¶ I/Hosea said, “Plant the seeds of good and fair conduct.
- ¶ “You^(plur) should be like people who plant good seeds. You should do what is right and honest.

Sow for yourselves righteousness: To sow/plant righteousness is a figurative way to tell people to live righteous lives. righteousness is behavior that is fair and proper and conforms to the standards of the LORD’s covenant with Israel. Stuart (page 170), Dearman (pages 271–272) and McComiskey (page 177). It especially concerns good relationships between people. Wood (page 211) and Keil (page 87). The meaning of the Hebrew word for righteousness includes being loyal, honest and just. TWOT (#1879b).

Here are other ways to translate this command:

Plant goodness (NCV)

Sow saving justice for yourselves (NJB)

Sow: This word implies planting seeds. Some versions make “seeds” explicit. For example:

I said, ‘Plant the good seeds of righteousness (NLT)

scatter seeds of justice (CEV)

for yourselves: In Hebrew, this phrase emphasizes the importance of the command for the people Hosea is addressing. The technical term for the phrase “for yourselves” is “ethical dative.” Macintosh (page 422) states that the ethical datives here give emphasis to the significance of the recurrence in question for a particular subject. Andersen and Freedman (page 568) say that ethical datives highlight the immediacy of the direct address. Some versions, including the NLT and CEV quoted above, do not make this phrase explicit.

10:12b

and reap the fruit of loving devotion;

- Harvest loyal love and kindness.
- Then you will experience faithful love. This love and kindness will be like a crop that you^(plur) harvest.

reap the fruit of loving devotion: The Masoretic Text has literally “reap to a mouth of loyalty/love.” Most

commentaries and versions understand the words “a mouth of” to mean “according to.” See Macintosh (page 422) and BDB (#6310). The word fruit may be derived from the LXX translation of the word. See the following footnote. This clause is a figurative way to tell people that righteous conduct will result in love.

reap the fruit: The word reap normally means to harvest ripened grain or fruit. Some versions make it explicit that love is a figurative crop or fruit. The LXX has “fruit of life.” This may indicate that the source Hebrew manuscript for the LXX also had the word “fruit.” It is also possible that the LXX translators regarded “fruit” to be implicit in the Hebrew text and chose to make it explicit. For example:

and you will harvest a crop of love (NLT)

harvest the fruit of loyalty (NCV)

loving devotion: This is the kind of love that conforms to the standards of the LORD’s covenant with Israel. Stuart (page 170) and McComiskey (page 178). The meaning of the Hebrew word for loving devotion includes being loyal, faithful, gracious, kind and merciful. TWOT (#698a). See also the note on “loving devotion” at 4:1c.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

harvest faithfulness (CEV)

Reap loyalty (REB)

10:12c

break up your unplowed ground.

- Plow for yourselves^(plur) your uncultivated ground.
- Break up your hardened ground.

break up your unplowed ground: This command is part of the metaphor in 12a–b that compares the people of Israel to people who plant seeds and then harvest a crop. In order to plant seeds they must first prepare the ground by loosening up the soil. In this metaphor the hard, unplowed ground is similar to the people’s stubborn hearts or minds. That hardness must become soft. Then they will be willing to start living according to righteousness and love. See Keil (pages 87–88), Davies (page 246), and McComiskey (page 177).

The Hebrew clause is more literally “plow for yourselves unplowed-ground.” See the note on “for yourselves” under 12a–b above.

Here are some ways to translate this command:

General Comment on 10:12a–c

- Keep the metaphor. Make the implicit similarity explicit if it will be helpful. For example:

Plow up the hard ground of your hearts (NLT)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. Make the implicit similarity explicit if it will be helpful. For example:

Loosen your hard hearts/livers like people break up hard ground for planting.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

Open your hearts/minds and start following the ways of the LORD.

In some languages, it may be confusing that the command to prepare the ground in 12c follows the commands to sow and reap in 12a–b. A farmer will normally break up unplowed ground first, before he sows and reaps. For that reason, it may be preferable to rearrange the order of these three clauses. See 10:12a–c (combined/reordered) in the Display.

10:12d

For it is time to seek the LORD

- The time has come to turn from your^(plur) sins and worship/serve Yahweh
- For now is the time to turn to Yahweh and begin to worship/serve him.

For it is time to seek the LORD: There is a textual issue here:

1. The Masoretic Text has “and it is time.” For example:

break up your fallow ground; It is time to seek the Lord (REB) (BSB, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The LXX has “of knowledge.” For example:

plow the new ground of knowledge (NCV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and commentaries.

In the Hebrew text, this clause begins with a conjunction that often means “and.” However, in this context, it probably introduces a reason. The reason to sow

righteousness, reap love and break up hard ground is because it is time to seek him. Some versions make it clear that this is a reason by using a word such as “for.” For example:

Break up the unplowed ground for yourselves, for it is time to seek the LORD (NET)

Some versions leave it implied that this is a reason. Some use punctuation to indicate it. For example, the NJB has a colon that implies reason:

break up your fallow ground: it is time to seek out Yahweh (NJB)

it is time: This phrase indicates that the people should not delay to seek the LORD. The words may add a sense of urgency to the command. Keil (pages 87–88) and Davies (page 246) both suggest that the force of the command is equivalent to the English expression “it is high time.” This expression means that it should have happened a long time ago. See *The Free Dictionary* by Farlex. Some versions make this urgency explicit. For example:

for now is the time to seek the Lord (NLT)

to seek the LORD: This phrase implies serious and persistent effort. It may refer to a time of distress or crisis in which the people turn away from their sin and turn to him in order to worship and serve him. Stuart (page 170) and Davies (page 246). For more information on what it means to seek the LORD, see the note on 3:5a.

10:12e

until He comes and sends righteousness upon you like rain.

- until he comes to cause you^(plur) to experience his goodness that is like refreshing rain/showers.
- Continue to worship/serve him until he returns to make you good and just and loyal.

until He comes and sends righteousness upon you like rain: In this clause, Hosea tells the people how long they should seek the LORD and what his response will be when they seek him.

until He comes: They should seek the LORD until He comes. This phrase is a figurative way to say that the LORD will restore his relationship with them. He will be gracious to them again. Keil (pages 87–88). This statement implies that previously the LORD had with-

drawn from them. Davies (page 247). See 5:6 and 5:15 for more information.

and sends righteousness upon you like rain: More literally, this clause part says “he will rain down righteousness on you.” The words like rain or showers imply that the righteousness he gives is refreshing and life-giving. Dearman (pages 271–272) and Stuart (page 170). The phrase indicates that the LORD will treat them justly and bless them according to what is right. Stuart (page 170) and McComiskey (page 178).

The word righteousness here is the same Hebrew word as in 12a, that the people are to sow. For the meaning of this word see the note on “Sow for yourselves righteousness” in 10:12a.

Here are some other ways to translate 10:12e:

until he comes and pours goodness on you like water. (NCV)

and I will come and pour out blessings upon you. (GNT)

Hosea 10:13

Section 10:9–15: The LORD will punish Israel

In this section, the LORD (10:9–11) and Hosea (10:12–15) warn the people of Israel that the LORD will punish them because of their past and current sin. This section includes figures of speech from agriculture that the Israelites in Hosea’s time would clearly understand. Some examples are comparisons of the people to farm animals (10:11) and to farmers (10:12–13).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Pronounces Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord Promises to Punish Israel (CEV)

Paragraph 10:12–15

Hosea is the speaker in this paragraph. He speaks to the people directly, using second person pronouns such as “you” and “yourselves.” He urges the people to seek the LORD instead of sinning as in their past. He also warns them how terrible the future judgment will be.

10:13a–c

In this verse, Hosea continues to speak directly to the people of Israel. These verse parts are another saying about sowing and reaping. It contrasts with the saying

in 10:12a–c. There, the saying figuratively reminds the people of Israel that the LORD requires them to be righteous and loving. But here the saying describes how the people actually lived. They were wicked and evil.

Notice the parallel parts:

^{13a} You have plowed **wickedness**

^{13b} and reaped **injustice**;

^{13c} you have eaten **the fruit of lies**.

10:13a

You have plowed wickedness

- But you^(plur) have planted/cultivated wrong thoughts and actions,
- But instead you have grown a crop of wickedness,

10:13b

and reaped injustice;

- and you^(plur) have reaped injustice.
- and you have harvested much evil.

10:13a–b

You have plowed wickedness and reaped injustice:

This is a metaphor. It compares people who live in wicked ways to people who plow (and by implication plant seeds) and then harvest a crop. People who plow wickedness will harvest a crop of evil.

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

You have planted wickedness and harvested evil. (GW)

You have plowed iniquity; you have reaped injustice (ESV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

You have been like people who plant wickedness and harvest a crop of evil.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

You have lived sinfully and are now full of evil.

In Hebrew, the contrast between 13a-c and 12a-c is implied. Some versions make it explicit by adding the word “but” to introduce this contrast. Use a natural way in your language to indicate this contrast.

You have plowed wickedness: This phrase contrasts with “sow for yourselves righteousness” in 12a. The Hebrew word for “plow” here probably implies sowing in addition to plowing. Macintosh (page 425). One method of growing crops was to scatter the seed and then plow it into the ground. This practice is mentioned by Hubbard (page 182), who suggests the following paraphrase: “But instead of all this, you have grooved (ploughed) into your way of life the seeds of iniquity.” Many versions use only the word plowed, but it may be better to use a word or phrase that more clearly shows the contrast to “sow.” For example:

cultivated (NLT)

planted (GNT)

The Hebrew word for wickedness means to do wrong. TWOT (#2222a), HALOT (electronic ed., page 1296). It is the opposite of the righteousness that God commanded them to sow in 12a. See Stuart (pages 170–171) and Macintosh (page 425).

and reaped injustice: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “you have reaped injustice/badness.” The phrase contrasts with “reap love” in 12b. It indicates that injustice is the result of wicked behavior. The word injustice is very similar to the Hebrew word for wickedness in 13a. Both words mean to do what is wrong. TWOT (#1580b). Hubbard (page 181) suggests that the word conveys a sense of violence in the doing of wrong. McComiskey (page 180) suggests that the word is often translated as “injustice” but in most occurrences it has the general sense of wickedness. Macintosh (page 425) suggests “what is wrong—opposite of goodness.”

10:13c

you have eaten the fruit of lies.

- It is as if the food/fruit you^(plur) have eaten is deception/lies.
- You have experienced the result of your lies/deception.

you have eaten the fruit of lies: This clause is part of the metaphor in 13a-b that compares the people of Israel to people who plant seeds and then harvest a crop. In this clause, the people of Israel are compared to people who eat fruit of deception/lies.

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

you have eaten the fruit of lies (NRSV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

It is as if deception has been your food.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

You have been deceitful in all you do.

In Hebrew, the word lies refers to either the act of lying or the lies that result from that action. TWOT (#975b), Andersen and Freedman (page 569). Stuart (pages 170–171) suggests “dishonesty.” Macintosh (page 425) and Wood (page 211) suggest “deceit.” To eat deception/lies is probably a figurative way to say that lies and deceit characterized the people’s conduct. Macintosh (page 425). Deception was normal behavior for them. See Hosea 11:12.

There are two main ways to understand the phrase fruit of lies. Either option is valid.

- The phrase fruit of lies means fruit that consists of deception/lies. The deception/fruit that Israel eats is the product of Israel’s wickedness and evil. Keil (page 88) and Davies (page 247). For example:

You have eaten lies, which is the fruit that your wickedness produced.

- The phrase fruit of lies means fruit that comes/ results from deception/lying. The fruit that Israel eats is the product of deception/lies. Andersen and Freedman (page 569). For example:

You have eaten the fruit that your lies produced. (GW)

10:13d

Because you have trusted in your own way and in the multitude of your mighty men,

- Because you^(plur) have trusted in your own power, in your many soldiers,
- You have confidence in your large army that is the basis of your strength.

Because you have trusted in your own way and in the multitude of your mighty men: There are two main ways to understand the relationship of this clause to the clauses that surround it:

1. This clause is related to the clauses that follow it. It gives the reason for the coming destruction (see 10:14). Wood (page 211), McComiskey (page 180), and Stuart (pages 170–171). For example:

^{13d}Because you have trusted in your own way and in the multitude of your warriors, ^{14a}therefore the tumult of war shall arise among your people, and all your fortresses shall be destroyed (ESV) (BSB, CEV, GNT, GW, ESV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NRSV, REB)

1. This clause is related to the clause that precedes it. It explains the deception/lies that Israel has eaten. Hubbard (pages 181–182) and Wood (page 211). For example:

^{13c}You have eaten the fruit of lies—^{13d}trusting in your military might, believing that great armies could make your nation safe. (NLT) (NJPS, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries. McComiskey (page 180) discusses several factors that support this option. One important factor is the change of number on the pronoun “you” from plural in 13a–c to singular here through verse 14. This indicates a break in the flow of thought and provides a connection between this clause and verse 14a.

Because: This word introduces the reason for the destruction that 10:14 tells about. Use a natural way in your language to introduce this reason.

you have trusted in your own way: In Hebrew, the pronoun you is plural in 13a–c. However, it is singular in this clause. Hosea may be thinking of the nation as one unit. See Davies (page 248). However, another option is suggested by Macintosh (page 426). He cites Kimchi, who proposed that the singular pronoun indicates Hosea is addressing the king of Israel. However, evidence in favor of this proposal is not sufficient to recommend it for translation. Translate the pronoun here and in 10:14 in a way that is natural in your language.

The word trusted means to place confidence in a person or an object.

way: There are textual and interpretation issues with the Hebrew word for strength:

1. The Masoretic Text has “you have trusted in your own way.” Here way should be interpreted as military strength or power. HALOT (electronic ed., page 231) sense 7. Favored by Andersen and Freedman (page 569), Hubbard (page 182), and Wood (page 211). HOTT recommends the MT with a B rating (almost certain), but it suggests the translation “on your way.” For example:

you have trusted in your power (NRSV) (CEV, GW, NCV, NIV, NLT, NRSV)

1. The LXX has “you have trusted in your chariots.” Favored by Stuart (pages 170–171) and Davies (page 248). The BHS editors suggest that the original reading of the word was *bārikbāka*, “in your chariots.” See the NET footnote on this word. For example:

you have trusted in your chariots (REB) (GNT, NET, NJB, REB, RSV)

1. The Masoretic Text has “you have trusted in your own way.” In this context, it may refer to the way that the nation of Israel conducts its affairs. HALOT (electronic ed., page 231) sense 4. Also McComiskey (page 180) and Macintosh (page 425) For example:

you have trusted in your way (NASB) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NASB, NJPS)

You may follow option (1) or (2). Both options make good sense in the context of military strength and the following reference to warriors. Most versions under option (3) also imply a trust in military strength here. All but the ESV use punctuation and wording that connect Israel’s reliance on their own “way” to reliance on their many warriors. The Display will follow option (1).

and in the multitude of your mighty men: In Hebrew, this phrase does not begin with the word and. The BSB and some other versions supply it. The absence of this word in Hebrew probably indicates that Israel’s strength consisted in their mighty men. The mighty men were not a separate item in addition to their strength.

Here are some ways to express the more accurate meaning:

...trusting in your military might, believing that great armies could make your nation safe. (NLT)

you have trusted in your power, in your great numbers of warriors (adapted from NJB)

The Hebrew word for “mighty man” means “strong or valiant man,” or “military hero.” HALOT (electronic ed., page 172) 1. “manly, vigorous” and 2 “(military) hero.” Also, McComiskey (page 180) and Andersen and Freedman (page 570).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

soldiers (NCV)

mighty men (KJV)

powerful forces (CEV)

Hosea 10:14

Section 10:9–15: The LORD will punish Israel

In this section, the LORD (10:9–11) and Hosea (10:12–15) warn the people of Israel that the LORD will punish them because of their past and current sin. This section includes figures of speech from agriculture that the Israelites in Hosea’s time would clearly understand. Some examples are comparisons of the people to farm animals (10:11) and to farmers (10:12–13).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Pronounces Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord Promises to Punish Israel (CEV)

Paragraph 10:12–15

Hosea is the speaker in this paragraph. He speaks to the people directly, using second person pronouns such as “you” and “yourselves.” He urges the people to seek the LORD instead of sinning as in their past. He also warns them how terrible the future judgment will be.

10:14

This verse gives the result of Israel’s self-reliance in 10:13d. An enemy will attack them. In Hebrew, this result is not explicit. Some versions make it explicit by using a word that introduces a result. For example:

therefore the tumult of war shall arise among your people (RSV)

So war will break out (CEV)

Use a natural way in your language to introduce a result.

10:14a

the roar of battle will rise against your people,

- that is why the sounds of war will be heard among your^(sing/plur) people,
- So war will begin/come against your people,

the roar of battle will rise against your people: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “an uproar will arise among your people.” This Hebrew phrase is a figure of speech (metonymy) that indicates a war against Israel will soon begin. This battle/war probably refers to the invasion of Israel by the Assyrian army. McComiskey (page 181), Wood (page 211). Many versions make it explicit that this clause refers to warfare. For example:

therefore the tumult of war shall arise among your people (ESV)

your people will hear the noise of battle (NCV)

Some versions do not include the metonymy, “an uproar will arise.” Instead, they state the meaning directly. For example:

war will come to your people (GNT)

10:14b

so that all your fortresses will be demolished

- and even your strongest fortresses will be destroyed.
- and all of your buildings and cities with thick stone walls will collapse.

so that all your fortresses will be demolished: This clause describes the war in more detail. The enemy army will destroy even the most well protected places in Israel.

The Hebrew word for fortresses means buildings or cities that have very thick, strong, stone walls to protect them. TWOT (#270g). For example:

and all your strong, walled cities will be destroyed (NCV)

All your fortifications will fall (NLT)

10:14c-d

as Shalman devastated Beth-arbel in the day of battle, when mothers were dashed to pieces along with their children: 10:14c-d gives an example to illustrate how severe the Assyrian war will be. The severity will be comparable to a past war. The Hebrew text and most versions introduce the comparison with a comparative word or phrase. For example:

as Shalman destroyed Beth-arbel on the day of battle (ESV)

just as when Shalman destroyed Beth-arbel (NLT)

It will be like the day when King Shalman destroyed the city of Betharbel in battle (GNT)

Use a natural way in your language to introduce the comparison.

10:14c

as Shalman devastated Beth-arbel in the day of battle,

- It will be like the terrible destruction of Beth Arbel when Shalman attacked it
- You^(sing/plur) will be completely destroyed just as when Shalman destroyed Beth Arbel on that day of battle,

as Shalman devastated Beth-arbel in the day of battle: This clause refers to a past battle that was no doubt known to the people in Hosea's time. Wood (page 211), Davies (page 248), McComiskey (page 181), and Stuart (page 166). Modern scholars, however, do not know who Shalman is, where Beth-arbel is, or when the battle occurred. Some scholars speculate that the name, Shalman, refers to Shalmaneser III or Shalmaneser V, past kings of Assyria, or else Salmanu, a king of Moab. Many scholars speculate that Beth Arbel may be modern day Irbid, Jordan.

the day of battle: This expression refers to the time that the battle occurred. Some versions leave this information implied.

Here are some other ways to say it:

in battle (GW)

when that battle happened

10:14d

when mothers were dashed to pieces along with their children.

- and bashed to death mothers with their children.
- when soldiers brutally slaughtered mothers and their children.

when mothers were dashed to pieces along with their children: This clause is more literally "mother with children was dashed in pieces." It describes the extreme brutality of the slaughter. It is possible that this is an expression that refers to extreme slaughter. In that case the meaning may not be limited to only mothers and/or children. Keil (page 88-89) calls it a proverbial expression denoting inhuman cruelty. Andersen and Freedman (page 571) suggests that "mother beside (or upon) children" is an idiom that may mean the murder of children in front of their parents before the parents were slain.

The Hebrew word for dashed to pieces means "to smite, smash, dash to pieces." TWOT (#2158). Andersen and Freedman (page 571), states that the verb can describe hurling of children against rock, dropping from a height, or smashing skulls.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

mothers and their children were crushed to death (GNT)

when mothers and their children were bashed to death. (NCV)

Hosea 10:15**Section 10:9-15: The LORD will punish Israel**

In this section, the LORD (10:9-11) and Hosea (10:12-15) warn the people of Israel that the LORD will punish them because of their past and current sin. This section includes figures of speech from agriculture that the Israelites in Hosea's time would clearly understand. Some examples are comparisons of the people to farm animals (10:11) and to farmers (10:12-13).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord Pronounces Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord Promises to Punish Israel (CEV)

Paragraph 10:12-15

Hosea is the speaker in this paragraph. He speaks to the people directly, using second person pronouns such as "you" and "yourselves." He urges the people to seek the LORD instead of sinning as in their past.

He also warns them how terrible the future judgment will be.

10:15a

Thus it will be done to you, O Bethel,

- Yes, terrible destruction like that will happen to you^(plur) at Bethel,
- You who live in Bethel, the same thing will happen to you,

Thus it will be done to you, O Bethel: This clause indicates that what will happen to Bethel is similar to what happened at Beth Arbel. Just like Shalman brutally destroyed that city, someone will brutally destroy Bethel also. The word Thus introduces this comparison.

Here are some other ways to introduce this comparison:

You will share that fate, Bethel (NLT)

So will it happen to you, O Bethel (NET)

it will be done to you, O Bethel: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “he/it will do.” In Hebrew this is a perfect verb form. In this instance, most commentators describe the verb as “prophetic perfect.” It describes future action as if it were already accomplished. See Keil (page 89), Hubbard (page 184), McComiskey (page 181), Andersen and Freedman (page 571) and Macintosh (page 431). to you Bethel.” The Hebrew clause does not specify the referent of “he/it.” There are two main interpretations:

1. The referent is intentionally impersonal. Macintosh (page 431). Hosea directs the reader’s attention to what will happen, not to who or what does the action. For example:

so it shall be done to you, Bethel. (NJB) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The referent is Bethel. Bethel, as the site of the evils of idolatry, has brought about the coming disaster. Keil (page 89) and McComiskey (page 181). Davies (page 249) lists this as one possibility. In this interpretation Bethel is the agent, not a vocative. For example:

So shall Bethel do unto you (KJV) (KJV, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

to you, O Bethel: There is a textual issue here:

1. The Masoretic Text has “to you Bethel.” For example:

so it shall be done to you, Bethel (NJB) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The LXX has “to you, House of Israel.” For example:

Thus it shall be done to you, O house of Israel (RSV) (RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. In support of option (1), Andersen and Freedman (page 572) notes that Bethel is a better parallel to Beth Arbel, especially as both are cities. Also, Bethel has symbolic importance as a shrine of antiquity and as center of the calf cult and its royal patronage in the northern kingdom.

In Hebrew, these words are literally “to you (plur) Bethel (sing).” The plural you probably refers to the individual people of the city of Bethel. In Hebrew, Hosea speaks directly to the city of Bethel as one would speak to a person. However, to address a city in this way may not be natural in some languages.

Here are some other ways to translate this vocative:

That is what will happen to you, people of Bethel (GNT)

Thus it will be done to you at Bethel (NASB)

Use a vocative that is natural in your language when a person speaks to a group of people.

10:15b

because of your great wickedness.

- because your evil is so terrible/extreme.
- because you are so very wicked/evil.

because of your great wickedness: This statement gives the reason why Bethel will be destroyed. Bethel was the center of worship of the calf idol, and it represented the extreme wickedness of Israel. Wood (page 211). In Hebrew, the word because here is literally “from-the face-of.” It is a Hebrew expression that means “by reason of.” HALOT (electronic ed., page 943) D.5.d.ii.

Here are some other ways to translate this statement:

because of the terrible evil that you have done
(GNT)

because you did so much evil. (NCV)

For your horrible wickedness (NJPS)

10:15c

When the day dawns, the king of Israel will be utterly cut off.

- When it is dawn, the king of Israel will not be there any longer.”
- As soon as the battle begins very early in the morning, the enemy will take away the king. There will be no more kings of Israel.”

When the day dawns, the king of Israel will be utterly cut off: This clause indicates that the enemy soldiers (Assyrian army) will quickly capture and imprison the king of Israel very early in the war. See 2 Kings 17:4, 5. Wood (page 211) and Stuart (page 172) note that the Assyrians under Shalmaneser V captured king Hoshea, the final king of Israel, even before the siege of Samaria began. Also see Macintosh (page 432) and Davies (page 249). Some versions make this meaning explicit. For example:

as swiftly as the passing of dawn, the king of Israel will be swept away. (REB)

When the day dawns: There is a textual issue here:

1. The Masoretic Text has “at the dawn.” For example:

At dawn the king of Israel will be completely cut off. (NRSV) (CBSB, EV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. Some scholars think that the original text was “in the storm.” For example:

In the storm the king of Israel shall be utterly cut off. (RSV) (RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions.

The word “dawn” refers to early morning just before sunrise.” It was common to start a battle early in the day to give the attackers the advantage of

surprise. According to Andersen and Freedman (page 572), an attack at dawn would have the advantage of surprise and give the soldiers an entire day to do battle. See also McComiskey (page 182) and Hubbard (page 184).

the king of Israel will be utterly cut off: This clause means that the Assyrians will take captive the king of Israel, king Hoshea. Stuart (page 172) and Davies (page 250). It also means that no other Israelite kings will rule after him. Andersen and Freedman (page 572), Keil (page 89), and McComiskey (page 182).

Here are some ways to translate this whole verse part:

at dawn, the king of Israel will be no more (NJB)

As soon as the battle begins at daybreak, the position of “king of Israel” will be gone.

This clause is more literally “the king of Israel destroyed he will be destroyed.” In Hebrew, this repetition intensifies the meaning.

Here are some ways to indicate this intensity:

the king of Israel will be completely destroyed.
(NIV)

the ruling of any king of Israel will completely end.

Hosea 11:1

Section 11:1–11 The LORD’s love for his people

This section refers back to Israel’s history, as do Section 9:10–17 and Section 10:1–8. In all three sections, the LORD describes the joyful beginning of his relationship with the people of Israel and their response of betrayal against him. The earlier sections focus more on the LORD’s punishment. The people will be taken into exile. This section focuses more on his love.

The LORD speaks of his love for Israel in the past (11:1–4), warns them of their future exile and destruction (11:5–7), and assures them that in the future he will turn from his anger and show them compassion. Because of his love for them, he promises that he will bring the people back to the land of Israel (11:8–11).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord’s Love for Israel (ESV)

Israel Is Like a Bad Son (GW)

Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. When he refers to himself, he uses first person pronouns (“I/me/my”) except for verse 10, which has “Yahweh” and “he.” When he refers to the people or nation of Israel, he uses “Ephraim,” “they/them,” or “he/it.” The only exceptions are in 11:8–9. There the LORD uses the pronoun “you(sg)” to speak directly to Ephraim and to Judah.

Paragraph 11:1–4

In this paragraph, the LORD describes his love and care for the nation of Israel during its early days.

11:1

This verse uses a metaphor that compares the nation of Israel to a child/son. It also compares the LORD to the loving parent of the child. The figure of speech here may refer indirectly to Exodus 4:22, 23. There it says:

²²Then say to Pharaoh, ‘This is what the Lord says: Israel is my firstborn son, ²³and I told you, “Let my son go, so he may worship me.”....’ ”

11:1a–b

(combined/reordered)

- Yahweh says, “When I called/told the people of Israel to leave Egypt, I loved them and chose them to be my own children.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{1a} When Israel was a child, **I loved him,**

^{1b}and out of Egypt **I called My son.**

11:1a

When Israel was a child, I loved him,

- ¶ “When the nation of Israel was still a child, I showed my love to him.
- ¶ Yahweh says, “I have loved Israel from the time he was a child.

When Israel was a child, I loved him: These clauses refer to the time when Israel became a new/young nation during the exodus from Egypt. Hosea uses a similar figure of speech in 2:15. There he compares Israel to a young female. It says “the days of her youth, as in the day she came up out of Egypt.”

In some languages, it may be more natural to reverse the order of the clauses. For example:

I loved Israel when he was a child.

child: The Hebrew word for child is masculine here. It can refer to a very young boy just weaned or to an older child or young man. TWOT (#1389a) In 11:3, it describes a young child who is still learning to walk and needs the protection and care of his parents. Hubbard (pages 186–187) Use a word in your language that refers to a young male child of that age.

loved: The Hebrew word for “love” has a broad range of meaning. In this context, it refers to the deep love, affection and loyalty that a father has for his son. Stuart (page 177, 178) and McComiskey (page 184)

11:1b

and out of Egypt I called My son.

- I summoned my son to leave Egypt.
- I led him out of Egypt and called him my son.

and out of Egypt I called My son: This clause refers to Israel’s past, when the LORD delivered the people of Israel from slavery in Egypt.

Matthew 2:15 also quotes this clause. There the phrase “My son” refers to Christ.

called: In this context, the Hebrew word for called may have two meanings simultaneously: See HALOT (electronic edition, page 1128): I A5 “to call, summon” and A2 “give someone a name.”

1. “to summon”
2. “to name/designate”

Both meanings apply to Israel at the time when they left Egypt. On that occasion, the LORD named/adopted Israel as his son. It was also when he summoned the people of Israel to leave Egypt. Andersen and Freedman (page 577), Keil (page 89), Stuart (page 178), Dearman (Kindle Location 3650), Macintosh (page 437), McComiskey (page 184) and Hubbard (page 187). For example:

And called him out of Egypt as my son. (GNT)

In many languages, it may not be possible to translate both meanings simultaneously. Many versions follow meaning (a) and leave meaning (b) implied.

General Comment on 11:1

In some languages, it may not be natural to refer to a nation as a child or a son (singular). It may be necessary to use plural terms such as children or sons. For example:

The Lord says, “I have great love for the descendants of Israel, who are like my children. When they were young, I called them to leave Egypt. (Tuwali Ifugao Back Translation)

It may also be more natural to combine and/or reorder the verse parts. For example:

The LORD says, ^{1b}“When I summoned the people of Israel to leave Egypt, ^{1a}I loved them and chose them to be my own children.

If you use plural terms, as in the preceding examples, consider adding a footnote for the benefit of readers who may not see the connection with Matthew 2:15. Here is a suggested footnote:

In the Hebrew language, this verse refers to Israel as “child (singular)” and “my son.” See Matthew 2:15.

Hosea 11:2

Section 11:1–11 The LORD’s love for his people

This section refers back to Israel’s history, as do Section 9:10–17 and Section 10:1–8. In all three sections, the LORD describes the joyful beginning of his relationship with the people of Israel and their response of betrayal against him. The earlier sections focus more on the LORD’s punishment. The people will be taken into exile. This section focuses more on his love.

The LORD speaks of his love for Israel in the past (11:1–4), warns them of their future exile and destruction (11:5–7), and assures them that in the future he will turn from his anger and show them compassion. Because of his love for them, he promises that he will bring the people back to the land of Israel (11:8–11).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord’s Love for Israel (ESV)

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Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. When he refers to himself, he uses first person pronouns (“I/me/my”) except for verse 10, which has “Yahweh” and “he.” When he refers to the people or nation of Israel, he uses “Ephraim,” “they/them,” or “he/it.” The only exceptions are in 11:8–9. There the LORD uses the pronoun “you(sg)” to speak directly to Ephraim and to Judah.

Paragraph 11:1–4

In this paragraph, the LORD describes his love and care for the nation of Israel during its early days.

11:2a

But the more I called Israel, the farther they departed from Me.

- But even though I repeatedly called the people of Israel, they continued to go farther away from me.
- But each time I instructed them, they turned farther away from me.

But the more I called Israel, the farther they departed from Me: There is a textual issue concerning the pronouns in this clause.

1. The LXX has “As I called/recalled them, so they went from me.” For example:

But the more I summoned them, the farther they departed from me. (NET) (BSB, GNT, GW, NAB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB, RSV)

1. The Masoretic Text has “they called them so they went from before them.” For example:

As they called them, so they went from them. (KJV) (KJV, NASB, NJPS) The ESV and CEV use passive constructions (“the more they were called, the more...”). The agent could be “I,” (as in the LXX), but it could also be something else.

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. It makes good sense in the context of 11:1b and is supported by the Syriac translation. The Syriac has “Just as they were called, so they went away from my presence.” Option (2) also has good support from commentaries and the Vulgate. Both Garrett (page 222) and Davies (page 254) mention the Vulgate. However, the unspecified referents of the pronouns they and “them” make the clause ambiguous and the meaning obscure. The ASV makes explicit that the referent of the first “they” is the prophets. Some commentaries propose other pronoun referents. For example, Macintosh (page 439) suggests that the Israelites call Egypt. Hubbard (page 187) proposes that the daughters of Moab or Canaanites call the Israelites. Some versions leave the referents implicit, so that the clause remains ambiguous.

But: The contrast between 11:1 and 11:2 is implied in both options, though many versions do not make it explicit. The BSB and some other versions make it explicit by adding the word But to introduce this con-

trast. Use a natural way in your language to indicate this contrast.

the more I called Israel, the farther they departed from Me: This clause compares the LORD's call to the people's response. Every time the LORD called them, their response was to withdraw from him. The words the more...the farther indicate this comparison. Here are some other ways to translate this comparison:

Every time I called them, they went farther away from me.

But the more I called to him, the more he turned away from me. (GNT)

Express this comparison in a natural way in your own language.

called: This is the same word as in 11:1 and may have the same meaning. See called in 11:1b. However, here the word may indicate calls in addition to the call out of Egypt in 11:1. The meaning may include the sense of "guide" or "instruct." Stuart (page 175) and Dearman (pages 280–281)

they departed from Me: This clause means that they deserted him to seek other gods instead of him. Wood (page 212)

11:2b–c (combined/reordered)

- And they kept offering animals and incense to false Baal gods.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{2b} They sacrificed **to the Baals**

^{2c} and burned incense **to carved images.**

They sacrificed to the Baals and burned incense to carved images: These parallel lines further explain the meaning of the statement "they departed from Me" in 11:2a. Dearman (pages 280–281) The people did not respond when the LORD called them to worship and obey him. They turned away from him to worship idols instead. The words sacrificed and burned incense frequently occur in parallel lines such as here. They describe two aspects of worship. Andersen and Freedman (page 578) The words translated as Baals and carved images are two ways to describe idols.

burned incense: See the note on 2:13a "the days of the Baals when she burned incense to them."

General Comment on 11:2b–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine the parallel parts in these two lines. For example:

They never stopped offering incense and sacrifices to the idols of Baal. (CEV)

11:2b

They sacrificed to the Baals

- Instead of worshiping me, they offered sacrifices to the Baal gods
- They made sacrifices to the Baals

11:2c

and burned incense to carved images.

- and burned incense when they worshiped idols.
- and offered incense to idols.

Hosea 11:3

Section 11:1–11 The LORD's love for his people

This section refers back to Israel's history, as do Section 9:10–17 and Section 10:1–8. In all three sections, the LORD describes the joyful beginning of his relationship with the people of Israel and their response of betrayal against him. The earlier sections focus more on the LORD's punishment. The people will be taken into exile. This section focuses more on his love.

The LORD speaks of his love for Israel in the past (11:1–4), warns them of their future exile and destruction (11:5–7), and assures them that in the future he will turn from his anger and show them compassion. Because of his love for them, he promises that he will bring the people back to the land of Israel (11:8–11).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord's Love for Israel (ESV)

Israel Is Like a Bad Son (GW)

Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. When he refers to himself, he uses first person pronouns ("I/me/my") except for verse 10, which has "Yahweh" and "he." When he refers to the people or nation of Israel, he uses "Ephraim," "they/them," or "he/it." The only exceptions are in 11:8–9. There the LORD uses the pronoun "you(sg)" to speak directly to Ephraim and to Judah.

Paragraph 11:1–4

In this paragraph, the LORD describes his love and care for the nation of Israel during its early days.

11:3a–b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{3a}It was I who taught **Ephraim** to walk,

^{3b} taking **them** in My arms,

These lines are metaphors that compare two things:

1. They compare the LORD to a father who loves and nurtures his child.
2. They compare Ephraim/Israel to his child.

11:3a**It was I who taught Ephraim to walk,**

- I myself taught my child Ephraim/Israel to walk.
- I was the one who guided the people of Israel like a father teaches his child to walk.

It was I who taught Ephraim to walk: In this clause, the LORD compares himself to a parent who teaches his child to walk. Andersen and Freedman (page 579).

It was I who: The Hebrew uses a pronoun for I that indicates emphasis. Some English versions express this emphasis by using special wording. For example:

I myself taught (NLT)

I was the one who taught (GW)

Other languages may be able to use an emphatic pronoun. You should express this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

Ephraim: In this clause, as elsewhere in Hosea, the name Ephraim refers to Israel. For example:

It was I who taught Israel to walk (NCV)

taught...to walk: This metaphor probably refers to the LORD's guidance and care of young Israel in the wilderness of Sinai. Dearman (pages 281–282), Andersen and Freedman (page 579).

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Use a metaphor. For example:

I myself taught Ephraim to walk (NJB)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

It was I who guided Israel like a father teaches his child to walk.

- Translate the meaning without a figure of speech. For example:

Yet it was I who led Ephraim (NET)

11:3b**taking them in My arms,**

- I picked my people up in my arms.
- I picked them up and carried them in my arms.

taking them in My arms: In the Masoretic Text, the first part of this phrase is more literally “he took them.” The LXX and Peshitta have “I...took him/them.” The last part of this phrase in the MT is literally “on his arms.” The LXX and Peshitta have “on my arm(s).”

The Notes will not discuss these and other textual issues separately, but will combine them with interpretation issues. The Notes will focus on two main ways to interpret the phrase as a whole:

1. This phrase means that the LORD took his child Ephraim up in his arms. For example:

I took my people up in my arms (GNT) (BSB, ESV, The ESV has been listed here because “took up by their arms” would normally be interpreted as picking a child up. This wording is unusual, however, because a parent who picks up a child does so by holding him under the arms, not by the arms. GNT, NAB, NASB, NJPS, NRSV, REB)

1. This phrase means that the LORD took his child Ephraim by the arm(s). For example:

I myself took them by the arm (NJB) (CEV, GW, KJV, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT)

You may follow either interpretation. They are supported by equal numbers of commentaries. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include Keil, McComiskey, Davies, and Macintosh. Commentaries that support interpretation (2) include Stuart, Garrett, Hubbard, and Wood. The Display will follow interpretation (1). This interpretation is supported by the LXX and Peshitta. It is also supported by a similar description of the LORD carrying

the Israelites through the wilderness like a child (Deuteronomy 1:31).

Interpretation (2) better fits the preceding context of a father teaching his child to walk, holding him by the arms as he guides him in the right direction. This understanding is supported by the lack of the conjunction “and” in the Hebrew text between 3a and 3b. The lack of “and” suggests that the second clause is closely connected to the first. See Hubbard (page 188). It is also supported by the similar description of the LORD guiding the Israelites through the wilderness by means of the cloud and fire (Exodus 40:36–38).

In interpretation (1), the LORD compares himself to a father who lifts his child to hold or carry him in his arms. This comparison may be a further description of what a father does in the overall process of teaching his child to walk. For example, when the child stumbles or grows weary, his father picks him up to give him comfort and encouragement. See Macintosh (page 444) and Pusey (page 111).

11:3c

but they never realized that it was I who healed them.

- But they would not admit that I was the one who had healed them. (CEV)
- But in spite of this, they refused to acknowledge that it was I who repeatedly healed them when they were sick/wounded and took care of them in other ways.

but: This clause contrasts with the previous one. Most versions use a word such as but or “yet” to indicate this contrast. Indicate this contrast in a natural way in your language.

they never realized that it was I who healed them: The LORD cared for the people of Israel as a father cares for his child. As a result, the people should have been grateful. However, they were not.

they never realized: In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally “they did not know.” There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew verb “know” here:

1. It means that they did not acknowledge or admit that the LORD was the one who healed them. For example:

But they would not admit that I was the one who had healed them. (CEV) (CEV, GNT, NET, NJPS)

1. It means that they did not know or realize that the LORD was the one who had healed them. For example:

but they did not know that I healed them (NRSV) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a slight majority of commentaries. Commentaries in favor of “did not acknowledge/admit” include Hubbard, Macintosh, Andersen and Freedman, Pusey, and Calvin. Hubbard (page 188) says that “the truth should have been obvious.” Andersen & Freedman (page 581) says, “The people are blamed for rejecting knowledge gained by experience of Yahweh’s healing, not for mere ignorance.” Commentaries in favor of “did not know/realize” include Davies, Garrett, McComiskey, and Wood. Wood (page 212) says that “they were blind to his healing purpose.” Garrett (page 223–224) says they “quickly forgot how the Lord repeatedly restored health.” At this time in Israel’s history, the LORD was leading his people through the desert, and Moses told them that it was the LORD who healed them (Exodus 15:26). So the people must have realized this. Much later, after they were settled in the land of Canaan, it is possible that everyone had forgotten these stories. See Joshua 24:31.

These words are similar to the phrase “she does not acknowledge” in 2:8a. See the comment there. In both places, the meaning is probably that the people were aware of the truth but refused to acknowledge it.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they have ignored My healing care. (NJPS)

They would not admit that I was the one who had healed them. (CEV)

healed: This word probably refers here to more than just physical healing. In this context, it refers to the many ways that the LORD helped Israel, especially in times of trouble in the wilderness of Sinai. The wider meaning of “heal” is mentioned by Keil (page 90), Dearman (page 282), Hubbard (page 188), and Davies.

However, the word definitely includes the idea of physical healing, and most of the versions used in TN use a form of that word. In Exodus 15:26, the LORD promised that if the people obeyed him, he would keep them from getting any of the diseases that he had caused the Egyptians to suffer, “For I am the LORD who heals you” (BSB). And in Numbers 21:6–10, the LORD directed Moses to provide a bronze snake on a pole. All those who had been bitten by poisonous snakes and would

have died were miraculously healed when they looked at the snake.

Some versions translate the word healed here as “cared for” or “took care of.” For example:

I took care of them (GNT)

If you translate the term in a similar way, it is recommended that you also use a term in your language that refers to physical healing. In the four other references in Hosea where a form of the Hebrew for “heal” occurs, it refers to physical healing or treating of wounds in 5:13 and 6:1 and to figurative healing of Israel from sin in 7:1 and 14:4. It does not occur elsewhere in Hosea in the generic sense of “take care of.” For example:

but they have ignored my healing care (NJPS)

but they refused to admit that it was I who healed them and cared for them.

Hosea 11:4

Section 11:1–11 The LORD’s love for his people

This section refers back to Israel’s history, as do Section 9:10–17 and Section 10:1–8. In all three sections, the LORD describes the joyful beginning of his relationship with the people of Israel and their response of betrayal against him. The earlier sections focus more on the LORD’s punishment. The people will be taken into exile. This section focuses more on his love.

The LORD speaks of his love for Israel in the past (11:1–4), warns them of their future exile and destruction (11:5–7), and assures them that in the future he will turn from his anger and show them compassion. Because of his love for them, he promises that he will bring the people back to the land of Israel (11:8–11).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord’s Love for Israel (ESV)

Israel Is Like a Bad Son (GW)

Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. When he refers to himself, he uses first person pronouns (“I/me/my”) except for verse 10, which has “Yahweh” and “he.” When he refers to the people or nation of Israel, he uses “Ephraim,” “they/them,” or “he/it.” The only exceptions are in 11:8–9. There the LORD uses the pronoun “you(sg)” to speak directly to Ephraim and to Judah.

Paragraph 11:1–4

In this paragraph, the LORD describes his love and care for the nation of Israel during its early days.

11:4

This verse gives another example of the LORD’s love and care for the people of Israel. Here the example is a farmer or a herdsman who cares for his animals.

11:4a–b

(combined/reordered)

- When I led Israel, I used ropes/cords that were made of kindness and love.
- I led/guided them in kind and loving ways.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{4a} I led them with cords **of kindness**,

^{4b} with ropes **of love**;

There is an ellipsis in the second line. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from the first line. For example:

^{4b} I led them with ropes **of love**.

Each line is a metaphor that compares the way that the LORD led Israel to the way that a caring herdsman leads his animals.

I led them: The Hebrew word for led can mean to pull an animal with a rope. It can also have the figurative meaning “to lead a person.” HALOT (electronic edition, page. 645) and BDB (#4900). In this context, the word may refer to the time when the LORD led his people out of Egypt. Macintosh (page 445).

with cords of kindness, with ropes of love: These phrases describe how the LORD led his people. He did so with kindness and love.

The Hebrew words for cords and ropes have the same meaning. Both words mean “rope/cord.” HALOT II (electronic edition, page 286) and HALOT (electronic edition, page 783).

In Hebrew, the first phrase is literally “with ropes of human.” The meaning may be that these ropes are intended to guide humans in contrast to ropes for animals. The phrase indicates kindness or gentleness instead of harshness. Keil (page 90). An alternative suggestion by Garrett (pages 224–225) is that the phrase “human ropes” refers to Moses. Another is that the intended meaning is “leather ropes,” as in the NET. Neither alternative has significant scholarly support.

The parallel phrase ropes of love has a similar meaning. It implies that the LORD showed love toward his people when he led them. He was like a gentle herdsman who cared for his animals with compassion. Macintosh (page 448) suggests that Yahweh is depicted as leading Israel as a considerate farmer, who from time to time leads his beast away from the rigors of plowing for rest and refreshment.

11:4a

I led them with cords of kindness,

- I led them with ropes made of kindness,
- Like a kind herdsman I led them gently with ropes.

11:4b

with ropes of love;

- with straps made of love.
- I guided them compassionately with cords.

11:4c

I lifted the yoke from their necks and bent down to feed them.

- I removed the yoke from their neck. I stooped down to feed them.
- I removed the load from their yoke and unfastened their harness/halter, and I bent down to feed them.

I lifted the yoke from their necks: This clause is more literally “and I was to them like [those who] lift a yoke on their jaws.” There are two main ways to interpret the Hebrew phrase “lift a yoke on their jaws:”

1. The phrase means to remove the yoke along with the harness. This interpretation is supported by the Syriac Peshitta. It has “I was to them as one who takes off the yoke from their neck.” For example:

and I became to them as one who lifts the yoke from their jaws (NASB) (BSB, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT)

1. The phrase means to lighten the weight on the yoke and loosen the harness. This interpretation is supported by the Targum that has “like the good ploughman who lightens the load on the oxen’s shoulder and gives leeway with the bridle.” For example:

and I became to them as one who eases the yoke on their jaws (ESV) (ESV, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. This interpretation is supported by HALOT. HALOT (electronic edition, page 1205) assigns the meaning “revoke, lift, take away”

to the verb phrase used in Hosea 11:4. However, some scholars think that interpretation (2) better fits the common usage of some of the Hebrew words in this phrase. The Hebrew phrase “lift a yoke” is not normally used for removing a yoke. The normal Hebrew expression is “break a yoke.” For example, see Genesis 27:40; Leviticus 26:13; Jeremiah 5:5; Ezekiel 34:27. Also, the Hebrew preposition “on” indicates that a yoke is on the animal, not removed from it. See Keil (page 90), Garrett (pages 224–225), and McComiskey (page 185). So it is recommended that you add a footnote with the other interpretation. For example:

Another interpretation of this phrase in Hebrew is: I became to them as one who lightens the weight of the yoke on their jaws.

Here is another way to translate this verse part:

I removed the yokes from their necks (GW)

The phrase lifted the yoke from their neck may refer figuratively to freeing the people of Israel from slavery. In this metaphor, their hardship was compared to the yoke that was attached by a harness so that the animal could pull a plow or cart.

yoke: There is a textual issue concerning the word yoke in this clause:

1. The Masoretic Text has yoke. For example:

and I became to them as one who lifts the yoke from their jaws (NASB) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, RSV)

1. Some scholars think that the original text had “infant.” Favored by Davies (page 257) and Hubbard (page 189). For example:

I was to them like those who lift infants to their cheeks. (NRSV) (CEV, GNT, NIV2011, NJB, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with a majority of versions and commentaries. This interpretation is favored by Dearman, Garrett, Kidner, Andersen and Freedman, Keil, Stuart, Wood, Macintosh, and McComiskey. Dearman (pages 282–285) sees parallels with Isaiah 30:28 “harness on the jaws” and Hosea 10:11 that depicts Israel as a heifer.

A yoke is an arched frame normally placed on the shoulders of a work animal at the base of its

neck. Andersen and Freedman (page 581). Generally the yoke is fastened to two animals and is attached to a cart or plow that they pull together. The word “yoke” can have negative or positive associations, depending on the kind of yoke. For example, 1 Kings 12:4 has: “Your father put a heavy yoke on us. But now you should lighten the burden of your father’s service and the heavy yoke he put on us, and we will serve you.” Whereas, Matthew 11:30 has: “For My yoke is easy and My burden is light.”

their necks: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “their jaws.” This probably indicates that here the word “yoke” refers both to the yoke and also to the halter or bridle around the animal’s jaws, that was used to direct the animal. Macintosh (page 446). See the 2nd ML in the Display for 11:4c for a way to make this explicit in your translation.

and bent down to feed them: The Hebrew phrase here is literally “and I bent down to him I fed.” There are three main interpretations of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as bent down:

1. The Hebrew word means “I bent down.” For example:

I bent down to them and fed them. (ESV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NKJV, NLT, REB, RSV)

1. The Hebrew word means “gently.” For example:

and gently fed them (NET) (NET)

1. The Hebrew word means “I offer.” For example:

and I laid meat unto them (KJV) (KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. It follows a common meaning of the Hebrew word. BDB (#5186). See Davies (page 257), Hubbard (page 189) and Wood (page 213). One grammatical difficulty with this interpretation is that the Hebrew text lacks a conjunction between “bent down” and “I fed.” Andersen and Freedman (page 583) point out, however, that a lack of conjunctions is typical of Hosea. Some scholars also support interpretation (2). Among those who support this understanding are rabbinic commentator, ibn Ezra, cited in Macintosh (page 446), Garrett, Keil, and McComiskey. However, only a small minority of versions follow it. In both interpretations, the LORD feeds them in a loving way.

feed them: The Hebrew text has “I fed.” English versions supply the object them or “him,” which is required to make the translation sound more natural in English. You may also need to supply an object here if it will sound more natural in your language.

General Comment on 11:4

The Hebrew text uses both plural and singular pronouns to refer to those whom the LORD cared for. In many languages, it is not natural to alternate pronouns in this way. Many versions translate all the pronouns in 11:4 as plural or else all the pronouns as singular. You should translate the pronouns in a natural way in your language. The Display uses plural pronouns, as in the BSB. An example of using singular pronouns is the NLT:

I led Israel along with my ropes of kindness and love. I lifted the yoke from his neck, and I myself stooped to feed him. (NLT)

Hosea 11:5

Section 11:1–11 The LORD’s love for his people

This section refers back to Israel’s history, as do Section 9:10–17 and Section 10:1–8. In all three sections, the LORD describes the joyful beginning of his relationship with the people of Israel and their response of betrayal against him. The earlier sections focus more on the LORD’s punishment. The people will be taken into exile. This section focuses more on his love.

The LORD speaks of his love for Israel in the past (11:1–4), warns them of their future exile and destruction (11:5–7), and assures them that in the future he will turn from his anger and show them compassion. Because of his love for them, he promises that he will bring the people back to the land of Israel (11:8–11).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord’s Love for Israel (ESV)

Israel Is Like a Bad Son (GW)

Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. When he refers to himself, he uses first person pronouns (“I/me/my”) except for verse 10, which has “Yahweh” and “he.” When he refers to the people or nation of Israel, he uses “Ephraim,” “they/them,” or “he/it.” The only exceptions are in 11:8–9. There the LORD uses the pronoun “you(sg)” to speak directly to Ephraim and to Judah.

Paragraph 11:5–7

In this paragraph, the LORD warns that Assyria will take the people of Israel into exile, because they continue to turn away from him.

11:5a–b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{5a} Will they not **return to the land Egypt**

^{5b} and **be ruled by Assyria**

In Hebrew, these lines are more literally “not he will return to the land of Egypt and Assyria it [will be] his king.” The interpretation of these lines depends on the function of the Hebrew word “not.” This word has two main functions here:

1. The word “not” introduces either a rhetorical question that implies a “yes” answer or a positive statement. This is one way to arrive at this interpretation. Three alternative ways are: (1) Follow the LXX, which apparently regarded the Hebrew word *lô* to be the Hebrew word for “to-him” at the end of 11:4, rather than the word “not” at the start of 11:5. See Davis (page 258). (2) Regard the *lô* to function as emphasis (“surely”). See Andersen and Freedman (page 584). (3) Regard the *lô* to function as an exclamation (“No!”). See NJPS. The BSB above translates it as a rhetorical question. An example of a positive statement is the NET:

“They will return to Egypt! Assyria will rule over them because they refuse to repent! (NET) (BSB, GNT, NIV, NCV, NET, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB) The GNT, NCV, NET, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, and REB all translate this interpretation as a positive statement instead of a rhetorical question.)

1. The word “not” introduces a negative statement. For example:

“They will not return to Egypt. Instead, Assyria will rule them because they have refused to return to me. (GW) (ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a majority of versions. The LXX “dwelt Ephraim in Egypt” seems to support interpretation (1). Wood, Davies and Stuart also support this interpretation. It is similar to statements about the people returning to Egypt in 8:13 and 9:3.

11:5a**Will they not return to the land of Egypt**

- ¶ “Will they not become slaves again, just as they were in Egypt?”
- ¶ “It will be as if they return to slavery in Egypt.”

Will they not return to the land of Egypt: This clause is the first line of the rhetorical question. The expected answer to this question is “Yes, they will return to Egypt.” This line is a figure of speech in which Egypt represents slavery. It means that the people will return to slavery. This slavery will be similar to their slavery in Egypt in Israel’s past. Also see the note “They will return to Egypt” under 8:13e.

Most versions translate this rhetorical question as a statement. For example:

They shall return to the land of Egypt (NRSV)

Translate this clause in a natural way in your language.

11:5b**and be ruled by Assyria**

- And will not the Assyrians take them captive and rule over them? Indeed, they will do so!
- But this time Assyria will be the nation to rule them.

and be ruled by Assyria: This clause is literally “and Assyria it [will be] his king.” It means that the people of Israel will become slaves in the nation of Assyria. They will no longer rule themselves.

In Hebrew, the word Assyria is emphasized here. The Hebrew clause has the independent pronoun “it”: “and Assyria it [will be] his king.” For example:

and it is Assyria, no one else, that will be his king

If possible, indicate this emphasis in a natural way in your language.

A king is normally a person, not a nation. For that reason, it may not be natural in some languages to say that Assyria will be their king.

Here are some other ways to say this:

and will not those from Assyria be the ones to rule over them

and it will be the Assyrians whom they must serve

11:5c**because they refused to repent?**

- This will happen because they refuse to turn away from their sins.
- Why? Because they refuse to turn away from their sins and return to me.

because they refused to repent?: There are two interpretations of the relationship of this line to those that come before and after it:

1. This line relates to the two lines that precede it. It gives the reason that the people will become slaves in Assyria. It is because they refuse to repent. For example:

The Israelites will become captives again, as they were in Egypt, and Assyria will become their king, because they refuse to turn back to God. (NCV) (BSB, GNT, NIV, NCV, NET, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. This line relates to the lines that follow it in 11:6. It gives the reason that the sword will flash in their cities and cause destruction. It is because they refuse to repent. For example:

They return to the land of Egypt, and Assyria is their king. Because they refuse to repent, a sword shall descend upon their towns... (NJPS) (NAB, NJB, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a majority of versions and commentaries. It is supported by both the Masoretic Text and the early versions.

repent: In Hebrew, this word is literally to “turn” or “return.” The same Hebrew word is used in 11:5a, where it refers to the people’s return to Egypt. Hosea probably used the same word here as a wordplay. The wordplay draws attention to the reason that the people will return to slavery. It is because they refuse to return to the LORD. See Dearman (pages 285–286), Garrett (pages 225–226), Macintosh (page 452) and Davies (page 258).

In some languages, it is possible to translate the wordplay directly by using the same word in 5a and 5c, as in Hebrew. For example:

They shall return to the land of Egypt, and Assyria shall be their king, because they have refused to return to me. (NRSV)

In some languages, it may not be possible to use the same word in both places. Translate this line in a natural way in your language.

Hosea 11:6**Section 11:1–11 The LORD’s love for his people**

This section refers back to Israel’s history, as do Section 9:10–17 and Section 10:1–8. In all three sections, the LORD describes the joyful beginning of his relationship with the people of Israel and their response of betrayal against him. The earlier sections focus more on the LORD’s punishment. The people will be taken into exile. This section focuses more on his love.

The LORD speaks of his love for Israel in the past (11:1–4), warns them of their future exile and destruction (11:5–7), and assures them that in the future he will turn from his anger and show them compassion. Because of his love for them, he promises that he will bring the people back to the land of Israel (11:8–11).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord’s Love for Israel (ESV)

Israel Is Like a Bad Son (GW)

Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. When he refers to himself, he uses first person pronouns (“I/me/my”) except for verse 10, which has “Yahweh” and “he.” When he refers to the people or nation of Israel, he uses “Ephraim,” “they/them,” or “he/it.” The only exceptions are in 11:8–9. There the LORD uses the pronoun “you(sg)” to speak directly to Ephraim and to Judah.

Paragraph 11:5–7

In this paragraph, the LORD warns that Assyria will take the people of Israel into exile, because they continue to turn away from him.

11:6a–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{6a} A sword will flash **through their cities;**

^{6b} it will destroy **the bars of their gates**

^{6c}and consume them **in their own plans.**

There is an ellipsis in the second and third lines. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from the first line. For example:

^{6b} swords will destroy **the bars of their gates**

^{6c}and swords will consume them **in their own plans**.

These three lines warn that an enemy will make war against the Israelites and will defeat them.

11:6a

A sword will flash through their cities;

- There will be war in their cities.
- The enemy will come and fiercely attack their cities.

A sword will flash through their cities: This line is more literally “and a sword will whirl in his cities.” The word sword is a figure of speech (metonymy) that represents “war.” Or the destructive power of war. Keil (page 91). This line says in a poetic way that an enemy will go to war against Israel.

The word flash means “whirl” or “twist.” The word describes the movement of a sword when used in an attack. Macintosh (page 452) and TWOT (#623). Here are some other ways to translate this line:

the sword will rage through his cities (NJB)

War will sweep through their cities (GNT)

11:6b

it will destroy the bars of their gates

- Their enemies will destroy the city gates.
- Their strong city gates will be broken down. They will not protect the people.

it will destroy the bars of their gates: This line continues to describe the enemy attack on the cities of Israel.

destroy: In Hebrew, this word means “destroy” or “exterminate.” DCH (Vol. 4, page 416). It can mean to destroy an object or a person. This line may refer to both actions. See the note below.

the bars of their gates: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the bars of their gates has various meanings. In this context, there are two main interpretations:

1. The word means bars. This word refers to metal bars that kept large city gates locked. HALOT II (electronic edition, p. 109). People would lock the city gates by sliding the bars into sockets in the wall. See the IVP Bible Background Commentary (electronic edition, Ho 11:6). This interpretation is favored by Keil (page

91), McComiskey (page 188) and Wood (page 213). This interpretation implies that the enemy will also break through the gates of each city to enter it and kill the inhabitants. For example:

It will destroy the bars of their city gates (NET) (BSB, ESV, GNT, GW, NASB, NET, NJB, NIV, NLT, RSV) Some versions translate “gates” instead of “bars.” For example, the GW has “city gates,” and the NLT has “gates.”

1. The word means “false prophets/priests.” HALOT (electronic edition, p. 109) V. This interpretation is favored by Stuart (page 180) and Hubbard (pages 191–192). These influential people claimed to represent the LORD, but they spoke lies to the king and his officials. For example:

and it will make an end of their priests (REB) (NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

11:6c

and consume them in their own plans.

- This will be the result of their useless schemes/plans.
- They will be destroyed because they trusted/followed bad advice.

and consume them in their own plans: This clause is literally “and it will devour from their schemes.” There are two main interpretations of this clause:

1. The clause means that their schemes/plans are the reason that the sword will devour them. For example:

and devour them because of their scheming (REB) (BSB, ESV, GNT, KJV, NASB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NRSV, REB)

1. The clause means that the sword will devour their schemes. For example:

and put an end to their plans (GW) (CEV, GW, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. This interpretation accounts for a causative particle *min* “from/because of” in the Hebrew clause.

Notice that in the Masoretic Text, this clause does not indicate what the sword devours. It says “and it will devour from their schemes.” Interpretation (1) assumes that one of the following options is true:

- The object of the verb “devour” is “the people.” This was understood implicitly by Hebrew readers. For example:

It will destroy my people because they do what they themselves think best. (GNT)

devouring them because of their plots (NJB)

- The verb “devour” is intransitive here, so it has no object. Hosea is giving attention to the reason for the devouring rather than to what is being devoured. McComiskey (page 188). This option is also favored by Macintosh (page 453–454). However, only a small minority of versions follow it. For example:

and devours because of their schemes. (NRSV)

Either option is acceptable. The Hebrew can be understood either way. Also the meaning difference is not significant. Even if the verb is intentionally intransitive here, the earlier parts of the verse make it clear that the cities, and by inference the people in the cities, will be attacked. Choose the option that is the most natural in your language.

consume: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as consume is literally “devour.” Here it is used figuratively to mean “slay” or “destroy.” BDB (#398) 4. For example:

destroy my people (GNT)

kill them (NCV)

them in their own plans: There is a textual issue with the Hebrew word for them in their own plans:

1. The Masoretic Text has “plans/schemes.” For example:

And devours because of their schemes (NRSV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. Some scholars think that the original text had the word “fortresses.” For example:

And will devour them in their fortresses (NET) (NET, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. Ancient versions also support this option.

The Hebrew word for their own plans means “their advice,” “their counsel,” or “their plan.” TWOT (#887b). Here it may refer especially to choices that the people of Israel made without seeking guidance from the LORD. These choices may include seeking help from idols or from Egypt. Macintosh (page 454), Hubbard (page 192) and McComiskey (page 188).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

their own evil plans (NLT)

their plots (NJB)

their scheming (REB)

they do what they themselves think best (GNT)

Hosea 11:7

Section 11:1–11 The LORD’s love for his people

This section refers back to Israel’s history, as do Section 9:10–17 and Section 10:1–8. In all three sections, the LORD describes the joyful beginning of his relationship with the people of Israel and their response of betrayal against him. The earlier sections focus more on the LORD’s punishment. The people will be taken into exile. This section focuses more on his love.

The LORD speaks of his love for Israel in the past (11:1–4), warns them of their future exile and destruction (11:5–7), and assures them that in the future he will turn from his anger and show them compassion. Because of his love for them, he promises that he will bring the people back to the land of Israel (11:8–11).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord’s Love for Israel (ESV)

Israel Is Like a Bad Son (GW)

Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. When he refers to himself, he uses first person pronouns (“I/me/my”) except for verse 10, which has “Yahweh” and “he.” When he refers to the people or nation of Israel, he uses “Ephraim,” “they/them,” or

“he/it.” The only exceptions are in 11:8–9. There the LORD uses the pronoun “you(sg)” to speak directly to Ephraim and to Judah.

Paragraph 11:5–7

In this paragraph, the LORD warns that Assyria will take the people of Israel into exile, because they continue to turn away from him.

11:7a

My people are bent on turning from Me.

- They persist in turning away from me.
- My people have committed themselves to abandon me.

My people are bent on turning from Me: The relationship of this line to the surrounding context is not clear. This line may be stating again the theme of turning away from the LORD as in 11:5. Some versions translate this line as a reason for the war described in 11:6 by starting the verse with the word “For.” The majority of versions leave implied the relationship of this line to the context. Translate the relationship of this line to the context in a natural way in your language.

bent on turning from Me: In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally “hung up to/on my apostasy.” Here the word “hung up” has the figurative meaning of “determined” or “fixated upon.” It means that the people will not change their attitude or behavior. McComiskey (page 189). The Hebrew word “to/on my apostasy” means to reject or rebel against the LORD. The Hebrew word “to my apostasy” is understood to mean apostasy/backsliding from “me” [the LORD]. Andersen and Freedman (page 586) suggest the case is ablative, indicating motion away from something. This is likely, since the word “apostasy,” as used in the OT, means the act of turning away from the LORD.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

My people are bent on turning away from me (ESV)

They insist on turning away from me (GNT)

my people are determined to desert me (NLT)

11:7b

Though they call to the Most High, He will by no means exalt them.

- Although they pray to the Most High, he will not help them at all.

- Even if they call to the Most High God, he will do nothing to help them.

Though they call to the Most High, He will by no means exalt them: In Hebrew, this sentence is literally “and to a height they call him together not he will exalt them.” This sentence has one main textual issue and various interpretations. The textual issue will be discussed first.

There is a textual issue concerning the Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as Most High:

1. The Masoretic Text has the phrase “and to a height.” See the separate note on the interpretations of this phrase. For example:

the One on high (NASB) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. Some ancient versions have the word “yoke” instead of “height.” Some early version examples are the Greek Aquila and Symmachus, the Aramaic Targum and the Latin Vulgate. For example:

the yoke that is on them (GNT) (GNT, RSV)

1. Some scholars think that the original text had “Baal” instead of “height.” The BHS editors recommend that the word “height” be changed to “Baal.” It is also supported by Stuart (page 174). A similar result can be attained without any change to the Hebrew text. Andersen and Freedman (page 587) suggest that the phrase, “and to a height” refers to an unspecified false god. The CEV translation may be an example of this interpretation. It has, “My people are determined to reject me for a god they think is stronger, but he can’t help.” For example:

they call to Baal (NET) (NET, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It has good support from scholars, ancient versions and most modern versions. See Dearman (page 286), Andersen and Freedman (page 574) and Wood (page 213). The LXX and Peshitta translate “height” as “God.”

Though: This word is not in the Hebrew text. The BSB supplies it to make explicit the logical relationship between the first clause of the sentence “they call to the Most High” and the second clause “he will by no means exalt them.” The logical relationship is that the people’s action of calling to the LORD does not result in the LORD exalting them.

Here are some other ways to indicate this connection:

To the Most High they call, but he does not raise them up at all. (NRSV)

Even if they call to the Most High, he will by no means exalt them. (NIV)

Indicate this relationship between the clauses in a natural way in your language.

they call: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “they call him.” This phrase is a single affixed word in Hebrew. There are two main interpretations of this phrase:

1. The people call to the LORD. The referent of they is the people of Israel. The word call means to pray. The referent of “him” is the Most High. For example:

they call out to the Most High (ESV) (BSB, ESV, GW, NAB, NIV, NRSV) The NLT is similar. It has, “They call me the Most High...” It is not included here because the NLT understands, “call him” to mean the name people use to refer to God, rather than to mean, “pray to him.”

1. The prophets called the people to return to the LORD. The referent of they is the prophets. The word call means to urge or summon. The referent of “him” is Israel. For example:

The prophets call them to turn to me (NCV) (KJV, NASB, NCV) The NJB and NJPS are similar. For example, the NJB has, “they are summoned to come up...” These versions are not included here because they do not explicitly state that the prophets are the ones calling the people and because they interpret, “height” to mean “upward” and not “the LORD.”

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a majority of versions. Interpretation (2) is possible, but it assumes that Hosea uses the non-specific pronoun “they” to introduce a new participant into the story line - “the prophets.” It is more likely that the pronoun “they” refers back to the previously introduced participant “the people.” It makes sense in this context and has the support of one of the ancient versions. The Syriac Peshitta has: “they shall call to God.”

to the Most High: The Hebrew text is literally “and to a height.” There two main interpretations:

1. The phrase “and to a height” is a short form of the descriptive phrase Most High. It refers to the LORD. Dearman (page 286) and Wood (page 213). For example:

To the Most High they call (NRSV) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NCV, NIV, NLT, NRSV)

1. The phrase “and to a height” means an upward direction. It refers figuratively to a high level of devotion/piety. In support, Macintosh (page 455) quotes rabbinic commentator ibn Janah, who says that ‘el ‘al denotes ‘the highest level’ i.e. true piety. Keil (page 91) and McComiskey (page 187) also support this interpretation. For example:

if they are summoned to come up (NJB) (NJB, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

He will by no means exalt them: This clause is literally “together not he will exalt them.” There are two main interpretations:

1. The LORD will not exalt/lift HALOT (electronic edition, pp. 1203-1204) Polal 2. Dearman (page 286), Wood (page 213). the people. The verb “exalt/lift” means to help them in some way, perhaps by answering their prayers. This clause depicts the LORD’s negative response to the peoples’ apostasy. For example:

he shall not raise them up at all (ESV) (BSB, ESV, GW, NAB, NIV, NRSV)

1. The people will not exalt the LORD. The verb “exalt/rise” means to honor or worship God. Note that the final mem on the verb “exalt” is a feature of the polel imperfect form. It is not a plural suffix although it resembles one. Therefore, the object is implicit and could be “him” or “God” here, just as it could be “them.” This clause depicts the people’s apostasy. For example:

They call me the Most High, but they don’t truly honor me. (NLT) (NLT) The ASV, KJV, NASB, NCV also follow interpretation (2). However, they interpret it to be the people’s negative response to the prophets who call them to the LORD. That interpretation was not recommended in the previous note on the phrase “they call.”

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It makes good sense as the LORD's negative response to the people calling to him.

by no means: There are two main interpretations of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as by no means:

1. The Hebrew word means "altogether." It functions as a superlative or to give emphasis to something in the following clause. BDB (#3162) 2b says it occurs often in poetry beginning a clause with emphasis. Here it gives emphasis to the following verb "exalt." For example:

He does not raise them up at all (NRSV) (BSB, ESV, NIV, NRSV)

1. The Hebrew word means "together" or "all at once." HALOT (electronic edition, p. 405) 2a. It refers back to the people who call on the LORD in the previous clause. This is the function of the Hebrew word in some ancient versions. The Greek Aquila and Symmachus translate as "all at once." The Syriac Peshitta translates as, "they will take counsel together." For example:

In unison they cry out to him (NAB) (NAB)

The Display will follow interpretation (1), but the Hebrew word can have either meaning. The context does not clearly favor one over the other.

Hosea 11:8

Section 11:1–11 The LORD's love for his people

This section refers back to Israel's history, as do Section 9:10–17 and Section 10:1–8. In all three sections, the LORD describes the joyful beginning of his relationship with the people of Israel and their response of betrayal against him. The earlier sections focus more on the LORD's punishment. The people will be taken into exile. This section focuses more on his love.

The LORD speaks of his love for Israel in the past (11:1–4), warns them of their future exile and destruction (11:5–7), and assures them that in the future he will turn from his anger and show them compassion. Because of his love for them, he promises that he will bring the people back to the land of Israel (11:8–11).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord's Love for Israel (ESV)

Israel Is Like a Bad Son (GW)

Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. When he refers to himself, he uses first person pronouns ("I/me/my") except for verse 10, which has "Yahweh" and "he." When he refers to the people or nation of Israel, he uses "Ephraim," "they/them," or "he/it." The only exceptions are in 11:8–9. There the LORD uses the pronoun "you(sg)" to speak directly to Ephraim and to Judah.

Paragraph 11:8–11

This paragraph contrasts with the previous one. The previous paragraph promises that the nation of Israel will be taken into exile in Assyria. This paragraph tells about the time after that exile. In these verses, the LORD promises that he will not completely destroy them. Rather, in the future he will bring them back to their land. McComiskey (page 191).

11:8a–d

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{8a} How could I give you up, **O Ephraim?**

^{8b} How could I surrender you, **O Israel?**

^{8c} How could I make you **like Admah?**

^{8d} How could I treat you **like Zeboiim?**

These lines show the LORD's emotional anguish due to the coming destruction and captivity of Israel. Garrett (page 227) compares the anguish to "a father at wit's end over what to do with a wayward child." They also indicate that the LORD is the one who decides the fate of Israel.

The lines are probably rhetorical questions with an implied answer of, "I cannot!" Some commentators do not classify these lines as rhetorical questions. Hubbard (page 192) refers to them as "self-cautioning questions." Macintosh (page 191) calls them expressions of bewilderment and grief. Dearman (pages 287–289) calls them statements in interrogative form. He classifies the form of verse 8 as "soliloquy." See the general comment for other ways to translate these lines.

11:8a

How could I give you up, O Ephraim?

- ¶ But I, Yahweh, say, "how can I give you^(sing/plur) up, Israel?

- **י** O Ephraim! In spite of all this, I can not abandon you^(sing/plur).

11:8b**How could I surrender you, O Israel?**

- Can I endure handing you^(plur), my people, over to your enemies?
- O Israel, I can not put you^(sing/plur) in the hands of your enemies.

11:8a-b

How: In rhetorical questions, this Hebrew question word can indicate emotions such as despair, amazement, or horror. TWOT (#75b) and BDB (#349) 2. Here it is an exclamation that indicates grief or anguish. Davies (page 261) and McComiskey (page 191) suggest that the question word “How” is an exclamation rather than an interrogative here. Hubbard (page 192) regards “How” to be a word of lamentation.

could I give you up...could I surrender you: In both these phrases, the LORD asks himself if he can give Israel to their enemy, Assyria, to destroy them.

Ephraim...Israel: Both names refer to the people of Israel.

11:8c-d**(combined/reordered)**

- Can I utterly destroy you, like what happened at Admah and Zeboiim?
- I could not make you cease to exist as I did to Admah and Zeboiim.

How could I make you like Admah? How could I treat you like Zeboiim?: In both questions, the LORD asks himself if he can destroy Israel as he destroyed these two cities. In some languages, it may be helpful to make explicit that these two clauses are about destruction. For example:

How can I destroy you like Admah or demolish you like Zeboiim? (NLT)

How: See comment above on How.

could I make you like...could I treat you like: In this context, the Hebrew words for make you and treat you have similar meanings. Here they both mean “do to you.”

Admah...Zeboiim: The LORD completely destroyed these two cities along with Sodom and Gomorrah because of their extreme wickedness. Andersen and Freedman (page 588) suggest that the cities represented the ultimate in wickedness and are a reminder

of how devastating Yahweh’s wrath and anger can be. See Deuteronomy 29:23.

General Comment on 11:8a-d

In some languages, it may be more natural to use statements instead of rhetorical questions or use some of each. It also may be more natural to combine some of the parallel parts. For example, the CEV has statements for the first two parallel lines. It has kept the third and fourth lines as rhetorical questions but has combined them.

Israel, I can’t let you go. I can’t give you up. How could I possibly destroy you as I did the towns of Admah and Zeboiim?

11:8c**How could I make you like Admah?**

- How can I destroy you^(plur) like the town of Admah?
- I can not utterly destroy/kill you, as I destroyed the people of Admah.

11:8d**How could I treat you like Zeboiim?**

- Can I truly bring you to an end like the people of Zeboiim?
- I can not wipe you from the earth, like I did to Zeboiim.

11:8e-f

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{8e} My heart **is turned within Me;**

^{8f} My compassion **is stirred!**

11:8e**My heart is turned within Me;**

- I have changed my mind. (GW)
- My heart/thoughts have changed.

My heart: The Hebrews considered the heart to be the center of thought and knowledge. Some languages use a different body organ, such as the liver, to signify attitudes and thoughts. Use an expression that is natural in your language for this purpose.

is turned: In Hebrew, there are two main interpretations of this phrase:

1. The phrase means “to change one’s mind/plan.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 253) Niphal 3. This view is favored by Davies and Stuart (page 181). For example:

I have changed my mind (GW) (BSB, CEV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NET, NIV, NJPS, REB)

1. The word means “to be in distress.” BDB (#2015) Niphal 1b. McComiskey (page 191) notes the similar use of hapak here to Lamentations 1:20. There the word “connotes the turmoil of deep, wrenching feelings.” This view is also favored by Hubbard. For example:

My heart is torn within me (NLT) (ESV, NCV, NLT, NJB, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It fits better with following context of 11:9 in which the LORD describes what he no longer plans to do. It also allows the second interpretation. His change of heart is based on his strong compassion for his people. McComiskey (page 191) notes that the people would indeed go into captivity, but God would not invalidate the promise of the land.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

My heart will not let me do it! (GNT)

A change of heart moves me (REB)

within Me: In this context, the Hebrew word indicates the location where the decisions/emotions take place.

11:8f

My compassion is stirred!

- I am completely overwhelmed by feelings of pity.
- I love you too much to destroy you like that.

There Hebrew is a word here which means “together.” Here it gives emphasis to the intensity of the emotion that the LORD feels. Some versions leave this word implicit. Some others indicate this intensity in a different way. The BSB indicates the intensity with the exclamation point at the end of the sentence. For example:

I am deeply moved. (GW)

Indicate the intensity of emotion in a natural way in your language.

compassion: The Hebrew word refers to an emotion of compassion and pity. It describes a desire to bring comfort. McComiskey (page 191), Dearman (pages 287–289) and Andersen and Freedman (page 589).

stirred!: In Hebrew, this word is literally “grow warm.” Hebrew uses the word “warm” or “hot” to describe strong feelings. For example:

my compassion grows warm and tender (NRSV)

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

My compassion overflows (NLT)

my love for you stirs up my pity (NCV)

Hosea 11:9

Section 11:1–11 The LORD’s love for his people

This section refers back to Israel’s history, as do Section 9:10–17 and Section 10:1–8. In all three sections, the LORD describes the joyful beginning of his relationship with the people of Israel and their response of betrayal against him. The earlier sections focus more on the LORD’s punishment. The people will be taken into exile. This section focuses more on his love.

The LORD speaks of his love for Israel in the past (11:1–4), warns them of their future exile and destruction (11:5–7), and assures them that in the future he will turn from his anger and show them compassion. Because of his love for them, he promises that he will bring the people back to the land of Israel (11:8–11).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord’s Love for Israel (ESV)

Israel Is Like a Bad Son (GW)

Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. When he refers to himself, he uses first person pronouns (“I/me/my”) except for verse 10, which has “Yahweh” and “he.” When he refers to the people or nation of Israel, he uses “Ephraim,” “they/them,” or “he/it.” The only exceptions are in 11:8–9. There the LORD uses the pronoun “you(sg)” to speak directly to Ephraim and to Judah.

Paragraph 11:8–11

This paragraph contrasts with the previous one. The previous paragraph promises that the nation of Israel will be taken into exile in Assyria. This paragraph tells about the time after that exile. In these verses, the LORD promises that he will not completely destroy them. Rather, in the future he will bring them back to their land. McComiskey (page 191).

11:9

In this verse, the LORD tells what he will do as a result of his change of mind in verse 8.

11:9a-b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{9a} I will not execute **the full fury of My anger**;

^{9b} I will not turn back **to destroy Ephraim**.

11:9a

I will not execute the full fury of My anger;

- I will not express all of my burning anger.
- I will hold back my extreme anger.

I will not execute the full fury of My anger: This clause means that the LORD will not do something that is motivated by anger. For example:

I will not act on my burning anger (GW)

The action that the LORD will not do is described in the next line “devastate Ephraim.” Garrett (pages 227–229) suggests that this clause doesn’t mean Israel will escape punishment. It means that Yahweh will not give full vent to his fury, as he did in the case of Sodom. See also Kidner (pages 104–105) and Carroll (pages 286–287).

execute: The Hebrew word here means to do an action. HALOT I (electronic edition, page 891).

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

I will not unleash my fierce anger (NLT)

I will not execute my fierce anger (NASB)

full fury of My anger: The Hebrew phrase here is a Hebrew idiom “the blaze of the nose.” It means strong “burning anger.” HALOT (electronic edition, pages 351–352). For example:

my burning anger (ESV)

My wrath (NJPS)

my fury (REB)

11:9b

I will not turn back to destroy Ephraim.

- I will not completely destroy Ephraim again,
- I will not bring the nation of Israel to an end.

I will not turn back to destroy Ephraim: There are two main interpretations of this clause:

1. The clause is more literally “I will not repeat to destroy Ephraim.” The Hebrew word shub has the sense of “again.” See BDB (#7725) 8 and HALOT (electronic edition, page 1430) qal 5. For example:

I will not again destroy Ephraim (ESV) There are two possible ways to understand this interpretation:

1. The LORD will not destroy Ephraim totally. He will not do again what he did to the cities of Admah and Zeboiim. Garrett (pages 227–229), Jamieson, Fausset and Brown (page 660) and Kidner (pages 104–105).
2. After the Assyrians destroy Ephraim, the LORD will not destroy Ephraim again at a future time. This clause refers to a future time following the exile in Assyria. Ephraim will not be destroyed yet again. See Stuart (page 182), McComiskey (page 192), Hubbard (page 194) and Wood (page 214). The version examples listed here could be understood as following either (a) or (b) above. (CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NAB, NASB, NCV, NJB, NRSV)
3. The clause is more literally “I will not turn to destroy Ephraim.” The LORD will not turn away from his promises and/or acts of kindness toward his people in order to destroy them. The Hebrew word shub has the sense of “change one’s course of action.” See BDB (#7725) 5e. See Macintosh (page 463) and Davies (page 263). For example:

I will not turn to destroy Ephraim (NJPS) (BSB, KJV, NIV, NJPS, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). However, interpretation (2) also has good support. It is recommended that you add a footnote with this interpretation. For example:

Another way to interpret this part of the verse is:
I will not turn in order to destroy Ephraim.

In both interpretations, the LORD implicitly contrasts the coming Assyrian destruction of Ephraim to the destruction of the cities of Admah and Zeboiim of the past. The LORD destroyed those cities totally. But he will not destroy Ephraim totally.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause that do not use the words turn or “again”:

I will not completely destroy Israel (NLT)

I cannot totally destroy Ephraim! (NET)

destroy: In this context the word means to completely destroy. Kidner (pages 104–105), Dearman (pages 289–292), McComiskey (pages 191–192), Macintosh (page 465) and Carroll (pages 286–287).

Ephraim: As in 11:8, the name Ephraim refers to the people of Israel.

11:9c–d

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{9c}For I am God and not **man**—

^{9d} the Holy One among **you**.

There is an ellipsis in the second line. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from the first line. For example:

^{9d} I am the Holy One among **you**.

These lines give the reason why the LORD will not allow the total destruction of Israel. It is because he is the holy God.

11:9c

For I am God and not man—

- because I am God, not just a human being.
- That is because I am not like a man—I am God,

For: The Hebrew clause starts with a word that introduces a reason. Many versions translate this word as “for” or “because.” Indicate that these lines are a reason in a natural way in your language.

I am God and not man: In this clause, God contrasts himself to man.

Here are some possible implications of this contrast:

1. God is able to refrain from expressing his anger fully. He punishes to correct wrong behavior, not to destroy. Jamieson, Fausset and Brown (page 660), and Macintosh (page 465).
2. God responds to Ephraim’s sin with mercy. This is contrasted with human responses such as anger and vengeance. Davies (page 263) and Wood (page 214).

3. God is faithful to his people. This is contrasted with the people of Israel, who were not faithful to God. Davies (page 264).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

For I am God and not a mere human being. (GNT)

For I am God and not a mere mortal (NLT)

God: In this clause, the Hebrew word for God is *el* and not YHWH. Some versions translate *el* as God instead of “LORD.” Use your general term for God here.

11:9d

the Holy One among you—

- I am the Holy God who lives among you.
- the Holy One who is with you.

the Holy One among you: This line expands on the previous one. It indicates that the chief characteristic that separates God from man is his holiness in contrast to man’s sinfulness.

among you: God is present among the people of Israel. He has a relationship with them. Even though the people of Israel are sinful, they are his people and he is their God. Dearman (pages 289–292) and Davies (page 263).

Holy One: The Hebrew word is literally Holy. Here the BSB and many other versions translate the Hebrew word Holy as Holy One, which is a name or title parallel to “God” in 9c. The word Holy means morally pure. He is completely good, separate from all sin and he opposes all that is evil. McComiskey (page 192), Macintosh (page 465) and Davies (page 263).

11:9e

and I will not come in wrath.

- I will not come against you with great anger.
- I will restrain my anger against you.

I will not come in wrath: There is a textual issue concerning the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as in wrath:

1. The Hebrew has an affixed word that means “in agitation/anger.” Preposition *h* “in/with” + noun *ir* “agitation,” HALOT (electronic edition, page 822) II. Favored by Stuart (page 182), Keil (page 92) and Dearman (pages 289–292). For example:

And I shall not come to you in anger (NJB) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NJPS, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NRSV, REB)

1. The Hebrew text has an affixed word that means, “into/against a city.” Preposition *ḵ* “in/into” + noun *îr* “city” HALOT (electronic edition, page 821) I. Favored by Garrett (pages 227–229), McComiskey (page 193), Macintosh (page 464), Andersen and Freedman (page 589), and Hubbard (page 195). This option has support from the LXX, Peshitta and Vulgate. However, few modern versions follow it. For example:

And I will not enter into the city. (KJV) (KJV)

1. The Hebrew text has a word that means, “to devastate.” HALOT (electronic edition, p. 146) II. This option requires a different Hebrew vowel, “e” instead of “i.” For example:

and I will not come to destroy (RSV) (RSV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. It makes good sense in this context as a summary statement that confirms what is said in the previous lines. This line is similar to 9a “I shall not carry-out/execute my anger.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I will not come in fury (NJPS)

I will not come against you in anger (NCV)

I won't stay angry (CEV)

not come in wrath: This phrase means that when God is present with his people he will not carry out his wrath. He will restrain his anger.

Hosea 11:10

Section 11:1–11 The LORD's love for his people

This section refers back to Israel's history, as do Section 9:10–17 and Section 10:1–8. In all three sections, the LORD describes the joyful beginning of his relationship with the people of Israel and their response of betrayal against him. The earlier sections focus more on the LORD's punishment. The people will be taken into exile. This section focuses more on his love.

The LORD speaks of his love for Israel in the past (11:1–4), warns them of their future exile and destruction (11:5–7), and assures them that in the future he will turn from his anger and show them compassion. Because of his love for them, he promises that he will bring the people back to the land of Israel (11:8–11).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord's Love for Israel (ESV)

Israel Is Like a Bad Son (GW)

Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. When he refers to himself, he uses first person pronouns (“I/me/my”) except for verse 10, which has “Yahweh” and “he.” When he refers to the people or nation of Israel, he uses “Ephraim,” “they/them,” or “he/it.” The only exceptions are in 11:8–9. There the LORD uses the pronoun “you(sg)” to speak directly to Ephraim and to Judah.

Paragraph 11:8–11

This paragraph contrasts with the previous one. The previous paragraph promises that the nation of Israel will be taken into exile in Assyria. This paragraph tells about the time after that exile. In these verses, the LORD promises that he will not completely destroy them. Rather, in the future he will bring them back to their land. McComiskey (page 191).

11:10a–b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning: The structure of verse 10 is a chiasm: A: They will walk after the LORD B: He will roar like a lion. B': When He roars A' His children will come trembling from the west.

^{10a} They will walk after the LORD; **He will roar** like a lion.

^{10b} **When He roars**, His children will come trembling from the west.

11:10a

They will walk after the LORD; He will roar like a lion.

- ¶ “In the future they will follow Yahweh. He will roar like a lion,
- ¶ “One day I, Yahweh, will roar like a lion, and they will follow me.

They will walk after the LORD: This expression means that the people will obey the LORD. It implies that they will be faithful and loyal to him instead of worshipping idols. Keil (pages 92, 93), Stuart (page 182) and Davies (page 264).

He will roar like a lion: This line is a figure of speech (simile) that compares the action of the LORD calling his people to a lion roaring. The simile means that

the LORD will summon/command his people to leave the foreign lands where they live to return to Israel. The comparison to a lion's roar may imply that the summons is irresistible. McComiskey (page 195) and Macintosh (page 470).

Chronologically, the lion's roar will happen before the people follow. In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of these two clauses. For example:

He will roar like a lion, and they will follow the Lord. (NET)

lion: The Hebrew word refers to an African lion with a large mane. The lion represents authority and majesty. Stuart (page 182).

11:10b

When He roars, His children will come trembling from the west.

- and when he roars, his children will tremble in awe, and come to him from the west.
- When I roar, my children will tremble as they return to me from the lands of the west.

When He roars: There are two main interpretations of the function of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as When:

1. It indicates time. For example:

when he roars (NRSV) (BSB, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. It indicates emphasis. For example:

Yea, he will roar (RSV) (NASB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

His children will come trembling from the west: This clause is more literally "and they will tremble children from [the] west." It describes the result of the roar of the LORD.

His children: The pronoun His is not in the Hebrew text, but it is implied from the context. The pronoun is supplied in the BSB and in many other versions.

The Hebrew word means either "sons" or children, both male and female. Here the word may refer specifically to future descendants of the Israelites. Andersen and Freedman (page 592). It could also refer more generally to the people of Israel, both adults and

children. Davies (page 265). Either understanding is acceptable.

Some versions make the second understanding explicit. For example:

my people will return trembling from the west (NLT)

will come trembling: There are two main interpretations of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as trembling:

1. It means "tremble" or "shake." TWOT (#735) suggests that the root meaning is "to shake," and that the phrase, come trembling in Hos 11:10-11 probably emphasizes bird-like movements. For example:

and his sons shall come trembling from the west (RSV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, RSV)

1. It means "quickly." HALOT (electronic edition, page 350) 2. For example:

They will hurry to me from the west. (GNT) (GNT, NCV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is supported by most versions, Hebrew lexicons, and commentaries. Commentaries that concur include: Andersen and Freedman, Davies, Dearman, Hubbard, Keil, Kidner, Macintosh, McComiskey and Wood.

The reference to trembling in this context can be translated in any of the following ways:

- Translate the word trembling without additional explanation. For example:

his children will come trembling from the west. (NET)

- Translate the word trembling as a reference to a person's emotional state. Here it may indicate that a person is timid and fearful of offending the LORD. It may also indicate an attitude of humility. Wood (page 214) and Andersen and Freedman (page 592) For example:

his sons shall come frightened from the west (NASB)

- Translate the word trembling as a reference to the movement of birds that flutter their wings when they are startled. HALOT (electronic edition, page 1047). The way the children come is explicitly compared to birds in the next verse which says, “they will come trembling like birds...” For example:

his children will come fluttering from the west
(NJB)

In Hebrew, the phrase will come trembling is more literally “and they will tremble.” The word come is not in the Hebrew text. It is supplied in the BSB and in many other versions. The meaning come is considered to be implied because of the following phrase “from the west.” According to a NET footnote, when the verb *haraḏ* “to tremble” is used with prepositions of direction, it denotes “to go or come trembling.” Also McComiskey (page 195) and Macintosh (page 466).

from the west: This phrase describes one of the directions from which the children come. The Hebrew word for west is literally “sea.” This word designates the coastlands and islands of the Mediterranean Sea. Since the Mediterranean is west of Israel, the Hebrew word “sea” is also the word for west. McComiskey (page 195).

This phrase implies that some of the people of Israel have relocated to the lands west of Israel.

General Comment on 11:10

In 11:10, the LORD continues to speak. Andersen and Freedman (page 591) and McComiskey (page 195). However, there is a change from first person pronouns that refer to the LORD, such as “I” and “my,” to third person pronouns, such as “he” and “his.” This kind of change is typical of Hosea’s writing style.

In some languages, this change of pronouns may sound awkward and unnatural. If this is true in your language, you can continue to use first person pronouns here. For example:

My people will follow me when I roar like a lion at their enemies. They will hurry to me from the west. (GNT)

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine some of the parallel parts. For example:

I, the LORD, will roar like a lion, and my children will return, trembling from the west. (CEV)

Hosea 11:11

Section 11:1–11 The LORD’s love for his people

This section refers back to Israel’s history, as do Section 9:10–17 and Section 10:1–8. In all three sections, the LORD describes the joyful beginning of his relationship with the people of Israel and their response of betrayal against him. The earlier sections focus more on the LORD’s punishment. The people will be taken into exile. This section focuses more on his love.

The LORD speaks of his love for Israel in the past (11:1–4), warns them of their future exile and destruction (11:5–7), and assures them that in the future he will turn from his anger and show them compassion. Because of his love for them, he promises that he will bring the people back to the land of Israel (11:8–11).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord’s Love for Israel (ESV)

Israel Is Like a Bad Son (GW)

Throughout this section, the LORD is the speaker. When he refers to himself, he uses first person pronouns (“I/me/my”) except for verse 10, which has “Yahweh” and “he.” When he refers to the people or nation of Israel, he uses “Ephraim,” “they/them,” or “he/it.” The only exceptions are in 11:8–9. There the LORD uses the pronoun “you(sg)” to speak directly to Ephraim and to Judah.

Paragraph 11:8–11

This paragraph contrasts with the previous one. The previous paragraph promises that the nation of Israel will be taken into exile in Assyria. This paragraph tells about the time after that exile. In these verses, the LORD promises that he will not completely destroy them. Rather, in the future he will bring them back to their land. McComiskey (page 191).

11:11a–b (combined/reordered)

- They will tremble when they return from Egypt or Assyria. They will be like doves/pigeons and other birds that flutter their wings.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{11a}They will come trembling like birds from **Egypt**

^{11b}and like doves from **the land of Assyria**.

There is an ellipsis in the second line. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from the first line. For example:

^{11b} They will come trembling like doves from **the land of Assyria**.

Each line is a metaphor. The metaphors compare the movement of the children to the movement of birds. In these metaphors, the English word order may wrongly imply that it is the birds/doves that come from Egypt or Assyria. Be sure to make clear in your translation that it is the people who come from these countries. As they come, they are like birds/doves that flutter their wings.

They will come trembling like birds from Egypt and like doves from the land of Assyria: There are two main interpretations of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as trembling. See the comments and recommendation about the phrase “will come trembling” in 11:10b.

birds from Egypt and like doves: The Hebrew word for birds is a general word for a bird, a flying creature with wings. HALOT (electronic edition, page 1047). The Hebrew word for doves means a specific kind of bird, a dove or pigeon. These are domesticated birds that are easily frightened. If doves and pigeons are unknown in your area, another option is to substitute a different kind of bird with similar characteristics that is known in your area.

Egypt...Assyria: These two locations, in addition to “the west” in 11:10b, may be examples of the various parts of the world where his children will live in exile.

General Comment on 11:11a–b

See 11:11a–b (combined/reordered) in the Display for a way to combine and/or reorder these two lines.

11:11a

They will come trembling like birds from Egypt

- They will tremble when they come from Egypt like birds
- They will tremble when will return from Egypt. They will be like birds that flutter/flap their wings as they fly.

11:11b

and like doves from the land of Assyria.

- or from Assyria like doves/pigeons.
- They will also tremble when they come out of Assyria. They will be like fluttering doves/pigeons.

11:11c

Then I will settle them in their homes, declares the LORD.

- I will give them back their homes to live in,” says Yahweh.
- They will live in their own homes again. I, Yahweh, declare this to be true.”

I will settle them in their homes: There is a textual issue in this clause concerning the word that the BSB translates as settle:

1. The Masoretic Text has “cause them to dwell.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 444) hifil 3. For example:

I shall settle them in their homes (NJB) (BSB, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, REB)

1. LXX has “cause to return.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 1432) hifil 1. For example:

I will bring them to their homes again (GNT) (CEV, ESV, GNT, NLT, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with a majority of versions. It fits the context well. However, option (2) is also acceptable. The meaning is very similar, and it has support from ancient versions. Option (2) requires different Hebrew vowels. However, it is represented by the LXX, the Syriac Peshitta, and the Targum.

homes: Here the word means more than houses, since many of their houses were already destroyed. It probably refers to their inherited land and property. Andersen and Freedman (page 592).

declares the LORD: This is the same expression as in 2:13c. See the note on that passage. This phrase emphasizes that the message was directly from the LORD. It also marks the end of this section of Hosea.

The main theme of the messages in this division is Israel’s past and present corruption. As a result of it, the LORD will bring judgment against them.

In this division, the LORD and Hosea alternate as the speaker. The LORD refers to himself using first person pronouns (“I/me”) in 11:12a–b, 12:9–10, 13:4–11, 14:4–8. Macintosh (page 474) and Hubbard (page 199) say that the LORD is the speaker in 11:12. However, it is possible that Hosea is the speaker in these verses. If so, then Hosea cites/quotes the words of the LORD as the basis of his message. See Stuart (pages 187–188). In the other verses of this division, the

speaker refers to the LORD using third person forms including “God,” “the Holy One,” “the LORD,” “he,” “the LORD God Almighty.” In these third person references, the Notes and Display will regard Hosea to be the speaker. However, it is possible that the LORD was also the speaker in these verses. See Dearman (pages 296–297). If so, the LORD referred to himself using third person forms. The Hebrew text most often uses “Ephraim,” “Jacob,” “him,” “they” or “he/it” to refer to the people or nation of Israel. Exceptions are when the speaker speaks directly to the people in 8:1, 12:6,9, 13:4–5, and 13:9–11 using the pronouns “you/your.”

Hosea 11:12

Section 11:12–12:14: Israel is deceitful and refuses to return to the LORD

In this section, the LORD accuses both Israel and Judah of wrongdoing, but then focuses on the wicked behavior of Israel (11:12–12:1). Hosea continues to describe Israel, giving examples from the life of their ancestor Jacob to show that Israel followed his bad behavior (12:2–8). The LORD then reminded the people how they had responded wickedly when he led them in the past (12:9–11). Hosea concludes this section by comparing Jacob’s care of sheep in Aram with the LORD’s care of his people through a prophet or prophets.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel’s Sin (NIV)

Israel and Judah Are Condemned (GNT)

Paragraph 11:12–12:1

In this paragraph, the LORD brings charges against both Israel and Judah. The statements here are similar to opening remarks made by a prosecutor in a court case. Or a presentation to teach or confront the people. See Dearman (pages 294–295) and Stuart (pages 187–188). Some versions use headings that correspond to such a context.

Here are some examples of other headings:

God’s Lawsuit against Israel: Breach of Covenant (NET)

Charges against Israel and Judah (NLT)

In the Masoretic Text, the first verse of Hosea chapter 12 begins here. The Notes and Display will follow the majority of English versions that regard this verse as Hosea 11:12.

11:12

This verse has similarities to 11:9c–d. Both verses use a less common Hebrew term for God and both refer to God as “Holy One.” 11:9 and 11:12 are the only places in Hosea that the Hebrew term ‘ēl is used for “God” and that the term “holy [one]” is used to describe him. 11:9c–d describes the holy God in the midst of people. 11:12 uses a similar description. It is not a happy picture of a father surrounded by his loving children. Rather it is a picture of someone encircled by hostile enemies, who attack him with lies and deception.

11:12a–b (combined/reordered)

- All around me the people of Israel are dishonest and deceitful.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{12a} Ephraim surrounds Me with **lies**,

^{12b} the house of Israel with **deceit**;

There is an ellipsis in the second line. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from the first line. For example:

^{12b} the house of Israel surrounds me with **deceit**.

These lines are metaphors that compare the people of Israel to an enemy army that surrounds a person or a city. The lies and deceit of the people are like the weapons of the enemy. Stuart (page 189), Andersen and Freedman (page 600) and Davies (page 269).

Ephraim...house of Israel: Both of these terms refer to the people of Israel. (See 4:17a “Ephraim” and 1:6c “the house of Israel”). See the General Comment on 11:12a–b for translation options.

surrounds Me: This figurative phrase was probably well known to Hosea’s audience because of Psalms that use it in a similar way. For example, Psalm 22:16 says: “For dogs surround me; a band of evil men encircles me....” Here, the pronoun Me refers to the LORD. Stuart (page 189) and Andersen and Freedman (page 600).

lies...deceit: In Hebrew, these two words have similar meanings. The word for lies means “evasion of truth.” TWOT (#975a). McComiskey (page 197). The word for deceit means “deceive,” “mislead.” It describes speech and behavior that intends to mislead, such as a merchant using inaccurate scales. TWOT (#2169b). Dearman (pages 296–297) and McComiskey (page 197).

General Comment on 11:12a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine some of the parallel parts. For example:

Israel surrounds me with lies and deceit (NLT)

11:12a**Ephraim surrounds Me with lies,**

- ¶ Yahweh continued to speak, saying, “I am surrounded by Ephraim’s lies.
- ¶ Yahweh says, “Ephraim tells one lie after another,

11:12b**the house of Israel with deceit;**

- Israel’s deceit encircles me like an enemy.
- and Israel constantly twists the truth.

11:12c–d

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{12c}but Judah still **walks with God**

^{12d}and is **faithful to the Holy One.**

In Hebrew, these lines are more literally “and/but Judah still it has roamed with God and with [the] holy [one(s)] faithful.” There are two main interpretations of this verse part: A third interpretation is not listed due to minimal version support. It proposes that the Hebrew term for God here, ‘el, refers to a pagan ‘el, rather than to YHWH. Likewise with “holy ones.” This view is favored by Andersen and Freedman (pages 600–603), Hubbard (page 199) and Garrett (pages 229–231).

1. These lines say that Judah remains faithful to God. The meaning of the word “roamed” is “follow.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 1194) cites Wolff “but Judah still goes about with God.” Andersen and Freedman (page 602) notes that this is the traditional interpretation. The people of Judah continue to follow God. The word “faithful” refers to Judah. In this interpretation, the parallel lines of the Hebrew text form a chiasm: Judah still (A) it has roamed (B) with God; (B’) and with [the] holy [one(s)] (A’) faithful. For example:

But Judah still roams about with God; he remains faithful to the Holy One. (NET) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NET, NJPS, NJB, NLT, NRSV)

1. These lines say that Judah wanders from God who is faithful. The meaning of the word “roamed”

is “wander restlessly.” BDB (#7300). This Hebrew word normally has connotations of rebellion. Davies (page 270). The word “faithful” refers to God. In this interpretation the faithfulness of God is contrasted with the rebellious nature of the people of Judah. For example:

and the people of Judah are still rebelling against me, the faithful and holy God. (GNT) (CEV, GNT, GW, NASB, NCV, NIV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation is also supported by the LXX, which has “Judah now God knows them and it will be called a holy people of God.” See also Dearman (pages 296–297), Macintosh (page 475), and McComiskey (page 197). At the time of Hosea, Judah was not yet as rebellious against God as Israel. McComiskey (page 197) notes that Judah had not yet incurred the guilt that Israel had brought on herself, and would be spared for a while. See also Dearman (pages 296–297).

11:12c**but Judah still walks with God**

- But Judah continues to travel on God’s path.
- Yet the people of Judah continue to follow God.

but Judah still walks with God: This line and 11:12d contrast the people of the southern kingdom of Judah with those of the northern kingdom of Israel. The people of Israel surrounded God with lies and deceit, but Judah continued to follow God.

still: The word still refers to something that continues. Here it indicates the continuation of a past or present event. TWOT (#1576a).

walks: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as walks, means “to roam about freely” or “to wander.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 1194). The meaning can be positive or negative. Here the word is used in a positive way. See the interpretations above.

with: The Hebrew word has meanings such as with, “beside,” “by,” or “accompanying.” It is commonly used of a close relationship. TWOT (#1640b).

God: Here the Hebrew word for God is el and not YHWH. This is the same word as in 11:9c. Some versions translate el as God instead of “LORD.” Use your general term for God here.

11:12d**and is faithful to the Holy One.**

- He is firm in his commitment to the Holy One.
- They are loyal to me, the Holy One.

faithful: The Hebrew word means “to prove to be firm, reliable, faithful.” HALOT (electronic edition, p. 63) nifal. The word commonly applies to trust in God. Andersen and Freedman (page 603) and Macintosh (page 475).

the Holy One: This term is more literally “and with holy [ones].” The term Holy One is also in 11:9. See 11:9d “the Holy One among you.” In 11:9 the word is singular. Here it is plural. It is probably an honorific plural, also called a plural of majesty. The term refers to God in both verses. McComiskey (page 197), Macintosh (page 473) and Keil (pages 94–95).

Hosea 12:1

Section 11:12–12:14: Israel is deceitful and refuses to return to the LORD

In this section, the LORD accuses both Israel and Judah of wrongdoing, but then focuses on the wicked behavior of Israel (11:12–12:1). Hosea continues to describe Israel, giving examples from the life of their ancestor Jacob to show that Israel followed his bad behavior (12:2–8). The LORD then reminded the people how they had responded wickedly when he led them in the past (12:9–11). Hosea concludes this section by comparing Jacob’s care of sheep in Aram with the LORD’s care of his people through a prophet or prophets.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel’s Sin (NIV)

Israel and Judah Are Condemned (GNT)

Paragraph 11:12–12:1

In this paragraph, the LORD brings charges against both Israel and Judah. The statements here are similar to opening remarks made by a prosecutor in a court case. Or a presentation to teach or confront the people. See Dearman (pages 294–295) and Stuart (pages 187–188). Some versions use headings that correspond to such a context.

Here are some examples of other headings:

God’s Lawsuit against Israel: Breach of Covenant (NET)

Charges against Israel and Judah (NLT)

In the Masoretic Text, the first verse of Hosea chapter 12 begins here. The Notes and Display will follow the

majority of English versions that regard this verse as Hosea 11:12.

12:1a–b (combined/reordered)

- Israel makes plans that are as futile as chasing the east wind all day long.
- Everything that the people of Israel do from morning to night is useless and destructive. (GNT)

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{1a} Ephraim chases **the wind**

^{1b} and pursues **the east wind** all day long;

These lines are metaphors that compare the people of Israel to an animal that attempts to catch and eat wind for its food.

Here are some ways to translate these figures of speech:

- Use a metaphor. Make the similarity explicit if it will be helpful. For example:

Ephraim is a foolish calf that tries to eat wind.

- Use a simile. Make the similarity or topic explicit if it will be helpful. For example:

Ephraim is like an animal that feeds on wind instead of pasture grass.

Israel’s behavior is as useless as feeding on wind.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

The people of Israel try to achieve worthless goals.

12:1a Ephraim chases the wind

- Ephraim is like an animal that eats wind instead of grass.
- The people of Israel try to accomplish foolish things.

Ephraim chases the wind: There are two main interpretations of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as chases:

1. The word means “feeds/graze.” It usually refers to an animal that grazes in a pasture. For example:

Ephraim feeds on the wind (ESV) (ESV, KJV, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB)

1. The word means “herd.” It usually refers to the herding of animals. For example:

Ephraim herds the wind (NRSV) (NJPS, NRSV)

1. The word means “chase.” For example:

What Israel does is as useless as chasing the wind (NCV) (BSB, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. McComiskey (page 197) and Keil (page 94) favor this interpretation. Hosea uses similar comparisons of Ephraim to animals elsewhere (10:11–13; 11:4).

wind: In this context, the word wind is used figuratively to mean “a vain or empty thing.” BDB (#7307) 2e. The metaphor “feeds on the wind” means to strive after what is worthless, meaningless, or futile. Keil, Wood, Davies, McComiskey, Hubbard, and Macintosh.

12:1b and pursues the east wind all day long;

- All day long he chases after the wind that blows from the desert.
- They continually try to get what is worthless.

pursues the east wind all day long: This metaphor means to do something that is useless and potentially harmful. Dearman (pages 297–299). Also see Stuart, Keil, Garrett, Macintosh, and Davies.

east wind: This phrase probably refers to the strong wind in Israel that blows from the eastern desert. It is a hot, dry, destructive wind. The Sirocco. Here the phrase may imply the destruction that will result from the foolish behavior of Israel, described in 12:1c–e.

all day long: There are two interpretations of the connection of this phrase to the surrounding context:

1. The phrase all day is part of the previous clause. It indicates that Ephraim pursues the east wind all day. McComiskey (page 197) says that the stupidity of this activity is heightened by the fact that this hypothetical animal does this “all day long.” For example:

Ephraim feeds on the wind, and pursues the east wind all day long (ESV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The phrase all day is part of the following clause. It indicates that Ephraim multiplies lies and violence all day. For example:

he daily increases lies and desolation (NKJV) (NJPS, NKJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

The phrase all day long is an expression that means continually. Keil (pages 94–95). Some versions translate it that way. For example:

Ephraim feeds on wind, and pursues the east wind continually. (NASB)

12:1c he multiplies lies and violence;

- His lies and wrongs have become more and more numerous.
- How violent they are, and so deceitful!

he multiplies lies and violence: The Hebrew word for multiplies means “make numerous.” TWOT (#2103) 1. It indicates that lying and violence continued to increase.

violence: In Hebrew, this word means “violent action.” In this context, it may refer particularly to social wrongs such as oppression and other evil behavior. BDB (#8270) and DCH (Vol. 8, p. 266).

12:1d–e

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{1d} he makes a covenant **with Assyria**

^{1e}and sends olive oil **to Egypt**.

These lines give examples of Israel’s attempts to gain favor with powerful nations. They are also examples of the kind of futile behavior that Hosea described as grazing on wind and pursuing the east wind. Here are some reasons this behavior was futile:

1. It challenged Yahweh’s role as Israel’s one true savior. Davies (page 271).
2. Israel’s covenant with Yahweh was exclusive. It did not allow them to make a covenant with Assyria. Dearman (pages 297–299).
3. It was an act of disloyalty to God and of political foolishness. Hubbard (page 201).
4. It gave a false sense of security. Garrett (pages 235–236).

12:1d**he makes a covenant with Assyria**

- He agrees to ally with the nation of Assyria,
- For example, they make an agreement to serve the rulers of Assyria,

he makes a covenant with Assyria: This clause refers to a political alliance between Israel and Assyria. It may refer specifically to the promise of Israelite king Hoshea to make Israel a faithful subject of Assyria. Stuart (pages 189–190), Garrett (pages 235–236), Davies (page 271), and IVPBBCOT “Assyria treaty.” See 2 Kings 17:3. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they make a covenant with Assyria (ESV)

they are making an alliance with Assyria (NLT)

They make agreements with Assyria (NCV)

12:1e**and sends olive oil to Egypt.**

- while at the same time he sends a gift of oil to Egypt to gain its help.”
- but they also send olive oil to Egypt, Assyria’s enemy, to gain their favor.”

and sends olive oil to Egypt: This clause probably refers to a gift that Israel sent to Egypt to gain their help or to make a treaty. Dearman (pages 297–299), Davies (pages 271–272), Keil (pages 94–95), Garrett (pages 235–236), and Stuart (pages 189–190). This action was foolish and dangerous for Israel. It caused Assyria to interpret it as disloyalty to them and invited their anger.

olive oil: The Hebrew word is literally oil. It refers to olive oil. Olive oil was abundant in Israel. It was valuable in that region, especially in Egypt where olives were not grown. IVPBBCOT “Assyria treaty.” Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and send olive oil as tribute to Egypt (NET)

while sending olive oil to buy support from Egypt (NLT)

Hosea 12:2**Section 11:12–12:14: Israel is deceitful and refuses to return to the LORD**

In this section, the LORD accuses both Israel and Judah of wrongdoing, but then focuses on the wicked behavior of Israel (11:12–12:1). Hosea continues to describe Israel, giving examples from the life of their ancestor Jacob to show that Israel followed his bad behavior (12:2–8). The LORD then reminded the people how they had responded wickedly when he led them in the past (12:9–11). Hosea concludes this section by comparing Jacob’s care of sheep in Aram with the LORD’s care of his people through a prophet or prophets.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel’s Sin (NIV)

Israel and Judah Are Condemned (GNT)

Paragraph 12:2–6

In this paragraph and also in 12:12, Hosea gives examples from the life of Jacob. Scholars do not agree on the purpose of the examples. There are two main views:

1. These examples show the similarity between Jacob and his descendants. Jacob set a bad example and his descendants followed it.
2. These examples show the contrast between Jacob and his descendants. Jacob set a good example but his descendants did not follow it.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Hosea 12:2 says that the LORD will punish Jacob according to his ways. Examples from Jacob’s life immediately follow in 12:3. It is reasonable to assume that these are examples of behavior or character traits that deserve punishment. Most versions and commentaries support this interpretation. A number of versions make interpretation (1) explicit, especially in 12:3. See the comments on that verse for examples. No versions make interpretation (2) explicit. Commentaries that favor interpretation (1) include Davies, Hubbard, Dearman, Garrett, Macintosh, and McComiskey. Some who favor interpretation (2) are Stuart, Keil, and Wood. For more details, see the following notes on these verses.

12:2a–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{2a} The Lord also brings a charge against Judah.

^{2b} He will punish Jacob **according to his ways**

^{2c}and repay him **according to his deeds**.

There is an ellipsis in the third line. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from the second line. For example:

^{2c}and He will repay him **according to his deeds**

In these lines, Hosea tells the descendants of Jacob that the LORD will punish them. The first line is a general statement. The second and third lines give more detail. He includes the people of Judah and the people of Israel. He will punish them fairly, just as they deserve.

12:2a

The LORD also brings a charge against Judah.

- ¶ Yahweh has a complaint/quarrel against the people of Judah,
- ¶ Yahweh accuses Judah of wickedness.

The LORD also brings a charge against Judah: Here Judah is parallel with “Jacob” in line 2b. This line is a figure of speech (synecdoche) in which Judah refers to all the descendants of Jacob. So the charge against the southern kingdom of Judah is also a charge against the northern kingdom of Israel. Stuart (page 190) suggests that this is an example of ascending parallelism in which a smaller subset of the whole (i.e. Judah) comes first in order. Although Judah is mentioned first, the charge is against the whole people. Others that agree both kingdoms are in view are Keil, Dearman, McComiskey, Hubbard, and Wood.

charge: The Hebrew word means “to fight with words,” as in a quarrel or a legal case. The same word is used in Hosea 4:1, where the BSB translates it as “case.” In both verses, some English versions use an expression that refers to an actual trial. Some who understand it as legal terminology describing a court case are Hubbard (page 202), McComiskey (page 200), Dearman (pages 299–302), and Stuart (page 190). For example:

The Lord also has a covenant lawsuit against Judah (NET)

But this verse may refer to an informal accusation. If possible, use a general expression that could be understood as either a formal or an informal accusation. Some who say that it may not describe a lawsuit or court case are Garrett (page 236) and Davies (page 272). For example:

The Lord has an accusation to bring against the people of Judah (GNT)

12:2b

He will punish Jacob according to his ways

- and he will punish Jacob for the evil he has done.
- He will fairly judge all the descendants of Jacob for their crimes.

He will punish Jacob according to his ways: This clause means that the LORD will punish Jacob fairly. The expression punish...according to his ways indicates the degree or extent of punishment. The punishment will be exactly what people deserve. It will not be too much or too little. The expression his ways refers to his sinful conduct. Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

he will punish Jacob as his conduct merits (NJB)

He is about to punish Jacob for all his deceitful ways (NLT)

punishes Jacob because of the way their people act (GW)

Jacob: Jacob is the ancestor of the people of Israel and Judah. But here Jacob is a figure of speech (metonymy) in which the name represents all his descendants. Some versions make this meaning explicit. For example:

the descendants of Jacob (CEV)

12:2c

and repay him according to his deeds.

- He will give back to him exactly what he deserves.
- He will pay them back based on what their deeds deserve.

and repay him according to his deeds: The meaning of this line is very similar to 2b. The Hebrew word for repay means “to give back.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 1432) 4b. Here the word deeds refers to wicked actions. Hubbard (page 202). This line describes the LORD’s punishment of the people of Israel. As in the previous line, the expression according to his deeds means that the extent of the LORD’s punishment will be exactly what the descendants of Jacob deserve. Here are some other ways to translate this line:

he will give them what they deserve (NCV)

he will repay him as his deeds deserve (NJB)

Hosea 12:3

Section 11:12–12:14: Israel is deceitful and refuses to return to the LORD

In this section, the LORD accuses both Israel and Judah of wrongdoing, but then focuses on the wicked behavior of Israel (11:12–12:1). Hosea continues to describe Israel, giving examples from the life of their ancestor Jacob to show that Israel followed his bad behavior (12:2–8). The LORD then reminded the people how they had responded wickedly when he led them in the past (12:9–11). Hosea concludes this section by comparing Jacob's care of sheep in Aram with the LORD's care of his people through a prophet or prophets.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel's Sin (NIV)

Israel and Judah Are Condemned (GNT)

Paragraph 12:2–6

In this paragraph and also in 12:12, Hosea gives examples from the life of Jacob. Scholars do not agree on the purpose of the examples. There are two main views:

1. These examples show the similarity between Jacob and his descendants. Jacob set a bad example and his descendants followed it.
2. These examples show the contrast between Jacob and his descendants. Jacob set a good example but his descendants did not follow it.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Hosea 12:2 says that the LORD will punish Jacob according to his ways. Examples from Jacob's life immediately follow in 12:3. It is reasonable to assume that these are examples of behavior or character traits that deserve punishment. Most versions and commentaries support this interpretation. A number of versions make interpretation (1) explicit, especially in 12:3. See the comments on that verse for examples. No versions make interpretation (2) explicit. Commentaries that favor interpretation (1) include Davies, Hubbard, Dearman, Garrett, Macintosh, and McComiskey. Some who favor interpretation (2) are Stuart, Keil, and Wood. For more details, see the following notes on these verses.

12:3a–4b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{3a} In the womb **he grasped his brother's heel**;

^{3b} and in his vigor **he wrestled with God**.

^{4a} Yes, **he struggled with the angel and prevailed**;

^{4b} **he wept and sought His favor**;

Lines 3a and 3b may be a figure of speech that indicates completeness. Here it describes Jacob's entire life. He struggled to overcome others from infancy to adulthood. McComiskey (page 201). Lines 4a and 4b give more details about Jacob's behavior. It is possible that these lines are a chiasm. If so, then lines 3a and 4b may refer to Jacob and his brother Esau. Lines 3b and 4a refer to Jacob and God. See Holladay, W. L. in 'Chiasmus, the key to Hosea xii 3–6' VT 16 (1966), pp. 53–64. See also Garrett (pages 238–241). Dearman (pages 304–305) agrees that a chiasm is possible. Andersen and Freedman (pages 608–614) agree that 12:4b may refer to Jacob and Esau. This view parallels the account of Jacob and Esau in Genesis 33:4–10. However, it is not recommended because of lack of representation in versions.

12:3a

In the womb he grasped his brother's heel,

- When Jacob was still in his mother's womb, he held on to his brother's heel.
- Even before Jacob was born, he struggled with his brother Esau.

In the womb he grasped his brother's heel: In this clause, Hosea refers to Genesis 25:26, which describes the birth of Jacob and his twin brother Esau. Esau came out first, then Jacob. Jacob was holding Esau's heel when he was born.

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as "he grasped...heel" looks and sounds like the name "Jacob." Genesis 25:26 indicates that he was named "Jacob" for this reason.

This Hebrew word has two main meanings. It can mean "he took by the heel." It can also mean "he attacked/supplanted." TWOT (#1676) gives the literal meaning as "take by the heel" and the figurative meaning as "supplant." In Genesis 27:36, Esau makes the second meaning explicit. Esau suggests that Jacob is rightly named because twice he deceived/supplanted him. Hosea may be using the Hebrew word as a pun or wordplay on Jacob's name in which both meanings are intended. Davies (page 272), Hubbard (page 203),

and Dearman (pages 302–304). Either of the following translation options is acceptable:

- Make the first meaning explicit. For example:

In the womb he took his brother by the heel (ESV)

- Make the second meaning explicit. For example:

In the womb he tried to supplant his brother (NRSV)

In the womb he attacked his brother (NET)

The meaning lines in the Display will each give one of these options.

12:3b

and in his vigor he wrestled with God.

- And when he was an adult, he fought against God.
- And when he was a grown man, he used his strength to struggle with God.

and in his vigor he wrestled with God: In 3b and 4a, Hosea refers to Genesis 32:28. That verse says that Jacob has struggled with God and with men and has overcome.

and in his vigor: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as and in his vigor means “physical power” in this context. HALOT (electronic edition, page 22) l. The Hebrew word resembles the word awn “wickedness.” Hosea may have chosen this word to create a pun or wordplay that associates Jacob’s manhood with wickedness. See Macintosh (page 481), Davies (page 273), Andersen and Freedman (page 607), Garrett (pages 236–239), and Dearman (pages 302–304). Here this word implies both age and strength. McComiskey (page 201) gives the paraphrase ‘In the strength of his manhood.’ He comments that the pairing of this word with ‘in the womb’ makes it likely that it shares the function of designating a period of time in Jacob’s life. Most versions make Jacob’s adult age explicit in some way but leave “strength” implicit. Here are some examples:

in maturity he wrestled against God (NJB)

in his manhood he strove with God (RSV)

when Jacob grew up, he fought against God (GNT)

In some languages, it may be necessary to make the meaning “strength” explicit. For example:

When he became a man, he used his strength to strive with God

he wrestled with God: The Hebrew word for he wrestled means “to strive, contend.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 1354) śarah l “to strive, contend.” The Hebrew word is the basis of the name “Israel,” which means “he who contends with God.” Macintosh (page 482), Hubbard (page 203), Davies (page 272), and Stuart (pages 190–191). The same word is repeated in 12:4 as “struggled,” where it refers to the same event. See also Genesis 32:28. See the previous comment for examples of other ways to translate this clause.

God: In this clause the Hebrew word for God is elohim and not Yahweh. Some versions translate elohim as God instead of “LORD.” Use your general term for God here.

Hosea 12:4

Section 11:12–12:14: Israel is deceitful and refuses to return to the LORD

In this section, the LORD accuses both Israel and Judah of wrongdoing, but then focuses on the wicked behavior of Israel (11:12–12:1). Hosea continues to describe Israel, giving examples from the life of their ancestor Jacob to show that Israel followed his bad behavior (12:2–8). The LORD then reminded the people how they had responded wickedly when he led them in the past (12:9–11). Hosea concludes this section by comparing Jacob’s care of sheep in Aram with the LORD’s care of his people through a prophet or prophets.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel’s Sin (NIV)

Israel and Judah Are Condemned (GNT)

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1. These examples show the similarity between Jacob and his descendants. Jacob set a bad example and his descendants followed it.
2. These examples show the contrast between Jacob and his descendants. Jacob set a good example but his descendants did not follow it.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Hosea 12:2 says that the LORD will punish Jacob according to his ways. Examples from Jacob's life immediately follow in 12:3. It is reasonable to assume that these are examples of behavior or character traits that deserve punishment. Most versions and commentaries support this interpretation. A number of versions make interpretation (1) explicit, especially in 12:3. See the comments on that verse for examples. No versions make interpretation (2) explicit. Commentaries that favor interpretation (1) include Davies, Hubbard, Dearman, Garrett, Macintosh, and McComiskey. Some who favor interpretation (2) are Stuart, Keil, and Wood. For more details, see the following notes on these verses.

12:4a

Yes, he struggled with the angel and prevailed;

- He fought against an angel and defeated him.
- Yes, he wrestled with the angel of God and won.

Yes, he struggled with the angel and prevailed:

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Yes, he wrestled with the angel and won. (NLT)

he fought against an angel and won (GNT)

he struggled: The Hebrew word means “persist” or “persevere.” It is similar to the word that the BSB translates as “wrestled” in 12:3b. A majority of commentators think the Hebrew verb here is a form of the word *śarah*, which is the word in the phrase “he contended with God” in 12:3. See Patterson and Hill (page 73). Alternative suggestions are that it is a form of the word *sarar* “rule” or *śor* “be dominant.” See Davies (page 274) and Dearman (page 304).

with the angel: The Hebrew word for with is a preposition that means “with” or “against.” BDB (#413) 4. Most ancient and modern versions and some commentators support this understanding. See Garrett (pages 238–141), Stuart (page 191), McComiskey (page 201), and Wood (page 216). A second interpretation is that here *ʾel* may be the word “God” rather than a preposition. The meaning might be that God or the angel of God prevailed. See Andersen and Freedman (page 608), Davies (page 274), Hubbard (page 203), and Macintosh (page 483). However, this second interpretation is not recommended. It lacks support from Genesis 32:25 and most versions. The Hebrew word for angel is made explicit here, although it does not occur in Genesis 32.

prevailed: In Hebrew, this word means to “overcome” or “be victor.” BDB (#3201) 2.

12:4b

he wept and sought His favor;

- Jacob wept and pleaded for him to be gracious.
- Then with tears he asked the angel to bless him.

he wept and sought His favor: The pronoun referents in this clause are left implicit in Hebrew. Either Jacob wept and begged the angel for his favor or the angel wept and begged Jacob for his favor. The clause probably refers back to Genesis 32:26. In that verse, Jacob asked the angel to bless him. This is the majority view of modern commentators and versions. It is favored by Macintosh, Wood, McComiskey, Hubbard, Davies, Stuart, Garrett, Dearman, and Keil. This is also the most natural way to understand most modern versions. An alternative view is that the angel wept and asked Jacob to let him go. It is favored by Andersen and Freedman and by rabbinic commentators Rashi, ibn Ezra and Kimchi, cited in Macintosh (page 485). The alternative view is not discussed in the notes because of a lack of representation in versions.

12:4c

he found Him at Bethel and spoke with Him there—

- At Bethel, he met with God, and God spoke with us^(incl) there.
- At Bethel, Jacob met with God, and it was there that God spoke with us^(incl), his descendants.

he found Him at Bethel and spoke with Him there:

In this sentence, Hosea probably refers back to the events found in Genesis 35:1–15. There are no explicit pronoun referents, so it is not clear who found whom or who talked with whom at Bethel.

he found Him at Bethel: There are two ways to interpret the referents of he and Him:

1. Jacob found God at Bethel. For example:

At Bethel he met God (NAB) (BSB, ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NET, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. God found Jacob at Bethel. For example:

God met him at Bethel (REB) (GNT, NCV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. According to Genesis 35:2 Jacob told his household that they were going to Bethel, and that he planned to build an altar there to God. It is there that God spoke to him and promised to make him into the mighty nation of Israel.

Bethel: Elsewhere, Hosea refers to Bethel as Beth Aven “house of wickedness.” Here, however, Hosea uses the actual name of Bethel.

and spoke with Him there: There is a textual issue here concerning the pronoun that the BSB translates as Him:

1. The Masoretic Text has “he spoke with us.” HOTTTP suggests following this option, but gives it a C (“uncertain”) rating. For example:

and there God spoke with us— (ESV) (CEV, ESV, KJV, NASB, NJB)

1. The Syriac Peshitta and some LXX traditions have “he spoke with him.” For example:

And there he spoke with him (NET) (BSB, GNT, GW, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

The Display will follow option (1). There is no evidence of an error in the MT. Hosea may have used the inclusive pronoun “us” to indicate that God’s promises to Jacob in Genesis 35:9–12 also applied to himself and his fellow-Israelites, all of whom were descendants of Jacob. Keil (page 96), Andersen and Freedman (page 614), Patterson and Hill (page 73), Davies (page 276), and Macintosh (page 485).

However, you may also follow option (2). This option better fits the wording of the historical context in Genesis 35. In that chapter, God speaks to “him,” not to “us.”

Hosea 12:5

Section 11:12–12:14: Israel is deceitful and refuses to return to the LORD

In this section, the LORD accuses both Israel and Judah of wrongdoing, but then focuses on the wicked behavior of Israel (11:12–12:1). Hosea continues to describe Israel, giving examples from the life of their ancestor Jacob to show that Israel followed his bad behavior (12:2–8). The LORD then reminded the people how they had responded wickedly when he led them in the past (12:9–11). Hosea concludes this section by comparing Jacob’s care of sheep in Aram with the LORD’s care of his people through a prophet or prophets.

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Israel’s Sin (NIV)

Israel and Judah Are Condemned (GNT)

Paragraph 12:2–6

In this paragraph and also in 12:12, Hosea gives examples from the life of Jacob. Scholars do not agree on the purpose of the examples. There are two main views:

1. These examples show the similarity between Jacob and his descendants. Jacob set a bad example and his descendants followed it.
2. These examples show the contrast between Jacob and his descendants. Jacob set a good example but his descendants did not follow it.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Hosea 12:2 says that the LORD will punish Jacob according to his ways. Examples from Jacob’s life immediately follow in 12:3. It is reasonable to assume that these are examples of behavior or character traits that deserve punishment. Most versions and commentaries support this interpretation. A number of versions make interpretation (1) explicit, especially in 12:3. See the comments on that verse for examples. No versions make interpretation (2) explicit. Commentaries that favor interpretation (1) include Davies, Hubbard, Dearman, Garrett, Macintosh, and McComiskey. Some who favor interpretation (2) are Stuart, Keil, and Wood. For more details, see the following notes on these verses.

12:5

In this verse, Hosea reminds the people of Israel that it is Yahweh who spoke with Jacob at Bethel. Macintosh (page 488) and McComiskey (page 202). Here are some possible reasons for this reminder:

1. Like their ancestor Jacob, they were the people of Yahweh, and they were obligated to serve him. Stuart (pages 191–192) and Macintosh (page 488).
2. The people should not confuse Yahweh with the idols that they worshiped. Hubbard (page 205) and Garrett (pages 240–241).
3. Yahweh has power and authority over all things on earth and in heaven. For this reason, the people should be confident in him and should do what Hosea urges them to do in 12:6. Keil (pages 97–98), McComiskey (page 202), and Davies (page 276).

12:5a

the LORD is the God of Hosts—

- This was Yahweh, God Almighty.
- Yahweh is the God of Armies.

the LORD is the God of Hosts: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “and Yahweh the God of (the) hosts.” The first word “and” in the Hebrew phrase connects it to the previous verse. Some versions leave this con-

nection to the previous verse implied. Some other versions make the connection clear. For example:

even the Lord... (NASB)

This was the Lord... (GNT)

yes, Yahweh... (NJB)

Indicate the connection of this phrase to the previous verse in a natural way in your language.

The Hebrew word for “hosts” means “armies.” In this phrase, the word “armies” could refer to armies of angels in heaven, McComiskey (page 202) suggests that this title may stem from the appearance to Joshua of an angel called “the commander of the host of the Lord” in Joshua 5:13–15. or to human armies on earth, or to both. Hubbard (page 205) suggests that the term refers to both the armies of heaven and of earth. Garrett (pages 240–241) note that in Amos the name “Yahweh God of hosts” describes the God of all the earth who judges the nations. Human armies were generally involved in carrying out judgment.

The phrase includes two different words for God, Yahweh and ‘elohim (God). Try to include both words for God in your translation if possible.

This phrase is used as a title. Here are some acceptable ways to translate this title:

- Translate it literally. Another literal translation is “God Sabaoth” (NJB), in which “Sabaoth” is a transliteration of the Hebrew word for “armies.” For example:

The Lord the God of Hosts (REB)

- Translate the title as a clause. For example:

The LORD is the God of Armies (GW) This is different from Hebrew, where the phrase ‘God of Hosts/ Armies’ is unlikely to be the predicate of ‘the LORD.’ See Macintosh (page 488). Nevertheless, in some languages this may be a natural way to translate the title.

- Make explicit the implied meaning of great power. For example:

The Lord God Almighty (NET)

The Lord God All-Powerful (NCV)

The Almighty LORD God

12:5b

the LORD is His name of renown.

- Yes, Yahweh the honored/exalted one is his name!
- Yahweh is the great name by which he will be remembered.

the LORD is His name of renown: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “Yahweh his remembrance.” The Hebrew word for “remembrance” means “memorial, by which one is remembered.” BDB (#2143) 2. Here are three acceptable translation options:

- Translate “remembrance” as name. McComiskey (page 202) states that “remembrance” occurs in parallel with “name” in a number of passages. Davies (page 276) calls it a common equivalent to shem, the regular word for “name.” Also see Andersen and Freedman (page 615). For example:

the Lord is his name (NLT)

- Make the greatness/power of the LORD explicit as well as name. For example:

the Lord is his great name (NCV)

- Translate both “remembrance” and name. For example:

the Lord is the name by which he is remembered! (NET)

Hosea 12:6

Section 11:12–12:14: Israel is deceitful and refuses to return to the LORD

In this section, the LORD accuses both Israel and Judah of wrongdoing, but then focuses on the wicked behavior of Israel (11:12–12:1). Hosea continues to describe Israel, giving examples from the life of their ancestor Jacob to show that Israel followed his bad behavior (12:2–8). The LORD then reminded the people how they had responded wickedly when he led them in the past (12:9–11). Hosea concludes this section by comparing Jacob’s care of sheep in Aram with the LORD’s care of his people through a prophet or prophets.

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Israel and Judah Are Condemned (GNT)

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It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Hosea 12:2 says that the LORD will punish Jacob according to his ways. Examples from Jacob's life immediately follow in 12:3. It is reasonable to assume that these are examples of behavior or character traits that deserve punishment. Most versions and commentaries support this interpretation. A number of versions make interpretation (1) explicit, especially in 12:3. See the comments on that verse for examples. No versions make interpretation (2) explicit. Commentaries that favor interpretation (1) include Davies, Hubbard, Dearman, Garrett, Macintosh, and McComiskey. Some who favor interpretation (2) are Stuart, Keil, and Wood. For more details, see the following notes on these verses.

12:6a–c

Notice the parallel parts that are related in meaning:

^{6a} But you must **return to your God**,

^{6b} **maintaining love and justice**,

^{6c} and **always waiting on your God**.

In these lines, Hosea urges the descendants of Jacob to return to the LORD. In the first line, he gives a general command. In the second and third lines he explains the actions that their return to God should include. An alternative view is that God was telling Jacob to return to him. However, this view is not supported in the Genesis passages concerning Jacob. Also, if God was speaking, then first person “me” would be expected instead of the phrase “your God.” See Andersen and Freedman (page 615), McComiskey (page 202), and Macintosh (page 491).

12:6a**But you must return to your God,**

- So/But now, you^(plur) descendants of Jacob, return to your God.
- Turn back to your God!

But: The Hebrew clause has a word that connects this verse to the previous verses. Here are some acceptable ways to understand how this verse connects to the previous ones:

- As a response. The logical response of the people to the actions of their ancestor Jacob and to the greatness of God is to turn to God. For example:

Therefore, return to your God (NASB)

So return to your God (CEV)

- As a contrast. Hosea urged the people to turn to God. This contrasts with Jacob, who struggled with God. Some may see a different contrast. Jacob sought the blessing of the angel, but the people of Israel refused to seek God. For example:

But you must return to your God (NET)

Some versions do not explicitly connect this verse to the previous ones. They leave the logical connection implied. For example:

You must return to your God! (NJPS)

Translate the connection to the previous verse in a natural way in your language.

you...your: In Hebrew, the pronouns you and your are singular. Most versions and commentaries regard them as collective singular pronouns that refer to the people of Israel in Hosea's time. The Display will use “you/your” plural, referring to the people.

you must return to your God: In Hebrew, this command is more literally “in your God you will return.” There are two main interpretations of this command: In Hebrew, the verb “return” has imperfect form here. Most versions translate it as a command or a plea. For the use of imperfect as a command, see IBHS: 31.5 Volitional Uses of the Non-Perfective.

1. God is the goal or destination to which they must return. BDB (#1119) 4 states that the prefix b- is often used with verbs of motion, when the movement to a place results in rest in it. BDB cites this verse as

meaning “to return (and rest) in thy God.” Similarly, Keil (page 97) suggests the meaning: “turn as to enter into vital fellowship with God.” For example:

You must return to your God (GW) (BSB, CEV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. God will help them return. HALOT (electronic edition, page 105) 16b describes this use as: “introduces the means or the instrument.” It does not mention Hosea 12:6 specifically. But see Macintosh (page 491), Hubbard (page 206), and Davies (page 276). This interpretation does not assume that the people are to return to God. It may refer to a return to love and justice as described in 6b. For example:

Turn back with God’s help (NJB) (ESV, NJB, REB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. In some languages, the subject you can be left implied. For example:

So now, come back to your God (NLT)

12:6b maintaining love and justice,

- Be loyal and just.
- Show^(plur) love to everyone and do what is right.

maintaining love and justice: The Hebrew word for maintaining in this context means to “keep” or obey God’s commands to show love and justice. DCH (Vol. 8, p. 478) I 6. See also McComiskey (page 202).

love: This is the same Hebrew word Hosea uses elsewhere. See the comment on “loving devotion” under 4:1c. It is a primary attitude and behavior required by God’s covenant with Israel. McComiskey (page 202).

justice: The Hebrew word for justice is also found elsewhere in Hosea. Here the meaning is the same as in 10:4b, where the BSB translates it as “judgment.” It refers to legal transactions and conduct that are fair and just.

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate “love” and justice using different forms of the words. For example:

Be loyal and just (GNT)

12:6c and always waiting on your God.

- Always trust in your^(plur) God patiently.
- Depend on your God at all times.

and always waiting on your God: This clause urges the people to wait for God to save and protect them. It implies an attitude of faith and trust in God instead of other sources of security. Garrett (page 241), Davies (page 276), McComiskey (page 203) and Stuart (page 192). The Hebrew word for always means “lasting” or “continually.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 1748) 1.

waiting: In Hebrew, this word refers to patient, trustful endurance. The same Hebrew word is often translated in other places as “hope.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 1082) Piel 2—b to hope, await. Hubbard (page 206) and Macintosh (page 491). Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and always trust in him as your God (NCV)

Patiently trust him (CEV)

and always depend on him (NLT)

Hosea 12:7

Section 11:12–12:14: Israel is deceitful and refuses to return to the LORD

In this section, the LORD accuses both Israel and Judah of wrongdoing, but then focuses on the wicked behavior of Israel (11:12–12:1). Hosea continues to describe Israel, giving examples from the life of their ancestor Jacob to show that Israel followed his bad behavior (12:2–8). The LORD then reminded the people how they had responded wickedly when he led them in the past (12:9–11). Hosea concludes this section by comparing Jacob’s care of sheep in Aram with the LORD’s care of his people through a prophet or prophets.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel’s Sin (NIV)

Israel and Judah Are Condemned (GNT)

Paragraph 12:7–8

In the previous paragraph, Hosea urged the people to return to God. This paragraph describes what the people do instead. They become wealthy through fraud and deceit, but they deny that they have sinned.

In Hebrew, the speaker is not identified. It may be Hosea or the LORD. Most versions leave the identity of the speaker implied. Some versions supply “the LORD

says.” The Notes and the Display will assume that Hosea continues to speak here.

12:7

A merchant loves to defraud with dishonest scales in his hands.

- ¶ But instead, your^(plur) merchants use scales that indicate the wrong weight. How you^(plur) love to cheat others!
- ¶ Instead, the people are like merchants that deceive people by using scales with incorrect weights. They love to cheat people. (GW)

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

A merchant **loves to defraud**;

with dishonest scales in his hands.

These lines compare Israel to a dishonest merchant. Most versions leave this comparison to Israel implied. Some versions make it explicit. For example:

Israel, you enjoy cheating (CEV)

A merchant loves to defraud with dishonest scales in his hands: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “Canaan/merchant in his hand [are] scales of deceit, he loves to defraud.” This description is probably a figure of speech (synecdoche) in which deceitful scales in the hand represents general dishonesty in business dealings. Stuart (pages 192–193) and Andersen and Freedman (pages 615–617). For example:

The businessmen love to cheat (NET)

A merchant: In Hebrew, this word is literally “canaan.” In Hosea’s time, this word could mean merchant. This is probably the main meaning here, and it refers to the people of Israel. However, in some contexts, this word refers to the land that the people of Israel conquered and occupied, or to the people who lived in the land before the Israelites came. BDB (#3667) II explains that the meaning of merchant(s) is because Canaanites, especially Phoenicians, were traders. Here the word may be a wordplay in which it means both merchant and “Canaanite” simultaneously. If so, the word may link the wicked behavior of the Israelites with that of the Canaanites. This suggestion is made by Davies, Hubbard, Macintosh, Garrett, Patterson and Hill, and Stuart. Most modern versions translate the Hebrew word as A merchant or something similar. Some versions make the double meaning explicit. For example:

The people of Israel are as dishonest as the Canaanites; they love to cheat their customers with false scales. Adapted from the GNT.

loves to defraud: This clause makes an even stronger accusation about the dishonesty of the Israelites. Davies (page 278). The Hebrew word for defraud means “oppress” or “exploit.” It refers to the abuse of power or authority against people of lower status. TWOT (#1713) says that the verb is concerned with acts of abuse of power or authority, the burdening, trampling, and crushing of those lower in station. The Hebrew form of the word loves indicates an ongoing action. BHRG 19.2.2. The merchant regularly takes delight in defrauding people. Here are additional examples:

...taking advantage of others (CEV)

To defraud is his delight. (NJB)

He loves to oppress. (ESV)

with dishonest scales: scales were made of a bar from which hung two balanced surfaces. A merchant used stone weights to determine the value of the money he charged. The phrase with dishonest scales refers to cheating by improperly suspending the balance or by altering the weights.” McComiskey (page 205). The same Hebrew word that the BSB translates as dishonest here is translated as “deceit” in 11:12. Here are some other ways to translate the phrase:

false scales (GNT)

false balances (RSV)

Hosea 12:8

Section 11:12–12:14: Israel is deceitful and refuses to return to the LORD

In this section, the LORD accuses both Israel and Judah of wrongdoing, but then focuses on the wicked behavior of Israel (11:12–12:1). Hosea continues to describe Israel, giving examples from the life of their ancestor Jacob to show that Israel followed his bad behavior (12:2–8). The LORD then reminded the people how they had responded wickedly when he led them in the past (12:9–11). Hosea concludes this section by comparing Jacob’s care of sheep in Aram with the LORD’s care of his people through a prophet or prophets.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel's Sin (NIV)

Israel and Judah Are Condemned (GNT)

Paragraph 12:7–8

In the previous paragraph, Hosea urged the people to return to God. This paragraph describes what the people do instead. They become wealthy through fraud and deceit, but they deny that they have sinned.

In Hebrew, the speaker is not identified. It may be Hosea or the LORD. Most versions leave the identity of the speaker implied. Some versions supply “the LORD says.” The Notes and the Display will assume that Hosea continues to speak here.

12:8

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{8a}And Ephraim boasts, “How rich I have become!

^{8b} I have found wealth for myself.

These lines quote what the people say about themselves. They boast of the wealth that they obtained from cheating and defrauding others that is described in 12:7.

12:8a**And Ephraim boasts: “How rich I have become!**

- You^(plur) Israelites boast, saying, “We^(incl) are so rich!
- They brag about how rich they are,

Ephraim boasts: In Hebrew, these words are more literally “Ephraim said.” The context implies that the words Ephraim says are boastful. The BSB and some other versions translate the word “said” as “boast” to make this meaning explicit.

How rich I have become!: There is a textual issue about the word that the BSB translates as How:

1. The Masoretic text has a word that adds intensity. Davies (page 278), McComiskey (page 205), Andersen and Freedman (page 617). For example:

Surely I have become rich (NASB) (BSB, CEV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The LXX has a word that indicates contrast. For example:

Yet I am become rich (KJV) (ESV, KJV, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. Some versions express this intensity with special punctuation or by adding words for this purpose. For example:

I am rich! (NLT)

“Ah, I have become rich (NJPS)

Use a natural way in your language to indicate this intensity.

12:8b**I have found wealth for myself.**

- How wealthy we^(incl) have become!
- about the great fortune they have made for themselves,

I have found wealth for myself: This line repeats the statement of 8a using different words. In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “I have acquired wealth for myself.”

Some versions leave the Hebrew phrase for myself implicit. The phrase may indicate Ephraim’s pride that he gained the wealth without help from anyone else. Some versions, like the BSB above, translate this meaning explicitly. For example:

I’ve made a fortune all by myself! (NLT)

I earned it all on my own (CEV)

12:8c**In all my labors, they can find in me no iniquity that is sinful.”**

- And we^(incl) have done nothing wrong to get it. We are sinless.”
- and that no one can accuse them of cheating/ wrongdoing.”

In all my labors, they can find in me no iniquity that is sinful: There are several textual variants of this clause that affect the meaning:

1. The Masoretic Text has “[in] all my toils people will not find in me iniquity which [is] sin.” Ephraim is the speaker. In this sentence, he boasts that he obtained his wealth without committing sin. For example:

In all of my gain no offense has been found in me that would be sin. (NRSV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The LXX has “none of the fruits of his toil will be available to him, because of the injustice with which he sinned.” God is the speaker (through Hosea). In this sentence, God says that Ephraim will not be able to use his wealth, because he obtained it sinfully. For example:

But of all his gains he will keep nothing because of the sin of which he is guilty (NJB) (NCV, NJB)

1. The Peshitta has “but all my labors will not be enough to rid me of the sin which I have sinned.” Ephraim is the speaker (In the RSV, God is the speaker through Hosea). This sentence is a comment that Ephraim cannot atone for his sin by gaining wealth. For example:

But all his riches can never offset the guilt he has incurred (RSV) (RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions.

iniquity that is sinful: There are two acceptable ways to understand this phrase:

- The Hebrew words for iniquity and “sin” are synonyms. Each word refers to offenses against others. Andersen and Freedman (page 617). For example:

In all my labors they cannot find in me iniquity or sin (ESV) Some versions translate this phrase with just one word. For example:

And no one can accuse us of getting rich dishonestly (GNT)

- The Hebrew words for iniquity and “sin” describe different types of offense. Iniquity is unintentional wrongdoing. Sin is intentional wrongdoing that the LORD forbids. Macintosh (pages 495–497) states that Ephraim’s oppression of others was unwitting, thus he claims he is not guilty of a conscious sin against God. Also McComiskey (page 205). For example:

no one can accuse me of any offense that is actually sinful (NET)

Hosea 12:9

Section 11:12–12:14: Israel is deceitful and refuses to return to the LORD

In this section, the LORD accuses both Israel and Judah of wrongdoing, but then focuses on the wicked behavior of Israel (11:12–12:1). Hosea continues to describe Israel, giving examples from the life of their ancestor Jacob to show that Israel followed his bad behavior (12:2–8). The LORD then reminded the people how they had responded wickedly when he led them in the past (12:9–11). Hosea concludes this section by comparing Jacob’s care of sheep in Aram with the LORD’s care of his people through a prophet or prophets.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel’s Sin (NIV)

Israel and Judah Are Condemned (GNT)

Paragraph 12:9–11

In this paragraph, the LORD reminded Israel that he was still their God. He reviewed how he led them in the past. Nevertheless, Israel responded with wickedness. The LORD used Gilead and Gilgal as examples of that wickedness.

12:9

This verse gives the LORD’s response to Ephraim’s boast in 12:8. He tells them what he will do as a result of the behavior that they boast about. He will make them return to living in tents.

A return to living in tents is a judgment in which the Israelites lose their homes and wealth. Stuart (pages 193–194). However, it is also a time of correction and restoration of their relationship with God. It is in the wilderness that God established his relationship with them the first time, and he will now do so again. See Hosea 2:8–20. Dearman (pages 310–311), Keil (pages 97–98), McComiskey (page 205), and Wood (page 217).

In Hebrew, this verse begins with a word that connects it to the previous verse. In many other places, this word is translated as “and” or “but.” For example:

But I am the Lord your God (NCV)

Many versions, however, leave the connection of this verse to the previous one implied. Use a natural way in your language to indicate the connection of this verse to 12:8.

12:9a

But I am the LORD your God ever since the land of Egypt.

- ¶ Yahweh responds, saying, “I am Yahweh your^(plur) God who brought you up from the land of Egypt.
- ¶ “Remember that I am Yahweh. I was your God in the land of Egypt.

But I am the LORD your God ever since the land of Egypt: In this clause, the LORD declares who he is and what he did in Israel’s past. His words imply at least two things:

1. The LORD is ruler over Israel. Garrett (page 243) and Hubbard (page 207).
2. The LORD is the true source of Israel’s wealth. Stuart (pages 193–194) and Keil (pages 97, 98).

In Hebrew, this clause is “I Yahweh [am/have-been] your God since/from the land of Egypt.” There are two main interpretations concerning the phrase “since/from the land of Egypt:”

1. The phrase refers to location. It refers to the exodus from Egypt. The phrase is a shortened form of the full declaration that occurs elsewhere in the OT: “I am the Lord your God, who brought you up from the land of Egypt.” Dearman (pages 310–311), Garrett (page 243), and Stuart (pages 193–194). For example, Exod. 20:2; Deut. 5:6. With this declaration, the LORD reminds the people who their God is. He is the all-powerful God, their heavenly king, rescuer, and benefactor. For example:

But I am the Lord your God, who rescued you from slavery in Egypt (NLT) (GNT, GW, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT)

1. The phrase refers to time. It refers to the time the people lived in Egypt or the time of the exodus from Egypt. With this declaration the LORD reminds the people how long he has been their God: from the time they lived in Egypt up to that current time. Hubbard (pages 207–208), Macintosh (page 499), McComiskey (page 206), and Keil (pages 97–98). For example:

Israel, I, the Lord, am still your God, just as I have been since the time you were in Egypt (CEV) (BSB, CEV, NASB, NJB, NJPS, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It has good support from modern versions and also from the LXX and the Peshitta. However, interpretation (2)

also makes sense and is acceptable. Either interpretation can imply the other one.

12:9b

I will again make you dwell in tents, as in the days of the appointed feast.

- I will make you^(plur) live in tents again, as you do when you celebrate the Feast of Shelters/Booths.
- I will make you live in tents again, as in the special days each year when you celebrate the Feast of Shelters/Booths.

I will again make you dwell in tents, as in the days of the appointed feast: In this clause, the LORD tells what he will do in response to the behavior Ephraim boasts about in 12:8. He will make them live in tents again.

The word again indicates repetition of a past event. Here the event is when the people lived in tents following the exodus from Egypt.

There are two main interpretations of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as appointed feast: The NJPS and the NET have “days of old” here instead of the MT “days of meeting.” HOTTP regards this as a textual issue and recommends following the MT. The phrase “days of old” may follow the Targum that translates the word similarly. See Davies (page 279).

1. The Hebrew word refers to the Feast of Booths/Tabernacles. Patterson and Hill (page 75), Davies (page 280), Wood (page 217), McComiskey (page 205), Keil (pages 97–98), Garrett (page 243), Dearman (pages 310–311), and Stuart (pages 193–194). This was the feast held in autumn, in which the people celebrated the ingathering of crops. During the time of the celebration, the people lived in temporary shelters. It reminded the people of the time when their ancestors lived in tents in the wilderness, after he brought them out of Egypt. See Leviticus 23:42–43. For example:

as in the days of the appointed feast (ESV) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NIV, NLT, NRSV)

1. The Hebrew word refers to the Tabernacle/Tent of Meeting. Andersen and Freedman (page 618), Hubbard (page 208), and Macintosh (page 499) The Tabernacle is the tent in which the LORD was present with the people after he brought them out of Egypt. It was also the place where they came to worship him at that time. For example:

I shall make you live in tents yet again, as in the days of the Tent of Meeting. (REB) Some versions imply the tent of meeting using different words. For example:

I will make you live in tents again, as you did when I came to you in the desert. (GNT) (GNT, NCV, The NJB has “days of meeting” and NCV has “worship days.” These may refer to worship in the tabernacle. NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It has the majority support of modern versions as well as from the LXX and the Peshitta. Interpretation (2), however, is also acceptable. Both interpretations refer to the time of exodus. Interpretation (1) does so indirectly, by comparing living in tents to the Feast of Booths. That Feast, in turn, reminds them of the time of the exodus. Interpretation (2) directly compares living in tents to the time of the exodus.

Hosea 12:10

Section 11:12–12:14: Israel is deceitful and refuses to return to the LORD

In this section, the LORD accuses both Israel and Judah of wrongdoing, but then focuses on the wicked behavior of Israel (11:12–12:1). Hosea continues to describe Israel, giving examples from the life of their ancestor Jacob to show that Israel followed his bad behavior (12:2–8). The LORD then reminded the people how they had responded wickedly when he led them in the past (12:9–11). Hosea concludes this section by comparing Jacob’s care of sheep in Aram with the LORD’s care of his people through a prophet or prophets.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel’s Sin (NIV)

Israel and Judah Are Condemned (GNT)

Paragraph 12:9–11

In this paragraph, the LORD reminded Israel that he was still their God. He reviewed how he led them in the past. Nevertheless, Israel responded with wickedness. The LORD used Gilead and Gilgal as examples of that wickedness.

12:10

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{10a} I spoke **through the prophets**

^{10b} and multiplied **their** visions;

^{10c} I gave parables **through the prophets**.

In these lines, the LORD continues to speak. He tells the people that he has communicated in various ways by means of his prophets.

In Hebrew, this verse begins with a word that connects it to the previous verse. In many other places, this word is translated as “and” or “but.”

Here the connection to the previous verse is unclear. These are some possibilities:

1. This verse expands on 12:9a. The LORD led them out of Egypt through his prophet Moses. The LORD continued to guide and teach them through other prophets in the years afterward. McComiskey (pages 206–207, Stuart (page 194), Dearman (pages 311–312), and Keil (page 98).
2. This verse gives a reason why the LORD will make them live in tents again. They knew what the LORD expected from them. He clearly revealed his expectations through the prophets. Stuart (page 194) and Wood (page 217).
3. This verse is information that is secondary to the main prophecy. It is only loosely connected to the surrounding verses. Macintosh (page 502).

Many versions leave the connection of this verse to the previous one implied. Use a natural way in your language to indicate the connection of this verse to 12:9.

12:10a

I spoke through the prophets

- I spoke by/through the prophets.
- I sent my prophets to speak for me.

I spokeThe timeframe is ambiguous. The Hebrew verb form can be understood as either sequential future or sequential past: “I will speak” or “I used to speak.” See Buth (page 359). Versions that translate the verb as future include the LXX and the NJB. The context, however, particularly an unambiguous parallel verb, “multiplied [visions],” suggests that the verb here should also be understood as past. Most versions follow this view. **through the prophets:** This phrase may indicate that the LORD gave the prophets authority to speak as his representatives. Keil (page 98), Dearman (pages 311–312), Macintosh (page 502), and Hubbard (page 208). Here is another way to make that explicit:

I sent my prophets to warn you (NLT)

12:10b**and multiplied their visions;**

- I myself gave them many visions,
- I myself revealed to them many things,

and multiplied their visions: This clause refers to the many visions that the LORD gave to the prophets throughout Israel's history. McComiskey (page 206). In Hebrew, this clause is more literally "and I, I multiplied visions." The explicit pronoun "I" at the front of the clause may indicate emphasis. Ibid. Here are two ways that versions indicate this emphasis:

I myself revealed many visions (NET)

It was I who gave vision after vision (REB)

visions: The Hebrew word can mean either "vision" or word of "revelation." HALOT (electronic edition, page 301). Since God did not always reveal a message visually, the word "perception" might be a near equivalent. McComiskey (page 206).

12:10c**I gave parables through the prophets.**

- and by them I spoke in figures of speech."
- and through them I taught lessons.

I gave parables through the prophets: This clause is more literally "and by/through the hand of the prophets I gave parables." The Hebrew expression "by/through the hand of" indicates the means by which something is done. Or agency. McComiskey (page 206).

There are two main interpretations of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as gave parables:

1. The word means to tell parables or to use figures of speech. NIDOTTE (#1948) suggests that in this verse it is likely that "compare" is meant and that it may be translated "Through the prophets I create parables." For example:

and told parables through the them (NIV) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB, RSV)

1. The word means to ruin/destroy. HALOT (electronic edition, page 225) III. For example:

and through the prophets I will bring destruction (NRSV) (CEV, GNT, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Most versions follow this view, and it fits the context of the parallel lines well. A main difficulty with interpretation (2) is that the meaning "ruin/destroy" does not occur in the Piel stem used here.

Some versions make explicit the purpose of giving parables. The purpose is to teach. For example:

I taught lessons through the prophets. (GW)

Hosea 12:11**Section 11:12–12:14: Israel is deceitful and refuses to return to the LORD**

In this section, the LORD accuses both Israel and Judah of wrongdoing, but then focuses on the wicked behavior of Israel (11:12–12:1). Hosea continues to describe Israel, giving examples from the life of their ancestor Jacob to show that Israel followed his bad behavior (12:2–8). The LORD then reminded the people how they had responded wickedly when he led them in the past (12:9–11). Hosea concludes this section by comparing Jacob's care of sheep in Aram with the LORD's care of his people through a prophet or prophets.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel's Sin (NIV)

Israel and Judah Are Condemned (GNT)

Paragraph 12:9–11

In this paragraph, the LORD reminded Israel that he was still their God. He reviewed how he led them in the past. Nevertheless, Israel responded with wickedness. The LORD used Gilead and Gilgal as examples of that wickedness.

12:11

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{11a}Is there **iniquity** in Gilead?

^{11b}They will surely **come to nothing**.

^{11c}Do they **sacrifice bulls** in Gilgal?

^{11d}Indeed, their **altars** will be heaps of stones in the furrows of the field.

Gilead and Gilgal are locations. Here they are probably figures of speech that represent the entire northern

kingdom of Israel. Patterson and Hill (page 75), Keil (pages 98–99), McComiskey (page 209), and Wood (page 217). They may be an example of the kind of parable or figure of speech that 12:10 describes. Garrett (pages 244–245) and Hubbard (page 209).

Here are three possible purposes for the verse: Hubbard (page 209).

1. to show the great extent of wickedness in Israel
2. to return to the main theme of this chapter, deceit and lying
3. to demonstrate the use of wordplays, which were part of the way God proclaimed his judgment. An example is the choice of words that share similar elements, such as Gilead, Gilgal and gallim “piles/heaps.” The similarity connects them to suggest a theme of emptiness. See especially Hubbard (page 210) and also Patterson and Hill (page 75), Keil (pages 98–99), Dearman (page 312), Davies (page 282), and IVPBBCOT. Another example is the repetition of a word root, such as awn, which has three separate meanings in chapter 12: “manhood/virility” in 12:4, “wealth” in 12:9, and “wickedness” in 12:11. The repetition ties together the folly of the behaviors highlighted in each occurrence. Hubbard (page 210).

12:11a–b

Is there iniquity in Gilead? They will surely come to nothing.

- Are the people of Gilead wicked? Yes/Indeed, they are worthless!
- The people of Gilead are wicked. They are truly worthless.

Is there iniquity in Gilead? They will surely come to nothing: In Hebrew, these clauses are more literally “if Gilead [is] wickedness surely they are worthlessness.” The noun forms, “wickedness” and “worthlessness” as used in this sentence are ungrammatical in English. However, in Hebrew a noun can occur instead of an adjective to give a degree of emphasis to it. McComiskey (page 209). Here are some acceptable ways to translate the clauses:

- As a rhetorical question followed by a response. The implied answer in the response is “yes.” For example:

Is there iniquity in Gilead? Surely they are worthless. (NASB)

- As a conditional clause followed by a conclusion. In traditional grammatical terms, the clause stating the condition is the protasis, which is followed by

the apodosis. The implicit understanding is that the condition is true. For example:

If there is iniquity in Gilead they shall surely come to nothing. (ESV)

- As statements. For example:

The people of Gilead are evil, worth nothing. (NCV)

Translate these clauses in a natural way in your language.

iniquity: In Hebrew, this word has a broad range of meaning that includes “idolatry,” “wickedness,” iniquity, “emptiness.” TWOT (#48a). The same word is used in the second part of the name Beth-aven, “house of wickedness.” See 4:15b.

Some versions translate the word here as “idolatry.” That translation is not recommended, because it limits its meaning. It is likely that Hosea’s use of the word here had a broader sense. Hosea uses the same word to refer to the people of Gilead in 6:8. There the word is associated with bloodshed, not specifically with idolatry.

Gilead: Gilead is the region in the northern kingdom of Israel located east of the river Jordan. The region includes land and cities belonging to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half tribe of Manasseh. It is also possible that Hosea had in mind the city of Ramoth-Gilead or Jabesh-Gilead. By the time of Hosea, Gilead was known to be a place of evil.

They will surely come to nothing: The Hebrew word for nothing here means “emptiness,” “vanity,” “falseness.” It designates something that is worthless either physically or morally. TWOT (#2338a). Garrett (pages 244–245) suggest that without Yahweh they are nothing, a non-people. In Hebrew, the preceding word surely emphasizes how worthless the people were.

There are two main interpretations of the time reference of this clause:

1. The people of Gilead were worthless at that time. The verb phrase, literally “surely worthlessness they are” is in the perfect tense/aspect, which normally indicates a completed state. For example:

They are worthless (GW) (GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB)

1. The people of Gilead will become worthless in the future. Keil (pages 98–99) and some others propose

that here the perfect verb form indicates the certainty of a future state. They will be destroyed. For example:

they shall surely come to nothing (ESV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, NET, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with the majority of versions. The Hebrew clause is an appropriate description of the people of Gilead at that time. See Hosea 6:8.

12:11c

Do they sacrifice bulls in Gilgal?

- In Gilgal, they sacrifice bulls.
- And the people in Gilgal, they sacrifice bulls to pagan gods.

Do they sacrifice bulls in Gilgal?: There is a textual issue here: One option would be the LXX. It has “rulers offering sacrifices in Gilgal.” It is not included here due to lack of representation in modern versions.

1. The Masoretic Text has “bulls they have sacrificed.” For example:

In Gilgal they sacrifice bulls (ESV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. Some scholars think the original text had “to bulls they have sacrificed.” The proposal is that the original text was *bagilgal l šawarim* but due to haplography or other error, the *l* “to” was dropped out. See Andersen and Freedman (pages 618–620). For example:

At Gilgal they sacrifice to bulls (NJB) (NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. See also HOTTP, Keil (pages 98–99), and Davies (282). Option (2) lacks support from ancient texts or versions. Davies (page 282) also states that there is no real need or justification for the suggested change.

The sacrifice of bulls probably refers to pagan sacrifices. The word for “sacrifice” here refers most often to pagan sacrifices in Hosea. McComiskey (page 209). Gilgal was also an unlawful place of sacrifice. Keil (pages 98–99).

The BSB and some other versions that translate 11a as a rhetorical question also translate 11c as a rhetor-

ical question. This is not recommended. A rhetorical question is not indicated in the Hebrew text.

Gilgal: Gilgal is a city in the northern kingdom of Israel located west of the river Jordan. It was a major center of idolatry. See 4:15b.

12:11d

Indeed, their altars will be heaps of stones in the furrows of the field.

- Yes, their altars are like useless stones heaped beside the furrows of a field.”
- Their altars are also as numerous as the stone piles in a plowed field.”

Indeed: In Hebrew, this clause starts with a word that has various possible meanings. TWOT (#361a). A basic meaning that fits the context here is “also/moreover.” Here it introduces the altars as a further description of the sacrificing of bulls in 11c. McComiskey (page 209). For example:

The altars of these are also like stone heaps upon a plowed field. (NJPS)

Yes, their altars are like the stone heaps beside the furrows of the field.

their altars will be heaps of stones in the furrows of the field:

This sentence describes the altars on which the people sacrificed bulls. It compares the altars to stone piles in fields. There are two main interpretations of the time reference:

1. This sentence describes the altars as they were at that time. Hubbard (page 209). For example:

Their altars also are like stone heaps on the furrows of the field. (ESV) (ESV, KJV, NASB, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB)

1. This sentence describes the altars as they will be in the future. It predicts that they will be destroyed. Keil (pages 98–99) and McComiskey (page 209). For example:

But their altars will become like piles of rubble beside a plowed field. (GW) (BSB, CEV, GNT, GW, NCV, NET, NIV, RSV)

The Display will follow interpretation (1), but you may follow either interpretation. In Hebrew, there is no explicit time reference, because this clause has

no verb. Both interpretations fit the context of the passage. Andersen and Freedman (pages 618–620).

The phrase heaps of stones in the furrows of the field may refer to stones that a farmer removes from his field to allow for plowing. The comparison, however, does not make explicit the way in which the altars are like these piles of stones. Here are some possibilities:

- The altars are/will be as numerous as the piles of stones. Andersen and Freedman (pages 618–620) and Patterson and Hill (page 75).
- The altars are/will be as worthless as the piles of stones. Hubbard (page 209) and Wood (page 217).
- The altars are/will be obstacles like the piles of stones that must be removed to allow for growth and harvesting. Garrett (pages 244–245) and Macintosh (page 504).

Most versions leave the point of comparison implied. However, you may include these possibilities in the translation or in a footnote if think it will be helpful.

Hosea 12:12

Section 11:12–12:14: Israel is deceitful and refuses to return to the LORD

In this section, the LORD accuses both Israel and Judah of wrongdoing, but then focuses on the wicked behavior of Israel (11:12–12:1). Hosea continues to describe Israel, giving examples from the life of their ancestor Jacob to show that Israel followed his bad behavior (12:2–8). The LORD then reminded the people how they had responded wickedly when he led them in the past (12:9–11). Hosea concludes this section by comparing Jacob's care of sheep in Aram with the LORD's care of his people through a prophet or prophets.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel's Sin (NIV)

Israel and Judah Are Condemned (GNT)

Paragraph 12:12–14

This paragraph compares/contrasts Jacob and the LORD. Jacob took care of sheep in Aram to attain a wife. The LORD took care of the people in Sinai by sending a prophet. Yet Israel provoked the LORD's anger, and he will hold them accountable.

Hosea is probably the speaker in this paragraph. This is suggested by the use of the phrase “the/his LORD” rather than “I.”

12:12

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{12a} Jacob **fled** to the land of Aram

^{12b} and Israel **worked for a wife**—

^{12c} **for a wife** he **tended sheep**.

These lines continue to describe Jacob from 12:3–4. (See also Genesis 28–29). The verbs, “fled,” “worked” and “tended” indicate that Jacob had a difficult life. He was of low status and served others. Keil (page 99) and Davies (page 282). This verse is the first part of a comparison/contrast of Jacob to prophets. The second part is 12:13. Garrett (page 246) suggests that the following comparisons may be intended here: both Haran and Egypt are foreign lands that served as places of refuge. Both Jacob and Israel worked as slaves. God created a situation in which both Laban and the Egyptians were eager to have Jacob/Israelites leave. Also, both departed with the wealth of their hosts. Jacob “tended” (šamar) sheep to get a wife (v. 12), and in the exodus Yahweh “tended” (šamar) Israel through his prophet (v. 13).

In Hebrew, this verse begins with a word that connects it to the previous verse(s). In many other places, this word is translated as “and” or “but.”

Here the connection of this verse to the previous ones is unclear. The previous verses may demonstrate that Israel has forgotten her humble beginnings and the LORD's loving care for her as a young nation. So here in 12:12, that history is reviewed as a reminder to them. See Deuteronomy 26:5–11 for a similar historical review for this purpose. Keil (page 99) and McComiskey (page 210). Most versions leave the connection implied. Use a natural way in your language to indicate the connection of this verse to 12:11.

12:12a

Jacob fled to the land of Aram

- ¶ Jacob had to flee to the land of Mesopotamia.
- ¶ Remember again our ancestor Jacob. He ran to escape from his brother and went to Syria.

Jacob fled to the land of Aram: The Hebrew word for fled means “ran away.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 156) 1. The word connotes running in a hurry, often from a threatening situation. McComiskey (page 210). Here it refers to a time when Jacob fled from Canaan, because Esau threatened to kill him. See Genesis 27:42–45.

Some versions make explicit that Jacob was the ancestor of the people of Israel. For example:

Our ancestor Jacob had to flee to Mesopotamia (GNT)

land of Aram: This phrase is literally “field/territory of Aram.” It refers to Paddan-aram. Also called Syrian Mesopotamia. See Davies (page 232). See Genesis 28:2. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Northwest Mesopotamia (NCV)

country of Syria (GW)

12:12b and Israel worked for a wife—

- He served his uncle to gain a wife.
- There he/Israel worked to earn a wife.

Israel worked for a wife: This clause is literally “Israel served for a wife.” Some commentators regard the prefix bet on the word for “wife” to be a “beth pretii,” which indicates “for a price.” Others disagree, since it is Jacob’s work, not the wife, that is the price paid. Andersen and Freedman (page 620) suggest that here the prefix means “for/to gain a wife” and that this use of bet is not its common meaning. It refers to Jacob serving his uncle Laban by caring for sheep. The clause may indicate that Jacob’s work substituted for a bride price. Andersen and Freedman (page 620).

In this clause, Jacob is called by the name Israel. Some versions use the pronoun “he” here instead. For example:

he worked for another man (GNT)

12:12c for a wife he tended sheep.

- It was for her that he cared for sheep.
- The bride price he paid was to guard her father’s sheep.

for a wife he tended sheep: The Hebrew text repeats the same phrase for a wife here as in 12b. It has the same meaning in both lines. Davies (page 282) and Andersen and Freedman (page 620) suggest a different possibility. The phrase “for a wife” in 12b may refer to Jacob’s first wife, Leah. The same phrase in 12c may refer to Jacob’s second wife, Rachel. However, this possibility is not supported in versions. Some other versions make explicit that the phrase for a wife means to pay for a wife. Here is another way to translate this clause:

and there he earned a wife by tending sheep (NLT)

and to pay for her he tended sheep (NIV)

The words he tended sheep make explicit the meaning of the Hebrew word “to guard, watch, protect.” TWOT (#2414) I.

Hosea 12:13

Section 11:12–12:14: Israel is deceitful and refuses to return to the LORD

In this section, the LORD accuses both Israel and Judah of wrongdoing, but then focuses on the wicked behavior of Israel (11:12–12:1). Hosea continues to describe Israel, giving examples from the life of their ancestor Jacob to show that Israel followed his bad behavior (12:2–8). The LORD then reminded the people how they had responded wickedly when he led them in the past (12:9–11). Hosea concludes this section by comparing Jacob’s care of sheep in Aram with the LORD’s care of his people through a prophet or prophets.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel’s Sin (NIV)

Israel and Judah Are Condemned (GNT)

Paragraph 12:12–14

This paragraph compares/contrasts Jacob and the LORD. Jacob took care of sheep in Aram to attain a wife. The LORD took care of the people in Sinai by sending a prophet. Yet Israel provoked the LORD’s anger, and he will hold them accountable.

Hosea is probably the speaker in this paragraph. This is suggested by the use of the phrase “the/his LORD” rather than “I.”

12:13

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{13a}But by a prophet the LORD **brought Israel out of Egypt,**

^{13b}and by a prophet **he was preserved.**

This verse is the second part of the comparison/contrast of Jacob to prophets from 12:12. McComiskey (pages 210–211) suggests that Jacob represented the early period when Israel was an oppressed tribal people. Moses, in this verse, represented the period when Israel became a nation. These two historical allusions

condemned Israel and are the basis for the words of judgment that follow in the next verse. In Hebrew, 13a and 13b both start with the same phrase, literally “and by a prophet.” This phrase parallels the phrase “for a wife” in 12:12. The phrases in verses 12 and 13 use the same Hebrew preposition, *bet* “for/by” prefixed to a noun. The noun is “wife” in verse 12 and “prophet” in verse 13. The similar Hebrew grammatical forms is one indicator that this verse is connected to the previous one.

The NLT adds the words “Then” and “Jacob’s descendants” to make the connection to 12:12 more explicit:

Then by a prophet the Lord brought Jacob’s descendants out of Egypt; and by that prophet they were protected. (NLT)

Use a natural way in your language to indicate the connection of this verse to 12:12.

12:13a

But by a prophet the LORD brought Israel out of Egypt,

- Yahweh used a prophet to rescue the people of Israel from slavery in Egypt.
- Years later, Yahweh led the descendants of Jacob out of Egypt through a prophet,

But by a prophet the LORD brought Israel out of Egypt: This sentence refers to Moses, but it leaves the prophet’s name implied. It may be preferable to do the same in your translation. Here Moses is one example that shows how the LORD uses prophets to guide and care for Israel throughout its history. Dearman (pages 313–315) suggests that Hosea speaks of prophets in general to indicate that the emphasis is on the prophetic office as such.

12:13b

and by a prophet he was preserved.

- By means of a prophet he took care of them.
- and through a prophet he guarded them.

and by a prophet he was preserved: This clause may also refer to Moses. See Patterson and Hill (pages 76–77), Keil (page 99), Garrett (pages 246–247), McComiskey (page 210), Davies (page 282), Macintosh (page 512), and Wood (page 218). However, it could refer to another prophet, such as Samuel. See Andersen and Freedman (pages 620–622), Dearman (pages 313–315), and Hubbard (page 211). It is preferable to leave the name of the prophet implied in your translation, as in 13a.

he was preserved: This phrase is more literally “he was kept.” The Hebrew word for “he was kept” is a form of the same word that the BSB translates as “he tended (sheep)” in 12:12. The repetition of this word is a further indication that these two verses are closely connected.

Here the Hebrew word refers to the LORD’s care of the nation of Israel through Moses and other prophets. Macintosh (page 512), Garrett (pages 246–247), and Keil (page 99) suggest that Moses is in view here. However, Dearman (pages 313–315) suggests that it could be a more general reference to the exodus and afterward. Some commentators suggest that here the word may refer especially to the LORD giving his law or covenant to guard them. See McComiskey (page 210) and Stuart (page 195).

Hosea 12:14

Section 11:12–12:14: Israel is deceitful and refuses to return to the LORD

In this section, the LORD accuses both Israel and Judah of wrongdoing, but then focuses on the wicked behavior of Israel (11:12–12:1). Hosea continues to describe Israel, giving examples from the life of their ancestor Jacob to show that Israel followed his bad behavior (12:2–8). The LORD then reminded the people how they had responded wickedly when he led them in the past (12:9–11). Hosea concludes this section by comparing Jacob’s care of sheep in Aram with the LORD’s care of his people through a prophet or prophets.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Israel’s Sin (NIV)

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This paragraph compares/contrasts Jacob and the LORD. Jacob took care of sheep in Aram to attain a wife. The LORD took care of the people in Sinai by sending a prophet. Yet Israel provoked the LORD’s anger, and he will hold them accountable.

Hosea is probably the speaker in this paragraph. This is suggested by the use of the phrase “the/his LORD” rather than “I.”

12:14

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{14a}Ephraim has provoked bitter anger,

^{14b}so his Lord will leave **his bloodguilt** upon him

^{14c}and repay him for **his contempt**.

There is an ellipsis in the third line. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from the second line. For example:

^{14c}and he/his Lord will repay him for **his contempt**.

In these lines, Hosea tells the Israelites that the LORD will judge them. The first line is a general statement. The second and third lines give more detail.

This verse has some similarities to 12:2. Both have a similar structure, a general statement followed by two lines that give more detail. Both use the expression “he will repay.” Both have the same purpose, to declare judgment against Israel. Andersen and Freedman (pages 622–623).

12:14a

Ephraim has provoked bitter anger,

- Yet Israel’s/Ephraim’s sinful conduct has caused Yahweh to feel deep/strong anger against him.
- Nevertheless, they incited/provoked intense rage in Yahweh,

The BSB and the Hebrew text leave implied the connection between this verse and the previous one. Some other versions do the same.

Some versions think that there is an implicit contrast to the previous verse and supply the word “But” to indicate it. Indicate the connection of this verse to 12:13 in a natural way in your language. For example:

But Ephraim has bitterly provoked him to anger...
(NIV)

Ephraim has provoked bitter anger: The phrase provoked...anger means “caused someone to become angry.” TWOT (#1016). Hebrew and some English versions do not make explicit that the LORD is the one Ephraim has provoked. For example:

Ephraim gave bitter provocation (REB)

Some versions make this information explicit for clarity. For example:

But the people of Israel have bitterly provoked the Lord (NLT)

But Ephraim bitterly provoked him to anger (NET)

Ephraim: As in many places in Hosea, the name Ephraim represents the people of Israel, as in the NLT quoted above.

provoked...anger: In Hebrew, this verb phrase is one word. There is no separate word for anger. Some versions leave the idea of anger implied. For example:

Ephraim gave bitter provocation (NJB)

Other versions make it make it explicit. For example:

Ephraim bitterly provoked him to anger (NET)

In some languages, it may be more natural to focus on the LORD’s anger caused by Ephraim’s provocation. For example:

But Ephraim has aroused his bitter anger
(NIV2011)

The people of Israel have made the Lord bitterly angry (GNT)

bitter: The form of the Hebrew word here is literally “bitternesses (plur).” It indicates the bitter manner in which Ephraim provoked the LORD. There is a strong consensus in the commentaries that “bitternesses” functions here as an adverb of manner. They probably provoked him by persisting in the sins listed in 12:7–8, 11. The bitterness does not refer to Ephraim’s bitter emotions against the LORD. Nothing in the preceding context hints at such an emotional response. Pusey (page 124) points out that the literal “with bitternesses” indicates that they provoked the LORD “with the most heinous sins, such as are most grievously displeasing to God.”

The plural form indicates intensity. It implies “very bitterly provoked to anger.” A noun that functions as an adverbial accusative. HALOT (electronic edition, page 1758) and the NET footnote on “bitterly.” In Hebrew, the adjective form bitter means “bitter, strong.” TWOT (#1248a). Here it probably implies that Ephraim’s bitter provocation caused the LORD to experience a correspondingly bitter or strong anger. According to TWOT (#1016), in the 45 instances of the Hiphil form of “provoke to anger,” a common theme is that God’s covenant people have aroused his wrath by means of their unfaithfulness. NIDOTTE (#4087) also mentions

Hosea 12:14 as “one of the earliest examples of divine anger.” See the NIV2011 and GNT quoted below.

12:14b

so his Lord will leave his bloodguilt upon him

- So his Lord/master will hold him accountable for his murders,
- and he will not forgive them for the blood they have shed.

so his Lord will leave his bloodguilt upon him: This clause is more literally “and his bloods on him he will leave.”

This expression probably means that God holds Ephraim (the people of Israel) accountable for his crimes, particularly the murders he has committed. God will not forgive Ephraim by removing the guilt. Instead, he will leave the guilt on Ephraim. The implication is that Ephraim will be punished accordingly. This view assumes that the Hebrew word “bloods (pl)” refers here to murders committed by Ephraim. See Keil (page 99), Stuart (pages 195–196), and Hubbard (page 211). Compare to 1 Kings 2:32–33. Here are some other examples:

so he will hold him accountable for the blood he has shed (NET)

He will hold them guilty of murder (GW)

his Lord: In the Hebrew text his Lord comes at the end of 14c. The BSB and many other versions place it here to conform to natural English. The pronoun his refers to Ephraim.

The Hebrew word for Lord here is *ʾadon*, “lord,” literally *ʾadonaw* “his Lords (plur).” McComiskey (page 211) suggests that the plural ending denotes the plural of majesty. The variation in vocalization distinguishes this use as a sacred name from uses that refer to human beings, not Yahweh. Versions indicate this by translating this word as Lord, not as “Lord” or “LORD.”

his bloodguilt: In Hebrew, this phrase is “his bloods.” The plural form of the word “blood” often refers to bloodshed/murders. The word can also indicate blood-guilt/accountability for a murder. BDB (#1818) 1g. Also Andersen and Freedman (pages 622–623), McComiskey (page 211), Davies (page 283), Macintosh (page 515), and Patterson and Hill (page 76).

The word can imply crimes so severe that the person who commits them deserves capital punishment. Stuart (pages 195–196) and Garrett (page

247). Some versions make this meaning explicit. For example:

They deserve death for their crimes. (GNT)

12:14c

and repay him for his contempt.

- and he will repay Israel/Ephraim what he deserves for his defiance.
- He will punish them appropriately for the scorn they have shown.

and repay him for his contempt: The meaning of this clause is similar to 14b. It means to give back to Ephraim an appropriate payment for his contempt. In this context, the Hebrew word for repay means “to pay back” or “requite evil.” DCH (Vol. 8, page 292) h. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Their Lord will punish them for the disgrace they have brought on him. (GNT)

His Lord will repay him for his insult. (NJB)

contempt: The Hebrew word means “reproach,” “reviling,” “taunt.” It often has a connotation of blaming or scorning someone. TWOT (#749a). Here it may indicate contempt for the LORD and/or his law. Keil (page 99), Garrett (page 247), and Stuart (pages 195–196). Here are some other ways to translate it:

his mockery (NJPS)

his insults (NRSV)

his disgraceful deeds (ESV)

Hosea 13:1

Section 13:1–16: The LORD’s anger against Israel

In this section, the LORD gives reasons for his anger against Israel. It was necessary to judge them because they continued to rebel against him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Final Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord’s Relentless Judgment on Israel (ESV)

Ephraim's Idolatry (NASB)

Paragraph 13:1–3

In this paragraph, Hosea is the speaker. He refers to Ephraim as a tribe for the first time (1a–b). In the past, the other tribes of Israel regarded Ephraim highly, with respect and fear. With the contrast that begins with “But” in 13:1c, Hosea again uses “Ephraim” as another name for Israel. Ephraim turned away from the LORD to worship false gods. As a result of their sin, the LORD brought death to them as a nation.

13:1a–b (combined/reordered)

- The Israelites feared and honored the tribe of Ephraim.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{1a}When Ephraim spoke, **there was trembling**;

^{1b} he **was exalted** in Israel.

These lines talk about Israel's past. There was a time when Ephraim had power and high status.

13:1a When Ephraim spoke, there was trembling;

- ¶ When the leaders of Ephraim spoke, people trembled/shook in fear.
- ¶ People used to fear the tribe of Ephraim (NCV).

When Ephraim spoke, there was trembling: This line is more literally “just as spoke Ephraim trembling.” BART interlinear. The Lexham Hebrew Bible gloss is “as/the moment of speaking Ephraim [there was] terror.”

When: This time word introduces two events that occurred simultaneously. People trembled at the same time that Ephraim spoke.” McComiskey (page 213).

Ephraim: Here the name Ephraim probably refers literally to the tribe of Ephraim. The literal reference to Ephraim as a tribe is supported by Keil, Garrett, Macintosh, Hubbard, Davies, McComiskey, and Wood. Some versions make that meaning explicit. For example:

When the tribe of Ephraim spoke, people trembled. (GW)

trembling: The Hebrew word for trembling occurs only here in the Old Testament. The meaning is probably trembling or “fear/horror.” This is the majority view of rabbinic and modern commentators as well as some

ancient versions. The Hebrew word also occurs once in a Qumran scroll with the meaning “trembling” or “horror.” See Macintosh (page 518), Hubbard (page 213), and Davies (page 286). Here the word trembling refers to the fearful response of the people to Ephraim.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

People used to fear the tribe of Ephraim (NCV)

When the tribe of Ephraim spoke, the people shook with fear (NLT)

13:1b he was exalted in Israel.

- People respected Ephraim.
- It was the most important and powerful tribe in Israel.

he was exalted in Israel: In Hebrew, the word exalted means “lifted” or “raised high.” NIDOTTE (#5951). In this context, the word refers to the power and importance of the tribe of Ephraim in Israel in the past. Some other descriptive words are “glory” (Garrett page 248), “pre-eminence” (Macintosh page 520) or “prominence” (McComiskey page 213). There is a combined textual and interpretation issue about the Hebrew verb form of he was exalted:

1. It is a passive form. he Ephraim was exalted. The implied subject is the people of Israel. The editors of the BHS suggest that the vowels for a Niphal perfect 3rd person masculine singular form be adopted for the word. See the NET footnote for “exalted.” However, this meaning may be possible for Qal as well. See DCH (page 768) 17b “be exalted.” They regarded the tribe of Ephraim to be powerful and important. For example:

he was exalted in Israel (NRSV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NAB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. It is a reflexive form. Ephraim exalted himself. A reflexive meaning normally has Niphal form. However, this meaning is possible for Qal also. See DCH (page 768) 17b “lift oneself up, exalt oneself.” Alternatively, rabbinic scholar Kimchi proposes the translation “he exalted his head.” The phrase “his head” is implied. The overall meaning is that he made himself important. See Macintosh (pages 519–520). The subject is Ephraim. The tribe of Ephraim made itself powerful and important. For example:

he exalted himself in Israel (NASB) (KJV, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow option/interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

The people of Ephraim were important in Israel.
(GW)

he was a power in Israel (NJB)

13:1c

But he incurred guilt through Baal, and he died.

- Yet Ephraim was guilty of Baal worship and was considered/counted as already dead.
- But then the people sinned by worshiping Baal. As a result, they died as a nation.

But: This word introduces a contrast in which “he” (Ephraim) again refers to Israel as a nation. This is the way Hosea has used Ephraim everywhere else. See the note on Ephraim in 12:14a.

Ephraim did not thank the LORD or worship him in response. Instead the people sinned by worshiping Baal. Use a natural way in your language to introduce this negative contrast.

he incurred guilt through Baal: This description may refer to the time when Ahab introduced Baal worship. See 1 Kings 16:31. Another way to say he incurred guilt is to say “he sinned.” For example:

But the people of Ephraim sinned by worshiping Baal (NLT)

and he died: The result of Ephraim’s Baal worship was that he died. In Hebrew, this is a past event. Qal waw consecutive. Some versions translate this as future “will die” or as a volitional “must die.” However, the Hebrew word form that is used here should not be translated as a future or volitional. Neither idea is indicated by a series of waw consecutive forms following a perfect form, as occurs here.

The word died does not mean that the people of Ephraim died physically, since the following verse says that they continued to sin. Davies (page 284) and Dearman (page 319). The following verses speak of Israel’s future destruction as a nation. The prophet views this destruction of Ephraim, including all of Israel, as already complete. So died probably refers to the strength and identity of Ephraim, along with Israel, as a nation. Davies (page 284) suggests that they were

excluded from his sphere of influence. McComiskey (page 213) suggests that the word “died” denotes the end of a viable relationship to the inheritance and ultimately the end of Israel as a nation. ICC (page 520) suggests the meaning “was accounted dead,” and says that “the strength of the kingdom...was terminally affected.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and you were destroyed (CEV)

and became as if dead as a nation

Hosea 13:2

Section 13:1–16: The LORD’s anger against Israel

In this section, the LORD gives reasons for his anger against Israel. It was necessary to judge them because they continued to rebel against him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Final Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord’s Relentless Judgment on Israel (ESV)

Ephraim’s Idolatry (NASB)

Paragraph 13:1–3

In this paragraph, Hosea is the speaker. He refers to Ephraim as a tribe for the first time (1a–b). In the past, the other tribes of Israel regarded Ephraim highly, with respect and fear. With the contrast that begins with “But” in 13:1c, Hosea again uses “Ephraim” as another name for Israel. Ephraim turned away from the LORD to worship false gods. As a result of their sin, the LORD brought death to them as a nation.

13:2a–d

These lines describe what the people did after their Baal worship resulted in the death of their nation. They increased their idolatry. Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning: This four line parallel arrangement is suggested by McComiskey (page 214).

^{2a}Now they sin more and more

^{2b}and make for themselves cast images,

^{2c} idols **skillfully made from their silver**, The Hebrew grammar allows the word “silver” to connect either to line 2b (see NIV, NLT, KJV) or to 2c. The Hebrew accent marks suggest that it is part of 2c. See Garrett (page 248–250). There is no difference in meaning between these options.

^{2d} all of them **the work of craftsmen**.

All four lines describe their sin. Line 2a is a general statement. Lines 2b–d describe their sin more specifically. The underlined parts all refer to the idols. The parts in bold print give further details about the idols.

13:2a

Now they sin more and more

- And now they increase their sin even more.
- Now they continue to sin all the more

Now: This word indicates present time from Hosea’s perspective.

they sin more and more: The Hebrew words are more literally “they increase to sin.” The Hebrew word for “increase” means to do again or more. BDB (#3254) Hiphil 2. a.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they go on sinning (NJPS)

they compound their sins (NJB)

13:2b

and make for themselves cast images,

- They make idols for themselves from their silver,
- by creating their own false gods from silver metal.

and make for themselves cast images: This line describes the sin that the people do more and more. Some versions use a word such as “by” to make explicit that this is the sin to which the previous line refers. For example:

Now you continue to sin by designing and making idols of silver (CEV)

for themselves: The people made the idols for their own benefit. This phrase along with 13:2c both emphasize the human origin and human purposes for the idols. Stuart (page 202).

13:2c

idols skillfully made from their silver,

- shaped/fashioned by their own skill,
- The idols have a beautiful appearance.

idols: The word idols refers to objects that people made by melting metal and pouring it into a cast. These idols were made out of silver metal and possibly other precious metals. People worshipped them as gods but they were false gods.

skillfully made: In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally “according to their understanding/skill.” It indicates that the craftsmen had a high level of skill and made idols that were artistically beautiful. McComiskey (page 214). Most versions leave “according to” implied.

from their silver: The Hebrew word for silver may refer here both to silver and to other precious metals. Davies (page 286).

13:2d

all of them the work of craftsmen.

- all of them made by human craftsmen.
- They are made by skillful workmen.

all of them the work of craftsmen: The word craftsmen here describes a person who cuts and engraves various materials. TWOT (#760a). Here it refers to the skilled workers who made the idols.

13:2e

People say of them, “They offer human sacrifice and kiss the calves!”

- People say about those who sacrifice to these calf idols, “They kiss calves!”
- It is said that the people who offer sacrifices to these calf-idols even kiss them!

People say of them: In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally “to them they [are] saying.”

There are two interpretations concerning the referent of the pronoun “to them:”

1. The pronoun refers to people, specifically the Israelites. For example:

People say this about the Israelites (GW) (BSB, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, REB)

1. The pronoun refers to the idols. For example:

Sacrifice to these, they say (NRSV) (CEV, GNT, NAB, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Most versions that support interpretation (2) regard

the word “sacrifice” in the next line to be a command. However, a command requires a different form of the verb. To read “sacrifice” as a command would require emending the MT participle into an imperative. Hubbard (page 215), Patterson and Hill (pages 78–79), and Davies (page 286). Interpretation (1) makes good sense of the verb form in the Masoretic Text.

The words People say of them refer to what people in general are saying.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The people of Israel say to each other (NCV)

they say (NAB)

They offer human sacrifice: In Hebrew this clause part is more literally “[those who] offer sacrifice of humankind.” There are two main interpretations of this clause part:

1. It means “those among humankind that offer sacrifice.” Patterson and Hill (pages 78, 79), Keil (pages 100–101), Macintosh (page 523), and Wood (page 220). A NET footnote classifies the phrase as a genitive of species: the genitive represents the whole class of a species (men) and the construct represents a part of the whole (those who sacrifice). The expression “a fool of men” in Prov 15:20 is similar. It refers to the people who offer sacrifices to calf-idols. It does not specify what kind of sacrifice they offer. For example:

“Those who sacrifice to the calf idol are calf kissers!” (NET) (CEV, GNT, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. It means “those who offer human sacrifice.” Andersen and Freedman (pages 630–632) and Hubbard (page 215). It refers to people who offer human sacrifices to the calf-idols. For example:

“Those who offer human sacrifices kiss calves!” (ESV) (BSB, ESV, GW, NIV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. There is no record in the Old Testament that human sacrifices were made to calf idols. People made such sacrifices only to Moloch. Keil (pages 100–101). A NET footnote adds that archaeological evidence does not provide any evidence of human sacrifice in the Northern Kingdom during Iron Age I (1200–722 B.C.).

and kiss the calves!: This gesture signifies the giving of honor or allegiance to the idol. See 1 Kings 19:18. Macintosh (page 524). There are three main ways to interpret the function of the Hebrew phrase kiss the calves:

1. The phrase kiss the calves is a statement of fact. Kiss is understood as a regular imperfect that indicates present and/or future action. For example:

Men bestow kisses to calves! (NJB) (BSB, GNT, GW, NAB, NJPS, NET, NJB, NIV, NRSV, REB)

1. The phrase kiss the calves is a command. The imperfect can be used for this function. See Ex 20:1–17 for another example. For example:

“kiss the calf idols!” (NLT) (CEV, NCV, NLT)

1. The phrase kiss the calves is an urging or wish. “Kiss” is understood as a jussive. A jussive can have the same form as the imperfect. For example:

“Let the men who sacrifice kiss the calves!” (NASB) (KJV, NASB)

The Display will follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. However, all three interpretations are acceptable grammatically and fit the context.

Hosea probably intends to express condemnation and perhaps ridicule of this behavior. Dearman (pages 319, 320) and Stuart (page 202). Follow the interpretation that best expresses condemnation and ridicule in your language.

Hosea 13:3

Section 13:1–16: The LORD’s anger against Israel

In this section, the LORD gives reasons for his anger against Israel. It was necessary to judge them because they continued to rebel against him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Final Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord’s Relentless Judgment on Israel (ESV)

Ephraim’s Idolatry (NASB)

Paragraph 13:1–3

In this paragraph, Hosea is the speaker. He refers to Ephraim as a tribe for the first time (1a–b). In the past, the other tribes of Israel regarded Ephraim highly, with respect and fear. With the contrast that begins with “But” in 13:1c, Hosea again uses “Ephraim” as another name for Israel. Ephraim turned away from the LORD to worship false gods. As a result of their sin, the LORD brought death to them as a nation.

**13:3a–d
(combined)**

- So they will vanish like morning mist or dew, like grain husks in the wind or smoke through a window.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{3a}Therefore they will be like **the morning mist**,

^{3b}like **the early dew that vanishes**,

^{3c}like **chaff blown from a threshing floor**,

^{3d}like **smoke through an open window**.

There is an ellipsis (deliberate omission) of the first three words in 13:3b–d. In many languages, these words will need to be supplied from 13:3a. For example:

^{3b} they will be like **the early dew that vanishes**.

^{3c} they will be like **chaff blown from a threshing floor**,

^{3d} they will be like **smoke through an open window**.

These lines contain four figures of speech (similes) that compare the people to temporary things. In a short time, they will quickly and completely disappear. The repetition of these similar lines gives emphasis to this consequence of their idolatry. Hubbard (page 216) and Stuart (pages 202–203).

Here are some ways to translate these similes:

- Make explicit that it is the people who will disappear. This is the majority view of commentators and modern versions. For example:

So those people will be like the morning mist; they will disappear like the morning dew. (NCV)

- Shorten and combine parts of the lines. For example:

And so, all of you will vanish like the mist or the dew of early morning, or husks of grain in the wind or smoke from a chimney. (CEV)

13:3a

Therefore they will be like the morning mist,

- That is why those people will soon vanish like an early morning cloud.
- So they will be like fog in the morning

Therefore: This word introduces the consequence of their ongoing sin of making idols and kissing calves.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

So (NCV)

That is why (GW)

like the morning mist: The phrase the morning mist probably refers to low-lying clouds or fog that disappears by the time the morning is over.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the morning cloud (NASB)

like fog in the morning (GW)

13:3b

like the early dew that vanishes,

- They will be like the dew that disappears in the morning sunshine
- or like water drops that vanish from the leaves when the sun comes out.

like the early dew that vanishes: This phrase refers to water droplets that collect on plant leaves in the early morning. It evaporates quickly. In some languages, it may be redundant to make the word early explicit.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the dew that quickly disappears (NJB)

like dew in the morning sun (NLT)

13:3c

like chaff blown from a threshing floor,

- or like chaff from a threshing place that is carried off by the wind.
- As a strong wind blows dust from a threshing floor, they too will be blown away.

like chaff blown from a threshing floor: This phrase refers to the husks and dust that remain behind after a farmer threshes grain. The wind carries it off. The word that the BSB translates as blown means to be blown away by a strong wind. Andersen and Freedman (pages 632–633) and McComiskey (page 214).

13:3d

like smoke through an open window.

- They will be like smoke that passes through an opening and is gone.
- They will disappear like smoke through a hole in a wall.

like smoke through an open window: This phrase probably refers to smoke from cooking fires or burning lamps that escapes through an opening in the wall. Hubbard (page 216) and Keil (page 101).

window: The Hebrew word for window is literally “hole in the wall.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 83). The word meaning does not indicate which part of the wall has the hole. It may be in the upper part of the wall near the roof or elsewhere. Andersen and Freedman (pages 632–633), Garrett (page 250), Hubbard (page 216), Davies (page 287), and McComiskey (page 214).

Many versions translate the word as window. Some, such as the GNT, translate it as “chimney.” Note, however, that the Hebrew word does not refer to the kind of window or chimney that is common in modern buildings. Translate this with a word or phrase in your language that best fits the meaning of a hole in the wall through which smoke passes.

Hosea 13:4

Section 13:1–16: The LORD’s anger against Israel

In this section, the LORD gives reasons for his anger against Israel. It was necessary to judge them because they continued to rebel against him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Final Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord’s Relentless Judgment on Israel (ESV)

Ephraim’s Idolatry (NASB)

Paragraph 13:4–8

In this paragraph, the LORD is the speaker. He states a complaint against the people of Israel. He always took care of them, but they forgot him. He must punish them in response.

13:4a–d

Notice the parallel lines. Lines a and c are similar in meaning. Lines b and d are also similar in meaning.

^{4a}“Yet I am the LORD your God

^{4b} ever since the land of Egypt;

^{4c} you know no God but Me,

^{4d} for there is no Savior besides Me.

In these lines, the LORD speaks of his special relationship with the people of Israel. He alone is their God. He alone delivered them from slavery in Egypt.

13:4a–b

Yet I am the LORD your God ever since the land of Egypt;

- ¶ “But I am Yahweh, your^(plur) God,
- ¶ Then Yahweh said, “Remember that I am Yahweh.

Yet: This word introduces a contrast between this verse and the preceding ones. Verses 1–3 describe the worthlessness of idols. By contrast, this verse describes the power of the LORD. Macintosh (page 527).

Some versions leave the contrast implied. Davies (page 288) suggests that the connection between 13:1–3 and 13:4 is weak and secondary. To leave the connection implied is one way to indicate a weak or uncertain connection. For example:

The Lord says (GNT)

Indicate the connection of this verse to 13:3 in a natural way in your language.

I am the LORD your God ever since the land of Egypt:

In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “and I [am] Yahweh your God from the land of Egypt.”

There are two main interpretations of the phrase “from the land of Egypt.” As in 12:9a, it refers to location rather than to time. See the notes there for advice on how to translate this phrase.

LORD your God: In this phrase, the Hebrew word for LORD is Yahweh. The Hebrew word for God is a form of

Elohim. Translate these words/names as you normally translate Yahweh and God.

13:4b

ever since the land of Egypt;

- who brought you up from the land of Egypt.
- I was your God in the land of Egypt.

13:4c

you know no God but Me,

- You^(plur) must not know any God except me.
- You must worship and serve only me,

you know no God but Me: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “and gods besides me you not know.” There are two main interpretations of the function of this clause: The word “know” has imperfect tense/aspect. Commentators suggest the following possible uses of the imperfect here. Imperative: “you must not know” Garrett (page 256–257), Dearman (pages 321–322), Stuart (page 203), and Wood (page 220). Present: “you don’t know” McComiskey (page 216). Frequentative imperfect with an implied prohibition: “you don’t know” Macintosh (page 527). Perfect: “you have not known” Keil (page 101). Pluperfect: “you had not known” Andersen and Freedman (pages 633–634).

1. This clause is a command. For example:

You must acknowledge no God but me (NLT) (KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT) The NASB and the NCV are somewhat different than the others in this list. They translate the clause as a past command that was not heeded. For example, the NCV has “You should have known no other God except me.”

1. This clause is a statement. For example:

You know no God but me (NRSV)

You have never known a [true] God but Me (NJPS) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This clause probably refers to the first commandment (or implies all ten commandments) in Exodus 20:2–17. Stuart (page 203), Hubbard (page 216), Garrett (pages 256–257), and Dearman (pages 321–322). The same tense (imperfect) is used both there and here. It is reasonable to understand the clause as a command in both places.

know: Here, know means to know the LORD in an intimate, personal way. See the note in 2:20b, which

has the same interpretation. The context here is a close relationship with the LORD in which the people trust him and are faithful to him. To know the LORD also implies having knowledge about his ways, his promises, and his requirements.

God: In this clause, the Hebrew word for God is Elohim, not Yahweh. Use your general term for God here.

13:4d

for there is no Savior besides Me.

- I am your^(plur) savior, no one else.
- because I am the one who delivers you.

there is no Savior besides Me: As in 13:4b, this clause probably also refers back to the exodus, when the LORD delivered Israel out of slavery in Egypt.

There are two main interpretations of the function of this clause:

1. It is a statement. It gives a reason why the people should follow only the LORD. He saved them from slavery in Egypt. For example:

There is no savior except me. (GW) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. It is a command. There is an ellipsis (deliberate omission) of the first three words in 13:4d. For example:

[You shall know] no savior except me. (NIV) (NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

Savior: The Hebrew word means deliverer or savior. NIDOTTE (#4635). Here it refers to God as the deliverer of the nation of Israel out of Egypt. McComiskey (page 216).

Hosea 13:5

Section 13:1–16: The LORD’s anger against Israel

In this section, the LORD gives reasons for his anger against Israel. It was necessary to judge them because they continued to rebel against him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Final Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord’s Relentless Judgment on Israel (ESV)

Ephraim's Idolatry (NASB)

Paragraph 13:4–8

In this paragraph, the LORD is the speaker. He states a complaint against the people of Israel. He always took care of them, but they forgot him. He must punish them in response.

13:5

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{5a} I knew you **in the wilderness**,

^{5b} **in the land of drought.**

There is an ellipsis (deliberate omission) of the first four words in 13:5b. In many languages, these words will need to be supplied from 13:5a. For example:

^{5b} I knew you **in the land of drought.**

In these lines, the LORD reminds the people of Israel of his gracious care for them when he brought them out of Egypt through the desert of Sinai.

13:5a

I knew you in the wilderness,

- It was I who cared for you^(plur) in the desert/wilderness,
- I am the one who fed your ancestors in a large area

I knew you: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “I, I knew you.” The explicit pronoun I at the front of the clause indicates emphasis. Andersen and Freedman (page 634), Macintosh (page 528), and McComiskey (page 216). For example:

It was I who knew you in the wilderness (ESV)

This emphasis reinforces the statements in 13:4 that the LORD alone is their God. Many versions leave this emphasis implied. Translate this emphasis in a natural way in your language.

There is a textual issue concerning the Hebrew word knew here: TN will regard this as a textual issue, as suggested by several commentators and the NET footnote on “cared” for this verse. It is also possible to analyze this issue as an interpretation difference. See more details in the following endnote.

1. The LXX and Peshitta have “cared-for/fed.” Some scholars propose that these versions translate the Hebrew word ra’ah, “to feed/protect.” See HALOT (electronic edition, page 1259), Stuart (page 203),

and Davies (page 289). An alternative proposal is that the meaning “to care for” is a sense of the word yaḏa’, “to know.” See HALOT (electronic edition, page 391) sense 7a, Macintosh (page 528) and Hubbard (page 216). For example:

It was I who fed you in the wilderness (NRSV)

I cared for you in the wilderness (NET) (CEV, GNT, GW, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The Masoretic Text has the word knew. For example:

It was I who knew you in the wilderness (RSV) (BSB, ESV, KJV, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions.

in the wilderness: This phrase refers here to the desert or wilderness of Sinai during the period of the exodus. Stuart (page 203).

13:5b

in the land of drought.

- where it was hot and dry.
- of heat and drought.

in the land of drought: This line describes the same location as 13:5a using different words. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as drought occurs only here in the Old Testament. The meaning is derived from an Arabic cognate that means “aridity” or “drought.” McComiskey (page 216), Macintosh (page 529), and Garrett (pages 257–258).

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

where it was hot and dry (NCV)

in the land of burning heat (NIV)

Hosea 13:6

Section 13:1–16: The LORD's anger against Israel

In this section, the LORD gives reasons for his anger against Israel. It was necessary to judge them because they continued to rebel against him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Final Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord's Relentless Judgment on Israel (ESV)

Ephraim's Idolatry (NASB)

Paragraph 13:4–8

In this paragraph, the LORD is the speaker. He states a complaint against the people of Israel. He always took care of them, but they forgot him. He must punish them in response.

13:6–8

In 13:4–5, the LORD speaks to the people of Israel using 2nd person pronouns such as “you” and “your.” In 13:6–8, he speaks about the people of Israel using 3rd person pronouns such as “they” and “them.”

Some versions, such as the GNT, translate these verses with 2nd person pronouns instead of 3rd person. Translate these pronouns in a natural way in your language.

13:6a–c

Notice the three poetic lines:

^{6a}When they had pasture, they became satisfied;

^{6b}when they were satisfied, their hearts became proud,

^{6c}and as a result they forgot Me.

These lines describe three stages of Israel's changing attitude toward the LORD. In Deut 8:11–14 the same three stages are described. Both passages have the same Hebrew words for “satisfied,” “proud,” and “forget.” It is recommended that you translate these Hebrew words in a similar way in both places.

13:6a**When they had pasture, they became satisfied;**

- They had plenty to eat, and they were satisfied.
- They were content because of the abundance of food they had.

When they had pasture, they became satisfied:

There are two main textual options in the first part of this clause (a single word in Hebrew):

1. The Masoretic Text is more literally “according to their pasturage.” HOTTG gives this option a rating of “B: some doubt.” With this option, the clause focuses on the relationship between eating/grazing and being satisfied. The source of the food is left implied. For example:

As they had their pasture, they became satisfied (NASB)

but when they had grazed, they became full (ESV) (BSB, ESV, GNT, The GNT has been listed here, because its rendering “But when you entered the good land,...” probably implies a land with good pasture. KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NJPS, NLT, REB, RSV)

1. Some scholars think that the original text was “as/when I pastured them.” In this option, the Hebrew word must be divided differently and have different vowels than the MT word. The MT has *kamar'itam*, “according to their pasturage.” The suggestion is to analyze the comparative *kā* as *kāmo* “thus/as.” Also the noun + suffix, *mar'itam* “their pasturage” is analyzed instead as the verb + suffix, *rā'itim* “I pasture/feed them.” With this option, the relationship between eating/grazing and being satisfied is similar. “I” (the LORD) is explicitly stated as the source of the food. For example:

I gave them food, and they became full and satisfied. (NCV) (CEV, GW, NAB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NRSV)

The Display will follow option (1). This option is supported by the LXX and Vulgate, Macintosh (pages 530–531), Davies (page 290), and McComiskey (page 216). However, option (2) is also well supported by versions and commentaries. This option is supported by the Peshitta and Targum. In addition, Macintosh (page 531) speaks of “Yahweh's pasturing of Israel.” Hubbard says that “‘when I fed them’ makes better sense than ‘according to their pasture.’” Wood (page 220) says that “God's care for his people involved his feeding them.” With both options, the result of available pasturage (food) is that the people are satisfied. Even with option (1), the historical context of Israel's time in the wilderness along with the context of 13:3 strongly implies that it was the LORD who supplied them with their food.

had pasture: The Hebrew word for had pasture is more literally “pasturage.” It usually refers to the grass or other vegetation that domestic animals eat. TWOT (#2185c). Here the word is probably figurative. It may refer particularly to manna that the LORD provided for his people in the desert of Sinai. Or it may refer to all the food and other provisions that the people of Israel needed to thrive. Wood (page 220).

satisfied: In Hebrew, this word means “to eat one's fill.” HALOT (electronic edition, p. 1303).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

became full and satisfied (NCV)

They became full (ESV)

13:6b

when they were satisfied, their hearts became proud,

- Yes, they were satisfied, but they became arrogant,
- But instead of thanking me, they became haughty and thanked themselves.

when they were satisfied, their hearts became proud: The LORD met the people's needs. But instead of being thankful to him, they became proud.

In some languages, it may not be natural to include the phrase when they were satisfied in both 6a and 6b. Some versions leave this phrase implied. For example:

and then you grew proud (GNT)

hearts became proud: In Hebrew, the phrase hearts became proud is more literally "and their heart was lifted up." This expression means they were proud/arrogant. TWOT (#2133) says "The high heart represents presumption (Deuteronomy 8:14) or pride (Ezekiel 31:10)." Here it indicates that the people did not acknowledge the LORD. They thought they did not need him.

13:6c

and as a result they forgot Me.

- and so they forgot me!
- As a result, they forgot about me.

as a result they forgot Me: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally "therefore they forgot me." The word "therefore" introduces the result or consequence of their prideful response to God's provision.

Here are some ways to indicate result or consequence:

therefore they forgot me (RSV)

And so they forgot Me (NJPS)

That is why you forgot me (GW)

forgot Me: Here the Hebrew word means to stop thinking/caring about the LORD. It probably implies at least these four things: NIDOTTE (#8894).

- They ignored their commitment to the LORD and to their covenant obligations.

- They followed other gods.
- They stopped temple worship.
- They trusted in the things they had instead of trusting in the LORD.

Hosea 13:7

Section 13:1-16: The LORD's anger against Israel

In this section, the LORD gives reasons for his anger against Israel. It was necessary to judge them because they continued to rebel against him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Final Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord's Relentless Judgment on Israel (ESV)

Ephraim's Idolatry (NASB)

Paragraph 13:4-8

In this paragraph, the LORD is the speaker. He states a complaint against the people of Israel. He always took care of them, but they forgot him. He must punish them in response.

13:7-8

Notice the parallel lines that are similar in meaning:

^{7a}So like **a lion** I will pounce on them;

^{7b}like **a leopard** I will lurk by the path.

^{8a}Like **a bear robbed of her cubs** I will attack them, and I will tear open their chests.

^{8b}There I will devour them like **a lion**,

^{8c}like **a wild animal** would tear them apart.

These lines contain figures of speech (similes) in which the LORD compares himself to fierce animals that attack and kill other animals or people.

These multiple animal similes give emphasis to the power and fierceness of the LORD in his judgment of them. Carroll (pages 296-297), Macintosh (page 534), and Garrett (pages 258-259). That judgment will be carried out through Assyria when their armies attack and destroy the nation of Israel. These similes are intentionally intense and shocking. McComiskey (page 217), Macintosh (page 534), Carroll (pages 296-297),

and Garrett (pages 258–259). and should be translated accordingly.

13:7a

So like a lion I will pounce on them;

- Therefore I will become like a lion to them.
- So I will do to them what a lion does,

So: Verses 13:7–8 describe the consequence of Israel forgetting the LORD. Most versions introduce this consequence with a word such as So or “Therefore” (NAB). Introduce this consequence in a natural way in your language.

like a lion I will pounce on them: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as I will pounce is literally “I became.”

There are two interpretations of the time reference:

1. It is future tense. It refers to what will soon occur. A future time reference is suggested by the parallel imperfect verbs in the series of similes, “I-will-lurk,” “I-will-attack,” “I-will-devour,” “will tear apart.” McComiskey (page 217) suggests that the function of the waw consecutive here is primarily to connote logical consequence. God becoming a lion is the logical consequence of the people forgetting him. The NET footnote for this word agrees. The future sense of the verbs that follow this one indicate that the activity of God is pending. The BART interlinear cites Waltke and O’Connor chap 33.1.2.f, calling this a ‘specific future.’ A future sense is also supported by the LXX and the Vulgate. For example:

So I will become like a lion to them (NRSV) (BSB, CEV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. It refers to what has begun to occur and is ongoing in Hosea’s time. The waw consecutive form is the standard way Biblical Hebrew indicates a past event in a story line. Keil (page 102) states that the word is the preterite that gives the consequence of forgetting God. The punishment has already begun and will continue in the future. Macintosh (page 532) agrees with rabbinical scholar ibn Ezra, who suggests that the waw consecutive [past] indicates the evils which have [already] befallen Israel. Davies (page 290) cites the NJPS “I am become” as a past event and suggests that the imperfect verbs that follow it might be meant as iterative present tenses, “I lurk,” “I attack them and rip open...” For example:

So I am to them like a lion (ESV) (ESV, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. Translate this time reference in a natural way in your language.

There are also two main interpretations of the meaning of the Hebrew word for “I became” here:

1. It means “be/become.” His actions toward the people will be like those of a lion. The specific behavior of a lion is left implied. For example:

So now I shall be like a lion to them (NJB) (ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NRSV, REB)

1. It means “attack.” He attacks the people like a lion does. For example:

So I will attack you like a lion. (GNT) (BSB, CEV, GNT, NET, NIV, NLT)

Interpretation (1) will be used in the Display. However, either interpretation is acceptable. Each one implies the other.

lion: A lion is a large cat that is capable of killing humans as well as other animals. If lions are not known in your language area, it is suggested that you provide a picture or describe it in a footnote.

13:7b

like a leopard I will lurk by the path.

- I will be like a leopard that silently waits by a path to ambush them.
- and I will hunt them like a leopard.

leopard: A leopard is similar to a lion. It is a large, spotted cat that is capable of killing humans as well as other animals. Leopards hunt by silently stalking their prey before attacking. If leopards are not known in your language area, it is suggested that you provide a picture or describe it in a footnote.

I will lurk by the path: There is a Hebrew wordplay in this clause. The Hebrew word for I will lurk is very similar to the word for “Assyria.” This can be seen in some ancient versions, the LXX and the Peshitta. For example, the Peshitta has “like a leopard by the way of Assyria.” Generally the wordplay is not translated or footnoted in modern versions. The Hebrew word for I will lurk is literally “I will watch.” TWOT (#2354 II). In this context, the meaning is to watch in order to ambush.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Like a leopard I will lie in wait along your path.
(GNT)

Like a leopard I will wait by the road to ambush you. (GW)

Hosea 13:8

Section 13:1–16: The LORD's anger against Israel

In this section, the LORD gives reasons for his anger against Israel. It was necessary to judge them because they continued to rebel against him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Final Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord's Relentless Judgment on Israel (ESV)

Ephraim's Idolatry (NASB)

Paragraph 13:4–8

In this paragraph, the LORD is the speaker. He states a complaint against the people of Israel. He always took care of them, but they forgot him. He must punish them in response.

13:8a

Like a bear robbed of her cubs I will attack them, and I will tear open their chests.

- I will attack them like a bear whose cubs were stolen. I will split open their chests.
- I will tear them apart like an enraged bear who has lost her cubs.

Like a bear robbed of her cubs: In Hebrew, these words are more literally “like a bear bereaved.” It refers to a mother bear that is enraged because of the loss of her cubs. Andersen and Freedman (page 635) suggest that the mother bear imagery is used to stress extreme rage that exceeds or surpasses that of humans. It is rage because of loss. See also Dearman (page 324), Davies (page 290), and Stuart (page 204). Garrett (pages 258–259) suggests that the children are the common people of Israel. The royal and priestly leaders robbed the children of Israel from the LORD and made them to be children of Baal.

bear: A bear is a large animal that is capable of killing humans as well as other animals. It has sharp teeth and long claws. If bears are not known in your language area, it is suggested that you provide a picture

or describe it in a footnote. You may also use a more general phrase. For example:

a fierce/angry wild animal

I will attack them, and I will tear open their chests:

The attack is ferocious. It does more than injure. It kills. Stuart (page 204). Be sure that you translate in a way that does not make the attack sound less severe.

tear open their chests: This phrase is more literally “and I will tear the enclosure of their heart.” The Hebrew word for “enclosure of their heart” refers to the breast or the rib-cage.

13:8b

There I will devour them like a lion,

- Like a lion I will devour them quickly
- I will eat them there as if I were a lion.

There I will devour them like a lion: The lionThe Hebrew has a different word for lion here than in 13:7a. However, there is no apparent meaning difference. comparison continues to indicate the violence of the LORD's judgment. TWOT (#1070c). According to TWOT, labi’ “lion” in Hosea 13:8 serves as a symbol of the violence of God in judgment (Hos 13:8).

The word There is left implied in some other versions. The word has no explicit referent. It may refer to the time and be translated as “then” or “immediately.” For example:

Like a lion I will devour you on the spot (GNT)

However, There might refer back to the path in 7b. Most versions that include the word “there” leave the referent unstated. For example:

I will devour them there like a lion (NET)

devour: In this figure of speech, the lion devours/eats those it attacks. A common figurative meaning of devour is to destroy. TWOT (#85). “Figuratively, droughts, famines, and pestilences are said to consume, meaning that they overcome. From this is also derived the usage of oppressors consuming their victims.”

13:8c

like a wild beast would tear them apart.

- in the same way that a wild animal would tear them apart.
- Like a wild animal I will split/rip them open.

like a wild beast would tear them apart: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “the animal of the field will tear them to pieces.” In this clause the subject changes from “I” (the LORD) to “A wild animal.” There are two main interpretations of this clause:

1. This clause compares either the behavior of the lion or of the LORD to the behavior of a typical wild animal. The cited versions may be following one of two possible interpretations here. One interpretation is that this line further describes the lion or the previous animals. Macintosh (page 533) describes this interpretation more technically as a circumstantial clause, “while/as if wild beasts rip them in pieces.” A second possible interpretation regards this clause as a separate metaphor in which the LORD is compared to an unspecified wild animal. This interpretation assumes that the Hebrew comparative *ki* is implied here. See Dearman (pages 323–324). It is difficult to be certain which of these two interpretations each cited version is following. Either one is acceptable. For example:

Like a wild animal I will tear you apart. (GW) (BSB, CEV, GNT, GW, ESV, NASB, NET, NCV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. This clause describes the behavior of wild animals. It is a literal description, not a figurative comparison. For example:

The beasts of the field shall mangle them. (NJPS) (KJV, NIV, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. This interpretation continues the pattern of figurative descriptions in each line.

a wild beast: This phrase is more literally “animal of the field.” Here this phrase refers to wild animals that attack human beings or damage land. NIDOTTE (#2651). It is singular, but it may also be understood as collective singular. Macintosh (page 534).

In some languages, the natural way to translate collective singular is by using plural. For example:

wild animals

Hosea 13:9

Section 13:1–16: The LORD’s anger against Israel

In this section, the LORD gives reasons for his anger against Israel. It was necessary to judge them because they continued to rebel against him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Final Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord’s Relentless Judgment on Israel (ESV)

Ephraim’s Idolatry (NASB)

Paragraph 13:9–11

In this paragraph, the LORD continues to speak.

13:9a–b

The NRSV has been used as the source line for 13:9a–b because of the recommended interpretation and textual options.

13:9a

You are destroyed, O Israel,

- ¶ “O Israel, I will destroy you^(sing).
- ¶ “I will destroy you^(plur) people of Israel.

(NRSV) I will destroy you, O Israel: In Hebrew, this clause is literally “it/he has destroyed you Israel.” There are four interpretations of the subject of this clause:

1. The LORD destroys Israel. Two possible ways to justify this view are: 1) The MT pronoun “it/he” refers to the lion or wild animal of 13:8. The animal represents the LORD. Therefore, logically “it/he” refers to the LORD. See Garrett (pages 259–260). 2) There is a textual error in the MT. The Hebrew word should be 1st person pronoun, “I.” See Stuart (page 200) and Andersen and Freedman (page 636). For example:

“I will destroy you, people of Israel! (GNT) (GNT, NCV, NET, NRSV, REB)

1. Israel destroys itself. For example:

Israel, you have destroyed yourself (NJB) (GW, KJV, NJB)

1. The destroyer is unspecified. For example:

“You are destroyed, O Israel (NIV) (BSB, CEV, NIV, NJPS, NLT)

1. Hatred of the LORD destroys Israel. For example:

It is your destruction, O Israel, that you are against me, against your help. (NASB) (NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It makes good sense following the animal descriptions in 13:7–8. The Hebrew verb pattern also best matches this interpretation. The MT has a Piel pattern. However, the expected pattern for reflexive and/or passive interpretations (2) and (3) is Niphal or Hophal. Interpretation (4) is possible but it is a minority view among versions and scholars.

The verb tense/aspect of this clause is probably prophetic perfect. A prophetic perfect presents a future event as if it has already happened. See the BART interlinear “it will destroy you” citing van der Merwe, *A Biblical Hebrew Reference Grammar for Students*, chapter 19.2.5 ii. This also matches the future time frame of the animal descriptions in 13:7–8. The majority of versions that follow interpretation (1) translate the verb as future.

13:9b

because you are against Me—against your helper.

- Who then can help you?^(sing) No one!
- No one can help you^(plur).

(NRSV) who can help you?: There is a textual variant of this clause:

1. The LXX and the Peshitta have a rhetorical question: “who will help you?” Instead of the MT *ki-bi bʾezreka* “but in me is your help,” the LXX may be based on a different Hebrew text *ki-mi bʾezreka* “for who is your help.” See the NET footnote on “Who” for this verse. This option is supported by Stuart (pages 204–205) and Davies (page 292). For example:

Who is there to help you? (NET) (CEV, GNT, NCV, NET, NRSV, REB)

1. The Masoretic Text has a statement: “for in me in your help.” For example:

though in me lies your help (NJB) (BSB, ESV, GW, NASB, NIV, NJPS, NJB, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It is a fitting introduction to the rhetorical questions in the following verse. It is also recommended by the editors of the BHS. *The Biblia Hebraica Stuttgartensia*, the standard edition of the Masoretic Text. See the NET footnote on “Who” for this verse.

The implied answer to this question is “Not me” or “No one.” If a rhetorical question is unnatural in your

language, you may translate it as a statement. For example:

Don’t expect help from me. (CEV)

Hosea 13:10

Section 13:1–16: The LORD’s anger against Israel

In this section, the LORD gives reasons for his anger against Israel. It was necessary to judge them because they continued to rebel against him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Final Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord’s Relentless Judgment on Israel (ESV)

Ephraim’s Idolatry (NASB)

Paragraph 13:9–11

In this paragraph, the LORD continues to speak.

13:10a

Where is your king now to save you in all your cities,

- Where is your^(plur) king, the one you hope will save you in all your cities? He is nowhere!
- In all your cities, you want your king to save you, but he cannot.

Where is your king now to save you in all your cities: In Hebrew, this clause is literally “where [is] your king then that he may save you in all your cities?” This is a rhetorical question. The implied answer is “Nowhere.” It implies that their king cannot save them. It does not necessarily mean they have no king. Wood (page 221).

There are textual issues concerning this clause. There is also an interpretation issue. First, the notes will discuss the textual issues:

There is a textual/interpretation issue concerning the word *Where*:

1. The LXX and the Peshitta have *Where*. For example:

Where then is your king, that he may save you in all your cities? (NET) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The Masoretic Text has the word “I will be.” For example:

I will be thy king: where is any other that may save thee in all thy cities? (KJV) (KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most versions and commentaries. It also has the support of the BHS editors. Davies (pages 292–293) states that the Hebrew word should be regarded as a dialectal variant for the standard Hebrew word for “where.” See also Macintosh (page 537), McComiskey (pages 220–221), and the NET footnote for “Where” in this verse.

king: The Hebrew word refers to the highest ruler. TWOT (#1199a). See Hosea 3:4a.

now: The Hebrew word has various meanings depending on context. Here it strengthens the word “where.” Some versions translate it as “then.” Keil (page 102) and McComiskey (page 220). According to TWOT (#144) this word is a particle that often occurs in sentences containing a question, command, or wish. Some versions leave it implied.

to save you: In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally “so that he may save you.” It expresses a wish or intention to save them. The Heb verb *wāyošīʾaka* “so that he may save you” looks like a *waw* consecutive. However, a *waw* consecutive would make no sense here. Macintosh (page 537) describes it as a simple *waw* with a jussive that has voluntative or potential force. Accordingly, the *waw* is understood here as “so that” rather than a simple “and.”

in all your cities: There is a textual issue concerning the phrase in all your cities:

1. The Masoretic Text has in all your cities. This phrase describes the populated locations in Israel where an enemy attack is most likely to occur. Macintosh (page 538) and Stuart (page 205). For example:

Where now is your king, to save you in all your cities? (ESV) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. Some scholars think that the original text has “to defend you.” Macintosh (page 537) notes that some commentators have questioned the MT reading because it restricts the king’s help just to cities, so they have emended the text in various ways. For example:

Where are all your princes, to defend you... (RSV) (RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It requires no changes to the Hebrew text.

There is another interpretation issue concerning the phrase in all your cities:

1. The phrase in all your cities describes where the king should save people. For example:

Where now is your king, that he may save you in all your cities (NASB) (BSB, ESV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET)

1. The phrase in all your cities describes where the rulers are located. For example:

Where now is your king, that he may save you?
Where in all your cities are your rulers (NRSV) (GW, NIV, NJB, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It best follows the syntax of the Masoretic Text. The MT text has: “where [is] your king then that he may save you in all your cities and your rulers....” Grammatically, the phrase, “in all your cities” is part of the first clause. The conjunction “and” that follows this phrase and starts the second clause confirms this.

13:10a–c (combined/reordered)

- You^(plur) asked for a king and for leaders, but how can they save the nation? (GNT)

13:10b and the rulers

- Where are your^(plur) leaders,
- Neither can your other rulers save you.

and the rulers: In Hebrew, this clause is literally “and your rulers.” There is an ellipsis of the question word “where” in the Hebrew clause. The question is implied from the first clause. Most versions make the word “where” explicit. For example:

Where are all your rulers— (ESV)

This clause is a rhetorical question. The implied answer is “Nowhere.” It implies that their rulers, whom they requested along with the king, are also unable to save them.

rulers: In Hebrew, this word can mean “judges” or rulers. TWOT (#2443). Here the role of governing is probably in view, not the role of a judge. McComiskey (pages 220–221).

13:10c**to whom you said, “Give me a king and princes”?**

- the ones you^(plur) demanded of me when you said, “Give me a king and princes”? They are nowhere!
- You begged me to give you a king and leaders, but none of those can save you now.

to whom you said, “Give me a king and princes”?:

In Hebrew, this clause is literally “whom you said give to me a king and leaders.”

The direct quote may refer back to the incident in 1 Samuel 8:5, 19, when the people of Israel requested a king. Andersen and Freedman (page 636) and Dearman (pages 324–325). This information should not affect your translation. However, you could add a cross-reference if desired.

In some languages, it may be more natural to use an indirect quote here. For example:

Where are all your rulers, those you wanted when you asked for a king and rulers?

king and princes: In Hebrew, the word princes refers here to any leader, chief, or official who serves in the government of the king. Here the word princes is parallel to “rulers” in 13:10b. Andersen and Freedman (page 636) and Macintosh (page 537).

General Comment on 13:10a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine the verse parts. For example:

You asked for a king and for leaders, but how can they save the nation? (GNT)

In some languages, it may be preferable to split the sentence parts into separate lines. For example:

What good is your king? Can he save you in any of your towns? What good are your leaders? You said, ‘Give us a king and leaders.’ (NCV)

Hosea 13:11**Section 13:1–16: The LORD’s anger against Israel**

In this section, the LORD gives reasons for his anger against Israel. It was necessary to judge them because they continued to rebel against him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Final Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord’s Relentless Judgment on Israel (ESV)

Ephraim’s Idolatry (NASB)

Paragraph 13:9–11

In this paragraph, the LORD continues to speak.

13:11a**So in My anger I gave you a king,**

- In anger I gave you^(plur) kings,
- I give you kings in my anger.

13:11b**and in My wrath I took him away.**

- and in wrath I took them away.
- In my rage I take them from you.

13:11a–b

Notice the parallel lines that are similar in meaning:

^{11a}So in My anger **I gave you a king,**

^{11b}and in My wrath **I took him away.**

So in My anger I gave you a king, and in My wrath I took him away: There are two main ways to interpret the identity of the king to which this clause refers:

1. The clause refers to the series of kings of Israel starting in the past and continuing in the time of Hosea. The Hebrew verbs are imperfect in form, “I give” and “I take away.” Wood (page 221) comments that the reference is not to one king but to the series of kings that had occupied Israel’s throne since the kingdom’s division. This interpretation is favored by Hubbard, Keil, Macintosh, McComiskey, Davies, and Wood. For example:

I give you kings in my ire, and take them away in My wrath. (NJPS) (GNT, NJPS, NLT, RSV)

1. The clause refers to king Saul, the first king of Israel. Patterson and Hill (page 80) comment that most translations and scholars render this Hebrew prefix conjugation verb as past tense. Although the form is imperfect the function is preterite. This rare use is noted in the IBHS 31.1.1, which states that in poetic texts recounting history, imperfect=present/future can function as a waw consecutive=past. This interpretation is favored by Andersen and Freedman and Stuart. See 1 Samuel 8. For example:

I gave you a king in my anger, and I took him away in my wrath. (NRSV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most commentaries. It also follows a standard use of the imperfect verb form and better fits the context of 13:10.

king: The word, king, is singular. See Davies (page 293), Keil (page 103), McComiskey (page 221), Macintosh (page 537), Wood (page 221), and Hubbard (page 219). However, it may have a collective sense (“kings”). This is indicated by the immediate context of 13:10, which pertains to the situation in Hosea’s time.

Hosea 13:12

Section 13:1–16: The LORD’s anger against Israel

In this section, the LORD gives reasons for his anger against Israel. It was necessary to judge them because they continued to rebel against him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Final Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord’s Relentless Judgment on Israel (ESV)

Ephraim’s Idolatry (NASB)

Paragraph 13:12–16

In this paragraph, the LORD expresses his anger against Israel and describes his coming judgment. He compares Israel’s situation to a painful childbirth and to a child who resists being born (13:13). He describes his coming judgment figuratively as a taunt to the grave (Sheol) and death to come and destroy (13:14) and as a desert wind that dries up springs and fountains (13:15). He also describes it nonfiguratively by citing horrible acts of war (13:16).

13:12a–b (combined/reordered)

- ¶ Israel, your^(sing/plur) terrible sins are written down and stored away. (CEV)

Notice the parallel lines that are similar in meaning:

^{12a} The iniquity of Ephraim is **bound up**;

^{12b} his sin is **stored up**.

These lines indicate that the LORD remembers the sins of the people of Israel. It is as if he has written a list of them on a document and stored it in a safe place. At a future time, he will punish the people for those sins. Some versions make explicit that the purpose of the storing is for future punishment. For example:

The sins of Israel are on record, stored away, waiting for punishment. (NCV)

iniquity...sin: The meanings of these words are similar. The Hebrew word for iniquity may refer to wickedness or evil deeds, as in 12:8c or 12:11a. It may also refer to the “guilt” that is caused by that wickedness. HALOT (electronic edition, page 800) mentions “guilt caused by sin (and the consequences thereof).” Carroll (pages 298–299) says that “the term ‘iniquity’ can refer to a transgression, the guilt due for it, or the punishment it incurs.” Here the Hebrew word for sin means to miss the way, to incur guilt. TWOT (#638).

bound up...stored up: The meanings of these words are similar. The first word means to wrap something. HALOT (electronic edition, page 1058) The second word means to hide or preserve something. HALOT (electronic edition, page 1049). Here the words describe a record of Ephraim’s sin as if written on a parchment that is stored and perhaps sealed to preserve it. Macintosh (page 542), McComiskey (page 223), and Carroll (pages 298–299).

General Comment on 13:12a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine these parallel statements into one line. For example:

Israel, your terrible sins are written down and stored away. (CEV)

13:12a

The iniquity of Ephraim is bound up;

- ¶ “The record of Ephraim’s evil deeds is stored away.
- ¶ “I will not forget the sins of the people of Ephraim.

13:12b

his sin is stored up.

- They are written on a list.
- It is as if I have written a list of those sins in a book.

Hosea 13:13

Section 13:1–16: The LORD’s anger against Israel

In this section, the LORD gives reasons for his anger against Israel. It was necessary to judge them because they continued to rebel against him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Final Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord's Relentless Judgment on Israel (ESV)

Ephraim's Idolatry (NASB)

Paragraph 13:12–16

In this paragraph, the LORD expresses his anger against Israel and describes his coming judgment. He compares Israel's situation to a painful childbirth and to a child who resists being born (13:13). He describes his coming judgment figuratively as a taunt to the grave (Sheol) and death to come and destroy (13:14) and as a desert wind that dries up springs and fountains (13:15). He also describes it nonfiguratively by citing horrible acts of war (13:16).

13:13a

Labor pains come upon him,

- Ephraim is in pain like a woman about to give birth.
- Labor pains of childbirth come to the people of Ephraim.

Labor pains come upon him: This line is a figure of speech that describes the pain that Israel experiences. The pain is like the pain a mother feels when she gives birth to a child.

There are two main interpretations of the time reference in this clause.

1. Present. It refers to Israel at the time of Hosea. For example:

Pangs of childbirth assail him (NJPS) (BSB, ESV, NASB, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NRSV)

1. Future. It refers to Israel at a time yet to come. For example:

The labor pains of a woman will overtake him (NET) (KJV, NET, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a majority of versions. The verse makes good sense as a description of Israel at that time.

There are at least two possible aspects of this pain:

1. It is severe. The nation of Israel suffers terribly as a result of sin. Macintosh (page 534) mentions that the consequences of Ephraim's record of guilt are

terrible, like the excruciating pain of a woman in labor.

2. It signals a time for birth. The nation of Israel has the opportunity to be reborn, by repenting and returning to the LORD. Hubbard (pages 220, 221) states that the birth pangs connote not so much anguish as timing. It is time for the son to be born. It is time for Israel to reject his haughty independence and to declare his total commitment to Yahweh.

Both aspects may be intended here. Some versions make the second aspect explicit. For example:

They have the opportunity to live again (GW)

13:13b

but he is an unwise son.

- He is like an unwise infant.
- But the people are as unwise as babies

but: In Hebrew, there is no explicit contrast. However, many versions regard 13b to contrast with 13a. They supply a word such as but to indicate that contrast. Some versions do not indicate it. Indicate the connection of 13b to 13a in a natural way in your language.

he is an unwise son: This is a new figure of speech that compares Israel to an unwise child. Wisdom in the Old Testament means to live according to the LORD's standards of right and wrong. TWOT (#647). In this figure of speech, Israel, like the infant, is described as being capable of such wisdom, but he does not use it.

13:13c

When the time arrives, he fails to present himself at the opening of the womb.

- For when it is time to be born, he will not come out of his mother's womb.
- who refuse to be born when the right time comes.

When the time arrives, he fails to present himself at the opening of the womb:

This clause gives the reason for the previous line. The child has no wisdom, because he chooses not to be born.

The Hebrew clause begins with a word that introduces this clause as a reason. Some versions use a word such as "for" to indicate it. For example:

...for at the right time he does not present himself at the opening of the womb. (ESV)

Many other versions, such as the BSB above, allow the context to indicate that this is a reason. Indicate that this is a reason in a natural way in your language.

Some versions make it explicit that the child chooses not to be born. For example:

like a child about to be born, who refuses to come out of the womb. (GNT)

they are like a child who resists being born. (NLT)

When the time arrives: In Hebrew, this phrase is a single word meaning time. The context indicates that here time refers to the time to be born.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

at the right time (ESV)

his time is due (NJB)

like a child about to be born (GNT)

he fails to present himself at the opening of the womb: The phrase he fails to present himself (DCH (page 464). refers to the infant failing to move into the birth position.

The phrase at the opening of the womb is more literally “at the breaking forth of children.” It refers to the part of a woman’s body through which an infant is born. HALOT (electronic edition, page 642).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he does not leave the womb (NJB)

but won’t come out of its mother’s womb (GW)

Hosea 13:14

Section 13:1–16: The LORD’s anger against Israel

In this section, the LORD gives reasons for his anger against Israel. It was necessary to judge them because they continued to rebel against him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Final Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord’s Relentless Judgment on Israel (ESV)

Ephraim’s Idolatry (NASB)

Paragraph 13:12–16

In this paragraph, the LORD expresses his anger against Israel and describes his coming judgment. He compares Israel’s situation to a painful childbirth and to a child who resists being born (13:13). He describes his coming judgment figuratively as a taunt to the grave (Sheol) and death to come and destroy (13:14) and as a desert wind that dries up springs and fountains (13:15). He also describes it nonfiguratively by citing horrible acts of war (13:16).

13:14a–d

Notice the parallel lines that are similar in meaning: Notice the poetic chiasmic structure: 14a grave, 14b death, 14c death, 14d grave.

^{14a}I will ransom them from the power of **Sheol**;

^{14b}I will redeem them from **Death**.

^{14c}Where, O **Death**, are your **plagues**?

^{14d}Where, O **Sheol**, is your **sting**?

There are two main interpretations of these four clauses:

1. The first two clauses are rhetorical questions. The implied answer is “No.” The LORD indicates by means of these rhetorical questions that he will punish Israel. For example:

Shall I ransom them from the power of Sheol? Shall I redeem them from Death? (NRSV) The second two clauses are also rhetorical questions. The LORD taunts death, implying, “Where is the destruction that you should bring to Israel? See Dearman (pages 328–329), Stuart (page 207), Davies (page 295), Macintosh (page 546), and Hubbard (page 221). For example:

O Death, where are your plagues? O Sheol, where is your destruction? (NRSV) (CEV, GNT, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB).

1. The first two clauses are statements. The LORD promises to save the people of Israel. For example:

I shall ransom them from the power of Sheol; I shall redeem them from Death. (ESV) The second two clauses are rhetorical questions. In light of the LORD’s preceding promise to save Israel,

he here mocks death because it can no longer destroy. See Andersen and Freedman (pages 639–640), Keil (pages 104–105), McComiskey (pages 223–224), and Wood (page 221). For example:

O Death, where are your plagues? O Sheol, where is your sting? In more literal versions, such as the NRSV and the ESV, the surface structure of the second set of rhetorical questions is the same in both interpretations. The meaning of 14a–b determines whether the message of the two questions here is bad/threatening or good/encouraging for the people of Israel. (ESV) (BSB, ESV, GW, The GW has statements for all four clauses. Unlike other versions that use statements, it uses the phrases “I want to...” It has been listed here, because it clearly supports the overall meaning of interpretation (2). KJV, NIV, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a majority of versions and commentaries. It best fits the context of judgment in the surrounding verses. Both the LXX and Syriac follow interpretation (2). However, many scholars hold that a promise of rescue here is out of place in the context of this whole paragraph that focuses on judgment. In addition, ch. 12 and the first part of ch. 13 all deal with Israel’s terrible sins and the LORD’s determination to punish them. However, it should be noted that ch. 6:1–3 and ch. 14 both contain promises that the LORD will forgive the people and restore their nation. It is clear from 1 Corinthians 15:55 that the Apostle Paul either reads this verse in a positive light as do the early versions, or else in rabbinic fashion he reframes the original declaration of judgment into a proclamation of victory over death in light of Christ’s resurrection. See Dearman (pages 328–329). Calvin (pages 478–479) points out that the apostles sometimes focused on a single word or concept in a quoted passage rather than then conveying the entire thought. Here, Paul probably alluded indirectly to this Hosea text because of his desire to praise “the incredible power of God.”

Some versions translate in a way that makes the implied meanings more explicit. For example:

Will I deliver them from the power of Sheol? No, I will not! Will I redeem them from death? No, I will not! O Death, bring on your plagues! O Sheol, bring on your destruction! (NET)

Should I, the Lord, rescue you from death and the grave? No! I call death and the grave to strike you like a plague. (CEV)

The GNT translates the rhetorical questions in the first two clauses as statements:

I will not save this people from the world of the dead or rescue them from the power of death. (GNT)

This may be a good translation option if a rhetorical question is not natural or effective in your language.

13:14a–b (combined/reordered)

- I will not save this people from the world of the dead or rescue them from the power of death. (GNT)

ransom...redeem: The Hebrew word for ransom means “transfer ownership of a person or object to another.” McComiskey (page 223). TWOT (#1734). The Hebrew word for redeem means here “reclaim [Israel] as one’s own.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 169). In this context of ransoming/redeeming from death, the words could be translated as “save/rescue.” For example:

Will I save them from the place of the dead? Will I rescue them from death? (NCV)

power of Sheol: The Hebrew phrase is more literally “hand of Sheol.” In Hebrew a common figurative meaning of “hand” is power or strength. TWOT (#844).

The word Sheol can refer to “place of the dead” or just “death.” McComiskey (pages 223–224).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the power of Sheol (RSV)

the place of the dead (NCV)

Some versions leave the word power implied. For example:

“Should I ransom them from the grave? (NLT)

13:14a I will ransom them from the power of Sheol;

- “Will I deliver them from the power of Sheol?
- “Should I rescue them from the grave? No!

13:14b**I will redeem them from Death.**

- Will I redeem them from death?
- Should I save them from death? No!

13:14c**Where, O Death, are your plagues?**

- O death, where are your^(sg) plagues?
- Death, bring your deadly diseases!
- O Death, hurry up and cause the diseases that kill people!

13:14d**Where, O Sheol, is your sting?**

- O Sheol, where is your^(sg) destruction?
- Grave, bring your disasters!
- Oh grave/Sheol, go ahead and destroy them.

13:14c–d

Where: Here the word Where does not ask about the literal location of plagues and destruction. It is used as part of a taunt. See interpretation (1) above. Some versions translate the taunt in a different way. For example, the NLT translates the rhetorical questions as commands:

O death, bring on your terrors! O grave, bring on your plagues! (NLT)

plagues: The Hebrew word means any kind of disease that causes death. BDB (#1698) and TWOT (#399b). The NASB has “thorns” here. “Thorns” is a second possible meaning of the word according to HALOT (electronic edition, page 212) sense II and NIDOTTE (#1823). However, only a small minority of versions follow it.

sting: There are two main interpretations of the meaning of the Hebrew word:

1. It means “destruction.” For example:

O Sheol, where is your destruction? (NRSV) (GNT, GW, KJV, NET, NIV, NRSV)

1. It means sting. For example:

O Sheol, where is your sting? (ESV) (BSB, ESV, NAB, NASB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The most common meaning of the Hebrew word is “destruction.” It has good support from the majority of versions and scholars. BDB (#6986) and TWOT (#2007a) give “destruction” as the meaning of the Hebrew word.

There is also some support for the meaning “sting.” The LXX and Syriac have “sting.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 1092) sense 3 and NIDOTTE (#7776) list “sting” as one sense of the word. However, both interpretations have good version support, so it is recommended that you give the other option in a footnote. For example:

This is what the Masoretic Text probably means. Some ancient and modern versions have “sting” here.

13:14e**Compassion is hidden from My eyes.**

- I will not have compassion on them.
- I refuse to pity these people.

Compassion is hidden from My eyes: The Hebrew word translated as Compassion is found only here in the Old Testament and the meaning is debated. For example, HALOT (electronic edition, page 689) gives the meaning as “compassion.” BDB (#5164) gives the meaning as “sorrow,” “repentance.” There are two main interpretations of this line:

1. The LORD will not show compassion. This interpretation is favored by Davies (page 296), Macintosh (pages 548–549), and Wood (page 221). See also the NET footnote on the first line of 13:14. For example:

I will no longer have pity for this people. (GNT) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, NASB, NCV, NET, NJB, NIV, NLT, REB) Most versions that follow this interpretation also follow interpretation (1) of 14a–d above, which says that the LORD will not rescue his people from death.

1. The LORD will not change his plan to save his people. This interpretation is favored by McComiskey (pages 223–224, Garrett (pages 264–265), and Keil (pages 104–105). For example:

I won’t even think of changing my plans. (GW) (GW, KJV, NJPS) Versions that follow this interpretation also follow interpretation (2) of 14a–d above, that the LORD will rescue his people from death.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. It better fits the recommended interpretation in 14:a–d and the context of judgment in the surrounding verses.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

I refuse to show mercy. (CEV)

For I will not take pity on them. (NLT)

Hosea 13:15

Section 13:1–16: The LORD's anger against Israel

In this section, the LORD gives reasons for his anger against Israel. It was necessary to judge them because they continued to rebel against him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Final Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord's Relentless Judgment on Israel (ESV)

Ephraim's Idolatry (NASB)

Paragraph 13:12–16

In this paragraph, the LORD expresses his anger against Israel and describes his coming judgment. He compares Israel's situation to a painful childbirth and to a child who resists being born (13:13). He describes his coming judgment figuratively as a taunt to the grave (Sheol) and death to come and destroy (13:14) and as a desert wind that dries up springs and fountains (13:15). He also describes it nonfiguratively by citing horrible acts of war (13:16).

13:15a–f

Although he flourishes among his brothers, an east wind will come—a wind from the LORD...: This verse describes the unexpected result of a condition. There are two possible interpretations:

1. 15a is the condition. 15b–f is the unexpected result. For example:

^{15a}Though he flourishes among his brothers, ^{15b}an east wind will come (REB) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. 14e is the unexpected result. 15a is the condition. For example:

^{14e}"I will have no compassion, ^{15a}even though he thrives among his brothers. (NIV) (NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries.

Here are some ways to show a condition and unexpected result:

- Introduce the condition in 15a. Leave the unexpected result implied. For example:

^{15a} Though Ephraim bears more fruit than his brothers, ^{15b}the wind from the east wind will come (NJB)

- Leave the condition implied. Introduce the unexpected result in 15b. For example:

^{15a}Ephraim was the most fruitful of all his brothers, ^{15b}but the east wind—a blast from the Lord—will arise in the desert. (NLT)

- Introduce both the condition in 15a and the unexpected result in 15b. For example:

^{15a} Even though he flourishes among his brothers, ^{15b}nevertheless, an east wind will come....

Indicate the condition and unexpected result in a natural way in your language.

13:15a

Although he flourishes among his brothers,

- Although Ephraim flourishes more than his brothers,
- The people of Ephraim have become important among their relatives. (GW)

Although: The Hebrew clause starts with a word that introduces a condition. The word *ki* is understood as concessive "although/even though." See HALOT (electronic edition, page 471) sense 12. See the examples above for other ways to indicate a condition and unexpected result.

he flourishes: The word *he* refers to Ephraim. Some versions make the pronoun referent explicit. For example:

Though Ephraim bears more fruit (NJB)

The Hebrew word for "flourish" means to "show fruitfulness" or "flourish." HALOT (electronic edition, page 961). Some of the letters in this word are also in the Hebrew word for "Ephraim." Hosea may have chosen this word to create an intentional pun or word play that links "flourish" to "Ephraim." See Hubbard (page 223), McComiskey (pages 226–227), Carroll (page 300), and Dearman (pages 331–332).

The tense of the verb indicates that he continued to flourish up to the time that Hosea spoke these words. Here are some other ways to translate this time span:

he thrives (NIV)

he flourishes (REB)

Translate this time span in a natural way in your language.

among his brothers: There are two main textual issues in this clause. The first concerns the word that the BSB translates as among:

1. The LXX has “between/among.” The word *bên* “between/among” closely resembles the word *bên* “son.” Some scholars suggest that *bên* is a northern spelling of *bên*. See Andersen and Freedman (pages 640–641). For example:

Though he flourishes among his brothers (REB) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, KJV, NABRE, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The Masoretic Text has the word “son.” For example:

Although he, a son of brothers, flourishes Adapted from the BART interlinear gloss. (no English versions)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with all versions.

There is also a textual issue concerning the Hebrew word for brothers in this phrase. These are the two main options:

1. The Masoretic Text has brothers. For example:

Though Ephraim may flourish among his brothers (NABRE) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, KJV, NABRE, NCV, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB)

1. Some scholars think that the original word was “reeds.” Scholars suggest that the MT substituted the word *ʾaḥ* “brother” for the word *ʾaḥu* “marsh plant, reed plant.” BDB (#269). See Garrett (pages 266–268) and the NET footnote on “reed plant.” For example:

For though he flourish among reeds (NJPS) (GNT, NASB, NET, NJPS, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. It has good support from scholars and early versions. The LXX, Peshitta and Vulgate all translate the Hebrew word as “brothers” here.

Here the word brothers refers to the tribes of Israel. The phrase “Although he flourishes among his brothers” implies that the tribe of Ephraim has become great or very important among the tribes of Israel. Dearman (pages 331–332) and Hubbard (page 223). See also Hosea 12:8; 13:1. Some versions make that implication explicit. For example:

No matter how much you prosper more than the other tribes (CEV)

The people of Ephraim have become important among their relatives. (GW)

13:15b

an east wind will come—a wind from the LORD

- nevertheless a devastating east wind will come. It is a wind from Yahweh
- Yet, I, Yahweh, will cause a hot, dry wind to blow
- Yahweh will send the enemy to come/destroy like the hot wind

13:15c

rising up from the desert.

- that blows from the desert.
- from the eastern desert.
- that blows from the desert/wilderness in the east.

13:15b–c

Notice the parallel lines that are similar in meaning.

^{15b}an east wind, will come—a wind from the LORD

^{15c} rising up from the desert.

an east wind will come—a wind from the LORD rising up from the desert: This is the second part of the clause that begins with 15a. The phrase from the LORD indicates that these lines describe a judgment from the LORD against Ephraim. The flourishing of Ephraim will not prevent it.

The phrase east wind often refers to the sirocco. The sirocco is a devastating, drying wind that comes from the desert to the east of Israel. Andersen and Freedman (pages 640–641) and Keil (pages 105–106).

Here, however, the phrase is figurative. It compares the armies of Assyria to the sirocco. Patterson and Hill

(page 81), Dearman (pages 331–332), Stuart (page 208), Keil (pages 105–106), and Wood (page 222).

Some ways that they are similar are that:

1. They both come from the east.
2. They both cause destruction.
3. The LORD sends them both.

Most versions translate the phrase here as the east wind or wind or something similar. They leave the comparison to the Assyrian armies implied. It is recommended that you translate in a similar way if possible.

However, it may be confusing or unnatural in some languages to use this figure of speech. If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Change the figure of speech to a simile. For example:

^{15b} the enemy is like an east wind that will come
—a wind from the LORD

^{15c} rising up from the desert.

- Change the figure of speech to a simile and make explicit the way that they are similar. For example:

^{15b} the enemy will destroy like an east wind that
will come—a wind from the LORD

^{15c} rising up from the desert.

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

^{15b} The LORD will send the enemy. They will come
from the east,

^{15c} moving swiftly from the wilderness.

- Use a different figure of speech with the same meaning that is natural in your language.

The east wind figure of speech continues in 15d–f. If you make a change in 15b–c you may need to make changes to 15d–f to concord with it. For example, if in 15b–c you translate the meaning without the figure of speech, you may need to translate 15d–f without the figure of speech there as well.

desert: This word refers to dry and barren land where very few people live. Another way to translate desert is “wilderness” (ESV).

13:15d–e (combined/reordered)

- Ephraim’s water sources will disappear.

Notice the parallel lines that are similar in meaning.

^{15d} His fountain will **fail**,

^{15e} and his spring will **run dry**.

These lines describe the effect of the drying wind on the water sources of Israel. They will dry up.

fountain...spring: The Hebrew words for fountain and spring are closely related. The word for fountain means a water source. HALOT (electronic edition, page 627). The Hebrew word for spring also means “source” or “headwaters.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 612).

Here are some other ways to translate these lines:

his spring will dry up; his well will become dry
(NET)

All their flowing springs will run dry, and all their
wells will disappear. (NLT)

Another option is to combine these two lines 15d–e. For example:

dries up streams of water (CEV)

and it will dry up their springs and wells (GNT)

fail...run dry: The Hebrew words for fail and run dry both mean to “dry up.” There is some debate concerning the Hebrew word in 15d that the BSB translates as “fail.” The MT has the word “ashamed” BDB (#954). The LXX, Peshitta, and the Vulgate, however, translate the word as “dry up” NIDOTTE (#3312). It is possible that these early versions based their translations on a different Hebrew word root. It is one that also occurs in a Qumran text. Modern versions follow the early versions here. See Andersen and Freedman (pages 640–641) and the NET footnote on this word.

13:15d His fountain will fail,

- Ephraim’s springs will no longer flow,

- It will dry up their streams

13:15e**and his spring will run dry.**

- and the water in his wells will disappear.
- and other water sources.

13:15f**The wind will plunder his treasury of every precious article.**

- His treasuries will be raided and all his valuable things will be taken away.
- It will empty his/their storage places of every treasure.
- His/Their enemies will rob/steal all their treasures.

The wind will plunder his treasury of every precious article: This clause probably refers to the plunder of Ephraim by Assyrian armies. The LORD used them to judge Ephraim.

Here are four acceptable ways to describe this event:

- Say that the east wind plunders. Macintosh (page 550). This translation option continues the east wind figure of speech from 15a. The east wind represents the Armies of Assyria, who plunder. For example:

However, the Lord's scorching wind will come from the east.... The wind will destroy every precious thing in their storehouses. (GW)

- Say that it is the LORD who plunders. McComiskey (pages 226–227) and Andersen and Freedman (pages 640–641). This translation option indicates that the LORD is the one who sends the Assyrian armies, represented by the east wind, to plunder. For example:

the Lord will send a wind from the east.... He will destroy from their treasure houses everything of value. (NCV)

- Say that the enemy plunders. For example: This translation option makes explicit that the enemy, the Assyrian armies, are the plunderers.

an east wind will come, a blast from the Lord rising over the desert.... The enemy will plunder his wealth, all his costly treasures. (REB)

- Leave the agent of plundering implied. Davies (page 296) suggests that "the east wind" need not be the grammatical subject of "plunder" here. The verb may have an indefinite subject equivalent to passive. In

this translation option, the fact that Ephraim will be plundered is what matters. The identity of the plunderer is not important. For example:

Every precious thing they own will be plundered and carried away. (NLT)

treasury: There are two main interpretations of the Hebrew word for treasury in this context: TWOT (#154a) has "treasure," "treasury," "storehouse."

1. The word means treasury. A treasury is a place where valuable things are stored. Dearman (pages 331–332) and Davies (page 296). For example:

to strip his treasury of everything worth having (NJB) (BSB, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NRSV)

1. The word means "treasure(s)" (valuable things). McComiskey (pages 226–227). For example:

That [wind] shall plunder treasures, Every lovely object. (NJPS) (CEV, GNT, KJV, NET, NJPS, NLT, REB)

The display will follow interpretation (1). However, the Hebrew word can mean either treasures or the place treasures are stored. So either interpretation is acceptable.

every precious article: The Hebrew phrase for every precious article is more literally "every vessel of preciousness." Some versions translate the phrase as a reference to foodstuffs. For example, the NET has: "delightful foods." But there is no evidence from the phrase or the context that the meaning is that limited or that it refers to food at all. This phrase refers to objects of value, such as those made of silver or gold. Hubbard (page 225) states that this phrase "probably means images, art objects, jewelry and serving vessels." It may refer in particular to treasures of the king and or temple, but it could include those of the general population as well. Andersen and Freedman (page 641), Keil (page 106), and Dearman (pages 331–332).

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase:

all its treasures (NIV)

your precious treasures (CEV)

everything of value (NCV)

Hosea 13:16

Section 13:1–16: The LORD’s anger against Israel

In this section, the LORD gives reasons for his anger against Israel. It was necessary to judge them because they continued to rebel against him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Final Judgment on Israel (GNT)

The Lord’s Relentless Judgment on Israel (ESV)

Ephraim’s Idolatry (NASB)

Paragraph 13:12–16

In this paragraph, the LORD expresses his anger against Israel and describes his coming judgment. He compares Israel’s situation to a painful childbirth and to a child who resists being born (13:13). He describes his coming judgment figuratively as a taunt to the grave (Sheol) and death to come and destroy (13:14) and as a desert wind that dries up springs and fountains (13:15). He also describes it nonfiguratively by citing horrible acts of war (13:16).

13:16a

Samaria will bear her guilt

- Samaria will suffer the consequences of her guilt,
- The people of Samaria must be punished for their sins,

Samaria will bear her guilt: There is a textual issue concerning the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as bear her guilt:

1. The Masoretic Text has “it/she will be held guilty Samaria.” BDB (#816). For example:

Samaria will be held guilty (NET) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. The LXX has “Samaria will be destroyed.” A possible root is BDB (#3456) “be desolate.” For example:

Samaria will become desolate (REB) (KJV, NCV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and commentaries. This interpretation is favored by Keil, Garrett, McComiskey, Davies, Macintosh, and Wood. The word guilt implies that a person has sinned. The phrase bear her guilt means

the people of Samaria will suffer the consequences of their sin. TWOT (#180) says that the meaning can shift from the sinful act that brings guilt to the status of guilt/culpability (deserving punishment) to the act of punishment. In this verse the meaning is the act of punishment because of their guilt.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

The people of Samaria are guilty as charged (GW)

The people of Samaria must bear the consequences of their guilt (NLT)

Samaria will pay the penalty (NJB)

Samaria will be punished (CEV)

Samaria: It is possible that the name Samaria represents the nation of Israel here, as “Ephraim” often does elsewhere. Dearman (pages 332–333) and Wood (page 222). The NCV translates “Samaria” as “The nation of Israel.” However, it is not certain. It makes good sense for Hosea to speak of the literal city and people of Samaria at that time, just prior to the Assyrian invasion of Samaria. Stuart (pages 208–209) suggests that at that time Samaria was the only major reminder left of the once successful, influential Northern Kingdom. It is recommended that you follow the majority of versions that translate the name either as Samaria or “the people of Samaria.”

13:16b

because she has rebelled against her God.

- for she^(sg) has rebelled against her God.
- because they have turned against me, their God.

because she has rebelled against her God: This line gives the basis or reason for Samaria’s guilt. McComiskey (page 227). Samaria is guilty of rebellion against God. A Hebrew word, translated here as because (“for” in some versions), introduces the reason. Introduce this reason in a natural way in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

For she has defied her God (NJPS)

Samaria will be punished for turning against me. (CEV)

her God: This phrase points to the relationship that the people should have with God. Hosea may intend to give attention to how inexcusable their behavior is. They rebel as if he is not their God. Macintosh (page 555). Some versions leave the word *her* implied. However, it is recommended that you translate the complete phrase, *her God*.

God: In this clause, the Hebrew word for God is a form of *elohim* and not *YHWH*. Use your general term for God here.

13:16c–e

Notice the parallel lines that are similar in meaning.

^{16c} They will **fall by the sword**;

^{16d} their little ones will be **dashed to pieces**,

^{16e} and their pregnant women **ripped open**.

These three lines describe the terrible consequences of the people's rebellion against God. They will suffer and die in war. The first line is a more general statement. The second and third lines give specific examples.

There is an ellipsis in the third line. In some languages the verb may need to be supplied. For example:

and their pregnant women will be ripped open

The second and third lines are passive in form. In some languages, it will be more natural to use active forms. For example:

^{16d} the enemy will dash Samaria's little ones to pieces,

^{16e} they will rip open the pregnant women.

13:16c

They will fall by the sword;

- Her people will be killed in war.
- The enemy will come to attack and kill them.

They will fall by the sword: This phrase can mean that the Assyrian army will kill some people using swords. The same phrase can be a figure of speech that means people will die in war, regardless of the weapon used. It is a standard description of the devastation of war. IVPBBC Hosea 13:16. Some versions, such as the BSB above, translate the Hebrew phrase more literally.

Others translate the wider meaning of war. Either way to translate this phrase is acceptable. Here are some other examples:

Her people will die in war. (GNT)

They will be killed by an invading army (NLT)

13:16d

their little ones will be dashed to pieces,

- Her children will be beaten to death against the ground,
- They will smash the little children against rocks.

their little ones will be dashed to pieces: This line is probably meant literally.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

children will be beaten against rocks (CEV)

their children will be smashed to death (GW)

13:16e

and their pregnant women ripped open.

- and their pregnant women will be cut open."
- They will slice open the pregnant women with their swords."

their pregnant women ripped open: This line is also probably meant literally.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

their pregnant women ripped open by swords (NLT)

their pregnant women disemboweled (NJB)

General Comment on Hosea 13:16a–e

The Hebrew pronouns that refer to Samaria within this verse vary in number and gender. 16a–b has feminine singular, "she/her." 16c–d has masculine plural, "they/their." 16e has masculine singular, "his." This amount of variation within a single verse is not natural in some languages. Translate these references to the city and people of Samaria in a natural way in your language.

Here are some possible options:

- Use a combination of singular and plural pronouns. For example:

Samaria shall bear her guilt, because she has rebelled against her God; they shall fall by the sword, their little ones shall be dashed in pieces, and their pregnant women ripped open. (RSV)

- Use only singular pronouns. For example:

Samaria must be punished for rebelling against me. Her people will die in war; babies will be dashed to the ground, and pregnant women will be ripped open.” (GNT)

- Use only plural pronouns. For example:

The people of Samaria are guilty as charged because they rebelled against their God. They will be killed in war, their children will be smashed to death, and their pregnant women will be ripped open. (GW)

This division concludes the book of Hosea. The mood is hopeful and the verses are poetic. Hosea pleads with the people of Israel to return to the LORD. If the people repent, the LORD will forgive them and restore their nation. The book of Hosea ends with a wise saying that is like a proverb. Here are some other examples of section headings:

Repentance to Bring Blessing (NIV)

The Repentance and Reconciliation of Israel (NJB)

Hosea 14:1

Section 14:1–3: Hosea pleads with his fellow Israelites to return to the LORD

Hosea is the speaker in this section. He urges the people of Israel to acknowledge their sin and their need for the LORD. He gives them an example of a prayer that will express their repentance. Here are some other examples of section headings:

Hosea’s Plea to Israel (GNT)

Turn back to the Lord (CEV)

14:1a

Return, O Israel, to the LORD your God,

- ¶ O Israel, return to Yahweh, your^(sing/plur) God,
- ¶ Hear me, people of Israel! Come back to Yahweh, your^(plur)/our^(incl) God.

Return, O Israel, to the LORD your God: In this clause, Hosea urges the nation of Israel to return to the LORD. This clause implies that the people are to repent and submit to the LORD. See Andersen and Freedman, Patterson and Hill, Garrett, Dearman, Carroll, Davies, McComiskey, and Macintosh.

O Israel: Here Hosea addressed the people of Israel directly. Some versions have added the word O to make it clear that O Israel is a term of address (vocative). Use a vocative that is natural in your language when a person speaks to a group of people.

The name Israel is a figure of speech that represents all the people of Israel. This is indicated by the plural pronouns in 14:2–3. Some versions translate this meaning explicitly. For example:

Return to the Lord your God, people of Israel.
(GNT)

Return...to the LORD your God: In Hebrew, the form of the word Return here indicates an invitation or plea. BHRG 19.4 2. The imperative form (i) Directives d. Invitation. Also Wood (page 223). Another way to translate Return is “come back.” For example:

Israel, come back to Yahweh your God (NJB)

The Hebrew preposition translated as to indicates that the people need to fully and seriously return to the LORD. The Hebrew preposition is ‘ad, BDB (#5704). McComiskey (page 229) comments that the phrase with this preposition stresses the extent of the action. It is stronger than the more frequently occurring phrase with ‘el that stresses direction. Macintosh (page 560) adds that the preposition denotes steady deliberation and seriousness of purpose that is necessary from the beginning to complete the large task. Some versions make this meaning more explicit by repeating the plea or by adding special punctuation. For example:

Israel, return! Come back to the Lord your God.
(CEV)

the LORD your God: The pronoun your in this phrase is a reminder to the people that the LORD is still their God, in spite of their sins. Patterson and Hill (page 85) and Davies (page 298). In some languages, this pronoun may imply that the LORD is not Hosea’s God. If that is true in your language, you may use the inclusive pronoun “our.”

14:1b**for you have stumbled by your iniquity.**

- because your^(sing) sins have caused you to stumble and fall!
- For you^(plur) are ruined/destroyed because of your^(plur) sin.

for you have stumbled by your iniquity: This clause states the reason for Hosea's plea.

In Hebrew the clause begins with a word that introduces a reason. Some versions, such as the BSB above, translate this word as "because" or for.

Some other versions leave the reason implied. Use a natural way in your language to indicate that this clause is a reason.

The Hebrew word for iniquity is the same word that the BSB translates as "iniquity" in Hosea 13:12. See the note there on "iniquity...sin" for more information.

stumbled: The literal meaning is to fall physically. Here it has the figurative meaning of "to fail" or to be "ruined." Hubbard (page 225) and McComiskey (page 229). TWOT (#1050) says that the verb usually describes physical falling, but numerous times the figurative use of failure or ruin occurs. The people have sinned and have experienced ruin and failure as a result.

Here are two ways to translate this meaning:

- Translate the word as "stumble" and leave the figurative meaning implied. For example:

For you have stumbled because of your iniquity. (ESV) This option is acceptable in languages in which the figurative meaning will be understood.

- Translate the meaning directly. For example:

For your sin has been your downfall! The English word "downfall" is readily understood to mean loss, failure or ruin. (NET)

Because your sins have ruined you.

Hosea 14:2**Section 14:1–3: Hosea pleads with his fellow Israelites to return to the LORD**

Hosea is the speaker in this section. He urges the people of Israel to acknowledge their sin and their need for the LORD. He gives them an example of a

prayer that will express their repentance. Here are some other examples of section headings:

Hosea's Plea to Israel (GNT)

Turn back to the Lord (CEV)

14:2

In this verse, Hosea explains how the people should return to the LORD. He offers a model prayer. It shows that a true return requires humility and sincere words.

14:2a**Bring your confessions and return to the LORD.**

- Take an offering of words with you^(plur) and return to Yahweh,
- Return to Yahweh, saying these words:

Bring your confessions and return to the LORD: According to OT teaching, people took an offering to God when they came to him. See Exodus 23:15; 34:20. Keil (page 106). The usual offering was an animal. Here, however, Hosea told them to take an offering of their words instead of an animal.

The words they should offer are the words that Hosea tells them to say to the LORD in the rest of this verse and in 14:3. Dearman (pages 337–338), Garrett (pages 270–271), Keil (pages 106–107), Stuart (page 213), Carroll (page 301), Hubbard (page 227), McComiskey (page 229), Macintosh (page 563) and Wood (page 223).

Some versions make clearer what words Hosea refers to here. For example:

Come back to the Lord and say these words to him: "Take away all our sin and kindly receive us...." (NCV)

Come back to the Lord with your words of confession (REB)

14:2b**Say to Him: "Take away all our iniquity and receive us graciously,**

- saying, "Forgive us all our^(excl) sins and accept what is good.
- "Take away every sin and accept our sincere words of confession.

The NJPS has been used as the source line for 2b–c because it follows the recommended interpretations.

(NJPS) Say to him: “Forgive all guilt and accept what is good: In this clause Hosea tells the people how to begin their prayer.

Forgive all guilt: The Hebrew syntax of this request, “every you will forgive iniquity,” is unusual. The word “every” goes with “iniquity” but it is interrupted by the verb “forgive.” The two main explanations for this odd syntax are: 1) This is a broken construct chain. This suggestion is probably correct, as similar examples occur elsewhere. For example, Hosea 6:9 has: “[the] way they murder to Shechem” in which the construct chain “the way to Shechem” is interrupted by the verb “they murder.” See Andersen and Freedman (page 645), McComiskey (page 229) and Davies (page 302). 2) The word “every” is meant as the adverb “wholly” as in “wholly forgive.” See the NET footnote on “Completely” for 14:2. This option has less support. Davies (page 302) and Macintosh (page 561) discuss this option but it is not clear that either one favors it. The word Forgive means to “take away guilt.” BDB (#4984) 3c. For information on the word guilt see the note in Hosea 13:12 on “guilt...sins.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause part:

Take away all iniquity (ESV)

Forgive all our sins (NLT)

And accept what is good: There is a textual issue regarding the Hebrew word that the NJPS translates as what is good.

1. The Hebrew word is: good. BDB (#2895) III 2. For example:

accept what is good (ESV) (CEV, The CEV makes explicit that their praise is what is good. The CEV has “Accept our good sacrifices of praise....” ESV, NAB, NJPS, NRSV)

1. The Hebrew word is: “word/speech.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 372) IV. The LXX has “speak to him,” a verbal form of this word. Some scholars question if “word/speech” is a true sense of the Hebrew word. ṭb. Macintosh (page 562) says that even though the word “good” can imply words, it is not certain that the Hebrew word itself can actually mean “word, speech.” The cited versions translate “word/speech” as “prayer.” For example:

accept our prayer (GNT) (GNT, NET)

1. The Hebrew word is: “graciously.” This option has a different subject and object than options (1) and (2). Instead of the people giving an offering to God, God offers graciousness to the people. The justification for this option is unknown. According to Davies (page 302) the root that underlies the option is TWOT (#793b) ṭb “goodness, graciousness.” This option requires a different form of the Hebrew word in the MT. For example:

and graciously receive us (NLT) (BSB, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It has the best support from lexicons. However, in this context, the phrase what is good refers to words of confession and repentance in prayer. For that reason option (2) is also acceptable.

14:2c

that we may present the fruit of our lips.

- May we^(excl) offer as bulls these good words from our lips.
- Then we will offer to you^(sing) praise from our lips instead of bulls.

(NJPS) instead of bulls we will pay [the offering of] our lips: The Hebrew clause is more literally “so that (or: and) we may pay bulls our lips.” There is a textual issue concerning the Hebrew word for bulls:

1. The Hebrew MT has bulls. The Hebrew word for “bulls” here is generally understood to be an adverbial accusative, “so that we may pay/offer our lips as bulls.” See Keil (pages 106–107), Carroll (page 301), McComiskey (page 229) and Macintosh (page 563). For example:

Accept our good sacrifices of praise instead of bulls. (CEV) (CEV, ESV, KJV, NAB, NET, NJB, NJPS) The ESV and the NAB are listed here because they translate the Hebrew word as “bulls.” However, in both these versions the people pay their vows by means of offering bulls. It is not recommended that you follow the ESV or the NAB translations of this clause. These translations do not express the logic flow of the verse up to this point. See also Hosea 6:6 and Macintosh (page 563).

1. The LXX has “fruit.” Two common ways to explain the LXX translation are: (1) The original Hebrew word was pēri “fruit” rather than pārim “bulls” or (2) the word final “m” in pārim is an “enclitic m” that marks case or emphasis and is not a plural suffix. See

Andersen and Freedman (page 645), Garrett (pages 270–271), Dearman (pages 337–338) and Hubbard (page 227). For example:

accept that which is good and we will offer the fruit of our lips (NRSV) (BSB, NABRE, NASB, NIV, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with the majority of versions. It is similar to the first part of the verse in which Hosea urges the people to take their words of repentance to the LORD.

There are two acceptable ways to understand the connection of this clause to the preceding one:

- This clause explains the phrase “what is good” in the preceding clause. The clause initial Hebrew connector, *waw*, means “and/namely” and indicates apposition here. The offering of praise from our lips is what is good. For example:

Accept what is good, namely the praise of our lips as equal to an offering of bulls.

- This clause gives the result of what is said in the preceding clause. The clause initial Hebrew connector, *waw*, means “so that” and introduces a result here. God’s acceptance of our prayer of repentance allows us to offer praise as a result. For example:

Accept our penitential prayer, that we may offer the praise of our lips as sacrificial bulls. (NET)

we will pay [the offering of] our lips: Here the Hebrew word for pay means to make a payment to fulfill a vow. BDB (#7999) 4. “make good, i.e. pay, vows.” See also Keil (pages 106–107) and Dearman (pages 337–338). The words the offering of are not in the Hebrew text but they are implied by the reference to bulls.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause part:

we may offer you the sacrifice of praise (NLT96)

we will dedicate to you our lips. (NJB)

Hosea 14:3

Section 14:1–3: Hosea pleads with his fellow Israelites to return to the LORD

Hosea is the speaker in this section. He urges the people of Israel to acknowledge their sin and their need for the LORD. He gives them an example of a

prayer that will express their repentance. Here are some other examples of section headings:

Hosea’s Plea to Israel (GNT)

Turn back to the Lord (CEV)

14:3

Hosea’s model prayer continues in this verse. It includes a list of three main sins that the people should confess and turn away from:

1. trust in foreign powers
2. trust in military strength
3. trust and worship of idols

They should stop depending on these things and depend instead on the LORD. Davies (page 303), Garrett (pages 271–272) and Stuart (page 213). They should acknowledge that the Lord is the one who cares for people like themselves, who have become like orphans.

14:3a

Assyria will not save us,

- Assyria will not save us^(excl),
- Foreign nations like Assyria will not rescue us,

Assyria will not save us: In this part of the prayer, the people admit to the LORD that the nation of Assyria will not save them from their enemies. Instead they promise to trust in the LORD to save them from danger.

Assyria may be a figure of speech that represents all foreign nations that Israel relied on to protect them. Stuart (page 213). Most versions leave the figurative meaning implicit.

save: This word means “deliver/save” from peril. BDB (#3467) Hiph. 1c.

14:3b

nor will we ride on horses.

- we^(excl) will not ride on horses used for war,
- we will not depend on our^(excl) horses and chariots,

nor will we ride on horses: In this part of the prayer, the people promise to trust in the LORD to save them from danger. They will not trust in their own military strength.

At that time, armies used horses in battle to carry soldiers and to pull chariots.

Here, riding horses is probably a figure of speech that represents the armies and the military strength of the Israelites. Carroll (pages 301–302), Dearman (pages

338–339), McComiskey (page 230). This reference to horses may also refer in part to reliance on Egypt. See Keil (page 107) and Dearman (pages 338–339). Hosea refers to horses in a similar way in 1:7.

Some versions make it more explicit that the Hebrew words refer to using horses in war.

Here are some other ways to translate this promise:

we will not mount war-horses (NIV)

We will not ride warhorses (NET)

and war horses cannot protect us. (GNT)

horses: In Hebrew, this word is a collective singular “horse” that indicates horses. McComiskey (page 230). In many languages, it is more natural to use plural here, as in the BSB.

14:3c

We will never again say, ‘Our gods!’ to the work of our own hands.

- and we will no longer say ‘Our^(excl) gods’ to objects our^(excl) hands have made.
- and we^(excl) will never again regard idols that we have made to be gods,

We will never again say, ‘Our gods!’ to the work of our own hands: In this part of the prayer, the people acknowledge that idols are objects that humans have made. They are not gods, and the people promise to stop worshiping them.

In some languages, it may be more natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

We will never again say that the things our hands have made are our gods. (GW)

gods: In Hebrew, this word is plural. However, there are two interpretations of the intended meaning:

1. It means gods. The word refers to more than one idol. For example:

Never again will we say to the idols we have made, ‘You are our gods.’ (NLT) (BSB, GW, KJV, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT, REB)

1. It means god/God. Some versions capitalize the word as “God.” Perhaps this is meant to imply that the people confuse the idol with the true God of Israel. The Hebrew word is a plural of majesty that

refers to one god. Macintosh (page 565). For example:

Nor will we say again, ‘Our god,’ (NASB) (ESV, GNT, NASB, NJB, NJPS, NRSV)

The Display will follow interpretation (1), but either interpretation is acceptable. Dearman (pages 338–339) and Davies (page 304) state that “Our God” and “our gods” are two possible ways to translate the Hebrew here. Follow the interpretation that is the most natural in your language in this context.

the work of our own hands: This phrase refers to “idols.”

14:3d

For in You the fatherless find compassion.”

- For you^(sing) are the one who shows compassion to fatherless people.”
- because it is you who loves and cares for orphans like us^(excl).”

For in You the fatherless find compassion: In this part of the prayer, the people acknowledge that the LORD shows compassion to orphans.

The first word in the clause introduces a reason. The Hebrew word is a relative particle. Most commentators and versions regard the particle here to function as a conjunction that introduces a reason. This function is mentioned in BHRG 6, 40, 40.6, 5. “indicates a cause (rare) (subordinating conjunction)” and Gesenius 158b. See also Macintosh (page 565), Davies (page 303) and Keil (page 107). The reason that the people should repent and return to the LORD is because he shows compassion to orphans. Some versions use a word such as For or “since” to introduce this reason. Some other versions leave it implied that this clause is a reason. For example:

In you the orphan finds mercy. (ESV)

Use a natural way in your language to indicate that this clause is a reason.

This part of the prayer implies that Israel is fatherless. The people have become orphans because of their rebellion against the LORD. The prayer is a request that the LORD will show compassion and restore his relationship with them as his children. Patterson and Hill (page 85), Hubbard (page 228) and Keil (page 107).

fatherless: The Hebrew word means “orphan, fatherless.” TWOT (#934a). Many versions translate the word as “orphan.” For example:

for you are the one in whom orphans find compassion. (NJB)

compassion: The Hebrew word for compassion means to “love deeply, have mercy, be compassionate.” TWOT (#2146).

The words compassion and “fatherless” link this last chapter of Hosea to the first two chapters of the book. Forms of the Hebrew word for compassion rhm occur in Hosea 1:6; 2:1, 19, 23. In those verses, the name of Hosea’s daughter was Lo-ruhamah “not loved” (or “not shown compassion”). The name indicated that the LORD no longer loved or had compassion for Israel.

The name of Hosea’s son, Lo-ammi “not my people” indicated that the LORD was no longer Israel’s father. In 2:23, however, the LORD promised that one day he would again love Israel and that the people would again become his own people. Here in 14:3d, this same promise is affirmed. Carroll (pages 301–302), Patterson and Hill (page 85), Keil (page 107), Garrett (pages 271–272), Andersen and Freedman (pages 645–646), Dearman (pages 338–339), Stuart (pages 213–214), Hubbard (page 228), Davies (page 303), McComiskey (page 230) and Macintosh (page 567).

Hosea 14:4

Section 14:4–8: The LORD promises to forgive and restore the Israelites

The LORD is the speaker in this section. In Hosea 14:4–7, the LORD gives his response to the people’s prayer of repentance in the form of a poem. In 14:8, he reminds the people that he will not tolerate idols. He also promises to care for the people and bless them. Here are other examples of section headings:

The Lord Promises to Forgive (CEV)

The Lord Promises New Life for Israel (NJB)

Paragraph 14:4–7

This paragraph is a poem with thirteen lines. In Hebrew, verses 4–6 each have three lines. Verse 7 has four lines.

^{4a} I will heal their apostasy;

^{4b} I will freely love them,

^{4c} for My anger has turned away from them.

^{5a} I will be like **the dew** to Israel;

^{5b} he will blossom like **a lily**

^{5c} and take root like **the cedars of Lebanon**.

^{6a} His shoots will sprout,

^{6b} and his splendor will be like **the olive tree**,

^{6c} his fragrance like **the cedars of Lebanon**.

^{7a} They will return and dwell in his shade;

^{7b} they will grow **grain**

^{7c} and blossom like **the vine**.

^{7d} His renown will be like **the wine of Lebanon**.

The poem has two main parts. In 14:4, the LORD gives his response to Israel’s prayer in direct, nonfigurative words. He promises them healing, love and forgiveness.

In 14:5–7, the LORD describes aspects of his healing, love and forgiveness more fully. Each line in this part of the poem is a figure of speech (simile or metaphor) that compares the LORD or Israel to something from nature that was familiar to people in that part of the world.

Verses 5–7 each end with the name “Lebanon.” “Lebanon” refers to the mountainous area of northern Galilee and modern-day Lebanon. It is a fertile and fragrant region. Dearman (page 341) suggests that the reference to Lebanon provides the source for the metaphors used in these verses.

14:4a

I will heal their apostasy;

- ¶ “I will heal/cure them of their disloyalty/unfaithfulness;
- ¶ Yahweh says, “I will cause my people to faithfully follow me.

I will heal their apostasy: The LXX has, “I will heal their colonies/settlements.” Almost no modern versions follow the LXX here. The Hebrew word for apostasy means “falling away” or “backsliding.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 643) and TWOT (#2340e). The Hebrew word root is šûb “turn away,” which is also

used of the LORD in 4c “turned away (my anger from him).” Some commentators see a word play in this double use of the root. Carroll (page 302) and Dearman (pages 339–341).

The Hebrew word for heal is figurative here. It means to heal hurts of the nation, involving the LORD’s restored favor and forgiveness. BDB (#7495) 2. fig., “heal hurts of nation, involving YHWH’s (restored) favour (and, often, forgiveness).” This healing may include several aspects:

1. The LORD will heal/correct the people’s rebellious, willful spirit. Macintosh (page 569), Hubbard (page 229) and McComiskey (page 232).
2. The LORD will heal/correct the problems that their waywardness has caused. Keil (page 107).
3. The LORD will cure their spiritual blindness. Or mental derangement. Garrett (page #273).
4. The LORD will forgive them. Dearman (pages 339–341).
5. The LORD will restore their covenant relationship. Stuart (pages 214–215) and Carroll (page 302).

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

I will cure them of their unfaithfulness (GW)

I will heal their disloyalty (NRSV)

I will forgive them for leaving me (NCV)

The Lord says, “I will bring my people back to me. (GNT)

14:4b

I will freely love them,

- I will love them without limit,
- I will love them deeply/generously,

I will freely love them: Some versions supply the word “and” here. Others, like the BSB, do not. For example:

The phrase freely love them indicates that God’s love for the people BDB (#157) sense 5. is voluntary and not forced. The Hebrew noun translated as “freely” is BDB (#5071) “voluntariness.” Here the noun is used as an adverb to describe the nature of the love. Macintosh (page 568) and Keil (page 107). It also indicates that his love is generous. Davies (page 304), Stuart (pages 214–215) and Macintosh (page 568).

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

Generously will I take them back in love (NJPS)

I will love them with all my heart (GNT)

I will heal you and love you without limit. (CEV)

14:4c

for My anger has turned away from them.

- for my anger has turned from him/Israel.
- because I am no longer angry with them.

for My anger has turned away from them: The phrase anger has turned away means to stop being angry. This clause implies that the LORD’s judgment against Israel is now complete. Hubbard (page 230).

The first word in the clause introduces a reason. Literally *kî*. Here it is a causal conjunction. McComiskey (page 232), Keil (page 107) and Hubbard (page 230). The reason that the LORD will heal and love them unconditionally is because he has turned his anger away from them. Some versions use a word such as for or “because” to introduce this reason. Some other versions leave the reason implied. For example:

I will no longer be angry with them. (GW)

Use a natural way in your language to indicate that this clause is a reason.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

because I am not angry with them anymore (NCV)

for my anger will be gone forever (NLT)

them: The Hebrew word here is literally “him.” The singular pronoun refers to the nation of Israel as one group. Keil (page 107), Davies (page 304), Hubbard (page 230), McComiskey (page 232) and Macintosh (page 568). However, it may be more natural in some languages to continue to use the pronoun them to refer to the people of the nation, as in 4a–b and many versions, including the BSB above.

Hosea 14:5

Section 14:4–8: The LORD promises to forgive and restore the Israelites

The LORD is the speaker in this section. In Hosea 14:4–7, the LORD gives his response to the people’s prayer of repentance in the form of a poem. In 14:8, he reminds the people that he will not tolerate idols. He also

promises to care for the people and bless them. Here are other examples of section headings:

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Paragraph 14:4–7

This paragraph is a poem with thirteen lines. In Hebrew, verses 4–6 each have three lines. Verse 7 has four lines.

^{4a} I will heal their apostasy;

^{4b} I will freely love them,

^{4c} for My anger has turned away from them.

^{5a} I will be like **the dew** to Israel;

^{5b} he will blossom like **a lily**

^{5c} and take root like **the cedars of Lebanon**.

^{6a} His shoots will sprout,

^{6b} and his splendor will be like **the olive tree**,

^{6c} his fragrance like **the cedars of Lebanon**.

^{7a} They will return and dwell in his shade;

^{7b} they will grow **grain**

^{7c} and blossom like **the vine**.

^{7d} His renown will be like **the wine of Lebanon**.

The poem has two main parts. In 14:4, the LORD gives his response to Israel's prayer in direct, nonfigurative words. He promises them healing, love and forgiveness.

In 14:5–7, the LORD describes aspects of his healing, love and forgiveness more fully. Each line in this part of the poem is a figure of speech (simile or metaphor) that compares the LORD or Israel to something from

nature that was familiar to people in that part of the world.

Verses 5–7 each end with the name “Lebanon.” “Lebanon” refers to the mountainous area of northern Galilee and modern-day Lebanon. It is a fertile and fragrant region. Dearman (page 341) suggests that the reference to Lebanon provides the source for the metaphors used in these verses.

14:5a

I will be like the dew to Israel;

- I will be like dew to Israel.
- I will be to the people of Israel like refreshing dew,

I will be like the dew to Israel: This clause is a simile in which the LORD compares himself to dew. The word dew refers to the drops of water that appear on plants in the evening and/or morning.

Here are two ways that the LORD is similar to dew: This comparison is very different from the comparison of Israel to dew in Hosea 6:4 and 13:3. In those verses Israel's love and the lives of the people are compared to the temporary nature of dew that disappears quickly.

1. He gives refreshment. Keil (pages 107–108), Hubbard (page 230), Davies (page 305) and Carroll (page 303).
2. He provides what is needed for life and health. In that part of the world, it seldom rained from April through October. The dew allowed fruit and other plants to survive and ripen during those dry months. Dearman (page 341).

Some versions make explicit a way that the LORD and dew are similar. For example:

I will be to Israel like a refreshing dew from heaven. (NLT)

14:5b

he will blossom like the lily

- He/Israel will blossom like a lily.
- and they will blossom like beautiful flowers.

he will blossom like the lily: This clause is a simile that compares Israel to a lily. Israel will blossom in a way similar to a lily.

The Hebrew word for lily refers to a flower. BDB (#7799). According to Keil (pages 107–108) the word may refer specifically to a white lily. Other possibilities may be an iris, tulip, crocus or other flower. See Davies (page 305), Macintosh (page 570), Patterson and Hill (page 87) and Stuart (page 215). The Hebrew word for blossom means to “bud” or “sprout.” BDB (#6524).

Here it probably refers to a bud opening into a flower blossom.

Here are some ways that Israel will (figuratively) blossom:

1. The people will reproduce abundantly like a lily. “Fertility.” See Keil (pages 107–108), McComiskey (page 233), and Stuart (page 215).
2. Israel will be beautiful and fragrant like a lily. “Beauty.” See Garrett (page 274), Stuart (page 215); “glory” Macintosh (page 570); “beauty and fragrance” Davies (page 305).

Some versions make explicit that the pronoun he refers to Israel. For example:

Israel will blossom like the lily (NLT)

Some versions have “flowers” instead of lily. This may be a good translation option to follow in languages that do not have a word for lily. For example:

They will blossom like flowers (GNT)

14:5c and take root like the cedars of Lebanon.

- He/Israel will grow roots like a cedar tree in Lebanon.
- They will be strong like trees in Lebanon that have/produce deep roots.

and take root like the cedars of Lebanon: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “and it will strike its roots like (the) Lebanon.” There is a textual issue with the name Lebanon in this clause:

1. The Masoretic Text has Lebanon. For example:

and he will take root like the cedars of Lebanon (NASB) (BSB, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. Some scholars think that the original word was “poplar.” Oort and Valeton, cited in Macintosh (page 571). For example:

he shall strike root as the poplar (RSV) (REB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and scholars. Ancient versions also follow this option.

The phrase that the BSB translates as take root is more literally “and it will strike.” The phrase “strike

its roots” means to “thrust” roots into the ground. BDB (#5221) 1d. Also Macintosh (page 570) and McComiskey (page 233).

The clause is a simile that compares Israel’s roots to the roots of a cedar of Lebanon. This simile is the reverse of the metaphor in Hosea 9:16. In that metaphor Ephraim’s roots are withered. This comparison implies several things:

1. Their roots provide nourishment, so Israel will have splendor/glory. See Wood (page 224) and Macintosh (page 571).
2. Their roots are hardy, so Israel will become great and last a long time. See Macintosh (page 571).
3. Their roots are deep and firm, so Israel will be strong and stable. See Macintosh (page 571), McComiskey (page 233), Stuart (page 215), and Garrett (page 274).

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

They will be firmly rooted like the trees of Lebanon. (GNT)

it will send roots deep into the soil like the cedars in Lebanon. (NLT)

cedars of Lebanon: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as cedars of Lebanon is more literally “like the Lebanon.” There are at least two acceptable ways to translate this expression. They are listed here in order of more specific to less specific:

- Make explicit that this expression probably refers to “cedar” trees that were famous in Lebanon at that time. See Psalms 92:12; 104:16. Carroll (page 303). For example:

He will send down his roots like a cedar of Lebanon. (NET)

- Make explicit that this expression may refer to the trees or forests of Lebanon. As in the Targum. See Macintosh (page 571), McComiskey (page 233), Davies (page 305), Carroll (page 303), and Andersen and Freedman (page 646). For example:

he shall strike root like the forests of Lebanon. (NRSV)

he shall take root like the trees of Lebanon (ESV)

Hosea 14:6

Section 14:4–8: The LORD promises to forgive and restore the Israelites

The LORD is the speaker in this section. In Hosea 14:4–7, the LORD gives his response to the people’s prayer of repentance in the form of a poem. In 14:8, he reminds the people that he will not tolerate idols. He also promises to care for the people and bless them. Here are other examples of section headings:

The Lord Promises to Forgive (CEV)

The Lord Promises New Life for Israel (NJB)

Paragraph 14:4–7

This paragraph is a poem with thirteen lines. In Hebrew, verses 4–6 each have three lines. Verse 7 has four lines.

^{4a} I will heal their apostasy;

^{4b} I will freely love them,

^{4c} for My anger has turned away from them.

^{5a} I will be like **the dew** to Israel;

^{5b} he will blossom like **a lily**

^{5c} and take root like **the cedars of Lebanon**.

^{6a} His shoots will sprout,

^{6b} and his splendor will be like **the olive tree**,

^{6c} his fragrance like **the cedars of Lebanon**.

^{7a} They will return and dwell in his shade;

^{7b} they will grow **grain**

^{7c} and blossom like **the vine**.

^{7d} His renown will be like **the wine of Lebanon**.

The poem has two main parts. In 14:4, the LORD gives his response to Israel’s prayer in direct, nonfigurative

words. He promises them healing, love and forgiveness.

In 14:5–7, the LORD describes aspects of his healing, love and forgiveness more fully. Each line in this part of the poem is a figure of speech (simile or metaphor) that compares the LORD or Israel to something from nature that was familiar to people in that part of the world.

Verses 5–7 each end with the name “Lebanon.” “Lebanon” refers to the mountainous area of northern Galilee and modern-day Lebanon. It is a fertile and fragrant region. Dearman (page 341) suggests that the reference to Lebanon provides the source for the metaphors used in these verses.

14:6a

His shoots will sprout,

- His new shoots/branches will spread out.
- They will be like cedar trees that grow/produce many branches.
- They will become numerous and strong.

His shoots will sprout: This clause continues the agricultural metaphors of 5b (“lily”) and 5c (“cedar”). The pronoun His refers to the nation of Israel. There are three main ways to interpret the reference of this clause:

1. The clause refers backward to the cedar in 14:5c. Davies (page 306) states that this clause forms a single poetic line with the previous clause. Also Wood (page 224). Most versions do not repeat the word “cedar” in this clause, but that would be the most natural referent. For example:

(6c ...like the Lebanon cedar,) and put forth his shoots (NAB)

(6c...like the forests of Lebanon.) His shoots shall spread out (NRSV) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NAB, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NRSV)

1. The clause refers in general to shoots or new branches of any kind of tree. For example:

They will be alive with new growth (GNT)

They will be like growing branches. (GW) (GNT, GW, NCV)

1. The clause refers forward to shoots of olive trees Patterson and Hill (page 87). in 14:6b. For example:

Its branches will spread out like beautiful olive trees (NLT) (CEV, NLT)

You may follow either of the first two interpretations. Most versions that are listed under interpretation (2) could also refer to cedar branches because of the preceding context. The Display will follow interpretation (1) along with the majority of versions.

shoots: In Hebrew, this phrase refers to the new growth of branches. BDB (#3127), Macintosh (page 572). The Hebrew word for “sprout” means to “grow out” or “spread.” BDB (#1980), Macintosh (page 572).

Here are some implications of this metaphor:

1. Israel will have many young shoots. With reference to Israel, this phrase may refer to the increase in the number of Israel’s children. See Macintosh (page 571), Keil (page 166), and Garrett (page 274).
2. Israel’s young shoots will spread widely. The shoots may indicate the expansion of Israel’s territory, as in Psalm 80:11 and Ezekiel 17:4. See Davies (page 306).
3. Israel’s young shoots will have good growth and health. The shoots are a sign of flourishing and growth. See Dearman (pages 341–342) and Garrett (page 274).

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Use a metaphor. Make the similarity explicit if it will be helpful. For example:

Israel will grow branches that are numerous and strong.

- Use a simile. Make the similarity or topic explicit if it will be helpful. For example:

Israel is like a tree that sends out many shoots.

They will be like spreading branches. (NCV)

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

The people of Israel will increase in number and become strong.

14:6b

and his splendor will be like the olive tree,

- His/Israel’s glory will be like an olive tree,
- They will be beautiful like an olive tree

his splendor will be like the olive tree: This clause is a simile that compares Israel’s splendor to that of an olive tree.

Olive trees grow to an old age and produce valuable oil. Macintosh (page 572). The Hebrew word for splendor can also mean “majesty,” “vigor” or “glory.” TWOT (#482a). According to Davies (page 306), the word “normally refers to the splendor or majesty of a king or of God himself.” Also Keil (pages 107–108) and Dearman (pages 341–342).

This comparison implies several things:

1. Israel will be beautiful like an olive tree. Keil (pages 107–108) says “beauty and glory.” Stuart (pages 215–216) says “visibility and beauty.”
2. Israel will have value like an olive tree. For “wealth and well-being,” See Garrett (page 274) and Patterson and Hill (page 87).
3. Israel will be fruitful like an olive tree. According to Macintosh (page 572) the word refers here to “perennial fruitfulness, rich abundance of its fresh branches and crisp foliage as well as its strong trunk.” This simile may refer to the multiplication of Israel’s sons and daughters.

Many versions translate this word as “beauty/beautiful.” For example:

he will have the beauty of the olive tree (NJB)

14:6c

his fragrance like the cedars of Lebanon.

- and his fragrance will be like a cedar of Lebanon.
- and have a delightful aroma like a cedar forest in Lebanon.

his fragrance like the cedars of Lebanon: This clause is a simile that compares the fragrance of Israel to that of the cedars of Lebanon. Israel would no longer be diseased or dying as described in Hosea 5:11–13. Instead Israel will have a scent of life. Garrett (page 274). (See the note on paragraph 14:4–7 for the ellipsis in this verse.)

cedars of Lebanon: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as cedars of Lebanon is more literally “like the Lebanon.” As in 14:5c, there are at least two acceptable ways to translate this expression. They are listed here in order of more specific to less specific:

- Make explicit that this expression probably refers to “cedar” trees that were famous in Lebanon at that time. McComiskey (page 233). Cedar trees have a very pleasant aroma. For example:

and the sweet-smelling cedars in Lebanon (NCV)

- Make explicit that this expression may refer to the forests of Lebanon. Carroll (page 303). For example:

and with the aroma of Lebanon Forest (CEV)

Hosea 14:7

Section 14:4–8: The LORD promises to forgive and restore the Israelites

The LORD is the speaker in this section. In Hosea 14:4–7, the LORD gives his response to the people’s prayer of repentance in the form of a poem. In 14:8, he reminds the people that he will not tolerate idols. He also promises to care for the people and bless them. Here are other examples of section headings:

The Lord Promises to Forgive (CEV)

The Lord Promises New Life for Israel (NJB)

Paragraph 14:4–7

This paragraph is a poem with thirteen lines. In Hebrew, verses 4–6 each have three lines. Verse 7 has four lines.

^{4a} I will heal their apostasy;

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^{5a} I will be like **the dew** to Israel;

^{5b} he will blossom like **a lily**

^{5c} and take root like **the cedars of Lebanon**.

^{6a} His shoots will sprout,

^{6b} and his splendor will be like **the olive tree**,

^{6c} his fragrance like **the cedars of Lebanon**.

^{7a} They will return and dwell in his shade;

^{7b} they will grow **grain**

^{7c} and blossom like **the vine**.

^{7d} His renown will be like **the wine of Lebanon**.

The poem has two main parts. In 14:4, the LORD gives his response to Israel’s prayer in direct, nonfigurative words. He promises them healing, love and forgiveness.

In 14:5–7, the LORD describes aspects of his healing, love and forgiveness more fully. Each line in this part of the poem is a figure of speech (simile or metaphor) that compares the LORD or Israel to something from nature that was familiar to people in that part of the world.

Verses 5–7 each end with the name “Lebanon.” “Lebanon” refers to the mountainous area of northern Galilee and modern-day Lebanon. It is a fertile and fragrant region. Dearman (page 341) suggests that the reference to Lebanon provides the source for the metaphors used in these verses.

14:7a

They will return and dwell in his shade;

- My people will again live in Israel’s shade.
- They will return and live again in peace and prosperity under Israel’s protective shade.

They will return and dwell in his shade: There are textual and interpretation issues in this clause. The first textual issue concerns the relationship of the subject and predicate. The issue of his/my shade will be discussed separately.

1. The LXX has “they will return and they will sit under his shelter.” With this option, the subject “they” will do two things: return and dwell. Some versions imply return by the phrase “dwell again.” The word dwell functions as a verb. For example:

People will reside again in his shade (NET) (BSB, ESV, GNT, GW, NAB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The Masoretic Text has “they will return [those who] dwell in its/his shade.” This option regards the word “dwell” to be a participial noun. It is favored by

Andersen and Freedman, Keil, Garrett, Macintosh, and Wood. With this option, those who return are identified as those who dwell in his shade. The word dwell functions as the participial noun “dwellers.” For example:

They that dwell under his shadow shall return (KJV) (KJV, NJPSThe NJPS has “They who sit in his shade shall be revived.” It translates the Hebrew verb “return” as “be revived.” It is an unusual translation of “return” that lacks support from commentaries and other versions.)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. The vast majority of versions more closely resemble the LXX/Peshitta than the Masoretic Text for this clause.

There are two main interpretations of the word that the BSB translates as return:

1. The word means “again.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 1430) 5. followed by a second verb: “to do again, be again.” Here the word is interpreted to be an auxiliary verb followed by the main verb, “dwell.” This view is preferred by Carroll (page 303). Davies (page 307) also mentions the NIV (“dwell again”) as an alternate translation. For example:

Again they shall dwell in his shade (NAB) (GNT, GW, NAB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The word means return. HALOT (electronic edition, page 1429) 1. “to turn back, return.” This may refer to the future return of the exiles to Israel. This view is preferred by Davies (page 307), McComiskey (page 233), Stuart (page 216), and Garrett (pages 275–278) (who cites rabbinic scholar ibn Ezra). For example:

They shall return and dwell beneath my shadow (ESV) (BSB, ESV, NJB, RSV)

You may follow either interpretation. Interpretation (1) is supported by most versions. Interpretation (2) is supported by more commentaries. Each interpretation implies the other one. The Display will follow interpretation (1) but will include return in the 2nd ML as implied information.

dwell: This word means to inhabit or reside somewhere. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

live (GW)

reside (NET)

in his shade: There is a textual issue in this phrase regarding the referent of the pronoun his:

1. The pronoun refers to “Israel.” See Keil (page 108), Andersen and Freedman (page 647), Garrett (pages 275–278), Dearman (page 342), Davies (page 307), and Wood (page 224). For example:

People will reside again in his shade. (NET) (BSB, NET, NIV, NLT96)

1. The pronoun refers to God. Some scholars suggest that the Hebrew text should be changed from “in his shade” to “in my shade.” Other explanations that do not require a change to the Hebrew text are possible. For example, the LORD may refer to himself in the third person, as “his.” Or if Hosea is now the speaker, then “his” could refer to God. This interpretation is followed by many modern versions. However, it has weak support. The MT, the LXX, and the Peshitta all have “his.” A main objection to this interpretation is that it goes against the context of the plant similes in 14:5–7 that describe the nation of Israel. Garrett (pages 275–278), Stuart (page 216), Macintosh (page 573) and Dearman (page 342) speak against this interpretation. For example:

My people will again live under my shade. (NLT) (CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NCV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It has good support from commentaries as well as the LXX and the Peshitta. Verses 5 and 6 describe the nation of Israel figuratively as a cedar tree. It is reasonable to assume that this verse continues this figurative description.

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as shade means “shadow, shade, as protection from sun.” BDB (#6738). Here the meaning is figurative. It refers to the figurative shade/shadow of the tree, which is Israel in the future.

Here are some implications of this figure of speech:

1. The shade describes the protection offered by the restored state of Israel. Macintosh (page 574). The Hebrew word has a secondary meaning of “protection.”
2. The shade describes the means for the people to flourish. Keil (page 108).
3. The shade describes Israel’s security and fruitfulness. Dearman (page 342).

4. The shade describes Israel's covenant with God. Those who dwell in his shade are those who live under the umbrella or "shade" of the national covenant. Stuart (page 216).

14:7b**they will grow grain**

- They will farm/produce fields of grain
- They will plant and harvest grain in abundance. (NET)

they will grow grain: In Hebrew, this clause is literally "they will cause grain to live." There are two main interpretations of this Hebrew clause:

1. It means that the people of Israel will grow grain. This interpretation is favored by Macintosh (page 573), McComiskey (page 233) and Keil (Page 108). It fits the standard meaning of the verb in Piel, "cause (something) to live" (although its use with grain is not typical). For example:

they will plant and harvest grain in abundance
(NET) (BSB, CEV, GNT, NAB, NASB, NET, NJB, NJPS)

1. It means that the people will flourish like grain. This interpretation is favored by Andersen and Freedman (page 647), Wood (page 224), Garrett (pages 275–278), and Davies (page 307). A difficulty is that the Hebrew text does not explicitly indicate comparison here. This interpretation requires significant changes to the syntax of the line. It changes the grammatical subject/agent from "they" (the people) to an unstated subject (presumably God). It also changes the grammatical object of the Hebrew verb "cause to live" from "grain" to "people." These changes are not supported by the MT syntax. For example:

They shall flourish like the grain. (ESV) (ESV, GW, KJV, NCV, NIV, NLT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It makes good sense without any changes to the grammar of the Hebrew text.

grain: There is a textual issue concerning the Hebrew word for grain:

1. The word is grain. Note that some versions use "corn" or "wheat" as a generic equivalent of grain. For example:

They shall bring to life new grain. (NJPS) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB)

1. Some scholars think that the original word was "garden." For example:

They shall flourish as a garden. (NRSV) (NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. It makes good sense without any changes to the Hebrew text. Garrett (pages 275–278) and Davies (page 307) state that the emendation to "garden" is unsupported and improbable.

14:7c**and blossom like the vine.**

- and they will blossom like a vine.
- They will blossom like grape vines,

blossom like the vine: There are two main interpretations of this clause:

1. The clause is a simile that compares Israel to a vine. Israel will blossom in a way similar to a vine. For example:

And they will blossom like the vine. (NASB) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, REB)

1. The clause means that the people of Israel will make vines grow. For example:

They will make the vine flourish (NJB) (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

The word blossom is the same as in 14:5b "he will blossom like the lily." See the note there for more information on blossom.

The Hebrew word for vine indicates grape vines as a collective. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

They will blossom like grapevines (GW)

and be fruitful like a vineyard (GNT)

14:7d**His renown will be like the wine of Lebanon.**

- They will be famous like the wine from Lebanon.

- and people will esteem/praise Israel as they esteem/praise the wine of Lebanon.

His renown will be like the wine of Lebanon: This clause is more literally “its memorial [will be] like the wine of Lebanon.” There are two main interpretations of the Hebrew word for “memorial” that the BSB translates here as renown:

1. The word means “memorial.” A memorial is something that people remember about a thing or a place. BDB (#2143)
2. “memorial, by which one is remembered b. renown (of Israel).” For example:

They will be as famous as the wine of Lebanon. (GNT) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, REB)

1. The word means “fragrance.” This meaning was originally suggested by rabbinic scholars ibn Janah, Kimchi and Ezra as parallel to the last line of verse 6, “his fragrance like a cedar of Lebanon.” See Macintosh (page 574). However, Davies (page 307) regards this meaning to be a mistranslation. For example:

their fragrance shall be like the wine of Lebanon (NRSV) (KJV, NASB, NLT, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with a majority of versions. It fits the standard meaning of the Hebrew word. The word “fragrance” is not an actual meaning of the Hebrew word in this clause.

This clause is a simile that compares people’s memory of Israel to people’s memory of the wine of Lebanon. Many people knew about the wine of Lebanon and had a high opinion of it. Likewise, many people will know about Israel and have a high opinion of it.

General Comment on 14:7

Many scholars regard the plural Hebrew forms in this verse to refer to the people of Israel and the singular forms to refer to the nation of Israel. Some versions follow the same singular and plural forms as in Hebrew. For example:

People will reside again in his shade;

They will plant and harvest grain in abundance.

They will blossom like a vine,

And his fame will be like the wine from Lebanon. (NET)

Some other versions change the singular or plural forms, perhaps to make the translation easier to read.

Some versions translate most Hebrew singular and plural forms as singular “he/his.” For example:

Men will dwell again in his shade.

He will flourish like the grain.

He will blossom like a vine,

And his fame will be like the wine from Lebanon. (NIV)

Some other versions translate most singular and plural forms as plural “they.” For example:

They will live again in God’s shadow.

They will grow like grain.

They will blossom like grapevines.

They will be as famous as the wines from Lebanon. (GW)

The NIV and the GW translations lose some of the distinctions between the nation of Israel (singular forms) and the people of Israel (plural forms). Translate these forms in a natural way in your language.

Hosea 14:8

Section 14:4–8: The LORD promises to forgive and restore the Israelites

The LORD is the speaker in this section. In Hosea 14:4–7, the LORD gives his response to the people’s prayer of repentance in the form of a poem. In 14:8, he reminds the people that he will not tolerate idols. He also promises to care for the people and bless them. Here are other examples of section headings:

The Lord Promises to Forgive (CEV)

The Lord Promises New Life for Israel (NJB)

Paragraph 14:8

This paragraph summarizes some major themes of the book of Hosea:

1. The LORD is Israel's true God and will not tolerate the worship of idols.
2. The LORD is the one who takes care of Israel.
3. The LORD is the source of Israel's blessings.

14:8a**O Ephraim, what have I to do anymore with idols?**

- ¶ "O Ephraim, what have I ever had to do with idols?"
- ¶ "People of Israel, I have nothing in common with idols. You^(plur) should also stay away from them.

O Ephraim, what have I to do anymore with idols?:

There are textual issues that have to do with the speaker in this rhetorical question:

1. The Masoretic Text has "Ephraim what to me again to idols." In this question to Ephraim, the LORD expresses his own attitude toward idols. Option (1) is supported by Andersen and Freedman, Dearman, McComiskey, Hubbard, Keil, Garrett, and Carroll. Carroll (page 303) argues that suggested changes from first to third person, as in the NJB or NJPS, are "unconvincing" for the reason that Yahweh is the speaker throughout the section. For example:

O Ephraim, what have I to do with idols? (NRSV)
(BSB, ESV, NASB, NET, NIV, NRSV)

1. Some scholars think that the original words were "Ephraim what to you again to idols." This question functions as a command that the LORD gives to Ephraim/Israel. He tells Ephraim to avoid idols. Patterson and Hill (pages 87–88) quote the NLT in support of option (2). For example:

O Israel, stay away from idols! (NLT) (CEV, NCV, NLT)

1. The LXX has "As for Ephraim—what is there any longer between him and idols?" Here the noun "Ephraim" is understood to be a *casus pendens*. See Stuart (pages 216–217). As a *casus pendens*, the noun "Ephraim" is a fronted subject. It is placed outside the following clause and resumed within the clause by the pronoun "him." The LXX has "to him" where the MT has "to me." This question functions as indirect speech. The LORD states that Ephraim will avoid idols. Stuart and Davies. Davies (page 308) says that the LXX rendering yields a stronger contrast with the next line and improves the sense. For example:

The people of Ephraim will have nothing more to do with idols. (GW) (GNT, GW, NJB, REB)

1. The Peshitta has "Ephraim shall say, 'What have I to do again/any more with idols?'" In this question, Ephraim expresses his own attitude toward idols. Macintosh (pages 576–577) thinks that the question expresses Ephraim's attitude. "What need more have I to do with idols?" For example:

Ephraim [shall say]: "What more have I to do with idols? (NJPS) (KJV, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with a majority of versions and commentaries. It makes good sense and does not require changes to the MT.

This clause is a rhetorical question that expects a negative answer. What do I have in common with idols anymore? Nothing! Since the LORD expresses this attitude to Ephraim, it clearly implies that Ephraim also should have nothing to do with idols.

The rhetorical question includes a Hebrew word that the BSB translates as *anymore*. In this expression, the Hebrew word means "more" or "further." DCH (page 291) 2. Expressing addition "...more, further." A literal translation of this word may incorrectly imply that the LORD had something in common with idols in the past but he will have nothing to do with them in the future. Garrett (pages 278–279) and McComiskey (page 236). However, the LORD never had anything in common with idols.

Here are some ways to avoid the wrong meaning and to translate the rhetorical question. Each bullet gives an example of a question and a statement.

- Make explicit that he had nothing in common with idols in the past. The word "ever" or "never" implies that the same is true in the present and will be true in the future. For example:

Ephraim, what have I ever had to do with idols?
The suggestion is from McComiskey (page 236).

O Ephraim, I have never had anything in common with idols!

- Make explicit that he has nothing in common with idols. Leave it implied that the same was true in the past and will be true in the future. For example:

O Ephraim, what have I to do with idols? (NRSV)

Ephraim, I have nothing to do with idols.

Use a natural way in your language to translate this rhetorical question.

14:8b

It is I who answer and watch over him.

- I am the one who answers and takes care of him/ Israel.
- I alone answer your^(plur) prayers and protect you.

It is I who answer and watch over him: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “I I [will] answer and I [will] watch over him.” In Hebrew, the pronoun I has emphasis. McComiskey (page 235). The BSB indicates this with It is I. Indicate this emphasis on the LORD in a natural way in your language.

The verbs in this clause use a form that indicates certainty. The verbs are perfect tense/aspect forms. Here it is probably to be understood as prophetic perfect. Macintosh (578) and the BART interlinear. Prophetic perfect is translated sometimes with present tense and often with future tense, depending on context. See Seow (page 149) who cites two examples: “We are finished! We are lost! (Num 17:27) or “I shall abandon you” (2 Chron 12:5). Many versions translate this clause with present tense. Some versions have future tense. For example:

It is I who answer and look after you. (NRSV)

I will answer their prayers and take care of them (GNT)

Translate this clause to indicate certainty in a natural way in your language.

answer: BDB (#6030). The BSB translates this word as “respond” in 2:21. This word means answer or “respond.” This clause does not say whom the LORD answers. However, this same clause also says “watch over him.” So some versions supply the same pronoun here. For example:

I will answer him and care for him (NET)

The word answer probably implies a response to the needs or the prayers of his people. McComiskey (page 235) suggests that the word describes God’s response to the needs of his people. Some versions make this implication explicit. For example:

I am the one who answers your prayers and cares for you.

watch over him: In this clause, the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as watch over him means “watchful care” or “protecting.” BDB (#7788) and TWOT (#2354). See also McComiskey (page 236), Keil (page 108) and Macintosh (page 578).

14:8c

I am like a flourishing cypress;

- I am like a luxuriant cypress/pine tree.
- I am like a flourishing/healthy, leafy tree,

I am like a flourishing cypress: This clause is a simile that compares the LORD. The pronoun “I” here refers to the LORD. Some commentators observe that this is the only occurrence in the Old Testament in which the LORD is compared to a tree. Dearman (pages 343–344) suggests that even though this simile is unique, it fits the metaphorical style of Hosea and also fits the context well. In this comparison the tree may represent one or more of the following characteristics:

1. life “The tree of life.” Keil (page 108) and Stuart (pages 216–217).
2. fertility Garrett (pages 278–279).
3. productivity McComiskey (page 236).
4. shelter Andersen and Freedman (page 647) and Keil (page 108).

flourishing: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as flourishing means “leafy” or “luxuriant.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 1269). Also Andersen and Freedman (page 647), Macintosh (page 579) and Davies (page 308). Here are some other ways to translate this word:

luxuriant (NET)

evergreen (NRSV)

green (NIV)

cypress: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as cypress can mean “fir,” “cypress,” “juniper,” or “pine.” TWOT (#289a). We cannot know which of these trees the word means here. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

I am like a green pine tree (NIV)

I am that glorious tree (CEV)

14:8d**your fruit comes from Me.**

- It is from me that your fruit comes.”
- the source of all your blessings.”

your fruit comes from Me: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “from me your fruit is found.” The word order gives emphasis to the phrase from Me. Hosea may give this emphasis to remind the people that the LORD, not Baal, is the source of true fruit. See Hubbard (page 233) and Stuart (pages 216–217). For example:

from me comes your fruit. (RSV)

It is from me that your fruit comes.

Indicate this emphasis on the LORD in a natural way in your language.

fruit: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as fruit can mean the fruit of trees or vines. When it refers to people it can mean offspring, or the result of actions. TWOT (#1809). Here the word may include all these meanings. Davies (page 308) and Hubbard (page 233). Some versions say this in another way. For example:

I am the source of all their blessings. (GNT)

General Comment on 14:8b–d

In Hebrew, 14:8b–d refers to Ephraim using third person “him” and second person “your.” In some languages, it is more natural to make the forms more consistent throughout 8b–d. For example:

^{8b}I will answer your prayers and take care of you.

^{8c}I am that glorious tree, ^{8d}the source of your fruit. (CEV)

^{8b}I will answer their prayers and take care of them.

^{8c}Like an evergreen tree I will shelter them; ^{8d}I am the source of all their blessings.” (GNT)

Translate these word forms in a natural way in your language.

Hosea 14:9**Section 14:9: Conclusion**

Either Hosea or the LORD may be the speaker in this section. The section is a single verse. It is a type of wisdom saying that is similar to sayings in Proverbs. Wisdom sayings occur frequently in the

genre of “wisdom literature.” Some examples of Old Testament wisdom literature are the books of Psalms, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, and the Song of Songs. It urges the reader to be wise by following the ways of the LORD. Hubbard (page 233) notes that this verse follows a literary pattern that is typical of admonitions in Proverbs. Imperatives or jussives (third person commands, usually singular) that show the way of wisdom are followed by reasons that support the commands, usually introduced by the word ‘for.’ See also the note on 9c.

Here are other examples of section headings:

Concluding Exhortation (NET)

Last Words

14:9a–b**(combined/reordered)**

- May those who are wise understand and thoughtfully respond to what is written here.

Notice the parallel lines that are similar in meaning:

^{9a} Whoever is wise, **let him understand these things;**

^{9b} whoever is discerning, **let him know them.**

^{9a} **Whoever is wise, let him understand these things:** ^{9b}**whoever is discerning, let him know them:**

In Hebrew, both these parallel lines begin with a question: “Who is wise/discerning?” This question introduces the topic of a wise/discerning person. There are two main ways to interpret the relationship of each topic to the next clause:

1. The topic is followed by an exhortation for a wise/discerning person to act in a certain way. In other words, if a person is wise/discerning, he should act in a certain way. For example:

Who is wise? Let them realize these things. Who is discerning? Let them understand. (NIV2011)

Let him who is wise understand these things; let him who is prudent know them. (NAB) (BSB, ESV, GNT, NAB, NASB, NET, NIV2011, NJB, NLT, REB, RSV)

1. The topic is followed by a statement that describes the way that a wise/discerning person acts. In other

words, if a person is wise/discerning, he will act in a certain way as a result. For example:

Who is wise? He will realize these things. Who is discerning? He will understand them. (NIV)

Those who are wise understand these things; those who are discerning know them. (NRSV) (CEV, GW, NCV, NIV, NJPS, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a majority of versions and commentaries. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include Dearman, Macintosh, Hubbard, Stuart, Garrett, and Andersen and Freedman. McComiskey supports interpretation (2). Carroll (pages 304–305) gives three interpretations for the two verbs: jussive sense, introducing a final clause, and expressing a consequence. He does not give a preference. The form of the Hebrew verbs used for “understand” and “know” normally indicates an exhortation, not simply a statement. The form of the verb used here is a jussive. See NET footnote (a).

14:9a

Whoever is wise, let him understand these things;

- ¶ If a person is wise, he should/must understand these things.
- ¶ May the people who are wise think about the words that are written here.

Whoever is wise, let him understand these things:

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

Let the wise understand these words (NJB)

Let the wise consider these things (REB)

People who are wise should/must understand these things.

Whoever is wise: In this context the meaning of the Hebrew word is “prudent in religious affairs.” BDB (#2450). Dearman (pages 344–346) describes wisdom here as “a patterned, disciplined response to the ways [of YHWH’s modes of action and instruction] revealed.”

understand: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as understand means “understand, know (with the mind).” It refers to a person who has insight and who makes good use of knowledge. BDB (#4000). TWOT (#239) says that the Hebrew word “is a power of judg-

ment and perceptive insight and is demonstrated in the use of knowledge.”

these things: This phrase refers to everything that Hosea has said in this book. Keil (page 108), Dearman (pages 344–346), Davies (page 309) and McComiskey (page 236). Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

these words (NJB)

what is written here (GNT)

14:9b

whoever is discerning, let him know them.

- If a person is intelligent/sensible, he needs to know them.
- May those who are prudent give attention to them.

whoever is discerning, let him know them: Here are some other ways to translate this line:

let the intelligent grasp their meaning (NJB)

and let the prudent acknowledge them (REB)

People who are sensible should/must know these things.

discerning: In Hebrew, this word is a form of the same word that the BSB translates as “understand” in 9a. The Niphal participle form. The meaning is similar: “intelligent, discreet, discerning, have understanding.” BDB (#4000) Niphal.

know them: See the note on know in 2:20b. TWOT (#838) says the word “expresses a multitude of shades of knowledge gained by the senses.” In this context, the word refers to a person gaining knowledge of the truth that Hosea has spoken. That includes learning what is true, being attentive to it and living by it. Macintosh (page 582) translates it as “observing, taking note of.”

The word them refers to “these things” in 9a.

General Comment on 14:9a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine these parallel statements into one line. For example:

May those who are wise understand what is written here, and may they take it to heart. (GNT)

14:9c-e

Notice the three poetic lines. The first line gives a topic “The ways of the LORD” and a statement about the topic. Those ways “are right.” The second and third lines give two different responses to the topic.

^{9c}For the ways of the LORD are right;

^{9d}and **the righteous walk** in them

^{9e}but **the rebellious stumble** in them.

14:9c

For the ways of the LORD are right,

- For the ways of Yahweh are right/correct.
- Because Yahweh’s paths are just and true.

For the ways of the LORD are right: The For introduces a reason or basis for what Hosea says in 9a-b. Literally kî. McComiskey (page 237) describes the word here as indicating “proximate cause.” The reason it is wise to understand Hosea’s words is because Yahweh’s ways are right. Stuart (pages 219–220) calls this line the “governing basis for both knowledge and behavior.” The reason that wise and discerning people should understand and know these things is because the ways of the LORD are right. Some versions, such as the BSB above, use the word “for” to introduce this reason. Some other leave the reason implied. For example:

The ways of the Lord are right; (NIV)

Use a natural way in your language to indicate that this clause is a reason.

the ways of the LORD: Here, as is common in wisdom writings, the word ways is used as a metaphor that compares behavior/conduct to a road or path. Hubbard (page 233). Here are some things this phrase means or describes:

1. The ways of the LORD are his own actions and behavior. HALOT (electronic edition, page 232) 5.
2. The ways of the LORD are what is morally and ethically right. Andersen and Freedman (pages 647–648), Macintosh (page 582).
3. The ways of the LORD are the basis of his guidance and requirements for his people. Dearman (pages 344–346), Keil (page 108), Carroll (pages 304–305), and Davies (page 311).

right: The Hebrew word means “just,” “upright.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 450) 5 and BDB (#3477) 3. The word describes actions that are correct/proper.

14:9d-e

and the righteous walk in them but the rebellious

stumble in them: These two lines refer to two ways that people respond to the LORD and to his teachings. Some people choose to follow him and his teachings, which leads to life. Other people choose to reject him and his teachings, which leads to death. See also Deuteronomy 30:19–20.

14:9d

and the righteous walk in them

- Righteous people walk according to them.
- People who are careful to do what is right walk faithfully in his paths.

the righteous walk in them: This line describes a righteous person as one who follows the ways of the LORD, his commands, and his high standard of moral conduct. Here are some other ways to translate this line:

the godly walk in them (NET)

righteous people live by them (GW)

Good people live by following them (NCV)

the righteous: In Hebrew, this word means “just,” “upright,” or “devout.” It describes people who have good character and who behave correctly according to the LORD’s moral and ethical standards. HALOT (electronic edition, page 1002) 5 and BDB (#3072) 3.

walk in them: This phrase is a metaphor that compares the way people think and behave to walking. HALOT (electronic edition, p. 247) 6 and BDB (#1980) II 3.

The words in them refer back to the ways of the LORD. Here are some other ways to translate the phrase walk in them:

live by them (GW)

live by following them (NCV) Stuart (page 219–220).

14:9e

but the rebellious stumble in them.

- But rebellious people trip/stumble on/over them.

- But those who reject Yahweh are destroyed because they refuse to follow them.

but the rebellious stumble in them: This line describes a rebellious person as one who has trouble because he/she does not follow the ways of the LORD. Here are some other ways to translate this line:

Rebellious people stumble over them. (GW)

But in those paths sinners stumble and fall (NLT)

But sinners stumble and fall because they ignore them. (GNT)

but: This word introduces a contrast. Here it indicates that there is a difference between rebellious people and righteous people. Introduce this contrast in a natural way in your language.

the rebellious: The Hebrew word means those who “transgress,” “rebel.” A participial noun = those who transgress. HALOT (electronic edition, page 981) 3a and BDB (#6586) 2. Here it refers to people who are disloyal to the LORD and his ways.

stumble in them: This phrase is a metaphor that compares rebellion against the LORD and his ways to physical stumbling and/or falling. The Hebrew word for stumble means stumble or “stagger.” HALOT (electronic edition, pages 502–503) and BDB (#3782) 1b. As in 9d, the words in them refer back to the ways of the LORD.

This phrase is figurative and means to stumble over the ways of the LORD, his commands, and his standard of moral conduct. A person who stumbles chooses not to obey the LORD’s commands. As a result, he suffers downfall and ruin. McComiskey (pages 236–237) says that “Ephraim’s ways will lead to death. Macintosh (page 582) says that they will suffer “utter ruin.”

Here the phrase does not refer only to a temporary or minor difficulty. These are Hosea’s final words that refer back to the book of Hosea as a whole. In these chapters, he includes many serious warnings. People who reject the LORD suffer ruin and death as a result. Here those warnings are in view. (See also Hosea 4:5a and 5:5a–c)